

Chapter 354 - 354 — The Jet That Came to Pick Them Up

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Even though the companions trapped inside the base had told her to run—and the man beside her had actually taken her and run—Barbara still couldn't get over it. All the way along, she kept chatting idly with Henry, trying to work through it in her own head.

At the end of the day, that much-touted American mantra—"Not a single soldier left behind"—had been drilled deep into people's hearts through years of propaganda.

Even in movies, it was almost always portrayed as live together, die together, and treated as something noble.

That kind of social atmosphere did have its uses. It made a lot of selfish people hesitate before choosing to abandon others when faced with a hard decision.

But it also created plenty of brainwashed idiots who insisted on staying behind and dragging everyone down with them. What should have been a simple escape, a survivable checkpoint, got twisted into a life-or-death situation—and in the end, both people paid the price together.

Humans, after all, are mostly selfish. Without that kind of cultural pressure, the number of people who'd abandon their companions would probably far exceed those willing to stay behind.

Once even one person ran, it was easy for panic to spread, dragging the weak-willed along and turning everything into a total collapse.

But Henry was different.

If he told someone to run, he genuinely meant it. He wanted them gone—fast. As for whoever stayed behind? Kill them if necessary, wipe them out cleanly, and move on. No psychological burden at all.

Even if he didn't silence them permanently, Henry had plenty of options: run, fly, vanish. If a companion stubbornly insisted on staying and restricted what he could do, that was just plain nonsense.

Of course, Henry knew his situation was special. It didn't apply to normal people, much less to American society as a whole.

And he wasn't worried about whether Nick Fury could get out alive.

Would the addition of Henry as a variable somehow prevent Fury from ever losing an eye to a Flerken, instead getting himself killed at the Pegasus Project base?

The key point was who was with Fury.

Vers. A member of the Kree Starforce. The future Captain Marvel.

Even with the Kree limiter still in place, that photon blast alone was more than enough to crush Earth's conventional military forces.

With that woman acting as his bodyguard, Fury would have to try to die.

Unless, of course, the two of them completely failed to get along.

But given the smooth, flexible personality of the future Director of S.H.I.E.L.D., soothing a confused alien warrior wasn't exactly a challenge.

Right now, Nick Fury was much like Phil Coulson would later be in Agents of S.H.I.E.L.D.

A spy who won people over with sincerity. Professional without being rigid, humorous without being flippant—someone it was genuinely hard to dislike.

To be honest, if Henry didn't already know what kind of person this "motherfucker hero" would become, along with all the tangled consequences surrounding him, Henry might have agreed that working under him wouldn't be a bad choice.

At least you'd have a boss overhead to block the wind and rain, while you just focused on doing your job. For many people, that was extremely appealing. That was leadership charisma, plain and simple.

And for example—when circumstances allowed—the man would even fly a jet out personally to pick people up...

Watching a silver-white, compact twin-engine experimental jet descend vertically in front of him, Henry pulled the car to a stop.

The rear hatch of the Quadjet opened, and Nick Fury appeared, holding an orange cat in his arms and waving at them.

"Hop on," Fury called. "You don't seriously plan on outrunning pursuit in that piece of junk, do you?"

Barbara, sitting in the passenger seat, didn't say a word—but the eager look in her eyes completely gave her away.

Henry didn't hesitate much over whether to go or not.

If he went, there was a chance to meet Talos, the Skrull general—the same one who had previously used Director Keller to dispatch S.H.I.E.L.D. agents against him and Barbara.

Henry had been planning to dig information out of the Skrulls anyway. Facing their big boss directly—and doing so beside Captain Marvel, whom they needed—meant at least having a chance to talk.

It also reduced the odds that Henry's involvement would force the Skrulls to abandon their recruitment strategy and switch straight to brute force.

More importantly, it was an opportunity to test exactly what kind of relationship existed between Kryptonians and Skrulls.

If things really escalated, that would only prove that Kryptonians were considered a higher-priority threat than the Skrulls' original objective.

And according to Henry's memories from before his transmigration, Talos was ultimately just trying to find his family, hidden aboard a Kree scientist's ship.

If he was willing to throw his family away just to kill a Kryptonian, then Henry would have to seriously consider retreating to Alaska and living in seclusion.

Just what in the hell had Kryptonians done, to make every other alien race want them dead on sight? Would the Kree act the same way?

To figure all that out, Henry nodded to Barbara and pulled the car over to the roadside.

The two of them opened their doors and got out. Barbara immediately stormed forward, angrily complaining to Fury, while Henry opened the rear door and let Katie out to follow him.

Walking with a tiger pressed close to your leg carried an undeniable sense of presence. Anyone who saw it would feel a twinge of envy.

At first, Nick Fury holding an orange cat hadn't been without intent—there was definitely a "cute versus fierce" angle to it.

But once he saw Henry approaching with Katie at his side, Fury instantly felt that the cat in his arms had lost all appeal.

Animals might not speak human language, but they were extremely sensitive to human emotions. The moment Fury's mood shifted, the orange cat in his arms began baring its teeth and struggling.

Fury wasn't careful enough, and the cat wriggled free.

Seeing that it was heading into the plane rather than running away, Fury didn't bother chasing it. Instead, he joked:

"Uh... Katie won't eat my dumb goose, will she?"

"A cat named Goose?" Henry stared at him. "You serious?"

"Hey, the name was given by the little guy's owner—it's on the collar. I can't just change it on a whim. What, you want me to call it Chewie instead?"

...Wow. That mouth of yours—did Stan Lee personally bless it or something? You actually know the cat's comic name.

Henry gave Fury a very strange look.

Fury, now feeling awkward himself, quickly stepped aside and gestured with his expression: Well? You getting on or not?

It had to be said—when a black man widened his eyes, the contrast made the expression especially vivid.

Henry boarded the experimental twin-engine jet with Katie in tow.

The future Quinjet, which would later become standard S.H.I.E.L.D. equipment, was essentially an enhanced helicopter: vertical takeoff and landing, troop and cargo transport, combined with jet-level speed.

The Quadjet, as an experimental predecessor, already resembled the future Quinjet in overall layout, though it was somewhat larger in size.

As for the interior details—starting from the moment he stepped aboard, Henry began a comprehensive scan.

After all, he still had the blueprints for the Iowa-class battleship USS Missouri, post-modernization, tucked away in his mind. Military-grade hardware like the Quadjet wasn't something you could just find in a library or university archive.

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Chapter 355 - 355 — Everyone's Own Agenda

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Barbara Morse was the first to board the aircraft. She held a doctorate in biology, so strictly speaking, she was a science person—definitely not from the humanities.

When someone from the sciences sees an aircraft—especially an advanced, non-public experimental jet—anyone who isn't interested probably wouldn't last very long in their field.

Barbara was obviously not that kind of person. And the fact that she had chosen to abandon a purely academic path to join S.H.I.E.L.D. as a covert operative already spoke volumes about her adventurous personality.

Someone like that was hardly going to remain indifferent upon seeing a plane like this.

So the moment she got on board, she sat down in the copilot's seat next to Vers, touching things here and there and firing off questions nonstop.

Perhaps because they were both women—or perhaps because Vers had that strong, big-sister aura—she was happy to answer Barbara's questions.

It was also possible that Vers was using the back-and-forth conversation to temporarily push aside all the unanswered confusion weighing on her mind.

Nick Fury, seated toward the back, wasn't idle either. He asked Henry about what had happened while he and Barbara were holding position outside the base.

With an eyewitness present, Henry had no reason to hide anything. He explained everything in full detail.

"So that means we can assume more Skrulls have already replaced S.H.I.E.L.D. agents—and we have no way to tell who's who," Fury summarized.

"Unless they give themselves away through their words or actions, that's correct," Henry replied.

However, from Henry's memories, the Kree—old enemies of the Skrulls—had developed Skrull detectors. Even Reed Richards of the Fantastic Four had created similar devices, which solved the Secret Invasion event in the comics.

In other words, disguised Skrulls were detectable, and it didn't require biological samples. Proximity alone was enough.

Henry himself had been using his enhanced senses to analyze them, but likely due to an insufficient sample size, he hadn't yet found a precise method—only a rough lead.

If he had to put it into words, the idea had come from the brainwave translator used for interpreting tiger vocalizations.

Different species showed distinct neural transmission patterns. And Skrulls weren't even carbon-based lifeforms; they were composed of materials not found on Earth.

Still, Henry hadn't yet identified a clear "pattern" that could definitively label a target as a disguised Skrull. For now, he could only rely on behavioral anomalies.

Meanwhile, Nick Fury had gone quiet, pondering when Keller might have been replaced—and whether the original director was still alive.

Henry didn't let Fury dwell too long. He had plenty of questions of his own. Showing curiosity also helped ease the legendary spymaster's suspicions—at the very least, it prevented the impression that Henry already knew everything.

"So where are we headed now?" Henry asked. "Fleeing the country?"

"Of course not," Fury replied. "We're going to Louisiana to find someone."

"Who?"

"Maria Rambeau. Former Air Force test pilot. A member of Project Pegasus."

"Why her?"

"Because she's tied to the answer to a mystery. Vers—who claims to be a Kree Starforce soldier—may have been the pilot in a costly experimental aircraft crash six years ago. To uncover the truth, we need to ask someone else who was part of Project Pegasus."

"And how does this relate to the Skrulls?" Henry asked.

"It relates to the answers Vers is looking for."

"Then why are you getting involved?" Henry pressed. "This doesn't concern you directly. Shouldn't your top priority be dealing with the Skrulls? Your organization's practically been infiltrated."

Chapter 356 356 — Exploring the Secret of the Flerken

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"Mom! It's Aunt Carol!"

The Black girl who had just climbed down from a propeller plane beneath the hangar rushed straight into the arms of the bewildered Vers. "I knew it! Everyone said you were dead!"

"I'm not the person you think I am," Vers said, not pushing the girl away, but still turning to the approaching Black woman—whose face was full of disbelief—and

Fury shook his head. "No, no, no—you've got it wrong, Henry. My instincts tell me that all the answers lie with Ms. Vers.

"What are the Kree? What are the Skrulls? Why are they on Earth? And why does all of this connect to Project Pegasus, which worked with both the Air Force and NASA?

"You don't seriously think that killing Skrulls on sight would end this, do you? As long as the underlying cause remains, Skrulls will just keep appearing.

"What we should be doing is finding that why—and then figuring out how to deal with the source. To do that, we need intelligence. Accurate, in-depth intelligence—not just surface-level information.

"The United States already has two million idiots who know how to pull a trigger. We don't need more. Deciding where the guns point and who gets shot—that's our job."

"Is that really all?" Henry asked skeptically, eyeing the seemingly righteous Fury. "You already brought up the U.S. military as an example. When it comes to looting, no one in this era dares claim first place if America calls second.

"Even in wars they lose, someone still profits. So don't tell me you're only getting involved to 'solve problems.' I don't buy it."

"Ha—sharp kid," Fury said, praising him without hesitation. Given their age difference, calling Henry "kid" was more than fair.

The still—two-eyed Fury spoke openly. "If you want to profit from something, you first need to know who holds the chips—and where you stand.

"If a little kitten tries to profit from a fight between a lion and a tiger, it'll probably just get bitten to death."

As he spoke, Fury picked up the orange cat that was trying to climb toward the cockpit and started petting it again. A question lingered unspoken in his mind: Why was this cat so attached to Vers?

"I'm not stupid enough to think Earth can challenge aliens with spaceflight technology. But war is only one language of politics. Even the weak have roles they can play—as long as they find the right point of entry."

What Fury didn't say was that he still remembered the key ingredient in the Infinity Formula his white-skinned father had used: something Earth didn't produce—Kree.

That didn't mean he would side with the Skrulls against the Kree just to stockpile some "raw materials."

But with two alien races bringing their conflict to Earth, there was no way he could simply ignore it. At the very least, he needed to understand the full story.

Still, whatever he planned to do, he lacked far too much information. He couldn't even form a proper judgment yet, so all he could do was take things one step at a time.

And there was one thing in this whole affair that lay completely outside his expectations—and fascinated him greatly.

Nick Fury glanced at the tiger lying at Henry's feet. A top-tier apex predator, willingly crouched beside a human—being bulletproof alone couldn't explain that.

"Honestly," Fury said bluntly, "compared to this farce of two alien factions fighting each other, I'm more curious about one thing, Henry. Why does this involve you?"

"I'd like to know that too," Henry replied truthfully. Out of everyone in this unfolding drama, he might have been the most confused of all.

As he spoke, Henry gently pressed his foot against Katie, almost like giving her a massage. The massive male tiger lay comfortably on its side on the rear cargo deck of the jet, just one step away from rolling onto its back and exposing its belly like a dog.

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explaining herself.

Seeing this scene of reunion after a long separation, neither Nick Fury nor Barbara Morse had the tactlessness to approach. They stayed some distance away.

Henry stood even farther off, because he had taken Katie off the plane to let her get some fresh air. To avoid scaring people with this "tabby cat," he obviously couldn't just wander closer to unfamiliar faces.

It wasn't that he feared Katie biting anyone—he feared others being startled. Given America's gun ownership rate, who knew whether this retired Air Force mom might suddenly pull out a gun and start shooting the moment she saw a tiger?

Another reason Henry lagged behind was that he wanted to get a close look at the single most illogical existence in the entire Captain Marvel movie—the orange cat

that was actually a Flerken: Goose.

Calling it "illogical" wasn't a complaint about fictional creatures appearing in a work of science fiction.

It was that the movie never explained how this orange cat casually appeared inside a supposedly heavily guarded Air Force base, then tagged along with the protagonists and provided massive assistance, all without any buildup.

Moving a step slower than the others, Henry ignored Goose's attempt to sneak away. He grabbed the Flerken by the scruff of the neck and lifted it up, face to face.

Sure enough, a Flerken wasn't quite the same as an ordinary cat. At the very least, it didn't meow like one. But since it had the outward appearance of a cat, its other features didn't stray too far either.

From skeleton to musculature, it was almost indistinguishable from a normal cat. The only notable difference was in the muscles surrounding the lower jaw, which were structured more like a snake's—allowing the Flerken to open its mouth to an absurd, almost impossible extent.

Up to that point, it still resembled a normal cat. But the internal organs were where it completely departed from any Earth-based biological logic.

The Flerken's brain folds were extraordinarily dense—far beyond those of a regular cat. Although its brain volume didn't reach human levels, the density of its cortical folds meant that, compared to a cat, a Flerken wasn't just a little smarter—it was leagues ahead.

Then there was the digestive system. From mouth to esophagus to stomach, everything deviated from mammalian norms.

Especially the stomach.

Ever since absorbing enough yellow sunlight to gain X-ray vision, Henry had found only two things he couldn't see through: lead, and the Flerken's stomach.

He could see the outside of Goose's stomach, which looked no different from a normal cat's—about the size of a slightly large adult fist. But when he tried to look inside, his vision simply skipped past it entirely, revealing what lay behind the stomach instead.

According to official lore, a Flerken's stomach contained a pocket universe.

A universe inside a universe—what kind of physical manifestation that entailed fascinated Henry to no end.

He had expected to see something like an event horizon or a miniature black hole. Instead, it was just... blocked. Completely hidden. Nothing to see.

It was like watching an adult film after getting fully prepared, only to find the entire screen covered in mosaic censorship. Enough to make anyone want to curse.

Goose seemed to sense that its secret was being scrutinized. At first, it had merely given Henry a disdainful, judgmental look. Now it began struggling violently, its paws flailing.

At least it still had some restraint—it didn't open its mouth or extend its tentacles to try and swallow Henry whole. Otherwise, Henry would have taken the opportunity to see just how formidable the Marvel Universe's infamous Flerken really was when facing a Kryptonian.

That said, Goose's claws were famous in their own right—they had famously cost Black Nick Fury one eye. Henry reacted instantly, catching one paw. He pressed his thumb against the paw pad, studied the claws closely, and even sniffed them.

There was no toxin, contrary to what one might expect. Instead, there was a strange energy fluctuation—one that caused wounds inflicted by the claws to resist healing.

Henry noticed this because the temperature around the Flerken's claws was abnormal, not consistent with normal mammalian body heat dissipation.

Unfortunately, Henry's probing seemed to irritate the Flerken further. Beyond Goose's increasingly sharp gaze, its entire body began emitting abnormal energy

Chapter 357 - 357 — Traces That Cannot Be Hidden

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Nick Fury said in surprise, "You recognize this cat?"

Flipping over the tag on the orange cat's collar and confirming it was indeed the one she knew, Maria Rambeau gave it a quick rub and said, "Goose belonged to Dr. Lawson.

"After the doctor's accident, no one could find Goose anymore. Every now and then, though, people would still spot it inside the base. When the doctor was still alive, Carol was also very close to Goose. Do you remember that?"

This question was directed at Vers, the Kree Starforce member.

At that moment, Nick Fury suddenly understood why the cat had appeared inside the base and why it seemed so attached to them. Goose wasn't clinging to him, the big Black guy—it was clinging to Vers.

However, Vers herself had no memory of this. She frowned and tried to recall something, but in the end she could only shake her head.

Just as she was about to say something, Maria Rambeau stuffed the orange cat into her daughter's arms. "Forget it. Come back to my place first. This isn't somewhere about:blank

fluctuations.

Most notably, the much-studied stomach began to contract and writhe.

Henry quickly shifted from holding to cradling, stroking Goose's head, neck, and back several times to calm it down.

It didn't work.

Goose enjoyed it briefly, then wriggled free, leapt to the ground, raised its tail arrogantly, and walked away.

In terms of personality, Goose was far more striking than Katie, who was well on her way to being raised into something resembling a pig.

In the unfamiliar environment, Katie showed none of the domineering presence of a king of the jungle. Instead, she stuck close to Henry's leg, as if afraid of being abandoned in this strange place.

Still, she didn't try to compete for attention. Henry petted the cat, and Katie simply watched with a placid, dopey expression. Even when Goose escaped and strutted away with its tail held high, flaunting its rear end, Katie only watched.

Seeing this, Henry couldn't help but sigh inwardly—this tiger had really been spoiled useless.

Just as he started walking over to join the others who had already disembarked from the Quadjet, he heard a child's excited cry:

"That's a tiger! That has to be a tiger!"

"No, young lady," Henry replied smoothly, "this is a tabby cat named Katie."

He casually rubbed the tiger's head and added, "Katie, say hello to the young lady."

"Roar!"

The bold little girl with the afro wasn't scared at all by the roar. She was so excited she tried to rush forward—only for her mother to grab her in time. Otherwise, the foolish child would have personally delivered herself into a tiger's jaws.

Maria Rambeau pulled her daughter behind her, one arm raised protectively as she asked warily, "That tiger won't bite, will it?"

Stopping where he was, Henry answered calmly, "If I said Katie doesn't bite, doesn't eat meat, and is a vegetarian, no one would believe me. If you're worried, I can stay farther away."

Relaxing slightly, Maria looked at the tiger that never left the man's side and said, "It's fine. Just make sure she doesn't run around."

Henry might have been agreeable—but that didn't mean her daughter was.

The little girl tugged at her mother's clothes. "Mom, can I pet her?"

"No!"

Just then, Maria noticed an orange cat walking toward them. She scooped it up reflexively. "If you're going to hold something, hold a real cat. Huh? Goose! Why are you here?"

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to talk."

Watching this, Henry broke out in a cold sweat.

You're worried that Katie might hurt your daughter, but it never crossed your mind that the cat might be even more dangerous?

When the group arrived at Maria Rambeau's home, she immediately spotted the Quadjet parked not far from the house. A flying machine that out of place in a small town was obviously not something a local would own.

Maria looked at them. "That plane... you flew it here?"

Nick Fury responded with his usual flippant tone. "Relax. It's a vertical takeoff jet. Won't mess up your lawn."

The little girl's eyes lit up instantly. "Mom! Can I go see it?"

Constantly crushing a child's enthusiasm wasn't good either—and honestly, Maria herself was curious about that unusual aircraft. Still, what concerned her more right now was what had happened to her close friend.

"Go ahead. But I still need to ask your Aunt Carol what's been going on all this time. I won't wait for you."

"Oh... then never mind."

The girl took her mother's hand, her bright eyes fixed firmly on the aunt who had come back from the dead.

The group entered the house—Henry and Katie included.

It was a very ordinary, typical suburban American two-story standalone home. The first floor consisted of the living room, kitchen, dining area, and so on, while the bedrooms were all on the second floor.

With only a mother and daughter living there, the house was actually a bit too large and took effort to clean. Still, it was kept very tidy. Everything showed signs of careful maintenance, making it easy to imagine how hard the homeowner worked to keep her life together.

Everyone gathered in the dining room. By American custom, serious conversations tended to take place in the dining room. The living room was furnished too comfortably—it was for casual chatting and relaxation.

One man and one tiger consciously stayed at a distance, not getting too close to the mother who still held some wariness, or to the curious child.

But everyone's attention was on Vers, listening as she recounted what had happened.

Even so, Vers didn't say much. She began with how she had been captured by Skrulls, strapped into a strange machine, and shown bizarre visions.

Those unclear hallucinations were what drove her to pursue answers she herself didn't know she was looking for.

That trail eventually led her to Project PEGASUS, where she discovered that she herself appeared in archival photos. That was why she had come to question Maria Rambeau—also a former participant in Project PEGASUS—about its details.

Compared to the utterly confused mother, Monica Rambeau, the daughter, was far more carefree. Lost in her own excitement, she suddenly said,

"Aunt Carol, we still kept all your old stuff—including your flight jacket. One time I accidentally got ketchup on it, and Mom wouldn't let me wear it anymore. I'll go get those things so you can see them!"

Without waiting to see whether anyone even needed them, she ran off to rummage through things.

Vers exchanged glances with the others and then said to Nick Fury, "Maybe you can go help her."

Nick Fury had actually wanted to stay, but he wasn't that socially clueless. "Alright. There might be a lot of stuff—probably easier with more hands. Bobbi, come with me. Henry, what about you?"

"I'll take Katie out for a walk," Henry said. "You know—after eating and drinking, there's always something that needs to come out. Your place doesn't exactly look like it has a litter box, so I'll take her to the nearby woods and find a suitable spot."

Nick Fury glanced at the tiger lying by Henry's feet, said nothing, shrugged, and left.

Henry, of course, wasn't just talking. He took Katie out through the kitchen's back door, heading off to find a suitable place to deal with the tiger's bodily needs.

Tiger urination wasn't like a dog lifting its leg or squatting. A tiger sprayed straight backward. So under no circumstances should you stand behind a tiger at that

Chapter 358 - 358 — The Pursuers Have Arrived

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After entering Louisiana, Nick Fury had spent some extra time confirming Maria Rambeau's place of residence.

This era didn't have navigation maps that could guide you directly to a specific street number. You had to search manually on a map, then guess where you were and which way to go.

The conclusion was simple: if the enemy wasn't stupid, after all this time, they should have caught up already.

If the Skrulls were still maintaining their impersonated identities, then with the advantage of their official authority, finding out what Vers and Nick Fury had been looking for in the base archives would hardly be difficult.

There was no need to deliberately track where the Quadjet had flown to. They should have been able to deduce the destination directly. A race of aliens that excelled at infiltrating enemy territory and seizing power through subversion surely weren't idiots.

So Henry didn't believe the abnormal signs he'd noticed were just coincidence. And sure enough—after observing more closely, he immediately found proof that trouble had arrived.

Three SUVs of the same model drove into the small town where they had landed. Most of the people inside wore black suits. Among them was Keller—the SHIELD agent who had previously ordered Henry and Barbara arrested outside the air force base.

Judging by this lineup, it looked nothing like the movie version where only two people showed up. So were all of them Skrulls in disguise, or had more SHIELD fools been tricked into coming along?

Without confirming that, it was hard to take action against them.

moment—unless you wanted a tiger-urine shower...

Henry used taking Katie out as an excuse because he had already noticed something abnormal.

Flying the Quadjet from California all the way here had not been completely smooth.

The Quadjet didn't have stealth capability. That meant if it flew too high, it had to be managed by air traffic control (ATC). At around 18,000 feet above sea level, it would definitely be monitored.

That airspace was mainly used by large commercial passenger planes and cargo aircraft. Those planes weren't very maneuverable and flew fast—by the time pilots visually noticed another aircraft on a collision course, there was basically no chance to evade. That was why strict management was required.

Airspace around airports was also heavily controlled due to takeoffs and landings.

Below 18,000 feet, airspace was divided into several classes with different rules, all meant to keep air routes safe and unobstructed.

Airspace below 1,200 feet was considered a transition zone. Flying at that altitude involved fewer restrictions. On one hand, aircraft limited to that height usually weren't very fast, and pilots had enough maneuverability to visually avoid each other.

However, Vers obviously couldn't fly the Quadjet at supersonic speed at that altitude. That would be like flooring a supercar in the slow lane—you'd have no idea what you might slam into.

So their ability to fly in had relied on Nick Fury using his special authority to secure a temporary flight corridor.

If someone failed to follow these rules, they'd be lucky enough to see U.S. fighter jets escorting them—and be forced to land at a designated airport. If they ignored warnings, the U.S. military was authorized to shoot them down. Before 9/11, though, things usually stopped at warnings.

Fortunately, the Quadjet itself was a U.S. military experimental aircraft, complete with valid transponder signals, so it didn't require additional identity verification.

But everything being compliant created another problem—

They had left behind traceable tracks.

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And in the movie, the reason only two Skrulls had come was because they had found evidence that Vers could be persuaded. They hadn't planned to use force, instead switching to a persuasion strategy—trying to win her over with shared hatred of a common enemy.

Now there were three vehicles, fourteen people total. Did this change mean their strategy had changed as well?

Thinking back, the only flaw Henry could come up with was the stolen car he'd left by the roadside. Since no one was in it, it gave the Skrulls reason to believe he had regrouped with Nick Fury and the others.

So... had he, this Kryptonian, become the variable?

Considering that the moment a Kryptonian appeared, the Skrulls started hunting him down, now that they'd caught up, it seemed wiser for him to avoid direct contact.

As long as these people talked, they couldn't hide anything from him. Keeping some distance would also make it easier for him to escape if necessary.

As for the trouble surrounding him—Henry couldn't deny that his fear of people like Mystique wasn't unfounded. If the enemy didn't confront him head-on but instead smeared him with false accusations, he still didn't have a good solution for that.

Before Vers chose to cooperate with the Skrulls, wiping them all out was one option. But that would require Nick Fury to step in and clean up afterward—and they'd also need a reliable way to correctly identify Skrulls.

Henry had no desire to owe Nick Fury that kind of favor. That would be no different from selling himself.

As for identifying Skrulls, Henry still didn't have much confidence. If he accidentally killed SHIELD agents because of it, don't think they'd kindly excuse it as collateral damage.

No matter how you looked at it, he was an outsider—not an internal SHIELD operative. Hoping they'd understand his "unavoidable mistakes" was less realistic than hoping America would suddenly turn pacifist.

So the only option left was to wait and see—and gamble that Kryptonians and Skrulls weren't ancient mortal enemies who had to fight to the death the moment

they met.

Letting Katie roam freely in the woods, Henry kept his attention on the Skrulls mixed in with SHIELD agents—and on the group inside Maria Rambeau's house.

And precisely because he was watching from the sidelines, he witnessed a rare and spectacular show.

First, the Skrulls didn't spend much time discussing what to do. The moment they got out of their vehicles, they split up and began carrying out their respective actions.

From how they openly transformed into local residents without any concern for being seen, Henry could be certain that all fourteen of them were Skrulls. Otherwise, they wouldn't so casually reveal that ability in front of outsiders.

Then one of them—disguised as a neighborly middle-aged man—went to Maria Rambeau's front door. Wearing a baseball cap, the chubby "uncle" used the excuse of taking kids to see the Quadjet to draw the attention of all the adults inside.

At the same time, someone else snuck in through the back door, transforming into... Henry and Katie—one man and one tiger.

This immediately attracted the bold little girl, Monica Rambeau.

Perhaps the idea of touching a tiger had been stuck in her head all along. When the Skrull-version Henry approached without stopping her, she indeed dared to get close to the tiger—only to be pounced to the ground.

Seeing this, the real Henry had only one thought:

Holy shit. Even if it means dying, they're determined to smear me. Just how deep is the hatred between Kryptonians and Skrulls?

Of course, the adults in the house couldn't possibly watch this happen. And for the sake of making sure everyone could see clearly, the tiger's pounce wasn't done in some blind spot. All it took was turning around.

Unsurprisingly, Vers fired a photon blast, blasting the tiger off Monica Rambeau.

Nick Fury swung his gun around, aiming it at the Skrull-version Henry. Barbara also abandoned her original target—the chubby man at the door—and looked toward Henry. She didn't point her gun, but questioned him verbally instead.

As for the other eleven Skrulls, they spread out, searching for Henry's whereabouts.

Strangely enough, despite being a high-tech civilization, they didn't seem to carry much advanced equipment. Was it for the sake of fully exploiting their racial ability to disguise themselves anytime, anywhere—so much so that they wouldn't even bring a laser gun?

Chapter 359 - 359 — The Secret of Krypton in This Universe

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Taking advantage of the moment when no one was paying attention, Henry activated his super speed, carrying Katie back into the living room. In an instant, he reappeared side by side with the Skrull-version of Henry—the one who had let the tiger attack the girl in the dining room.

Perhaps because he'd already faced the real thing before, the Skrull-Henry didn't immediately shout that the other was a fake—an action that would have looked suspicious at first glance.

Instead, he wore a confused expression and said in surprise,

"What's going on here?"

The Skrull-version of Katie, who had earlier been blasted away by a photon blast, also got back on her feet. She perfectly mimicked a tiger's posture—baring her teeth, letting out a low rumbling growl, lowering her forelegs as if ready to pounce again at any moment.

By contrast, the real Katie beside Henry looked like a clueless big cat. She simply sat down, tilted her head, and stared at the other "tiger" that looked identical on the outside but felt fundamentally different.

"Ms. Vers, do you have a way to tell them apart?" the real Henry asked, deliberately not showing how much he already knew about Skrulls. Instead, he threw the question to the person who should be most familiar with them—the Kree Starforce warrior.

"Skrull disguises are flawless, from appearance all the way down to DNA," Vers said seriously. "But they can only access short-term memories. Things from long ago, they might not know. Can you two talk about your past?"

The Skrull-Henry immediately dismissed the idea.

"Even if I did, who here could verify which of us is telling the truth?"

He said this up front because, aside from outward appearance, he couldn't obtain much additional information about the person he was imitating. Not to mention the Kryptonian DNA lock—even short-term memories required direct contact to copy.

He couldn't afford to fall into a self-verification trap.

As for the real Henry, he couldn't say much either. If the Skrull limit for short-term memory was six years, then six years ago Henry had still been in a Red Empire research institute in Siberia.

In any case, these Skrulls were just wearing the skins of small-town residents, relying on their eyes alone to search for one man and one tiger.

Inside the house, the Skrull-version Henry—who had let the tiger attack—offered no explanation. He simply walked over to the blasted-away tiger and checked on his "companion's" injuries.

The only sound in the room was Monica's sobbing, as her mother comforted her. She wasn't wailing loudly, which was already impressive for a child. But being pinned down by a tiger—that kind of helpless terror was something a person would remember for life.

Maria Rambeau said angrily, "I don't know where you're from, but I let you into my home as guests. That doesn't give you the right to hurt my family!"

Nick Fury, though suspicious, still kept his gun aimed at the man he'd only met earlier that day.

"Henry, whatever you're trying to do, control your pet. Don't think a 9mm pistol can't kill a tiger."

Even Barbara said in confusion, "Henry, what are you doing? How could you let Katie hurt someone—especially bite a child?"

There was a clear bite mark on Monica Rambeau's arm—left by the Skrull-version of Katie. Blood was still flowing.

Vers said nothing, but her glowing fists spoke volumes. If the person in front of her made the slightest move, this time it wouldn't just be knocking someone away—it would be punching straight through them.

"If I said... that wasn't me," Henry asked calmly,

"would you believe me?"

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So what if he talked about it? That was something even he didn't want to remember.

Still, there was a way to break the stalemate.

Henry asked, "Ms. Vers, when Skrulls mimic someone, does that include the special abilities the original possesses?"

"No," Vers replied. "When Skrulls shapeshift, their physical capabilities remain their own. They can't use abilities they didn't originally possess."

"Then, Fury," Henry said calmly, "you should understand why I'm asking this."

The moment he finished speaking, a gunshot rang out.

Nick Fury fired a shot straight through the arm of the Skrull-version of Henry. The impostor immediately screamed,

"Why did you shoot me?! He's the fake one!"

Skrull disguises don't fail during sleep or injury. Only death forces them back into their original form.

So as long as the shot wasn't fatal, it wouldn't expose him yet.

But that single shot was enough for Barbara to confirm the truth. She raised her gun and aimed at the Skrull-Henry in the dining room, shouting,

"Alien! Reveal your true form!"

Then another gunshot rang out.

The real Henry cried out, "Hey! What was that for?!"

Nick Fury, who had fired again, didn't look the least bit embarrassed.

"You know—just to be safe. Had to double-check."

Rubbing his arm and pretending it hurt, Henry stuck his finger through the bullet hole in his clothes and said sternly,

"I'll let it slide this time. Do it again, and I won't be so friendly."

The Skrull-Henry stared at the real one in shock, feeling that his exposure was profoundly unfair.

Is this really how Kryptonians behave under a yellow sun?

Seeing himself and his tiger companion surrounded, he looked momentarily at a loss.

At that moment, General Talos—the Skrull leader—entered through the kitchen's back door. He maintained his original form, not disguised as anyone else.

In a calm, confident voice, he said,

"You don't really think the only alien you need to worry about in this house... is us, do you? The one you should truly be watching is the companion you call Henry. He is a notorious Kryptonian."

Talos's words sparked curiosity, confusion—and anger.

Barbara was the one who reacted with fury, shouting,

"What nonsense are you talking about?!"

Henry, on the other hand, was genuinely confused—at least on the surface. He put on a bewildered expression and said,

"What are you talking about? Kryptonian?"

Nick Fury, meanwhile, was intensely intrigued by this new information.

"What's a Kryptonian? Vers, have you heard of that term?"

"I only know that Kryptonians were once the most unhinged superpower in the universe," Vers replied. "But that's ancient history. Krypton was defeated long ago."

Oh? There's history like that too? Henry thought silently.

Talos grew more animated as he continued,

"Kryptonians weren't just a mad superpower. Their people were influenced by the color of their star—sometimes becoming insane, sometimes monstrous.

"And because their political system was a strictly controlled pyramid structure, no Kryptonian child was born naturally. From the moment of birth, their future role was decided.

"Under such a system, other worlds were either enslaved or destroyed. Peace was never an option. And do you know what ultimately happened to the planets whose resources they plundered?

"Their cores collapsed. The planets ceased to exist. No exceptions. Kryptonians were the most terrifying plague in the universe.

"Fortunately, we discovered their weakness. Green stars weaken Kryptonians to the brink of death. The annihilation battle in the Barrington System finally halted their

Chapter 360 - 360 — The Exiled Flawed One

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It was Nick Fury, ever the seasoned operator, who knew how to control the tempo of events. No matter how interested he was in what the Skrulls were saying, he wasn't about to let them take the lead.

He smoothed things over for Henry, saying,

"Henry is an excellent doctor. If you don't trust him, then at least tell Bobby where your first-aid kit is. The girl's wounds really do need to be treated."

It was the classic psychological trick—when someone strongly rejects the first option, they're far more likely to accept the second.

Being watched warily, Henry didn't push his luck by stepping forward to show off his medical skills. With Barbara stepping in to help, Maria Rambeau didn't object forcefully. Her daughter truly did need treatment.

Fortunately, the injury on Monica's arm hadn't been caused by a tiger's four longest canines—only the sharper back teeth had left bite marks.

There was bleeding, and it looked frightening, but the bone wasn't crushed, nor was there any tearing. Unfortunate, yes—but still a blessing in disguise.

Perhaps the Skrulls had already anticipated the possibility of being exposed when they staged this frame-up. They hadn't bitten down hard, clearly holding back.

Vers was concerned about the girl's injury as well, but most of her attention remained on the Skrulls. She looked ready to start a fight at the slightest provocation.

What restrained her was the fact that even more Skrulls were entering the house, positioning themselves at both the front and back doors, sealing off all escape routes.

Though they had the numerical advantage, they carried no weapons. All of them reverted to their original forms—green-skinned, bald, with pointed ears.

Even the Skrulls who had initially impersonated Henry and Katie returned to their true forms and retreated behind General Talos. The one who had been shot was receiving treatment from his companions.

It was hard to say whether this display signaled goodwill, but at the very least, they had no intention of starting a fight immediately.

Nick Fury paid the Skrulls' movements no mind. Instead, he looked at Henry—who seemed just as bewildered—and asked,

"What that guy said about Krypton... did you know any of it?"

"Honestly? This is the first time I've heard any of it," Henry replied.

"But you don't look very shocked."

Henry shrugged.

insane expansion.

"After that, Kryptonians were confined to their homeworld. Their planet was surrounded by a cosmic trap of their own creation—the Phantom Zone—preventing anyone inside from escaping and anyone outside from entering.

"And all of this happened... well, by your planet's calendar, about nine thousand years ago. So tell me—why would a Kryptonian, who should be eternally imprisoned on his homeworld, appear here?"

The spotlight returned to Henry.

Naturally, he didn't answer a question he himself didn't know the answer to. He simply shrugged and put on a confused expression. Then, as if changing the subject, he pointed at the injured girl.

"Do you want me to treat her wounds?" Henry said.

"A bite like that won't cause fatal blood loss, but if it's left untreated and exposed to air, there's a risk of bacterial infection.

"There's also the risk of tetanus. As for rabies... well, is that something we need to worry about? I can guarantee Katie doesn't have it—but I can't say the same about that one. Who knows what kind of alien pathogens it might carry."

Perhaps being exposed to Henry's newly revealed alien identity frightened her. Maria Rambeau only tightened her hold on her daughter, watching him warily.

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"If being shocked could change the facts, then maybe I should act shocked. But as someone who's never known his parents since childhood, should I really be surprised by my origins?

"If the timing weren't off, and someone told me today that I was the son of Kennedy and Marilyn Monroe, I might even believe it. Being an alien doesn't really seem worth making a fuss over."

Marilyn Monroe died in 1962, John F. Kennedy was assassinated in 1963. Henry arrived on Earth around 1970—he couldn't even fake a connection if he tried.

In truth, Henry felt a sense of relief. At last, his origins had been confirmed.

Based on his abilities, he had long suspected he was Kryptonian—everything matched Superman's powers, though the exact level was uncertain. But whether Krypton even existed in this universe had always troubled him.

Now, hearing from the Skrulls that "Krypton" did indeed exist here—albeit with a different history—at least confirmed that he wasn't the result of some double or triple dimensional crossover.

A new question immediately followed:

If Krypton was universally hated across the cosmos, why had he ended up on Earth?

Talos, who clearly knew far more about Krypton than Henry did, instantly grasped the source of the unease he'd been feeling all along.

The Skrull general laughed heartily.

"Ha! Looks like you're an exiled defective."

"An exiled defective?" Henry tilted his head, clearly reacting to the term, and looked at the Skrull general with his condescending air.

Talos wasn't about to hold back—this was his chance to savor a sense of superiority.

"Do you know what's most disgusting about Kryptonian civilization?

"Unlike normal lifeforms, your people don't reproduce naturally, male or female. Krypton relies on the so-called 'Codex' system to continue its species—two individuals contribute DNA, and a child with no genetic defects is produced.

"From the moment that child is born, their future role is already decided—engineer, soldier, artist. Society runs like a perfectly meshed machine, devoid of passion. Whatever kind of person is needed, that kind of child is manufactured.

"But even the most perfect system produces anomalies. Children born naturally—without passing through the Codex—are labeled 'defectives' by your civilization.

"And defectives have only one fate: exile. They're sealed into pods and launched randomly into space, originally meant to be sent into the Phantom Zone that surrounds Krypton.

"But for someone like you—not captured by the Phantom Zone, not landing on an uninhabitable world or being swallowed by a star, but instead falling onto a life-bearing planet—that kind of luck is the first in nine thousand years. You should be proud."

Though his words spoke of "pride," the mockery in his tone was unmistakable.

Don't be fooled by the Skrulls' current status as refugees hunted by the Kree. According to Marvel canon, the Kree built their empire by exploiting the Skrulls. The Skrulls themselves once established a vast empire, standing alongside the Kree and the Shi'ar as one of the three great galactic powers.

Henry, of course, didn't expose the Skrulls' past—he wasn't supposed to know any of that. Instead, he countered their accusations directly:

"So discrimination against Kryptonians is why you've repeatedly framed me? You even dragged an innocent child into it!"

Shrewdly, Henry pulled Monica Rambeau—the little Black girl with the wild afro—into the picture, tying himself to her and seizing the moral high ground to condemn the Skrulls.

That move alone caused the Skrulls' standing in everyone else's eyes to plummet further.

Already viewed unfavorably, they now faced openly hostile expressions from Nick Fury, Vers, and the others—looks that practically screamed I don't like you.

Talos hadn't anticipated that the atmosphere would shift so sharply against him.

Chapter 361 - 361 — The Reason for Revealing Himself

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General Talos was only one step away from his objective. Unfortunately, the crucial memory-extraction device had been destroyed along with the Skrull ship, reduced to cosmic dust.

Although the Skrulls' science officer had also taken refuge on this primitive planet—and rebuilding the device wouldn't be much of a problem—Talos simply couldn't wait that long.

The best solution was to directly win over Vers, who had likewise been deceived by the Kree, and have her willingly reveal the information he wanted.

That was far easier than capturing her and strapping her onto another memory-extraction device. The consequences of the first attempt were still fresh in his mind: despite starting with her hands restrained, she had crushed twenty of his best soldiers and blown up the ship as a bonus.

With manpower and resources already stretched thin, Talos had no courage left to gamble like that again. So he defended himself:

"I have to say this—Kryptonians have an absolutely terrible reputation throughout the universe. Your kind's way of doing things borders on boundless madness. Anyone would be afraid.

"And our goal is simply to secure a slim chance of survival for our people. We don't have the luxury of trial and error. So you must understand—when we saw a Kryptonian, our first instinct was to eliminate you as a variable.

"If you truly arrived on this planet by a rare coincidence and have remained sane, I can order my people to abandon their hostility toward you. You were never our target.

"As for what happened to the girl, I offer my sincerest apologies. And you needn't worry about alien pathogens—we can have our medical officer provide advanced treatment.

"Look—we've shown ourselves in our true forms, and we're unarmed. That's our sincerity. Why don't we sit down and talk?"

Once again, Nick Fury took control of the situation. He lowered his gun first and said,

"What exactly is there to talk about? All I've seen is you people causing trouble and hijacking other people's identities.

"I won't even bother asking whether Agent Keller is still alive. Now that you think you have the numbers and a sure win, you suddenly want to talk—is that it?"

Facing the challenge, Talos nodded slightly. Most of the Skrulls immediately shifted back into human disguises and exited the house, reducing the sense of pressure inside.

One Skrull remained behind—smaller in stature, with distinctly female features. Talos said,

"This is our medical officer. Would you like her to examine the girl's wounds?"

"No!" Maria Rambeau snapped, still completely unwilling to trust the Skrulls as she shielded her daughter.

Talos made the same choice Henry had earlier—he didn't force the issue. He sent the shorter Skrull out as well and stayed behind alone to face Fury and the others.

"Let me clarify one thing first. Unless absolutely necessary, we do not kill those we impersonate. Agent Keller is still alive—he just has a bump on his head. By now, he should already be back with S.H.I.E.L.D.

"And I don't have much to discuss with humans. But with you, Vers—assuming that's what you go by now. Or should I call you Carol Danvers?—there is room for conversation.

"I believe you're also very interested in what really happened in that accident six years ago. And I just happen to have the audio recording from the crash site, taken

He had appeared in his true form intending to negotiate and recruit. Yet after hearing his subordinates' reports, he'd agreed to framing the Kryptonian—only to realize now that the trap had backfired spectacularly.

At this point, all he could do was try to salvage the situation—because letting things deteriorate any further would only make matters worse.

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from what you humans call the 'black box.'"

Maria Rambeau, who had been half-distracted by the Skrulls, blurted out in disbelief,

"That's impossible. They told us nothing survived the crash—including the black box."

Talos smiled faintly, with a hint of pride.

"That's what they told you. But our racial abilities allow us access to places others can't easily reach—and to obtain things others can't."

As he spoke, Talos produced a disc from inside his coat.

"This recording is extremely valuable. Don't you want to hear it? For example, it may reveal that we are all victims of the Kree—not enemies."

Nick Fury didn't make the decision for Vers. He simply looked at the woman who claimed to be a member of the Kree Starforce.

Vers herself was deeply conflicted. She challenged him:

"Why should I believe you?"

"That depends on whether you're curious about the truth," Talos replied calmly. "If you weren't curious at all, why would you chase down the Pegasus Project in the first place? Why not simply report our location and have an army sent to wipe us out?"

"Why are you doing all this?" Vers asked. "What are you looking for?"

Talos answered,

"Dr. Wendy Lawson was actually a defecting Kree scientist—Mar-Vell. She realized she was fighting an unjust war and chose to support the Skrulls instead.

"And the way she chose to help was by developing a faster-than-light engine, hoping to lead the remaining Skrulls out of the Kree Empire's grasp. That's why I say everything I've done is for the survival of my people.

"As for why she chose this backward planet for her research, I don't yet know. But one thing I do know is this—Mar-Vell, or Dr. Lawson, trusted you. So I've chosen to trust you as well. Please don't betray that trust."

One of the main reasons Vers had abandoned her primary mission to pursue the truth was precisely because of Dr. Wendy Lawson.

Her Starforce commander, Yon-Rogg, had once said that when meeting the Supreme Intelligence, everyone saw the person they respected and valued most.

Yet Vers had never known who that silver-haired elderly woman was, or why she mattered so much to her.

Only after the Skrulls' machine began extracting her memories did unfamiliar fragments surface—among them, images of Dr. Lawson.

So rather than defeating the Skrulls outright, Vers wanted to know what truth lay behind the accident six years ago. Once she had the answers, she could always fight them later if necessary.

But before she could respond, an orange cat suddenly slipped between everyone's feet and wandered toward the Skrulls.

The moment it approached, Talos completely lost his composure. He stumbled backward several steps and pressed himself against the wall, shouting in panic,

"Oh no—get that thing away from me! Don't let it come any closer!"

Vers scooped up the orange cat and cradled it against her chest, deliberately stepping closer to Talos as if teasing him.

"You're scared of a cat? The tiger over there is far more terrifying, you know."

"That thing is not a cat!" Talos yelled. "It's a Flerken!"

"A Flerken?" The unfamiliar word immediately drew mocking looks from everyone present, all directed at the Skrull general who had been so arrogant just moments ago—only to crumble in an instant.

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Chapter 362 - 362 — The Black Box Revealed

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The Skrulls' complete collapse in composure allowed everyone else to quietly reclaim a bit of control over the situation.

Vers turned to Maria Rambeau, who was finishing bandaging Monica's wound, and asked, "Maria, do you have anything that can play that thing?"

General Talos cautiously reminded them, "It's best to use a computer. The files on that disc aren't ordinary audio tracks—normal players won't work." As he spoke, he still didn't dare get too close to the woman holding the Flerken.

While packing up the first-aid kit, Maria Rambeau shot the Skrull an irritated look. In the end, she still compromised. "I do. There's a modern computer in my workshop. I can try to see if it can read what's on the disc."

The truth from six years ago wasn't something only the Skrulls wanted to know. Vers wanted it. Maria Rambeau—who had lost her closest friend—wanted it as well. What exactly had been recorded in that black box, which her superiors had claimed was destroyed? Of course she was curious.

As for the score over her daughter being bitten, that could be set aside for now. It wasn't forgiven—just postponed.

Everyone moved to a small detached building next to the main house. One room was filled with tools and materials, while another, quieter room contained a desk with a state-of-the-art computer running Windows 95.

While the system booted up, Maria Rambeau led her daughter outside the workshop and sat her down on a chair. She took out a Walkman and a pair of headphones.

The girl with the explosive afro, having clearly learned nothing from being bitten by a tiger, protested loudly, "Why can't I listen too? I want to know what happened!"

"No negotiations," Maria said firmly. "If this is classified material, just hearing it would be a crime. Don't think being young gives you a free pass—this isn't an ordinary offense. There's no juvenile protection for breaches of secrecy."

"Fine," Monica Rambeau said, not the type to throw a senseless tantrum. With her mother's help, she put on the headphones and listened to the music.

As a retired Air Force pilot—and one who had participated in classified projects—Maria Rambeau was extremely sensitive about matters like this. Retirement hadn't dulled that instinct at all.

After making sure her daughter was protected, she looked at the others. The meaning in her eyes was obvious.

Henry was the first to raise both hands and back away. "I'm just a civilian. I don't have clearance for classified material. I'll wait outside." With that, he took Katie with him and moved away from the workshop, stopping under the shade of a tree, facing the Skrulls who had once again disguised themselves as humans from a distance.

Barbara Morse, the S.H.I.E.L.D. trainee, wasn't quite sure where she stood. In the end, Nick Fury gave her instructions.

"Bobbi, keep an eye on the Skrulls. If they make any suspicious moves, shoot immediately. I'll hear the gunfire from inside."

"Yes, sir," Barbara replied. Instead of standing with Henry, she took position by a pillar on the workshop's porch—able to monitor the Skrulls while also guarding the workshop behind her, as well as the Black girl sitting outside.

Henry could afford to leave so casually because of his super hearing. He could hear everything happening inside the workshop without being present—avoiding unnecessary suspicion or the risk of violating secrecy laws.

After all, his super hearing hadn't been exposed yet. Not using it properly would be a waste.

The black box playback was, in essence, an audio recording of Carol Danvers piloting the experimental aircraft during its test flight, with Dr. Wendy Lawson seated in the copilot's seat—the recording from their final flight on the day of the accident.

Chapter 363 - 363 — Defeat Does Not Equal Victimhood

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Compared to the Skrulls' grating attempts at persuasion, what truly shook Carol Danvers was the voice of her closest friend.

After the crash, the equipment hadn't completely shut down, so any sounds near the microphone were still captured.

This included Dr. Lawson bleeding blue blood, and the two of them being pursued by alien spacecraft outside Earth's atmosphere—so many elements that defied common sense that it was no wonder the Air Force investigators had never dared to release the recording.

But for the person involved, hearing words she herself had once spoken caused those memories to surface all at once—along with even more buried information.

Who had killed Dr. Wendy Lawson. Why she herself had been gravely injured and fallen into a coma. What crucial memories she had lost. And who the true instigator behind it all was.

As everything came flooding back, it shattered the worldview she had built over the past six years.

She was not a proud Kree warrior. She wasn't even Kree at all—she was a native of Earth, a human from a backward planet.

For Vers—or rather, Carol Danvers—she didn't even know which was more devastating: the collapse of her worldview, or the realization that she had been deceived and exploited by the Kree.

The lost warrior burst out of the workshop, seemingly wanting to scream at the sky—but the pressure choking her chest prevented any sound from coming out.

The Skrull general followed close behind. This was exactly the moment he had been waiting for. The enemy of my enemy is my friend—a truth that held across the universe.

He did his best to persuade Carol Danvers, now with her memories restored, to stand on the same side as the Skrulls. This was the very reason he had revealed his true form and confronted these humans face-to-face.

"So what exactly do you want me to do?" Carol Danvers snapped, already agitated. "You heard it yourself—the faster-than-light engine was destroyed. It blew up. Nothing was left."

Being harassed by people she had considered enemies just moments ago, when her emotions were already in turmoil, she was showing remarkable restraint by not blasting them with a photon blast. Changing sides was even more out of the question.

Talos, however, knew more than these Earthlings. "No. What was destroyed was only the faster-than-light engine itself. The engine's core was stored elsewhere. That location—that's what I'm looking for."

"And if I let you get your hands on something like that," Carol shot back, "won't you just use it for war? Like what happened to the planet Torfa—reduced to ruins, its civilization completely destroyed?"

"No! That wasn't us," Talos said firmly. "That was Accuser Ronan's doing—to wipe us out. We were nothing more than refugees, struggling to survive on Torfa."

"You're lying—"

Talos cut in, his voice softer, almost pleading. "I don't know what the Kree told you. But our goal has always been just one thing: to find the faster-than-light engine that Dr. Wendy Lawson was researching for us.

"And then use it to gather our people, scattered across the galaxy, and escape to a place the Kree can never find. A quiet life. Maybe beyond the Milky Way—another distant galaxy, or even another universe. Anywhere will do."

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Maria Rambeau said softly, "Do you remember? The doctor once said that what she was researching wasn't meant for war—but to end war."

General Talos immediately seized the opening. "Exactly. Mar-Vell—who you called Dr. Lawson—agreed with that, which is why she chose to help us.

"You know the Kree's methods yourself. At the very least, when I said the devastation of Torfa was carried out by Accuser Ronan, you didn't refute me. Because you know it's exactly the sort of thing the Kree are capable of.

"If you were willing to trust Dr. Lawson, why not try trusting us as well? Ms. Rambeau, I also thank you for speaking frankly—your judgment wasn't clouded, even with what happened to your daughter.

"Of course, regarding the girl's injury, I offer my deepest apologies. She was never our real target. If there is anything we can do to make amends, please say so."

For the sake of winning Carol Danvers over, the Skrull general had lowered his posture considerably.

Even Maria Rambeau—who by all rights should have been furious over her daughter being injured—found herself unconsciously shifting her stance and choosing to support the Skrulls on this matter, regardless of whether she still intended to settle that score later.

Perhaps the fact that the Kree had deceived and exploited her closest friend, and made her believe that friend had been dead for six years, weighed far more heavily in her heart.

No one knew what Nick Fury was thinking, but he made no move to interfere with Carol Danvers' decision. He simply allowed the others to continue persuading her.

His attitude, in turn, influenced Barbara's. The young woman, fresh out of school, walked over with barely contained excitement to the Kryptonian whose identity had just been exposed.

"Henry, the Skrulls are basically cosmic refugees now—driven out and hunted everywhere. The Kree, on the other hand, spread violence everywhere, even brainwashing and controlling Lieutenant Danvers. It looks like we should help the Skrulls and fight the Kree together. Will you join us too?"

Sitting on the grass with his back against a tree, Henry was enjoying the sunlight filtering through the leaves while absentmindedly rubbing Katie's massive tiger head.

Hearing the invitation, he simply stood up, brushed off his backside, and asked in return, "Why should we join a war that doesn't belong to us?"

Nick Fury walked over and answered him. "Because we've already been dragged into it. If Earth doesn't have the power to knock both sides flat, then the only choice left is to help one side resist the other."

The conversation among Fury, Barbara, and Henry drew the others closer. Even Carol Danvers was curious—would this man who traveled with a tiger choose to join them?

It wasn't a question of underestimating his combat value. Earth's gunpowder weapons might not pierce his defenses, but out in the cosmos there were far stronger individual weapons—more than enough to punch through what a backward civilization might mistakenly believe to be invincible.

Seeing the Skrulls approaching as well, Henry made no effort to hide his displeasure. "Ms. Vers... or rather, Ms. Danvers."

"Just call me Carol."

"Looks like you've accepted your new identity—or rather, recovered your old one. But I don't know how much you remember about Earth. Do you remember World War II?"

"World War II?"

"The Second World War, from 1939 to 1945. Sixty-one countries took part, over two billion people were affected, and around 110 million directly participated. The largest war in Earth's history, in terms of both scale and manpower."

Carol Danvers frowned, then relaxed. "I remember now. But why are you bringing this up?"

"Near the end of the war, Berlin and Tokyo were bombed by the Allies. In the end, those two Axis nations surrendered and became the defeated powers. Do you think

Chapter 364 364 — Parting Waysa

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All the resentment Henry had been bottling up finally erupted at once. He was only a step away from pointing at the other man's nose and cursing him out.

"Have you ever stopped to think about how I got dragged into this mess in the first place? If it weren't for you Skrulls sneaking into Bobaibi's organization for no damn reason anAh d trying to frame me, I'd be getting ready to clock out at Stark Industries right about now.

"Do I have any blood feud with the Kree? No. You are my problem. After all the chaos you stirred up, I don't even know if I'll ever get back to a normal life.

"Do you have any idea what kind of consequences your earlier attempt to frame me might cause? Or what kind of changes exposing my Kryptonian identity—something I didn't even know about myself—will bring to my life?

"Did any of you spare a thought for that? Of course not. To you, a crazed Kryptonian with no organization and no backing is just like a stone by the roadside—pick it up and toss it into the river, done."

Suppressing the urge to smash the other man's skull with a single punch, Henry stepped back, his expression dark.

about:blank

the German and Japanese people of that time deserved sympathy?"

"Of course not!" Carol replied without hesitation. "Whether in Europe or East Asia, their invasions caused unimaginable loss of life and economic devastation. Why should the aggressors be pitied?"

"Exactly. That's my answer too." Henry shrugged, utterly unconcerned.

"Kryptonian, what are you trying to imply?" Talos snapped angrily, pointedly emphasizing that Henry wasn't an Earthling either. "Are you saying the suffering of my people is a lie?"

"I never said it was fake," Henry replied calmly. "I just don't know whether you're innocent—or whether that suffering was earned."

Talos bristled. "I can state this responsibly: the war began because the Kree coveted Skrull technology. After stealing our starship and weapon designs, they turned around and invaded us.

"Our homeworld was destroyed, our people slaughtered. The Kree even hunted down those kind enough to help us. Even toward innocent planets and neutral powers, their approach has always been conquest—not peace.

"Look at your own kind—no, not your kind. Just look at what happened to Lieutenant Danvers. Do you really think other Earthlings would receive kinder treatment from the Kree?

"If you don't rise up and resist, today's fate of the Skrulls will be Earth's fate tomorrow. Anyone with common sense shouldn't harbor any illusions about that militaristic empire."

A slow, sarcastic clap echoed from Henry's hands. "Well said. Truly. Then let me ask you this—Carol, you served in the Kree forces. Do you know the real reason for this war?"

Struggling internally, unsure whether she should repeat words she no longer fully believed, Carol Danvers finally spoke.

"The Skrulls believe it's their duty to conquer and rule every planet in the universe, claiming that this brings peace. Using their racial abilities, they infiltrate worlds and overthrow governments from within.

"In the end, they either establish colonial rule... or destroy the planet. The Kree are the ones resisting all of that—the saviors. Are you saying the Kree's narrative is true?"

Henry answered flatly, "That's something I don't know. All I know is this—it isn't my war."

At this, Talos exclaimed heatedly, "I admit that I've done terrible things in this war. But so what? The reality now is that the Skrulls are being hunted and exterminated like insects—and it's the Kree who are doing it!"

Henry met his fury head-on, unflinching. "You lost. You were driven out like homeless dogs by the Kree, so you have your reasons to resist.

"Carol Danvers was brainwashed and controlled by the Kree—so her rebellion after waking up is only natural. But what about me?"

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"Since you've decided to cooperate, then this no longer has anything to do with me. Let me make this perfectly clear: I have no interest in obstructing your plans.

"I didn't even know what Skrulls were, what Kree were, or what a Kryptonian was at the beginning. None of this concerns me. So don't disturb my life again. Goodbye."

With that, Henry turned around and prepared to leave—only to find every path blocked by Skrulls wearing human disguises.

Seeing them form a semicircle and cut off all exits, Henry turned back irritably.

"So this means you're not letting me leave? Mr. Fury, do you agree with this?"

The dark-skinned man who'd been named looked troubled. He truly hadn't expected things to develop this way. At the very least, cooperating with the Skrulls hadn't been an option at the start. And he wasn't sure whether he should really let Henry—now exposed as a Kryptonian—just walk away.

General Talos, however, was clearly the sort who adjusted his attitude based on who he was dealing with.

When it came to recruiting Carol Danvers, he lowered himself, pleading humbly, practically one step away from hugging her leg.

But facing a banished Kryptonian—a defeated enemy from a Skrull fleet thousands of years ago—his pride as a member of a higher civilization surfaced uncontrollably.

"How about this, Kryptonian. I apologize for my earlier mistake. I'll make you an offer: help us fight the Kree, and I'll use my assumed authority to rescind the previous orders issued against you. That should be enough, shouldn't it?"

Henry actually laughed in anger.

Back then, Mystique of the X-Men had started with personal favors, mixed in threats, and kept raising the stakes until he gave in. He'd compromised because he knew that if she truly wanted to make trouble, he'd end up just as exhausted as he was now.

But the Skrulls had already crossed the line—repeatedly trying to frame him. And now they were using "cleaning up the mess" as leverage to coerce his cooperation.

How were these situations even comparable?

A gun only carries negotiating power before the trigger is pulled. Once it's fired, positions are clear. At that point, what difference is there between compromise and surrender?

"If apologies worked, the world wouldn't need laws or police. If threats worked, then I deserve to be threatened a second time, a third time.

"I've said it already—this isn't my war. Don't drag an innocent bystander into it."

With that, Henry let out a sharp whistle. Katie, who had been lying on the ground, immediately stood up. Man and tiger turned to leave.

But the Skrull foot soldiers, still disguised as humans, stood shoulder to shoulder, blocking his path.

Just as Henry was considering how to break through, Nick Fury spoke up from behind him.

"Henry, you don't even have a car. How are you planning to leave? This place is a long way from any bus station or airport."

After thinking for a moment, Henry replied, "I just need to walk down the road with Katie. Sooner or later, the police will pick me up and give me a ride. No need to trouble yourselves.

"And if you really are short on manpower, you shouldn't be wasting people on me. So—are they really going to stand there blocking the way?"

Using his slightly taller frame, Henry glared at the Skrulls in front of him, seriously weighing what kind of consequences revealing the fact that he could punch someone's head clean off would bring.

Or should he just let the tiger loose?

In the end, it was Nick Fury who stepped in to smooth things over.

"Talos, tell your people to clear the way. Let my friend leave. You're the one asking us for help—not the one giving orders. Remember that."

"No. You don't know what a mad Kryptonian might do. Should I list some of the things they've done in the past? They're nothing but deranged beasts," Talos insisted.

Even Carol Danvers couldn't stand it anymore.

"Don't project your prejudice against an entire race onto one person," she snapped.

"During the time Henry traveled with us, he controlled both himself and his companion perfectly. The ones causing trouble the whole time were you.

Chapter 365 - 365 — An Exposed Weakness

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Henry shot Barbara Morse a strange look when she followed him.

He really wanted to say, Woman, you're slowing me down—in the literal sense, not as some metaphor. But in the end, Henry didn't refuse her company.

Once he noticed that the Skrulls behind them had already left together with Nick Fury and the others, he finally asked,

"Why did you come with me? Shouldn't you be helping Fury?"

"Fury said that if he doesn't make it back, there should at least be someone who knows the truth and can report it to the agency. So he told me to leave with you."

After a moment's thought, Barbara added, "He doesn't completely trust the Skrulls either."

"Mm." Henry, deep in thought, only responded with a single sound.

"We don't need to wait for the police to give us a ride. I'll contact the local S.H.I.E.L.D. branch and have them send someone to pick us up. If things move fast enough, we should be back in Los Angeles by tomorrow."

With that, Barbara took out her phone and began making the call.

Henry didn't stop her. His mind was still turning over the information the Skrulls had revealed about Kryptonians.

The greatest weakness of Kryptonians had already been publicly exposed by General Talos. However, in this universe, Krypton hadn't exploded—so there was no kryptonite. Instead, the widely known Kryptonian weakness was green sunlight.

In Henry's memories from before transmigrating, in DC Comics the planet Barrington, suspended beneath a green sun, had indeed caused serious trouble for Superman and Supergirl. It wasn't instantly lethal, but in such a weakened state, a Kryptonian without assistance could easily be killed.

"I can agree to help you. But forcing someone who doesn't want to be involved—what's the point? Hoping for an 'accident' during the fighting? Don't make the little sympathy I just developed evaporate completely."

When the key figure spoke, her words carried weight. The Skrull general finally relented, waving his hand for his subordinates to step aside.

"I hope you won't regret today's decision," he muttered.

For Nick Fury and Carol Danvers, Henry's departure wasn't a choice between friend and enemy. This war had nothing to do with Earth's survival—it was simply a question of whether they were willing to help the Skrulls.

Under those circumstances, who had the right to force an uninvolved outsider to help?

Nick Fury hadn't forgotten what happened to the last Black Californian congressman who tried that kind of thing. Henry Brown was a textbook case of someone who responded to kindness but not coercion—and who had nothing tying him down.

Well... maybe that was no longer entirely true. His Kryptonian identity, and Charlize Theron's presence in his life, might yet change how he acted in the future.

But for now, Nick Fury knew better than to push things too far. He raised his voice and said:

"Henry, don't worry about the trouble surrounding you.

"Once I've handled things on my end, I'll go back and clean up the mess these extraterrestrial guests caused. Assuming that director Keller in my organization is still alive."

As he spoke, Nick Fury shot Talos a sharp glare. Helping Carol Danvers—and incidentally the Skrulls—didn't mean he fully trusted these green-skinned shapeshifters.

He then called Barbara over, whispered a few instructions into her ear, and gestured for the trainee agent to leave.

Barbara Morse wore a regretful expression, clearly disappointed that she wouldn't get to take part in a battle involving aliens. But she also understood priorities and didn't act on impulse.

"Henry, I'll go with you," Barbara said, hurrying after the man and the tiger as they walked away.

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And then there were all those stories involving red suns and yellow suns across parallel universes, with Supermen crossing into each other's worlds and becoming as fragile as ordinary people on the other side.

So one thing was clear: what affected Kryptonians wasn't kryptonite itself, but the star-like radiation that kryptonite emitted.

From that, it followed that different colors of kryptonite causing different effects could be extrapolated into different colors of sunlight having similar influences on Kryptonians.

The most common green kryptonite weakened Kryptonians; when made into weapons, it could injure or kill them.

Red kryptonite caused drastic personality changes, often manifesting as an opposite persona—and sometimes the change was permanent, persisting even after the kryptonite was removed.

Blue kryptonite canceled out the effects of red kryptonite and could temporarily strip Kryptonians of their powers.

Black kryptonite split a Kryptonian into separate good and evil personas.

Gold kryptonite permanently removed a Kryptonian's powers without affecting their descendants.

Silver kryptonite made Kryptonians neurotic, inducing hallucinations and amplifying negative emotions.

Pink kryptonite turned Kryptonians into "gay Kryptonians"—or, by some accounts, directly caused gender reversal.

Platinum kryptonite granted non-Kryptonians Kryptonian abilities.

Orange kryptonite temporarily gave animals—other than humans—superpowers.

Those were the general categories of naturally occurring kryptonite; artificially synthesized or anomalous variants were another matter entirely.

If stellar light of different colors truly had the same effects on Kryptonians, then it wasn't hard to understand why the Skrulls described Kryptonian fleets as insane.

After all, a spacefaring civilization whose temperament and power fluctuated wildly with environmental conditions—sometimes deranged, sometimes malevolent, sometimes with an entire fleet floating around in pink bubbles—would leave any enemy utterly dumbfounded.

Worse still, Kryptonians remembered everything they did while under the influence of kryptonite or altered sunlight, even after recovering. Those memories and emotions would then feed back into their core personality.

Superman himself often felt deep remorse after returning to normal and recalling what he'd done while affected by kryptonite.

For Henry, who planned to stay on Earth and had no intention of roaming the cosmos, he didn't need to worry much about other colors of stars altering his personality. What he did need to consider was how Nick Fury might make use of this information.

First of all, natural kryptonite existed in Krypton's core. It wasn't something you could just pick up off the surface. As long as Krypton didn't explode, no one would ever discover it.

As for using artificial "sun lamps" of different colors to influence Kryptonians—Henry felt that was also unlikely.

In DC Comics, only two entities openly possessed the technology to synthesize kryptonite: the cosmic tyrant Brainiac, and Superman's archenemy, Lex Luthor. Later on, others followed—but without Luthor opening the door, the technology wouldn't have spread.

Batman never publicly admitted to being able to synthesize kryptonite; he merely collected and stored natural samples. Though, admittedly, everyone suspected he could...

If artificial kryptonite was that difficult to produce, did Earth really have the capability to develop sun lamps capable of affecting Kryptonians?

This wasn't like dealing with vampires—shine some UV light and you get burns, maybe even disintegration.

The underlying mechanism by which kryptonite—or stellar radiation of different colors—altered Kryptonian physiology and psychology had never been definitively explained.

If the difficulty level were raised to something comparable to the neighboring "genius tier," then maybe—maybe—this universe could create sun lamps that affected Kryptonians. But it would likely require someone on the level of Reed Richards to pull it off.

...

Well, originally Henry had thought it impossible for this universe to artificially recreate his weakness. But the more he thought about it, the more plausible it seemed.

Chapter 366 366 — Possible Landmines Hidden in the Universe

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Another piece of evidence supporting Henry's line of thinking came, of course, from the movie The Flash.

No matter how many times Barry rewound time in the Flashpoint timeline—where his parents were both alive—he was never able to save Supergirl, Kara Zor-El, from being killed by General Zod.

Zod also retrieved the Genesis Codex from Supergirl's body. He even mentioned that he had already detected Kal-El's escape pod somewhere in the universe. After killing the infant, he confirmed that the Codex was not inside Kal-El, which was why he continued his pursuit all the way to Earth.

Some people believed that Supergirl lost to Zod in the Flashpoint world simply because she had been imprisoned by the Russians for too long, without enough exposure to sunlight to properly power up.

But General Zod himself was also a Kryptonian. Following the plot of Man of Steel, he didn't start receiving yellow-sun empowerment the moment he broadcast his message searching for Kryptonians on Earth.

He only began to absorb yellow-sun radiation after reaching the planet's surface and engaging in battle—specifically after Superman shattered his helmet and exposed him directly to the sun, at which point he adapted rapidly.

In other words, the length of time Zod was empowered by the yellow sun wasn't significantly longer than Supergirl's. If the Codex inside Kara Zor-El were truly that miraculous, why hadn't it enabled her to defeat Zod?

A rarely discussed background detail was that Kara Zor-El herself had been born under the control of the Codex. She belonged to the engineer template, just like her parents and lineage.

Krypton's Codex-based reproduction system, beyond ensuring genetic superiority, obviously wouldn't allow a military family to produce a musician, or a ruling family to produce a scientist.

Especially when Reed Richards—infamous for his talent for causing trouble—was involved.

It made Henry feel that from now on, whenever someone approached him with a flashlight, or tried to turn on a light, he'd need to be extra cautious.

In the movies and comics he'd seen before transmigrating, General Zod and his fellow Kryptonians wore individual combat armor that seemed capable of isolating solar radiation.

Only when their armor was damaged or deliberately removed did they begin to absorb yellow sunlight and grow stronger.

Who knew how Kryptonians in this universe worked? Or whether their individual armor had the same properties? Not to mention that those events had occurred nine thousand years ago—roughly the span of time it took Earth to progress from the Neolithic Age to the modern era.

Another point Henry fixated on was the fact that he was classified as an exiled defective—a naturally born Kryptonian.

Many believed Superman's strength came from his father, Jor-El, breaking down Krypton's genetic archive—the Genesis Codex—and infusing it into his blood. But that explanation had never been officially confirmed.

While American comics treated retcons like everyday meals, none of Superman's versions ever claimed his power came from carrying the Codex within him. At most, it was said that Superman held the key to Krypton's rebirth—yet he could also choose to become the guardian of its tomb.

What was consistent across all depictions of Krypton's origin was its rigidly stratified society. From the moment of birth, every child's future was already decided.

Only Kal-El—born naturally to Jor-El and Lara—stood apart. He was the first naturally born Kryptonian child in thousands of years.

Because he wasn't created through the Codex, his potential hadn't been artificially constrained. He wasn't locked into a predetermined path. All possibilities lay open to him.

In Henry's view, that was the true reason Superman was so powerful.

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There had to be continuity in familial traits—otherwise postnatal education and training would be meaningless.

Compared to a top-tier soldier template like General Zod, it was only natural that Supergirl, an engineer, would fall short in raw combat ability.

That wasn't even counting the fact that Zod had clawed his way up through countless large and small battles to earn the rank of general, while Kara Zor-El in The Flash had been captured by the Russians around her teenage years and locked away in a sunless laboratory for experimentation.

The disparity in postnatal training and lived experience between the two was simply enormous.

Given both innate and acquired differences, if an engineer were somehow able to reverse-kill a general, it would be nothing short of a mockery of Krypton's long-maintained Codex reproduction system.

So Supergirl's defeat was inevitable—no matter how many times the Flash rewound time, that outcome couldn't be changed.

As for the naturally born Kal-El, he had been captured and crushed by General Zod while still in space, without ever having the chance to demonstrate his potential.

Henry couldn't help but connect all this to what General Talos had said—about him being a defective, a Kryptonian outcast.

Even though he couldn't be sure whether his origins truly matched what the Skrull general had described, nor whether Kryptonian traits worked exactly as Henry theorized, he never believed he could grow to rival Superman himself.

But if Kryptonian tradition truly involved exiling naturally born "defectives" into space—and if most of those infants were captured by the Phantom Zone encircling Krypton—

Then, based on DC's official settings regarding the Phantom Zone, the least controversial aspect was that time did not exist there. It lay outside normal space-time continuity, a trans-dimensional realm.

Those imprisoned within did not die. In some versions, consciousness stagnated; in others, awareness remained active, and prisoners could even move about—enduring endless, meaningless passage.

If Henry's speculation was correct, this meant that Krypton had effectively dumped all potential "Superman seeds" into a storage space even better than cryogenic

vaults.

Over thousands of years, just how many naturally born Kryptonian infants had been trapped there?

Even Darkseid would probably rather face an army of Doomsdays than an army of Supermen.

Of course, it was also possible that in this universe the Phantom Zone worked differently—entering it meant instant death, end of story.

As for whether the difference between Codex-born and naturally born Kryptonians truly worked as Henry imagined, he couldn't be one hundred percent certain.

He could only guess that he hadn't been born according to any fixed occupational template. But that kind of birth didn't mean he would inevitably grow into another Superman. It was also possible that he carried some genetic defect.

After all, Krypton's Genesis Codex was essentially an extension of eugenics. Any genetic flaws, or defects arising during embryonic development, would be filtered out by that reproductive system.

Natural birth bypassed that entire elimination process.

But whether or not he was naturally born only affected his future potential. What truly mattered for survival was that his identity as a Kryptonian—and Kryptonian weaknesses—had been exposed in front of Nick Fury.

Fortunately, because so much time had passed, the Skrulls only remembered Kryptonians as mad, unstable beings influenced by different stellar lights. They no longer remembered the specifics of Kryptonian power changes.

Which meant that most of Henry's abilities were still secrets to Fury—aside from his already exposed invulnerable body.

If the Skrulls had still remembered how Kryptonians behaved under a yellow sun, they would have used manipulation and sowed discord just the same, dragging him into conflict with official organizations—but they likely wouldn't have confronted him head-on.

Yet judging from their earlier behavior, these aliens from a higher civilization were still just as arrogant as ever. They had actually dared to stand unarmed in front of a Kryptonian!

Chapter 367 367 — Aliens That Just Won’t Let Go

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During the ID check, the girl nudged Henry smugly with her elbow.

"See? S.H.I.E.L.D.'s benefits are pretty great, right? One phone call, and they're already arranging a flight to send us straight back to the West Coast."

Henry didn't say anything. He simply glanced at the girl beside him, then at the two S.H.I.E.L.D. agents standing in front of them.

The vehicle S.H.I.E.L.D. had sent to pick them up was a five-seat SUV.

For a typical family of four, it would count as a spacious, comfortable ride—perfect for road trips. But for Henry's group, with Henry and Barbara plus Kitty, who weighed somewhere between five and six hundred pounds, the back seat was... cramped.

To keep the "tabby cat" from getting uncomfortable and lashing out with claws or fangs, Henry had no choice but to wedge himself between Kitty and Barbara, physically separating them.

As everyone knew, the middle seat was the worst seat in the car...

That said, with a giant warm heat pack on his right and a soft, fragrant girl on his left, Henry didn't really have much to complain about.

The only real question was—where exactly were these two in front planning to take him?

"Sir," Henry asked calmly, "may I ask where we're headed right now?"

"We're heading east," the driver replied. "We'll be crossing into Mississippi and going to Keesler Air Force Base. It's a model base that's partially open to civilians, without heavy flight operations. We'll board a military cargo aircraft there and fly back to the West Coast."

Sitting in the middle, Henry subtly pressed against Barbara's body as he stole a glance at the sun's position outside the window.

What the driver and front passenger were saying sounded perfectly reasonable—so long as the car wasn't heading north.

At first, Barbara felt a little annoyed by Henry's seemingly impatient closeness. Even ignoring the two grown men in front, there was a full-grown tiger in the back seat—nothing about this was convenient.

But she wasn't a girl who only thought about sex.

Noticing where Henry was looking, she followed his gaze out the window. One glance was all it took for her to realize something was wrong.

If they were still in the city or a small town, detours and direction changes would be normal. But they were already on the highway. On this old interstate system, north

Henry genuinely wanted to let his fists loose and smash a few skulls.

Taking several deep breaths, he forced himself to calm down.

After all, they had provided a great deal of information about Krypton—knowledge he could never have obtained on Earth.

For that benefit alone, he decided to forgive their rudeness. He'd already endured far worse from Earthlings; surely he could tolerate a bit of alien arrogance too.

As Henry continued walking down the road, he was suddenly stopped by a vehicle that cut in front of him.

One man, one woman, and one tiger came to a halt.

Two men in black suits stepped out of the car and asked, "Are you Agent Barbara Morse?"

"Yes, sir. I'm Barbara Morse, S.H.I.E.L.D. trainee agent," Barbara answered.

The two men presented their credentials, bearing the S.H.I.E.L.D. eagle emblem.

"Hello, Agent Morse. We're agents from the New Orleans S.H.I.E.L.D. branch. We're here under orders to escort you to an Air Force base."

One of them glanced at Kitty and added, "Since one of the passengers is an adult tiger, we can't arrange civilian air travel. If we're sending you back to Los Angeles, it'll have to be via military transport aircraft. I trust you understand."

"That's fine," Barbara replied immediately, nodding as she handed over her ID for verification.

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and east were very different things.

Barbara knew that Keesler Air Force Base sat along the Gulf of Mexico. They had started in northern Louisiana—so even if they weren't going east, they should have been heading south. Continuing north was flat-out wrong.

Did S.H.I.E.L.D. really send a driver who didn't know the route?

If so, that would be an embarrassment for the most high-profile secret intelligence organization in the United States.

Henry quietly slipped his hand into Barbara's jacket.

Not toward any indecent location, but around it—he smoothly extracted the service pistol holstered under her arm.

Strictly speaking, this violated protocol. But out of trust, Barbara didn't stop him. Whether from personal experience or official reports, she knew this man wasn't the impulsive type.

Holding the gun low, hidden from the rearview mirror's blind spot, Henry asked casually,

"Officers, are you sure this is the right direction to Keesler Air Force Base?"

"Yes," the driver replied smoothly. "We'll be there very soon. Please be patient. The cargo-passenger aircraft assigned to you is already waiting on the runway. Once you board, it'll take off immediately."

If they had said something like orders from above required a detour, Henry might have hesitated—and Barbara would have stopped him.

But a lie this sloppy couldn't fool even a rookie trainee like Barbara.

In the blink of an eye, Henry raised the gun and shot the front passenger!

The driver yelped in shock, swerving violently.

Barbara and Kitty were both thrown off balance by the sudden movement, but Henry sat rock-solid, pressing the gun straight against the driver's temple.

"Please pull over," he said politely.

The sincerity in his voice only made it more chilling.

The "agent" slumped over the glove compartment, already revealing his true form—green skin, pointed ears. There was no mistaking a Skrull.

The driver, however, refused to stop, shouting in panic,

"Why did my partner turn into that?! What's going on?!"

"Your acting is terrible," Henry said flatly. "Don't try again—it's embarrassing to watch. Pull over to the side of the road. Don't make me repeat myself."

"Wait! I don't know anything! You can check my identity—"

Henry had no interest in listening to excuses from an enemy that had targeted him again and again.

He fired a shot straight into the man's left arm.

Then he pressed the muzzle back to the driver's head and said in a low voice,

"You're welcome to try flipping the car. But I promise you, I won't be hurt at all.

"It'll just make me angrier. And when I get angry, the consequences are serious. So cooperate, pull over, and I guarantee I won't kill you."

The driver grimaced and finally followed Henry's instructions, pulling the car onto the shoulder.

"You've really misunderstood me..."

Once the car stopped, Henry yanked the handbrake.

"Barbara, get out. And you—engine off, get out too."

Henry watched the driver's every move. Only after the man exited the vehicle did Henry finally relax slightly and step out himself, leaving the SUV that now held a dead alien.

The driver, clutching his bleeding arm, leaned against the hood, his face twisted in pain.

His performance was convincing enough that Barbara, watching from the side, began to doubt Henry's judgment.

Did we get it wrong?

Henry opened the door for Kitty and helped her out, then stuffed the gun back into Barbara's hand.

"Watch him," he said. "Where's that mobile phone you were using earlier?"

Having her weapon back in hand made Barbara feel more at ease.

The shot Henry had fired earlier had killed an alien—that was one thing. What scared her was the possibility that Henry might kill the wrong person. It wasn't

Chapter 368 368 — A Misunderstanding That Crossed the Line

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Before long, the call connected, and a gentle, clear female voice came through.

"This is Mr. Tony Stark's private line. May I ask who's calling?"

"This is Henry Brown. Please put me through to Mr. Stark. Just tell him I've got something interesting here and need his help dealing with it."

"Please hold."

The call switched to hold music. Not long after, it connected again. From the background noise, it sounded like the other end was in the middle of a lively party.

"If this thing isn't interesting, I'm flying to Los Angeles tomorrow and kicking your ass!" Tony Stark snarled over the phone. "That's your punishment for interrupting my flirting."

"I've got two aliens here," Henry said calmly. "One dead, one alive. Interested?"

"E.T.? I've got a full-scale model at home—picked it up from Amblin, probably used in the movie. You and I both know what that thing is. Wash your ass clean tomorrow. Don't dirty my shoes."

Henry chuckled.

"Not that kind of prop—real, living aliens. Well, one's had its brains splattered pretty badly and is dead.

"I know Stark Industries doesn't do biotech. But what about those organizations your uncles and aunts are involved with—interested? If not, I'll just call the cops.

"Let the state police haul the aliens away. Bury them, or put them in a museum for display—I don't care. What do you think?"

"Fuck!" Tony cursed, then asked sharply, "Where are you?"

"Uh, roughly on Louisiana State Highway 165, near the Arkansas border."

"Stay put."

Tony Stark hung up without ceremony.

Henry didn't feel the least bit offended. If anything, Tony's increasingly arrogant personality was starting to resemble the future Iron Man more and more. Whether that was a good thing or a bad thing, Henry couldn't quite tell.

Barbara, however, stared at Henry in astonishment.

"You can just contact Tony Stark directly?"

"Haha. I'm the CEO of Stark Pictures, you know. Talking to the big boss isn't a big deal. Being able to order him around—that's real skill."

Looking at the smug grin on his face, Barbara suddenly didn't know whether she should flatter him a bit or roast him mercilessly.

Before she could decide, the satellite phone in Henry's hand rang again.

Since he'd just made a call, it obviously wasn't a scam. Henry answered immediately, only to hear a low, aged voice on the other end.

about whose gun was used; she just didn't want this man to make a mistake.

Keeping her gun trained on the unidentified "agent," Barbara pulled out her phone with her free hand and passed it to Henry.

Henry looked at it, turned it over, raised it, lowered it—then sighed.

"No signal."

"There's none here?" Barbara leaned over to check. She had no solution either.

"Should we drive back?"

"No. I'll look inside the car."

Henry walked straight to the passenger side, opened the door, shoved the Skrull corpse backward, and rummaged through the glove compartment—coincidentally finding a satellite phone.

In reality, he'd already seen it with his X-ray vision.

Pulling out the antenna, and not caring in the slightest about call charges, Henry dialed the number without hesitation.

After all, it wasn't his bill.

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"Henry Brown?"

"Yes. Speaking. May I ask who this is?"

"You don't need to know. Remember what I say next: stay where you are. Don't move. A helicopter will arrive shortly to pick you up.

"All of you—humans, aliens, and the alien corpse—will be taken back to base together. Understood?"

The authority in that voice compelled obedience almost instinctively. Even Henry wasn't immune.

"Yes, sir. But what about the vehicle we drove here?"

"Leave it. Someone will retrieve it."

"Understood."

The other party ended the call without another word.

Barbara asked, "So we're not taking the car?"

"They said a helicopter's coming to pick us up," Henry replied.

"There's a base nearby?"

Henry gave a fake smile.

"Isn't that the kind of question you shouldn't be asking a regular civilian like me?"

Pouting, Barbara muttered, "Fair point."

At that moment, the agent being held at gunpoint spoke up.

"You two, I think there's been a misunderstanding."

Henry had already decided he didn't want to waste any more words on these people.

He didn't care how others talked—soft words, hard words, bullshit, or insults. In the end, they were all just air vibrations, a physical phenomenon.

Only someone deeply insecure and overly sensitive would be hurt by such weak sounds.

But what Henry could not tolerate was having his bottom line challenged again and again—especially by people who acted one way to his face and another behind his back.

The Skrulls' self-proclaimed cleverness had completely exhausted his patience.

Barbara, however, didn't share Henry's sense of disillusionment. On one hand, she hadn't been the primary target. On the other, she was still unsure of the agent's true identity.

So she asked, "What misunderstanding are you talking about?"

"General Talos sent us to make sure the two of you truly left and wouldn't interfere with our next operation. But you didn't even ask—you just killed one of our companions outright. Is that how allies behave?"

"Damn it, you really are a Skrull!"

Barbara didn't even bother considering his accusation. She raised her gun higher, almost pressing the muzzle against his forehead.

Henry, on the other hand, laughed derisively.

"Only liars worry all the time about being deceived. I can't even be bothered to ask what other lies you've told. You can explain yourself later. Don't bother trying to convince me."

People often say the most effective lies aren't outright falsehoods, nor the classic nine truths and one lie.

They're all truths—just with certain facts deliberately omitted, letting the listener fill in the blanks.

General Talos had done exactly that when persuading Carol Danvers. This guy was no different.

At the same time, Henry noticed a military helicopter approaching in the distance.

It was a UH-60—the U.S. military's famous Black Hawk. As a medium utility and attack helicopter, the Black Hawk was commonly used for tactical personnel transport. Using it to pick them up was no problem at all.

But using a helicopter to transport a full-grown tiger—would that really work?

Henry glanced at Kitty beside him, his thoughts drifting.

The biggest issue with helicopters was noise.

To achieve hovering and vertical takeoff and landing, a helicopter's engine powered the main rotor above. That rotor not only controlled movement but also generated lift.

Chapter 369 369 — The Howling Commandos

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Before long, the deafening roar of the helicopter had grown loud enough for ordinary people to hear clearly, naturally drawing the attention of both Barbara and the wounded Skrull.

Still maintaining his human disguise, the Skrull did not reveal his true form. He gave up trying to persuade Barbara. Toward the human side's incoming reinforcements, he felt both fear—and a faint trace of hope.

The olive-green military Black Hawk helicopter landed directly on the ground. The .50-caliber machine gun mounted beside the side hatch made it abundantly clear that this was not some kind of rescue chopper.

And the people who jumped out...

One glance was enough to tell something was off.

None of them wore standard military uniforms. Instead, they were dressed in all kinds of coats and trench coats. Some looked like gym rats who loved showing off their muscles, wearing tight tank tops that exposed broad swathes of... furry muscle.

This group wasn't unfamiliar to Henry.

That wasn't to say he personally knew them—only that he'd seen them before, at Howard Stark's funeral.

After all, the white, one-eyed man leading them left a deep impression. But in this universe, Nick Fury was still Black. So who was this one-eyed guy?

Comparing them to the group Henry remembered from the funeral, there were fewer people this time, and the elderly woman who had led them back then was absent.

Yet the one who reacted most strongly wasn't Henry—it was Kitty.

Normally good-natured to a fault, Kitty unexpectedly displayed hostility as these people approached.

A tiger doesn't bare its fangs and bark uselessly like a dog, crouching low before pouncing.

A tiger's hostility is shown by lifting its head, locking eyes with its target, and letting out deep, rumbling growls. Like a king looking down upon his subjects, it exudes the majesty of an apex predator. If it lowers itself and dips its head—that's the prelude to an attack.

And Kitty's gaze was fixed on a man who seemed immune to the chill of autumn, still dressed lightly, chest hair and muscles on full display.

The man being threatened by Kitty didn't retreat in the slightest. He met the tiger's stare head-on, lips curling as he let out a low, rumbling growl of his own—a clear show of mutual provocation.

If this had been a group of ordinary people, they'd probably be shouting in panic, telling Henry to control his pet.

But this group didn't spare Kitty a second glance. Even the two at the front—who looked noticeably more aged than when Henry had seen them four years ago—remained completely unfazed.

Henry remembered that four years ago they had already shown signs of age, but they'd been vigorous and spirited. Now, aside from their still-sharp eyes, their physical condition had clearly declined.

The white, one-eyed old man didn't step forward. Instead, the Irish old man behind him—wearing a bowler hat and sporting an elegant upturned mustache—came up and extended his hand.

By contrast, in fixed-wing aircraft, lift was provided by the wings, while the propellers only supplied forward thrust. The difference in engine output was enormous—and so was the noise.

Animals were already uneasy in unfamiliar environments. Add deafening noise to the mix, and it was practically guaranteed to make them irritable and aggressive.

So... should he use Kitty as an excuse to ditch all these troublesome people and complications?

Looking at the clear, foolish gaze beside him, Henry somehow saw a trace of gentle innocence in it. He couldn't help but laugh.

Yeah—this tiger was definitely spoiled beyond saving.

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"Timothy Dugan. The Howling Commandos."

Wow. So it really was them.

This Timothy Dugan was Dum Dum Dugan himself—the WWII veteran who'd survived into the modern era thanks to the SSS formula slowing his aging.

The Howling Commandos weren't some secret organization. Back in World War II, they'd made a legendary name for themselves alongside Captain America. What most people didn't know was that they'd never truly disbanded after the war.

Henry stepped forward and returned the handshake.

"Henry Brown. A nobody."

"Hah. A nobody doesn't get little Tony calling us up," Dum Dum Dugan replied. With Howard Stark having served as their logistics support back in the day, the Howling Commandos were plenty familiar with the Stark family. That was why Dugan spoke with such easy, uncle-like familiarity.

Even as he chatted casually, Dugan's eyes swept sharply across the scene, quickly assessing the situation.

The Skrull—still disguised as a S.H.I.E.L.D. agent and being held at gunpoint by Barbara—suddenly cried out loudly:

"Sir! Sir! I'm a Level Three S.H.I.E.L.D. agent!"

"These two are terrorists wanted by the Los Angeles West Coast Division! Director Keller has issued a shoot-on-sight order! Don't worry about me—kill them immediately!"

Dum Dum Dugan didn't buy that nonsense for a second. Instead, he stepped forward, grabbed the man by the chin, and examined him closely.

"This is an alien? Doesn't look like it," he muttered, then dipped his fingers into the blood seeping from the man's wounded arm and rubbed it between his fingertips.

That gesture alone utterly crushed the captured Skrull's remaining hope.

"The one dead in the passenger seat—that's what they really look like," Henry said.

Everyone's attention shifted to the SUV's front passenger seat. Because of the angle and the window, it was hard to see clearly.

Dum Dum Dugan opened the door, pulled the alien corpse out a bit, and took a look.

"Good lord, that's ugly."

Then he started poking and prodding the dead Skrull's face, fiddling with it as he went.

"Is this real?"

This madman even had the nerve to dip a finger near the hole Henry's pistol had blasted into the Skrull's head—some mixture of blood and alien fluids—and taste it.

Henry could only think: Figures. A WWII veteran—someone who crawled out of piles of corpses.

Sure enough, tasting something thoroughly unpleasant, Dugan spat a few times to the side.

"Good?" Henry asked without thinking.

Dugan shot him a look like he'd just seen a ghost. Henry chuckled awkwardly and wisely dropped the subject.

As if to cleanse his palate, Dugan clipped the end of a cigar and lit it on the spot. Then he pointed at the black-suited man under Barbara's gun.

"How are you going to prove this guy's the same species as the one in the car? He doesn't look like it to me."

"Got a knife?" Henry asked. "I've got an idea I want to try."

Reaching behind his back, Dum Dum Dugan pulled out a large Rambo knife. Grinning smugly, he said, "This thing may be a movie invention, but it works damn well. Remember to give it back."

He shoved it into Henry's hand.

Weighing the blade—its edge showing a strange sheen—Henry knew immediately this wasn't a prop. It was a real, sharpened weapon.

Walking up to the Skrull impostor who was still desperately trying to smear them, Henry ignored his screams. He grabbed the man's hand, slammed it onto the car hood—

—and brought the knife down.

A finger was severed cleanly. The resulting scream was so miserable it almost shook Barbara's resolve.

She didn't move only because, from the earlier conversation, she now knew for certain that this was a Skrull. As for Dum Dum Dugan's comrades—those hard-as-nails men weren't moved in the slightest by alien screams.

Henry held up the severed finger for everyone to see.

No explanation was needed. Before long, the finger began to change—its disguise peeling away as it reverted to its original form.

Chapter 370 370 — Withdrawal

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Mutants might possess abilities like this. But the defining trait of mutants is how rare it is to find two exactly alike—even those with similar powers are uncommon.

Given that the person in front of them could shapeshift, and there was another corpse with a similar appearance sitting inside the car, the odds that they were aliens rather than mutants were extremely high.

After a series of confirmations, the one-eyed white-haired old man leading the group finally broke his silence and addressed everyone:

"Vince, move the one in the car onto the helicopter. Agent, lower your weapon—this one is being transferred to us. Then all of you get on the helicopter and come with us."

The muscle-bound giant wearing only a tank top—Warwolf Vince Marcus—lifted the dead Skrull from the passenger seat with one hand, hoisted it onto his shoulder, and carried it toward the helicopter.

Dum Dum Dugan retrieved the Rambo knife he'd lent to Henry. Without carrying any weapon himself, he escorted the Skrull being held by Barbara back toward the helicopter as well.

Barbara lowered her gun, but she didn't relax her guard. She stayed close to Dum Dum Dugan, watching the Skrull who was still trying to frame her as they boarded the helicopter.

It couldn't be helped—the reputation of the Howling Commandos was simply too great. Barbara had no reason to doubt their loyalty to the U.S. government and thus followed their orders without question.

Moreover, according to internal intelligence, the Howling Commandos were also part of S.H.I.E.L.D.—though Barbara had never seen them before. She had always assumed it was because her clearance level was too low. It never crossed her mind that there were effectively two S.H.I.E.L.D.s.

But when it was Henry's turn, although he walked with the group toward the helicopter, Kitty stopped once they got close enough.

The thunderous roar of the helicopter's engines made the tiger hesitate, unwilling to move forward.

Seeing this, Henry said, "Looks like my pet isn't meant to enjoy this flight."

The others continued straight past him and boarded the helicopter. Only the one-eyed old man and Barbara stopped, turning back to look at the man and tiger.

Waving a hand, Henry hooked a thumb toward the car behind him. "Are you taking this vehicle back immediately? Let me borrow it for now. No matter where I drive it, you can probably recover it anyway."

Seeing this, Barbara tried to turn back toward Henry. "Henry, I'll stay with you—"

But the man with the tiger stopped her.

"Bobbi, you have your duty, and I have mine. You need to report everything about those aliens, and I need to take care of Kitty.

"I can't just abandon her and let her roam around on her own so I can follow you. And don't forget—if something goes wrong on Fury's end, the only support he can rely on is you. That's your most important mission."

The girl pouted, looking aggrieved. "Fine..."

The one-eyed old man simply said, "Suit yourself," and walked away without looking back.

By nature, their unit wasn't meant to have too much contact with civilians—even civilians with special abilities.

"Just as I suspected," Henry said calmly. "Once a body part is separated, it loses control—just like death—and reverts to its true form."

Even without watching the transformation, no one would mistake that green, clawed finger for something human.

"And if you were wrong?" Dum Dum Dugan asked.

"Then we'd try another way to prove it," Henry replied with an unconcerned smile.

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Besides, who among their team didn't have something special about them? The other side wasn't all that unique.

The Howling Commandos had deployed for the aliens. And the fact that Henry knew to go through Tony Stark to reach them meant there was no need to worry about him leaking sensitive extraterrestrial information.

At their level, there was no need to bother with nondisclosure agreements. Anyone who leaked secrets would be eliminated. Anyone suspected of leaking secrets would also be eliminated. This was an unspoken consensus.

Signing a piece of paper—or not—changed nothing. Only the dead truly kept secrets.

Moreover, Old Nick Fury had no real desire to bring this man back to the Howling Commandos' secret base, let alone arrange transportation for him and that tiger back to the West Coast afterward.

If the man wanted to leave on his own, there was no reason to stop him.

However, these thoughts were completely overturned after they returned to base and interrogated the living Skrull. Everyone regretted not finding a way to bring Henry Brown back with them.

No one had expected that this man wasn't, as the reports suggested, an X-gene mutant. He was also an alien—specifically, a Kryptonian from Krypton.

Yet according to testimony from trainee agent Barbara Morse, even Henry Brown himself didn't know this. When it came to Krypton, this Kryptonian had to rely on Skrulls for answers.

During interrogation, the Skrull did everything he could to redirect this planet's indigenous authorities toward that Kryptonian, away from Skrull operations.

As a result, when it came to Krypton, he was not only forthcoming—he went out of his way to smear the Kryptonian's reputation.

After all, Krypton's reputation in the universe was already terrible. Blackening it further carried no psychological burden—despite the fact that these events had occurred nine thousand years ago.

In a secure line, Old Nick Fury reported the situation to Peggy Carter.

With such an identity involved, it was impossible not to pay attention. But according to Agent Morse's account, the man himself might have been completely unaware of it.

On the other end of the call, Peggy Carter asked, "If I remember correctly, the earliest records on Henry Brown only trace back to Alaska in 1990?"

"Yes. His time on a crab fishing vessel is the first publicly recorded trace of him."

Peggy Carter made a swift decision. "Send people to investigate further. Expand the search to the Yukon and Siberia. But keep it subtle—he's connected to Tony, after all.

"He's only just managed to make himself less conspicuous and move out of certain people's crosshairs. Don't let anything tied to him draw attention again. Choose the personnel carefully."

Old Nick Fury replied, "Understood. I'll handle Siberia personally. Alexei and Melina came to the U.S., and I didn't even greet them properly before they left. As an old friend, I should at least say hello."

There was a brief silence on the other end before Peggy Carter spoke again. "Know your limits, old man. We both know your time is limited. You're not like me—I can still linger on a hospital bed."

"Don't worry," Old Nick Fury said calmly. "I know this isn't the era where I can grab a machine gun and fight my way in and out alone. Even though the Red Empire is gone, not all of the old comrades are."

"You've got a plan?"

Old Nick Fury answered confidently, "That idiot Alexei wouldn't seriously think this era still needs a Red Guardian, would he?

"The same goes for the Iron Maiden. Once the intelligence they stole is proven false, how much credibility do you think they'll have in the new government?"

"While contacting those people, I can also look for alien intelligence connected to Siberia—muddy the waters a bit, make it harder to tell what my real objective is."

"That plan is viable," Peggy Carter said. "I'll allocate whatever northern resources are available to you. Be careful."

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## Chapter 371 371 — The FBI Moves In

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Since he said he'd leave by car, Henry naturally did just that—driving off with Kitty.

The Howling Commandos flew off toward the northeast. There was probably a secret base for them somewhere in that direction. Henry, on the other hand, turned around and headed south. He drove to the outskirts of Monroe, the nearest city, then abandoned the car and disappeared.

Although the alien corpse in the vehicle had been taken away, the alien blood splattered across the windshield—and the bullet holes—had not been cleaned up. Driving a car like that into the city would have been far too conspicuous.

A conscientious police officer would notice something like this in minutes.

Don't assume American cops never meddle—that's only true in big cities. In small towns, cops manage everything from the sky to the ground to the seashore. They're practically city wardens with law enforcement authority and guns.

And Henry was never planning to drive back to the West Coast anyway. Even without sleep, it would take several days to reach Los Angeles.

Sure, Stark Industries didn't require him to clock in—but that didn't mean he wanted a cross-country road trip.

Since he had no interest in that kind of journey, Henry ditched the car in the outskirts of Monroe and then grabbed Kitty, flying back to the West Coast in one go.

As someone who regularly rode "Kryptonian Airlines" between the city and the Sheep Cave Valley laboratory, Kitty was no longer a tiger that would pee herself just from a roller coaster ride. This trip was a bit longer than usual, but it was still over in the blink of an eye.

Henry didn't take Kitty straight back to his rented place in Los Angeles. Instead, he first went to the wilderness near Sheep Cave Valley Laboratory, caught a wild deer, snapped its neck, and left it as Kitty's dinner. Only then did he head back to the city alone.

It was fortunate he hadn't brought Kitty back with him.

Just as he'd feared, his apartment had been invaded by a swarm of FBI agents collecting evidence. There were even technicians examining his computers.

He didn't know exactly when they'd started, but it was already nightfall, and a large group was still working overtime.

The Stark i486 desktop he'd been using was gone—taken away entirely. Any portable materials, such as discs and videotapes, had also vanished, packed up and loaded into FBI vehicles.

The speakers and audio equipment hadn't been spared either. Not only had the machines been dismantled, but the silver wires he'd carefully laid out were yanked into a tangled mess.

After such rough handling, those cables were probably damaged. Even if reinstalled, their original sound quality would be gone. After all, did they have any idea how picky a Kryptonian's ears were?

As for the computer Henry had personally assembled, its operating system and hardware differed too much from anything commercially available. The technicians didn't dare dismantle or remove it without authorization.

They were powering it on and poking around inside, though it was unclear whether their blind tinkering would yield anything meaningful.

Henry's operating system was based on Linux, but it wasn't a common distribution like Red Hat or SUSE. The command syntax was completely different.

A real expert might figure it out given enough time—but that wasn't something just anyone could do. Henry's custom system didn't even include documentation or a help command.

To make things more confusing, he'd deliberately renamed the commands instead of following standard conventions, creating a system all his own.

Even BB, the core cleaning robot, had been taken—charging dock and all. The FBI agents had even carried off Kitty's metal food bowl.

If Kitty ever came back and saw that, she'd probably pounce on whoever stole her dinner bowl.

Judging by the scale of the operation, it looked like the FBI had been waiting a long time for this opportunity. Henry didn't doubt their identity—their badges were worn openly, and they were dressed in official FBI jackets. It was unlikely that S.H.I.E.L.D. was impersonating them.

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The camera and projector equipment used to assist Charlize Theron had long since been dismantled and taken away. That made Henry suspect there might be another film studio pulling strings behind the scenes.

The digital imaging technology he'd led Stark Industries to develop had already attracted targeted action from Sony—but Henry was certain that other studios wouldn't sit idle if given the chance.

Although the "FBI" that had issued a shoot-on-sight order for Henry had actually been S.H.I.E.L.D. in disguise, the real FBI was more than happy to go along with it. If things blew up later, someone else could always take the fall.

Now that the opportunity had landed in their laps, why wouldn't they act?

So yes—thanks a lot to those green-skinned bastards. Damn Skrulls.

Naturally, Charlize Theron, who lived in the same building, noticed what was happening to Henry's apartment.

She had probably just wrapped up a long day of work, because her agent, J.J. Harris, was also present. Ignoring her agent's attempts to stop her, Charlize protested the FBI's actions alongside old Gary.

Their protests, of course, had no effect.

Although the FBI operation didn't involve a court-issued search warrant, there had already been a prior "FBI" action carried out by S.H.I.E.L.D. impersonators—and Henry had fled the scene. As a result, the apartment was considered a crime scene and could be investigated directly.

This left Charlize frantic. She repeatedly begged J.J. Harris to find some way to fix the situation. But when it came to an agency like the FBI, even a seasoned agent like him had very limited influence or connections.

At this stage in her career, she simply wasn't powerful enough to stand up to the FBI—not even to argue her case properly.

So... should Henry ask Tony Stark to step in again?

The two aliens from earlier had been a public matter. Whether Stark lifted a finger or not didn't matter to Henry—as long as the people behind Stark noticed, someone would clean things up.

But this mess was clearly a private matter. Worse, he didn't know who was really behind it, or how complicated things might get.

More importantly, Henry didn't believe his relationship with Tony Stark was the kind of brotherly bond where favors were freely exchanged.

For wealthy people, there's only one reason to get involved—profit. Without benefit, why would someone who burns through hundreds of thousands in minutes bother dealing with irrelevant trouble?

Calling in a favor wasn't impossible—but it might only work once. After that, everything would be strictly business.

Personal favors require relatively equal standing. When the gap is too wide, why would a rich man bother exchanging favors with some nobody off the street?

If this were a full-powered Superman, anyone he approached would be the one reaching upward. But in the eyes of the world, Henry was just a somewhat clever mutant—unless he was willing to reveal far more of his hand.

Henry didn't believe his face alone was enough to truly order Tony Stark around. What he'd told Barbara earlier had just been him talking big.

So the easiest solution to this problem was to wait until the Captain Marvel incident concluded, and Nick Fury returned to S.H.I.E.L.D. Let them clean up the mess they'd left behind.

Whether this situation had been caused by Skrulls impersonating agents or not, S.H.I.E.L.D. still bore responsibility for letting aliens infiltrate them. Henry had no obligation to pay for their negligence.

Whether S.H.I.E.L.D. later chose to hold the Skrulls accountable—that was their business.

All Henry could hope was that nothing else went wrong before Nick Fury stepped in to handle the aftermath.

As for rushing in to stop the FBI on the spot—Henry never even considered it. The apartment had already been trashed. Showing up now and forcing them to return his belongings would be pointless.

At best, they'd unload the items from their vehicles and dump them back inside. He'd still have to clean up himself. There was no chance they'd restore everything to its original state.

The losses incurred here only made Henry feel more justified about what he planned to do next.

After all—what's owed will always be repaid. The timing just hadn't been right before.

The Skrulls owed him.

And it was time to collect.

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### Chapter 372 372 — The Laboratory's Hidden Space

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Ever since the FBI started keeping tabs on him, Henry had already moved anything that couldn't see the light of day out of Old Gary's apartment building. What remained inside no longer contained anything with excessive black-tech elements, and all important data had long since been backed up offsite.

So it didn't really matter if everything there got seized. He could deal with the aftermath later. With that in mind, Henry left the vantage point where he could observe his apartment and returned to Sheep Cave Valley Laboratory.

Kitty, having just eaten her fill, behaved nothing like her wild counterparts that would usually find a relatively flat boulder to lie down on.

Wild predators typically eat one meal that can sustain them for one or two weeks—pushing it to a full month at the extreme. Because they never know when their next meal will come, they gorge themselves whenever food is available.

After eating to the point of being stuffed, they naturally reduce their activity levels and appear lethargic.

But Kitty was different.

Being well fed and accustomed to regular meals, she didn't binge like wild predators. She ate on Henry's three-meals-a-day schedule. Once she felt satiated, she stopped—and then promptly became full of energy, ready to wreak havoc.

That was why, upon arriving at Sheep Cave Valley, Henry saw Kitty leaping between massive boulders and ravines, every bit like her mountain-king kin.

Perhaps because Henry had brought her here too many times, the area around the laboratory was saturated with the tiger's scent. As a result, many wild animals actively avoided this region.

Whether or not they had ever seen a tiger was irrelevant. The pheromonal signal of an apex predator was etched into their DNA—it couldn't be faked.

With no BB robot or innocent small animals to chase and toy with, Kitty could only burn off her energy by exploring the wilderness. At least this place wasn't a monotonous cat climbing frame; it offered some novelty.

Henry didn't disturb the tiger in her frolicking. The nearest living humans were more than twenty kilometers away—well beyond a tiger's normal activity range. There was no risk of her hurting anyone, nor of her getting shot by someone with a gun.

Henry unlocked the laboratory and entered. Passing through the container house, he slipped behind a shelving unit and opened a concealed door, entering a second, hidden layer of space.

This area was a cave carved along the natural rock formations, used to store things he didn't want exposed—including nearly six hundred thousand dollars in dirty cash.

Even those unfortunate souls who had once broken into the lab would never have imagined a second level existed. And even if they somehow discovered it, they'd still have to decide whether to enter a pitch-black space with no lighting, accessible only by climbing.

Inside here, Henry relied entirely on Kryptonian flight and night vision. If someone else with the same abilities showed up—or if someone was bold enough to risk it all—then he could only accept his bad luck.

He'd come here for one reason: to retrieve equipment for doing bad things.

For example—his night suit.

A question that had long bothered Henry resurfaced yet again: if you're going to do something shady, why wouldn't you first put on a disguise and work from the shadows? Why insist on going in barefaced and confronting people head-on?

Exhibitionism? Is streaking the true mark of masculinity? Settling grudges on the spot? Then getting ironclad evidence against you and happily stepping on a sewing machine for ten years or more? Is mutual destruction the new trend of the age?

The old wisdom said, "A gentleman's revenge may wait three years." So why was modern fashion all about "a thug's revenge, morning till night"—street-punk style?

Then again, if everyone were that clever and truly understood Romance of the Three Kingdoms, it would just make life harder for the cops. So maybe it's better to discard that old wisdom and keep things simple—like a gangster.

Henry stuck to his own rhythm. Super strength was a last resort; a super brain came first. When doing bad things, put on a disguise. Don't keep handing evidence to others while feeling smug about it.

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"No witnesses" might count as a successful assassination in medieval times. In the modern era of forensic science, it's not about whether something can be solved—it's about whether someone wants to solve it, and whether sufficient evidence can be found.

An intelligence agency like S.H.I.E.L.D. might act on mere "suspicion," but in the end, convincing others and reaching a verdict still depended on evidence.

Since commissioning clothes from others risked exposing his identity, Henry had used gold coins to purchase Kevlar fabric directly from the Continental Hotel—the same material used for bulletproof suits—and sewn the outfit himself.

To conceal his physique, the suit wasn't skintight or perfectly tailored. Instead, without hindering movement, he padded and altered his height, body width, shoulder angle, and other proportions.

The shoes were several sizes too large and also concealed small tools inside. Gloves were the trickiest part—dexterity had to be preserved, so the fabric couldn't be too thick or distort the shape of his hands too much.

Arm length and hand shape were the hardest elements to disguise.

Then there was the full head covering.

It exposed nothing—not the eyes, ears, mouth, or chin. From the outside, it looked like a smooth, featureless egg, with only a slight protrusion for the nose and no other distinguishing traits.

This design wasn't without drawbacks. At the very least, Kryptonian heat vision and freeze breath couldn't be used unless he wanted to blow his own mask apart.

Speech was handled via a bone-conduction microphone and speaker embedded in the neck, complete with voice modulation. He could speak without opening his mouth, ensuring no one could identify him by voice—because it wasn't truly his voice being used.

This night suit covered every inch of skin. Entirely black, made of Kevlar, it had taken Henry considerable effort. It was effectively the first suit of combat gear he had ever designed for himself.

...The Joker costume didn't count. That had just been off-the-rack clothing bought at random.

This suit's primary function was concealment—ensuring that anyone trying to identify him by body shape or skeletal structure would come to the wrong conclusion.

Last time, even with his face painted beyond recognition, someone had still reconstructed his appearance beneath the makeup. Fortunately, he'd had a second layer of protection, or he would have been tracked down.

Henry didn't believe he could pull off the Superman trick—glasses on, glasses off, and suddenly no one recognizes you. He hadn't yet figured out how to make glasses with hypnotic effects.

Beyond that, he would rely on Kryptonian physical abilities.

The reason he'd specifically sought out Kevlar fabric was simple: he'd learned from past disasters. He himself was bulletproof—but his clothes weren't. After being hit by concentrated gunfire, he might survive, but social death was a real possibility. Hence, the effort to make proper ballistic protection.

As for weapons...

Henry still strapped on a telescopic baton. It was far weaker than his fists, but it served as camouflage and reduced the chances of exposing his super strength.

Once dressed, a powerful sense of déjà vu washed over him. Add a cape and a pair of pointed ears, and he could pretend to be Batman.

No—better call himself Super Black.

The other name was unlucky. Might as well accumulate some virtue for his Kryptonian parents—assuming they even still existed. If they were both gone, what if their karma reserves were insufficient?

With everything prepared, Super Black used the starry sky to conceal his flight and returned to Louisiana—specifically, Maria Rambeau's house.

Thanks to these supposedly high-tech civilizations, their reconnaissance methods still relied on eyesight. And aside from raw combat power, Captain Marvel lacked corresponding detection abilities.

Of course, that was based on portrayals in comics, animation, and movies.

Given how often Henry had been burned over the years, he knew better than to treat others as idiots or stone-age primitives. Arrogance was how you got yourself killed.

In reality, these people behaved far more rationally and methodically.

So Super Black landed ten kilometers away. Carefully observing Skrull movements to avoid triggering their alertness, he began to move closer—stealthily.

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Chapter 373 373 — Modifying the Quadjet

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The first thing Black Super took note of was the number of Skrulls.

Perhaps because it was night, or because the Skrulls had relaxed their guard—and also because they wanted to build trust with Carol Danvers and the others—they were moving about in their original forms.

That made it easy for Black Super to count them. Including General Talos, there were fifteen Skrulls in total. Most of them were gathered around the Quadjet, assisting their technical personnel in modifying the aircraft.

And that number matched what Black Super had seen before he left.

Which meant that the two Skrulls who later disguised themselves as S.H.I.E.L.D. agents to "escort" him and Barbara had not been exposed.

In other words, General Talos was still holding back a trump card...

Or there was another possibility: some of the Skrulls were acting independently, beyond Talos's direct control, pursuing their own objectives.

So just how many Skrulls had already infiltrated Earth?

Among the FBI agents who ransacked his home, had some of them already been replaced by Skrulls?

The more Black Super thought about it, the more it felt like the curtain of the Marvel Universe hadn't even fully risen yet—and he'd already run headfirst into an epic-difficulty Secret Invasion scenario.

And worse, he himself had become a target of those green-skinned monsters.

That said, the reason Black Super rushed back to lie in wait wasn't just to make sure Nick Fury lived long enough to clean up the mess left by Skrulls impersonating S.H.I.E.L.D. agents.

His first score to settle was also to see exactly how the Skrulls were modifying the Quadjet—turning an aircraft designed for atmospheric flight into something capable of passing through the atmosphere, operating in space, and then returning to the ground.

He watched as more than a dozen Skrulls split into several groups, carrying out different modification tasks under the direction of a single commander.

The engine modifications were what caught Black Super's attention most—but after observing for a while, he realized the technological level wasn't as high as he'd expected.

Originally, the Quadjet used two supersonic combustion ramjet engines. Like all jet fighters, these engines relied on intaking air, mixing it with fuel, combusting it, and expelling massive amounts of gas in a specific direction to generate thrust.

After the Skrulls' modifications, a fusion reactor had been added. However, this reactor's primary purpose was only to provide energy and regenerate oxygen. The main thrust still relied on the jet's original method—fuel undergoing explosive combustion to generate propulsive gas.

Yet the aircraft's fuel efficiency—based on this limited, consumable fuel—had not been improved at all. It was as if they assumed there were gas stations scattered throughout the universe.

If anyone seriously planned to use this engine for interstellar travel, the odds of a one-way trip were practically one hundred percent.

In addition to the engines, the Skrulls had installed many extra devices on the Quadjet. The most important ones were a shield generator and an artificial gravity system.

The artificial gravity system—a piece of black technology among black technologies—was something Black Super couldn't possibly understand just by looking at it.

The layout and wiring design were comprehensible, but the core component of the device was a part brought by the Skrulls themselves. That component wasn't particularly complex in structure, which meant the key lay in its material.

From Black Super's X-ray vision analysis, it was made of a substance not found on Earth, making it impossible to determine its function.

In short, without that core component, the Skrulls' hand-built artificial gravity device had no technical merit at all. Once the core was added, however, the entire system was transformed into incomprehensible alien technology.

The shield generator was much the same.

From the fact that the Skrulls hadn't bothered to reinforce the Quadjet's airtight sealing, Black Super could infer that the shield didn't just help the craft endure atmospheric reentry heat—it also prevented internal air from leaking out.

Blocking energy attacks up to a certain level was clearly within its capabilities. That also explained why, in the movie, the Quadjet endured multiple laser hits without visible damage. It certainly wasn't because Earth-made aircraft skin was that impressive.

From these modifications, Black Super finally understood why—after the Quadjet was recovered by the military—the mass-produced Quinjet models were still restricted to atmospheric use only.

Many of the Skrulls' additions couldn't be reverse-engineered at all. If the key materials couldn't be replicated or obtained, recreating such high-level alien technology would be a joke.

So these guys had clearly held something back—just like how they hadn't told Nick Fury and the others the full truth, despite claiming to be completely forthcoming.

Then again, Black Super himself wasn't any better. Who would bare their heart and soul to strangers or people they barely knew?

If the Skrulls hadn't kept harassing him, Black Super wouldn't have cared whether their attitude was genuine or fake, good or bad. But since they refused to rein themselves in, collecting a bit of "emotional distress compensation" felt entirely justified.

The only question was how far to go—to choose the option with the fewest lingering consequences.

While waiting for the Skrulls to act, Black Super remained hidden in the small woods, running through all possible scenarios and outcomes, refining the optimal course of action.

Just like his pitch-black suit blending into the night, what lay hidden wasn't just fangs—but the wisdom to strike once, decisively, and retreat unscathed.

Aside from the Skrulls modifying the aircraft, the actions of the humans unfolded exactly as Black Super remembered from the movie.

At Carol Danvers's invitation—and with encouragement from her daughter Monica—Maria Rambeau joined this venture that might very well be a one-way trip.

Without knowing that Captain Marvel would later power up and resolve everything single-handedly, the main risk of this operation came from the Kree Starforce reinforcements led by Yon-Rogg.

In other words, their plan was operating under a strict time limit.

Once the Kree pursuers arrived, these Skrulls—now without a mothership—would have no choice but to hide among the human population. They lacked the equipment to confront the Kree military head-on.

After all, aside from Yon-Rogg's elite squad, the Kree also had an unknown number of regular troops in support.

From the battle on Torfa, even when a group of Skrulls allied with the local natives, they couldn't defeat a six-person Kree squad—only force them to retreat. The only noteworthy "victory" was essentially a plot-device capture of the future Captain Marvel.

Of course, Black Super couldn't guarantee that reality in this universe would play out exactly like the movie in his memory. Just like how the film showed only a single Skrull technician modifying the Quadjet—whereas here, more than a dozen were involved.

Still, once the Kree caught up, the outcome was all but predetermined.

Thus, the Skrulls' objective was likely to decode the state vector left behind by the Kree scientist Mar-Vell—Dr. Wendy Lawson—locate the energy core of the light-speed engine, and escape as quickly as possible.

Then they would lie low on Earth, hoping the Kree would eventually withdraw once they failed to locate the Skrulls. That would give them a chance to use the energy core to complete Lawson's research, build a functional light-speed engine, and lead the remaining Skrulls to a new home.

General Talos hadn't actually said any of this outright—but anyone listening could more or less piece together the outline of the plan.

On paper, it sounded decent. In practice, it relied far too heavily on wishful thinking.

For example: once the Kree knew Skrulls might be hiding on Earth, would they really just give up and leave if they couldn't find them?

Dr. Lawson's light-speed engine had never been completed—aside from the energy core they still hadn't obtained, what resources did the Skrulls on Earth even have to finish the research?

More critically, Talos's true objective went beyond the energy core. He had left many things unsaid—factors that would affect everyone's decisions and actions.

There were simply too many uncertainties in this plan. No wonder Maria Rambeau had initially been unwilling to join. Anyone with a functioning brain would struggle to accept a plan that relied so heavily on improvisation.

Only Carol Danvers—the tough woman who had been toyed with by the Kree—was different. Whether she was truly convinced by the Skrulls and believed helping them was the righteous path, or whether she was simply burning with a desire for revenge, the result was the same.

She'd been pulled onto the Skrulls' war chariot.

As for Nick Fury, Black Super couldn't quite read his true intentions.

Perhaps, just as Fury himself had said: when you lack the power to defeat both sides causing trouble, joining one of them is the best option. And so-called neutrality is nothing more than a bargaining position at the negotiating table.

Chapter 374 - 374 — Kree Cruiser

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Out in space, Black Super arrived just outside Earth's atmosphere ahead of everyone else. Aside from basking for a moment in the unfiltered yellow sunlight—no longer attenuated by the atmosphere—he was simply waiting for Carol Danvers to pilot the Quadjet into space.

After all, following an aircraft in broad daylight while wearing a stealth suit would be about as subtle as announcing, "There's a fly here, please take a look."

Although flying with his own body wouldn't be picked up by conventional radar, it could still be seen with the naked eye. So Black Super chose to get into position early rather than expose himself by doing something stupid.

In fact, he wasn't the only one waiting in space. The Kree pursuers had already arrived. They were parked in Earth's orbital zone, holding position and not making any overt moves.

What surprised Black Super somewhat was that the Kree had dispatched only a single spacecraft—he couldn't tell whether it counted as medium-sized or small by Kree standards, nor what its precise classification was.

Its silhouette was a boomerang-like curved design, rather than the spindle or spherical shapes that Earth physicists theorized were most efficient for space travel.

The reason for the Kree warship's design was simple: it allowed for the maximum number of engines to be mounted laterally, producing greater thrust. Combined with their black-tech artificial gravity systems, there was no need to rely on rotating sections to simulate gravity.

Since Black Super had no idea how the Kree ship's external sensors or detection systems were configured, he didn't dare approach too closely and risk drawing attention.

Using Earth's high-orbit artificial satellites as cover, he edged closer to the Kree vessel, observing it cautiously.

Fortunately, his Kryptonian X-ray vision still worked—good news. He could see roughly one hundred to one hundred fifty humanoid lifeforms moving about inside the ship.

Accounting for flight crew and necessary support personnel, he estimated that perhaps one-half to one-third of them could be deployed for a boarding operation.

In other words, Nick Fury and the others might soon be facing more than fifty Kree soldiers—far more than what the movie had depicted. And that didn't even include Yon-Rogg's elite team.

Perhaps because they didn't yet know where their target was on Earth, the Kree ship didn't act aggressively. Instead, it launched only a single one-man landing craft toward the surface.

Not long after that Kree pod descended, Carol Danvers's Quadjet blasted free of Earth's gravity well like a rocket at full thrust, reaching a hovering position in space.

Still using satellites as cover, Black Super moved closer to the Quadjet. In the direction its nose was pointing, a concealed spacecraft shed its camouflage and revealed itself in the void.

Based on his memory of the movie, this had to be Mar-Vell's laboratory—a Kree cruiser.

Its shape was unlike the boomerang-style Kree warship. Instead, it resembled a long, cargo-focused vessel. Not perfectly boxy, but far larger in volume.

The Quadjet entered the cruiser through an opening concealed by a force field, and at the same time, the distant Kree warship began to move.

The Kree vessel didn't rush in immediately. Instead, it deployed small attack craft and a larger sub-vessel, forming up in space.

Judging by its size and configuration, that sub-vessel was likely an assault landing ship or troop transport.

Even so, they didn't advance on the Kree cruiser right away. They were waiting for the surface team to return and regroup.

Taking advantage of this window, Black Super avoided the docking port and the obvious observation windows near the bow, approaching the cruiser from its underside.

Fortunately, Kryptonian flight produced no flashy sound or light effects—unlike Captain Marvel, who practically announced her arrival to the universe. Black Super

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silently attached himself to the ship's belly, pressing all ten fingers against the hull.

Back when he had used sonar-like vibration principles to acquire the full design of the U.S. Navy's Iowa-class battleship Missouri, he had learned how effective such methods could be.

In the vacuum of space, there was no air to carry sound—but vibrations through solid matter worked much the same.

Combining that technique with his X-ray vision, Black Super quickly mapped out the cruiser's overall structure in his mind. Still, that was a long way from truly understanding or reverse-engineering the ship.

Unlike the Missouri, which followed a technological lineage familiar to Earth, this vessel was built on a completely different tech tree. He could see the structures of most systems, but not their functions—let alone the materials involved.

That said, he could infer the purposes of certain compartments from their contents.

Living quarters and cargo bays were obvious enough. Beyond the engine rooms and power sections, the most numerous spaces were illuminated cultivation chambers—greenhouses filled with plants Earth had never seen before.

As for the Skrulls being sheltered aboard Mar-Vell's cruiser, there were fewer than expected—only around ten. Possibly even fewer than the number General Talos had brought to Earth.

That made sense. With no external resupply and the need to remain self-sufficient aboard the ship for an unknown duration, it simply couldn't support a large population.

Now that Carol Danvers and the others had boarded the cruiser, not only had they recovered the Tesseract, but General Talos had also reunited with the Skrulls hiding aboard.

Seeing that object, Black Super suddenly understood why Nick Fury might have involved himself so deeply in this affair.

According to the Avengers: Endgame timeline, Tony Stark and Steve Rogers traveled back to a 1970s U.S. military base to retrieve the Tesseract—meaning it had remained in U.S. military custody, not S.H.I.E.L.D.'s.

Then, in 1989—six years ago—the Pegasus Project incident occurred. Chief scientist Wendy Lawson died, and test pilot Carol Danvers went missing.

Nick Fury had claimed that the Air Force was merely covering up a billion-dollar loss. But the real catastrophe they dared not disclose was the loss of the Tesseract—originally seized from Hydra during World War II.

So it was quite possible that Nick Fury already knew all this, and planned to pull a double-cross once the Skrulls obtained the light-speed engine's energy core. Transferring the artifact from the U.S. military to S.H.I.E.L.D. would be a major coup.

Until the prize was in hand, though, there was no need to eliminate potentially useful allies—so he kept his true intentions to himself.

Truly worthy of the name "Black Nick Fury." If you cut him open, his insides would probably be just as dark as his skin.

The Space Stone carried consequences far too great—it was a red-hot potato coveted by countless parties. Even if you managed to seize it, without a viable way to use it, holding it was pointless. So it wasn't Black Super's objective.

What he wanted was the data storage systems aboard this research vessel.

Kree technology—that was what truly interested him.

People often said Tony Stark wasn't as smart as Rocket Raccoon, and the reason was simple: their starting points were worlds apart. One began with advanced galactic civilization; the other with a planetary one.

Though Black Super had now been confirmed to be Kryptonian, he was an exiled infant with no Kryptonian technology to his name. There was little chance a Fortress of Solitude was waiting for him at the North Pole.

So how could the knowledge archive of a Kree scientist not be tempting?

If that database contained information on other cosmic civilizations—even something as basic as a universal "elementary school history textbook"—Black Super wanted to know whether it included anything about Krypton.

Not because he wanted to go back and see what Krypton in this universe was like, but because he wanted to understand the weaknesses and flaws that had been exposed by a defeated interstellar power.

And besides, the information he had so far came only from Skrull oral accounts. Would the Kree version tell a different story?

That, too, was something Black Super wanted to find out.

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Chapter 375 375 — Infiltration

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Black Super had originally planned to keep hiding outside the hull until he confirmed the location of his target, then slip in, dismantle what he needed, and return straight to Earth in one clean move.

However, the Kree's actions forced him to change that plan.

The sub-vessel that looked like a landing craft docked directly with the cruiser's boarding port, positioning its hull sideways and blocking most of the entrances and exits.

The smaller craft spread out to patrol the exterior of the cruiser. And because this was a ship built by the Kree themselves, they knew exactly where the blind spots of the weapon emplacements and sensor arrays were—there were even guards stationed behind the engines.

If the cruiser showed any abnormal activity, they would immediately destroy the laboratory ship's propulsion system.

To avoid being spotted by those patrolling "little bugs," Black Super had no choice but to enter the cruiser through the nearest maintenance access.

The small maintenance hatch he selected wasn't designed for use in space. The passage behind it lacked a pressurized airlock. Opening it in the near-vacuum of space would cause a massive loss of atmosphere, so this kind of hatch could only be opened from the inside.

That sort of inconvenience was nothing to Black Super. By using super-speed vibration to slip through molecular gaps, he phased directly into the ship's interior without triggering any alarms.

The first thing he did after entering was locate the nearest terminal. He wanted to see whether he could pull up the cruiser's schematics or find the location of its data storage systems through the terminal interface.

Considering signal latency across space, it was impossible that all Kree warship data was uploaded to some kind of cloud server. There had to be local storage.

And since this ship needed to remain hidden, external communications would be even more unlikely. So where was the data stored?

Black Super's hopes were quickly dashed the moment he started interacting with the terminal.

Right—he'd overlooked something. The interface was written in Kree script. He couldn't read it.

A super brain might learn fast—even languages wouldn't be a problem—but to decode a language, you still needed reference material. Without any point of comparison, those alien glyphs were just meaningless scribbles.

Learn Kree on the spot?

The thought flashed through his mind and was immediately discarded. He chose a simpler approach.

Trace the wiring.

Marvel's advanced civilizations, for all their sophistication, still generally followed technological principles Earth could understand—the gap lay in execution and materials, not in some utterly alien logic. As for Celestials... that was far beyond the curve, and Black Super had never encountered them, so they didn't count.

Any networked electronic system, no matter how advanced, ultimately relied on two things: power and data. In advanced civilizations, both could be transmitted wirelessly.

But was wireless transmission truly flawless?

Wireless was convenient, yes—but in terms of reliability, nothing beat wired connections. And for maximum redundancy, you'd use both.

For something like a spacecraft—where reliability mattered far more than convenience—Black Super didn't believe for a second that the Kree would rely entirely on systems that could be disabled with a sheet of tinfoil.

That was why, under his X-ray vision, the cruiser's hull was packed with dense layers of cabling. Even behind the terminal's panel, there were physical connections.

Anyone who had ever worked in a server room knew that tracing cables was a basic skill. And with X-ray vision, Black Super didn't need to guess blindly or hope the wiring was neat enough to follow at a glance.

He just needed to pick a line and follow it.

Even if the hardware behind this particular terminal wasn't his target—if different systems had their own dedicated alien lines and processors—that was fine.

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All he needed was to identify what Kree data storage devices looked like, or at least their general design. Then he could strip out everything that matched. He could study it all later back on Earth.

As for whether ripping out every device that functioned like a hard drive would cripple the ship...

He almost wanted to say, not my problem. But if he wanted to preserve the cruiser's basic functionality, there was another angle to consider.

What he was after was Mar-Vell's research data. That system should be separate from the ship's flight and control systems, not integrated into them.

If the cruiser's systems were physically compartmentalized, then his target would be a standalone electronic system—unrelated to ship operation, running independently, and seemingly nonessential. He only needed to extract the storage from that system.

But if Kree technology integrated everything into one unified system...

Well then, that really would be a case of not my problem.

With his objectives clarified, Black Super followed a cable that appeared to be related to data transmission.

The journey, however, was anything but smooth.

The Kree boarding party had already captured the Skrulls along with Nick Fury and the others, and they were now conducting a sweep of the ship for remaining stragglers.

To avoid these search teams, Black Super sometimes had to duck into the wrong branch corridor, wait for a patrol to pass, then double back.

Other times, his luck was worse, and a Kree squad would follow him down the same branch. Then he could only keep moving, staying ahead until another room or junction gave him an escape.

He was doing all this because he didn't want to leave behind too many traces. Otherwise, he could have simply smashed his way through the hull.

He could also rely on high-frequency vibration to phase through walls—but he couldn't maintain that state for long. He had to choose thin partitions where phasing required less effort.

Passing through molecular gaps demanded coordination between multiple abilities. The longer he maintained that state, the higher the risk of making unnecessary mistakes.

Pure high-speed vibration—like the Reverse-Flash blurring himself until no one could see clearly—was doable.

But that kind of ability signature was too distinctive. Black Super had no intention of letting anyone identify him by a unique power profile.

So he played a deadly game of hide-and-seek with the Kree search teams, until he finally reached a compartment that housed a cluster of mainframes.

Judging by the internal layout, this wasn't just a research lab. Adjacent to it was a massive energy-generation unit, currently offline.

It looked like a backup power system—or so Black Super judged.

Although he still hadn't found his exact target, this wandering had effectively eliminated many compartments that were obviously not what he was looking for.

Before moving on, Black Super began studying the mainframes in this room—examining how Kree technology differed from Earth's, and how their data was actually stored.

To test this, he deliberately performed random operations on the terminal, listening for mechanical sounds elsewhere in the compartment. He couldn't directly see energy flow, but he could infer activity from changes in heat.

Using this method, he gradually pieced together how Kree systems operated.

And he had a strong feeling that he was getting close to the answer.

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Chapter 376 - 376 — Captain Marvel Goes on a Rampage

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Just as Black Super located what appeared to be a data storage unit and was about to dismantle it for a closer look, the ship's power suddenly became unstable. Parts of the vessel flickered, some systems tripped and shut down, and even the mainframe in front of him was affected.

That said, this incident also highlighted one of Kree technology's strengths: a mainframe reboot didn't immediately cripple critical systems. At the very least, life support and artificial gravity didn't fail on the spot—otherwise everyone aboard would have died right there.

However, some devices that required massive energy input were very likely taken offline.

Black Super glanced toward Carol Danvers' location. Several compartments away, Captain Marvel had—just as expected—gone full power.

In her binary form, she was already at the very top of the Marvel Universe's superhero power scale, so long as one didn't compare her to beings on the level of the Celestials.

At this stage, all she needed was time to adapt to and fully master this power. Once she did, she could pretty much walk sideways across the universe without issue.

The real problem was her... questionable judgment. She trusted people far too easily.

Whether in the comics or the movies, even back when she was still Ms. Marvel, Carol Danvers had always been like this—solving every conspiracy by smashing it head-on with overwhelming force.

In short, wherever she went, she inevitably became the center of attention, which ran completely counter to Black Super's operating principles. Best to stay far away.

He had no interest in jumping into the X-Men's mess, and even less reason to become some kind of cosmic police officer alongside Captain Marvel.

As for the contrived excuse that someone had to go into space to uphold justice—it was probably just the movie writers' way of preventing Earth-based supervillains from getting instantly vaporized by Captain Marvel before the "main characters" had a chance to shine.

Besides, one crucial piece of Kryptonian intel he'd gotten from the Skrulls was that Kryptonian fleets were affected by the color of the local star, which could alter their temperament.

Even if their powers weren't directly lost, Black Super still preferred to stay on Earth, bathing comfortably in yellow sunlight. Otherwise, every time he wanted to "deliver justice" in some star system, he'd first have to check the color of its sun—way too much hassle.

As for the one person he did need to keep alive this time—Nick Fury, whose heart might well be as black as his skin—he still needed Fury to clean up the mess the Skrulls had caused. As someone in the know within S.H.I.E.L.D., Fury was the most suitable choice.

At the moment, though, Fury was holding Goose the Flerken like the ultimate talisman, and things seemed fine.

Flerkens were hit-or-miss—sometimes they didn't do anything unless they spotted a threat—but with that trump card in hand, plus the stolen Kree weapons, it should've been enough for them to escape...

That was when Black Super suddenly remembered why he'd entered the ship in the first place.

The Kree's small combat craft were still patrolling outside.

Could the modified Quadjet really dogfight that many enemy fighters in space? In the movie, only a single Kree Starforce fighter had chased them.

This meant that escaping the cruiser might be Nick Fury's real bottleneck.

On the other hand, the Kree boarding force was larger than Black Super had initially expected. He'd forgotten that the Skrulls also had more fighters accompanying Fury and the others.

Their total numbers were still inferior to the Kree, but at least it wasn't like the movie, where Talos alone had to protect a bunch of civilian Skrulls while being chased everywhere.

From the overall situation, Fury's side was still at a disadvantage. As long as Carol Danvers hadn't gone on a full killing spree, her binary form could be tied down, making it hard for her to support others.

With their numerical advantage, the Kree naturally deployed in full force—to suppress the rebelling captives and defeat their own traitor once again.

Failure wasn't even a consideration to them. One side was the already-defeated Skrulls, the other was C-53's powerless natives. Only their former Starforce member

Chapter 377 - 377 — Translating the Kree Script

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posed any real trouble.

This chaos inevitably affected Black Super as well.

A three-man Kree squad was moving toward his position.

Avoid them—or engage head-on?

Now that everything had descended into chaos, continuing to waste time playing hide-and-seek instead of taking advantage of the confusion would be stupid. And he also needed to make sure Nick Fury didn't die by accident—there wasn't much time left for him to do what he came for.

So Black Super chose to act boldly.

He positioned himself in a blind spot just inside the doorway, preparing to ambush the approaching Kree squad.

Unlike their portrayal in the movies, Kree soldiers had well-developed tactics for close-quarters combat aboard ships. They didn't recklessly rush into open spaces or blindly leap around corners without understanding the situation.

Especially the latter—that would be like offering themselves up as live targets. Even if their armor could stop some bullets, it wasn't meant to shrug off everything.

That said, they hadn't progressed to the point of tossing grenades before entering either. Still, the three-man fireteam entered with proper discipline, each soldier raising their weapon to cover a different direction.

That kind of tactic worked against conventional enemies.

It meant nothing against Black Super.

He burst behind them with super speed, kicked off the wall, and rebounded midair. Before they could even register his presence, two of them were smashed to the ground by his fists, and the third was tackled.

The problem was force.

Against humans of similar size, that punch would have been more than enough to knock them unconscious. Against Kree soldiers, it felt just a bit lacking.

The two he'd knocked down were on the floor, but still conscious, struggling to push themselves up and raise their weapons.

Black Super delivered a follow-up—one kick each—handing out a concussion combo. He then kicked the third man's weapon away and planted a foot on his chest.

Since Black Super was completely covered head to toe, with no insignia or markings, all that could be confirmed was that he was a humanoid lifeform—nothing more.

The pinned Kree soldier began shouting in his native language. Black Super didn't understand a word of it.

The reason he'd left one alive was because he remembered that Kree wristbands came with universal translators—capable of translating the languages of intelligent species across the galaxy. Maybe he could make use of that.

"Can you understand what I'm saying?" Black Super asked, his voice emerging from the throat-mounted speaker.

The Kree soldier continued shouting.

Annoyed, Black Super delivered two sharp slaps—firm but controlled—finally quieting him down.

Pointing at the man's wristband, Black Super said, "Translate."

Even if he still didn't understand Black Super's words, the Kree knew what to do. He activated the universal translator and said:

"You are a native of planet C-53? Do you think you can trample the dignity of a Kree warrior without facing punishment?"

Black Super's attention shifted to yet another piece of black-box technology.

This universal translator didn't use a separate microphone or speaker to replace the user's voice or hearing. Instead, it allowed the user to speak and understand the target intelligent species'... language directly.

Or perhaps it was some kind of brainwave interpretation system, enabling communication on a higher cognitive level altogether.

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"Can this device translate written text?"

Black Super grabbed the Kree soldier's arm, examining the wristband mounted there.

The defeated Kree warrior was only putting up a tough front verbally. Faced with the questions of this unknown figure, he answered honestly, "Through the universal translator, I can understand the writing of all civilizations in the universe."

That clearly wasn't the answer Black Super wanted.

"Then is there a reference table? A dictionary, maybe—Kree script compared with the writing of... what you call planet C-53?"

"Why would something like that be necessary?" the Kree asked, genuinely puzzled.

Alright, that was Black Super being too Earth-centric. For a highly advanced civilization, when a universal translator solved all communication problems, who would bother learning languages the old-fashioned way?

So he took a step back and asked instead, "Then how do I use this thing?"

As he spoke, he reached to strip the wristband off the Kree.

The Kree hurriedly protected his gear. "You can't use it. Only those with Kree blood can activate its functions."

Black Super was about to ask why Carol Danvers could use one—then remembered she'd had her blood replaced by the Kree. He dropped the issue.

After all, even future Earth smartphones had passwords, fingerprints, and facial recognition. Kree equipment being restricted to its owner was hardly strange.

Rather than wasting time trying to crack it, Black Super simply hoisted the still-living Kree and dragged him over to the rebooting mainframe screen, pointing at the text displayed on it.

"What does this line mean?"

"What do you mean, what does it mean?"

Kree weren't cats or tigers—you couldn't grab them by the scruff of the neck. Black Super had him by the back of the neck directly. If he was going to lift him, he couldn't let go, so the pressure in his fingers couldn't be light.

At the same time, he couldn't strangle the Kree unconscious or kill him outright—much less snap his neck. Since Black Super didn't yet have a perfect grasp of Kree physiology, the poor fellow in his hand became a test subject, Black Super loosening his grip right before actually choking him to death.

As a result, the Kree under his control was utterly terrified. Even his voice trembled with fear, just short of breaking into tears.

Seeing that his captive was on the verge of collapse, Black Super gave more direct instructions.

"Read all the text on the screen. Wherever my finger points, you read. Don't miss anything, don't get it wrong. I'll know."

He pointed at the screen with his free hand, prompting the Kree to read aloud.

Once one screen's content was finished, Black Super would enter another menu and have the Kree read the next screen.

Even though, through the universal translator, Black Super couldn't hear how the original Kree words were pronounced, with his super-brain assisting him, he rapidly began deciphering the Kree script.

Kree writing wasn't phonetic like the alphabetic systems used across much of Earth. Instead, it resembled Hangul: consonants and vowels arranged vertically, horizontally, diagonally, or in compound forms to create a single "character," with two or three characters forming a word.

The same word could mean one thing as a verb and something entirely different as a noun. So when understanding Kree, you couldn't isolate individual words—you had to rely on context, interpreting full sentences and even entire paragraphs.

Just like in Korean, where the written form of "ancient temple" and "farewell" can be identical—without context, it's impossible to tell which is meant. Kree worked the same way.

Having a living reference to translate for him greatly accelerated Black Super's understanding. Aside from not knowing how to pronounce the words yet, he was already starting to grasp what was written on the screen.

Unfortunately, pleasant study sessions never lasted.

A throwing blade wreathed in high-energy heat shot in from the doorway!

So focused on decoding the script, Black Super almost let the captive in his hand take the blade for him. At the last critical moment, though, he flung the Kree aside and dodged the blade himself.

"I didn't know a little bug had snuck onto this cruiser," a voice said coldly. "Where did you crawl in from, you shady little thing?"

Chapter 378 - 378 — Goods Secured

The newcomer wasn't an ordinary Kree soldier—it was an elite warrior of the Starforce. That much was obvious from his equipment alone, which was completely different from the standard-issue gear of the rank and file.

He was a tall, blue-skinned Kree with a thick, Viking-like beard. Compared to him, ordinary Kree looked like macaques standing next to a silverback gorilla. His sheer bulk made that abundantly clear.

He carried multiple weapons and tools of various types. Considering that many weapons stored their blades for safety, this man could be regarded as a kind of weapon master—something like a Predator.

Faced with such a visibly dangerous opponent, Black Super naturally stopped focusing on deciphering Kree text.

Under a yellow sun, Kryptonians could walk sideways through the DC Universe—but this was still the Marvel Universe. Krypton was a failed contender in cosmic power struggles here. Carelessness could get him killed.

Black Super pulled the telescopic baton from his belt and snapped it outward with a flick of his wrist. The arm-length baton was coated in matte black, matching his outfit perfectly.

His opponent, perhaps out of a warrior's sense of respect, didn't draw a firearm. Instead, he produced a similar baton-like weapon. Electricity crackled along its length, clearly indicating that getting hit by it would be far more than just painful.

"Don't you have a name, little bug?"

"Black Super."

"Bron-Char."

Names exchanged, the battle began.

Bron-Char charged like a brown bear, his massive frame moving with startling speed. His baton came down in a crushing overhead strike, like a war hammer—lethal even without the added energy discharge.

Black Super let the tip of the Kree's baton pass within a hair's breadth of his nose. At the same time, he used his own baton to strike the inside of Bron-Char's arm, then hooked the back of the knee in one smooth motion, throwing the Kree off balance and lifting him into the air.

The final strike came immediately after—a baton blow aimed straight at Bron-Char's face, slamming him hard into the deck!

Three moves, seamless and fluid, executed in one breath. Bron-Char suffered a heavy loss in the very first exchange.

That said, he was indeed an elite Starforce warrior, and his physique was far superior to that of ordinary Kree.

Black Super had already adjusted his strength upward based on the earlier soldiers, but this combo, while not exactly a mosquito bite, was only enough to make Bron-Char shake his head and push himself back up for another round.

Black Super had no sense of martial honor, nor any desire to show respect to his opponent. He was simply gathering data on Kree physical capabilities, trying to develop more efficient and less energy-intensive tactics.

Using a cannon to kill mosquitoes felt great—but it was also stupid.

That said, this opponent clearly wasn't an ordinary Kree. Who knew if he possessed some kind of mutation or special ability? Unfortunately, Black Super didn't have the luxury of time to find out.

When the first captive had activated his universal translator earlier, he'd also sent out a distress signal to his comrades. That was why Bron-Char had arrived so quickly.

And Bron-Char was only the first.

Black Super could sense more Kree converging on his position. There was no time to indulge in some pointless "fight to your heart's content" fantasy.

Before Bron-Char could pull out another weapon, Black Super surged forward again. He wrapped the baton around Bron-Char's arm, locked it in place, and then drove the massive Kree straight into the bulkhead!

The impact smashed through the thinner section of the wall. The hulking Kree crashed through and ended up half-embedded in it, dazed, blue blood streaming down his forehead.

Under the gaze of the Kree prisoner who'd been thrown aside, Black Super—fresh off a decisive victory—turned and ran.

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Black Super's withdrawal wasn't solely because of the pursuing enemies. More importantly, from the menu screens he'd just forced the Kree to interpret—combined with what he'd already pieced together—he now knew exactly where to find what he wanted, and what that thing actually was.

Mar-Vell's laboratory had been remodeled beyond recognition by the Skrulls left behind on the ship. No wonder Black Super hadn't even considered this place during his earlier reconnaissance.

Perhaps it was the boredom of six years spent trapped here. The Skrulls living aboard this cruiser hadn't merely built lighted grow rooms to cultivate plants and slow the depletion of stored rations.

They had repurposed entire compartments and machines, reshaping them to better support long-term habitation, creating a self-sustaining living cycle.

The only machine left largely untouched was the extractor that held the Tesseract. But given its placement in such a vast, open chamber, that clearly wasn't its original location either.

As for the main laboratory—it had been converted into a breeding chamber. The plants grown in the illuminated cultivation rooms all originated from seedlings synthesized here.

The Skrulls' ability to produce their own food during this time wasn't because the cruiser carried a conventional seed vault capable of endlessly producing high-quality crops.

At the level of Kree and Skrull civilization, biodiversity was no longer preserved through seed banks, but through gene libraries, much like Krypton's Codex.

Only this gene library was far broader in scope—not limited to Kree or Skrull DNA, but encompassing countless species of flora and fauna, preserving only the most optimal genetic templates, and not restricted to species from the Skrulls' homeworld.

Their genetic technology was advanced enough that, given a species' genetic code, they could synthesize it directly from raw matter.

That raw matter was derived from waste—excrement, unusable plant residue, decomposed food scraps—broken down and recombined through chemical processes into biological substrate.

In essence, it was an artificial simulation of a natural ecological cycle.

But trapped within a cruiser, unable to rely on nature itself, they had no choice but to substitute technology for every step, maintaining a fragile internal ecosystem just to keep everyone alive.

Unlike ordinary ships that relied purely on resupply, this was exactly why the cruiser couldn't support a large population.

It was precisely because so many compartments were filled with various plants that Black Super had subconsciously dismissed the area earlier, failing to realize that this seemingly non-essential space—unrelated to navigation or life-support—was in fact Mar-Vell's original research lab.

With Captain Marvel going berserk and the cruiser suffering a brief power outage earlier, the imprisoned Skrulls had seized their chance to escape. Along with them, the two humans—Nick Fury and Maria Rambeau—had begun their breakout.

The Kree soldiers, who had previously been spread throughout the ship sweeping every compartment, first converged on the area where Black Super had appeared. Now they were being redirected to intercept the fleeing Skrulls.

The upside was that Kree troop movements had become more concentrated.

Naturally, Black Super chose a route far from the crowds, heading straight for his objective.

He deliberately avoided using super-speed to dash past the aliens, because he couldn't be sure whether this unfamiliar high-tech civilization had experience—or equipment—specifically designed to counter speedsters.

What he knew of them came from films and comics, fragments rather than the full picture.

Betting that they definitely didn't have such countermeasures—or that they weren't carrying them—was unnecessary risk. Taking the long way around was the safest choice.

Avoiding contact altogether and minimizing exposure remained the ideal scenario.

After a tense but uneventful journey, he arrived at his destination: Mar-Vell's laboratory.

Amid rows of seedlings, Black Super finally spotted his target.

At the same time, he confirmed what Kree technology used as data storage.

Chapter 379 379 — Battle in Space

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It was a transparent, multi-faceted glass object—sometimes irregular in shape. Data was engraved and erased using light of specific wavelengths.

To the naked eye, it looked like a cloudy, low-grade crystal. Who would ever imagine that such an unassuming object contained the knowledge of an advanced civilization?

Black Super removed the largest storage crystal and examined it closely.

It was roughly the size of a fist—a perfect regular icosahedron. Among the fourteen crystals in the lab, it was the most symmetrical and complex in shape.

The others included seven irregular forms, two large stellated dodecahedrons, three diamond-cut shapes, and one hexagonal column.

Some were mounted in read-write rigs surrounded by thirty-six probes for full-spectrum access; others were simply stored in cabinets.

In fact, those irregular ones were likely brought by the Skrulls themselves. Otherwise, it was hard to explain why the same type of device would follow two entirely different design aesthetics.

And given how much overlap existed between Kree and Skrull technology, it was clear these two empires hadn't just stumbled upon each other in some cosmic dark forest.

According to official origin lore, the Skrull Empire predated the Kree Empire.

When Skrull explorers arrived at Hala in the Large Magellanic Cloud, they discovered two intelligent species.

Arrogant as an advanced civilization, the Skrulls decided to test both races—intending to uplift one and exterminate the other.

Instead, the Skrull observation team was ambushed and defeated by the Kree once the truth came to light. The other observed species, the Cotati, were slaughtered by the Kree.

Seizing the Skrulls' abandoned technology, the Kree rapidly rose into a military empire. That first encounter sparked mutual hostility, leading to a war that lasted hundreds of thousands of years—

—setting aside the question of which planet's orbital period defined a "year."

—until the Skrull Empire was ultimately destroyed, its people scattered.

From one perspective, it resembled America's break from Britain—except that the United States didn't then wipe out the British Isles and hunt the English across the globe.

The Kree did exactly that.

In short, neither alien race was innocent.

Stealing from them gave Black Super zero moral burden.

So without even checking the contents, he swept up all the storage crystals—Kree-made and Skrull-made alike.

After suffering so much under the Skrulls' "hospitality," taking a little compensation was only fair.

With Captain Marvel currently on their side, it wasn't a good time to burn bridges completely. And in the end, this Kree cruiser would fall into Skrull hands anyway.

He was only taking non-essential data—leaving the engines intact instead of turning the ship into a space coffin. That already made him generous.

Besides, if they had an excuse to linger on Earth, he would be the one stuck dealing with the fallout.

Black Super did briefly consider swiping a Kree-brand reader as well. Building one himself wouldn't be difficult, but having a ready-made unit would save him the trouble of calibrating light wavelengths.

Still, with more than a dozen crystals already weighing him down, even lightly equipped, he already looked like a thief who'd struck gold.

Adding an entire machine would really cement the image of someone moving house.

Tempting as it was, the Quinjet departing the Kree cruiser had already come under attack from Kree fighters in open space.

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Being able to withstand the siege of more than a dozen nimble light fighters without being blown apart was due partly to the shield field the Skrulls had installed on the Quinjet, and partly to Maria Rambeau's exceptional piloting skills.

One had to remember that the Quinjet was originally designed for atmospheric flight. In the vacuum of space—where aerodynamics were meaningless—for Maria

Rambeau to achieve this level of performance using only the Skrulls' hastily installed attitude-adjustment thrusters could only be described as sheer talent.

Even so, shields had their limits. No matter how skilled the pilot, being mobbed from all sides inevitably led to mistakes. The Quinjet's situation was hanging by a thread.

As for Captain Marvel in her Binary form, things unfolded much as they had in the movie. She was tied down by former comrades from the Kree Starforce. Even though the burly Bronn-Char was still embedded in the bulkhead where Black Super had wedged him—unconscious and unmoving—the strongest combatant on the field was effectively neutralized.

Which meant that, despite being the powerhouse, Captain Marvel was unable to help.

Black Super had no choice but to step in himself—if only to make sure Nick Fury didn't end up as a spectacular firework in the vacuum of space.

After all, he was still counting on Fury to clean up the mess the Skrulls had left behind inside S.H.I.E.L.D. If Fury died here, Black Super would have to spend far more effort—and owe far more favors—to deal with the shapeshifters' fallout.

Even though this went completely against his laid-back, "salted fish" philosophy of life, Black Super reluctantly activated his super-speed, rapidly disengaging from the Kree cruiser and entering open space.

He secured his loot at his lower back and crouched briefly against the outer hull of the Kree cruiser.

The Kree's experience in space combat was on an entirely different level from that of a pilot who'd only ever done test flights. Worse still, among the Kree fighters was one clearly distinct command craft, flown by a far more seasoned operator.

It was precisely the arrival of that command fighter that turned the Kree assault into layered waves, attacking from all directions like surging tides. The fact that the Quinjet hadn't already exploded into a fireball was nothing short of a miracle.

It was clear that a one-versus-seventeen scenario was beyond the scope of any pilot. Under these conditions, Maria Rambeau had no chance of recreating some cinematic canyon dogfight miracle and turning the tables on the Kree fighters.

And the problem she faced wasn't just numerical disadvantage—excessive baggage was her greatest burden.

Because inside that Quinjet, it wasn't just Maria Rambeau, Nick Fury, Goose the Flerken, and Talos' family of three.

In addition to the dozen-plus Skrull soldiers who had accompanied them earlier, nearly twenty Skrull refugees once sheltered by Dr. Mar-Vell were also crammed inside.

Imagine a craft that was supposed to rely on agility, its cabin packed like a rush-hour bus.

Goose lay sprawled atop the cockpit console. Did it never occur to them to make use of the little creature's pocket universe and temporarily swallow some of the excess passengers?

Unfortunately, now was clearly not the time for such reminders—the Quinjet was on the verge of being blown apart.

Spaceflight differed fundamentally from atmospheric combat. With no air, many maneuvers familiar to atmospheric fighters simply didn't exist. There was no concept of turning radius or turn rate, nothing like what was depicted in Star Wars.

A spacecraft's direction and speed depended entirely on propellant usage. Any fuel spent accelerating had to be matched by an equal amount spent decelerating.

Apply force in a different direction, and the craft's trajectory changes accordingly. Every movement followed the mathematical result of vector addition—unless captured by a celestial body's gravity, adding another force into the equation.

In other words, with proper control, spacecraft could execute right-angle turns—or even sharper maneuvers—without issue. The only real limit was whether the pilot could endure the G-forces involved.

Thus, the Kree fighters' wave-based attacks were nothing more than sequences of acceleration, deceleration, reorientation, and renewed acceleration. Simple actions—but under coordinated command, the resulting time-differentiated strikes were still lethal.

The instant Black Super made up his mind, he locked onto the main engines of every Kree fighter.

Chapter 380 - 380 — A Front-Row Seat to Captain Marvel’s Show

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It had to be said—the Kree pilot with lightning-fast reactions had done Black Super a huge favor. Otherwise, he would have been the one living rent-free in Nick Fury's head.

Black Super's flying speed was, of course, far beyond what a Quinjet could ever hope to catch. The real concern was that, once they realized they couldn't pursue him, they might resort to off-the-books tactics—calling in backup.

After all, this was Earth. American airspace. Their home turf.

Unlike the attitude-control nozzles—which altered direction through propellant exhaust—the main engines not only provided primary thrust but also supplied energy to power the entire craft. They were, quite literally, the heart of the system.

Using a Kryptonian ability that appeared to be flight but was actually gravitational manipulation, Black Super struck with maximum speed and minimal distance, crippling the engines of every Kree fighter and leaving them drifting on inertia alone.

The attitude thrusters remained intact, and the remaining propellant could still adjust orientation—but without main engine power, their energy weapons were effectively dead as well.

The extent of damage varied from craft to craft due to differing angles of attack, but none of them exploded.

For some reason, dressed all in black, Black Super found it hard to summon killing intent.

There was only one miscalculation—the uniquely shaped command fighter launched from Mar-Vell's Kree cruiser, piloted by a female member of Starforce.

This larger craft possessed a shield field far stronger than that of the smaller fighters. And because it wasn't his first target, the pilot had precious fractions of a second to react once she realized they were under attack.

Her response was immediate—she diverted maximum shield output to the aft section, concentrating energy around the engine.

As a result, Black Super's strike merely sent the craft tumbling through space, failing to destroy its main engine.

By then, however, Black Super was already plunging back through the atmosphere toward the surface. He didn't bother turning back to deal with the survivor.

Leaving a single enemy behind would at least give Nick Fury something to do. Otherwise, Fury and Maria Rambeau might get it into their heads to chase down the mysterious figure who'd helped them, just to see who he was.

That cursed curiosity was worse than a cat's.

The one fighter that had escaped Black Super's grasp proved equally pragmatic. Rather than staying behind to rescue her comrades, she continued the pursuit. After all, a smaller support vessel remained behind to conduct recovery operations.

Perhaps her original mission had always been to pursue the fleeing Skrulls and the natives of C53, which was why she hadn't chased after the far more threatening Black Super.

Partly because he was already retreating at tremendous speed toward the planet's surface—and partly because completing the mission mattered more than chasing an elusive enemy.

From reports sent by Bronn-Char and other soldiers, she knew there was an unknown hostile infiltrator aboard the cruiser. But his behavior suggested a scavenger stirring chaos to steal something—though the extent of the loss was still unclear.

Per Commander Yon-Rogg's orders, this individual was classified as a secondary target. Only after eliminating the primary objective would they deal with him.

And the primary objective, of course, was the Kree Empire's sworn enemy—

the Skrulls.

Thus, Minerva piloted her fighter in relentless pursuit of the lagging craft packed with Skrulls, firing first to cut off any chance of regrouping, then chasing down the lumbering, overloaded target like a predator closing in on a wounded beast.

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In broad daylight, even if bodily flight couldn't be picked up by radar, there was still the risk of eyewitnesses. Once recorded, given America's intelligence-analysis capabilities, who knew what dangerously accurate conclusions they might draw. Black Super had no desire to be exposed.

Besides, daytime really wasn't for bats—ah, no, wrong reference. Daytime wasn't for nightwalkers. A black stealth suit stood out far too much in the sun.

As for Ronan the Accuser's flagship—the Dark Aster, the Kree Empire's most powerful warship with a history spanning 9,509 years—and the fleet under his command, that was Captain Marvel's true debut stage. There was no need to steal her spotlight.

Still, after depositing the advanced alien data-storage devices he'd "borrowed" into the second-layer secret chamber of the Sheep Cave Valley laboratory, Black Super

didn't remove his stealth suit. Instead, he returned to the ground beneath the battlefield.

High above, Ronan the Accuser ordered his fleet—including his flagship—to carry out a surface bombardment of Planet C53. Four Kree warships launched ballistic warheads toward Earth.

Black Super couldn't be certain just how powerful those missiles were. But surely they weren't planet-busters—at most, they'd wipe out surface life. Like the extinction of the dinosaurs after a comet impact.

...Probably.

Then again, if someone told him those missiles could burrow into the crust and blow up the planetary core, he wouldn't be all that surprised either. At the level of a galactic empire, lacking a few planet-destruction tactics would be downright embarrassing.

Watching the scene unfold, Black Super genuinely wondered what kind of person could believe that Asgard's claim of protecting Midgard was meant seriously.

He couldn't help muttering to the sky,

"Heimdall, Midgard's about to be played to death by the Kree. Asgard's supposed to be the protector of the Nine Realms—aren't you going to do something?"

As expected—no response.

Then again, the only one who'd ever said such things out loud was Thor, fresh out of his chuunibyou phase. Thinking about it that way, it almost made sense.

Midgard was one of the Nine Realms—that much was true. As part of the World Tree, it was certainly something Asgard would preserve. But... protecting Earth and protecting Earthlings were two very different concepts. Surely no one confused the two.

Only that chuunibyou prince believed Asgard's own propaganda. His clear-headed father? Silent and indifferent, just waiting to die.

What nonsense about "All-Father-tier beings not meddling in trivial matters." What —was all of Asgard down to just Odin himself? Not a single soldier worth deploying? Or did Heimdall simply miss it? Was the Bifrost too slow to send reinforcements?

If it was because Earth no longer worshipped the Norse gods, and thus they felt justified in not intervening—could they still call themselves protectors?

At the end of the day, it was just a transaction.

Gazing skyward, Black Super felt as though he could see those gods looking down on mortals. The whole thing struck him as deeply ironic.

"Who are you?!"

The untimely shout snapped him out of his brooding. Commander Yon-Rogg of the Kree Starforce stepped out from his crash-landed single-pilot craft.

He drew his energy pistol and aimed it at the masked figure clad entirely in black.

No one in the Kree Empire's camp would play tricks in front of him.

As for the Skrull Empire... it no longer existed. Any Skrull smart enough, encountering him alone, would run immediately. An elite Starforce commander wasn't someone an ordinary Skrull could handle one-on-one.

So the only possibility for someone hiding their face yet refusing to flee was a native of Planet C53. Only the ignorant were fearless enough to stand before him. That was why Yon-Rogg activated his universal translator and spoke.

Above them, Captain Marvel—now in Binary mode—charged head-on into the incoming orbital missiles.

Chapter 381 - 381 — The Kree Version of Krypton

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"Hah! So that's what those shape-shifting freaks told you—that Krypton offended every civilization in the universe and got hunted down by everyone?"

Yon-Rogg holstered his weapon and laughed loudly, then began telling a rather different story.

In the war between the Kree and Skrull empires—one that had dragged on for hundreds of thousands of years—the borders of both sides had actually changed very little. Each side consisted of a dominant core civilization ruling over numerous subordinate ones. The goal was never merely territorial expansion, but the annihilation of the other core civilization and the amplification of one's own influence.

If one were to compare it to Earth's history, it resembled the European colonial era more than anything else.

They conquered territories for markets, resources, and manpower—not like America's westward expansion, where indigenous peoples were wiped out so settlers could claim the land and multiply.

Only by ruling many civilizations with a single dominant one could an empire of such scale be sustained.

To ensure stable rule, the military capabilities of subject civilizations were strictly limited. Thus, the great wars between the Kree and Skrulls were nothing like the

Not only did Asgard fail to respond, even Earth's own defensive forces were nowhere to be seen.

The lack of a military response was understandable. Every power on Earth was prepared to defend against neighbors on the same planet. No one had seriously considered attacks from space.

After all, during the X-Men's clash with the D'Bari, alien fighters and even warships had entered the atmosphere and struck the surface.

With so many U.S. troops witnessing it firsthand, Black Super didn't believe for a second that no reports had gone up the chain of command. The reason reinforcements still hadn't arrived after all that chaos was simple—they didn't know how to respond.

There was also another possibility: both sides might have noticed that a certain public-spirited good Samaritan had already shouldered the problem. Naturally, they were happy to let him.

It wasn't fair to accuse them of freeloading. From another perspective, their inaction was simply because they were powerless.

Lowering his head, Black Super stopped watching Captain Marvel detonate the missiles one by one in the sky. Time was short, and Yon-Rogg was the reason he'd come back.

"How much do you know about Krypton?" Black Super asked, then added, "Do you even know what Krypton is?"

"And who are you?" Yon-Rogg shot back. "Why do you want information like that?"

Rather than bargaining or probing indirectly, Black Super chose the faster route. He quickly repeated everything the Skrulls had told him about Krypton, then asked:

"That's what the Skrulls told me. So I want to know—does the Kree side have a different version?"

Yon-Rogg countered, "Are you a Kryptonian?"

Black Super hopped down from the rock he'd been sitting on and approached the Starforce commander.

"That's what the Skrulls claim. I don't exactly have a birth certificate or proof of identity to confirm anything.

"But I don't fully trust a single source of information. Since you're enemies of the Skrulls, do you have a different story to tell me?"

The enemy of my enemy is my friend—a principle valid across the universe. Black Super was trying to exploit the Kree–Skrull rivalry to get Yon-Rogg talking.

Of course, there was always the chance the Kree would deliberately lie or mislead him. To judge truth from falsehood, Black Super's super-brain was running at full capacity, scrutinizing every reaction and detail in Yon-Rogg's behavior.

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Mongol invasions, where vast numbers of auxiliary troops followed a central army in a cold-weapons "world war."

Instead, the core civilizations themselves clashed directly on the battlefield. The subject civilizations merely supplied resources—endlessly producing weapons and materiel—slowly bleeding themselves dry to fuel the war.

The Solar System lay on the fringe of this inter-imperial conflict. The Kree Empire was the first to establish an outpost on one of Uranus's moons, using it as a watchtower against the Skrull Empire.

As for what the Kree had been doing on Earth, Yon-Rogg skipped over it. It had little to do with the question at hand, and Black Super didn't press him on it.

Krypton, Yon-Rogg explained, was located in the Vega system, about fifty light-years from Earth. The Skrulls originated in the Andromeda Galaxy and had come to occupy most of the Milky Way—including the Vega system.

In other words, a newly spacefaring civilization had emerged inside Skrull territory.

By Skrull imperial doctrine, if a planetary civilization was divided internally, they would evaluate which faction was worth supporting, then help it eliminate the others.

If the civilization was already unified, they would use their shapeshifting abilities to infiltrate and overthrow its government, installing a pro-Skrull regime and completing their conquest.

But Krypton's unique DNA-based technological path made those tactics ineffective.

For civilizations like that, the Skrull Empire's standard solution was simple: eradication, just as they had done to countless others.

Krypton resisted.

The Skrull Empire, having underestimated them, was briefly shattered by this newly spacefaring world. Naturally, such a civilization became an attractive ally to the Kree.

That alliance ended with the Battle of the Barrington System, where the Skrulls annihilated the Kryptonian fleet. Krypton then used an unknown technology to deploy the Phantom Zone around the Rao system, sealing off further Skrull incursions—and effectively isolating itself.

All of this had happened roughly ten thousand years ago.

"So what you're saying," Black Super summarized, "is that Krypton's real enemy was only the Skrulls, who conveniently claimed to represent the entire universe—and that the Kree were useless allies who didn't actually help at all?"

He couldn't hide his skepticism at the clear bias in Yon-Rogg's account.

"You don't seriously think I'd fabricate something this elaborate, something that couldn't stand up to scrutiny, just to recruit you—do you?" Yon-Rogg replied. "I'm a warrior, not a silver-tongued diplomat."

Black Super chose not to dwell on interstellar politics.

"I've heard enough about Krypton's feud with the Skrull Empire. What about Krypton itself? How much do you know about its internal structure?"

What he didn't say was that, judging from how desperately the Skrulls had tried to frame or kill him the moment they encountered him, the hatred between them ran far deeper than words alone suggested.

Yon-Rogg answered without evasion.

"The Kree Empire did send covert envoys during Krypton's most active period, offering assistance. So we do have a certain level of understanding. More detailed records are preserved by the Supreme Intelligence.

"But I'm a soldier. What I know best is war history. As for internal matters, what I know is largely the same as what the Skrulls told you."

"The Supreme Intelligence..." Black Super repeated, then asked, "Who—or what—is that?"

He did have pre-incarnation knowledge, but this wasn't something he should already know in-world, and he wasn't certain whether reality matched his memories. So he asked.

Yon-Rogg explained:

"The Supreme Intelligence is a living computer. It contains the brains of the greatest politicians, philosophers, scientists, and thinkers in Kree history—merged into a single collective consciousness.

"Every five years, the people of the Kree Empire elect a representative. Upon death, that individual's brain is specially processed and added to the Supreme Intelligence's gestalt. It is constantly evolving, never stagnant.

"Approximately—using C53's orbital period—nine hundred thousand years ago, the Supreme Intelligence was chosen as the Empire's absolute ruler. It is our leader, our sage, our elder."

That matched Black Super's expectations.

Within the Kree Empire, the Supreme Intelligence wasn't some distant, untouchable figure that ordinary people might never encounter.

As a biological computer, it could communicate with anyone through terminals or receivers, allocating a negligible portion of its processing power.

It could be a kind older sister—or a wise life coach.

This accessibility, combined with an impressive record of sound decisions, was why the Kree people accepted its long-term rule.

Chapter 382 382 — The Arrested Criminal

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A brown, old-model Cadillac with a license plate flagged by an all-points bulletin appeared on the streets of Los Angeles. A patrol car immediately lit up its siren and lights and pulled it over.

The wanted "dangerous individual," Stark Industries' film subsidiary CEO Henry Brown, was sitting in the driver's seat. Even more dangerous—there was a fully grown adult tiger in the back seat.

The rookie officer riding along nearly drew his gun and emptied the magazine on the spot.

But among America's three strangest major cities—New York, Los Angeles, and Las Vegas—law enforcement officers tend to be both well-traveled and unusually bold. The veteran cop quickly noticed that the tiger was chained in the back seat.

Don't do anything stupid, and there won't be a problem.

He immediately stopped his rookie partner.

He understood very well that the bulletin itself was suspicious. It only said the target was "dangerous" and needed to be apprehended. It didn't say what crime had

As Black Super pondered this, Yon-Rogg extended an offer.

"Kryptonian—if you wish to know more, I can take you to Hala to meet the Supreme Intelligence.

"I know it was you whom Bron-Char encountered aboard the cruiser. I'm willing to overlook his defeat and the losses you caused. But first, I need your assistance."

Assistance?

Black Super's attention flicked skyward. Captain Marvel—now having just obliterated a Kree warship and sent Ronan's remaining fleet fleeing—was descending back to the surface.

Yon-Rogg raised his weapon again, aiming at the traitor of the Kree Starforce.

She was no longer glowing, apparently having exited Binary mode. That didn't make her weak—far from it. She was the kind of person you killed only if you wanted to, never because you could.

"Who are you?" Carol Danvers demanded sharply. "The man in black."

There was no chance Black Super would foolishly leave a yellow-sun system and wander into deep space.

Now he knew: Kryptonians were a species utterly dependent on terrain. Go to the wrong place, and they didn't even need enemies to kill themselves.

How desperate did one have to be to leave Earth?

Joining the Kree? Don't be ridiculous.

He glanced at the furious Carol Danvers and said calmly, "I'm just passing through. Looks like you've got a score to settle—don't mind me."

Then he turned to Yon-Rogg.

"This isn't my war. Your offer means nothing to me. Take care of yourself, Kree."

Carol wasn't satisfied.

She turned to Yon-Rogg. "Who is he?"

"I don't know," Yon-Rogg replied. The two exchanged bewildered looks—

—and then realized the man was gone.

The disappearance was so sudden it was as if his suit came with a max-level stealth skill. Two elite Starforce veterans couldn't even tell how he vanished.

The confrontation, however, continued uninterrupted.

Yon-Rogg holstered his weapon again, beginning with the words, "I'm so proud of you," trying to rekindle the Kree warrior pride that Vers had spent six years chasing under his command.

He didn't get far.

A photon blast sent him flying.

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been committed, how dangerous the suspect was, or provide any convincing justification—just a blanket order to grab the man.

The whole thing felt like a high-level power struggle, with decisions being made far above their pay grade.

If the charges were airtight, then law enforcement should act impartially. But in cases like this—where the situation might still turn around—you still act by the book, but you don't make a mortal enemy out of someone who might bounce back.

Fortunately, the suspect only asked for a lawyer and otherwise cooperated fully. The only real problem was the tiger—something even seasoned LAPD officers didn't know how to handle.

In the end, they called in animal control hunters. One tranquilizer dart solved the issue. Throughout the process, Kitty behaved like a well-fed house cat—calm and nonthreatening—so much so that even the animal-handling professionals felt no danger.

And so Henry Brown was arrested by the LAPD and taken to the police station, where he waited to see whether the FBI or his lawyer would arrive first.

Henry contacted a lawyer himself using the public phone at the station.

In the United States, practicing attorneys must hold licenses for the states they operate in; they can't freely practice across state lines.

Stark Industries' projects, however, weren't limited to any single state. As a result, its legal advisory structure consisted of multiple partner law firms, prepared to respond to issues wherever they arose.

At Stark Pictures in Los Angeles, routine business matters and commercial disputes had their own in-house legal counsel. But for problems outside the scope of ordinary business, they had to rely on the more comprehensive legal team of Stark Industries proper.

Henry called the Los Angeles representative of Stark Industries' legal advisory group—the managing partner of a well-known law firm.

Meanwhile, the LAPD chief informed the FBI's Los Angeles field office that Henry Brown had been apprehended and told them to send someone to pick him up.

Owen Davis, Assistant Special Agent in Charge of the FBI's Los Angeles office—the de facto head of the Bureau in the city—was genuinely surprised by the news.

Henry Brown was supposed to be a bulletproof mutant. And now he'd been arrested by a bunch of street cops?

But from Owen's perspective, not catching him would have been good news. Now that they had him, Owen had no idea what to do.

At times like this, the only option was to dump the problem back onto the organization that had impersonated the FBI and issued a shoot-on-sight order for the man.

But the FBI couldn't simply hand Henry over.

That organization wasn't officially recognized, had no lawful authority, and there was no legitimate channel for transferring a detainee.

Besides, the FBI's pursuit of Henry Brown had mostly been opportunistic—riding the wave after someone else made the first move. Everything they'd done stayed within a vague gray zone of "reasonable procedure," but there had been no court order at any point.

So the only way forward was an off-the-books transfer.

In plain terms: calling in favors.

If Owen wanted to talk favors with that shadowy organization, he couldn't approach their Los Angeles front man—the thin, slippery Director Keller.

The best contact was an old war buddy.

Nick Fury.

Owen immediately redialed a number he'd already called more times than he cared to count.

He assumed it would go like the previous attempts—ringing endlessly with no answer.

This time, however, he was calling a mobile phone rather than a landline. After about ten rings, it would normally roll over to voicemail.

But only a few rings in, the call connected.

And a familiar voice came through, delivering familiar words in a familiar tone:

"Motherf— you white monkey! Do you have any idea how busy I've been these past few days? Busier than a damn Jew! You've called me this many times—you'd better have something important, or I swear this black grandpa's gonna kick your ass red!"

Chapter 383 - 383 — At Best, an Administrative Error

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Nick Fury was, of course, not about to tell the whole truth. For situations like this, a man long accustomed to bureaucratic doublespeak replied smoothly:

> "This stemmed from an internal administrative error on our end. The criminal record of a highly dangerous mutant offender was mistakenly entered under another mutant's file. As a result, we mobilized armed pursuit and even issued an incorrect shoot-on-sight order. In short—this was a mistake."

"What?! Fury, are you serious?"

"All right, Owen, I won't hide it from you. I can't go into details, but yes—we screwed this up on our side."

"Fuck! Then what are we supposed to do now?"

Thinking back to what Barbara had reported, Nick Fury had already been considering whether S.H.I.E.L.D. should quietly compensate Henry Brown for the damages caused when an assault team broke into his home.

What he never expected was that S.H.I.E.L.D. would finish tearing the place apart—only for the FBI to come right after and completely ransack it.

So Nick Fury said simply:

"Find a reason and let him go. He's the CEO of Stark Pictures now, a public figure with a reputation. You don't seriously think he's like some homeless drifter who could vanish into a back alley and no one would care, do you?"

Owen Davis ignored the torrent of profanity.

Back in the trenches, the dirtier the language, the closer the bond. When it came to enemies, nobody wasted breath—just a burst of bullets and that was it.

But this call was serious business.

Owen spoke as if claiming credit.

"Hey, I helped you catch the guy you wanted taken care of. I think that's worth a good bottle of liquor—assuming you want him transferred."

"...Who?"

The tone alone allowed Owen to picture the look of confusion on Nick Fury's face.

"Henry Brown."

"WHO?!"

That didn't sound like surprise or delight.

It sounded like panic—the same tone Fury had used years ago when Owen told him they were surrounded.

Owen felt a sinking feeling.

"I'm saying we caught Henry Brown. Well—LAPD did. I've already sent people over to handle the transfer."

"Motherf—! Why the hell did you arrest that guy?!"

"Well... wasn't he your target? From what I heard, when your people went out using FBI credentials, they even issued a shoot-to-kill order. It's just that against a bulletproof mutant, our equipment wasn't exactly—"

"That's enough, Owen. I get it now."

On the other end, Nick Fury rubbed his forehead, finally remembering the mess the Skrulls had left behind—exactly what Barbara Morse had warned him about.

Barbara Morse's situation was easy to resolve. He'd return to headquarters, file a report detailing the entire incident from start to finish, and with the added credit of helping recover the Tesseract, her case would quietly disappear—even though she hadn't seen it through to the end.

But Henry Brown...

That was something Nick Fury had genuinely forgotten.

And he certainly hadn't expected things to spiral this far while his attention was elsewhere.

"...All right, Fury," Owen Davis said cautiously. "You're going to have to explain this to me. Because I'm starting to think I really screwed up."

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"Damn it! You should've told me this earlier. I couldn't get through to you for days!"

"That's exactly because of the 'administrative error.' You understand, right?"

"Jesus Christ! Can't your people step in and clean this up?"

"For that same 'administrative error,' we're in the middle of a full internal purge and renovation. What do you think?"

Carol Danvers had taken the Skrulls away—along with that Kree cruiser in space.

But were they all gone? Were there still aliens left inside S.H.I.E.L.D.?

No one dared take the Skrulls at their word.

According to Barbara Morse's report, both the Los Angeles and Louisiana S.H.I.E.L.D. branches had problems. Internal investigations were underway, and everything was in chaos.

Owen Davis sighed in defeat.

"All right. I get it. I'll handle it on my end."

"Owen."

"What?"

"...Nothing. I'll buy you a drink someday."

"One won't be enough. I'll need to get drunk."

"Bourbon. My favorite."

"Bring plenty. Talk to you later."

Owen Davis wanted to drink himself unconscious and forget reality altogether.

"Yeah. See you."

The call ended.

As Nick Fury drove, the man in the passenger seat spoke up.

"Does this have something to do with the Kryptonian you mentioned?"

"You could hear my call?" Black Nick Fury asked irritably.

White Nick Fury replied calmly, "My ears aren't that good—but my brain still works."

"So," Black Fury said, "got any advice for me?"

"Heh. I thought the weaned little brat didn't like people meddling in his business," White Fury mocked.

Black Fury ignored the jab and said seriously:

"If this were our old Cold War enemies—the KGB brats—I'd know exactly how to play them. But an alien? I've got zero experience there. If you can't even help with that, I honestly don't know what you're good for."

White Fury shot back, "You don't know this, you don't know that—then why did you drag me out here so solemnly? Don't tell me you think I'm retired, sitting around playing chess with old men all day. I've got my own mission. I just haven't left yet."

"If this didn't involve aliens, I wouldn't have called you," Black Fury complained. "We don't even have protocols for extraterrestrials."

After some thought, White Fury finally said:

"Henry Brown is a very special case. He's not an alien who just suddenly arrived on Earth with no ties or history."

"You're emphasizing that—why?" Black Fury asked.

"Carter wants us to investigate his life on Earth, and we are. But as long as we can't confirm that this alien is a threat, we don't touch him. Not even a little."

"Why?"

"Because of Stark."

"Tony Stark? That snot-nosed kid?"

White Fury continued:

"That little lion can't wait to show the world his claws and fangs. And the man placed as CEO of Stark Pictures is nothing more than bait."

"Anyone who touches that bait—no matter the reason—will face Stark's full retaliation. Even if Henry Brown murdered someone in broad daylight, I wouldn't doubt Tony Stark's ability to make it go away."

"Just like O.J. Simpson—charged with murder and still walked free. It has nothing to do with whether Henry Brown is an alien. We already know he's special—we just don't know how special."

Black Fury frowned. "You're serious? Their relationship is really that close?"

"It's not about their relationship. I already told you—the cub just needs an excuse to prove he's worthy of being king. Who the excuse is doesn't matter. What matters is that someone gets torn apart."

"You're sure?"

"That intelligence came directly from the Stark family's butler, Edwin Jarvis, to Agent Carter," White Fury replied. "In my opinion, it's highly reliable."

He added, "So now you know what you should've told your friend earlier."

Black Fury remembered how he'd hesitated on the phone with Owen Davis, wanting to say something—but stopping himself because S.H.I.E.L.D. hadn't yet finalized its stance on the Kryptonian.

Still, the advice held true.

That man was no nobody. As long as he stood at the center of Stark's web of influence, nothing about him could be treated lightly.

Chapter 384 384 — Preparing to Release

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When a case lacks sufficient evidence—or worse, when the order itself is flawed—what can be done?

Obviously, you release the suspect.

What else? Fabricate evidence out of thin air and force a conviction?

If the person involved were an insignificant nobody, a social outcast, it might be easy enough to bend the rules—plant some evidence, make them disappear, and be done with it. Don't fool yourself into thinking the FBI is some bastion of pure justice. They're perfectly capable of playing dirty.

But unfortunately, this was not such a person.

Lost in thought, Black Fury drove to a warehouse.

He got out, opened the door himself, went inside, and closed it again personally.

He parked in the empty warehouse, stopping in front of the only object placed at its center.

A coffin-like cryogenic container, thick power cables running from its base.

White Fury stepped out of the car, took one look, and immediately understood.

"This is what you wanted me to see?"

He walked closer, peered through the glass viewport—and swore.

"Fuck! Where did you get this thing?"

Black Fury shrugged. "You remember, right? I just went through a Kree-versus-Skrull incident, with a Kryptonian making a brief appearance."

"Who else knows you have this?" White Fury demanded sharply.

Black Fury replied:

"I learned how important this was from you, so I handled everything myself. No one else touched it—not even the procurement of this cryo-container."

"As for who on Earth might know this existed... probably only the former Air Force test pilot. After all, she's the one who shot it down. But she doesn't know what happened afterward—or who handled it."

Inside the cryo-container lay Minn-Erva, a member of the Kree Starforce—the female Kree who had dogfought Maria Rambeau's Quinjet and been shot down.

She was the only Kree corpse Black Fury had managed to recover.

On the Kree cruiser in space, the Kree casualties had apparently been retrieved by their own forces—not a single body left behind.

There was also whatever Goose the Flerken had swallowed—but until the creature spat up even the Tesseract, no one knew whether it would eventually cough up those "hairballs" too.

White Fury recalled what he himself had revealed before and couldn't help but warn him:

"The Infinity Formula is a curse. I was ordered to use it. If I had the chance to choose again, I never would have."

"You're collecting this now—what are you planning to do?"

"I'm not interested in a drug that has to be used constantly while relying on limited materials," Black Fury said calmly. "But I believe the Infinity Formula has far more potential than just letting certain bastards live longer."

"And no, that wasn't aimed at you, old man."

"...Fine," White Fury sighed. "I'll give you all the data related to the Infinity Formula."

"But understand this—if word of this leaks, the pressure you'll face will be unimaginable. The old-money elites already want to force their way into taking over S.H.I.E.L.D.'s labs."

"I know," Black Fury replied confidently.

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The man in question was not someone public authority could casually crush. He had a high-profile lawyer at his side and belonged squarely to the category the FBI hated dealing with the most. Worse still, everyone involved knew full well that what they'd done was deeply improper—and they had no idea how to placate him.

After hanging up on Nick Fury, Owen Davis didn't even have time to think about how to curse his old war buddy. His mind was racing, focused entirely on damage control.

He reviewed the subject's file—what little of it they had—and gradually formed a plan.

Owen Davis decided to personally go to the interrogation room, where the suspect and his attorney were being temporarily held.

To be honest, the sheer absurdity of the situation was something Owen Davis had never encountered in his entire career.

The suspect didn't know what crime he had supposedly committed. The lawyer had nothing to defend against. The organization that had issued the shoot-on-sight and arrest orders couldn't produce a single piece of legal evidence. And after repeated inquiries, all they got back was one phrase:

> "Administrative error."

The end result was that the FBI—who had actually arrested the man—had no idea what to do next, while the suspect and his lawyer sat across from each other in silence inside an interrogation room.

On FBI turf, even they didn't dare speak too freely.

After all, this wasn't some dirt-poor nobody, nor a welfare-dependent citizen barely scraping past the tax threshold.

This was the hottest man in Hollywood right now.

Of course, that "heat" wasn't from newspapers or tabloids—it was from private industry chatter. Film-grade digital imaging technology had disrupted countless people's livelihoods and stirred up even more envy and greed.

Faced with someone like that, Owen Davis didn't even consider pushing the blame onto his subordinates.

None of them could take the fall. In the end, it would all come back to him.

Better to face it head-on.

And with Tony Stark backing the man—if that young master decided to personally step in—the situation would escalate to the point where the FBI Director himself would have to fly in from Washington, D.C.

Guess who'd be the one getting cut down then?

The key to breaking the deadlock, as Owen Davis saw it, was this:

The opponent was careful—

the incident where one of his agents had been outplayed and forced into reassignment in Alaska was still fresh in his memory. Even though those two agents resigned shortly after, it had left a permanent blemish on his record.

—but the man was not someone skilled at wielding power.

He wasn't old money.

He had extraordinary abilities, yes—but his mindset was still that of someone from the bottom: cautious, afraid of trouble, unwilling to escalate.

This didn't mean people from privileged backgrounds weren't afraid of trouble. The difference was that they could afford to pay to make trouble go away—lawyers, settlements, scapegoats.

As a result, they behaved far more recklessly.

Fortunately, this man wasn't like that.

With a lawyer present, intimidation was off the table. But there were still perfectly legal ways to make someone back off once they understood the cost.

Having made up his mind, Owen Davis ordered the necessary documents prepared. He straightened his appearance in front of a mirror, put on the posture of authority, and entered the long-silent interrogation room with his subordinates.

He introduced himself first.

"Owen Davis. Assistant Special Agent in Charge, FBI Los Angeles Field Office."

He extended his hand—not to Henry Brown, but to the attorney.

They shook hands formally. Only then did he give Henry Brown a perfunctory handshake.

The lawyer did not object to this subtle slight, which made the underlying implication unmistakable.

In Owen Davis's eyes, that was a small win.

Everyone sat.

The seasoned FBI regional head had no intention of letting the lawyer dictate the tempo. He spoke first:

"Mr. Brown, allow me to offer my apologies for the inconvenience and the time you've lost."

"After verification, we've confirmed that the nationwide manhunt order attached to your name was the result of an administrative error by another agency. Criminal records belonging to a different mutant were mistakenly assigned to you and erroneously uploaded into the national law enforcement system."

"That mistake led to this incident."

Chapter 385 385 — The Missing Seized Property

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The ugly look on Henry's face was signal enough.

Even though the famous lawyer privately despised this suddenly risen, rough-edged upstart, he would never show it outright. Whatever his personal opinion, he still possessed the professional polish expected of a top-tier attorney.

Recalling the figures he had just seen, the lawyer said evenly,

"Once you sign this statement, you'll be free to leave."

As he spoke, a sharp-looking agent placed a document on the table and slid it forward.

It was a declaration stating that the detainee had not been subjected to improper treatment.

Law enforcement agencies were wary of follow-up disputes; even when they'd done nothing wrong, they preferred to have a liability waiver signed before releasing someone.

The lawyer recognized the routine immediately. He reviewed the document, found nothing problematic—standard clauses and boilerplate language—and placed it in front of Henry, nodding.

Henry didn't bother with words. He signed his name quickly.

He'd already lost more than enough time to police stations and federal buildings.

"May my client leave now, Director Davis?" the lawyer asked as he stood, buttoning his suit jacket—clearly confident in the outcome.

But Owen Davis didn't yield.

"Actually, there's one small matter left to resolve."

"What matter?" the lawyer asked.

Owen Davis accepted a thicker file from an agent behind him, flipped through it casually, then slid it across the table.

"Searches of crime scenes do not require additional court orders. However, due to the volume of digital equipment involved rather than traditional paper documents, those items were transferred to specialized forensic units."

"Unfortunately, due to an operational oversight during analysis, all digital equipment seized from Mr. Brown's residence has been lost."

"We have assessed the listed items and determined a compensation value."

"In addition, damages caused during the investigation were also appraised."

"If Mr. Brown agrees, we can issue a compensation check immediately. You'll be free to purchase new furniture and equipment."

The lawyer reviewed the document carefully, found no overt issues in language or format, and passed it to Henry.

Henry read it—and couldn't help but laugh.

The furniture didn't matter.

But the compensation list for his equipment?

The highest-valued item was a Stark computer he'd bought four or five years ago—and even that was depreciated.

Everything else lacked a brand name and was classified as worthless scrap.

Not even scrap metal value.

FBI compensation was calculated per item—each worth only a few dollars.

In total, the payout for all confiscated information, audio, and imaging equipment came to less than a thousand dollars.

Seven hundred and change.

More than half of that came from the ancient Stark computer.

All the time, knowledge, and effort Henry had poured into his custom-built systems were deemed worthless.

How could he not laugh?

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"Director Davis, you are aware that losing seized property is a very serious dereliction of duty, aren't you?"

"Mr. Brown was not a suspect, so those items were merely property held in custody," Owen Davis replied calmly. "Even so, the loss of custodial property is indeed our responsibility. That is why we're offering compensation. I believe this is a reasonable and lawful resolution."

That soft-but-firm counter was never going to impress a seasoned lawyer.

Henry, however, was thinking further ahead.

Appraisals were always subjective, except for items with clear price tags and depreciation standards. When something was needed, its value could be inflated at will. When it wasn't, people wouldn't take it even if you paid them.

The equipment he'd built by hand had no market price, no patents, no sales history.

Were they really going to listen to him explain how much technical expertise was packed into it? Or should he submit technical documentation and invite industry experts to testify?

Once the items were in their hands, and the official verdict was "scrap," then scrap was exactly what they would be—no matter the truth.

As for where the equipment had gone?

Henry didn't need to think hard. There was no way that so many large, valuable devices had simply vanished.

The FBI's actions had no solid legal basis to begin with. Without someone pushing from behind the scenes, they never would have acted at all. And once they did, was there any chance the spoils would stay untouched?

So this was something he had to swallow.

Lost was lost. He wasn't even particularly heartbroken.

What mattered more right now was something else.

"Then what about my pet?" Henry asked. "And my car? When can I get them back? Don't tell me those were lost too."

"Mr. Brown, your car is currently in an LAPD impound lot and can be retrieved at any time," Owen Davis replied. "As for your pet—"

Thinking of the tiger gave him another headache.

"—it should be at a temporary animal holding facility. You can pick it up whenever you like."

"I see."

Losing objects was one thing. But if Katie were mistreated or picked up bad habits, that would be a real loss.

Henry picked up the document and raised his pen.

He didn't sign immediately, though. Instead, he turned to his lawyer.

"There's nothing legally problematic about this document, correct?"

"No," the lawyer replied. "If you accept the compensation amount and sign, then the items listed become officially classified as lost property and are no longer tied to you. The FBI still bears responsibility for recovering them—but when that might happen is anyone's guess."

"Alright."

Just as he was about to sign, Henry paused again.

"Director Davis," he said, "there's a mobile phone registered under my name that was also inside my house. It's not listed among the lost items. Was it taken as well? Could it have been mixed in with the rest?"

"Did anyone try calling it? Maybe it was simply stored somewhere and forgotten. If it rings, wouldn't that answer the question?"

Owen Davis replied, "I understand your concern, Mr. Brown. I'll have my people conduct another review."

"Much appreciated."

Henry signed cleanly and decisively.

An FBI agent immediately handed him the prepared check and the receipt for the signed documents.

Henry pocketed them without even looking at the pitiful number on the check. He stood up, ready to leave.

Turning to the lawyer beside him, he said,

"Would you mind giving me a ride, sir? I need to go to the impound lot to retrieve my car."

The lawyer didn't hesitate. Though this was well outside his professional obligations, he nodded.

"Certainly. I'm heading in that direction anyway. But shouldn't you retrieve your pet first?"

"Would you dare?" Henry shot back.

The lawyer instantly remembered what that "pet" was.

Chapter 386 - 386 — I’m Not Kind, I’m Just Lazy

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If that man had been locked up—or at least entangled in lawsuits—he wouldn't have had the spare capacity to worry about the missing items.

But if he walked away unscathed, how could he possibly not come looking for them?

Which meant that those who had taken the items had to prepare a safeguard.

The "phone" mentioned in the warning almost certainly referred to a wireless mobile phone. No one would deliberately bring up a landline in this context. Yet

about:blank

A fully grown tiger.

Concerns about leather seats instantly became irrelevant. The real question was whether he dared share a vehicle with such a creature.

He laughed awkwardly.

"Mr. Brown, please come with me. My car is parked in the lot. Yours was towed to the LAPD impound yard—I'm familiar with the place. I'll take you there."

"Oh?" Henry asked in mild surprise. "Even someone as accomplished as you deals with impound lots?"

"Not exactly by choice," the lawyer replied dryly. "Some clients lack the patience to wait while I look for parking. I've gotten to know the people there quite well."

"Ha. Small people with a bit of power always love making life difficult, just to prove they exist."

Though he agreed wholeheartedly, a lawyer still had to sound objective.

"That's simply their job," he said with a smile. "And frankly, it's all they're allowed to do."

"True enough."

Henry wasn't oblivious to the faint contempt in the lawyer's tone. He simply pretended not to notice and continued chatting politely as they left together.

Once the two headaches were gone, Owen Davis finally let out a long breath.

This was almost the best possible outcome. No prolonged negotiation. No additional complications. The matter was resolved cleanly.

Before leaving the interrogation room, Owen Davis patted the agent who had accompanied him on the shoulder and said earnestly,

"Be more careful next time. We got lucky today. Don't assume tomorrow's luck will be the same."

He knew perfectly well how those items had been "lost." That was why his warning carried just the right amount of weight.

"Yes, sir."

The agent didn't return to his desk after leaving with his superior. Instead, he found a quiet corner and made a phone call.

The person on the other end picked up immediately.

"Everything accounted for, right? Why are you calling again?"

"Damn it, watch what you say on the phone," the agent snapped. "Don't mention anything you shouldn't. I'm calling to tell you the guy checked out clean. He's been released."

"His belongings are now officially lost property. There was a phone among them. Find a way to deal with it."

"You can track people through a phone?"

"I won't acknowledge that," the agent said coldly. "Don't ask what you shouldn't."

He hung up immediately—the call was far too risky to prolong. He'd already noticed footsteps approaching.

Quickly, he pulled out a cigarette and lit it, as if that had been his purpose all along.

A colleague passed by, thought nothing of it, and lit one too. The two chatted casually about recent cases, trading experiences and insights.

Elsewhere, in a certain research facility, the person who had taken the call pondered its implications.

If it hadn't mattered, that call would never have been made.

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after several inspections, they hadn't found any mobile phone—or anything resembling a homemade device.

That left the simplest method of locating it: call the number and listen for the ringtone.

Using the list on hand and the target's investigation report, the researcher found a private number—one not issued by a company—and dialed it. But no ringing could be heard among the confiscated research items.

After letting the call ring for a short while with no response, the researcher hung up. Perhaps the information had been incorrect, or merely a bluff.

What no one realized was that a timer inside the main unit had already been activated.

It was an insidious timer—no beeping alerts, no countdown display—just electronic components quietly coming online.

There was an ultra–high-frequency sound, inaudible to humans, signaling that a Kryptonian device had activated: If you don't want to clean up the environment, come shut me down.

Clearly, this wasn't a Kryptonian's home—and the one who could hear it wasn't present.

Strictly speaking, this setup didn't align with the classic "leave a way out of the maze, spare a path in the trap" principle. But the purpose of a self-destruction mechanism was simply to inform its creator when to stop—not to warn others. Wasn't that the whole point?

In any case, ten minutes later, the mastermind behind it all—Mickey Schulhof—had just exited Sony America's Los Angeles headquarters.

The message from his researchers had made him take the matter very seriously. Many of the personnel had been transferred from the Japanese headquarters and had arrived just that day to begin dismantling and analyzing the equipment.

To ensure their peace of mind, Mickey Schulhof needed to meet with the head of the FBI's Los Angeles office—to add another layer of insurance to the situation.

The company-provided executive car, a Lexus LS, was parked at the front entrance.

Though Sony was a Japanese company operating in the U.S. and had adapted many practices to local norms, Schulhof still enjoyed having two lines of employees standing in formation to welcome him whenever he entered or exited the building.

Call it cultural baggage if you want—but anything that put him in a good mood was worth keeping. Whether others enjoyed it was their problem.

Just as he strode past the lineup like a general and was about to get into the car, a massive explosion rang out, terrifying everyone—including Mickey Schulhof himself.

Shards of glass rained down from above, injuring many on the spot.

Before the shock had even faded, a huge object slammed directly onto the roof of the Lexus LS.

Dragged under bodyguard protection, Mickey Schulhof—who had been about to take cover inside the car—ended up staring straight into the eyes of the thing that had landed there.

The horrific corpse, its clothes still burning, sent the usually composed president of Sony America into hysterical screams.

Heavy impacts followed in rapid succession—some bodies hit the ground, others crashed into people. The scene was beyond gruesome.

Seated in the lawyer's car, Henry naturally heard the explosion from several kilometers away—his hearing made that unavoidable. Even the lawyer driving noticed something, though the sound was faint.

He asked,

"Where did that come from?"

"I'm not sure," Henry replied casually.

What he was actually thinking was this: while he hadn't designed lethal traps specifically for intruders, he'd never said he didn't build devices meant to erase evidence.

But with such a spectacular blast, had he used too much explosive?

Earlier, he'd reasoned that since there was only one trigger, and whoever stole his equipment might not store everything together, the blast radius needed to be larger to ensure total destruction of the missing items.

In hindsight, that logic had flaws.

Henry reflected seriously. It would've been better to install individual self-destruct mechanisms on each device—then the charge could be smaller.

Yes. Improvements for next time.

As for the human casualties... Henry consciously ignored that.

He had never considered himself kind—only lazy. People had laid out their own escape routes, washed their own necks clean. If he didn't swing the blade, it would've been an insult to himself.

Besides, self-destruct mechanisms were basic, weren't they?

Don't underestimate a nerd who grew up in the Gundam Wing era.

The fact that self-destruct systems always got finished before other functions was a terminal condition. The only thing missing was a big red skull-shaped button to make it obvious.

Still, appearances had to be maintained.

Chapter 387 - 387 — The Disappearance of Katie

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In front of others, Henry showed no cracks at all. He continued chatting idly with the lawyer—purely meaningless small talk, just to keep the atmosphere from getting awkward.

With the lawyer's help, retrieving his Cadillac from the impound lot was relatively painless.

Since it hadn't been towed for a violation, he only had to pay the storage fee. Once your car enters an impound lot, you pay—no exceptions.

For an old car like his, scratches didn't matter. As long as all four wheels were still there, it was fine.

The car was easy.

His pet was not.

Heading alone to the animal shelter, Henry learned that Katie wasn't there.

Standard shelters mostly handled small animals like cats and dogs. Even snakes, turtles, or lizards were manageable.

But Katie was a fully grown tiger, weighing over five hundred pounds. Even the largest cages at the shelter would barely allow her to turn around.

If it were merely a matter of discomfort, maybe they could've forced it. But the real reason the shelter refused was simpler: the bars weren't thick enough. An adult tiger's bite strength would tear them apart.

Los Angeles didn't exactly have apex predators strolling down the streets every day. Shelters weren't equipped to capture and house tigers.

So Katie had been transferred to the Los Angeles Zoo, temporarily housed at the large carnivore facility.

Overworked as ever, Henry had no choice but to drive to the zoo.

Fortunately, unlike an impound lot, the zoo didn't require a ticket just to talk. After explaining himself at the service booth, someone came out to escort him inside.

His guide was a young female keeper from the carnivore section.

The troublesome kind.

People who chose this line of work almost always loved animals. And being young meant their passion hadn't yet been worn down—leading to overly idealistic views and opinions.

Sure enough, Henry was "welcomed" with an interrogation the moment they met.

"Mr. Brown," the keeper said sternly, "after reviewing the records, we found that your tiger did not undergo proper quarantine procedures or clear customs legally. How do you explain that?"

She was serious—and objectively attractive. Judging from her non-uniform clothing, she also came from a reasonably well-off background.

She wasn't the type to wear excessive, unprofessional jewelry, nor did she carry impractical gear that only looked professional. Everything she used was functional—and either branded or visibly expensive.

Likely someone who'd been pampered at home, popular at school—perhaps even a cheerleader type—with no shortage of admirers.

All those factors added up to her current demeanor: proud, convinced that what she believed was absolute truth.

Simply put, in Henry's estimation, she was very likely one of those extreme animal-rights activists with a screw loose.

Yes, stereotypes and first impressions were unfair—but looking at her, Henry couldn't shake that conclusion.

Even without the lawyer present, Henry hadn't read all those law books for nothing—especially not after thoroughly studying regulations related to keeping a tiger.

"May I ask," he said calmly,

"through which legal channel did you determine that I failed to complete quarantine and customs procedures?"

"Aren't those documents something I would be required to present?"

"Or is it simply that if you can't find them, you assume they don't exist?"

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The female keeper was stunned into silence by a single sentence. Her expression froze in shock, and for a long moment she couldn't say a word.

Just as she was about to speak again, a balding, middle-aged white man with a stocky build—wearing the same uniform—walked over.

"Kylie, don't bother Mr. Brown with your routine."

Compared to an overly idealistic young person, a middle-aged white guy responsible for administrative affairs was far more smooth and worldly.

He stepped forward and immediately extended his hand.

"Mr. Brown, I'm Andy Thompson, the zoo's administrative director. The FBI has already contacted us and explained the general situation.

"As long as you sign a few documents and settle the temporary custody fees, you can take your pet with you. However—"

The balding man hesitated and glanced at him.

"—how exactly are you planning to take that tiger away?"

"Oh, I drove here. I'll just have her sit in the back seat."

Andy Thompson said awkwardly,

"Um... that's not quite what I meant."

"See, Andy! This guy didn't prepare anything at all. Why should we return a tiger to a criminal? If he ends up in prison, who's going to take care of that tiger?"

The girl shouted excitedly.

The balding man looked extremely embarrassed and said,

"The FBI just notified us that Mr. Brown was mistakenly identified as a suspect. It was all a misunderstanding.

"That's why they instructed us to allow Mr. Brown to reclaim his pet. You already knew this—why say something so rude?"

He pulled the emotional girl behind him protectively and said,

"I apologize, Mr. Brown. Kylie just started working here and isn't familiar with certain matters yet."

The intent to shield her was obvious. Henry had no desire to argue with a woman who clearly had something wrong in her head.

"Forget it. Whatever needs signing, however much it costs—bring it over. I want to head home as soon as possible. My place is a total mess and needs cleaning."

"Mr. Brown, the documents are all here."

The balding man hurriedly handed over the clipboard along with a pen.

Henry didn't even look at it, signing his name rapidly. In truth, he had already read everything—nothing more than standard liability disclaimers, plus fees for personnel support and the duration of custody.

Handing the clipboard back, Henry asked,

"How do you want payment—cash, check, or credit card?"

"Any of those are fine," the man said with a flattering smile.

Because the zoo had dispatched personnel and specialized vehicles to assist with containing the tiger, all labor costs were charged to Henry. The custody fee mainly covered meals and the manpower required to care for her.

Strictly speaking, in a wrongful case caused by FBI error, Henry—the victim—shouldn't have had to pay any of this. But considering that he was already dumping a massive problem onto someone else's head, it was better to resolve the money issue quickly.

Wasn't there a saying like that?

If money can solve it, it's not really a problem. Spending a bit of cash to smash a huge black pot onto someone else's head—satisfying!

Too lazy to haggle, Henry pulled out his checkbook and wrote a check for the full amount, even though it was a significant sum for most people.

He could've paid cash—he had more than enough on him—but using a check in this situation also served as proof of payment, preventing future disputes.

The balding man accepted the check, signed a receipt, and handed it back, smiling professionally.

"Kylie, take Mr. Brown to retrieve his pet."

"I refuse. He doesn't look like someone capable of properly caring for a dangerous animal. Just look at him—he came empty-handed."

The female keeper turned her head away in dissatisfaction, refusing to look at anyone.

"You—!"

Chapter 388 - 388 — The Tiger Is Released

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The tiger enclosure at the zoo was peaceful and serene. There were no bloody scenes, no tigers tearing into one another.

Andy Thompson gave up on instructing the stubborn woman and decided to lead the way himself.

"Mr. Brown, please follow me. The temporary holding area for large predators is this way."

Henry didn't say anything and followed. When passing by the girl, he deliberately controlled the direction of his head, refusing to even glance at her.

People like her were no different from online keyboard warriors—the more you argued, the more excited they became, like they were shooting adrenaline. Ignoring her was best. Not even worth the breath.

But although Henry intentionally ignored her, the girl seemed unwilling to let it go and followed anyway.

No one stopped her. No one bothered with her. Her legs were her own—she could walk wherever she wanted.

Entering the predator section, most of the enclosures were open-air pits without roofs, designed to make the beasts seem almost within reach rather than separated by glass.

There was only one large building—an internal multi-purpose center for zoo staff. Cub care, medical treatment, and routine checkups all took place there.

Katie, as an external tiger, should logically have been temporarily housed in one of the individual rooms inside, designated for large predators.

However, when Andy Thompson led Henry to the room that was supposed to be Katie's temporary holding area, what they saw was an empty concrete chamber.

There were no obstructions inside—certainly nothing capable of hiding a beast roughly the size of a motorcycle. The walls were painted white, which was hardly camouflage for a yellow-and-black striped animal.

The balding man stared at the empty room in disbelief. He didn't even consider the possibility that the tiger could turn invisible—he personally unlocked the iron gate and went inside to inspect it.

"Kylie, what is going on? Where's the tiger?"

All rooms suitable for housing large predators were clustered together in this area, fully visible at a glance. Yet all four rooms were just like this one—completely empty.

The female keeper said smugly,

"I put her into the tiger enclosure, together with the other tigers."

"You—what the hell are you doing? Do you think that was smart?!"

Andy Thompson exploded in rage.

"Tigers have extremely strong territorial instincts!

"The tigers in this zoo have lived together for a long time—that's why they can coexist peacefully. You let an outside tiger come into contact with them without any protection at all—what do you think is going to happen?!"

After chewing her out, the balding man immediately ran outside toward the tiger enclosure to assess the situation. If a tragedy had occurred, they would need to seal off the area immediately.

The zoo was a family destination, full of children. If they witnessed too much bloodshed, tomorrow's headlines would be a nightmare.

Passing by another zoo employee, the balding man shouted,

"Get Raven and bring the tranquilizer gun—we might need it!"

The female keeper finally realized she'd likely screwed up and hurried after him.

Henry, meanwhile, was thinking about what might happen when Katie—who hadn't seen another tiger since being brought to the U.S.—encountered her own kind.

Would she even remember basic tiger social behavior? Or would she be pinned down and beaten by the zoo's tiger group?

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The well-fed beasts each occupied their own territory, lazily basking in the sunlight. Even when visiting tourists shouted and made a racket nearby, it only prompted the tigers to take turns getting up and stretching their limbs before settling back down.

A few energetic young guys were, of course, dissatisfied with such a lackluster performance. They jeered from the sidelines, urging the tigers to put on a bloody showdown.

Among them was a Black guy who bragged loudly in front of his girl that if he were thrown into the tiger pit, he'd show everyone how to fight these tigers barehanded. The way he talked, it was as if his African ancestors had possessed him, a god of war descended to the mortal world—peerless and invincible.

Zoo staff had long grown used to this kind of behavior from visitors. Andy Thompson hurriedly counted the number of tigers and discovered that there really was one extra!

To his eyes, all tigers looked the same. The fact that he could even remember how many were supposed to be in the enclosure already proved that he was doing his job as an administrative supervisor. Recognizing individual tigers was far beyond him.

"Kelly, go get some people to help and bring Mr. Brown's pet out," he ordered.

That bald white man's instruction naturally received no positive response from the female keeper. The attractive woman tilted her head, wearing an attitude that suggested the world should bend around her.

"I already said it—this guy can't take care of a tiger. I don't want any part of this. And look at them now, getting along just fine. Letting that tiger stay in the zoo is clearly the best solution."

"You...!" Andy wanted to curse, but the words stuck in his throat.

Perhaps she had someone backing her up—someone who made an administrative supervisor powerless against her.

Henry, however, had no time to appreciate this real-life workplace drama. He walked to the edge of the tiger enclosure's railing and looked down at the group of tigers.

In truth, he spotted his own Kitty at a glance. The lazy thing clearly had no intention of moving, behaving exactly like the zoo's tigers. Had she assimilated that quickly?

"Roar!"

Henry let out a tiger's roar. No matter what they had been doing, every tiger froze and lifted its head, looking toward him.

"Kitty, time to go home," Henry called out in normal speech.

Lying atop the highest rock like a true mountain king, Kitty finally got up at her leisure. She roared a few times to either side. The rest of the tigers answered back, like underlings responding to their boss's orders.

Seeing this, Henry was genuinely surprised. How long had it even been? And she had already subdued the zoo's tiger pack?

But then again, considering the quality of meat Henry fed her, and the amount of activity she got chasing BB around, how could zoo-raised tigers compare? Even in sheer size, they were a notch smaller. Submission on sight—there was never going to be a fight.

Just then, one tiger wandered toward the edge of the pit near the wall. Kitty immediately charged with the ferocity of a tiger descending the mountain.

Tourists cried out in shock. Even the rowdy young men grew excited, cheering loudly, eager to see a tiger-on-tiger bloodbath.

To everyone's surprise, Kitty didn't bite any tiger. Just before reaching the wall, the tiger near it leapt straight up on the spot.

Using the jumping tiger as a springboard, Kitty stomped down hard—launching herself even higher.

She landed on a protruding part of the enclosure's artificial rockwork, borrowed the momentum, and kicked off again in the opposite direction.

The tiger executed a stunning forward flip—something no one would ever imagine—cleanly vaulting out of the zoo's deep-pit-style tiger enclosure.

Kitty landed right where the loudmouthed youths were gathered. The Black guy who had earlier boasted about wrestling tigers wet himself at the sight of Kitty right in front of him. He collapsed onto the ground, utterly incapable of running.

If this had been the wild, if Kitty were a truly wild tiger, she could have enjoyed an extra meal right then and there.

But Kitty had no habit of hunting live prey. Before the thought of "playing" with the two-legged creatures in front of her could even form, one sharp whistle from Henry called her over.

Ignoring the chaos erupting across the zoo as visitors panicked over a tiger escaping the enclosure, Henry rubbed Kitty's head.

"Where did you learn a move like that, you show-off?"

Chapter 389 389 — The Ones Who Were Waiting

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"Damn it!" Andy Thompson cursed. It was hard to tell whether he was swearing at that troublesome woman or at the mess unfolding in front of him.

In fact, vehicles were allowed on the internal roads of the zoo. Driving straight to the big-cat area and removing Kitty with minimal witnesses wouldn't have been difficult at all.

With her auxiliary device already removed, Kitty might not understand human language, but she could sense emotions perfectly well. Henry's mix of indifference and mild disdain only made her feel more pleased with herself.

Henry was happy. Kitty was happy.

Which meant someone else definitely wasn't.

The female keeper came charging over like a madwoman, completely disregarding the dangerous tiger right in front of her. She grabbed Henry by the sleeve.

"How could you let it get out?!"

Henry was stunned by the question. He replied blankly, "I don't have telekinesis. It jumped out on its own. It wasn't me."

"I don't care. I'm taking this tiger back into the enclosure," the keeper snapped, stirring up trouble without restraint.

But the chaos didn't stop there.

The support personnel who had been summoned earlier—armed with tranquilizer rifles—arrived on the scene. Seeing a tiger outside the enclosure, one of them immediately raised his gun and took aim.

Should Henry stop the man with the gun?

The distance was too great. To stop him in time, Henry would have to reveal his abilities. And the angle was... awkward—so awkward that Henry didn't quite want to intervene.

So, possessed by a flair for drama, Henry continued grappling back and forth with the woman. Kitty stayed right beside him, step for step, glued to her Kryptonian two-legged companion.

With tranquilizer rifles, the real danger came the moment the trigger was pulled. By the time there was any warning, the dart's speed would make it too late to do anything.

So Henry focused on the shooter's breathing.

Some less-skilled marksmen habitually hold their breath or exhale deeply right before pulling the trigger, to keep their lungs from disturbing their aim. The better the shooter, the shorter this pause.

The instant Henry sensed the man holding his breath, he let out a tiger's roar—and simultaneously pretended to be shoved, falling backward.

The female keeper, already entangled with Henry, was thrown off balance by his sudden fall.

She didn't tumble onto him in a cinematic, perfectly timed lip-to-lip moment like in the movies. In reality, she merely stumbled awkwardly.

What proved fatal was that, alerted by the roar, Kitty suddenly leapt sideways—clearing the shooter's line of fire.

The tranquilizer dart, dosed to bring down a full-grown tiger, flew straight into the keeper's ample chest.

The dart didn't have enough kinetic energy to send a person flying, but it was powerful enough to pierce tiger hide. A direct hit like that was no joke.

The girl didn't even get a chance to curse anyone out—the dart dropped her instantly.

The man who fired the shot screamed in panic, rushing over and grabbing the fallen woman. Even the bald white supervisor, Andy, finally reacted and tried to take control of the situation.

Henry kindly reminded him, "Mr. Thompson, you'd better call your medical staff first. That was a tiger-dose tranquilizer. If it hit a person and isn't treated properly, you might want to start preparing a memorial for a colleague."

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Or they could have waited until closing time and transported the tiger then, reducing the chaos to the bare minimum. As long as both sides coordinated properly, it would have been simple. Henry wasn't so unreasonable as to insist on making a huge spectacle.

But faced with that female keeper's enthusiasm, Henry no longer wanted to bother with anything. He just wanted to leave as soon as possible. Whether the zoo descended into chaos or not was none of his concern—Kitty was right beside him. With her clearing the way, moving through the crowd was effortless.

If anyone raised objections, he could just say it was approved by the FBI. The paperwork had been signed, the money paid, everything was legal and compliant. What—was he not allowed to take his own pet?

His tabby cat was clearly gentle. She hadn't bitten anyone. If people wet their pants from fright, who was to blame for that?

Amid the turmoil, Henry and Kitty—one man, one tiger—strolled out of the zoo at ease and got into Henry's car.

The zoo's chaos was quickly left behind. There was no need to dwell on distant matters—he still had to deal with his rental apartment.

Returning to Old Gary's apartment building, the flamboyant landlord gave Henry a huge hug. It wasn't sexual in the least, just the enthusiasm of an old friend. Knowing Gary's personality well, Henry accepted it without resistance this time.

"Hey, you alright, kid?" Gary asked. Then he suddenly panicked and glanced around. "You're not here to grab some stuff and run, are you? You need to leave now. The FBI practically emptied your place. If the cops come back, you won't be able to get away."

"Relax, Gary. I'm fine." Henry waved an FBI check in front of him. "The FBI admitted their mistake. This is the compensation check they issued.

"You don't seriously think they'd sign something like this willingly if they weren't in the wrong, do you? I also have copies of their written statements, but those aren't important. This check is what really matters."

Gary, suddenly very interested, took the check and examined it closely. "I've never seen an FBI check before. This is a first. But... seven hundred grand? What exactly is this compensating for?"

"I heard they hauled off quite a lot of stuff from my place. But since all of it conveniently disappeared, this is the compensation for those items."

"What?! Do you realize they practically stripped your apartment bare?"

Henry frowned. "That bad?" In truth, Henry had already checked privately and knew exactly what the situation was. But when acting, one had to commit fully—maintaining logical consistency in one's behavior was already second nature to him.

Besides, out with the old, in with the new. Using a pile of obsolete junk to screw over thieves and federal parasites alike could be considered a good use of resources. Expecting someone else to foot the bill on top of that would have been excessive.

Gary said with lingering fear, "Honestly, even burglars wouldn't have been that thorough. Charlize and I helped clean up a bit. Speaking of her—she's been really worried about you these past few days."

Henry chuckled and was about to crack a joke when a shrill cry sounded behind him.

"Henry!"

A leopard-like pounce followed, and suddenly a body slammed into him, nearly knocking the Kryptonian over.

Two legs wrapped around his waist, arms clutching his head tightly to her chest. Charlize Theron's emotional outburst was hard for outsiders to comprehend.

Imagine it: just as her life had begun to show a glimmer of hope, the man she relied on had been driven away by the FBI—rumor had it they'd even issued a kill-on-sight order. For her, it was nothing short of the sky falling, the end of the world.

Nearly hysterical, she shouted, "What happened? I don't know anything! No one would tell me anything—not the FBI, not the police. I didn't even know where to ask questions!"

As Henry comforted the koala-like girl clinging to him, he couldn't help but sigh inwardly—youth really was something else.

If this were the fully realized future Charlize, she'd be wrapped in icy detachment, keeping others at arm's length. She'd never display emotions so openly.

Henry knew Hollywood well enough to understand how many child stars with promising futures had been destroyed by hidden darkness.

Rebellion was the mild outcome. Some became mentally impaired or morbidly obese. Some lost their lives entirely. Beneath the glamorous spotlights of Hollywood lurked unimaginable shadows.

Chapter 390 - 390 — Invalidated Evidence

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With damage of this scale and such heavy loss of life, there was no way the matter could be quietly brushed aside. Moreover, it involved a multinational corporation, elevating it directly to the federal level. The LAPD didn't even have standing to intervene—everything was immediately taken over by the FBI.

As one of the parties directly involved at the explosion site, Sony America's president, Mickey Schulhof, naturally couldn't just leave at will. Still, given his status, he was treated with considerable courtesy.

In hindsight, that courtesy turned out to be a blessing. Escorting him to a quiet place not only kept troublesome reporters at bay, but also ensured that his unrestrained outbursts weren't overheard by too many people.

Charlize Theron, coming from South Africa, had no star-family resources, no old-money background. She had fought alone to carve out her path.

That was why, in the future, she would appear on screen with such cold detachment—not just because it suited her roles, but because her environment had shaped her.

Without that armor, her fate might have been even worse than those child stars saddled with toxic parents. It wouldn't have been surprising if she'd faded into obscurity before ever reaching the summit.

Henry held the emotionally overwhelmed girl, comforting her while pondering her future.

Nearby, her agent, J.J. Harris, watched the scene with thoughts similar to Henry's.

Charlize Theron was undeniably talented—but romance was the biggest variable in a woman's life. And now she'd crossed paths with such a... special man.

With J.J. Harris's seasoned eye for people, even she couldn't quite define Henry.

Should Charlize keep her distance from him—or draw closer?

Would he lift her higher, helping her climb to greater heights? Or would he drag her down, plunging together into an abyss?

In J.J. Harris's long career, she had rarely encountered someone who left her so conflicted.

While this side was a bittersweet sort of happiness, the situation elsewhere was bleak beyond words.

Henry had thought he was merely destroying some small handmade Kryptonian equipment. Unfortunately, the charge he used turned out to be a bit excessive.

At Sony America's Los Angeles building, an entire floor had been blown open—walls breached on all sides. Not a single window remained intact; every pane of glass was shattered.

Because his main goal was to melt and destroy equipment, Henry hadn't used standard explosives.

In fact, as an ordinary civilian, he couldn't have obtained real explosives anyway. The destructive device he designed was a homemade compound, concocted using his knowledge of chemistry—one of the reasons it slipped past inspections.

That same reason also led to a miscalculation in explosive power. The only consolation was that the blast was stronger rather than weaker. At least his target—the handmade equipment—was completely destroyed.

The researchers working on that equipment, and Sony America's Los Angeles building itself, were far less fortunate.

Henry's primary agent was thermite, chosen specifically to melt equipment. Thermite was extremely effective against metal—and living beings—but far less effective against reinforced concrete.

The result of Henry's handiwork was devastating: an entire floor of researchers wiped out, equipment destroyed. Worse still, many of the researchers had been flown in from Japan and had arrived that very day—only to be greeted by such warm hospitality the moment they stepped into the lab.

Thankfully, the building didn't collapse. Otherwise, the scale of the disaster would have been even greater.

Even so, this marked the greatest loss Sony America had suffered since its establishment.

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The moment Owen Davis, head of the FBI's Los Angeles field office, met Mickey Schulhof, the latter blurted out his first sentence:

"Arrest Henry Brown, that damn sour radish! He's the one who blew up my company and got so many people killed!"

"Mr. Schulhof, please choose your words carefully," Owen Davis replied coolly. "Without concrete evidence, statements like that can be construed as defamation."

"How can there be no evidence? I got that equipment from you people—that equipment is what exploded and caused me such massive losses! What kind of job are you doing? You didn't even detect explosives and just handed it over to me like that!"

"Mr. Schulhof!" Owen Davis raised his voice. "The FBI has committed no illegal acts. If you insist on pushing this narrative, then we will have no choice but to open an investigation into you for making false accusations. I believe that is something neither of us wants to see."

Having exchanged initial pleasantries, Owen Davis decided on the spot that there was no point continuing to engage with this old white man. He summoned a young agent and instructed him:

"You'll take Mr. Schulhof's statement—strictly regarding what he personally witnessed at the explosion site. Nothing extra. Don't say more, don't write more. Do you understand what I mean?"

"Yes, sir," the young man replied, wearing a confident leave-it-to-me expression.

Did Owen Davis feel reassured?

Today's entire mess had been created by his own troublesome subordinates.

What was even more tragic was that whenever the most troublesome person left, another one would immediately rise to take their place. The worries never decreased—there would always be a new worst offender.

For example, the agent now walking toward him, who had already been promoted to first place on Owen's internal troublemaker list.

"Sir," the seasoned agent who had previously sat in on Henry Brown's interrogation and personally escorted that walking disaster out of the building stepped forward to greet him.

Even though Owen wanted to sigh deeply—or strangle the man—he maintained his superior's demeanor. "Any results from the scene investigation?"

The veteran agent spoke smugly. "The fire investigation unit still needs to file their report, but I took a look myself. Based on the blast center, debris patterns, and staff testimony, the explosion did originate from the batch of equipment we seized from Henry Brown's residence.

"This time he's finished. With casualties and losses on this scale, branding him a terrorist wouldn't be a stretch. He'd be looking at a hundred or two hundred years in prison, minimum."

"Oh?" Owen Davis replied dryly. "And then all of us go to prison with him for abuse of authority. I'd probably get more than ten years. You wouldn't escape either—five to seven years at least."

The seasoned agent frowned. "So... this can't be made to work?"

Owen Davis said coldly, "Don't forget what we just did today. We just convinced Mr. Brown—who was wrongfully detained due to 'administrative error'—to sign a settlement agreement.

"At the same time, he waived any claims regarding the missing seized property. We even issued compensation and officially defined the status of that equipment. You know what that means."

"It means the chain of association between that equipment and Henry Brown was broken, from his possession to Sony's lab."

"Exactly!" Owen snapped. "Any first-year law student knows this is grounds for reasonable doubt. When seized property is lost or stolen, how do you prove no one tampered with it before assigning liability to the original owner?"

"But we all know that equipment came from his place. No one else could've done this."

Owen Davis sneered. "You haven't been in this line of work for just one day. You should know that once evidence passes through an illegal third party, outside notarized custody, it becomes invalid.

"No one can prove that the unauthorized third party didn't alter or contaminate the evidence—unless you trace the entire chain and verify every step. And tell me, do you dare?"

"Especially when there's nothing here that can't be fabricated, and all the physical evidence has been burned to slag, making forensic analysis nearly impossible. Under these conditions, it's extremely difficult to directly link the bomb to Henry Brown.

"If we hadn't already finalized the conclusion regarding the loss of the seized property, we might have been able to designate Sony's lab as an authorized forensic facility.

"Then—from seizure, to transfer, to examination—all through legal channels. If that were the case, Henry Brown would never escape. But now? With your professional knowledge, do you really think this is still feasible?"

Even this normally sharp agent showed hesitation. "What if we claim another 'administrative error'—retract the earlier conclusion about the missing evidence?"

"You think Stark Industries' legal team would just let that slide?" Owen shot back. "Let you stitch together this case with lies? If this gets dug into, everyone in the LA office goes down with it. Do you think the others would agree?"

"But we know it was him. Otherwise, how could this happen right after he signed the agreement?"

Chapter 391 391 — Intelligence Exchange

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At the bar counter, far from the bartender, two men sat shoulder to shoulder—one Black, one white. They didn't look at each other, seemingly unrelated, yet they were clearly in conversation.

"Fury, explain this to me," complained Owen Davis, Assistant Director in Charge of the FBI's Los Angeles Field Office. "This time, I got screwed hard by the mess you people caused."

Owen Davis replied icily, "Yes, he's the prime suspect. So what? I'll ask you one thing—how did he detonate the bomb? The timing was too perfect.

"He'd just left our office."

"Maybe he went and set it off immediately after leaving?"

"I already checked with his attorney," Owen said. "He was with the lawyer the entire time, on the way to the impound lot. At no point did he leave the lawyer's sight. Don't even mention breaking into Sony's lab."

"The phone! He specifically mentioned a mobile phone—maybe he used that to trigger it!"

"The lawyer confirmed he didn't make any calls. And how exactly would a phone detonate a bomb?"

At this point in time, using mobile phones to remotely trigger explosives wasn't common practice at all. Owen Davis hadn't even considered that angle.

Mobile phones were expensive, subscriber records were clear, and only after cheap prepaid phones became widespread did such detonation methods become common among bombers.

Even if they investigated the phone, Henry could account for it. The detonator had used a custom circuit board and cloned chips—once everything was melted down, there was no way to prove that phone had ever rung inside Sony's building.

As for telecom logs and switching station records, Henry had made sure to delete those afterward. Years of honing hacking skills were meant for moments exactly like this.

"Then maybe it was a timed bomb," the agent ventured. "That's why he was so quick to agree to compensation—he just wanted to get the agreement signed."

Owen Davis let out a snort. "Do you have any idea how many uncertainties there are in that theory?"

"And from the beginning, the reason we wanted to resolve the wrongful detention through a settlement was because he'd clawed his way up from the bottom.

"His cautious, conflict-averse personality matched our expectations. Even with a lawyer present, he didn't want prolonged contact with us. After he signed the agreement, who wasn't laughing at him back in the office?"

"And now everyone feels differently? Besides..."

Seeing his superior hesitate mid-sentence, the agent pressed, "Besides what?"

"Think back carefully. We weren't the ones who seized the equipment initially. We took over another 'FBI' unit's case.

"What happened during the gap before we arrived—can you say with absolute certainty that Henry Brown was the one who did this?"

"Then what about Mickey Schulhof? How do we explain this to him?"

"Explain?" Owen Davis let out another nasal scoff. "If he can't deal with the Japanese side, then he's nothing.

"Does he think he can take it out on us? And if Sony has any sense, keeping this quiet is the smartest move."

The seasoned agent was confused at first, then suddenly understood. "A commercial dispute?"

"Exactly. Compared to lawsuits over corporate espionage, a few dead people barely matter," Owen Davis replied.

What he was truly considering, however, was this:

How is Stark going to respond?

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Nick Fury—the Black Nick Fury, who had narrowly avoided getting a mouthful of Molotov cocktail—looked just as helpless. "How was I supposed to know you'd move that fast? Find the slightest excuse and charge straight in. That kind of reckless momentum is something you'd expect from fresh recruits on their first battlefield."

"Who knew you'd pull an 'administrative error' and flip the whole situation on its head," Owen shot back. "If I didn't know exactly how many hairs you've got on your ass, I'd be wondering whether you dug this pit on purpose just to watch me fall in."

"Fuck!" Fury snapped. "We're not that close. And do you know what happened to me because of that goddamn 'administrative error'? I almost got cleaned up as a traitor. You guys just ended up with a headache—I nearly lost my life."

Owen Davis was startled. "Shit. What the hell happened on your end? Tell me whatever you can. I need to watch out for the same trick."

Fury figured his old war buddy had a point and chose his words carefully. "I can't go into too much detail because of classification rules.

"What I can tell you is this: the enemy found a way to impersonate our personnel and issued non-compliant orders, which led us into illegal operations and a cascade of mistakes. Fortunately, things were resolved in the end."

What Fury didn't say was that the Skrulls had already left with Carol Danvers—aboard the cruiser left behind by the Kree scientist—setting out in search of a new home.

To be honest, Fury had wanted to keep that cruiser. But it was in space. Without Skrull assistance, he couldn't even get off the planet, let alone figure out how to operate a spacecraft far beyond Earth's technological level—much less research what was inside it.

Before leaving, the Skrulls had complained that most of the research data onboard—including encyclopedic knowledge brought from their homeworld—had been looted by the Kree when they briefly seized the ship.

Fortunately, the navigation system and the research facilities were separated, which was why the cruiser could still fly.

That at least gave Fury a small measure of comfort. No one even considered the possibility that the data might have been taken by a third party, and the blame went neatly onto the Kree.

The only vehicle on Earth capable of leaving the atmosphere was the modified quadjet—but that craft had already been registered under S.H.I.E.L.D. and couldn't be used without authorization.

Besides, Carol Danvers had asked for the ship specifically to escort the Skrulls away. How could Fury possibly refuse?

Even though the Skrulls had left, Fury couldn't guarantee that all of them were gone.

He had no means of identifying Skrulls disguised as humans. All he could do was keep his guard up—and share that intelligence with his old friend in the FBI.

Owen Davis was no stranger to strange situations. His first instinctive question was, "Mutants?"

Fury shook his head. "No. It's rare enough to find mutants with even similar abilities. This time, there were quite a few enemies—most of them are dead now—but I can't confirm whether any are still hiding."

Though not entirely accurate—since "leaving" was being framed as "killed"—they were all off Earth either way. Fury was deliberately phrasing it as a warning.

"The Red Empire?" Owen asked. "Didn't they collapse years ago?"

"The regime collapsed," Fury replied smoothly, "but the people are still around." The guess was wrong, but Fury went along with it. They were old enemies anyway—no harm in slinging some mud their way.

"True..." Owen said, sounding subdued.

He tapped his fingers on the counter, thinking, then suddenly asked, "Fury, do you think it's possible those people planted a bomb inside that batch of information equipment? Why would they target Henry Brown?"

"Possible. No idea," Fury answered tersely, draining his bourbon and signaling the bartender for another.

The Skrulls wanting to blow up Henry Brown?

According to Barbara Morse's later report, even after Henry Brown left Maria Rambeau's house, the Skrulls continued targeted actions against him.

Chapter 392 392 — The Best Timing

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"Even so, that still doesn't prove those devices contained Stark Industries' proprietary technology," Nick Fury said, still unconvinced.

Owen Davis explained, "But the devices included cameras and similar equipment, so it's not entirely unrelated. And what's happening behind the scenes isn't just Stark versus Sony.

"The narrative of a U.S.–Japan clash plays very well with certain groups. Sony can't find a single ally—forget lobbyists, they can't even get a foot in the door to negotiate with Stark.

"The old-money circles are just waiting for Sony to show a crack. The moment an opportunity appears, they'll swarm like hyenas. In that situation, even if the evidence isn't airtight, it won't stop a judge from ruling in Stark's favor."

Fury commented dryly, "So Sony's best chance is to frame themselves as the victims and blur the line of corporate espionage. They didn't send anyone to persuade you to overturn the 'lost evidence' conclusion?"

"Oh, of course they did. Why wouldn't they?" Owen snorted. "Their plan was simple—if they could label the transfer of the equipment into their hands as a terrorist act

From Fury's perspective, more attempts at framing or assassination wouldn't have been surprising. Planting a bomb in Henry Brown's home was entirely plausible.

But why the Skrulls would insist on killing a Kryptonian—that was beyond him.

It clearly wasn't about Earthly grudges. As for cosmic grudges... Fury wouldn't even know who to ask anymore.

"Could it be competitors coveting digital imaging technology?" Owen Davis speculated from his own professional angle.

"Rich people doing shady things?" Fury replied, following the line. "Nothing surprising about that."

Poor people, after all, could only commit so many crimes—grab a gun, fire a bullet, one life gone.

But elaborate, bizarre schemes? Those took money, time, and leisure. Especially when things escalated into commercial warfare.

The reason such acts didn't make headlines was simple: the wealthy always had PR budgets scrubbing the mess.

But intelligence and law enforcement agencies saw these struggles clearly—and sometimes even played supporting roles in them.

They were the kind of affairs that challenged the limits of imagination, not morality.

Sensing that the questions were digging deeper and edging toward dangerous territory, Fury changed tactics and countered, "What about you? How are you wrapping this up?"

Owen Davis answered bluntly, "Mickey Schulhof is finished."

"Oh?" Fury asked. "You didn't consider giving him a hand? Selling him a favor?"

Draining his own drink and ordering another, Owen said, "Tony Stark stepped in. He needed to protect his people—and he wanted to take a huge bite out of Sony while he was at it.

"And Sony themselves had no intention of protecting Schulhof. From what our international affairs guys say, Sony's new president this year—Nobuyuki Idei—has wanted to replace him for a long time.

"It was only because the former president, now CEO, Norio Ohga—the Japanese executive who appointed him—kept backing him that he managed to hold onto the position.

"For the sake of his career, Schulhof took this gamble. He wanted to steal Stark Industries' technology to secure his seat. But he screwed it up. And we all know what comes next."

Fury asked curiously, "Even with everything blown to pieces, you can still build a case?"

"Yes," Owen replied. "The debris recovered from inside Sony America's LA building nails them. Those custom-built devices have a very distinctive look—comparing them with the records and photos from when we seized them, they can be positively identified as the same items."

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by Henry Brown, then corporate espionage wouldn't even enter the discussion."

"And you didn't agree," Fury said. "Afraid of getting dragged down with them? Compared to abuse-of-power charges, negligence in evidence handling carries a lighter penalty. Am I right?"

Owen Davis shook his head, his tone righteous. "If today's explosion had injured or killed innocent civilians, then for the sake of justice and principle, even if we had to bear legal responsibility, we'd still put the terrorist behind bars.

"But this explosion was a showdown between the wealthy. As for the dead—calling them innocent isn't entirely accurate. I can say with certainty that not a single one of my subordinates wants to be buried alongside Sony.

"We've already signed off on the 'lost evidence' ruling. I'll take the administrative punishment. From that point on, this matter has nothing to do with us. At most, we launch an internal review and reflect on our failures. As for who actually masterminded the bombing—does anyone really care anymore?"

Even if a formal investigation into the explosion were launched, Owen Davis was prepared to find a few petty criminals to step forward and confess to stealing items from the FBI evidence room.

He had no intention of sacrificing his career—or going to prison—just to cover for Sony or the greed of his troublesome subordinates.

Fury sighed helplessly. "True enough. Once Stark Industries' lawyers step in, all the public will care about is how much Sony has to pay."

"Exactly," Owen Davis said, first with a hint of melancholy, then firmly. "That's all they can care about." He drained his whiskey in one go.

He slipped a bill under the glass and stood up. "I'm heading out. I've got mountains of paperwork to deal with, and I still have to write a self-criticism report.

"Damn it—back in the military, I could dump this stuff on the clerks. Why is it that here, I have to do it all myself with no one to help?"

Fury didn't turn his head or move his eyes, only raised his glass slightly in a mock toast. "Think of it this way—those subordinates of yours, following your orders, nearly buried you alive. You'd still trust them with all the paperwork?"

"Fuck!" Owen Davis cursed as he turned and walked away, tossing back one last line. "See you around."

Fury didn't reply. He simply sat there quietly, drinking his favorite bourbon.

Before long, another man in a black suit took the seat Owen Davis had vacated. He had a square face, broad ears, thinning hair, and a shiny forehead—a young man. "Sir."

"Just call me Fury, Coulson."

"Yes, sir," the young man said. He ordered a whiskey from the bartender and adopted the same calm, unobtrusive posture. "Director Davis has already left."

"I know. I'm not worried about him," Fury said. "I asked you here today just to have a drink."

"Thank you, sir."

"You look like you've got a lot of questions. Go ahead—ask."

After taking a sip, Phil Coulson asked, "The Sony building incident... was it really the Skrulls framing Henry Brown?"

"It's possible. Just possible," Fury replied. "From a timing perspective, the Skrulls did have the opportunity. But what does your intuition tell you? Who do you think did it?" He was testing the newcomer.

Phil Coulson thought for a while, then shook his head. "I can roughly infer the Skrulls' behavioral patterns. They're infiltration specialists—spies who exploit every available tool and relationship. But I don't know Henry Brown well."

"Cautious. That's smart," Fury said. "And that's exactly what I appreciate about you. You think for yourself instead of blindly following orders."

"...Sir, do you think disobeying orders is a good thing?"

"No, of course not. But people who only know how to obey orders belong in the military. Our organization needs more flexible minds—otherwise we'll just repeat the same mistakes as before."

Such an unreserved compliment made Coulson, who hadn't been out of the Army for long, feel embarrassed. He quickly changed the subject. "Sir, then who do you think the mastermind was?"

"Henry Brown," Fury answered instantly, without hesitation.

Chapter 393 393 — A Confidential Warning

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In the afternoon, beneath the Stark family's grand villa on Malibu Beach.

A bikini party was in full swing on the sand. A group of young, beautiful girls played and laughed in the chilly November sea breeze.

Their enthusiasm and liveliness didn't quite look like genuine enjoyment, though—it was more as if they were trying to shake off the cold through movement.

The owner of this stretch of beach was Tony Stark, who had become the darling of the news media in less than a year.

Endless gossip headlines filled the papers. On any day the paparazzi didn't catch Tony Stark on a date with some beauty, that was considered real news in the industry.

And then came floods of text-only rumor pieces—Tony Stark hospitalized with syphilis, Tony Stark undergoing treatment for impotence, Tony Stark... As if a headline only needed the words "Tony Stark" in it to be publishable.

It could be said that, aside from his own employees, Tony Stark had found a rather unconventional way to support an entire workforce.

Yet the man lounging on a beach chair today wasn't like he was in summer—no parasol, no beach shorts, no bare upper body. Instead, he was dressed casually, basking directly in the sunlight and enjoying the rare warmth.

Henry, who had been invited to this bikini party, was dressed in a sharp, formal suit. He looked nothing like someone there to have fun.

Earlier, he had gone to Sheep Cave Valley Laboratory to retrieve the last remaining piece of hand-built tech in his possession—Kitty's tiger translator. It was something he'd removed in advance, back when he was preparing to get himself arrested.

Being called back halfway by this guy naturally put him in a foul mood.

"But hasn't he been constantly framed by the Skrulls?" Coulson asked. "Even though we don't know why."

Fury analyzed calmly. "Henry Brown is full of mysteries. For example, his life before the age of twenty practically doesn't exist.

"A competent spy, even if they can't fabricate a perfect background, will at least fill in something to prove their assumed identity existed.

"Someone like Henry Brown—who leaves nothing at all—is utterly unqualified by that standard. Of course, now we know why. Because he isn't even human.

"The fact that he earned Tony Stark's trust speaks volumes about his intelligence. But he's not some bookish nerd. This man is shrewd.

"A shrewd man like that, instead of leveraging a legal team to tear into the FBI over its mistakes, simply signed the agreement, took the compensation—and then Sony blew up right afterward.

"If you tell me he had nothing to do with it, would you believe it? The only thing I can't figure out is how he triggered the bomb. That's the key to whether he can be directly linked to the incident."

Coulson was shocked. "But... that's not what you said to Director Davis just now."

"Because he doesn't need that explanation," Fury said flatly. "No one wants to go after Henry Brown. Otherwise, do you think he wouldn't have figured out who the prime suspect was?

"You don't seriously believe someone promoted to Assistant Director in Charge lacks basic judgment, do you?"

"No, sir, that's not what I meant," Coulson said quickly. After a moment's thought, he added, "Then should we consider Henry Brown a dangerous individual?"

Fury shook his head. "Does he warrant attention? Absolutely. Is he dangerous? Not necessarily. In this case, he simply found the best possible point to strike back—and he struck back."

"Even if innocents were harmed?"

"Are thieves innocent?" Fury countered.

Coulson tilted his head, thought for a moment, then said hesitantly, "Ah... when you put it that way, maybe not so innocent after all."

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But watching Tony Stark shiver as he drank cocktails in the cold sea wind, Henry couldn't help laughing. "Committing to the act all the way through, huh. Young Master Stark, with that level of professionalism—are you aiming for an Oscar for Best Actor?"

"Achoo!" After sneezing and finally realizing how stupid he looked, Tony Stark said to the people nearby, "Happy, get the girls inside the villa. I already thought this was a bad idea. Why didn't any of you stop me?"

The loyal head of security just shrugged. He knew full well that offering advice wasn't his role, so he treated the young master's grumbling as everyday background noise.

Setting the ill-timed cocktail down on a side table, Tony Stark stood up and headed toward the hillside. His villa sat atop the slope, built right along the edge of a cliff.

Its design wasn't the minimalist, modern style of his future home, but rather something older—like a nineteenth-century manor left behind by history. Perhaps it would be renovated someday.

Whenever Tony Stark came to the West Coast, he stayed here. Whether it was for the one-of-a-kind ocean view or some other random reason, Henry had no idea.

As they climbed uphill, Henry noticed that Tony Stark moved with an easy, brisk stride. Was it youth—or did this guy actually keep up with fitness?

Thinking of scenes from the movies—Tony sparring with Happy Hogan, or swinging a hammer nonstop in a cave while building his armor—his physical condition, while nowhere near those super-soldiers injected with all sorts of serums, was clearly above average.

There were even people online speculating that his Iron Man suits must contain some kind of inertial dampeners or other black-tech to help him withstand G-forces.

But had anyone considered that this guy's physical conditioning might simply be at fighter pilot—or even astronaut—levels? Sure, dampeners existed, but not to some absurd sci-fi extent.

Truly worthy of a rich family's heir.

Even in dress shoes, Henry easily kept pace with his boss. After all, he was still eating from Stark's bowl.

Since this entire area was private estate land, security inside wasn't especially tight. At least, when Tony moved, he had Happy lead the guards to keep their distance, deliberately leaving space for a private conversation with Henry.

"First thing," Tony said. "About that call you made to me earlier—don't tell me anything about it. My aunt asked me to pass on a message. The reason they didn't make you sign a nondisclosure agreement is because some information isn't sealed by fines or prison time.

"Those people believe only the dead keep secrets. Even someone like you—who's hard to kill—is no exception. They'll always find a way. Do you understand what I'm saying?"

"I understand," Henry replied. To be warned only now was actually a bit surprising to him. Still, it was very much the style of secret intelligence agencies. He asked, "Who's this 'aunt' you're talking about?"

"Peggy Carter. A hard-as-nails grandma who fought in World War II."

From the way Tony Stark ground his teeth when he said it, it was obvious he'd been spanked plenty by that woman as a kid. Henry didn't tease him about it, though. Instead, he said, "I'm actually surprised you're not curious about any of that."

"Why would I be curious about that kind of thing?"

Tony's counterquestion left Henry momentarily speechless.

Thinking seriously about Tony Stark's personality, it became clear that he was extremely goal-oriented—once he identified a problem, he solved it. His scientific progress followed the same pattern: find the issue, fix the issue.

He might overdo it and create new problems along the way, but he didn't have an especially strong curiosity drive. He wasn't much like a traditional scientist—his temperament was closer to that of an engineer.

Even his investigation into S.H.I.E.L.D. only happened because Nick Fury and others appeared directly in front of him, and because it might involve himself.

Chapter 394 - 394 — The Seat Is Different Now

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Tony Stark really wanted to curse, but couldn't figure out what to curse about. After holding it in for a long while, he finally squeezed out a single question:

"Why?"

Because I wanted to test your attitude—your stance included.

Of course, Henry didn't say what he was actually thinking. Instead, he replied:

"I was never a good person to begin with. I just want to reduce trouble. Different situations require different responses; different environments demand different attitudes.

"It's like walking on the beach—barefoot, wearing flip-flops, or wearing leather shoes. Do you think your mindset and attitude would be the same? Even if you don't consider the value of the shoes, how you feel in that moment will be different.

"In the past, I had nothing, so I wasn't afraid of people taking advantage of me—there wasn't much to take anyway. But now you've put me up on a pedestal and turned me into a target. If I kept the same attitude as before, anyone could treat me like a cake and casually scoop out a bite. I'd be annoyed to death.

"What you did today—wasn't it for the exact same reason? Or do you think I should just rely on thick skin and brute force to tank everything? If that's the case, remember to write it into the contract next time."

Whether he had figured it out—or simply given up—Tony Stark no longer fixated on his earlier emotions. Instead, he changed the subject and joked:

"I just think it's a shame. Used you as bait, and all I caught were yellow-skinned monkeys. Looks like you're not very good bait."

Henry laughed. "The blue-blooded sharks are still beneath the surface. If you want to hook the real target fish, you need patience."

Henry wasn't angry at all about being used as bait—this outcome had been anticipated from the start.

Or rather, the moment he jumped from being a penniless nobody to becoming the executive president of a long-established movie studio, extra attention was inevitable. And where there was attention, there would naturally be trials and temptations.

That was exactly why Henry hadn't wanted to accept Tony Stark's job offer in the first place. It was impossible to take all the benefits while avoiding all the trouble.

But once he agreed, Henry intended to play his role properly. He just hadn't rushed headlong down a suicidal path, partly because the ones who bit the bait early were always small fry. The real target fish were still lurking below the surface.

This time, it was the Skrulls bursting onto the scene and acting without reason that exposed cracks, giving others a chance to take advantage.

Tony Stark quickly set aside his pointless sympathy and said, "Forget it," then turned and continued walking uphill.

"Oh, just like that?" Henry teased. "I thought you might drag me to the police station. Looks like when your own interests are involved, Young Master Stark's

about:blank

Otherwise, if he wanted to know what his father had done back in the day, Edwin Jarvis was still alive. As the head of Stark Industries, all Tony needed was to open his mouth and ask. Did anyone really think that loyal old butler could keep secrets from him?

Yet this young master didn't even know that his own father was a founding member of S.H.I.E.L.D., and he still managed to live indulgently until the age of thirty-eight.

That wasn't just a lack of curiosity—it was outright indifference.

As for remembering the name of the girl he slept with yesterday, that was hardly worth testing him on. It was no different from asking what he'd had for dinner a week ago.

Tony Stark's lack of interest was a good thing for Henry. At least he didn't have to think about spinning lies or deciding how much truth to reveal.

After all, "Kryptonians" played no small role in this whole affair—even if Henry himself had been dragged onstage against his will.

So Henry asked out of genuine curiosity, "If you're not interested in that, then what did you call me here for?"

"The explosion. What was that about?"

Henry replied without hesitation, "Misjudged the charge."

Tony Stark stopped in his tracks, turned around, and stared at him for a long moment.

Henry put on an innocent expression and shrugged. "It's not like I asked them to take the bomb from my house and then not give it back. I use it as an alarm clock—what, that's not allowed? Besides, it can't even blow me up."

moral standards aren't quite so firm either."

Tony Stark squinted at him and turned back with a strange look.

"You really want to go to prison and pick up soap? Or do you think thieves stealing a bomb and blowing themselves up somehow makes it the bomb owner's fault?"

"It's like the castle doctrine. If someone enters private property without the owner's consent, the homeowner is allowed to use force to defend themselves, and the consequences carry no legal liability or prosecution.

"The one who commits the first wrongdoing bears all the consequences. That's a core principle of Anglo-American law. If bomb makers had to bear joint liability for every misuse, do you think executing arms dealers a hundred times over would even be enough to atone?"

Alright—classic Western logic. Henry couldn't quite keep up with that line of thinking. He still instinctively leaned toward splitting blame evenly, trying to balance everything.

And besides, wasn't this guy a weapons dealer himself? A perfect example of how one's position determines one's perspective.

Henry still wanted to complain, but he held back. Continuing would really start to sound like he was eager to send himself to jail. That kind of enthusiasm was unnecessary.

As they continued uphill, Tony Stark said:

"Anyway, what Sony stole was technology Stark Pictures is developing. Whether your private information devices contained related technical data or not doesn't matter. They showed intent—so they deserve to die for it.

"Compared to the explosion case, which involves too many variables to identify a mastermind, a corporate espionage case is judged by results. As long as Sony can't provide lawful proof that they obtained those devices legitimately, it's illegal acquisition, and the espionage charge stands.

"The lawyers Obadiah picked are veterans at this kind of lawsuit. As long as you cooperate properly, Sony will get played alive."

Henry followed along casually and said, "I've been cooperative enough, haven't I? Whatever the lawyers tell me to do, I do it. But everything got blown up. Whether there were technical files inside—does my word alone really count?"

"But there's also no way to prove there weren't," Tony Stark said smugly, hanging his sunglasses back on his head. "Convincing the judge is the lawyers' job. If someone can't do it, I'll just replace them with someone who can."

Right—rich people logic. Henry didn't even have the energy to complain anymore. The lawyers were the real protagonists here; he just needed to provide support.

Tony Stark didn't notice Henry's expression and continued:

"When the settlement comes through, I don't want a single cent. Lawyer fees and necessary taxes will be deducted first—whatever's left is yours. I just want to win the case. No problem with that, right?"

"That's something you should discuss with the lawyers," Henry replied. "I'll just cooperate as best I can. But if this lawsuit drags on for three to five years, you won't exactly be showing off Stark-style dominance."

"Relax. Sony's headquarters in Japan has already surrendered. They're using this opportunity to dump Mickey Schulhof. Right now, it's just a matter of ironing out

terms. The settlement's set at two hundred million dollars."

"Two—" Henry choked, momentarily unable to speak.

In the U.S., lawyers' fees were usually either flat-rate or contingency-based. Under the latter, no other fees were charged, and all litigation expenses were covered by the lawyers themselves—but the cut was typically a hefty 20% to 35%.

As for taxes, it depended on how much of the settlement was compensatory versus punitive. Only punitive damages—like emotional distress—were taxable. Compensation for property loss was not.

So from that \$200 million settlement, roughly a third to a quarter would actually be kept.

...Thinking of how hard Fixer had worked to scam a crime boss, risking being double-crossed, only to earn less than a fraction of this take, Henry suddenly felt life was meaningless.

Even if he used Kryptonian powers to rob banks nonstop from the West Coast to the East Coast, he still might not reach that number.

So this was the world of the rich.

This was the profit of those who made the rules.

"As for the conditions they proposed," Tony Stark continued, "I want to hear your opinion."

Chapter 395 395 — Sony’s Conditions

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"Alright, alright, stop there. I think I more or less get what you mean," Tony Stark said. But after a moment, he added, "Still... is two hundred million dollars really that much?"

Henry was left speechless. After a pause, he could only say,

"Young Master Stark, why don't you ask that same question to literally anyone else and see whether they try to beat you to death."

"It's just a number." Tony waved it off. "Fine, forget that. I said I wanted your opinion."

"Ask away," Henry replied. "Though I don't think I'll have anything useful to say."

Tony Stark naturally ignored that weak counterattack and went straight to the point.

"Sony wants Stark Pictures to join their digital alliance. What do you think?"

Henry answered without hesitation:

"Is that really necessary? The HD digital VCR consortium they set up a few years ago defined standards for consumer camcorders. What we're doing is film digitization—it's a completely different track.

"Besides, our primary market is Hollywood. Stark Pictures itself is part of Hollywood. Partnering with Sony is basically opening another gate into Hollywood and giving them a foothold.

"Sure, Sony can provide a world-class market. But Stark Industries' strategic focus is the military-industrial complex, isn't it? Are you planning to enter the home audiovisual appliance market too?

"I'm not interested in playing that big of a game. And if the two sides cooperate while Stark Pictures can't commit enough commercial power, then sooner or later we'll be reduced to Sony's manufacturing plant or R&D lab. If you're fine with that, I have no objections."

As he said this, Henry realized something.

This wasn't something Tony Stark couldn't have thought through—he simply couldn't ignore the idea once it occurred to him.

So when Tony said he wanted Henry's "opinion," he wasn't really asking about the pros and cons.

He was just asking whether Henry wanted to play along.

As if confirming Henry's realization, Tony asked again,

"You're not interested?"

Henry replied calmly:

"Like the example I gave earlier. For me, a car just needs four wheels and the ability to run once you fuel it. If you put a fighter jet in front of me, I'll admire it—but I won't want to fly it."

If I want speed, I'll just fly myself.

A Kryptonian could afford that kind of pride.

"I understand," Tony Stark said, not pressing the issue further.

This man's purpose was clear—he stayed in Hollywood for his girlfriend. Beyond money, what other benefit would there be in playing an even bigger game?

But there was no response from behind him.

He turned around and saw a face utterly devoid of enthusiasm. Tony Stark immediately understood and mocked him:

"Don't tell me this amount scared you. I thought you were the type who wouldn't be moved by any amount of money."

Regaining his composure, Henry replied helplessly to Tony's teasing:

"It's like someone who thinks a car just needs four wheels and the ability to run—seeing a sports car doesn't move them much.

"But if what zooms past next is a fighter jet flying at several Mach? I think anyone would be stunned."

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They were nearing the villa now. A group of secretaries—men and women, young and old—were waiting at the entrance.

Henry still couldn't tell whether Pepper Potts, the woman who might one day become Mrs. Stark, was among them.

Tony gave the group instructions as he walked past.

"Move the beach party inside the house. Get things ready."

With that, he entered the villa and headed upstairs.

At gatherings like this, the first floor was public space—anywhere not explicitly closed off was fair game. The second floor and above were private living quarters; unless specifically invited, it would be rude to go up.

Henry, of course, had no intention of following Tony Stark upstairs. From both an etiquette standpoint and an optics standpoint, that would have been strange.

He stayed on the first floor instead, taking the chance to look around this villa—his first visit—while carefully staying out of the way of the event staff setting things up.

This was another Stark property, and Henry had been to one before: the Beverly Hills villa where Katharine Hepburn had once stayed. That one had been old-fashioned in style, very much in line with the tastes of early-20th-century elites.

The villa in front of him now was also an estate-style property, but the interior décor was... well, hard to describe.

There were antiques, yes—but far more of the furnishings reflected an engineer's obsession with functionality.

Worse, the changes clearly hadn't been guided by a coherent design philosophy. The result was an interior that felt like two incompatible styles dragging each other down.

Forget aesthetics—Henry felt uncomfortable just looking at it.

No wonder this place would later be torn down and replaced with a villa better suited to its owner's taste.

If Henry had to name the best house he'd ever seen, it would still be the Mellon family's Oak Springs Farm. The gardens, carefully designed by the lady of the house, Rachel Lambert, and the consistent taste throughout the interior, radiated understated excellence.

They didn't need gold toilets or gaudy jewelry to scream wealth. Everything in the house was something the old-money couple actually used, and not a single item was cheap or boring.

What left the deepest impression on Henry was a mug Mrs. Lambert loved to use. It had a picture of kittens chasing butterflies among flowers.

He'd assumed it was some famous artist's work, the kind of mug that sold for tens of thousands of dollars—something befitting the Mellon family.

It turned out she'd bought it at a market for five dollars, and she'd been using it for over ten years.

That wasn't thrift—it was taste. Her judgment wasn't determined by price. She wasn't like the kind of rich people who only cared whether something was expensive, not whether it was good.

As for Tony Stark, his current state of mind probably matched this house perfectly. Old and new colliding, not in harmony, but in confusion. That was likely why he could live in a place that felt so awkward.

Chattering voices filled the air as the girls from the beach—now changed into light, breezy dresses—entered the villa. The warmth brought color back to their cheeks.

Everyone looked relieved. Finally, they didn't have to act like idiots playing on a beach in the middle of winter.

Most of them couldn't read the meaning of this house at all. They clustered around the food and bar, looking for warmth through calories or alcohol.

A smaller group gathered near the DJ, asking about the upcoming music so they could plan how to perform.

There were still plenty of girls aiming to become Mrs. Stark.

Not long after, Tony Stark reappeared at the party, now dressed casually.

Happy Hogan popped up from who knew where, carrying a silver tray with a glass dome. Beneath it was a cocktail he'd just mixed himself, delivered to Tony at precisely the right moment.

Finding the music too tame, Tony Stark raised his glass and shouted,

"Music! Hard liquor! Ladies, let's move!"

With the boss's command, the atmosphere instantly transformed. The DJ switched to trendy electronic dance music.

The thunderous rhythm made everyone's body move instinctively. The girls danced wildly, each trying to showcase herself and win the young master's attention.

It was chaotic—but strangely orderly. No one deliberately shoved toward Tony Stark. Everyone just danced confidently where they stood.

Chapter 396 396 — The Christmas Banquet

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Christmas of 1995 was Henry's first Christmas and New Year holiday since joining Stark Pictures.

As if celebrating a resounding victory, the head of the Stark Group himself—Tony Stark—hosted a uniquely extravagant Christmas banquet.

As the CEO of Stark Pictures, Henry should have been one of the stars of the evening. But as a high-level salaried employee, he was naturally no match for Tony Stark's brilliance.

On this rare occasion, the young master—usually surrounded by beautiful women—had rendered the invited actresses little more than spectators standing on the periphery, sighing in resignation.

Yet Tony showed no impatience at being encircled by a group of balding old men instead of beauties. On the contrary, he seemed to be enjoying it immensely, basking in their flattery.

Henry's companion that evening was Charlize Theron, who normally wouldn't have qualified to attend an event of this caliber.

The actresses invited were either the biggest stars of the era or highly anticipated rising talents:

Nicole Kidman, Sandra Bullock, Julia Roberts, Demi Moore, Michelle Pfeiffer, Uma Thurman, Jodie Foster, Meg Ryan... and many others.

It could be said that anyone who received an invitation from Stark Pictures showed up—after all, Tony Stark's name was on it.

The same went for the male stars, only in even greater numbers. Some had even flown back from overseas vacations just to attend.

Beyond actors, famous directors, producers, and agents were all gathered here as well. Charlize Theron owed her presence entirely to Henry.

Even so, these A-list stars and top directors still weren't qualified to approach Tony Stark directly.

Because standing beside him were the CEOs and presidents of Hollywood's Big Eight studios—and even board members from their parent corporations. These were the true top figures of the industry, at least on the surface.

With Tony present, Henry didn't even count as a backup option. The crowd formed concentric circles around Tony Stark, all waiting for a chance to speak to him.

Reduced to a nobody, Henry was more than happy to linger on the edge of the banquet. Charlize, meanwhile, took a lap with her agent, J.J. Harris, then came back to catch her breath.

Smiling, Henry gestured toward the core of the crowd and asked,

"Doesn't that look like a kid proudly showing off to a bunch of adults? And everyone else is just nodding along obediently."

Charlize looked a little awkward. "Um... do you really have to put it that way?"

"I just find it funny," Henry replied. "The real old-money families didn't show up, so Tony can only flaunt his presence in front of this second-tier crowd. So childish—tsk, tsk."

In front of true old money, Hollywood's big shots were little more than stewards and servants. The Big Eight studios, for instance, almost all had parent companies or conglomerates behind them.

The people who truly matched those old-money families in status would be someone like Henry Brown, CEO of Stark Pictures. Tony Stark stepping in personally was nothing less than dimensionality reduction.

Even Henry was impressed by this bizarre spectacle.

As Tony Stark passed by Henry, he raised his glass in invitation.

"Don't be a buzzkill—move a little! Relax, I won't tell your girl about what happened today."

With that, he plunged into the crowd of women.

Listening to a line that practically screamed "there's no silver here", Henry felt... oddly reassured.

Yeah right. I totally believe you.

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So Henry wasn't surprised at all to find himself marginalized, given his lack of connections at the very top.

And he didn't mind it either. It let him observe the various states of this elite circle at leisure, which he found endlessly entertaining.

Tony Stark, meanwhile, was flamboyantly displaying his frivolity and self-satisfaction. He even rejected others' attempts to approach him in openly rude ways.

With that very attitude, Tony created apparent weaknesses in others' eyes—while simultaneously protecting himself.

...Or perhaps this was simply who he really was. To Henry, it didn't look like an act at all.

Had he completely let himself go?

Charlize Theron, however, didn't share Henry's relaxed mood. She'd barely caught her breath when J.J. Harris, ever the dutiful agent, was already pulling her back into the crowd to meet important people.

"Oh, Henry, you're free too? Perfect—come with me," J.J. Harris said, drafting him without ceremony.

Henry pointed at himself in surprise. "Me too? Are you sure?"

J.J. Harris replied,

"You control Stark Pictures' investment projects, don't you? To those big-name directors, that makes you exactly the person they want to curry favor with.

"Come along—this is helping your girl. Don't expect me to play the role of an old nanny, managing everything for you two while you do nothing."

At that point, Henry had no choice but to comply. "Alright, alright, I'm coming."

But before he could follow, a Stark Pictures staff member approached and said,

"Mr. Brown, we need to start preparing for the presentation."

"Already?" Henry said in surprise, glancing at his watch.

Charlize shot a pleading look at her agent. J.J. Harris immediately understood and said,

"Go take care of your work, Mr. Brown. That's more important. Leave your girl to me."

Henry wasn't the type to dump trouble on others lightly. He said solemnly,

"I'll leave everything to you, ma'am,"

before following the staff member away.

When Henry reappeared in the hotel banquet hall, he was accompanied by a large group of Stark Pictures engineers.

They set up a projector and a large screen in an open area of the hall, then wheeled in a computer about the size of a small refrigerator, connecting it to the projector.

Aside from the screen, none of the equipment was commercially available. Most of the components were supplied by Stark Industries and assembled into experimental units by Stark Pictures' engineers.

Henry supervised the entire process, ensuring nothing went wrong. Once everything was ready, a black-and-white film appeared on the screen.

A Bill of Divorcement—the 1932 film starring John Barrymore and Katharine Hepburn.

This was the first film Katharine Hepburn had made in collaboration with Stark Pictures. Its success led to a long-term contract with her and marked the beginning of her complicated entanglement with Howard Stark.

In that era, actors weren't freelancers as they are today—they were more like studio employees, assigned roles by the company.

As the saying goes, insiders watch the craft, outsiders watch the spectacle.

Most people present were naturally familiar with the film. What Henry projected were Katharine Hepburn's highlight scenes. Even those who hadn't seen the movie at least recognized the actress.

At first glance, it looked like Stark Pictures was simply showcasing a prized work from its own catalog at the banquet.

But for those most concerned with film technology—directors, producers, and the like—something immediately felt... off.

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Chapter 397 397 — Digital Restoration

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The fact that the projector could display accurate colors under normal indoor lighting was impressive, but not the most important part—at least not in terms of cinema itself.

What truly stood out was the image quality.

Although the image wasn't being shown on a full cinema-sized screen, the projection surface was still far larger than any commercially available television.

And yet, even at that scale, there was almost no noticeable loss of detail.

Eyebrows. The corners of the eyes. Fingertips. The subtle facial expressions and delicate body language that are vital to film—each was rendered clearly. The fine details of the set design were even more striking.

Most people present weren't old enough to have seen this classic in theaters when it was originally released. They had only watched it on VHS or through television movie channels.

The details lost on a TV screen were now fully restored. For those fluent in cinematic language, the very same shots now conveyed far more information. How could the directors not be astonished?

More importantly, the projector in use was not a cinema-grade film projector.

Which meant this was not being projected from film stock.

Traditional cinema projectors use bulbs that flicker at a specific frequency to match the movement of film reels—they are not continuously lit.

In other words, the bulb lights up only when a frame aligns properly in front of it, projecting that single frame onto the screen. During the reel's movement between frames, the bulb switches off.

This happens extremely quickly—24 frames per second—fast enough for the human eye to perceive smooth motion. That's why the light appears continuous.

But flickering light and steady illumination are fundamentally different. Laypeople might not detect it—but professionals certainly could.

That was how the directors present confirmed that what they were watching was not film projection.

If it wasn't film—and given Stark Pictures' recent technological developments—then everyone knew exactly what this demonstration was.

Several directors deeply interested in film technology—Steven Spielberg, James Cameron, and others—gathered around Henry, firing off questions about technical specifications and the restoration process.

Henry held nothing back, engaging them earnestly in discussion.

Then a voice cut in from behind:

"How old was Katharine when she made this film?"

Under normal circumstances, interrupting like that would have been rude. But no one dared challenge the woman who had spoken. The crowd instinctively stepped aside.

Even those who didn't recognize her were quietly informed by others nearby. At this level, everyone was perceptive enough to retreat and observe.

Henry turned around and saw a couple he had met only once before.

"Mr. Mellon. Mrs. Lambert. It's been a long time."

Though he mentioned only their surnames, that was enough. Everyone present immediately recognized them:

Paul Mellon and Rachel Lambert Mellon—members of one of America's most prominent old-money families.

Henry had once met them while representing Audrey Hepburn, introduced by Hubert de Givenchy. It was they who had lent their private jet to transport Hepburn back to Switzerland for recovery after surgery.

Paul Mellon extended his hand first.

"Congratulations, Mr. Brown, on your achievements today. I hope you won't mind that my wife and I arrived uninvited."

Henry quickly shook his hand.

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"It's an honor for Stark Pictures to have you here. We're delighted—how could we possibly mind?"

At most American events—unless they are highly private affairs—there are certain individuals who simply don't need invitations.

The event staff had done well not to bar guests of this stature at the door. This wasn't a military base requiring clearance.

Though perhaps they had failed in not informing the host beforehand—leaving Henry momentarily caught off guard.

Then another voice entered, edged with rivalry.

Tony Stark approached, saying:

"The most valuable resource humanity has is intelligence. Keeping someone like him at your side as if he were a bulletproof vest—that's the real waste.

"That's like sending Einstein or Oppenheimer to the front lines as infantry. Though Hemingway might've managed—once he's had a few drinks, he sounds like he could single-handedly punch through a division."

Paul Mellon replied, soft yet firm:

"The usual approach to a startup is to invest modestly and observe the outcome. Only if it proves its value does one absorb it into the larger enterprise.

"Handing an established company directly to someone unproven—that's not conventional business practice. Betting everything on a man without results to show for himself carries as much risk as drilling for oil at random."

Tony didn't yield.

"That's the old-school 'let results speak' theory. I'm young. Acting a little crazy comes with the territory.

"If I'd done everything by the book, Stark Industries would've been dismantled by now."

Sensing sparks nearing the fuse, Henry quickly intervened.

"Mrs. Lambert—you asked earlier about this film.

"It was released by Stark Pictures in 1932. Katharine Hepburn was 24 at the time. It was her first Hollywood film after transitioning from stage success.

"Our engineering team has used the latest computer technology to digitally restore original film reels. We've corrected damage from mold and decay and preserved every detail from the original 35mm stock."

Rachel Lambert gently looped her arm through Henry's—careful not to block the projector light—as they stepped closer to the screen.

"Sometimes I envy them," she said softly. "To preserve their most beautiful years, remembered forever."

Henry smiled.

"Madam, I remember well the contributions you and Mr. Mellon have made to preserving culture.

"From da Vinci to Van Gogh, Monet to Cézanne, to Mark Rothko—these artists may have become names in history.

"But without patrons and preservers like you, their works might have faded into dust, forgotten in some obscure corner of time.

"Film is the same.

"If these reels simply sit in storage, they'll decay. The so-called classics would survive only as memories—no one would ever see them again.

"This same technology can be applied to photographs and negatives—and even go further. For example..."

Henry snapped his fingers.

"Gentlemen—play the colorized version."

Immediately, engineers began adjusting settings at the computer.

The directors and producers watching closely noticed an interface on the projection screen—strikingly similar to Windows 95.

That confirmed it beyond doubt: the projector was connected to a computer. There was no hidden film projector anywhere.

The second segment began.

The same scene as before—but now in color.

The figures came alive. Gasps spread through the room.

These were Hepburn's highlight moments. She seemed to command the entire frame—her skin luminous on the large screen, radiating the vitality of her most beautiful years.

And in that moment, cinema itself felt reborn.l

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Chapter 398 - 398 — The Aftermath of Old Affairs

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Rachel Lambert was born in 1910—three years younger than Katharine Hepburn. The two women could be considered of the same generation.

And yet now, someone she could practically call "big sister" had returned to her enviable twenties—radiant and luminous on the screen.

How could she not feel a trace of envy?

Even if it existed only in film, not in reality.

Rachel covered her mouth in disbelief.

"Can something like this truly be done?"

Henry answered honestly.

"The limits of computer technology lie in imagination and hardware capability. Whether it's color fading due to aging, or a film that was originally shot in black and white—

"Subtle differences in grayscale correspond to different colors. We only need to analyze those tonal variations and restore the original hues.

"But the amount of data involved is enormous. It's beyond the processing power of commercially available home computers. This result was only possible thanks to Stark Industries' supercomputers."

Technically, ordinary machines could do it too—if one were willing to let a single photograph render for days on end. But there was no need to dive into that level of detail. Mrs. Lambert wasn't an engineer.

"Oh... I see."

Rachel's expression dimmed slightly.

Noticing her disappointment, Henry quickly added:

"If you have old photographs or films you'd like restored, we can handle them as a special project."

"Really?" Rachel brightened, then hesitated. "What if there's only a single photograph left? No negative?"

Henry smiled.

"It must be a precious memory. If you're concerned, you can bring the original to Stark Pictures. If there aren't too many items, scanning and archiving would only take a day.

"You can take the originals back immediately afterward. The digital restoration timeline would depend on your requirements and the volume involved. Would that work?"

Henry was smoothly building goodwill when Tony Stark's voice cut in.

"Hey, hey. I built the supercomputer. Shouldn't you ask me before volunteering it? What am I, a grandfather clock you only acknowledge when it strikes the hour?"

Rachel turned to Tony with wide, pleading eyes.

"Is that not allowed?"

Even Tony Stark wasn't immune to that look.

"Alright, alright—don't look at me like that. Go talk to Mr. 'Women's Best Friend' here. He'll solve everything."

Henry let out an awkward chuckle at his new title.

Paul Mellon, meanwhile, had not been idle.

"Mr. Brown," he asked calmly, "what would such a supercomputer cost?"

Henry answered without overthinking.

"The one Stark Pictures uses was custom-built by Stark Industries. Many components were bespoke, so pricing is difficult to calculate precisely.

"But based on current requirements for image processing, a suitable supercomputer would likely fall within the ten to thirty million dollar range. Since we're not competing in performance rankings, we don't need to pursue absolute top-tier specifications."

"Thirty million dollars? That's not expensive at all," Paul said lightly, glancing at his wife with understated extravagance. "Shall we build one ourselves?"

Even Tony Stark was briefly stunned.

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This wasn't the future world's richest man yet—just a newly minted heir still finding his footing and feeling triumphant over squeezing Sony.

Henry quickly stepped in.

"Mr. Mellon, if it's only for this purpose, please allow us to handle it. Supercomputers come with significant maintenance costs and specialized staff salaries.

"If you have concerns, we can draft a formal contract outlining all terms clearly to avoid future disputes."

Paul nodded mildly.

"That would be acceptable."

One round of subtle sparring—decided.

The young future Iron Man still couldn't quite overpower America's old blue-blood aristocracy.

Sensing tension, Rachel changed the subject.

"Henry, we actually came to see you for a reason."

"Oh? How may I help?" Henry asked directly. He knew people like this did not attend parties for idle conversation.

"Do you remember," Rachel said gently, "mentioning at our home that the painting Lady with an Ermine might be authentic?"

Henry nodded.

"I do. Though that was three years ago. In hindsight, I may have been presumptuous. If I was mistaken, please forgive youthful indiscretion."

Rachel patted his hand reassuringly.

"There's nothing to forgive. After your remark, we gathered those who claimed to possess the original for authentication.

"That process wasn't simple. Museums were involved. It took until mid-this year to organize a formal evaluation.

"We invited over a dozen trusted experts. Their collective conclusion was that the painting you identified most closely matched the characteristics of the original."

Henry blinked.

"Most closely matched'? What kind of phrasing is that?"

Rachel sighed.

"The prevalence of forgeries is beyond imagination. Even museum pieces have been exposed as copies. Sometimes the original artist created multiple nearly identical works.

"Without clear records, how can later generations determine authenticity? In many cases, if no obvious flaws exist, the judgment becomes a matter of which piece best aligns with the era's characteristics."

"That's... complicated," Henry admitted.

"It is."

Rachel accepted a wrapped bundle from an attendant and carefully unfolded it.

Inside lay the famed image—Lady with an Ermine.

Henry instinctively refrained from taking it.

"This is...?"

Rachel explained calmly.

"The authenticated original has been donated to the National Gallery in Washington. Borrowed museum pieces were returned according to contract.

"But the private collectors declined to reclaim their forgeries. Those remain with us.

"This entire authentication process began because of your comment. Without it, the true masterpiece might have remained hung among imitations on our wall.

"My husband and I agreed to gift one of the replicas to you. It is not the original—but do not underestimate it. Experts believe it to be a seventeenth or eighteenth-century copy. An antique in its own right."

Henry finally accepted the painting, visibly surprised.

"May I truly accept this?"

"Of course," Paul Mellon replied. "Your insight prevented us from making a foolish mistake. I only hope you won't use this reward unwisely."

Henry answered sincerely.

"Rest assured, Mr. Mellon. I will preserve it carefully."

Publicly accepting it also meant he could never pass it off as authentic—but that had never been his intention.

Some gifts weren't about value.

They were about doors quietly opening.p

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Chapter 399 - 399 — The Gift of Old Money

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The Mellons gifting a Da Vinci replica to the CEO of Stark Pictures didn't linger long in the media headlines.

But in certain circles, it was a very significant event.

Take the person closest at hand—Tony Stark. He wasn't the least bit envious.

Instead, he went on a tirade about the three great masters of the Renaissance, then marched straight through medieval religious art and all the way to Picasso's abstract period, dismissing the entire history of art as overrated fluff.

After all, he was an engineer.

Show him an eleven-meter, full-scale Gundam model, and maybe he'd raise an eyebrow.

But was this whole affair nothing but benefits?

Not quite.

Henry only learned later that the authentication gathering hosted by the Mellons had caused a considerable stir in the art world.

Art and antiques revolve around two things: the seller's integrity and the buyer's discernment. Once money and goods have changed hands, no one admits fault afterward.

Yet in a field rife with forgeries, the Mellons had gathered every claimant to the original painting—including museums—and staged what amounted to an arena match judged by expert appraisers.

It was like buying a collection of supercars—not to race them on a track, but to smash them head-on in pairs to test structural rigidity.

Once something was publicly declared fake, wouldn't the holder resent the original seller?

Whether the seller had knowingly committed fraud or had simply lacked expertise, the damage to reputation was fatal. In high-end art dealing, reputation is everything.

The disreputable forgery dealers might fleece amateurs. But the truly large transactions happen among insiders dealing in "authentic" masterpieces.

For those dealers, reputation is life itself.

Selling a fake—or even appearing incompetent—can be ruinous.

That was why the Mellons' authentication event made enemies.

The elderly couple themselves hardly cared about resentment. But breaking unwritten rules inevitably caused inconvenience.

They were avid collectors and patrons behind major museums. Even subtle resentment—receiving information later than others, being placed further back in negotiation queues—could become troublesome.

Unless, of course, that resentment was redirected.

And that was precisely what gifting out one of the replicas accomplished.

Why had the authentication event happened?

Because someone said the real painting was here.

That someone was Henry.

He only pieced this together much later. No one explained it directly—there were only hints. Following those threads, he assembled his own version of the "truth."

Was it entirely accurate? He couldn't be sure.

But one thing was certain:

Gifts from old money are never simple.

Fortunately, Henry wasn't part of the art world. His wealth and status didn't qualify him for that circle anyway. So if he had to shoulder some of the redirected resentment, so be it.

He'd still gained a high-quality antique replica.

There was another ripple effect—this time in Henry's own domain.

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Helping Rachel Lambert Mellon restore her old photographs and films had effectively given Stark Pictures a powerful wave of publicity.

It was said that Mrs. Mellon now proudly showed off her digitally restored color photographs of her youth to anyone who visited. Oak Spring Farm reportedly displayed enlarged restored portraits of the couple in their younger days.

In their social circle, that kind of word-of-mouth endorsement carried tremendous weight.

Henry had no choice but to establish a dedicated external digital restoration department within Stark Pictures—specifically to serve old-money clients.

Otherwise, he would have been overwhelmed by "well-meaning inquiries" from wealthy patrons with ulterior motives.

Since the service was unique, profits were staggering. Competitors in the information technology field tried to enter digital restoration as well.

But because Stark Pictures' most advanced techniques hadn't been made public, their inferior results nearly got them sued by bargain-hunting aristocrats.

The clientele could afford anything. And Henry had never intended to price the service cheaply for mass accessibility.

The new restoration department was rapidly becoming a major revenue pillar for Stark Pictures.

So who truly gained more from this exchange with the Mellons?

Hard to say.

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With old money leading the way, Stark Pictures' film-grade digital imaging technology entered wider awareness.

While UHD quality comparable to 35mm film remained limited by hardware constraints, higher-than-television digital standards were increasingly embraced—especially by cost-conscious production teams.

At the same time, Stark Pictures continued digitizing and restoring its classic film library.

Henry even pushed the distribution department to partner with an old theater, funding projection upgrades in exchange for exclusive screenings of digitally restored classics.

The result?

Nostalgic audiences filled seats to relive memories. Younger cinephiles discovered legendary films on the big screen for the first time.

Though ticket revenue alone couldn't offset restoration costs, the initiative functioned as a powerful demonstration of capability.

Film fans began urging other studios to restore their own classics.

Hollywood's eight major studios approached Stark Pictures for talks.

But once the financial sheets were laid bare, they accepted Henry's argument:

The timing wasn't right.

Until home entertainment technology advanced further—until HD televisions and Blu-ray emerged—restoration wouldn't be truly profitable.

At present, only sentiment could justify such losses.

And when they saw the supercomputer platform required for the work?

Nine out of ten retreated immediately.

The tenth asked about acquisition and maintenance costs—and fled just as fast.

Only the reckless Tony Stark, at the helm of Stark Industries, would indulge such extravagance.

Yet few outsiders noticed the deeper strategy:

Tony was using Stark Pictures' demanding technical needs to aggressively push Stark Industries' technological advancement.

It was like a second round of competition between him and Henry after building the supercomputer.

Whoever failed to keep up would lose.

As for Moore's Law?

Tony Stark had just kicked it straight into the trash.

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Chapter 400 400 — The Film Outlook for 1996

In 1996, Charlize Theron already had two films scheduled for release.

One was That Thing You Do!, a musical comedy directed for the first time by Tom Hanks, set for an October release.

The other was a Jerry Bruckheimer production, The Rock, scheduled for June.

In another universe, Charlize had never appeared in The Rock. That counted as one of the butterfly effects brought about by Henry.

However, The Rock was very much a male-led film. Charlize played Sean Connery's daughter—few scenes, but with speaking lines.

By comparison, she had more screen time in That Thing You Do!, though still in a supporting role. But in terms of production scale and box office potential, the two films weren't remotely comparable.

Yet in early 1996, before either film had premiered, everything was still uncertain.

Who knew whether a producer might take a pair of scissors and cut someone's scenes entirely? That sort of thing was commonplace in Hollywood.

Or the box office could flip expectations upside down—flops becoming hits, hits becoming flops.

After all, this was a world with mutants and superheroes. Real-life explosions and superhuman battles already provided plenty of spectacle. Would audiences still flock to theaters seeking thrills?

There was no precise mathematical formula to predict box office results. No one knew how this universe would play out.

Charlize didn't let the fact that she had two speaking supporting roles go to her head.

The production budgets of her two films were \$26 million and \$75 million respectively—solid big-budget projects.

Compared to Henry's own acting past, she had already surpassed him by far. He had only ever appeared in one major production—the \$10-million Universal Soldier.

That said, Hollywood inflation in recent years had been climbing fast. Film budgets were skyrocketing like fireworks.

Charlize's opportunities owed a great deal to her agent, J.J. Harris. Without her information network, even with Henry as CEO of Stark Pictures, they wouldn't have known where to apply pressure.

During the filming of The Rock, the production coincided with Henry's troubles—when he was framed by the Skrulls.

The crew had reportedly considered cutting Charlize's role.

In the end, it was Sean Connery himself who intervened, ensuring she remained in the film despite her limited screen time.

After Henry cleared his name, he and Charlize treated Connery to dinner in gratitude. That was when they learned why the veteran actor had looked after her.

Connery had worked with Audrey Hepburn in 1976's Robin and Marian. And when he learned Charlize was in the same cast, Katharine Hepburn had personally called him, asking him to take care of the girl.

Connections among the older generation of film legends often bore fruit in unexpected ways.

Connery, a former Royal Navy serviceman who had once served aboard an aircraft carrier before retiring due to health issues, was the sort of man who honored his word.

And once Henry's "crime" was proven to be a misunderstanding, Connery's defense not only saved Charlize's role but also spared the production from potentially offending Stark Pictures.

In a way, he earned goodwill on both sides.

As for Bruckheimer, a producer of his stature certainly had the standing to ignore Stark Pictures' opinions.

But filmmaking is a collaborative art. No one deliberately seeks enemies. If one can gain a friend without commercial conflict, why choose to make an adversary?

This little episode became a surprising advantage.

When J.J. Harris pitched Charlize for new roles, she now had more to talk about.

For newcomers, having no buzz is the worst fate—whether good or bad buzz hardly matters.

Though the spotlight during the incident was on Henry Brown, Charlize benefited indirectly. And since it ended positively, it became a win-win story.

Of course, she couldn't go around name-dropping Sean Connery recklessly.

With J.J. Harris guiding her, she handled the balance perfectly—memorable without being obnoxious.

Armed with that slight edge, Charlize continued attending auditions with her agent, pursuing the next opportunity.

On a practical note, she had already received her salary payments, easing her financial pressure considerably.

As a minor supporting actress without box-office bonuses, her compensation was straightforward—thanks to guild protections.

She was still an employee in the grand scheme of things, but no longer suffocating under financial strain.

Henry wanted to help her land stronger projects.

But the truth was that most prime opportunities were controlled by the major studios. Only what they passed on trickled down to smaller companies.

Stark Pictures, at this point, was a second-tier studio in Hollywood.

Even though Henry demanded that every proposal and script first pass across his desk for secondary review, he still couldn't rely on his pre-transmigration memories to "pick up bargains."

Even with a superbrain to sift through memories of past blockbusters, he had to admit he wasn't a walking Hollywood encyclopedia.

Sometimes project titles bore no resemblance to their eventual release names. Scripts were revised beyond recognition. Trying to predict future success from early drafts was about as reliable as consulting a temple oracle.

At this point in the mid-1990s, the only truly reliable piece of foreknowledge he possessed was the iceberg-destroying juggernaut:

Titanic.

But although filming hadn't officially begun, pre-production had already started the previous year.

And the film's success was inseparable from its tyrannical director, James Cameron. Interfering with that production was nearly impossible.

The only real opportunity might arise if the production ran out of funds—if 20th Century Fox hesitated to keep pouring money into the bottomless pit, and Cameron was forced to seek outside investors.

At Stark Pictures' Christmas party, Henry had already used the digital imaging showcase as an opportunity to chat with Cameron, subtly implying that if funding ever fell short, he could come knocking.

But how things would ultimately unfold—

That wasn't something even a Kryptonian could decide.

The human heart was never something that could be forced.

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Chapter 401 401 — A Visitor from Bollywood

And squeezing in his own secret work in whatever hours remained—

A rather unusual visitor arrived.

Karan Patel.

An utterly unremarkable name.

He was Indian. Very Indian. Also very overweight.

His profession?

Butler.

Yes. That kind of vibe.

Karan Patel had come as the representative of a major Bollywood film dynasty—the Ginger family—and their production company, to discuss cooperation with Stark Pictures regarding film-grade digital imaging technology.

In heavily curry-accented English, he launched into an endless introduction about the Ginger family’s history and status in Bollywood.

After World War II, when India gained independence and entered its most turbulent era, the family that became a pillar in the hearts of the Indian people was not the Gandhis, nor some Brahmin lineage—

—but the Ginger family.

From the great-grandfather onward, every generation had produced a film star. Even the current head of the family, "Ginger," remained one of Bollywood's top celebrities.

"Ginger" was both their surname and the title used by each generation's patriarch. No need to remember individual names—just call him Ginger.

Rather like Hubert de Givenchy, Audrey Hepburn's close friend. His brand had become so famous that he preferred people to call him "Givenchy" rather than by his personal name—even close friends.

Incidentally, the Ginger family had maintained five generations of single male heirs. Their film company supported a vast network of actors and staff. The films they produced had become cultural symbols for the Indian people, inspiring them through hardship and sustaining hope for national revival.

In short, Ginger Films represented not only Bollywood, but post-independence India itself.

Naturally, such a company pursued the latest film technology, seeking superior visual language to remain at the forefront of cinema—

...within India, at least.

They absorbed Hong Kong martial arts, Hollywood sci-fi, European humanism, East Asian cinematic aesthetics—added curry flavor—and turned it into their own distinct style.

Technologically, they followed the same philosophy: always the first Indian company to experiment with foreign innovations, leading others in the industry to follow.

Recently, the biggest technical news in Hollywood had been Stark Pictures' digital cinema technology.

Ordinary audiences cared about stars and box office.

Industry professionals—especially those focused on technology—were watching Stark Pictures closely.

The news had reached Bollywood.

Thus, Karan Patel had come to see Henry Brown.

First problem: how was a Kryptonian supposed to maintain inner respiration while being slowly suffocated by curry fumes?

Second problem:

Five generations using the same name. A household name. A superstar.

No one in India found that suspicious?

Was this like that old internet joke—where levels of myopia are classified as mild, moderate, severe... and Indian?

Chapter 402 402 — Traces of the Eternals

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Henry looked at the silent, overweight butler before him and added,

"If Mr. Ginger is willing, whether he comes to the United States or I travel to India, either is fine.

"If you continue to represent him, our cooperation can still be discussed. But business is business—you'll need to speak with our commercial department manager. If the terms are appropriate, they'll forward it to me for a final decision.

"There's no need to answer immediately, Mr. Patel. You may return and consult with Mr. Ginger. If the matter isn't suitable for discussion over the phone, I can wait

Henry raised a hand to stop the torrent of words.

"Mr. Patel. Let me clarify. You're proposing that Stark Pictures bring its latest technology to India, manufacturing digital cameras and projectors locally. Is that correct?"

Patel leaned forward enthusiastically.

"Yes, Mr. Brown! Consider this—India's population is approximately 960 million this year. The second largest in the world!

"If every person bought one digital camera, that's 960 million units! If every household required a digital projector, that's 200 to 300 million units!

"Think about the scale! White American dollars would flow like a fountain! You would only need to bend down slightly to pick up money! Can you find such opportunity anywhere else? No! Impossible! Only India offers this!"

Henry began to understand why, decades later, Indian executives would dominate American tech leadership.

They could talk.

And somehow make it sound convincing.

Listening to Patel, Henry almost believed him himself.

Was this man some future telecom-scam mastermind sent back in time?

Then again, in a culture where cosmology casually included kalpas, universes destroyed in Shiva's breath, and Brahma's days lasting billions of years—

Perhaps verbal exaggeration was simply a national skill.

Henry raised both hands this time.

"Mr. Patel. Cooperation isn't impossible. But there are additional matters I wish to discuss directly with Mr. Ginger himself."

Patel's head tilted side to side in unmistakable Indian fashion.

"Mr. Brown, please rest assured. I am Mr. Ginger's full representative. Any conditions can be decided through me."

Henry paused.

Then made a decision.

"Even if the matter concerns the Eternals?"

Patel froze—just a fraction too long.

"...Mr. Brown, I'm afraid I don't understand that word."

Bad acting.

Henry didn't enjoy playing prophet.

But if the opponent truly was an Eternal—

And if the Ginger family's public identity was a long-standing celebrity cover—

Then perhaps it was worth the gamble.

He raised a finger dramatically.

"There's another magic word," Henry said calmly.

"Krypton."

"Whether you understand it or not, please pass along this message."

"The Kryptonian wishes to speak with the Eternal."

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until you've flown back to India and obtained his response."

Before departing, Karan Patel had naturally conducted his research on "Henry Brown." He had assumed he could easily handle this young white executive—talk circles around him and leave him dazzled.

But now, face to face, he realized things were not as he had imagined.

There was an inexplicable confidence about Henry, as if everything were already within his grasp—calm, unhurried.

And it wasn't the empty arrogance of youth, the kind that deflates like a punctured balloon once exposed. Nor was it bluster masking insecurity.

Henry was different.

Patel found that unsettling.

In truth, Henry hadn't been in a position of power for long—barely a year. But his confidence didn't come from status.

It came from the strength he kept hidden.

That was why, in the eyes of other tycoons, Henry Brown was just an upstart who had risen too quickly from nothing.

And yet he moved among them with ease, impossible to take advantage of.

After all, for a Kryptonian, not using his fists was already the height of mercy.

If someone gained a small advantage, Henry simply didn't care.

But if someone tried to seize what wasn't theirs through force?

Then it became a matter of skill—and survival.

If truly pushed, Henry had even considered forging a pair of knuckle-dusters.

One engraved with "Morality."

The other with "Reason."

Then he would ask the other party: would they prefer to be persuaded by virtue—or by logic?

Patel might not understand where Henry's confidence came from, but he knew one thing clearly:

He was not the one qualified to speak on matters involving that secret.

"Mr. Brown," Patel finally said, "I will relay your request to Mr. Ginger word for word. However, what response he gives, I cannot say here. I hope you understand."

"Of course," Henry replied, standing to escort him out. He extended a hand in goodwill. "Let's hope for a result satisfactory to all parties."

Patel shook it solemnly.

"As you say."

After his secretary escorted the Indian butler away, Henry found himself pondering a question:

How many Eternals were actually on Earth?

In the film version, there were ten. But across the universe, other Eternals existed. They were, fundamentally, precision bio-machines created by the Celestials.

In the comics, however, over a hundred Eternals had appeared. Though over the long ages some had perished, some gone mad and fought among themselves, their numbers had dwindled.

In the film, the Eternals existed to facilitate the Emergence—the birth of the Celestial Tiamut.

In the comics, they were merely the result of one of the Celestials' genetic experiments on Earth. Tiamut himself was already an ancient Celestial—a rebellious one who respected life—long in existence.

Film-Ginger was a brown-skinned Bollywood superstar.

Comic-Ginger (Kingo Sunen) was a samurai-like Eternal living in Hokkaido, Japan.

And the most frustrating detail—

Film Eternals had differentiated abilities.

Comic Eternals were uniformly immortal, superhumanly strong, capable of flight, energy projection, molecular manipulation—each simply expressing those powers differently according to personality and will.

It was like comparing movie mutants to comic-book mutants.

Same label. Vastly different ceilings.

Even if the first suspected Eternal Henry encountered was the Bollywood version of Ginger, that didn't prove this world followed the film canon.

And many who thought Eternals weak forgot something—

Their primary opponents were Deviants.

The only time an Eternal directly acted against humans in the film was when Druig used mind control to halt a battle between Spanish conquistadors and Mayans.

Yet neither side dared storm the temple to challenge the Eternals themselves.

That alone said something.

In short, Henry had already seen far too many elements that didn't belong purely to the MCU.

What exactly was this world?

He couldn't say.

He wasn't even sure whether the Celestial egg beneath Earth's core truly existed.

Chapter 403 403 — Ginger’s Invitation

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The response from India came even faster than expected.

His desire to meet Ginger had been impulsive.

As for what he would do upon meeting him—

He hadn't decided.

Perhaps he simply believed that those who carried similar secrets could speak freely without fearing betrayal.

After thinking for a while and reaching no firm conclusion, Henry set the matter aside.

Perhaps that Eternal celebrity had no interest in meeting him at all.

If they ever met, he could decide how to handle it then.

Recently, the most important of Henry's private projects was developing a machine capable of reading Kree and Skrull storage devices.

The alien hard drive he had taken from the Kree cruiser still hadn't been opened.

Who knew what treasures—or dangers—lay inside?

As for the apartment he rented from Old Gary—

He continued renting it, even assuring the flamboyant landlord that incidents like the FBI raid would never happen again.

But honestly?

That promise made him uneasy.

He rebuilt only the sound system in the apartment.

For the filming and projection equipment used to train Charlize's acting, he simply purchased Stark Pictures products—out of his own pocket.

He did not rebuild BB, the core cleaning robot.

All relevant programs and training data had been backed up to the undersea server, so strictly speaking, the loss wasn't serious.

Besides, BB's hardware frequently needed upgrades anyway—thanks to Katie's destructive tendencies.

The machine for reading the alien hard drive was currently under construction at the Sheepfold Valley laboratory.

Power limitations meant he could only build the hardware shell for now. Fine spectral calibration—and actual data reading—remained impossible.

If the FBI could raid his home once, it could happen a second or third time.

So where could he safely house technology that absolutely could not be exposed?

That question was giving Henry a headache.

Reviewing his resources, the safest location was undoubtedly the undersea server site.

So... an underwater laboratory?

But the turbine generators driven by ocean currents were already struggling to meet existing power demands.

His first undersea server—about the size of a twenty-seat mid-sized bus—had devoted more than half its internal volume to power generation equipment.

To supply a full laboratory?

He'd have to carpet the seafloor with generators like solar panels.

Sometimes he envied superheroes and secret organizations in movies and comics.

They could establish hidden bases anywhere.

Electricity and water were endless.

And somehow no one discovered them until the series finale.

As if governments were blind.

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The very next day, Karan Patel returned to Stark Pictures to reply to Henry's earlier proposal.

The plump butler wore a broad smile.

"Mr. Brown, Mr. Ginger asked me to convey that he is currently in the middle of film production and cannot leave at the moment.

"However, he would be delighted to invite you to India. He will cover all expenses for your visit and arrange accommodation at a five-star hotel.

"In fact, Mr. Ginger has already dispatched his private jet yesterday to pick you up.

"The aircraft will arrive in Los Angeles tonight. Considering crew rest requirements, you could depart as early as the day after tomorrow. If you prefer to leave sooner, we can arrange for a local crew to handle the flight.

"After arriving in India, aside from business discussions, if you wish to tour the country, we can arrange a professional guide to ensure you receive the highest standard of hospitality—truly a home-away-from-home experience.

"And of course, Mr. Ginger will personally host you and demonstrate the Ginger family's strength in Bollywood—proving that we are Stark Pictures' best possible partner in India."

The speech came in one breath, barely a pause between phrases.

Then Patel suddenly added, "Ah, almost forgot. If Mr. Brown wishes to bring a companion, we will extend the same level of hospitality."

So... he was suggesting Henry bring Charlize along?

Was that an attempt to add a little leverage—another variable in play?

Henry smiled.

"I can ask my girlfriend. But she has work commitments of her own. I'm not sure whether she'd be free to travel."

Patel grinned knowingly.

"No problem, no problem. Mr. Ginger only instructed that you need not travel alone. Bring as many companions as you wish.

"Though, of course, the style of reception may differ depending on whether there is a lady accompanying you. I believe you understand."

"Oh. I see."

Henry gave a wry smile.

"I understand your meaning. But that kind of reception won't be necessary."

"Of course, of course. Not necessary at all. Even during your stay, arrangements can be adjusted at any time."

Whether that had come from Ginger himself or from Patel's improvisation—who knew? Or perhaps Western businessmen traveling to India were simply accustomed to... certain assumptions about hospitality.

As for Charlize going—

Truthfully, Henry didn't want her traveling there.

He had never personally witnessed India's public safety and sanitation issues, so he refrained from judgment. But this trip involved more than business.

There were matters he couldn't explain to her.

Which meant he'd have to send her off sightseeing alone—or leave her idle at the hotel.

How secure would one have to feel to let their girlfriend walk Indian streets alone?

Even with guides and security escorts, Henry wouldn't feel at ease.

Better not to ask.

Besides, there was another problem at home.

No pet hotels accepted tigers.

It wasn't yet the era of pet boarding boutiques and "fur babies." And ordinary pet stores certainly didn't provide tiger daycare.

Aside from sending Katie to a zoo again or hiring a specialized handler, the simplest solution was to take her along.

So Henry asked directly:

"If I wish to bring a pet, can you assist with arrangements in India? Quarantine, customs clearance, that sort of thing."

"Of course," Patel replied smoothly. "Whether it's a cat or a dog, with proper veterinary documentation, I can handle all matters upon arrival in India."

"Mm."

Returning to the United States afterward would require careful attention. India was classified as a high-risk rabies region. Without proper paperwork, U.S. customs might detain Katie—and that would be a nightmare.

Fortunately, after the Skrull incident last October—when Henry had been dragged into the FBI mess and Katie temporarily sent to the zoo—he had taken her to a professional animal hospital.

He'd obtained a complete set of medical records and vaccinations, including rabies and other transmissible diseases.

At the time, he'd done so to preempt legal trouble. The zoo employee involved had made repeated attempts to find regulatory loopholes to confiscate Katie permanently.

Henry had hired a lawyer familiar with California wildlife regulations and worked with the appropriate officials to shut that down.

Technically, Katie hadn't even entered the United States through proper channels in the first place. If someone wanted to nitpick, they absolutely could.

So he'd closed that vulnerability.

Now, those documents would prove useful.

"I'll need a day to consult relevant regulations," Henry said. "Including requirements for bringing the pet back into the U.S.

"And I'll need to ask my companion whether she wishes to join me on this business trip. Assuming no complications, we'll follow your schedule and depart the day after tomorrow. Is that acceptable?"

"Certainly."

Patel handed over a hotel business card.

"This is my contact information. If you have additional requests, please reach out anytime. I will send a car to collect you for the airport."

"Very well. I'll leave the arrangements in your hands."

They shook hands and parted.

That night, Charlize returned home after a full day of auditions and training.

She sat on the couch reviewing acting tapes, arms wrapped around Katie's neck, practically burying herself into the tiger's thick fur—using the massive predator like an oversized plush recliner.

She was truly treating a tiger like a house cat.

Recently, unless Katie climbed to the top of her cat tower, she could hardly escape Charlize's enthusiastic affection.

Thankfully, Katie was a tiger, not a lion.

Otherwise, her mane would've been braided into ribbons by now.

Just imagine Simba from The Lion King with decorative braids.

Henry would've had to intervene on humanitarian grounds.

Meanwhile, Henry was in the kitchen.

After weighing Patel's words, he finally said casually,

"Hey, I'll be traveling to India for a few days starting tomorrow."

He left out the invitation detail.

Charlize lifted her face from Katie's neck, leaning backward over the couch to look toward the kitchen upside-down.

"India, huh? Do you need me to go with you?"

Interesting phrasing.

Not Do I want to go?

But Do you need me to?

Logical. Practical. Almost clinical.

If she'd wanted to go, she would have asked whether she could.

The question suggested she didn't actually intend to.

Henry replied,

"You're at a crucial stage right now. You've done two films, yes—but both are supporting roles. The results aren't out yet.

"Harris's strategy—maximize auditions, maximize exposure—is correct. This period may be the most important phase of your career.

"I'm going to India primarily for work. And I wouldn't feel comfortable letting you wander the streets alone. So it's better if you stay.

"When you've achieved something solid, when you're in the mood to travel for pleasure, we'll go together."

"Mm. Sounds good."

She accepted easily—because that was what she'd been thinking too.

"Oh, right. I'm taking Katie with me."

"What? Why! I can take care of her!"

She scratched behind Katie's ears and under her chin. The tiger squinted blissfully, tongue peeking slightly out.

Henry chuckled.

"Nope. No protests. I wouldn't feel comfortable leaving Katie alone here. Even if you promise to take care of her."

A tiger that doesn't roar is still not Hello Kitty.

Henry wasn't about to gamble on whether Katie's wild instincts had truly disappeared.

He preferred not to test that theory the hard way.

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Chapter 405 - 405 — First Impressions of Mumbai

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A twenty-four-hour flight is neither particularly fast nor unbearably slow. The plane landed at Chhatrapati Shivaji Maharaj International Airport in Mumbai, India.

This was India's most populous city and the capital of Maharashtra. While it wasn't near the Ganges—whose waters were jokingly said to be "clean enough to drink"—the local sanitation still maintained India's consistent style and standard.

The moment the plane touched down and the cabin door opened—

Even without a Kryptonian's enhanced sense of smell, the difference was obvious.

Katie took a step back.

The air itself carried a distinct Indian flavor. Whether in his previous life or this one, this was Henry's first time experiencing it firsthand.

Not all of the crew were Indian, but they were well-traveled professionals. At the very least, none of their polished service smiles cracked. For that composure alone, Henry almost felt like tipping them.

But that would've been a mistake.

Flight attendants don't accept one- or two-dollar tips—especially not those on private jets. The women hoped to land a wealthy target; the men waited to attach themselves to a rich patroness. What was a few small bills supposed to accomplish?

---

What truly impressed Henry was the trip through customs.

Or rather, Karan Patel's influence.

Or more precisely, the power of the Kingo film dynasty.

Henry went through VIP clearance.

As for Katie? She merely wore a collar and leash. No cage required—unlike in the United States, where they insisted on crating her.

For animal quarantine, Henry handed the documents to Patel to handle.

Whether it was the completeness and legitimacy of the paperwork—or the U.S. dollars discreetly placed at the bottom—that did the trick, Henry couldn't say.

A few heavy stamps came down, and Katie was officially admitted into India.

Noticing Henry's look, Patel gave his head a characteristic Indian wobble and said:

"Mr. Brown, in great Hindustan, there is no corruption. That was the animal quarantine fee."

"Mhm. I understand."

Yeah. Sure you do.

Henry had watched the officer slide the bills into his pocket without even properly reading the bold header on the documents before stamping them.

Still, Henry didn't call it out.

When in Rome, do as the Romans do.

Besides, it benefited him. No laws were being broken—just time being saved. There was no need to develop moral fastidiousness over procedural purity.

---

Outside the airport, a Bentley waited.

The interior was spacious enough that even with Henry and Katie in the back seat, it didn't feel cramped.

On the way to the Kingo family's headquarters in Bollywood, Henry initially considered lowering the window to enjoy some "authentic Hindustan breeze."

Katie shrank back into the cabin.

That alone told him something.

Normally, she loved sticking her massive head out the window to terrify pedestrians.

Then the smell hit him.

An overwhelming wave of curry-scented air assaulted his senses.

He immediately rolled the window back up and gratefully surrendered to British luxury air conditioning.

The British, having once colonized India, clearly understood how to design export models for this market. The climate control was exceptional.

Inside and outside felt like two entirely different worlds.

For a fleeting moment, Henry regretted coming.

There was an old joke:

Odor severity comes in four levels—mild, moderate, severe... and India.

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Bollywood was technically shorthand for the Bombay film industry, centered in Mumbai.

But much like Hollywood, the name had evolved into a symbol representing India's thriving film industry as a whole.

India also had Kollywood and Tollywood in other states, along with several smaller production hubs.

Together, the three "woods" essentially represented the backbone of Indian cinema.

In terms of output and ticket volume sold, Indian cinema ranked first in the world.

Of course, ticket count was not the same as box office revenue.

In the 1990s, North America remained the largest film market. That was why Hollywood was so prosperous.

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Kingo Film Company was located in the heart of Bollywood—an old-established studio with its own sound stages, equipment, and talent pool.

But Mumbai traffic lived up to its reputation.

Even with two police motorcycles clearing the way, the Bentley's progress was merely tolerable.

Without police assistance, it would've been pure gridlock hell.

Lane-cutting and chaotic merging weren't the main problem.

The real issue was that too many things that had no business being on the road were on the road.

Street vendors.

Human-powered bicycles stacked with goods.

Livestock wandering freely.

And yes—Henry finally witnessed the legendary traffic caused by cows.

Drivers wouldn't even honk.

They simply followed behind the cow patiently.

If the cow lay down in a narrow street, everyone waited.

Peacefully.

Still, Henry also noticed something interesting.

While India revered cows, he saw herders whipping and driving some of them along the roadside.

Curious, he asked:

"Mr. Patel, I thought cows were sacred in India. Isn't harming them illegal? What's going on there?"

From the front passenger seat, Patel glanced in the direction Henry indicated and replied matter-of-factly:

"Mr. Brown, the sacred cows protected by our laws and religion are specifically Indian zebu cattle.

"In our belief, the cow is the mount of Lord Shiva and a symbol of the universe, representing health and prosperity. You can identify them by the distinct hump on their shoulders.

"The animals you see being driven—those are ordinary water buffalo. No hump. They're used for plowing fields or raised for meat, leather, and dairy production.

"Those are economic livestock. Like anywhere else in the world.

"In fact, our beef exports to Southeast Asia and Africa are a major industry for India. We do not worship every cow."

Henry couldn't help but smile faintly.

India, famed worldwide for its caste system—even cows were divided into ranks.

And no one here found that odd.

In fact, there was pride in the explanation.

Cultural differences like this weren't for outsiders to judge.

Henry certainly wasn't foolish enough to lecture them about what constituted "advanced civilization."

After all—

Who decided what was advanced, anyway?

And meddling in that debate was not something he had any interest in doing.

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Chapter 406 - 406 — Kingo

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Compared to Hollywood films, Indian cinema has two defining characteristics.

The first is length.

Hollywood theaters care deeply about the number of daily screenings. Ideally, each film would run around ninety minutes so that more showtimes can fit into a single day.

If a movie runs too long, theaters complain—and studios bring out the scissors. It doesn't matter if the film is butchered beyond recognition. The runtime must be controlled.

After all, ticket prices don't increase just because a movie runs an extra thirty minutes.

Indian films, however, typically run between two and a half to three hours—and often include an intermission.

That's because many films are not shown exclusively in formal cinemas. Sometimes a projectionist loads a projector, screen, and an old tent onto a truck and drives into remote villages.

One film is enough to fill the evening—from after dinner until bedtime. If the film were too short, it wouldn't reach the intermission point, yet it wouldn't be long enough to justify screening two movies. The audience would be left with nothing to do.

The second distinctive feature of Indian cinema is its song-and-dance culture.

Instead of dubbing or subtitling countless regional dialects, music and dance serve as a universal language.

When lovers confess their feelings—they sing and dance.

When heroes and villains clash—they sing and dance.

When praising gods or chanting epics—there must be singing and dancing.

And when the story reaches its triumphant ending?

If no one sings and dances, it would be an affront to heaven and earth.

It's not just on-screen, either. Audiences sometimes stand up and join in.

That's why Indian film choreography often features one bold, easily repeatable move, with characters competing as if in a dance battle. It makes it easier for viewers to follow along instead of flailing randomly.

In India, actors don't necessarily need to sing—but if they can't dance, they'll never become major stars.

Kingo's films had a unique charm. Even if they didn't surpass his previous box office records, they consistently earned enough to turn a profit. That was how one star could sustain an entire film company.

Hollywood produces about seven hundred films annually. India averages sixteen hundred.

Yet fewer than ten percent turn a profit. Ninety percent lose money.

Even so, countless dreamers continue to throw themselves into the industry.

In such an environment, for Kingo Film Company to have survived since the end of World War II, its leading star's contribution could not be overstated.

After what felt like eighty-one trials—just short of completing a mythical pilgrimage—Henry finally crossed Mumbai from the airport and arrived at Kingo Film Company.

Inside the studio, a song-and-dance sequence was being filmed.

Henry intended to quietly observe.

Instead—

The entire set erupted in screams.

Not the kind reserved for global superstars.

The kind that signaled impending disaster.

...Right.

Henry had momentarily forgotten what he'd brought with him.

A tiger, on a leash but not in a cage.

Panic was inevitable.

Apparently the leash was too thin to notice at first glance.

about:blank

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Henry crouched down immediately, placing one hand on Katie's neck—ready to restrain her if necessary—and raised his other hand.

"Don't worry! Katie won't bite!"

Granted, even English spoken by extraterrestrials isn't universally understood.

Fortunately, before panic escalated into a stampede, the chosen male lead stepped forward, calling out in Hindi:

"Don't panic! The tiger is leashed—it won't hurt anyone!"

After repeating it several times and calming the crowd, he added:

"Our guest has arrived. We'll pause filming. Thirty-minute break."

Once the lead actor spoke, assistants and crew moved efficiently. Makeup artists retouched faces. Sets disrupted during the commotion were reset.

The interrupted shot would obviously need to be reshot.

Others finally relaxed, drinking water and catching their breath.

---

The man walking toward Henry was not a stereotypical Indian star.

He wore silk harem-style trousers and a fitted embroidered silk vest, leaving much of his sculpted torso exposed.

Unlike the round-faced, slightly plump male stars common in Bollywood, this man's physique resembled a heroic statue—something passed down from ancient Greece through medieval Europe.

Powerful. Chiseled. Explosive.

Despite the flamboyant costume, he didn't stride with theatrical swagger. Instead, his movements carried calm, aristocratic grace—like a British nobleman from a period drama.

Karan Patel stepped forward.

"Mr. Brown, allow me to introduce my master—the present-day Kingo, president of Kingo Film Company."

Then turning:

"Master, this is Mr. Henry Brown, CEO of Stark Pictures."

As the one whose tiger caused the chaos—and as a guest—Henry made the first move.

"It's an honor to meet you, Mr. Kingo. And I must apologize for the disturbance. I didn't expect my pet to cause such a commotion."

"Pleasure to meet you as well, Mr. Brown. There's no need to worry about the pet. No one was hurt, after all."

They shook hands.

In that moment, both men realized something:

The other was a very good actor.

Not in the sense of harboring sinister intent.

But both carried secrets—and both had the composure and skill to conceal them flawlessly.

Kingo, aware of Henry's unusual request, deliberately avoided mentioning it. As though such secrets didn't exist.

That alone earned Henry a measure of respect in Kingo's eyes. Far better than some overeager youth demanding answers immediately.

Henry felt similarly.

Kingo was nothing like the flamboyant, exaggerated persona seen on screen. In person, he was impeccably polite—like a man raised with refined education and flawless etiquette.

Of course, that might simply be because Henry was an outsider. In films, Kingo acted carefree and playful among familiar allies—especially under the watch of someone he respected as an elder brother.

For now, though—

There was mutual appreciation.

In the martial world, it's not about saving face. It's not about proving strength.

It's about acting.

"A true gentleman knows when to bend and when to stand tall."

How to bend. When to extend.

That is an art.

Those who lack composure, whose emotions show plainly on their faces, who react impulsively—such people rarely achieve greatness.

At the very least, this first meeting left both with a favorable impression.

And for someone who had lived seven thousand years—  
That was not easily earned.

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Chapter 407 407 — The Eternals

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Unlike big-name Hollywood actors—who prefer luxury trailers as their private lounges—Kingo's dressing room was a lavish tent.

Inside were a vanity table, cabinets filled with cosmetics, two large racks of costumes, and a small table with three chairs for discussions and work. The tabletop was piled with production materials: script pages, storyboards, shooting schedules, and more.

Henry was invited inside.

Karan Patel immediately resumed his duties as a proper steward.

After clearing the table and pouring a cup of milk tea into fine porcelain for his master, Karan turned and asked, "Mr. Brown, would you prefer black tea, milk tea, or coffee?"

"Black tea. No sugar, please."

Still happily stroking Katie's head with his back to Henry, Kingo said, "Black tea is good—but you should try the milk tea. It tastes better."

"One shouldn't take what another favors," Henry replied with a smile.

In truth, he had already noticed something.

Though high-grade black tea, milk tea, and coffee had all been prepared, the milk tea quantity was noticeably smaller. That meant Kingo preferred milk tea, while the others were for guests.

Moreover, Kingo was drinking authentic English milk tea—not Indian masala chai with spices and herbs. English milk tea is brewed directly with milk instead of adding milk to tea afterward. The difference in flavor was profound.

But Henry, long resigned to America's abundance of good coffee and scarcity of good tea, had no intention of drinking anything else in India—a major tea-producing country.

Though Indian black tea is fermented, unlike green tea that relies solely on heat processing, the aroma rising from the cup was the first scent in India that Henry not only tolerated—but genuinely enjoyed.

He took a slow sip of the deep amber liquid.

The fruity aroma was sharp, reminiscent of citrus peel. The finish lingered pleasantly, with layers of flavor touching the front, middle, and back of the tongue. The returning sweetness was something cheap tea could never achieve.

As he savored it, it felt as though all forty trillion cells in his body had awakened.

"Which region is this from?"

Kingo turned his head with a smile. "Nilgiri. One of India's three major tea regions. But because its climate resembles Sri Lanka's, it doesn't have the same global reputation as Ceylon tea."

When facing a wild predator, one should never break eye contact—it signals fear. If the animal is hungry, that's practically an invitation to be attacked.

Yet Kingo turned his back on Katie as though she posed no threat. His hand continued stroking her casually, without force or restraint.

In short—

He truly wasn't afraid.

If he wasn't reckless or foolishly brave, then there was only one explanation:

He had the strength not to fear a tiger.

In the film version, Kingo was portrayed as a sharpshooter. But the Eternals were no ordinary beings.

In the comics, even without considering individual specializations, the average Eternal possessed fifteen-ton strength, flight capability, cosmic energy manipulation, molecular-level control, plus self-healing and regeneration as baseline traits.

They were, collectively, a race of supermen.

For reference—

Thanos—the Mad Titan, also known as the purple sweet potato demon—was classified in the comics as an Eternal.

He was a second-generation Eternal born on Titan, genetically flawed and exiled. That rejection shaped his destructive philosophy.

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In the films, however, Thanos belonged to the Titan race, whose civilization collapsed due to resource depletion after rejecting his plan to eliminate half their population.

In the comics, Titan's people were second-generation Eternals—not first-generation beings created directly by the Celestials.

Using Thanos as a benchmark, Henry mentally elevated Kingo's threat level several tiers.

"This tea truly lives up to its reputation," Henry said lightly. "You know how it is in America—good tea isn't easy to find."

"Even for the CEO of Stark Pictures?" Kingo teased. "Perhaps you're modest compared to the Hollywood Eight, but your company's assets—and your salary—surely exceed that of most Americans."

"A year ago, I was still scraping by at the bottom. The best job I had was serving others. If I wanted access to high-end things, I had to sneak around. I didn't care to make trouble, so I mostly avoided them. Only now can I enjoy such things openly."

During his time assisting Audrey Hepburn, his food and lodging had matched hers.

But she was never extravagant. Her preferences leaned toward health and freshness—not ostentatious luxury.

Those who think that's the same as top-tier indulgence fall into two categories:

Either they've never tasted true luxury.

Or they've been fooled by marketing façades.

The tea and coffee Kingo served were rare masterpieces—from cultivation to brewing, every stage handled with meticulous care.

India's poverty was real—but so was the unimaginable luxury of its wealthy elite.

Kingo raised an eyebrow at Henry's self-deprecation.

"In that year, no one offered tribute?"

"I spent most of it buried in research. Those who tried to approach me before I'd proven anything weren't investors. They were opportunists."

"I see. Forgive me. No one dares attempt deception in front of me."

"Film dynasty, after all. Fifth-generation head, hm?"

Henry's brow lifted meaningfully.

Kingo released Katie's head and returned to the small table, taking a sip of milk tea.

Calmly, he said, "Before we proceed—I need to know where you learned that word."

Henry answered evenly.

"Most of the written records of the Maya civilization were destroyed. But scholars still study what remains, trying to reconstruct history through oral traditions in South America.

"There's a book titled Curiosities of South America that mentions a rainforest settlement ruled by 'Eternals.' A paradise without conflict. The ruler was said to be immortal—or perhaps a hereditary title passed down.

"But others describe it as a place from which no one returns—a cannibal land. The account appears alongside tribal legends.

"With no solid evidence, only eyewitness claims, most scholars dismiss it—like the Loch Ness Monster or the Yeti."

The most crucial clue, of course, came from Henry's pre-reincarnation memories of the films.

But that part would remain unspoken.

The book he referenced did exist in this world—and it did contain vague references to Eternals.

Back when Henry had been researching global love legends, he'd read widely across cultures. Even then, he'd noticed how frequently the term "Eternals" appeared in obscure folklore.

Usually just rumors. No proof.

Now—

It served perfectly as his justification.

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Chapter 408 408 — The Purpose of the Meeting?

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"Ah, that was Druid's fault," Kingo said with visible irritation. "He always thinks his abilities guarantee perfection. But his arrogance is exactly what ruins everything."

Henry smiled. "So it is true. There have been records about the 'Eternals' all over the world—but mostly anecdotes, folklore, strange tales. Nothing concrete.

"Then I heard about a film dynasty in India—five generations, each one looking like they were stamped from the same mold. I began to wonder whether it might be the same situation. Something connected to 'Eternal.'

"When Mr. Patel visited, I tested the waters. By the way—living like this... has no one truly discovered you?"

Kingo put on an exaggeratedly displeased expression. "Of course they have. I've even had someone try to stab me through the heart, thinking I was a vampire."

Beside him, the plump steward broke into a nervous sweat. "Master... haven't you forgiven me? I've apologized countless times."

Kingo laughed. "My dear servant, one day I will forget it. Until then, may I not occasionally comment on how clever you mortals think yourselves?"

To Henry, the exchange was clearly performance—affection disguised as teasing hostility.

Once the theatrics subsided, Kingo turned serious.

"You came to see me. What do you want?"

Henry hesitated. "Honestly... I didn't think that far ahead. I didn't expect you to actually agree to meet."

"Why not?" Kingo replied lightly. "You mentioned another magic word. That caught my interest. Krypton. Care to explain?"

Henry's gaze drifted briefly toward Karan Patel.

Kingo waved it off. "Don't worry. His lips are sealed. You haven't seen him spreading my secrets, have you?"

Henry shrugged. "Very well. But I hope Mr. Patel understands this involves a certain American intelligence agency."

He then recounted the events surrounding Captain Marvel's awakening—how the Skrulls had abruptly targeted him, dragging him into a conflict he had never sought.

He spoke of being identified by the Skrulls as a Kryptonian, and of the fragments of information he had learned from both Skrulls and Kree.

"So," Henry concluded, "do you know anything about Krypton?"

"You claim to be a Kryptonian orphan?" Kingo did not doubt him. Names like Skrull, Kree, and Kryptonian were not terms an ordinary Earthling could casually invent.

"That's what the Skrulls said. But it's true—I arrived on Earth alone."

He omitted any mention of the Red Empire laboratory.

Kingo nodded slowly. "I know of the Skrulls. The Kree. And Kryptonians. But Krypton's presence in cosmic history was brief. What I know likely adds nothing to what you already understand."

"...I see." Henry couldn't hide a flicker of disappointment.

That, at least, confirmed one thing: the Eternals had never directly dealt with Krypton. The Skrulls, enemies of Kryptonians, seemed to know more.

"Is there anything else I can help you with?" Kingo asked.

Henry pondered.

What did he truly want?

The most tempting thing was Eternal technology—possibly derived from the Celestials.

Chapter 409 409 — Insights from Brainwave Research

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The rapid-fire translation left Kingo stunned.

He pointed at Katie—who had her backside aimed at him, clearly wanting to leave the tent but not quite daring to—and asked, "This little one is... complaining?"

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But asking outright would expose naked ambition. And he wasn't even certain he could reverse-engineer it.

If it were something essential, he would have planned carefully. But it was merely... desirable. A bonus. Was it worth risking this promising opening?

Before he decided—

Katie rose and began pacing the tent.

Her unease brushed against Henry's awareness.

"What is it?"

"Rrrr."

—Need to pee.

"Oh."

Yes. That was important.

Henry stood. "My apologies, Mr. Kingo. Where's the restroom? My pet needs relief. Surely you wouldn't want a carnivore marking your tent."

Kingo made a helpless face. "I'm used to worse. But Karan—escort our guest."

That comment made Henry twitch.

If even an Eternal could say he was "used to it"... how wild were Indian public habits?

After briefly resuming his role as tiger janitor, Henry found himself thinking he really needed to rebuild the BB core robotics series soon—unless he wanted sanitation permanently added to his job description.

When he returned, Kingo asked curiously, "You understand the tiger? Did you raise it from birth?"

"It's actually a tiger-striped—... never mind," Henry gave up mid-lie. "Yes, I raised her. But the understanding part comes from a device I built."

"Katie, come here."

He adjusted the attachment behind her ear.

"This device analyzes tiger brainwaves and vocal patterns to interpret intent. I use a frequency inaudible to normal humans—only I can hear the translated result. It also works in reverse, converting human speech into sounds tigers comprehend. For now, only English."

Kingo tilted his head. "Ah. That explains the faint buzzing I sensed."

Because the device clipped behind the ear to prevent accidental removal, toggling its settings required an awkward motion.

Katie flicked her ear irritably and gave a protesting growl.

"It itches, you foolish two-legged creature."

She retreated, tail swishing, pacing again.

Henry sighed. "Now what?"

"Isn't there any sunlight here? I've been trapped in a little cold box all day, and everything smells terrible. After landing, it smells even worse. There's nowhere decent to rest."

To ordinary ears, it was only a low rumbling growl—vibration deep in the throat.

But Henry heard the full translation.

And the unmistakable disdain.

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Henry said awkwardly, "Tiger language doesn't actually have that many words. And a tiger's thoughts are simpler than a human's. That is roughly what she means.

"But the phrasing you heard—I rendered it in a more irritable tone. I do have a 'polite' version programmed, but since we're out and about, I can't adjust the translation profile.

"So... just take it as flavor text. I honestly never planned on letting the translation play aloud for normal people."

"Pfft—ha! Hahaha!" Kingo burst into laughter. "Then why not keep the translator permanently set to this mode?"

"Battery life," Henry replied matter-of-factly. "Originally, the output volume was extremely low—just enough for me to hear. Amplifying it so ordinary humans can hear increases power consumption several times over."

He called Katie back and switched off the external voice output.

In standard mode, the twin earpieces could last about seven days without charging. With audible human-level translation turned on, the battery would die in four hours.

Henry had no desire to constantly search for charging outlets—or to explain to ordinary people why his tiger could speak—so Katie reverted to looking like a normal tiger again instead of a chatty, grumbling little brother.

The reason Henry chose that slightly abrasive tone for her translation was simple: tigers should sound like kings of the forest. If she spoke like a courteous gentleman, it would feel absurd.

Originally, he had experimented with giving her a Black urban accent—the translated voice came out like rap lyrics. But it was so obnoxious even Henry couldn't stand it. If he had kept that version, it might not have been long before he'd be brewing tiger bone wine...

Kingo was clearly intrigued by the device. He didn't take it for a pre-recorded gimmick. After all, Henry wasn't pitching a product for investment.

Considering Henry's accomplishments in Hollywood over the past year—using new digital imaging technology to challenge traditional film systems—it made sense. Without real achievement, how could he have earned the respect of that famously brilliant billionaire heir and been entrusted with one of his companies?

Curious, Kingo asked, "How did you come up with this? Care to explain?"

"You're actually interested?" Henry raised a brow.

"Of course," Kingo replied. "When you've lived long enough, something genuinely new becomes exceedingly rare.

"Your digital imaging technology is an evolution—pushing existing foundations further. The difference between you and companies like Sony is simply that you moved faster and produced something practical.

"But this translator... I can't even imagine how you conceived it. Tell me."

Henry thought for a moment. "Do you know Professor X from the X-Men?"

"I'm aware of them. A well-known mutant group."

"It started the first time I encountered Professor X."

Henry briefly described the incident—how his mind had been invaded, which sparked his desire to develop mental defenses.

"At first, I only wanted to create something like Magneto's helmet—a device to block psychic intrusion.

"Later, after raising a tiger, I began to think more deeply about brainwave research. Combined with sensory hardware and data analysis, I spent over a year refining the methodology to reach this stage."

Kingo looked surprised. "So although a mutant triggered the idea, you achieved all this using nothing but a tiger? You didn't collaborate with other mutants?"

"How would I even ask?" Henry laughed. "'Hey, Professor X, I'd like to build a helmet to block your telepathy. Please assist with testing.' Who would willingly help create something that counters themselves?"

"Fair enough." Kingo leaned forward slightly. "Then what conclusions have you reached about psychic abilities?"

Chapter 410 410 — Kingo's Request

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A brief silence settled over the tent, making the atmosphere slightly awkward.

But Kingo did not remain contemplative for long. He sighed.

"As far as I know, Krypton rose to power in an astonishingly short time—enough to threaten the Skrull Empire—because of your species' unfathomable intelligence.

"Unfortunately, that same volatile madness made cooperation with other civilizations nearly impossible. Otherwise, it would not have been the Shi'ar Empire rising to prominence today. It might have been Krypton—forming the third great power of the nearby galaxy."

It sounded like praise, yet Henry felt detached.

"I was abandoned as an infant. Praising Krypton doesn't exactly stir pride in me."

Not to mention—he wasn't even a native Kryptonian. He was a transmigrator.

Kingo smiled faintly. "It is praise for you as well, Mr. Brown. Please accept it modestly.

"And I intend to give you a test."

Henry didn't quite understand why the question mattered, but it still felt like a reasonable exchange.

"To be honest, building a functional psychic-blocking helmet now wouldn't be difficult for me.

"The real problem is testing it. I can't exactly go provoke powerful telepaths. And if a test fails, I can't just kick them out of my mind and pretend nothing happened.

"But defense aside—regarding brainwaves, I can now read them. At least, I can interpret Katie's with high accuracy.

"For other species—including humans—I'd need far more comparative data. As for interference, my capabilities are limited.

"For example, I can convert human speech into a brainwave pattern Katie understands—essentially a universal translator concept. But compared to the Kree's cosmic translation tech, I'm nowhere near that level.

"If you're asking about manipulating consciousness—erasing memories, altering perception, locking away awareness..."

He shook his head.

"I've never had the need. So I haven't pursued technological solutions for that."

Kingo had shed his playful demeanor entirely. He listened intently, fingers lightly tapping the table in thought.

"You mentioned you can currently read tiger brainwaves. What about other organisms? How long would research take?"

Henry smiled. "The hardest part with Katie wasn't decoding her—it was building the methodology and defining the research framework.

"Once the framework exists, adapting it to another organism mainly requires accumulating comparative data. The time investment depends on the goal.

"If I wanted precise, word-for-word translation of an unknown language or animal cognition, that would take significant time. But if I only needed emotional states? That's relatively simple."

Kingo's gaze sharpened.

"And if you were to influence a human consciousness—could you?"

Henry blinked. "I don't commit crimes. Well... fine, psychic manipulation isn't technically codified in most legal systems. But ethically? That's questionable."

Even as he answered, Henry was thinking.

Why is he so focused on this?

Could it be about Thena?

Mahd Wy'ry—the Eternal madness. In the film, her condition stemmed from residual memories bleeding through, triggering violent episodes.

Is that happening here too?

If so... is Kingo looking for a cure?

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Henry frowned slightly. Being tested for no clear reason was always irritating.

"Don't misunderstand," Kingo continued calmly. "This will benefit you as well. I am willing to cooperate with your research. Study whatever you wish."

That truly caught Henry off guard.

"Cooperate with my research? What exactly do you mean?"

"Precisely what it sounds like. If you are curious about the Eternals—our physiology, our technology—I will assist you. Naturally, nothing invasive or harmful. Whatever results you obtain cannot be considered anything but a gain for you."

Henry lowered his gaze in thought.

"If this is a test, and the benefit is upfront... then what happens if I pass? What do you want from me?"

Kingo's expression grew serious.

"If you are able to understand Eternal biology or technology to a level I deem sufficient, then yes—I have a request.

"It concerns one of my people. A dear friend."

He tapped his temple.

"She has... a problem here. I hope you might help. Even an evaluation would suffice."

So it was indeed about the Eternal warrior—Thena.

Henry did not immediately agree.

"This sounds neurological—or consciousness-related. Among your kind, isn't there a healer? Or a technological specialist who could address this?"

"Our leader possesses healing abilities," Kingo said. "But her proposed solution is to erase all memories and start anew.

"We believe the condition stems from the accumulation of knowledge and memories over countless ages—beyond what the mind can sustain.

"But you understand the dilemma. If she loses her past—our battles, our shared experiences—is she still the person we know?

"We do not wish to lose our friend. To look at her face and treat her as a stranger... that would be tragic. So the matter remains unresolved.

"The reason I approached you is precisely because you lack preconceived notions. I want to hear how a Kryptonian might approach such a condition."

Henry considered that carefully.

"And your technological expert? He has no solution?"

Kingo snorted. "He is a timid, overly sensitive coward. Ever since he believes he committed a grave mistake, he refuses to conduct further research. I have no patience to persuade him."

So even the Eternals were not united. Interesting.

Henry asked again, "Have you considered Professor X? If you've lived into this era, why not consult the foremost authority in mental phenomena?"

"We do not trust mutants," Kingo replied flatly. "Especially those with strong ideological convictions—even if they claim to stand for justice.

"The mutants we have encountered are rigid, uncompromising, narrow-minded. I have no reason to believe the X-Men are different from the Brotherhood or the Hellfire Club.

"Furthermore, the X-Men are far too conspicuous. Their existence invites attention. Contacting them risks exposing us.

"We have watched civilizations collapse. In desperate times, people drag down anyone nearby. I would advise you to minimize your involvement with mutants."

Henry almost laughed.

That sentiment was becoming universal.

"But in terms of visibility," Henry countered, "am I really less conspicuous than the X-Men? Associating with me carries no risk?"

Kingo grinned.

"We share a convenient cover. Film industry cooperation. For us, that is the perfect disguise."

Henry had to admit—he agreed entirely. To the outside world, they would be discussing cinema technology. No one would imagine an Eternal and a Kryptonian negotiating behind the curtain.

Which reminded him—

They hadn't yet discussed any actual business.

"Speaking of film," Henry said, "what kind of cooperation are you proposing? I'll accept your 'test,' but we still need a legitimate agreement on record."

Kingo nodded.

Chapter 411 411 — Henry’s Requirement

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From all available intelligence, this universe had not yet reached the point where Kryptonite could be picked up off the street.

As far as the public knew, a Kryptonian's only open weakness was a green sun.

A red sun merely stripped away their powers, rendering them ordinary. That fact, however, did not seem widely understood.

Still—since the Skrulls had already revealed the "green sun" weakness in front of Nick Fury, Henry couldn't rule out the possibility of S.H.I.E.L.D. attempting something creative. A green-sun radiation device, perhaps.

In the DC universe, only two and a half individuals could reliably manufacture artificial Kryptonite:

Brainiac, the techno-tyrant; Lex Luthor, with his twelfth-level intellect; and "half" credit to Batman—who never confirmed it, yet everyone assumed he could.

Those figures might not exist here.

But this universe had Reed Richards.

It had Tony Stark.

"At minimum, we wish to import film-grade digital imaging equipment from Stark Pictures.

"In an ideal scenario, we would pursue joint production—technology transfer—with manufacturing based in India."

Henry responded immediately.

"That can be arranged. However, equipment produced in India must be restricted to sale and maintenance within India."

He paused, then added:

"We can extend that region to South Asia and West Asia. Those markets are difficult to serve directly from the United States—too small, too complicated. Letting you handle them makes sense."

Now it was Kingo's turn to widen his eyes.

"You agreed that quickly?"

"Why not?"

"And the regional restriction—you can enforce that?"

"Easily," Henry replied with a smile. "These systems are computer-based. Region locking, embedded authentication signatures—digital watermarking in source files—it's straightforward.

"The traditional methods still apply: manufacturing origin labels, serial registration. If Indian-manufactured systems appear in Hollywood, we void service, revoke screening rights, or remotely disable playback.

"As long as the contract clearly defines territorial limitations and buyers are informed, enforcement becomes a legal matter.

"Of course, grey markets will always exist. That's inevitable—and manageable."

Kingo gave him a knowing look.

"You're willing to concede substantial profit margins. That suggests you want something from the Eternals."

"Yes."

Henry met his gaze directly.

"Battle armor."

Even Superman had a suit with his family crest—he didn't patrol naked simply because he possessed invulnerability.

Henry's concern was not merely about shredded clothing after gunfire.

He wanted a full system—radiation shielding, ideally with stealth capabilities.

Radiation against what?

Kryptonite.

He needed protection against Kryptonite radiation.

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Was engineering a synthetic green-spectrum radiation source truly that difficult?

Henry refused to gamble on their limitations.

Better to prepare a radiation-resistant suit now than regret it later.

Unfortunately—

High expectations often led to disappointment.

Kingo shook his head helplessly.

"I would like to agree. But Eternal battle armor can only be donned aboard our mothership.

"After we defeated the Deviants and separated, the ship was sealed. I cannot access my armor, nor could I provide it for your research."

"I see..." Henry tried to mask his disappointment.

"But," Kingo continued, "if what you want is the technology behind the armor, I can tell you this—it originates from the same source as this."

He formed a finger-gun gesture with his right hand.

Immediately, luminous geometric lines manifested a few centimeters above his skin—intricate patterns of light suspended in midair.

At the tip of his index finger, energy condensed into a brilliant orb.

A second later—

Thud.

The energy projectile shot forward, punching a small hole into a sofa across the tent.

"The source of this," Kingo said, lowering his hand slightly, "is the same as our armor. It draws from the cosmic energy within us.

"This ability is innate—but each Eternal manifests it differently.

"The armor is woven by the mothership's system, channeling that internal energy into structured form. If you understand that principle, you could theoretically create something similar."

Henry stared intently at the glowing patterns still flickering along Kingo's forearm.

When Kingo relaxed his finger-gun pose, the lines faded.

When he formed it again, they reappeared.

"May I?" Henry asked.

Kingo didn't respond verbally—he simply extended his hand.

Henry reached forward.

To his surprise, the luminous constructs were not intangible projections. They had substance. Even the empty spaces between the lines felt resistant, as though a barrier prevented direct contact with Kingo's skin.

This was mass—energy equivalence treated like a chew toy.

Einstein's coffin lid must have been rattling.

But Henry's senses had already been fully engaged from the moment Kingo activated the construct. He was cataloging everything.

Kingo was correct—the energy was drawn internally.

The "gun" structure wasn't external machinery. The glowing lines defined the boundaries of structured energy—an organized containment lattice.

Like a magical circle.

Or, in more scientific terms—

Like a circuit board.

The lines acted as pathways. Nodes behaved like resistors or capacitors. The configuration shaped output.

Henry withdrew his hand and fell silent in thought.

Kingo waited a moment before asking, "Well? Any insights?"

Henry countered with a question.

"Is this configuration fixed?"

"No. Given time to charge, I can produce more powerful projectiles. The lattice becomes more complex."

"And without forming this structure?"

"I can still fire—but at minimal strength. Even then, it surpasses a human handgun. Ironically, reducing output to non-lethal levels requires more focus. Usually I just punch instead."

Henry nodded slowly.

"I haven't seen other Eternals. But I do have a hypothesis."

Kingo leaned forward eagerly. "Let's hear it."

Henry spoke carefully.

"The source of your ability isn't your hand. It's your brain.

"Think of irrigation channels in farmland. When dry, they lie dormant. Once water is released—even before fully filled—the channels activate and guide flow.

Chapter 412 412 — Indian Cuisine

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As a subcontinent, India has long been one of the most intense crossroads of Eastern and Western peoples and cultures. Yet unlike many regions shaped by conquest, no single force completely suppressed the other. Climate, geography, and trade instead blended influences into something distinctly Indian.

After Columbus "discovered" the New World and European powers such as Britain and Portugal established colonial footholds in India, they brought not only new crops but also new culinary techniques. In time, Indian cuisine would even flow back and reshape the food culture of its former colonizers.

But perhaps the most profound influence came from India's central role in the global spice trade. For centuries, spices were gathered and distributed through India before being shipped across Eurasia.

Take curry, for instance. It is less a single dish than a "United Nations of spices." Depending on the region, anywhere from eighty to over three hundred ingredients may find their way into a curry blend. Such culinary extravagance could only

"The pathways are determined entirely by your brain. There is no physical device in your hand acting as a mediator.

"However... it appears each Eternal brain is limited to constructing one primary 'irrigation system.' What you call your 'innate talent.'

"That would explain why your armor requires the mothership's assistance—it falls outside the fixed neurological template of your personal talent.

"But once energy is shaped, it becomes remarkably stable—and capable of functions beyond raw output.

"It behaves almost like... programmable clay."

Henry paused.

"If that's accurate, then theoretically the mothership could guide you to access other Eternals' abilities—by constructing alternate pathways externally."

Kingo's eyes widened.

"...We've never considered that."

He laughed softly.

"Unfortunately, with the mothership sealed, experimentation isn't possible."

Henry shrugged lightly.

"Which reinforces my conclusion—the key lies in your neural waveform. That anomalous mental signature is what regulates the energy."

Kingo studied him carefully.

"That's a fascinating conclusion. And you arrived at it without instruments? Simply by observation and touch?"

Henry nodded.

"My sensory capacity exceeds normal parameters. I only use instruments for validation or computational modeling. For preliminary analysis, they aren't necessary."

Kingo regarded him with renewed respect.

"You surpass my expectations, Kryptonian."

He turned toward his steward.

"Karan. Dismiss the crew for the day. Filming ends here.

"And inform the chef—we're hosting a dinner."

He faced Henry again, smiling warmly.

"Henry. May I call you Henry? I am considerably older, after all.

"You've come to India. You cannot leave without sampling our cuisine."

Henry's expression froze.

It was the face of a man contemplating whether immediate death might be preferable.

Kingo laughed.

"Relax. Not the kind you saw on the streets."

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emerge in a land where spices were abundant; in spice-scarce regions, no one would dare cook so lavishly.

Thus, one defining feature of Indian cuisine is simple:

It is unapologetically generous with spices.

Indian barbecue, for example, does not rely solely on soy sauce or salt for marination. Meats are soaked in mixtures of spices, yogurt, and lemon juice, tenderizing them while infusing deep layers of flavor.

Indian fried rice incorporates cinnamon, cloves, star anise, fennel, coriander, and more—often customized with regional ingredients depending on the state.

Staples are not limited to rice, either. Flatbreads in countless variations serve as dietary pillars, each prepared with distinct techniques.

All of this came as a pleasant surprise to Henry—who had arrived in India prepared to be satisfied so long as no one served him Ganges water and E. coli levels stayed within survivable limits.

Henry's attitude toward food was simple: he did not belittle or compare cuisines. Nostalgic comfort and familiar flavors were one thing. Exploring something entirely new was another.

The latter required two qualities:

A spirit of adventure.

And an iron stomach.

Fortunately, as a Kryptonian, Henry possessed both—and even enjoyed testing them.

Kingo's banquet that evening exceeded expectations. Every dish seemed to expand Henry's culinary vocabulary and awaken his palate.

Even Katie surprised him.

The tiger devoured the grilled meats with rare enthusiasm. Normally, when presented with both raw and cooked meat, Katie would prioritize the raw cuts, only glancing at cooked food if still hungry afterward.

Henry's barely concealed astonishment did not escape Kingo's notice.

The Eternal—who had lived roughly seven thousand years, give or take—laughed.

"This is India. One of the most biodiverse places on Earth. One of the few lands where lions and tigers both exist.

"You didn't think you were the only one capable of raising a tiger, did you?

"Throughout history, kings have kept fierce beasts to demonstrate their power. If someone raises them, someone must feed them.

"And merely feeding them plain meat is hardly impressive. The real artistry lies in feeding them creatively.

"India has long had palace cuisine specifically designed for lions and tigers—crafted to stimulate their appetite. Most people have no idea such traditions exist."

Henry sighed. "Well. You've successfully reminded me that I belong to the 'most people' category."

Kingo burst into laughter.

The rotund chef stood nearby, impeccably clean and meticulous about hygiene. Though he did not understand English, Kingo occasionally conversed with him in Hindi, and the two shared frequent chuckles.

Fortunately, they were not mocking the naïve foreigner. They were reminiscing about the peculiarities of tiger cuisine.

The chef had once questioned why his family's inherited palace recipes included dishes meant specifically for big cats. The flavors were unusual—nothing a human would normally prefer.

In ancient courts, royal chefs had to gauge a tiger's reaction rather than verbal feedback. The animals could not critique seasoning. The chefs could only observe appetite and behavior, refining recipes accordingly.

It required either great dedication—or too much free time.

The chef had once resisted learning such seemingly useless skills. But, as tradition dictated, paternal discipline prevailed—and the craft survived.

Mid-conversation, Henry abruptly interjected in Hindi:

"Chef, would you be willing to teach me these recipes?"

The chef blinked in surprise.

"Mr. Brown—you speak Hindi?"

Henry nodded. "I've watched a few Bollywood films before. And before coming here, I studied from a Hindi-English textbook. I wasn't confident about my accent, so I didn't dare speak earlier."

Kingo switched to Hindi as well.

"Your pronunciation leans toward Calcutta—colonial-era usage. The textbook you used must be an older edition."

"Not surprising," Henry replied dryly.

Chapter 413 413 — The Secret of the Eternals

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The Eternals were extraordinary.

And here, we are speaking of the true Eternals—the First Generation directly created by the Celestials.

Not the second generation who lived on Titan and were later culled by Thanos.

The First Generation could not reproduce among themselves. However, they could mate with other humanoid intelligent species and produce second-generation Eternals. After that point, reproductive limitations no longer applied. Yet these later generations were not acknowledged by the Celestials.

Although the films described them as "advanced bio-machines," after personally studying Kingo, Henry felt that calling them machines was almost blasphemous.

They were biological beings.

The chef chuckled. "Proud white men."

He immediately froze and apologized.

"Sorry, Mr. Brown—I didn't mean—"

"It's fine," Henry replied self-deprecatingly. "White people are often proud. That's not incorrect."

Only Kingo caught the deeper irony—that Henry spoke not merely as a white man, but as a Kryptonian. The Eternal laughed softly.

As dessert was served and masala chai—milk tea brewed directly with spices—warmed the air, Kingo returned to business in English.

"Henry, how do you intend to structure operations in India? Do you have authority to make decisions on Stark Pictures' behalf?"

Henry sipped his tea calmly.

"It's flexible. Profits—set them reasonably.

"You can establish the company structure as you see fit. It can be a Stark Pictures overseas subsidiary or a joint venture with Indian stakeholders.

"I share digital imaging patents fifty-fifty with Stark Pictures. Even when integrated into equipment, I retain roughly thirty percent of revenue share.

"At worst, I convert my share of Western profits into Indian market share. Stark Pictures' income in Europe and America won't decrease.

"Even if Tony Stark himself objected, he'd have little ground."

Kingo raised an eyebrow.

"That is a considerable sum. You don't mind?"

Henry smiled faintly.

"Is money that important?"

Kingo considered this seriously before nodding.

"Money is important."

Then he laughed.

"But not that important.

"We live within social rules. We support many people. So yes—money matters.

"But unlike most, we can abandon those rules at any time. In that sense, money matters far less.

"The fact that you understand this... proves we are of the same kind."

Finally, Kingo added:

"Don't worry. You won't suffer in the company's formation. I still need your intellect to help my friend."

Henry did not boast.

"I'll do my best. But I won't promise miracles without seeing her condition first."

"That," Kingo replied warmly, "is enough."

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In every physiological test Henry conducted, he found no mechanical components—no artificial structures.

And yet their performance exhibited machine-level precision.

Precision so exact it defied biological randomness.

For example—

Henry once asked Kingo to draw a straight line exactly one centimeter long, freehand, without any measuring tools.

Kingo drew it.

Perfectly straight. Exactly one centimeter.

No deviation.

He could repeat the task a hundred times, a thousand times—ten thousand times—and the result would remain identical. Even if someone jostled him mid-drawing, he would resume and complete the line with perfect accuracy.

...Of course, in practice, Kingo did not indulge Henry with ten thousand repetitions. After ten trials, Henry stopped the experiment.

Henry himself, with his super-brain, could achieve similar control—but it required focus. If distracted, minor errors could occur. That had already been verified in earlier testing.

The Eternals, however, displayed no such fluctuation.

Henry couldn't help recalling the biblical Adam and Eve—who were said to have lived over nine hundred years, with subsequent generations gradually declining in lifespan.

Now it seemed plausible.

These "first-generation" beings truly were different.

Their precision greatly simplified Henry's research.

Ordinary biological data collection required statistical models and tolerance ranges. Variability had to be accounted for.

The Eternals had virtually no variance.

Identical inputs yielded identical outputs.

Only changes in parameters altered outcomes. External interference alone could not disrupt their execution.

Frankly, many Earth-made machines were less consistent.

With such an ideal subject, Henry's study of Kingo's cosmic energy control advanced rapidly.

He gained deeper insight into what the Eternals referred to as their "innate talents."

When Kingo intended to attack, the mere formation of that intent triggered a specific neural pattern—like a cryptographic key.

That brainwave activated the cosmic energy stored within his body.

A portion of that energy first formed a conversion lattice—the glowing geometric construct around his hand.

Subsequent energy flowed through this "device," transforming into another energy form, producing the projectile-like discharge.

In summary, Eternal abilities depended on two conditions:

1. A brain capable of ultra-precise control.
2. An internal reservoir of cosmic energy.

Comparing brains alone, Henry concluded that Eternals were far inferior to Kryptonians in raw cognitive potential.

Kingo's learning speed and deductive reasoning were not extraordinary.

What he possessed instead was vast experience. His long life allowed him to rely on instinctive pattern recognition—making correct decisions based on accumulated memory.

But when confronting truly unknown problems, he stalled—like a computer freezing.

Which explained why the Eternals had failed to resolve Thena's Mahd Wy'ry for thousands of years.

Their options remained limited to:

Memory wipe and reset

Isolation

Passive tolerance

Three thousand years without progress on a neurological disorder would be unimaginable in human civilization.

As for the cosmic energy within them—

It was not mystical "qi" or immeasurable magic.

It had a clear biological origin:

The mitochondria within Eternal cells.

Chapter 414 414 — A Research Bottleneck

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Kingo stared at the disturbingly detailed medical report in his hands, then looked back up at Henry.

"If I hadn't watched you conduct the examination and write this myself," he said slowly, "I would suspect you had secretly dissected an Eternal to obtain this data."

"You're the first Eternal I've ever met," Henry replied. "Before meeting you, I wasn't even certain your kind existed. And I promised I'd share all my findings."

Strictly speaking, he wasn't lying.

When Kingo activated his ability, the mitochondria in his hand cells exhibited peak activity.

The longer he charged, the more mitochondria across his body joined the process—until reaching a systemic limit.

This explained how the Celestials embedded cosmic energy storage within Eternal physiology—and how energy replenished after expenditure.

Eternals resembled machines in another sense:

They began at peak condition upon creation, then gradually declined.

Unlike humans, they did not rely on constant cellular turnover. No regular apoptosis cycle. No stem-cell regeneration as a baseline metabolic process.

Only when injured would cellular death trigger regeneration.

This minimized telomere shortening from replication, dramatically extending lifespan.

Their uniqueness extended further:

Even their blood cells possessed nuclei and mitochondria.

And blood no longer primarily transported oxygen.

Their lungs functioned as energy conversion reactors—absorbing ambient spatial free energy and converting it into cosmic energy.

Their digestive systems performed similar conversions—transforming consumed matter into pure cosmic energy.

Blood then distributed that energy to replenish mitochondrial reserves.

If cosmic energy consumption remained low, Eternals theoretically did not require food or oxygen.

Which explained their ability to survive in space.

Eating, then, was largely behavioral—an adaptation to human society.

All of these findings came from Henry's "Kryptonian-brand organic sensor suite"—his own senses.

He compiled the results into a handwritten report for Kingo.

A complete physiological analysis.

Kingo read it.

And stared.

Then stared again.

The document included hand-drawn cross-sections of blood cells. Skeletal diagrams. Organ schematics. Detailed neural and lymphatic mapping centered on the brain.

The level of detail rivaled modern medical textbooks.

Except—

These diagrams depicted Eternal anatomy, subtly but distinctly different from humans.

Kingo understood one thing clearly:

Henry hadn't guessed.

He had seen.

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He knew of the Eternals—but whether they truly existed in this universe had been uncertain until now.

"Half a day," Kingo muttered. "You did all this in half a day?"

"It was only an examination."

In truth, Henry's speed came from prior conceptual familiarity. He already knew several possible origin models for the Eternals—Celestial-made constructs, or genetically altered early humans from a million years ago.

His task had simply been to determine which framework fit Kingo—and fill in the observational blanks accordingly.

The decisive factor?

Their DNA.

It bore no resemblance whatsoever to human genetic structures.

An eight-strand, four-dimensional helical configuration—biologically impossible under conventional Earth chemistry.

Most of Henry's time had been spent analyzing that alien genomic architecture while drafting the handwritten report.

Kingo sighed, flipping through the pages.

"I rescheduled filming. Cleared three days for you. I never expected this much progress in hours."

He had planned to grant Henry three full days for preliminary study. If Henry failed to produce something acceptable within that window, the "test" would effectively end.

Instead, Henry exceeded expectations.

In fact, Kingo felt a faint unease.

If this young Kryptonian could uncover so much so quickly... what else might he discover?

Henry, however, seemed genuinely curious.

"You've lived in modern society for centuries. Have you never conducted systematic health examinations?"

Kingo shook his head.

"Ajak—our healer—can directly cure injuries. We tell her where it hurts, or she sees the wound.

"We do not suffer disease. Only combat injuries require treatment. And I should clarify—human weapons cannot harm us."

"Understood."

Henry then asked, "Why did your people come to Earth? I assume it wasn't exile like my supposed Kryptonian background."

Kingo smiled.

"We were sent to protect Earth's civilization. Though not in the way you imagine. Not as caretakers.

"A hostile alien species—the Deviants—arrived here. We were deployed to eliminate them.

"That mission concluded centuries ago. Since then, we await recall orders.

"We do not interfere in human affairs.

"So no—before you ask—we did not participate in world wars. They were not our wars. Though... some among us disagreed."

Henry nodded.

He understood detachment.

Whether as a Kryptonian or as a transmigrator, he too lacked complete emotional belonging to Earth.

He had people he cared about.

But becoming a self-sacrificing superhero devoted to "saving the world"?

That wasn't him.

Kingo noticed Henry did not probe further about global conflicts. That subtle indifference reassured him. If Henry felt no inherited duty to Earth, negotiations would be simpler.

Setting aside the report, Kingo asked, "Is there more you can do?"

"To proceed further, I'd require biological samples. And potentially invasive procedures. We agreed not to go that far."

Chapter 415 415 — Australia

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From Mumbai, they flew directly to Perth International Airport in Western Australia.

The journey took eleven hours and ten minutes—nearly the operational limit of Kingo's private jet.

Kingo didn't hesitate. Once flight clearance was secured, they went straight through. It wasn't his first trip to Australia.

After clearing immigration in Perth, they refueled and continued inland, landing at a remote regional airstrip.

Karan Patel, ever efficient, retrieved a Ford Explorer from a storage hangar—one of the early SUVs that had defined the segment's popularity.

Because they were traveling with a tiger, the third-row seats were folded flat. The entire rear cargo space became Katie's territory.

"Have you figured out how to utilize cosmic energy?"

"Not yet. Understanding the mechanism isn't enough."

"I expected as much."

If Eternal abilities were so easily replicated, Kryptonians would be terrifying beyond reason.

After a moment, Kingo asked, "Would blood samples help?"

Henry blinked.

"Of course. But would you consent?"

Kingo considered.

"A new condition. If you help resolve my friend's condition—even providing a viable method or recommendation—I will give you fifty milliliters... no, one hundred milliliters of blood."

Henry smiled.

"Generous terms. I suppose I passed your test."

"You exceeded expectations, Kryptonian."

There was genuine satisfaction in Kingo's voice.

"Do you have time? We can visit my friend immediately."

"Where is she?"

"Australia."

Henry raised a brow.

"You're free? I assumed you were busier than I am."

Kingo grinned and winked.

"I have confidence in your efficiency."

Henry sighed.

"Very well. I have no urgent obligations. But what about our business agreement?"

Kingo thought for a moment.

"For contracts with American companies, it is best to comply with U.S. law. I'll dispatch someone from my side who holds a California legal license to negotiate detailed terms with Stark Pictures."

"Good. We'll draft a memorandum of understanding first—provide them a framework. By the time we return from Australia, the contract should be prepared. You'll come to Los Angeles to sign?"

Kingo chuckled.

"It's been a long time since I visited America. The last time I was in North America, it was during westward expansion. The locals weren't particularly welcoming to my complexion. I haven't returned since."

Henry gave a self-deprecating smile.

"Then I suppose I'm fortunate. This Kryptonian happens to look like a white man."

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Karan drove.

Henry and Kingo sat in the second row, continuing the conversation that had barely paused for the entire journey.

They had talked endlessly.

At first, film—Hollywood versus Bollywood, production culture, evolving cinematic language. Henry elaborated on digital filmmaking's future, emphasizing how computer-generated effects would expand storytelling possibilities.

Kingo even asked how Indian cinema might break into international markets.

On that topic, Henry was cautious.

Success had no universal formula. If it did, those who knew it would never publish it openly. What could be shared publicly were only conservative strategies—the kind that might succeed, and at worst avoid catastrophic failure.

Cultural barriers were formidable. Humor did not always translate. Emotional resonance depended heavily on shared historical context.

A crude example Henry mentioned:

An American man tells a foreign woman, "You look like a peach," and his friends burst into lewd laughter.

If the woman lacks familiarity with American slang, she might interpret it literally—sweet, pleasant, attractive. But in certain contexts, it carries overt sexual innuendo.

In American slapstick or raunchy comedies, audiences laugh.

Export that scene abroad, and reactions split—confusion or offense.

The reverse is equally true.

One approach for global crossover was packaging Western narrative frameworks in local aesthetics—lowering the comprehension barrier for Western audiences.

But Henry doubted that was the answer Kingo wanted.

So he declined to pretend expertise.

Beyond cinema, Henry learned far more about the Eternals' hidden history.

Their battles with the Deviants were indeed central—but far from the whole story.

The Deviants were intelligent beasts—no culture, driven purely by instinct to eradicate humanity. That alone justified the Celestials' deployment of the Eternals.

Yet they did not only interact with humans and Deviants.

In the 10th century, the Eternals migrated westward from Mesopotamia to Europe, and eventually to the Americas to eliminate the final Deviant strongholds.

Unexpectedly, they received assistance from an Asgardian—Thor Odinson.

After their final victory, they settled among the Maya civilization and were worshiped as gods—though in truth they were merely waiting for Celestial recall orders.

Henry suspected only Ajak truly knew the complete mission parameters. He wondered when Ikaris had been informed.

Then, in the 11th century—

War.

Between the Eternals and the Inhumans.

Yes—the Inhumans. The genetically modified humans engineered by the Kree as experimental super-soldiers. Eventually abandoned when the Kree Supreme Intelligence deemed them unnecessary.

The Inhumans had isolated themselves on the island of Attilan in the North Atlantic, developing advanced technology in secrecy.

Once the Deviants were eradicated, the Inhumans apparently decided they were ready to rule Earth.

They acted accordingly.

Had they remained confined to their island, the Eternals might have ignored them.

But conquest campaigns changed the equation.

To the Eternals, the Inhumans were Kree interference—non-native constructs.

They intervened decisively.

The outcome?

Most of the Inhumans elevated Attilan into space, relocating to the Blue Area of the Moon to avoid annihilation.

The Eternals resumed their vigil.

Ten of them.

Ten beings forced an entire advanced civilization into retreat.

The implication of that power was obvious.

Though, as Henry noted privately, perhaps that was before figures like Black Bolt had emerged as overwhelming anomalies.

Chapter 416 416 — The Place of Seclusion

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The drive from the small inland Australian airstrip to their destination took only an hour or two across the desert.

It was January—but in the Southern Hemisphere, that meant peak summer.

The heat was merciless.

Henry had packed for India, not for the Australian interior. Not that it mattered much for him—Kryptonians were unaffected by heat or cold. Clothing was merely social camouflage.

Katie, however, suffered.

Her thick winter coat—meant for snow and subzero wilderness—was utterly unsuited for desert heat. For a tiger built to roam icy forests, arriving suddenly in

Inhuman descendants remained scattered across Earth—but without Terrigen crystals, they could not awaken.

The Eternals chose not to exterminate them, as they had the Deviants.

Unawakened, they were simply human.

For centuries, the Eternals still interacted openly with humanity.

Some were revered as gods.

Others as sages.

Others as prophets.

That explained the scattered historical records Henry had found.

Their tension with mutants, however, stemmed from something more psychological.

In earlier eras, mutants awakening powers often developed god-complexes.

Those who believed themselves divine inevitably challenged those worshiped as divine.

Eternals did not adhere to "turn the other cheek."

They responded decisively.

Fortunately, ancient communication networks were primitive. Mutants were less numerous and less coordinated than in the modern age.

Thus most Eternal lives remained peaceful.

But whenever a newly awakened mutant arose nearby—especially an arrogant one—conflict was nearly inevitable.

The pattern created a sort of survivorship bias:

Flashy mutants sought them out—and were defeated.

Quiet mutants concealed themselves and lived unnoticed.

The observable data then simplified into a crude conclusion:

Mutants who challenged Eternals were crushed.

Which further hardened Eternal prejudice.

Kingo carefully framed mutant interference as one of the reasons the Eternals eventually retreated into obscurity.

Henry didn't press.

He had no interest in prying into wounds for the sake of "truth."

But he now understood far more about this world:

Deviants

Inhumans

Mutants

And the layered conflicts beneath human history

The picture of Earth was far more complex than he had assumed.

And far less stable.

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this climate was like being slow-roasted alive.

She drank enormous amounts of water and wedged herself in front of the SUV's air-conditioning vents, refusing to move.

Outside, the scenery shifted subtly but remained desolate. Endless yellow earth—not cinematic sand dunes, but still barren enough to evoke a deep loneliness.

Henry asked, "Kingo, your friends really chose to live somewhere this... empty?"

"Yes," Kingo replied, a trace of regret in his voice. "I told you—Mahd Wy'ry. Too many centuries of memory and knowledge burden the mind. To reduce strain, life must become simple. Repetitive."

"...That sounds unbearably lonely," Henry murmured.

After experiencing the stimulation of modern civilization, who could truly return to isolation—growing food, building everything by hand, surrounded by nothing?

It was why Henry, after escaping captivity in this world, hadn't chosen to disappear into Alaska or some frozen nowhere. He had returned to society.

Peaceful environments did not guarantee peaceful minds.

Sometimes they amplified inner spirals.

He knew that firsthand.

Nearly twenty years wasted in stagnation—

Well... the later years hadn't been wasted. They had been worse.

A flicker of darkness rose in his thoughts before Kingo interrupted.

"How lonely could it be? Thena has Gilgamesh."

Right.

Depression was not cured by silence—it required companionship. Someone to pull you out of quicksand.

"So two of your people live here?" Henry asked.

"Yes. I purchased this land for them."

"You bought it?" Henry blinked.

"Of course. This is modern society. You can't simply claim unoccupied land and build a house."

Fair point.

"They're lucky to have you," Henry said sincerely.

Kingo actually looked embarrassed.

"It's nothing. I simply have more money than most of the others. If they had the means, they would do the same."

"So you deliver supplies regularly?"

"Not anymore."

"Why?"

"At first, yes. But eating isn't essential for us. It's habit, not necessity.

"And Thena needs simplicity. Fewer possessions, fewer variables. At first we coordinated what to send. Too much. Too little.

"Eventually Gilgamesh got tired of the logistics. He told me to stop sending anything. He cleared land, grows corn and vegetables. It's enough."

Self-sufficiency.

Henry couldn't decide whether he admired it or feared it.

Suddenly Kingo brightened.

"Look! We're here. See that windmill? The house is near it."

The SUV slowed to a stop.

"We'll walk from here," Kingo said. "No engine noise. No disturbance."

"That's fine."

It felt grounding, walking on actual earth after so much air travel.

Katie, however, refused to exit.

When Henry opened the rear door, a wave of desert heat flooded in. The tiger visibly recoiled in disgust.

Henry grabbed her by the scruff and dragged her out.

"You're not staying inside. Once the engine shuts off, this car becomes an oven."

"Rrr."

—Lazy.

Chapter 417 417 — Two Generals of the Eternals

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To make a good first impression on this newly met Eternal, Henry had no choice but to sacrifice Katie's dignity.

A pet wasn't a wife.

Getting petted wouldn't cost her a chunk of flesh.

Still, when Katie raised a paw, clearly intending to shove Gilgamesh away, Henry instinctively stepped forward. He wasn't worried about the tiger hurting an Eternal—but if she shredded the man's clothes, that would be awkward.

He needn't have bothered.

True to his mythic reputation, Gilgamesh was no ordinary strongman. An elbow braced, a pivot, a casual twist of his torso—and Katie lost her balance, landing neatly on all fours.

Concern dissolved instantly.

A young adult tiger was simply no match for the Warrior King.

Gilgamesh, perceptive enough not to push things too far, released her before she truly erupted.

"Excuse me?" Henry kicked her lightly. "Who raised you? You dare say 'lazy' in front of me?"

Katie reluctantly followed.

The homestead was modest to the point of austerity.

A small adobe house.

A barn.

A sun-bleached canopy.

A windmill drawing groundwater upward.

Beneath the surface, however, the plumbing was surprisingly advanced. Water pumped into storage barrels at the windmill's base, then piped into the house. Waste flowed into a subterranean septic system.

Primitive exterior. Practical infrastructure.

Kingo's steps grew lighter as he approached and knocked.

He turned to Henry theatrically.

"Ladies and gentlemen, prepare yourselves. The mightiest warrior among the Eternals. The legendary strongman—Gilgamesh."

The door opened.

Not Ma Dong-seok.

Instead, a towering West Asian man—six-foot-five, roughly 260 pounds, black hair, green eyes. Broader than Henry, radiating sheer physical dominance.

If not for the pink checkered apron he was wearing.

"Kingo," he said flatly. "Who are they?"

"My dear friend," Kingo beamed. "This is my steward, Karan Patel. This is Henry Brown—a Kryptonian. And that is Katie."

They say even the toughest men love cats.

Gilgamesh's stern expression melted instantly at the sight of Katie panting with her tongue out.

"Hello, Katie."

He stepped forward and vigorously ruffled the tiger's head.

Katie had now encountered a second being with absurd physical strength.

Even using all four limbs, she couldn't escape his grip.

Her dignity suffered greatly.

But she was trapped.

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A thoroughly aggrieved Katie darted behind Henry, trying to use his comparatively thin legs as cover—despite being much larger than him.

The sight made Gilgamesh laugh heartily.

He stepped forward and extended a hand to Henry.

"A man who loves cats can't be all bad. So you're not some alien Kingo couldn't handle, dragged here for me to deal with."

Kingo protested immediately.

"Hey! What do you mean I couldn't handle him? When we hunted Deviants, I was a main force!"

"When your kill count has an extra zero, then we'll discuss who the main force was. Oh wait—the Deviants on Earth are extinct. I suppose you'll have to wait for our next mission to catch up."

The two old comrades bickered with easy familiarity.

Henry didn't interrupt. Nor did he leave Gilgamesh's hand hanging awkwardly. He shook it firmly.

"Pleasure to meet you. I hope our visit isn't too intrusive."

They released hands without any childish attempt at strength-testing.

That restraint didn't escape Henry's notice.

Gilgamesh was not merely brute force—there was awareness and control beneath the power. Seven thousand years of existence did not produce fools.

Before Gilgamesh could continue, Kingo hurriedly cut in.

"Where's Thena? I brought Henry to see if he can treat her Mahd Wy'ry."

Gilgamesh's expression turned skeptical. He pointed at Henry.

"He can? A Kryptonian? You're certain?"

Kingo replied, "He's like Sherlock Holmes—well, do you remember Sherlock Holmes? London, long coat, pipe-smoking nuisance. Never mind.

"Henry examined me for half a day and nearly deduced my entire genealogy. Kryptonian intelligence isn't exaggerated—they nearly brought the Skrull Empire to its knees as a single-planet civilization.

"So I thought—let him see Thena. Maybe he'll find something Ajak and Phastos never considered."

Gilgamesh looked back at Henry.

"Can you?"

"I've never seen this condition in person. I can't guarantee anything," Henry answered evenly. "I can only promise to do my best. Any proposal I make, you're free to judge for yourselves."

Gilgamesh nodded once.

"You may see her. But she doesn't know you. I can't predict her reaction."

He turned and walked toward the back of the property.

"Follow me."

Behind the house, near a weathered tree stripped nearly bare of leaves, a woman sat with her back to them.

Even without seeing her face, the platinum hair caught the blazing sunlight, reflecting brilliance that made it difficult to look away.

She wore a white linen robe—simple, breathable—yet it accentuated her silhouette with unintentional elegance.

If nothing else, the silhouette alone could kill.

They approached.

She did not turn.

Whether from indifference, loss of warrior vigilance, or simple trust in the footsteps she recognized—it was impossible to say.

Gilgamesh stepped forward.

"Thena. Kingo's here. He's brought a Kryptonian who claims he might help your condition."

The woman remained seated. Only her neck turned slightly.

Her profile appeared—exquisite yet distant. Like a Greek marble statue granted temporary life. Sunlight kissed her skin, making it glow.

"Cure Mahd Wy'ry?" she murmured softly. "Is that possible, Kryptonian?"

There was no hope in her tone. No desperation.

Only mild curiosity.

Chapter 418 418 — Diagnosis

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Being stared at by someone like Thena was profoundly unsettling.

Those hollow eyes felt as if they were trying to pull in another's soul to fill the void within.

She yearned for life—

and yet was indifferent to it.

Her own. Or anyone else's.

Standing before her, Henry felt like an insect hopping in front of a bullfrog. At any moment, a tongue could snap out—and he would simply cease to exist.

The sensation was disturbingly vivid.

After finishing attaching the two earpiece sensors, Henry instinctively stepped back several paces, almost as if retreating from danger.

If it came to a fight, he didn't believe he would lose—not even one against three combat-oriented Eternals.

But experience radiated differently than raw power.

The sheer battlefield aura Thena carried—unrestrained, ancient, honed over millennia—pressed down on him in a way he wasn't accustomed to. For a brief moment, he felt intimidated before any conflict even began.

That realization forced a quiet moment of self-reflection.

Henry smiled gently.

"There's no loss in looking. But if we don't look, there's no chance at all. Perhaps I truly can help."

Kingo, more anxious than Thena herself, asked, "Henry—you really have an idea?"

"Earlier, I didn't. Now, I have some thoughts. But I need to examine her first."

He directed the final question to Thena.

"Is that acceptable?"

She turned fully now, regarding him with calm detachment.

"Where will you examine me? Alone?"

"Wherever you're comfortable. No need to avoid anyone. I won't be conducting anything invasive."

Henry whistled.

Katie—doing her best to stay far from Gilgamesh—reluctantly padded over.

Henry removed the translation devices from behind her ears.

"These detect brainwave activity," he explained. "They aren't shaped for you, but we can improvise. Hook them over your ears or into your hair. As long as they don't fall."

Thena neither objected nor reached for them.

Henry gently brushed aside her pale hair, exposing one ear, and attached the modified device.

Up close, he studied her face.

Fortunately, she did not resemble Angelina Jolie.

No disrespect—just personal preference. Those famously full lips were not to Henry's taste.

This Thena—Athena minus an "A"—weapon master of the Eternals—had sharp, resolute lines. Not sweet or delicate, but cool and almost austere.

Her eyes, however, were hollow.

They should have burned with warrior's fire.

Instead, they resembled extinguished embers.

Beautiful.

But distant.

Like a goddess carved in stone—present, yet not entirely alive.

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No wonder these two had chosen isolation.

It wasn't only to ease Thena's burden.

It was to protect others from it.

If even he found it difficult to withstand her presence face-to-face, how could ordinary humans endure it?

He set the thought aside.

Now he needed to focus.

The tiger translator, of course, could not interpret Thena's brainwaves into language. That wasn't the goal.

Henry was listening to the raw, high-frequency transcribed output—the indirect signal patterns.

Brainwaves couldn't be observed directly. They required instrumentation.

At first, Gilgamesh didn't understand what Henry was doing. From his perspective, the Kryptonian simply placed the devices and then stood there, listening to something invisible.

He was about to speak when Kingo quickly pressed a finger to his lips and gestured toward his ear.

"Listen," Kingo whispered. "High frequency."

Gilgamesh focused.

Now he heard it—a faint, chaotic, piercing tone in a register most humans couldn't perceive.

After a short period, Henry began guiding gently:

"Alright. Please adjust into a posture you find comfortable. Close your eyes. Listen to my voice.

"Recall the happiest experience you can remember."

"..."

"Don't say it aloud. Just think it. If none exists, then let me know."

"...Understood."

"Now recall a moment of triumph. Perhaps after a battle victory. Or after drinking every man under the table."

...

"Oh. That emotion is strong. Good.

"Now recall your sweetest memory. Embracing a lover. Skin against skin."

"I have no such memory," Thena said flatly.

"Ah. Understood. Moving on.

"Recall something that made you angry."

A spike.

"Alright, that's enough. I won't ask who provoked that."

Henry quickly adjusted before inviting physical retaliation.

"Now calm yourself.

"Imagine lying in a vast grassland. The grass supports your body, separating you from the soil—but you can still smell the earth.

"The sky is blue. The clouds are white.

"The sun is warm—not harsh. Everything is peaceful.

"When you feel calm, open your eyes."

What Henry didn't notice immediately was that Kingo, Gilgamesh—even Karan Patel—had unconsciously followed along.

They were breathing slower.

Their heartbeats had synchronized with Henry's voice.

At first, Henry matched their rhythm.

But gradually, the rhythm shifted.

Their pulses began matching his cadence.

It was close to hypnosis.

Fortunately, Henry had no intention of exploiting that state.

Three Eternals falling under influence would have been catastrophic.

Once awareness returned fully, Kingo immediately asked,

"Well?"

"Give me a moment," Henry said. "I have a question."

He addressed Thena directly.

"Thena—during the guided recall, did unrelated memories intrude? Images you did not intentionally summon?"

"Yes."

"Thank you."

"I believe I understand."

Gilgamesh leaned forward.

"What do you mean?"

Chapter 419 - 419 — The Solution

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Henry asked Thena again,

"In the fragments you remember—your companions' personalities, their manner of speaking—are they identical to the people in your real memories?"

Thena considered briefly, then shook her head.

"No. They feel... like different people."

"Then treat those memories as not truly yours," Henry said calmly. "Perhaps it's the mind's compensatory mechanism—overlaying unfamiliar memories onto familiar faces to make sense of them."

"Sit down," Henry said calmly.

He pulled out a sketchpad and pencil from his bag.

"At first, Kingo told me Mahd Wy'ry results from accumulated centuries of memory and knowledge overwhelming the brain."

He began writing across the page—line after line—until it became densely packed and nearly illegible.

"According to that explanation, the mind is overloaded."

He held up the page, filled edge to edge with text.

"But Thena's case doesn't resemble overload."

He picked up an eraser.

"If I want to keep writing on this page, what do I do?"

Gilgamesh answered immediately.

"Erase the old writing."

"Correct."

Henry erased hastily—not thoroughly—leaving faint traces beneath.

Then he wrote again over the partially erased page, leaving gaps, overlaps, ghost impressions.

He turned the page toward them.

"This is closer to Thena's condition."

The Eternals studied it.

Gilgamesh spoke carefully.

"You're suggesting... there are memories that aren't hers interfering with her own?"

Henry did not correct the wording.

Not hers... or not from this life?

Instead, he asked gently,

"Thena. The intrusive fragments—do you recognize their content?"

She answered slowly.

"No.

"They appear to take place in the Centauri system. Not on Earth.

"Our companions are present—but the one leaving these memories... appears to be me."

Silence fell.

This was not cognitive overload.

It was residual imprint.

Layered existence.

And if Henry's suspicion was correct—

This was not madness.

It was a system fault in something far older than Thena herself

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Kingo cut in, "Do you have a solution, Henry?"

"I have an idea."

"Then say it," Gilgamesh urged.

Even Thena, who had long resigned herself to living this way, showed a flicker of interest. The emptiness in her gaze softened slightly.

Henry opened his sketchbook again.

This time, he used two different colored pencils, writing overlapping text in the same space.

"Have you ever played this game?" he asked. "When two colors of text overlap, and you want to see only one—what do you do?"

The three Eternals stared blankly.

Henry sighed lightly.

"You place a transparent filter of the same color over it. The unwanted color disappears, leaving only the target text visible.

"I don't have colored film with me to demonstrate. But you understand the principle?"

This time, they nodded.

Henry continued.

"Simply put—we build a neural filter.

"It would detect the brainwave frequency corresponding to the intrusive memory fragments and generate an opposing waveform to cancel them out."

He tapped the page.

"Thena's normal memories and the interfering fragments operate on distinct frequency patterns. I don't need to worry about filtering the wrong signal—they're clearly separable.

"Suppress the intrusive signal. Reduce its cortical response. The interference stops."

Kingo frowned.

"Suppress, not erase. So the memories still exist?"

"Yes," Henry replied patiently.

"All biological brains—Eternals included—don't store memory like stone carvings or ink on paper.

"Memories move from short-term to long-term storage. If not revisited for long periods, they sink deeper into inactive layers and eventually fade from accessible recall.

"The brain discards what it deems unnecessary.

"I assume even you cannot recall what you ate for breakfast and dinner on a random day five thousand years ago?"

Gilgamesh cleared his throat awkwardly.

"Actually... I can. Which date would you like?"

Kingo and Thena both leaned away from him in visible irritation.

Kingo said bluntly, "Ignore him. You think he's this big because of bone structure? Henry's right. We don't remember trivial details like that."

Henry suppressed a sigh and continued smoothly.

"Thena's problem isn't memory volume.

"It's uncontrolled recall frequency.

"The intrusive fragments activate repeatedly, without her intent. That constant activation increases cognitive load and destabilizes her mental state.

"If we suppress those specific activation patterns, her brain regains equilibrium."

He gestured lightly.

"Think of it as noise-canceling headphones. When external noise is detected, the device emits an inverse wave, neutralizing the sound.

"I propose building a device that does exactly that—for those specific brainwave signatures."

He added:

"This only works because Eternal neural patterns are extraordinarily precise and consistent. Human brainwaves are far too chaotic for such targeted filtering—unless you're someone like Professor X.

"My confidence is based on my research into telepathic defense systems."

The three Eternals exchanged uncertain glances.

Henry clarified further.

"Let me be clear. This is not a cure.

"It is correction.

"Like glasses for nearsighted humans."

Chapter 420 - 420 — Sound-Absorbing Steel

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Henry had played a small trick here.

Instead of discussing who should pay the reward, he simply accepted triple compensation.

It wasn't price gouging—these Eternal heavyweights had offered it voluntarily. Henry merely smiled and accepted.

True, it might not align with strict commercial ethics. But fresh Eternal blood—three separate samples from three different individuals—was simply too tempting to refuse.

He paused.

"You do know what glasses are, correct?"

Gilgamesh rolled his eyes.

"Yes. We know what glasses are."

"Good."

Henry turned back to Kingo.

"If the device is damaged, Thena reverts to her previous state. Then we build another one. That's all.

"Does that satisfy our agreement?"

Kingo nodded slowly.

"I wanted a solution. Not necessarily a cure. I can accept this. But are you certain it will work?"

"I won't collect payment until I verify effectiveness," Henry said lightly. "No risk of me taking the blood and running."

"Payment?" Gilgamesh asked.

Kingo answered openly.

"I promised Henry that if he resolves Thena's condition, I'll give him one vial of my blood.

"He originally wanted to study our armor system—but you know that requires access to the Domo.

"I think a hundred milliliters of blood is reasonable compensation—if this works."

"One vial? That much?" Gilgamesh asked uncertainly.

"Not much. About a hundred milliliters. Roughly the volume of one finger."

He added dryly,

"My finger. Not yours."

Gilgamesh immediately said,

"If that's all, I'll donate too. If he helps Thena."

Thena spoke calmly.

"I will as well."

Henry blinked.

"Well. Originally, this was only between Kingo and me. But if you're willing... that triples my compensation.

"I have no reason not to give this everything I've got.

"Are you certain?"

"Of course," Gilgamesh said firmly.

The matter was settled.

Three Eternals.

Three samples of Celestial-engineered biology.

For Henry—

The real research was only beginning.

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From how readily they agreed, it was obvious the condition had troubled them for a very long time. They were willing to overlook even a tripled reward.

Still, if he disappointed them, the consequences would likely be... unpleasant.

After reaching agreement, Henry stood up, brushing dust from his clothes.

"Since we're settled, I'll return to the U.S. and produce a prototype as soon as possible. When it's ready, I'll have Kingo's butler arrange delivery."

Gilgamesh looked disappointed.

"You can't make it here?"

"I'd love to," Henry said helplessly, spreading his hands. "But I don't exactly have materials with me."

"Materials..." Gilgamesh suddenly remembered something. "Wait here."

He dashed back into the house and returned moments later, holding a fist-sized stone. Its base shimmered silver, threaded with blue crystalline light.

At first glance, Henry's heart skipped a beat.

He had just confidently concluded that kryptonite didn't exist in this universe.

And now an Eternal casually produced a glowing blue rock.

Blue kryptonite? What does that even do here?

Gilgamesh didn't notice Henry's brief alarm.

"This is sound-absorbing steel," he said. "You mentioned something about absorbing sound waves to help Thena. Can you use this?"

"Sound-absorbing steel?"

Then it clicked.

Vibranium.

"May I?" Henry asked.

Gilgamesh simply extended his palm without hesitation.

Henry first touched the glowing blue portions cautiously. His abilities showed no abnormal reaction. Only then did he fully take the vibranium ore and examine it carefully.

"Where did you get this?"

"When I was in Africa, someone threw it at me. Hurt quite a bit," Gilgamesh replied casually. "So I kept it. It's great for throwing at people too."

Of course it is.

Holding raw vibranium for the first time, Henry carefully studied the fictional super-metal's properties.

Gilgamesh leaned forward eagerly.

"Well? Can you use it? If there's any left over after you make the device, you can keep that too."

Henry looked at the three hopeful Eternals and sighed.

"Do you have any idea how valuable vibranium is?"

"Doesn't matter," Gilgamesh shrugged. "If it works, use it."

Henry nodded slowly.

"Yes. It's not just usable—it's better than what I originally planned."

He explained:

"My original design required an external power source. I'd need to test and evaluate energy consumption before determining battery capacity.

"But vibranium absorbs and stores energy inherently. That eliminates the need for charging systems."

He paused.

"However... I'll need to redesign everything around this material. And proper fabrication would normally require specialized equipment.

"Are you in a hurry?"

The three Eternals nodded in perfect unison.

Henry scratched his head.

"Of course you are."

He sighed.

"Fine. I'm already taking triple compensation. I'll do it here."

He then added seriously,

"Don't mention what you're about to see."

Then he remembered the fourth person present.

His gaze shifted toward Kingo's Indian butler.

The man immediately put on an innocent smile and awkwardly rocked side to side.

Before Kingo could speak, Henry cut in:

"Mr. Patel, I understand Kingo trusts you. But this concerns my personal privacy—not just Eternal matters. Would you mind stepping away?"

The butler nodded gracefully.

"I just remembered we brought supplies in the car. I'll prepare dinner."

Kingo gave him permission.

Once Patel left, Kingo complained lightly,

"Really, Henry? He's been with me over twenty years."

Henry said nothing.

Instead, he gripped the vibranium ore with both hands—

And twisted.

With raw force, he snapped off a smaller chunk.

Then—

Chapter 421 421 — Vibranium Jewelry

Twin beams of red heat vision flared from his eyes.

Temperature rising.

As one of Earth's strongest metals, vibranium was notoriously difficult to process. Captain America's shield had been a historical accident. Even Howard Stark once claimed he could not replicate it.

That was likely due to material scarcity rather than technical limitation—but that didn't help Henry now.

Wakanda possessed full vibranium processing technology.

Henry had... heat vision and brute force.

Kingo stared in shock.

"Alright," he muttered. "That's definitely not normal."

Thena and Gilgamesh didn't look much better.

Gilgamesh leaned toward Kingo and whispered,

"You said he's from where?"

"Krypton."

"Kryptonians can do that?"

"Apparently."

Henry ignored them.

The ore resisted melting.

Heat flooded in—

And was absorbed into the molecular lattice.

Stored.

Not liquefied.

He narrowed his eyes, increasing output.

Still no melting.

He recalled the lore:

Specific vibrational frequencies could suppress vibranium's absorption properties.

Energy beyond its storage threshold could fracture it.

That's how the Black Panther suit discharged accumulated kinetic energy—otherwise it would eventually overload and rupture.

Henry muttered to himself.

"Fine. If you want vibration..."

He shifted strategy.

Instead of pure thermal energy, he modulated his heat vision—introducing oscillating micro-frequency pulses.

Controlled.

Precise.

The vibranium's blue glow intensified.

The internal energy matrix destabilized.

There—

A faint structural softening.

Henry's lips curved slightly.

"Got you."

He increased the frequency shift incrementally, maintaining heat input while pushing the lattice toward resonance instability.

A thin seam formed.

Not melting—

But workable.

Behind him, three ancient super-beings watched in silence as a Kryptonian casually began reverse-engineering vibranium metallurgy in the Australian desert.

And for the first time—

They understood why entire interstellar empires once feared Krypton.

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Henry steadily increased the temperature of his heat vision.

At the same time, he emitted sound waves from his mouth—starting at low frequency and gradually increasing—carefully testing which frequency band could suppress vibranium's metallic properties.

Then—

At a certain threshold, everything clicked into place.

The small chunk of vibranium ore in his hand suddenly glowed red and liquefied, pooling in his palm like a round, crimson droplet of molten metal.

As for impurities, Henry didn't even need to remove them intentionally. Once the ore melted, non-vibranium materials naturally floated to the surface.

He pulled a fine needle from his bag and gently scraped them away, leaving pure vibranium in his hand.

Ordinarily, vibranium was alloyed with other metals before use. Even Wakanda's Black Panther suit was made from vibranium alloy, not pure vibranium.

Pure vibranium itself wasn't especially hard. If it were, it couldn't be drawn into fibers. Its legendary "hardness" was largely an illusion created by its ability to absorb kinetic and other forms of energy into its molecular bonds.

To increase true structural hardness, it had to be alloyed.

For example, one component of adamantium—the metal bonded to Wolverine's skeleton—included vibranium.

But Henry didn't need hardness.

He needed absorption—and controlled release of inverse waves.

Pure vibranium was ideal.

Besides, alloy formulas involving vibranium were notoriously difficult to discover and often the result of luck. Henry had neither the time nor the desire to experiment with metallurgy recipes.

His super-brain finalized a design instantly.

Ignoring the extreme heat, he shaped the molten vibranium like clay.

With the needle, he carved intricate patterns into the still-soft surface before it fully cooled.

These weren't decorative engravings.

They were circuitry.

Specific brainwave frequencies would be absorbed upon contact, guided along these patterned channels like a circuit board. The structure would then generate an inverse waveform, precisely canceling the targeted neural signal.

Absorbed energy would be converted and released immediately, preventing overload accumulation.

Other brainwave frequencies would simply dissipate. It offered no telepathic shielding—its function was singular and precise.

The first prototype took the shape of a headband.

Henry exhaled a burst of freezing breath, rapidly cooling and solidifying the metal. Only polishing remained.

Without bothering to finish aesthetics, he handed the headband to Thena.

"Try it."

The three Eternals had been stunned into silence by the entire process.

Kingo even leaned close to Henry's face, squinting.

"If you were a heavyset black man, I'd assume you were Phastos in disguise.

"Or maybe you are Phastos. Did Sprite help you fool us? Drop the illusion—I've seen through it!"

Henry pushed Kingo's face aside with one hand and offered the headband again with the other.

"Just try it. No downside. You know how to wear a headband, right?"

Thena examined it carefully, turning it over in her hands.

It looked ordinary.

Could something so simple really help?

After a moment, she placed it over her platinum hair.

The moment it settled into position—

The noise vanished.

Completely.

Her hands hadn't even dropped from the band yet when her eyes widened.

Silence.

No whispering.

about:blank

No intrusive images flashing across her mind.

Just stillness.

She wasn't even looking at anyone in particular—she was simply experiencing what it felt like to exist without the constant interference.

Gilgamesh rushed forward.

"Thena? Does it work?"

She nodded slowly.

Both hands pressed against the sides of the band, as if afraid to let go.

Kingo and Gilgamesh erupted like children, jumping and cheering.

Henry was pulled into the celebration, spun around in their enthusiasm.

At one point both Eternals hugged him from either side, nearly tearing up.

"You did it, Henry!"

"Exceeded expectations," Henry replied, bending to pick up the vibranium ore.

He had used less than one-twentieth of the original stone. Most remained intact.

He had no intention of claiming the nearly whole piece as payment.

"There's plenty left," he said. "Let's make backups.

"That way you can rotate them daily—and not panic if one gets lost. Unless you somehow lose all of them at once."

Gilgamesh laughed loudly in agreement and clapped Henry on the back.

Hard.

Bang bang.

Only after doing so did he realize what he'd done.

Henry remained standing.

Unaffected.

Gilgamesh blinked.

Henry grimaced slightly.

"Ease up. A normal person would've been launched into orbit."

"No one's launching you anywhere," Gilgamesh declared proudly. "If someone tries, tell me first. I'll launch them."

Ignoring the boastful Eternal, Henry sat down again in front of Thena.

"Any preferred jewelry styles?

"Animals? Plants? Flowers?

"Oh—and I still need to polish the headband. You'll have to give it back eventually."

Thena subtly recoiled, reluctant to remove it.

Henry sighed.

"I'll make a replacement first. Then I'll finish the original."

She studied him.

"Can you make anything?"

"Only things I've seen. If you ask for a flower native to your homeworld, I'm out of luck—unless you describe it first."

He opened his sketchbook and quickly drew options:

Headbands. Hairpins. Earrings. Studs. Nose rings. Lip rings. Brow rings. Even eyeglass frames.

On impulse, he sketched Thena wearing rectangular thin-framed glasses, her hair neatly tied back, pearl earrings understated and elegant.

She looked like a stern executive.

Or an unapproachable professor.

Kingo suddenly leaned over Henry's shoulder, arm slung around him.

"So this is your type? The abstinent, no-nonsense woman?"

Henry stroked his smooth chin thoughtfully.

"Maybe. Don't you think this style suits her?"

Thena glanced once at the sketch.

"Not bad."

Her tone revealed nothing.

But for the first time—

There was something resembling light in her eyes.

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Chapter 422 422 — “Rich and Naive, Easy Target!”

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The cooperation agreement between Stark Pictures and Bollywood's Kingo Film Company quickly became a hot topic in Hollywood circles.

Neither company was publicly listed, so they weren't obligated to disclose full details. But when technology transfer is involved, secrecy only goes so far.

The two parties had established a joint venture subsidiary in India. Once the business scope and product lines were announced, it became obvious what Bollywood had gained.

Every piece of cinema-grade digital imaging equipment and related software developed under Henry Brown's leadership was now available through the Indian subsidiary—serving South Asia, Central Asia, and West Asia.

What truly caught industry attention was Henry's region-lock strategy.

Products designated for the Indian subsidiary could not function outside their licensed markets.

Even if someone shipped Indian equipment to Hollywood—Stark branding and all—Los Angeles would refuse repair and warranty service.

Worse, footage shot on Indian-region cameras could not be edited in Stark's rental post-production studios. Nor could locked-region projectors play restricted files.

On paper, it looked like global expansion.

To insiders, it was a joke.

India? Central Asia? West Asia?

What profit was there?

They would've understood a partnership with Sony Japan. At least Japan could offer significant returns.

The only person who could have stopped this deal was Stark Pictures' chairman—Tony Stark.

But the infamous billionaire playboy was reportedly too busy indulging in models and nightlife to care. Whether he ignored the matter or simply didn't mind, Stark Pictures allowed Henry Brown to proceed unchecked.

According to internal leaks, Henry had exchanged his patent revenue share for equity in the Indian subsidiary.

In other words, Stark Pictures' actual profits in digital imaging remained largely unchanged. Henry simply redirected his own earnings.

No one could confirm the details.

But one conclusion spread rapidly throughout Hollywood:

Henry Brown, the tech genius—

Was a bookish fool.

They might as well hang a sign around his neck:

"Naive. Loaded. Come fleece me."

Henry found the rumor both ridiculous and convenient.

Was he supposed to publicly announce that behind this deal he had acquired:

Three vials of Eternal blood from three different individuals?

Roughly eleven pounds of purified vibranium?

In Marvel canon, vibranium once sold for \$10,000 per gram.

Ignoring inflation and timeline discrepancies—

Eleven pounds was roughly five kilograms.

Five thousand grams.

Fifty million dollars.

And that was purified vibranium, not raw ore.

Of course, Henry couldn't liquidate it.

But still.

Very fragrant profit.

He had no intention of advertising any of it.

Neither vibranium nor Eternal blood was merely "valuable."

Exposure meant death.

Henry might not fear dying.

But dealing with waves of suicidal opportunists would be exhausting.

Let them mock him.

He'd rather feast on shark fin and bird's nest in private than boast publicly and invite disaster.

And amusingly—

The ridicule brought unexpected benefits.

The group Tony Stark had instructed him to monitor finally began making contact.

Unlike the previous schemers and opportunists, these newcomers weren't desperate or crude.

They didn't reach for his wallet.

They offered resources.

Quality resources.

The kind that made one feel like they'd stepped into the inner circle of the Big Eight studios.

Nothing was explicitly priced.

But Henry understood the strategy:

Provide first.

Collect later.

And human favors were far harder to repay than money.

Across the negotiation table now sat seasoned Jewish financiers.

Their philosophy?

Trade sesame seeds for watermelons.

Offer one unit of goodwill.

Demand ten in return.

Henry didn't reject them outright.

He selected what was genuinely useful.

Declined what wasn't.

This wasn't forced commerce.

And not every "good resource" was free of traps.

It had become a fishing match.

Float rising.

Line tightening.

But who was the fisherman—and who the fish?

That remained unclear.

Henry understood their urgency.

Rumors painted him as a reckless academic squandering Stark's leverage.

Everyone wanted a slice of the cake before it vanished.

They believed he was soft.

Squeezable.

Henry ignored outside gossip.

But concerns from the person sharing his bed were harder to dismiss.

Charlize Theron had been busy attending auditions lately, leaving less time for formal acting training. Whenever she had free time, Henry practiced with her—and afterward, they relaxed together.

Proper release reduced stress.

For young people, it mattered.

Now, resting in his arms, Charlize asked casually:

"Everything's okay lately... right?"

To an outsider, it sounded vague.

To Henry, it was crystal clear.

He held her closer.

"Don't worry. Everything's going according to plan."

"Plan? What plan?"

He couldn't explain the Eternal matter.

But Tony Stark's confidential assignment?

That could be partially disclosed.

Charlize's eyes widened.

"You mean Mr. Stark made you CEO... to use you as some kind of undercover agent?"

Henry smiled faintly.

"Let's just say... I'm the bait."

And somewhere in Los Angeles—

The sharks were circling.

Exactly as intended.

~~~~~

Chapter 423 423 — The Audition Invitation

Seeing Charlize's wide-eyed expression—so close it was practically filling his vision—Henry couldn't help but kiss her forehead.

"It's not as dangerous as you're imagining," he said gently.

"Think about Jen. Her advantage is her perspective and the level of people she interacts with. She has access to better information. That's how she finds you quality auditions and knows where to apply pressure to increase your chances.

"What Tony wants me to do is similar. I'm just an extra pair of eyes on the West Coast. Paying attention to certain wealthy circles. Nothing illegal. Nothing dangerous.

"No breaking into houses. No stealing documents. Even if Tony asked, I wouldn't do that. So you can relax."

He continued calmly,

"But you know my background. Someone like me doesn't just get accepted into that circle out of nowhere. So sometimes you need... a little maneuvering.

"Sure, the reputation isn't flattering. Let them gossip. Let them wait for me to fail like I'm a circus clown. It doesn't matter."

"So you're betting everything on Mr. Stark?" Charlize interpreted.

Henry laughed softly.

"I'm not Jewish. That's already a disadvantage in Hollywood. If I want to climb the ladder properly, I'd have to work twice as hard for half the recognition.

"And if I refuse to play the game at all, then I'd just be surviving under someone else's terms. You don't think that road is easier, do you?"

Charlize buried her face against his chest, thinking.

Henry spoke more seriously.

"I'm telling you this not because I need your help. And definitely not because I want you taking risks for me.

"If anything involving me comes up, come talk to me. Don't act based on what others tell you.

"You remember those 'casting agents' who claimed they could guarantee roles if actresses 'cooperated'?"

She nodded.

"Most of them had zero authority. Just names on paperwork. Using fake leverage to exploit people. Some even targeted male actors.

"That's what information imbalance does—it gets weaponized."

He brushed her hair back.

"So follow your plan. You and Jen have a rhythm. Keep climbing steadily as an actress.

"I'll support you where I can. And if anyone crosses your red line, you walk away. I'll handle the rest.

"Focus on what you're meant to do. That's the biggest help you can give me."

Charlize tilted her head slightly.

"Sometimes it feels like I'm your public cover. The distraction."

Henry chuckled.

"Depends how you look at it. I won't deny that your visibility helps. But helping Tony is incidental. I wouldn't even bother if it weren't for you.

"So protect yourself. Focus on your goals. The rest doesn't matter."

She nodded quietly.

After a moment, she added,

"But earlier you said climbing Hollywood the straight way is hard. Sometimes you need alternative routes. Isn't that the same for me?"

Henry shook his head.

"As long as we're excluding illegal or dirty deals, here's how I see it:

"If you want to follow the Golden Age model—always the leading lady, always the princess—it's possible. But in this era, that requires heavy backing. Like Nicole Kidman or Meg Ryan.

"And one or two box office failures? Capital drops you instantly."

He continued:

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"I don't want you trapped in a single image.

"Lead roles—yes. Supporting roles—also yes.

"Action. Comedy. Horror. Romance. Thriller. If the project's good, do it.

"The broader your range, the longer your career lasts. Longevity beats princess status.

"We're here to make money—not to be adored as royalty for a decade and fade away."

Charlize frowned slightly.

"But if I appear too often, won't audiences get tired of me?"

"Only if you look the same every time," Henry replied.

"Don't be the actor who can't stand looking messy. Let audiences finish two films and only realize during the credits that it's the same person.

"That's success.

"You get paid twice. And no one calls you repetitive."

He grinned.

"Besides, anyone can look ugly. Looking stunning? That's rare. That's your advantage.

"Though admittedly, that means competing in a crowded field."

She narrowed her eyes playfully and grabbed him.

"Now I see where you're sneaky."

Henry laughed.

"Speaking of which—I do have a solid audition opportunity. Talk it over with Jen. If you're interested, the chances are good."

"What project?"

"1492 Pictures. Jingle All the Way. Christmas release. Arnold Schwarzenegger starring. Directed by Brian Levant."

She blinked.

"You think that's good?"

"Actually, Rita Wilson approached me directly. She said the film's very male-heavy. She's the only major female presence and wanted balance.

"There's a supporting police role that could be rewritten as female. Strong screen presence. Uniform. Big sunglasses."

Charlize tried to recall.

"Rita Wilson is...?"

"Tom Hanks' wife. They have two kids—one born last year. If she's reaching out, there's likely goodwill from Hanks behind it."

Charlize smirked slightly.

"Goodwill from Jewish Hollywood?"

Henry shrugged.

"At least they're not the predatory kind. If we're going to owe someone a favor, we should choose carefully."

She nodded.

"I'll talk to Jen and follow up."

Henry tightened his arms around her slightly.

Outside, Hollywood buzzed with rumors.

Inside, the game continued—

Quietly.

Strategically.

Exactly as intended

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Chapter 424 424 — Progress on the Secret Research

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The exhausted girl slept soundly.

She rarely stayed the night at Henry's place. But whenever she did, she slept especially well—as if she had found a safe harbor. The nightmares that once startled her awake had not visited in a long time.

Henry, however, was far from restful.

Holding someone soft and fragrant in his arms was one of life's pleasures—but the pile of research waiting for him had grown too large.

Most of the digital imaging development had already been handed over to Stark Pictures' technical teams. Henry functioned more as a guide—occasionally correcting their course to ensure they didn't veer off track.

His real workload lay elsewhere.

In projects no one else could assist with.

Research into Eternal blood related to future battlesuit development—but Henry wasn't in a hurry. Threats like exotic solar radiation or kryptonite weren't imminent.

Vibranium was the same. Without a clear purpose, crafting random gadgets would be a waste. Anything he made casually would likely end up as a paperweight—or a brick.

His true focus remained the Kree and Skrull storage crystals he had taken from the Kree cruiser months ago.

If he could extract usable alien technology—especially in the field of energy—it would change everything.

Recreating a device to read alien storage crystals wasn't difficult. He had seen the original hardware; duplicating the read-spectrum system on Earth posed little challenge.

The real difficulty lay elsewhere.

The data.

Mountains of alien-language documentation.

Without foundational knowledge or matching equipment, most of it was theoretical castles in the sky.

Worse—

Much of it was incomprehensible.

This was a Kryptonian with a super-brain.

And yet, without structured indexing or guided progression, mastering alien science from scratch left him without a clear starting point.

Mar-Vell, the original Kree scientist owner of these archives, had not thoughtfully labeled sections as:

"Primary School Level"

"Secondary Education"

"University Core Curriculum"

"Do Not Proceed Without Prerequisites"

So Henry resorted to brute-force absorption.

Read everything.

Memorize everything.

Search for threads.

Attempt to reconstruct the technological tree.

By comparison, learning Kree and Skrull languages through reading was child's play.

With some prior exposure to Kree, Henry quickly abandoned translating into English and began reading the original texts directly.

Skrull was manageable because the archives included comparative translations between Skrull and Kree.

Even so—

After several months, he could meaningfully understand less than ten percent of the material.

Partly due to limited daily time allocation.

But also because the knowledge truly reflected the level of a professional scientist. Very little was simple.

What he could understand most readily?

Mathematics.

Apparently, math really was universal.

Technical terminology, however, often left him staring blankly.

Still, there was progress.

Henry categorized the Kree data into:

1. Reference Literature — Established, verified knowledge.
2. Research Notes — Mar-Vell's hypotheses, experimental stages, and partial errors.

He chose to focus first on the reference material.

That didn't mean the research notes were trivial. In fact, Mar-Vell's work on the Pegasus Project, the light-speed engine, and Tesseract studies were all in that category.

Henry simply wasn't prioritizing them yet.

Skrull technology archives contained not only documents—but vast genetic libraries.

There was also something resembling a Skrull Imperial Encyclopedia.

Biology.

Minerals.

History.

Territorial expansion.

Technological evolution.

It even contained an entry on Krypton—classified as a defeated civilization.

Many extinct civilizations followed.

The common conclusion?

"Not worth preservation."

The sheer arrogance was chilling.

The Skrulls had clearly intended to rebuild elsewhere—why else carry a cultural archive during their escape?

And they did not record extermination as shame.

They recorded it as merit.

As achievement.

The version Henry possessed was incomplete—only directory structures and summaries were accessible. The deeper content was encrypted.

He didn't rush to break that encryption.

Even the accessible encyclopedia dramatically expanded his understanding of the galactic landscape.

Cross-referencing Skrull summaries allowed him to interpret Kree materials more effectively.

He was no longer just decoding equations.

But mastering two galactic empires' science overnight?

Impossible.

Materials science alone posed massive barriers.

Many raw elements used in alien technologies simply did not exist on Earth.

Without materials, you needed substitutes.

Substitutes weren't documented in alien manuals.

Henry felt like a butcher who had paid dearly to learn dragon-slaying techniques—only to discover dragons did not exist.

Henry would never risk building alien-tech prototypes inside old Gary's apartment building.

If the FBI ever raided again, he couldn't rely on self-destruct theatrics twice.

He needed a base.

A proper one.

The funds from Sony's settlement and Tony Stark's concessions made serious infrastructure viable.

An underwater laboratory?

A submarine?

Or—

The Watchtower space station?

He paused that thought immediately.

In DC lore, the Watchtower got invaded or crashed constantly. It was practically a mandatory tourist destination for alien conquerors.

Without Bruce Wayne-level finances, constructing something that fell from orbit every other year was... unwise.

Chapter 425 425 — An Upgrade in Treatment

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Ever since Henry acquired the label "naive and loaded," he had noticeably become more popular.

Even the high-and-mighty industry elites—those who usually looked down on everyone—now greeted him with a few extra smiles.

No matter how you dressed it up, filmmaking was a high-risk investment.

Between creative accounting black holes and labyrinthine revenue structures, it was nearly impossible for outsiders to determine whether a film truly made money.

But when disasters like last year's Cutthroat Island happened—a \$98 million budget with barely \$10 million at the box office—it could bankrupt a studio outright.

That was why Hollywood's "Big Eight" studios were always shifting. Sometimes they couldn't even maintain a full eight.

An investor capable of sharing risk was valuable.

An investor foolish enough to provide money without knowing how to reclaim it?

Even better.

Turning a blockbuster into a paper loss through accounting tricks was practically a traditional Hollywood art form.

Wall Street investors—frequent victims—knew that best.

And yet, newcomers kept diving into the pit, time and again proving just how deep Hollywood's hole could be.

Even insiders weren't immune. Many had seen promised backend profits vanish with a single phrase:

"The film lost money."

So how could someone like Henry—backed by Stark Pictures and Stark Industries, seemingly an insider but essentially an outsider—not be welcomed?

If he wanted to, he could attend a party or banquet every night.

And if he wanted to go further—different encounters every night wouldn't be difficult either.

Of course, Henry wasn't foolish enough to accept everything.

But neither did he reject everything coldly.

If he suddenly turned into a shut-in nerd who went straight home after work, he might very well receive a dismissal notice from Tony Stark the next day.

After all, his primary assignment was to observe the West Coast—not to tinker with cameras all day.

Stark Industries didn't need him for scraps of technical development.

Missiles were consumables.

Cameras weren't.

Henry didn't deliberately curry favor with anyone.

He simply chose whom to engage with based on temperament.

Now that invitations were abundant, the power of choice had shifted to him.

Sure, many invitations still carried the subtext:

"It's an honor for you to be invited. Declining would be rude."

But in reality, declining carried little consequence.

Henry mentally crossed it off.

For now.

Energy first.

Then infrastructure.

Then—

The real leap forward

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Henry knew people viewed him as a fool.

He even leaned into the persona of a tech-obsessed bookworm.

But no one truly dared treat him as one.

Sony's lesson loomed large.

Henry Brown had walked away untouched.

Whatever role Tony Stark played behind the scenes, it spoke volumes.

As for the FBI failing to prove Henry's involvement in the Sony explosion—

From another perspective, if someone left such obvious evidence that they landed in prison, would they even be worth associating with?

Yes, "naive and rich" fueled his popularity.

But Sony's loss reminded everyone—

He was not easy to provoke.

Just like his boss.

Young.

Wealthy.

And sharp-edged.

Henry accepted Hollywood's tentative olive branch.

That, in itself, was a signal.

The next step?

Find the young man's weakness.

Exploit his preferences.

Control him.

Hollywood's initiation ritual rarely deviated from that formula.

Sometimes what destroyed a person wasn't venom or knives.

Sometimes it was sweet words.

Seemingly sincere kindness.

Harder to execute.

Just as effective.

At least the invitations insulting his intelligence had decreased.

That made things simpler.

Still, navigating elite gatherings required caution.

If these events were like college parties—eat, drink, make eye contact, and slip into a room together—that would be easy.

Unfortunately, Henry's pre-reincarnation college life had been dull.

Post-reincarnation?

He never even attended university.

As he entered what he privately called "Phase Two" of diplomatic maneuvering with Hollywood, a very unusual invitation arrived at his desk at Stark Pictures.

The envelope was crafted from high-quality 30-pound black linen paper.

The seal was traditional wax—except the wax was gold.

Not dyed gold.

Real gold flecks infused within.

The crest stamped into the wax meant nothing to Henry.

This was America.

Not Europe.

Coats of arms here were either inherited claims of dubious aristocratic lineage—or self-designed vanity projects.

Half of them had crowns, as if every European royal house had relocated to the United States.

The envelope bore the words:

"To be opened by Henry Brown."

The handwriting was precise Gothic script—like medieval church manuscripts.

Germany had used this typeface up until the end of World War II.

In 1980s Los Angeles, certain Black gangs wore Gothic-lettered shirts as identity markers. Later, hip-hop culture would revive it as fashion.

So—

Was this from some gang?

Out of caution, Henry retrieved surgical gloves from his drawer before breaking the seal.

Inside was not a thick stack of paper, but a single invitation card of equally fine material.

It carried a faint fragrance—not synthetic perfume, but the natural scent of crushed rose petals.

The embossed watermark patterns were machine-pressed.

The decorative laurel motifs, however, were hand-painted.

Symmetrical at a glance.

Imperfect upon inspection.

The invitation listed a time and place:

Chapter 426 426 — An Unexpected Invitation

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The red lettering on the invitation—mixed with gold dust—contained blood.

Not the blood of animals like cats or dogs.

Human blood.

The discovery made Henry fall into deeper silence.

Normally, invitations to Hollywood banquets or parties always came with a clear reason or theme.

A celebration banquet.

A birthday party.

An Oscar campaign dinner.

Whether it was a masquerade ball or a costume party, the theme would always be clearly stated in the invitation.

Just by reading the card, you could usually tell what the event was about—and what kind of clothing you were expected to wear. Even if there was no written invitation, the person extending the invite would explain these details verbally.

But an invitation that only listed time and place, with nothing else—

Unless the recipient was very close to the host—

Was considered extremely rude.

Mystery might seem intriguing, but for wealthy people afraid of death, deliberate secrecy felt like a threat.

For people accustomed to controlling everything, surprise and fright were practically the same thing.

Under normal circumstances, Henry would have tossed such a strange invitation straight into the trash.

He almost did.

But just before throwing it away, he paused.

Then lifted the card to his nose and sniffed again.

If it were merely human blood, he would have discarded it.

But his superhuman sense of smell detected something else.

The blood came from more than one person.

Since it wasn't processed medical plasma but fresh blood directly drawn from bodies, it still carried biological signatures—cholesterol levels, blood sugar markers, subtle health traits.

Henry could distinguish at least ten different individuals.

The day before Easter.

An old manor in the outskirts of Los Angeles.

But the most unusual detail was the signature.

Not a person.

Instead:

Mystikos Sect.

Henry couldn't immediately recall any known organization by that name.

But instinctively—

He disliked it.

Upon closer focus, he identified the reason.

Beneath the floral fragrance—

Was the faint metallic scent of blood.

Subtle.

Almost imperceptible.

But unmistakable.

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Whether those people were alive or dead was unknown.

But they had certainly been bled.

Groups obsessed with blood were rarely respectable religions.

Often they weren't even ordinary humans.

A word immediately surfaced in Henry's mind.

A group.

A nuisance in the Marvel universe that was difficult to classify.

Vampires.

People often assumed vampires were weak—fodder any superhero could bully.

With the right equipment, even ordinary humans could kill them.

But vampires had one enormous advantage.

They were a network.

Killing one or two meant nothing.

Destroying a nest or two barely mattered.

In Henry's evaluation, vampires ranked just below mutants and Skrulls as a persistent nuisance.

Like cockroaches.

If you saw one, there were probably thirty hiding nearby.

No matter how many you killed, they never seemed to disappear.

And in Marvel's version, killing a vampire sire didn't automatically destroy all their descendants.

So the question became:

Should he go?

Or not?

Another characteristic of vampires was their ability to infiltrate power structures.

Money.

Beauty.

Health—albeit a distorted version of it.

All were easily obtained for creatures pulled from myth into reality.

Hollywood's darker corners were the perfect hunting grounds.

Thinking of that, Henry realized he had to go.

Even if he himself wasn't afraid, he had to consider Charlize Theron.

Burying his head in the sand and pretending the threat didn't exist would be foolish.

Since someone had already targeted him, understanding their strength, organization, and background was necessary.

Of course, the rules he knew about vampires came mostly from fantasy.

Those rules might not apply here.

Who knew?

Maybe vampires from outside Marvel had wandered into this universe.

After all, vampire stories had been wildly popular in American media for decades.

And the Continental Hotel system already existed here—something not originally from Marvel.

If the visitors happened to be the Morlun family...

Then it might be time to start packing.

That clan hunted animal totems across the multiverse and counted Spider-Man among their enemies.

Henry had no interest in crossing paths with them.

Whether he could defeat them wasn't the issue.

The problem was the trouble they brought.

But there was another possibility.

Cooperation.

The stage was Hollywood.

There was no irreconcilable hatred between them yet.

In business, profit determined alliances and enemies—not ideology, skin color, or even species.

Henry reminded himself not to repeat past mistakes.

He had already reflected on his earlier prejudices toward mutants and superheroes.

Perhaps—

Just perhaps—

This time he might meet a reasonable, even benevolent vampire.

The thought made him snort.

Even he didn't quite believe it.

He slid the invitation back into its envelope and tucked it into his jacket pocket.

Henry had only just arrived at the office, but he was already preparing to leave again.

Passing through the outer office, he saw his secretary—a chubby Black woman—watering a cactus.

Since Henry had joined Stark Pictures, this was the sixth succulent plant she'd owned.

The previous ones had all died from overwatering.

Average lifespan: about two months.

"Yulian," Henry called.

"Yes, Mr. Brown."

The girl quickly set down the watering can and straightened herself.

Chapter 427 427 — The Mystikos Sect

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After the brief sigh, Henry got straight to the point.

"Who are they?"

Charlie hesitated for a long moment before finally answering.

"I should advise you to stay far away from them. But with your status, it's not surprising they've approached you. And honestly... you probably can't shake them off."

"They're the Mystikos Sect, one of the Thirteen Vampire Sects."

"These vampires generally follow the ancient Camarilla principles—controlling their own kind, including limiting the spread of their progeny. But they don't strictly follow the Masquerade rules. Instead, they actively infiltrate human society."

"They rarely step into the spotlight or become media headlines. Most of the time they appear as important investors in financial circles."

Henry's earlier guess had been confirmed.

"No need to be nervous," Henry said casually. "I just wanted to tell you I'll be out today. If anything comes up, leave it in a memo. If it's urgent, call my mobile."

"Understood, Mr. Brown."

Soon afterward, Henry drove to a place he hadn't visited in a while.

The Continental Hotel.

Inside the hotel's café, the man he was looking for sat in his usual seat.

The aging gunman nearing retirement.

Charlie Fisher.

"Mind if I sit?" Henry asked.

Charlie didn't object.

He was drinking coffee laced with whiskey.

Henry placed a Continental gold coin on the table and signaled the waitress nearby.

"An espresso, please."

Charlie sighed.

"I thought you'd never come back here again," the old assassin said. "Shame, really. You had a chance to leave all this behind."

Henry shrugged.

"I thought once I stepped back into the sunlight, I could leave this world behind too."

He placed the envelope on the table.

"But then I ran into something unfamiliar."

He turned the wax seal upward so Charlie could see the crest.

"I came to ask for advice."

The seasoned gunman glanced down.

His eyelids twitched.

Then his brow furrowed.

"They found you already?"

Henry smiled faintly.

"So you people do know about them."

He leaned back in his chair.

"I thought once I walked into the sunlight there would be no shadows."

He tapped the envelope.

"Turns out even glamorous Hollywood has places your kind can reach."

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But instead of feeling proud, he felt only annoyance.

Being targeted by creatures like this was not something any sane person would celebrate.

"Camarilla?" Henry said casually. "I thought that was something novelists made up. So it actually exists? Don't tell me there's also a Sabbat."

Charlie snorted.

"There is."

"Simply put, the Camarilla believes in parasitizing human society, while the Sabbat believes humans should be enslaved."

"But those ancient factions have splintered into many sects over the centuries. Their doctrines aren't exactly what they used to be."

Henry grinned.

"Sounds like the Sabbat probably got wiped out by so-called heroes. Otherwise we'd be seeing blood farms everywhere by now."

Charlie gave him a strange, unpleasant smile.

"How do you know they're all gone?"

But he didn't continue down that path.

Instead he asked:

"So—what exactly do you want to know about the people who contacted you?"

Henry shrugged.

"Maybe... the parts I should know?"

Charlie nodded approvingly.

"Smart choice."

"I won't tell you too much. The more you know about them, the harder it becomes to leave their sight."

"They're probably approaching you for business cooperation. That's their usual method. Give you a little sweetness, then take a share of your business."

Henry laughed dryly.

"That sounds about right."

"I doubt they're trying to turn me into one of them. Honestly, I'm not even sure their teeth could pierce my skin."

Charlie smirked.

"Even if they couldn't bite you, imagine a vampire pressing its mouth against your neck. Wouldn't the saliva alone disgust you?"

Henry grimaced.

"Oh hell. You're absolutely right."

Charlie chuckled before returning to seriousness.

"My advice is simple. If you can avoid them, avoid them. And don't even think about cooperating."

"Why?" Henry asked. "Business is just mutual benefit, isn't it?"

Charlie leaned forward slightly.

"We like to call Jews vampires sometimes."

"But they're actual vampires."

"You understand what I mean?"

Henry silently interpreted the statement.

So their business tactics were even worse than Wall Street bankers.

"That bad, huh?" Henry said.

"Worse," Charlie replied.

"They'll use all kinds of tricks and pressure tactics. They'll cling to you for a while. But if you hold out long enough—or if things risk becoming public—they'll withdraw."

"Remaining unseen is one of the Mystikos Sect's core principles."

Henry tapped his fingers lightly on the table.

"Pressure tactics, huh..."

Charlie's gaze sharpened.

"Take care of your girl."

"If you create a weakness for yourself, don't blame others for targeting it."

Henry frowned.

He had already considered that risk when he began dating Charlize Theron.

But accepting the possibility didn't mean he liked it.

"Do you know how far they're willing to go?" Henry asked.

Charlie nodded slowly.

"Generally, they still follow rules of the game—both society's and their own."

"Once things turn violent, it becomes a war. And war attracts attention."

"That's the last thing they want."

This information mattered a great deal to Henry.

The worst scenario would be enemies with no limits whatsoever.

Of course, vampires had limits very different from ordinary humans.

Understanding that difference was crucial.

Judging vampires by human moral standards would only get someone killed.

"So," Henry said slowly, "should I hire vampire hunters or priests to protect my girl? Flex a little muscle so they know I'm not easy prey?"

Charlie shook his head immediately.

"That would only escalate things."

Chapter 428 428 — A Cannibal’s Patron

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"And honestly, instead of hiring some fake priest or amateur hunter, you'd be better off going to the man behind you."

Henry blinked.

"My boss?"

"Tony Stark?"

Charlie shrugged.

"Tony's situation is hard to judge right now."

"But Howard Stark had dealings with vampires before. Even if certain factions disliked him, both sides maintained a respectful distance."

Henry raised an eyebrow and leaned closer, clearly eager for gossip.

Charlie pushed his face away.

"This isn't some secret conspiracy."

"During World War II, Howard Stark supplied Captain America and the Howling Commandos."

"Even if Stark couldn't order them to eliminate his business rivals, if some vampire idiot provoked him..."

"The Howling Commandos would wipe them out."

Henry looked surprised.

"They'd really do private jobs like that?"

Charlie shrugged.

"Even setting personal relationships aside—think about it from the government's perspective."

"A genius brain equivalent to all the scientists of the Manhattan Project combined."

"If vampires tried to mess with someone like that, they'd be grabbing the government's balls."

"In that situation, whichever hand reached out would be cut off."

"Unless Howard Stark was the one who approached the vampires first and made a deal."

"Do you see the difference?"

Henry rubbed his chin.

"That sounds a lot like the legend about vampires not entering a house unless invited."

Charlie nodded.

"Every legend comes from somewhere."

"Maybe some writer heard about vampire etiquette and turned it into fiction."

Henry frowned again.

"But does Stark still have that level of deterrence today?"

Charlie snorted.

"Probably not."

"But dragging that rich young playboy into the situation to split the pressure on you—sounds easier than taking vampire attention alone, doesn't it?"

Henry waved it off.

"Let's skip that terrible idea."

"You don't have anything more useful?"

Charlie thought for a moment.

"Actually... there is one development you might want to pay attention to."

Henry leaned forward.

"What is it?"

Charlie lowered his voice.

"A group of old monsters have come to the West Coast."

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The fragmentary warning made little sense to Henry.

He couldn't understand what Charlie was referring to, nor why the situation required such caution.

Seeing the confused expression on the young man's face, Charlie finally seemed satisfied and explained further.

"Do you know what America's old money elites, the really old ones, care about most when they reach a certain age?"

"Don't bother guessing. I'll tell you."

"Health."

"A group of wealthy people who lived through World War II have all experienced sudden, rapid health deterioration around the same time."

"They've gathered here on the West Coast, hoping to obtain medical treatment using the resources on the island."

"Some of them even want to receive the Embrace from vampires and become one of them."

Charlie continued:

"It's precisely because these old-money families suddenly showed up—and they're desperate—that the Mystikos vampires have grown more arrogant lately."

"Their behavior has become even more brazen than before."

"So before you make any decisions involving the Mystikos Sect, you should remember that these old-money figures might step in—either to complicate matters or openly support the vampires."

"Now you see why I suggested dragging young Stark into this."

That was a lot to process.

Henry needed a moment to think.

If it were only vampires, creatures that could never step into the light, the solution would be simple.

Drag them into the sun.

Problem solved.

No need to worry about disposing of the bodies.

But once those old-money elites entered the equation—especially dying ones desperate for survival—anything could happen.

People on the verge of death could make terrifying decisions.

Charlie had also mentioned "the island."

Could it be that island?

The legendary place whose resources were whispered about in certain circles?

Was it secretly controlled by vampires?

Trouble piling on top of trouble.

Seeing Henry's conflicted expression, Charlie chuckled.

"Thinking about declining the invitation?"

"Or planning to reject whatever they propose?"

Henry glanced at him.

"You're saying that won't work?"

"It will work," Charlie said. "Otherwise I wouldn't have suggested it."

"Don't meet them. Don't cooperate."

"But like I said, they'll keep pestering you."

"You'll need to withstand the pressure."

"The best solution is to redirect their attention."

So...

Throw Tony Stark under the bus?

Charlie's repeated hints sparked a suspicion in Henry's mind.

He suddenly asked:

"They're not part of the High Table, are they?"

Charlie's smile didn't change.

But he leaned back in his chair, no longer leaning forward across the table.

He picked up his whiskey coffee and took a slow sip.

Blocking his mouth.

Blocking the conversation.

Message received.

Discussion over.

about:blank

Henry immediately understood.

Coming to the Continental for information had likely been predicted.

Charlie's reaction clearly signaled that the topic was closed.

Henry wasn't foolish enough to keep pressing.

Besides, everything Charlie had said probably contained a degree of manipulation anyway.

From the direction of those hints, the real target seemed to be Tony Stark.

Henry himself was merely collateral damage.

Fine.

If that was the case...

Tony Stark absolutely deserved to know.

Why should Henry carry this problem alone?

This confirmed something Henry had suspected for a while.

Getting close to famous figures in the Marvel world inevitably dragged you into their karmic disasters.

Tony Stark clearly had far more trouble surrounding him than Henry had previously imagined.

Honestly, it was a miracle Stark survived until 2008 before building the first Iron Man suit.

All those eccentric habits later?

Probably developed from years of stress.

Of course—

Tony Stark's personality issues had nothing to do with Henry.

Henry wasn't his father.

He had no obligation to teach the billionaire playboy how to behave.

After finishing his espresso, Henry simply nodded politely and left the Continental.

Places like that remained shelters for the dark underworld.

Cannibals' territory.

Never somewhere you could truly rely on.

Recognizing that fact, Henry adjusted his thinking.

From now on, any information the Continental possessed about him should be assumed to be known by the vampires as well.

His "steel body" mutant ability wasn't exactly secret.

Anyone with resources could discover that.

But linking Henry Brown to "The Tinkerer"?

Very few people knew that.

Even inside the Los Angeles Continental, it wasn't common knowledge yet.

The Tinkerer had disappeared for quite some time.

The only lingering trouble was the money he'd taken from that Black crime boss.

Money the FBI had been watching closely.

Though whether they still cared now was unclear.

Other than that...

There weren't many real weaknesses.

With Stark Industries behind him, even if someone exposed the Tinkerer's identity to the FBI, Henry wasn't afraid.

Stark's legal team would bury the case in paperwork.

Henry kept no diaries.

No secret ledgers.

No illegal funds sitting in banks.

Nothing stored in Gary's apartment.

Without physical evidence, even the IRS couldn't accuse him of tax evasion.

As long as the authorities didn't fabricate evidence, they couldn't legally touch him.

Henry had deliberately spent time studying California law, tax law, and relevant federal statutes.

Cleaning up his traces had been worth the effort.

And if prosecutors ever fabricated charges?

That would be even better.

Stark's lawyers would turn the case into prosecutorial misconduct, permanently poisoning any future investigation.

In short:

Information leaking from the Continental wasn't a major threat.

Henry's real weakness was still the same.

His girlfriend.

The future Oscar winner.

Charlize Theron.

Of course, there was no need to assume the worst immediately.

Preparation was enough.

After all, nothing had started yet.

He hadn't even met the vampires.

No one knew how things would unfold.

Henry drove to the Hollywood Kid Supercomputer Service Center.

This facility also housed the server rooms for Stark Pictures' rentable editing suites.

There were twenty editing rooms available for external studios.

After months of market adoption, every room was now running at full capacity.

Chapter 429 429 — Reporting Matters

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Even with all twenty rental editing suites running at full capacity, they used less than one-third of the theoretical computing power of the supercomputer "Hollywood Kid."

Of the remaining processing capacity, about half was allocated to the old film digital restoration team, while the rest went to the R&D department.

However, Stark Pictures' R&D team still lacked the ability to fully utilize the remaining computing power. Their usage required submitting requests and scheduling time slots.

In reality, those requests were almost always approved. The scheduling system mainly served to notify others what tasks would be running and how long they might take.

But the ones who truly consumed the machine's power were still Henry and Tony Stark.

And what they ran on it were mostly private projects.

Although Tony Stark spent most of his time in New York on the East Coast, he could still remotely control the supercomputer's virtual machines over the network.

Back in July 1995, Tatu Ylönen of the Helsinki University of Technology in Finland released a new encrypted communication protocol:

Secure Shell Protocol (SSH).

This protocol replaced insecure systems like Telnet, FTP, and rsh, quickly becoming the preferred remote access method for server users.

Because SSH used a lightweight text-based interface, even dial-up connections allowed Tony Stark on the East Coast to smoothly operate the supercomputer located on the West Coast.

At that time, SSH was still open-source software, so the version used by Hollywood Kid had been jointly modified and improved by Henry and Tony Stark.

Originally, the two communicated through a separate email server.

Later, they switched to leaving messages on a hidden bulletin board inside a private Docker container.

In other words, as computing technology improved, both their security systems and firewalls were constantly being upgraded.

After all, whenever the two of them got bored, they would run stress tests or edge-case experiments on each other's code, poke at one another's systems, and then upgrade the defenses again.

However, the message board was primarily used by Henry.

He used it to submit work reports and summarize West Coast intelligence.

Tony Stark rarely left messages or replies.

So Henry never knew whether that billionaire actually read any of it.

Normally, Henry submitted a weekly report.

Anything that wasn't in the newspapers—or differed from what the media reported—would be included.

How to analyze or use that intelligence was Tony Stark's responsibility.

Today wasn't the usual reporting day.

about:blank

Some wealthy productions had purchased the editing software outright and tried using high-performance commercial computers.

But most of them eventually came back.

The software was identical.

The workflow identical.

But here, the computing power was backed by a supercomputer.

Rendering speed could easily be twice as fast as commercial machines.

Given that difference, the choice was obvious.

Studios preferred Stark's facility.

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Henry had come to the Hollywood Kid service center specifically to report the information he had just learned about vampires.

Although the invitation was addressed to him, the real target was clearly the owner of Stark Industries.

If this wasn't reported early, things might spiral out of control later.

Because this wasn't a scheduled report, Henry had no idea how long it would take for Tony Stark to read it.

Or whether these reports simply vanished into the void after being posted.

Honestly, that wasn't Henry's problem.

As an employee, doing the job well enough to justify his salary was sufficient.

Even if Stark Industries doubled its fortune, Henry wouldn't get a share of it.

Organizing the report took only a few microseconds.

The real delay came from typing it out.

After all, keyboards had physical speed limits.

If Henry had written it by hand, it wouldn't have taken even a minute.

After sending the report, Henry followed his usual habit.

He quietly slipped into Tony Stark's virtual machine to see what the genius billionaire had been working on lately.

No surprise there.

Artificial intelligence.

Tony Stark had begun studying AI years earlier.

His MIT graduation project—the robotic arm Dum-Dum—primarily demonstrated achievements in mechanical engineering, but it already contained early AI elements.

After earning:

a PhD in Engineering Physics at MIT,

and a PhD in Aeronautical Engineering at Caltech,

Tony Stark had recently returned to MIT to pursue a third doctorate—Artificial Intelligence.

However, Stark's current AI research differed greatly from the data-driven machine learning models that would become popular in the future.

His system relied instead on:

large numbers of automated procedures,

image tracking,

and fuzzy logic decision-making.

In simple terms, this type of AI couldn't truly learn.

It simply kept adding more and more exception cases into its decision tree, creating the illusion of an all-purpose intelligence.

That was why the robotic arm Dum-Dum often behaved strangely.

Those odd actions were usually the result of misjudged environmental conditions.

Stark's current AI work on the Hollywood Kid supercomputer focused primarily on interactive responses—in other words, conversation.

His research questions included:

How to recognize voice input

Convert speech into text

Extract actionable commands from the text

Execute those commands

Provide appropriate responses if execution failed

Another challenge was determining which voices should trigger responses and which should not.

Different speakers might require different logic paths.

All of these were part of Stark's research.

Perhaps this was the prototype of his future AI butler:

JARVIS.

The only problem?

He was running these AI experiments on a supercomputer designed mainly for graphics processing.

Henry started writing a program that could allow the GPU to share computational workloads with the CPU, improving overall performance.

He planned to install it in his own virtual machine.

Whether Tony Stark noticed the hint or not wasn't Henry's concern.

At that moment, a notification sound interrupted his thoughts.

The secret message board had a reply.

Henry immediately dropped the half-finished program and jumped into the message board server.

Sure enough—

There was a new message.

Philanthropic Billionaire:

So vampires contacted you, but the real target is me.

You're sure about that?

West Coast Wage Slave:

Intel from the Continental. Reliability is high.

Young Playboy Spreading Love Everywhere:

But from what you described, they targeted you first and are trying to drag me in.

Can't you just block this on your side?

West Coast Wage Slave:

They're vampires.

If they don't achieve their real objective, do you think they'll give up—or create more trouble?

Either way this will reach you sooner or later. I'm just informing you in advance so you don't complain later.

Chapter 430 430 — The Mysterious Banquet

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Henry answered Tony Stark's last question.

But there was no follow-up.

The young billionaire had probably gone offline.

After finishing the hint program he intended to leave for Stark, Henry returned home. Tony Stark's artificial intelligence code contained quite a few clever ideas, and some of them could definitely help improve the behavior logic of Henry's core robot, BB.

Since Henry was currently rebuilding BB's system, he had to admit Stark's approach was very valuable as a reference.

Of course, Henry had no intention of copying Stark's unfinished AI program and transferring it to his own server.

It wasn't because the prototype version of JARVIS was incomplete.

The real reason was simpler.

With the abilities both men possessed, tracing file transfer routes would be trivial.

Henry simply didn't want to expose the location of his private server.

After all:

> Wherever something passes, it leaves traces.

That rule applied not only in the real world, but even more so on the internet.

Young Playboy:

Fuck! You changed my ID again!

Stop doing childish things!

West Coast Idiot:

Oh, you can see that?

I thought I only changed how the name displays on my end. Sorry.

Playboy With Insufficient "Essence" Left to Spread Love:

How did you even get in here? I encrypted my user data!

Playboy:

Fuck! You changed it again!

West Coast Donkey:

Your encryption is garbage.

Did you forget this host is a supercomputer?

Brute-force cracking doesn't take long.

Furious Professor Tony:

You're stealing computing resources again!

Fine, whatever.

But do you actually believe vampires exist?

West Coast Pig:

If refusing to believe would make them disappear, I'd happily deny it.

Unfortunately reality doesn't bend to my beliefs, so debating that question is pointless.

Great Professor Tony:

I originally thought those creatures were just mutants with certain abilities.

But mutant powers rarely repeat themselves.

If what you're saying is true, then groups of vampires and werewolves wouldn't be surprising.

So tell me—

Do you believe in magic?

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Better to stay cautious.

Besides, their current arrangement was already a habit:

take something, leave something.

Both of them silently agreed not to probe into what the other was doing outside the Hollywood Kid supercomputer.

Otherwise Stark Industries' servers would never be able to keep Henry out—Tony Stark knew that perfectly well.

Unfortunately, by the time he realized it, he had already invited the wolf into the house.

Too late to kick him out.

Back to real-world arrangements.

In the Western world, Easter isn't fixed like Christmas.

It falls on the first Sunday after the full moon following the spring equinox.

The vampire invitation specified the evening before Easter.

April 6th, 1996.

A Saturday night.

After repeated consideration, Henry decided he couldn't simply ignore the event.

If the creatures behaved like Charlie from the Continental described—relentless and persistent—

then avoiding them wouldn't stop their ambitions.

So at the appointed time, naturally at night, Henry drove alone to the location.

His outfit was the same one respectable suit he owned:

navy Armani suit

newly purchased brown calfskin shoes

The estate hosting the banquet looked completely normal.

There were none of the signs one might associate with a cult.

No disturbing blood smell.

No eerie decorations.

By all appearances, it was simply a typical upper-class gathering.

Many attendees were elderly men and women who required assistance just to walk.

Their clothing and jewelry were exquisite.

Their hair and beards meticulously groomed.

Yet none of that could hide the unmistakable signs of decline on their skin.

These people were clearly near the end of their lives.

Not long after arriving, Henry was stopped by one such elderly man.

The old man looked so frail he seemed ready to collapse at any moment.

He leaned closer and asked in a hushed tone:

"Sir... are you one of them?"

"No, Mr. Bernard," Henry replied calmly.

"I'm also a guest who received an invitation."

"Oh... I can see that."

The old man stepped back and looked Henry up and down.

That glance carried a deeper meaning.

Henry's Armani suit might be considered luxury for blue-collar and white-collar workers alike.

But to true members of the upper aristocratic class, proper clothing meant hand-tailored suits, made from high-quality fabric.

Celebrities wore Armani mainly because of sponsorship deals.

It didn't necessarily mean the clothes were truly elite.

Of course, compared to two-hundred-dollar department-store suits, Armani still looked impressive.

The old man didn't rush to conclusions, though.

"Have we met somewhere before?"

"New York, four years ago," Henry replied.

"At a fundraising banquet hosted by Ms. Audrey Hepburn for UNICEF. I was her assistant."

"Oh... now I remember."

The old man patted Henry on the arm thoughtfully.

"Good luck, kid."

Then he walked away.

Even though the old man had tried to remain polite, Henry could clearly sense the meaning behind his reaction.

The man probably thought Henry was another naïve youngster lured here as a blood bag.

That was why he fled so quickly.

Honestly—

Henry was already starting to regret coming.

Looking around, he saw young people roughly his age scattered throughout the venue.

They behaved as if they had entered some extraordinary place.

Constantly trying to network.

Constantly seeking connections.

But meeting rejection everywhere.

Despite the elegant surroundings—

fine food, expensive wine, refined atmosphere—

two groups were clearly separated.

Even while standing in the same room.

One group:

Old money elites.

The other:

Ambitious young hopefuls.

Old wealth on one side.

Hungry opportunists on the other.

Henry's appearance and age clearly placed him among the latter.

Young.

Ignorant.

Full of excessive ambition.

Too blind to realize they might merely be items on someone else's menu.

Then suddenly—

A third type of person appeared.

She was also young.

But possessed stunning beauty and overwhelming confidence.

Even when facing the elderly elite, she maintained a proud, superior attitude.

She wore a tight crimson dress.

Her high heels added nearly a hand's height to her stature.

The blonde beauty brushed past everyone attempting to talk to her—

even those reaching out to plead for attention.

She walked straight toward Henry.

Her lips, painted with Chanel Coco #920 Honey Apple, glowed with a seductive sweetness.

Irresistibly inviting.

"Henry Brown?" she asked.

"Yes. That's me."

Suddenly—

She leaned in close.

Too close.

From his ear down to his neck, she quickly sniffed along his scent.

Someone timid might have jumped three steps back.

Henry did step back—

but not from fear.

He simply didn't want to stand too close to a beautiful woman.

Especially if she might be a vampire.

Besides, the banquet hall was full of hidden cameras and microphones.

The surveillance was subtle but thorough.

Henry had no intention of giving reporters a chance to spin gossip from a single photograph.

For some reason, his reaction amused the woman.

She chuckled softly, shooting him a flirtatious glance.

"Come with me," she said.

"Lord Dragoneiti wishes to see you."

She didn't hide the invitation.

Many people noticed.

Some looked jealous.

Some sympathetic.

Others secretly delighted.

Ignoring the spectators, Henry followed her.

They entered a corridor guarded by several massive men.

The message was obvious:

No entry without permission.

Beyond the corridor was another banquet hall.

The decorations were similar.

But the people inside were completely different.

Clothing here was far more casual.

Some appearances were... difficult to describe.

For example:

A man with a wild punk hairstyle wearing a leather vest.

If someone like that had walked into the front hall earlier, the elderly guests might have had heart attacks.

Aside from unusual fashion, everyone here shared the same aura as the blonde woman:

arrogant and flamboyant.

Every single one of them looked down on others.

Literally.

With their noses.

Near the fireplace stood two chairs.

One was already occupied.

A tall man with brown hair and blue eyes.

Strong build.

Chapter 431 431 — Gitano Dragoneiti

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"Some people say the taste of brandy is the closest thing to the taste of fresh blood. What do you think, Mr. Brown?"

The man raised his glass, swirling the liquor with theatrical flair, sniffing it with exaggerated appreciation.

Henry ignored the pretentious display.

He lifted the glass and drank the XO cognac in one gulp—a brandy aged at least six years.

"I've never tasted blood," Henry said calmly. "So I can't compare."

"But I'm pretty sure whoever said that must've been a Froggy."

"Because if a Rashka said it, brandy would suddenly become vodka."

"Froggy" was an American slur referring to the French—who were stereotypically mocked for eating frogs.

"Rashka" was a mocking American-Russian hybrid pronunciation referring to Russians.

The joke amused the man across from him.

"Hahaha, quite right."

He picked up the bottle and poured Henry another glass.

"My name is Gitano Dragoneiti. A pleasure."

Henry stood and extended his hand.

"Henry Brown. The pleasure is mine, Mr. Dragoneiti."

By standing, Henry subtly increased the physical distance between them again.

When people weren't familiar with each other, overly intimate gestures often signaled hidden motives.

As the saying went:

> Excessive courtesy often hides ulterior intentions.

Dragoneiti didn't seem offended by Henry's caution.

He stood, shook Henry's hand politely, and gestured for him to sit again.

"Mr. Brown has accomplished quite a few things quietly lately," Dragoneiti said.

"Promoting digital cinema technology.

The Sony building explosion in Los Angeles."

"You walked away with the benefits while escaping the trouble unscathed."

"Anyone watching would have to applaud."

Henry chuckled lightly.

"That explosion had nothing to do with me."

"Maybe Sony just couldn't agree with a thief about commission fees and someone blew the building up."

"After all, I'm the victim whose property was stolen."

The usual social dance.

Say everything politely.

Reveal nothing.

He looked completely normal.

Between the chairs sat a small table with fine liquor and glasses.

The bottle hadn't been poured yet.

Henry was guided to the empty chair.

Only then did the blonde woman open the bottle and pour brandy into both glasses.

The mysterious host sat calmly across from him.

The real conversation was about to begin

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Even if everyone suspected him.

Dragoneiti didn't challenge the denial.

Instead, he casually added:

"Did you know Mickey Schulhof was extremely unhappy with you?"

"He tried to approach the Continental Hotel to place a bounty."

"Fortunately the bounty never passed approval. Otherwise you'd be facing endless assassination attempts."

The implication was obvious.

He was hinting that Henry's safety existed thanks to his intervention.

If Henry didn't know how the Continental worked, he might have believed the claim.

Henry smiled.

"With Schulhof's personality—lavish and obsessed with appearances—he probably couldn't bear to pay the bounty."

"Maybe it was just a performance to show he was angry."

At the Continental, placing a bounty didn't require gold coins.

But the minimum price was \$100,000.

And if the target was particularly dangerous or influential?

A low bounty would simply be rejected.

Henry's case qualified easily.

A bulletproof mutant wasn't exactly an easy target.

Realistically, the bounty would need to start at one million dollars.

Most gunmen couldn't deal with someone like that.

It would require specialists—or elaborate poisoning schemes.

The difficulty rose exponentially.

If the reward was too small, no one would bother.

And the Continental demanded full payment in advance.

No killing first and collecting later.

So if the employer couldn't afford the bounty, the offer simply wouldn't be accepted.

Dragoneiti wasn't surprised by Henry's response.

Henry had once worked within the Continental's orbit.

Knowing those details wasn't unusual.

Still, even if the "life-saving favor" didn't work, revealing the information was still a smaller favor.

Dragoneiti smiled.

"Mr. Brown truly matches Ms. Fisher's description."

"Cunning. Clever."

"Those who thought you were merely a bookish nerd paid a heavy price."

Mentioning Munni Fisher—Henry's former superior—was another attempt to assert dominance.

But Munni herself had failed to control Henry.

Why would some stranger succeed now?

Henry smoothly shifted the conversation.

"Compared to my small affairs, shouldn't world affairs be more interesting?"

"The Red Empire has collapsed.

Japan's economic bubble burst.

Europe is integrating."

"Right now the United States has no real rival."

"That's not good."

"My boss and his fellow merchants of death can't sell weapons without enemies."

"If they can't sell weapons, they don't have money to spend."

"And if they don't spend money, the American economy slows."

"So the urgent question is: who should be our next enemy?"

"Some say Afghanistan.

Others say Iran.

Some say Saddam Hussein."

"What do you think, Mr. Dragoneiti?"

Dragoneiti raised his glass calmly.

"Anyone will do."

"None of them can defeat the U.S. military anyway."

But he still tried to steer the conversation back to his real objective.

"What about Tony Stark?"

"What has your employer been doing lately?"

Henry shrugged.

"Probably in bed with some minor actress or model."

"If you want that information, you'd get better results calling New York paparazzi."

"He doesn't exactly report his schedule to me."

Dragoneiti leaned forward slightly.

"What if we asked you to deliver an invitation?"

"Arrange a meeting between us and Tony Stark."

Chapter 432 432 — The Real Game Begins

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Henry was simply telling the truth.

And judging from Tony Stark's recent behavior, Gitano Dragoneiti had to admit the scenario Henry described was entirely plausible.

Henry didn't bother asking what Dragoneiti actually wanted from Stark.

But Dragoneiti clearly had no intention of letting Henry leave empty-handed.

So he continued:

> "The reason I wish to meet Mr. Stark is actually quite simple — business cooperation."

"I possess capital. A great deal of capital that can be invested."

"Perhaps Stark Industries doesn't currently need funding. But we can offer something else... something many people dream about."

He gestured vaguely toward the outer hall.

"Like those old men outside."

"What do you think they desire more than money?"

"Health. Youth. Vitality like young people."

"With our assistance, those things are easily obtained."

"And if you wanted them... negotiations would not be impossible."

"I'm sure the Continental has already told you certain secrets ordinary people never hear about."

Henry didn't immediately give in to the soft temptation.

Instead he asked calmly:

> "And the price?"

"There are far more people outside who want what you're offering."

"Yet you approached me specifically."

"So this certainly isn't free, Mr. Dragoneiti."

Dragoneiti chuckled.

"This is exactly why I enjoy dealing with clever people."

"As I said — it's all part of business cooperation."

Henry spread his hands helplessly.

"Of course I can deliver the invitation."

"But I've already said—I'm not his parents, and I'm not his guardian."

"That man does whatever he wants."

"You remember one of his recent scandals?"

"At a charity dinner hosted by Stark Industries, President Bill Clinton and First Lady Hillary Clinton attended in person."

"Vice President Obadiah Stane told everyone Tony Stark was ill and recovering."

"And the very same night—photos appeared in newspapers showing Stark partying somewhere else with two women draped over him."

Dragoneiti said calmly:

"Wasn't that Stark expressing dissatisfaction with the Democratic administration's military cuts?"

Henry shrugged.

"Who knows?"

"Maybe he just wanted to sleep with those women."

"So tell me—"

"If I invite him, and he casually agrees..."

"What are the chances he doesn't show up at all?"

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He deliberately avoided specifying the trade.

Henry also refused to ask directly what they wanted.

Because the answer was obvious:

They wanted equity. Influence.

Give a small favor, harvest enormous profits.

A classic move.

Henry shrugged helplessly.

"Stark Industries is beyond my authority."

"But if you want shares of Stark Pictures, you'll still have to talk to Tony Stark."

"He's the sole owner."

"I don't even hold a single share."

Dragoneiti tilted his head.

"That seems rather poor treatment for a man with such valuable technology."

"Don't you think, Mr. Henry Brown?"

Henry smiled lightly.

"Well, leaving Stark Pictures means losing access to a supercomputer."

"So I make do with the situation."

A soft but firm rejection.

Dragoneiti nodded.

"Indeed."

"Inside Stark's company, the resources are unimaginable."

"Who would expect Hollywood equipment to run on a supercomputer?"

"You should hear how many technical people complain to me about that."

Henry caught the hidden meaning immediately.

Dragoneiti didn't want Henry himself.

He wanted a nail embedded inside Stark's organization.

Henry responded with another casual deflection:

"To Tony Stark, Stark Pictures is basically a toy company compared to Stark Industries."

"That's why he allows an outsider like me to control those resources."

"He doesn't care about it."

Dragoneiti leaned forward slightly.

"What if we changed the form of cooperation between us?"

Henry played along.

"What sort of cooperation?"

Dragoneiti lowered his voice conspiratorially.

"I don't believe your talent is limited to digital imaging technology."

"Especially for someone who also possesses remarkable medical skills."

"If we supported you..."

"If we helped you enter Stark Industries and climb upward..."

"How high do you think you could go?"

He smiled faintly.

"Perhaps just as Howard Stark and Obadiah Stane once worked together..."

"You could create a new era."

"Tony Stark and Henry Brown."

Inside, Henry nearly gagged.

The proposal was so nauseating it gave him goosebumps.

Should he kill this vampire right now?

Or kill Iron Man later?

But the statement also revealed something important.

The vampire clearly knew something about Henry's "Tinkerer" identity.

Henry maintained his calm expression.

> "Same question as before."

"What's the price?"

"The only thing I believe in is that nothing in this world comes free."

Dragoneiti smiled proudly.

"The price... and the reward."

"What if I told you I could make you one of us?"

"A member of our kind."

"Of course, such a transformation has... certain inconveniences."

"So we could reserve that privilege."

"When you're ready, we perform the ritual."

"Until then, we support your rise within Stark Industries."

"But for such cooperation..."

"We would require proof."

"A guarantee you won't betray us later."

Henry understood immediately.

They wanted a pledge of loyalty.

So he asked calmly:

> "What kind of guarantee?"

Dragoneiti answered briefly.

"Your girl."

There it was.

They were targeting Charlize Theron.

Chapter 433 433 — Temptation

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Under normal circumstances, if someone wanted to control Henry Brown, they would control his children, parents, or at the very least his wife in order to trust his loyalty.

But Henry was like someone who had appeared out of thin air.

No family. No relatives.

The only leverage available was a girlfriend.

And even that felt unreliable.

Could they use the "Tinkerer" identity against him?

Not really.

At a high enough level, the stains from the Tinkerer's past barely mattered. Even murder charges weren't a big deal—unless the victim was someone important.

She wasn't even a proper celebrity yet.

If she disappeared in Los Angeles, nobody would notice.

Maybe only her mother would travel from South Africa searching desperately.

Henry knew showing anger would only confirm their strategy.

So he tilted his head thoughtfully and replied:

"If she truly means that much to me, how could I hand her over?"

"But if I hand her over easily..."

"Wouldn't that prove she's not actually valuable to me?"

"Would such a guarantee really satisfy you?"

Henry's counter-question made Dragoneiti hesitate slightly.

Because throughout his long life he had learned something:

> People who sacrifice family for loyalty... almost never remain loyal.

Whenever the benefits of betrayal exceed loyalty, people always betray.

That was human nature.

Nothing was eternal.

Real control came from keeping rewards withheld.

Offer just enough hope.

Increase their investment repeatedly.

When the sunk cost becomes unbearable, loyalty finally becomes stable.

But that strategy wouldn't work with Henry Brown.

They couldn't leave obvious vampire influence on him.

Because Howard Stark once had close connections with the Howling Commandos.

And among them was a vampire–werewolf hybrid:

Nina Price — the Midnight Vampire.

Which meant Howard Stark knew vampires existed.

Because of that connection, vampire infiltration attempts in Stark Industries had always failed.

Their agents were stuck in insignificant positions.

None had ever gained the opportunity Henry Brown now possessed —

A chance to reach the core of Stark Industries.

If Tony Stark became suspicious, their investment in Henry would collapse instantly.

So they had only one option:

Keep Henry clean.

Let him infiltrate Stark Industries without any visible vampire ties.

Only then could he quietly climb toward the center of power.

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The case that once had the best chance of destroying him was the one involving California State Assemblyman Mike Liddell Horton.

But after the FBI ran into a wall during that investigation, they quickly found a scapegoat and closed the case to appease the media.

Reopening it now would be extremely difficult.

Just like the Sony explosion case.

The FBI themselves had closed it and cut off the evidence chain.

If they reopened it, the entire Los Angeles office could be accused of dereliction of duty.

And who would volunteer for that?

Facing such a slippery opponent as Henry Brown, even a centuries-old schemer like Gitano Dragoneiti found him troublesome.

Still, spiders didn't expect prey to be caught instantly.

They simply waited for the prey to stick one leg to the web.

Then during the struggle—

another leg.

One hand.

Then both hands.

Eventually the whole body would be stuck.

A clever spider would even wrap extra silk around the prey and store it for later consumption.

And after centuries of accumulating resources, surely his clan could afford one gamble.

Acting like miserly bankers—investing one dollar to demand two back immediately—wasn't how immortals behaved.

Real vampires took risks.

And if they were cheated?

They simply killed the swindler and confiscated everything.

That was how vampires accumulated wealth.

So Dragoneiti showed no disappointment about the lack of guarantees.

He simply smiled and shifted tactics.

"Perhaps asking for your girl gave you the wrong impression," he said smoothly.

"But cooperation should benefit both sides."

"I have resources in Hollywood."

"Helping elevate your girlfriend's career would be trivial."

"Many stars already cooperate with us."

"If I told you their names, you would probably be surprised."

"This is what I meant earlier—everyone gets what they want."

"And if you personally don't feel that girl deserves heavy investment, that's fine too."

He gestured toward the hall outside.

"Anyone here you like—you can take them home."

"Male or female."

"Or perhaps a celebrity."

"Just say the name. Tomorrow she will appear wherever you want."

"Don't underestimate our power."

"The things we can accomplish are far beyond your imagination."

"Even your current boss—Tony Stark—looks like an inexperienced child from our perspective."

He leaned forward slightly.

"So go ahead."

"Tell me your wish."

"We may not be able to shout 'Abracadabra!' like a genie and grant it instantly..."

"But there are very few things we cannot accomplish."

Henry listened carefully.

Then he thought seriously for a moment before cautiously asking:

"Do you happen to have a mature, commercially viable miniature nuclear fusion technology?"

Energy crisis solved.

Dragoneiti froze.

"...Hmm."

Henry continued.

"Then how about a nuclear-powered submarine capable of diving to at least 1000 meters?"

"And I don't just want command authority."

"I want full ownership."

"And I don't accept supervision."

Great.

Now his underwater lab problem would be solved too.

Dragoneiti fell silent again.

"...Hmm..."

Compared to the fusion reactor, the submarine request was actually more realistic.

But still—

Who on earth casually owned a nuclear submarine?

Even if you somehow obtained one, you still needed:

maintenance facilities

trained crews

spare parts

nuclear safety management

Even wealthy vampire clans rarely bothered with such burdens.

At best, some owned commercial or research submarines for secret transportation routes.

But nuclear submarines?

Even if they could acquire one—

Why would they hand it to a mutant stranger?

Seeing both requests ignored, Henry lowered his expectations again.

"Fine."

"Then let's return to Hollywood."

"Give my girlfriend a lead role in a film that lands in the year's Top 10 box office."

This time Dragoneiti didn't even bother responding.

A female lead role in a big-budget movie?

Easy.

But guaranteeing Top 10 box office of the year?

You'd need a fortune teller to predict which movies would succeed.

If that were possible, Hollywood studios would never lose money.

Three requests. Three failures.

Henry had no interest in proposing a fourth.

He sighed lightly.

"Mr. Dragoneiti..."

"You're not expecting me to ask for things I could obtain myself, are you?"

"How would that demonstrate your indispensable value?"

Dragoneiti frowned slightly.

"Money. Power. Women."

"Don't those tempt you?"

Henry shrugged casually.

"They do."

"But not enough for me to pay a special price."

"I can obtain those things on my own."

"And honestly, I'm satisfied with what I already have."

"I don't have that many ambitions."

If he truly cared about those three things, this story would already be titled:

"The Kryptonian Business Empire: Crushing the World with Iron Fists."

One day beating Bill Gates.

Next day beating Warren Buffett.

Whenever bored, squeeze them like rags and drain their wealth.

While Dragoneiti showed a rare hint of difficulty—and Henry looked relaxed—

One of the vampires under Dragoneiti suddenly moved.

With lightning speed.

Before anyone could react—

He snapped a mutant power-suppressing collar around Henry's neck.

And activated it instantly.

Henry had actually noticed the movement.

But he still allowed the collar to be placed on him.

Because he wanted to see what would happen next.

Was this the will of all the vampires present?

Or merely the action of a particular faction?

Sure enough—

Compared to Henry wearing the collar,

Dragoneiti himself looked far more shocked.

Though the displeasure on his face disappeared in an instant.

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Chapter 434 434 — The Impatient Fool

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If Henry's senses hadn't been so sharp, he might have missed the momentary flash of irritation on Gitano Dragoneiti's otherwise aristocratic face.

So even vampires weren't perfectly unified.

That was good news for Henry.

The vampire who had fastened the collar on Henry looked exactly like the stereotypical degenerate vampire seen in movies.

A burly man with messy hair and a thick beard—yet he leaned close to Henry's ear like a lover whispering sweet words.

Except the words were pure threat.

> "Mutant... what right do you have to negotiate with us?"

"We say something, you obey. Understand?"

Suppressing the urge to recoil from the foul breath blowing into his ear, Henry ignored the man completely.

Instead he addressed Dragoneiti directly.

"I used to think that with longer lifespans, even if someone wasn't very smart originally, accumulated experience would at least make them more mature."

He tilted his head.

"But apparently there are still idiots who behave like street thugs."

"Is that normal among vampires?"

Dragoneiti seized the opportunity to vent some frustration at his subordinate.

"Some dogs are simply impossible to train."

"Give them a moment's freedom and they break the leash and start biting people."

"Living longer doesn't change that."

"Some creatures don't want to be human. They prefer being dogs."

"After all, living like an animal is much easier than living like a man."

Henry laughed.

"Well, that's certainly educational."

The scruffy vampire was furious.

He shoved Henry hard.

Henry pretended to lose balance, stumbling against the armrest of his chair.

Then the vampire turned toward Dragoneiti.

"Elder, I'm helping you."

"And yet you're siding with a mutant against your own kind."

"How is that right?"

Dragoneiti raised an eyebrow.

"And how exactly did you help me?"

The vampire proudly explained:

"This mutant only dares to speak like that because his body is bulletproof."

"But now his power is suppressed."

"The collar around his neck has explosives inside."

He lifted a small remote detonator.

"At any moment I can blow his head off."

"So now we tell him what to do—and he obeys."

Dragoneiti asked calmly:

"And what exactly do we want him to do?"

The vampire answered immediately:

"Infiltrate the Stark Group."

"Help us control the company."

Dragoneiti looked at him with mild disbelief.

"You just said he needs to infiltrate."

"How exactly does he do that while wearing a bomb collar?"

"We take it off later."

"And once it's off, why would he listen to you?"

The vampire turned to Henry and snarled:

about:blank

"You better listen!"

"Or I'll kill you!"

Henry raised his hands innocently.

"Of course I'll listen."

"My credibility is as reliable as Jewish merchants worldwide."

Then he lost his composure slightly and started chuckling through his nose.

The sarcasm was obvious.

The vampire's rage exploded.

He grabbed Henry's collar, revealing yellowed teeth as his canines lengthened into fangs.

"You sarcastic bastard!"

"I'll drain you dry!"

"Mutant or not!"

BANG!

A gunshot exploded.

The bullet entered through the back of the vampire's skull.

When it exited the forehead, it left a bowl-sized hole.

Blood and brain matter splattered everywhere—covering Henry's suit.

So much for that Armani suit.

Henry pushed the corpse away and looked curiously at Dragoneiti.

"Does that actually work?"

"Will it kill him?"

Dragoneiti handed the pistol to one of his subordinates and calmly wiped his hands with a silk handkerchief.

"You mean killing him?"

"No."

"He'll recover soon."

"Just extremely hungry."

"But the pain is real."

"We still have nervous systems."

"For discipline, this level is perfect."

He avoided discussing their real weaknesses.

Henry didn't press.

Instead he watched with fascination as the vampire began regenerating.

The man slowly stood up.

A huge crater remained in his skull.

His body swayed awkwardly, like a drunk trying to regain balance.

Watching vampire regeneration wasn't exactly a common opportunity.

Henry carefully observed the process—even the microscopic details invisible to normal eyes.

Even the missing brain tissue began reconstructing itself.

Henry commented casually:

"Looks like his stupidity is natural."

"Not the result of having his brains blown out too many times."

Ignoring the earlier warning that newly regenerated vampires would be extremely hungry, Henry calmly returned to his seat.

As expected—

The recovering vampire lunged toward Henry, desperate for blood.

But Dragoneiti had already anticipated this.

A subordinate quickly brought out a large beer mug filled with blood.

The starving vampire immediately changed targets.

Like a dog chasing food, he abandoned Henry and threw himself at the blood.

He even knocked the mug over in his frenzy.

Then he dropped to the floor, licking the spilled blood like an animal.

The humiliating sight darkened Dragoneiti's expression.

But instead of reprimanding the subordinate, he studied Henry carefully.

Henry's reactions kept surprising him.

He wasn't like those mortals who worshipped vampires and desired immortality.

Nor did he fear their power.

Though that part made sense—Henry belonged to another extraordinary group.

Still, Henry showed zero concern about the suppressor collar around his neck.

Was he simply confident in his value?

Or did he have another reason?

At this point Dragoneiti had already lost most interest in continuing persuasion.

With his experience, he could easily tell Henry had been playing along half-heartedly the entire time.

Allowing his subordinate to interrupt earlier had been another way to probe Henry's mindset.

Unfortunately, the results were disappointing.

Still, he decided to give Henry one final chance.

Pretending not to notice the collar around Henry's neck, Dragoneiti spoke calmly.

Chapter 435 435 — Parting on Bad Terms

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The classic good cop—bad cop tactic.

Whether it had been prearranged or not, it might work well on ordinary people.

But for Henry, it only depended on how much he felt like playing along.

Although Gitano Dragoneiti maintained his aristocratic elegance, Henry could still sense the subtle shift in his mood—from earlier enthusiasm to the current cold detachment.

If this had been a few years ago, Henry might have chosen to say some conciliatory words, hoping the other party would leave him alone before quietly disappearing somewhere far away.

After all, back then he had no attachments.

Even if they chased him, could they really follow him to the ends of the earth?

But things were different now.

So when faced with Dragoneiti's veiled threat, Henry simply replied with deliberate calm:

"I understand."

"Everyone runs into people like that sometimes."

"They can be quite troublesome, right?"

Who exactly are 'they'?

That was the first question in the old vampire's mind.

But before Dragoneiti could ask further, the reckless vampire who had already recovered stood up again.

Almost deliberately, he smeared the blood on his mouth and cheeks even more messily.

Then he declared arrogantly:

"Look at this."

"A weak human would already be on the way to the morgue after an injury like that."

"But we—whose vitality is far stronger—can survive."

"This proves we are superior lifeforms."

He glared at Henry.

"Mutant."

"Are you still unwilling to submit?"

"If you continue to resist the inevitable, the future will leave you only one fate—slavery."

"I look forward to seeing whether that unreliable, hard body of yours can keep you alive until then."

Henry seemed completely unconcerned.

Instead, he said thoughtfully:

"You know... that speech sounds familiar."

"Oh right."

"That's basically what our boss Magneto always says."

"Mutants are more evolved than humans, therefore mutants should rule the world."

He shrugged.

"Mr. Brown..."

"It's somewhat embarrassing to admit."

"But newly turned descendants often behave like that fool—impulsive and reckless."

"You must understand..."

"I won't always be there to stop him in time."

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"Why don't you guys go talk to Magneto and decide who should be the boss?"

"Although last I heard, the old man got chased by the U.S. military all the way to some island north of Madagascar, hiding among the people on Africa's east coast."

He tilted his head.

"So how is your world domination project going?"

"You've had a complete power structure for ages."

"Surely this ambition didn't start today."

"So why couldn't you do it before?"

"What suddenly makes you think you can do it now?"

The young vampire was completely thrown off.

Even with blood all over his face, his embarrassment was obvious.

After a long pause, he finally blurted:

"...We have guns now."

Henry burst out laughing.

He tried to suppress it, but his shoulders shook uncontrollably.

"Alright, you have guns."

"As if humans don't."

Then he asked calmly:

"How many nuclear warheads do you control?"

"I mean the kind that can actually be launched."

"We don't need nuclear weapons!" the vampire snarled.

Henry looked genuinely surprised.

"You don't?"

"Did I hear that right?"

"You want to challenge nuclear-armed nations without equivalent weapons?"

He leaned forward slightly.

"Can your regeneration withstand nuclear explosions?"

Wolverine had technically survived an atomic blast once—by hiding inside a well.

Could vampires do the same?

If they could, Henry would need to significantly revise his evaluation of Marvel vampires.

But the young vampire only shouted angrily:

"We hide among humans!"

"What kind of madman would use nuclear weapons on us?!"

Henry nodded slowly.

"Oh, so that's your strategy."

"You're betting your survival on politicians having humanity."

Then he asked softly:

"Are you serious?"

The young vampire had no answer.

Who would have thought—

A vampire could be mocked for being too kind?

The humiliation was unbearable.

He pulled a remote control from his pocket and roared:

"I'll kill you!"

He slammed the button—

—or tried to.

BANG!

Another gunshot.

This time the bullet punched through his hand, blowing a hole through it.

His head remained intact.

Henry immediately noticed the precision of the shot.

The bullet had severed the tendons in the hand, causing the fingers to hang limp.

Pressing the detonator was now impossible.

The remote fell to the ground and was quickly picked up by the shooter, who handed it to Dragoneiti.

Dragoneiti examined the device.

Then he raised it slightly.

"It appears there's no disarm switch on this."

The injured vampire knelt on the floor clutching his hand, laughing through the pain.

"That collar can't be unlocked."

"Only detonated."

Henry scoffed.

"Do you even believe that yourself?"

"I wouldn't need complicated tools."

"I could walk down to South Central, find a random kid, give him a piece of wire and a five-dollar bill."

"He'd unlock it for you in seconds."

As he spoke, Henry casually pulled a hairpin from a nearby woman's head.

He fiddled with the collar around his neck.

Click.

The supposedly "unremovable" collar popped open and fell off.

Henry caught it easily.

He examined it theatrically.

"Well."

"I just saved five dollars."

"Which technician told you this thing couldn't be opened?"

"You should bite him first."

In reality, the device was so crudely made Henry almost felt embarrassed criticizing it.

The detonator wiring was exposed.

The battery was exposed.

Remove either one and the bomb wouldn't work.

Chapter 436 436 — Uneasy Days

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Henry's first meeting with the vampires had ended unpleasantly, but it hadn't escalated into a mortal feud...

Had it?

Henry couldn't shake the uneasy feeling.

According to most movies and novels, vampires were vengeful creatures, the kind that would retaliate over the smallest slight.

But their long lifespans also meant something else:

they often became fascinated with anything that could relieve their boredom.

Until the vampires made their stance clear, Henry couldn't justify attacking them first under the excuse of "prevention."

If he misjudged the situation and it escalated into full-blown war with no room for retreat, that would be incredibly foolish.

In the martial worlds of old, striking first might have been considered smart.

But in modern society?

Strike first and you bear all the responsibility.

As for the lock?

Barely worth mentioning.

Henry almost tossed the collar at the kneeling vampire.

But in the end he placed it politely beside the wine bottle on the table.

Maintaining his composure.

The young vampire stared in shock.

"How... how did you open it?"

Henry leaned down close to him.

"You didn't think my only strength was a special ability, did you?"

"My greatest weapon has always been intelligence."

"Not this bulletproof body."

He straightened.

"But someone who refuses to use his brain probably wouldn't understand that."

Henry turned toward the host.

"Mr. Dragoneiti."

"I have other matters to attend to, so I can't stay longer."

"Thank you for the invitation tonight."

"But I'll be leaving now."

He began walking toward the exit.

Dragoneiti did not stand.

He did not attempt to stop him.

Instead he calmly poured himself another drink.

Then he said quietly:

"If you leave like this, Mr. Brown..."

"Things may become different in the future."

The threat could not have been clearer.

But Henry had no intention of backing down.

He pointed at the stunned vampire kneeling on the floor.

"With companions like that..."

"I don't think whether we cooperate or not will change my situation much."

"What do you think?"

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And since this was Henry's first real contact with vampires, he couldn't draw firm conclusions yet.

The reckless thug-like vampire certainly matched the grotesque stereotype Henry had imagined.

But the other one—the elder—was completely different.

Deep, composed, calculating.

That one was far more dangerous.

And with Henry's current knowledge, he simply couldn't predict what methods such a person might use.

Expecting them to simply forget everything was unrealistic.

Otherwise Old Charlie from the Continental wouldn't have described them with the phrase:

> "They'll pester you endlessly."

Charlie Fisher had his own motives, so not everything he said could be trusted.

But that particular warning?

Probably worth believing.

Unfortunately, Henry had no suitable personnel for surveillance, and no effective monitoring network for this situation.

So the only option was to wait passively for the vampires to make a move before deciding how to respond.

Or—

He could personally monitor everything 24 hours a day with Kryptonian senses.

...Right.

And never live a normal life again?

Was staring at vampires all day really going to make life better?

With that lingering anxiety, time slowly passed.

Spring faded into early summer.

---

Henry was currently lounging in the CEO office of Stark Pictures.

Officially, he was "reviewing development progress on Git."

In reality, he was slacking off.

The internet in 1996 was still primitive compared to the future.

Resources were scattered and limited, but the basic framework already existed.

At this time, portal websites controlled the flow of information.

Sites like:

Yahoo!

MSN

Lycos

Excite

They acted as the main gateways directing internet traffic.

Search engines built around web crawlers hadn't yet taken center stage.

People often assumed that if someone had simply invented Google early, they would have become unimaginably rich.

But it wasn't that simple.

Portal sites were important because they guided users into understanding the internet.

They were like a table of contents in a book.

They told readers what information existed and where to find it.

But only within that book.

Only when users grew dissatisfied with the limited information available through portals would the internet eventually shift toward search engines as the main navigation tool.

That transition required time.

For someone like Henry, however, the limited recommendations on portal homepages were far too restrictive.

To be fair, most sites featured there were legitimate and high-quality.

Advertising dominance hadn't yet completely taken over.

At this stage, most internet companies were still fueled by passion and investment money, not profit.

They hadn't even figured out sustainable business models yet.

So the internet still felt relatively free of commercial stink.

But some websites could never appear on portal homepages.

And they wouldn't show up in internal searches either.

These fell into two categories:

1. Sites that refused to cooperate with portals and used technical methods to block traffic redirection.
2. Sites that portals refused to list, due to legal or reputational concerns.

These places formed the proto-dark web.

Some sites were even more aggressive.

Just like Henry's old Joker BBS.

If your cybersecurity wasn't good enough, simply connecting to the site could result in your system being counter-hacked immediately.

Henry, of course, ignored such limitations.

He simply scanned every responsive IP address and monitored internal traffic across connected servers.

Internet information was messy and unreliable.

But it was still the fastest and least restricted communication channel in existence.

Which meant valuable intelligence could definitely be found there.

For years, Henry had quietly monitored online information and refined his own search engine.

Chapter 437 437 — The Threat Emerges

Now, with vampires possibly targeting him, and lacking other leads, the internet became an obvious place to look.

Unfortunately, most results were just fabricated vampire stories.

Of course, real vampires wouldn't openly announce themselves online.

Neither would their thralls or human followers—the ones hoping to become vampires someday.

Only a few arrogant individuals dared to hint at their identities.

And even then, people usually dismissed them as lunatics.

Most communication occurred through cryptic language and subtle clues.

Sometimes, deeper conversations revealed hints.

Sometimes someone simply slipped up.

So Henry constantly adjusted his algorithms, trying to identify meaningful patterns rather than relying on crude keyword searches.

What he didn't realize was that the vampires had already begun applying pressure.

Just not on him.

Instead—

They targeted the people around him.

Those people had endured it for quite some time before finally reaching their limit.

---

Bang!

The door to Henry's office burst open.

J.J. Harris stormed inside, dragging along a barely restrained Charlize Theron.

Henry had already detected their approach with his super-senses, so he wasn't startled.

But when J.J. slammed both hands on his desk, her fury was undeniably intimidating.

"What exactly did you do?!"

Her voice was low and vibrating with anger.

Henry blinked calmly.

"That depends."

"I know what I've done."

"But I don't know which of those things affected you."

He gestured toward the chairs.

"So let's sit down and talk."

Then he spoke toward the door.

"Miss Williams, please bring coffee for my guests."

Outside the office, Henry's secretary—the chubby Black girl—had been half-peeking through the doorway hoping to overhear gossip.

Henry's sudden call startled her.

"Y-yes, Mr. Brown!"

She hurried off toward the coffee machine.

It wasn't really her fault she hadn't stopped them.

Henry never required her to block visitors.

The CEO's office was usually open to employees, and anyone could come discuss work matters unless a meeting was already underway.

And besides—

One of the visitors was Charlize Theron.

She had come to Stark Pictures many times before.

Everyone recognized her.

Which was exactly why Charlize and J.J. Harris had been able to storm straight in without resistance.

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After sitting down, the two women showed completely different expressions.

One was still seething with anger.

The other looked apologetic.

Charlize spoke first.

"I actually wanted to ask you tonight," she said softly.

"But J.J. insisted we come immediately."

Henry nodded.

"Alright then."

"So what exactly happened that made you this angry, Ms. Harris?"

J.J. Harris finally explained.

"For the past month, my work has faced resistance like I've never seen before."

"Projects I was confident about suddenly rejected me for no reason."

"Even jobs that had already been verbally agreed upon—if the contract wasn't signed yet—they replaced us with someone else."

"And the ones that were signed?"

"They're trying every possible excuse to terminate the contracts without compensation."

Her voice grew sharper.

"And that's not even the worst part."

"Big-name stars who shouldn't even care about these tiny roles have been taking turns targeting the jobs I arrange."

"I seriously doubt they even want those roles."

"Until today, I finally heard from a contact that the problem traces back to you."

She stared straight at Henry.

"So I want to know."

"Who exactly did you offend that they can pull something like this?"

Henry tapped his fingers lightly on the desk.

Then he asked calmly:

"So... only work-related interference?"

"Only?" J.J. snapped.

"This is already extremely serious!"

"And it's not just affecting Charlize."

"Even my other clients are getting dragged into this mess because of me."

Just then, Yulian Williams, the chubby secretary, brought in coffee.

She set the cups in front of the guests.

But instead of leaving, she lingered nearby with the tray, clearly hoping to listen to the gossip.

Henry didn't scold her.

He simply said:

"Miss Williams."

"Please close the office door on your way out."

"And if anyone comes looking for me, inform me through the intercom."

"Got it, boss."

Though she agreed, her steps were slow and reluctant as she left.

The CEO office door was made of solid wood, thick and tightly sealed.

Once it closed, anyone outside would hear nothing unless they pressed their ear against the door.

Only then did Henry speak again.

"I think I know who's causing the trouble."

"Who?" J.J. asked immediately.

Henry said the name calmly.

"Gitano Dragoneiti."

J.J. inhaled sharply.

"Gi—"

"How did you manage to offend him?"

Henry shrugged.

"So you've heard the name."

"That saves me some explanation."

Charlize frowned.

Their conversation sounded like riddles to her.

"Who is that?" she asked.

Henry gestured toward J.J.

"You explain."

J.J. hesitated slightly before speaking.

"I've only heard the name once before."

"Ordinary people don't even know they exist."

"They control a lot of resources."

"And their influence is wide—wide enough to reach the major Hollywood studios."

Her expression grew uneasy.

"The worst part is... their methods are strange."

"People who offend them sometimes disappear without a trace."

Charlize leaned forward.

"And...?"

J.J. hesitated.

Then said it anyway.

"I've heard they're... vampires."

Charlize burst out laughing.

"Vampires?"

"That's impossible."

But when she saw both her agent and Henry maintaining completely serious expressions, the smile slowly faded.

"...Wait."

"You're serious?"

Henry pointed at himself.

"Mutants running around the world used to be shocking too."

"Now everyone's used to it."

"So having vampires or werewolves around isn't that surprising."

"Back in World War II, Captain America's Howling Commandos already had all kinds of monsters among them."

Of course, Henry himself wasn't a mutant.

He was an alien.

But when talking to normal people, using the mutant label was incredibly convenient.

It saved a lot of explanation.

And misdirected people.

Mutants were at least Earth natives.

Aliens?

Try explaining that properly.

Charlize leaned back, stunned.

"So vampires really exist..."

"I thought they only showed up in movies or novels."

Then she suddenly looked worried.

"What if I accidentally walk into a vampire den somewhere and never come out?"

Henry shook his head.

"Not likely."

"As far as I know, their gathering places are closed environments."

"You can't enter unless someone inside brings you in."

"Ordinary people won't encounter them."

When Henry first arrived in Los Angeles, he had practically explored the entire city.

Officially it was to find good restaurants.

In reality it was also reconnaissance.

He had never seen a public nightclub suddenly raining blood from the sprinklers while vampires massacred everyone inside.

If that kind of thing happened regularly, it would be impossible for ordinary society not to notice.

He also never deliberately forced his way into sealed or restricted locations.

Which was exactly why he hadn't encountered vampires until now.

J.J. asked again:

"So what do they want?"

Henry answered honestly.

"Their real target is Tony Stark and Stark Industries."

"You, me—we're just collateral."

J.J. sighed.

"That's... bad."

Charlize looked confused.

"How bad?"

Henry explained calmly.

"It means the situation can't be solved by apologizing or cooperating."

"If we give them one inch, they'll keep pushing forward."

"There's no end."

"Eventually they'll force us to do things we don't want to do."

"Possibly even illegal things."

"I told you already."

"Their goal is Stark Industries."

"In that process, we're just expendable pawns."

Charlize finally understood.

If the problem could be solved with an apology or compromise, that would still be negotiable.

Chapter 438 438 — Happy Birthday

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After thinking for a moment, Henry added:

"Darling, the reason I'm telling you all this is so you'll be extra careful in daily life."

"I don't know when they might escalate their methods, or how far they're willing to go."

"Anything done in my name—someone claiming I asked them to take you somewhere or have you do something—just refuse immediately."

"If something really comes up, I'll tell you myself or come get you personally."

"I'll never send strangers or people we don't both know."

"If anyone insists, just call me directly."

Charlize wasn't the type of girl who panicked and cried for help whenever trouble appeared.

She thought carefully about Henry's advice before asking:

"Would... these people really go that far?"

What she didn't say out loud was obvious:

That would basically be kidnapping.

It was a simple question.

So simple that Henry didn't know how to answer.

After a moment, he spoke honestly.

"I hope they won't."

"But vampires aren't just one or two individuals."

"They're a group. A big one."

"And within that group..."

"There are some who act like polite aristocrats—smiling while stabbing you in the back."

"And others who behave like street thugs—reckless, impulsive, and completely irrational."

"That's why I didn't even bother pretending to cooperate with them."

"I rejected them outright."

"Because inside their ranks there are too many unstable time bombs."

"They could explode at any moment."

"And when they do, they won't care who gets caught in the blast—even their own people."

"In many films and novels, vampires are portrayed as insane."

"That stereotype didn't appear for no reason."

"Don't treat them like normal humans."

But if the vampires had larger ambitions, the outcome would either be death or being forced into crime.

Neither option was acceptable.

Even if the pressure wasn't directly on her.

J.J. Harris also had no right to ask Henry to betray Stark Industries just to make her job easier.

But the feeling of mortals suffering while gods fight was truly awful.

After laying everything out clearly, Henry asked:

"That's why I asked earlier."

"Is it only work that's being targeted?"

"If there's no threat to your lives, then we deal with this professionally."

"Find a way to break through."

"Not surrender."

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Charlize forced herself to stay strong.

"I understand."

But her face was still pale.

She just hadn't realized it.

Seeing the tension on her face, Henry opened a drawer and pulled out a beautifully wrapped box.

"Well then," he said lightly.

"Happy birthday."

Charlize frowned.

"You do know my birthday is still months away, right?"

"I know," Henry replied.

"August 7th."

"I was planning to give it to you then."

"But considering the current situation... earlier seems better."

So it was probably something useful for her safety.

Charlize began unwrapping the gift.

Inside the box were five watches.

Three women's wristwatches

Two pocket watches

The wristwatches came in:

Gold

Silver

Soft pink gold, striking and elegant

The pocket watches were simpler—one gold and one silver.

No flashy pink gold this time.

Charlize's eyes immediately lit up.

Even J.J. Harris couldn't hide her reaction.

"All... all of these are for me?" Charlize asked.

Henry nodded.

"I made them myself."

"Using gold and platinum."

"They're not famous brands, but the designs should match many outfits."

"You made them yourself?!" Charlize exclaimed.

Both she and J.J. quickly examined the watches closely.

Henry smiled.

"Don't worry about accuracy."

"They use tourbillon mechanisms."

"Not like Rolex watches that need adjusting every day."

It was ironic.

Rolex might be among the least accurate luxury watches, yet they held the best resale value.

Pawnshops would often refuse many expensive brands or only offer about 30% value.

But Rolex?

They accepted it without hesitation and would lend up to 70% of its value.

Some even more expensive brands weren't nearly as popular in second-hand markets.

Charlize hadn't yet reached the level where every accessory she wore needed a famous label.

Henry's watches had elegant designs that perfectly suited her taste.

She immediately chose the pink-gold wristwatch.

The metal bracelet fit her wrist perfectly.

The edges were carefully polished too, so unlike cheap metal watches, it wouldn't scratch the skin.

Seeing how much she liked it made Henry smile.

"Now press the side button."

Charlize followed his instructions.

Normally that knob should be pulled out to adjust the watch.

But pressing it didn't seem to do anything.

She felt no movement.

However—

At the exact moment she pressed it, the watch on Henry's wrist flashed a red warning light.

It also emitted a beeping alarm sound.

Henry raised his wrist to show them before silencing the alert.

"It's also an alarm device."

"If you're ever in danger or trouble, pressing that button will send me a signal."

Charlize stared at him.

"All of them can do that?"

"Of course."

Henry continued:

"I'll admit that each watch and pocket watch also contains a tracking device."

"But the tracker only activates after you trigger the alarm."

"Normally it won't tell me where you are."

"But if you're uncomfortable with that possibility..."

"Then you probably shouldn't wear it."

Chapter 439 439 — A Problem Pressing Close

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The information from J.J. Harris was extremely valuable.

At the very least, it gave Henry a clearer picture of how powerful vampires were in the United States—especially in Hollywood.

Within the circles of old white elites and old-money families, vampires had not achieved complete control.

That was good news.

If even those circles had fallen, Henry would have to start wondering whether the people living in the White House were still human.

If the world had really reached the stage where all the shadowy rulers were vampires, Henry would probably just find a quiet place to hide and stop getting involved in anything.

Fortunately, things hadn't gone that far.

Compared to the open and widespread presence of mutants, vampires were incredibly low-key—so much so that people barely noticed they existed.

Mutants might still attract attention, but they were no longer shocking.

Mention vampires, however, and most people would still react with disbelief.

With this new understanding, Henry said to J.J.:

"Since that group can't completely control Hollywood resources, we should focus on the areas they can't influence."

Charlize rolled her eyes.

"You jerk."

"You didn't have to ruin the moment by saying that."

But she made no move to take off the pink-gold watch.

Henry chuckled.

"I prefer explaining things clearly."

"If you found out about it later in some awkward situation, I'm not confident you'd calmly listen to my explanation."

Knowing his personality well by now, Charlize stuck out her tongue playfully at him in protest.

Meanwhile, J.J. Harris—who had just witnessed an overload of couple affection—suddenly felt like going home to hug her husband.

Still, Henry didn't leave her out.

He turned to her and said:

"Jen, I don't believe Dragoneiti's blockade covers everything."

"There must be areas they can't fully control."

"And those areas are our opportunities."

"If vampires truly ruled Hollywood and controlled all resources..."

"Then surrender wouldn't be my plan."

"I'd just leave."

J.J. nodded.

"As far as I know, they do have influence over the top-tier resources and the major studios."

"But control?"

"Not even close."

"However, those top-tier resources operate on mutual benefit exchanges."

"Charlize's commercial value isn't high enough yet to attract their attention."

"But within the level she currently works in..."

"The vampires can easily sabotage things."

"And that's exactly what makes this situation so difficult."

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"I'll help however I can."

"The choices might be fewer, but it's still better than being completely controlled."

"Our current strategy is simple."

"If we can avoid something, we avoid it."

"If we can't avoid it, we give it up."

"And if there's something we absolutely cannot give up—then we'll find a solution together."

Charlize and J.J. exchanged a glance.

They felt helpless, but they had to admit his reasoning made sense.

Compared to being dragged into a conflict between vampires and Tony Stark, their current problems didn't seem so terrible.

J.J. then said:

"There actually is something we can't ignore right now."

"And we're almost out of time."

Henry asked,

"What is it?"

J.J. opened her schedule notebook.

"Charlize appears in The Rock."

"The premiere is scheduled for June 7th."

"I had already arranged a gown rental company."

"But they've refused to work with me now."

"And every other rental company I contacted gave me the same response."

She looked at Charlize.

"You can't seriously have her attend the premiere wearing that, can you?"

Charlize glanced at herself.

She was currently wearing:

A T-shirt

Jeans

A short denim jacket

Perfectly normal casual wear.

Even stylish for everyday life.

But on a red carpet?

She would get absolutely destroyed by the press.

J.J. continued:

"Sean Connery helped Charlize quite a bit during filming."

"But I can't keep asking a legendary actor like him to speak for her all the time."

"So events like the premiere, where they appear together, are extremely important."

"We need to show Mr. Connery proper respect."

"At the very least, Charlize must have an appropriate outfit."

Henry rubbed his chin.

"A gown, huh..."

"What if we buy one?"

J.J. shook her head.

"Sometimes if a star hasn't reached a certain level of commercial value, some brands don't want that person wearing their dresses publicly."

"The dresses you can buy are usually not from the current season."

"And you'd spend a lot of money on something you can only wear once."

"Maybe twice if you alter it and wait long enough."

"If we do that repeatedly in the future, the cost becomes enormous."

She looked at him.

"Are you sure you can afford that?"

She didn't even bother asking Charlize.

As her agent, she knew exactly how much Charlize was earning.

Her current salary only allowed her to escape the working-class grind.

A wardrobe budget like that was impossible.

Charlize shook her head quickly.

"Let's not buy one."

"That's too wasteful."

"Is there another option?"

"Another option..." Henry leaned back in his chair, hands behind his head, thinking.

J.J. added:

"Some small designers I know have also received pressure from that side."

"They don't dare work with me anymore."

"Especially when it comes to Charlize Theron's gowns—that topic is completely untouchable."

Neither woman really knew what kind of solution Henry could provide.

They had managed to hold out for an entire month before coming to him.

At this point they were basically out of options.

Suddenly Henry stopped spinning his chair.

He turned to face the desk again.

"I'll try making a call."

"But honestly, I don't know if it'll work."

Both women immediately wondered:

Can he really fix this?

Henry had already picked up the phone and started dialing a long-distance number.

"Bonjour!"

Then he launched into rapid-fire French.

The two women could only recognize the language.

Chapter 440 440 — Visiting Château du Jonchet

They understood none of the content.

The conversation sounded cheerful, full of laughter.

That alone made them feel a bit hopeful.

After hanging up, Henry immediately dialed another number.

More French.

This conversation lasted even longer.

The two women waited anxiously.

Finally Henry put the phone down.

Before they could ask anything, he spoke first.

"Jen, does Charlize have any scheduled work after this?"

"And do you have anything urgent?"

J.J. shook her head.

"No."

"Everything on our schedule has already received clear rejections."

"We can't even try negotiating anymore."

Henry nodded.

"Good."

"Then it's not a problem."

"We're flying to Paris."

"We're going to visit a friend of mine."

He stood up and picked up his suit jacket.

Then he chuckled.

"Although I'm not even sure he'll admit I'm his friend."

"I didn't realize my reputation was that big."

J.J. asked cautiously,

"Who are we going to see?"

Henry answered:

"Hubert de Givenchy."

"He stepped down as creative director of LVMH last year and retired."

"But he still has plenty of connections."

"We'll ask him if there's any way to solve Charlize's problem."

J.J. stared at him.

"You... know Givenchy?"

Henry shrugged.

"I met him when I worked as Audrey Hepburn's assistant."

"I wasn't even sure I could reach him, so I didn't mention it before."

"But it seems things worked out."

He sounded slightly uncertain.

Perhaps it was because, during Hepburn's final days, Henry had helped Givenchy arrange everything when they brought her back to Switzerland.

That shared experience had left a bond.

Just moments ago, the two women had been in a situation where no one in Hollywood would even work with them.

Now suddenly they were about to visit a legendary fashion designer in Paris.

It felt surreal.

Henry, however, didn't dwell on the emotion.

He opened the office door and said:

"Miss Williams."

"Please book flights to Paris for me, Charlize, and Ms. Harris."

"Yes, boss."

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The commune of Romilly-sur-Aigre, in France's Eure-et-Loir department, lies southwest of Paris.

It's a small place with fewer than five hundred residents, still preserving much of its old-world charm.

In the early 1970s, Hubert de Givenchy, who held the title of a French count, purchased a Renaissance-style castle built in the 16th century there—

Château du Jonchet.

To design the castle gardens, Givenchy invited Rachel Lambert Mellon, the daughter-in-law of the Mellon family who had also designed the White House Rose Garden.

The collaboration sparked a friendship that lasted decades.

Although called a castle, Château du Jonchet is architecturally closer to Versailles than to a medieval fortress.

It was designed primarily as a residence and administrative center, not a defensive stronghold.

After stepping down as creative director of LVMH and leaving the fashion industry, Givenchy retired here.

His main interests became collecting 17th- and 18th-century bronze and marble sculptures.

Of course, Givenchy wasn't the only resident.

Living with him was his partner, Philippe Venet, also a fashion designer.

Venet had co-founded Givenchy with Hubert and served as the house's chief tailor until 1962, when he launched his own label.

Their professional paths diverged, but their relationship continued unchanged.

From Charles de Gaulle Airport in Paris, renting a car and driving a little over two hours brings visitors to the small town.

The grounds of Château du Jonchet extend far beyond the main building.

They include:

A maze of boxwood hedges

The rose garden designed by Rachel Lambert Mellon

A greenhouse

An artificial lake

A private chapel

A moat

An indoor swimming pool

A dog cemetery

And even a small forest

Naturally, the castle required a number of servants and staff to maintain the property.

As a side note:

Hubert de Givenchy's father was the Marquis of Givenchy from the Taffin family, a title granted during the reign of Louis XIV in 1713.

The marquiseate was inherited by Givenchy's elder brother, leaving Hubert, the younger son, with the lesser title of count.

Because Henry had arranged the visit in advance, entering the estate posed no difficulty.

They soon arrived at the main entrance of the castle.

To Henry's surprise, Givenchy himself—already sixty-nine years old—stood outside waiting to greet them.

After parking the car, Henry first opened the door for the two women before stepping forward to greet his host.

The two men exchanged a traditional French cheek-kiss greeting.

"Bonjour, Givenchy."

"Coucou, Henry. Long time no see."

Henry presented his gifts:

A box of chocolates from La Maison du Chocolat

And his own book, Love from a Foreign Culture, which had been published some time ago (English edition only)

The chocolates, though high-quality, were commercially available.

Givenchy casually handed them to a servant.

But he examined the book with interest.

"This is the book Audrey recommended for you?"

"Yes."

"Fortunately the book jacket still carries Audrey Hepburn's endorsement, so it didn't lose money."

"But sales were... average."

Givenchy chuckled.

"I have a feeling the real reason is that you were too lazy to promote it."

Henry laughed awkwardly.

The retired fashion legend still had sharp instincts.

Henry quickly introduced his companions.

"These two are Charlize Theron and her agent J.J. Harris."

Then he turned back.

"Ladies, this is Count Hubert de Givenchy."

Since it was their first meeting, the greetings were polite and formal.

They exchanged handshakes, not the traditional hand-kiss greeting.

Givenchy also introduced his partner.

"This is Philippe Venet, my husband."

"Nice to meet you."

"A pleasure."

"Good afternoon."

The group then entered the house.

Being invited into a French person's home is actually quite rare.

Unlike Americans—who frequently host parties at home—French homes are considered very private spaces.

Without sufficient friendship, visiting someone's home is almost impossible.

However, for social figures at the level of Givenchy or the Mellons, their "home" is so large that separate areas are naturally reserved for receiving guests.

Naturally, their visit included touring:

The rose garden designed by Rachel Lambert Mellon

And Givenchy's private sculpture collection

In a house belonging to a fashion icon, it's difficult to explain the atmosphere with complex theory.

Simply put—

Everything felt comfortable.

Visually comfortable.

Experientially comfortable.

And the sense of being immersed in the space was deeply relaxing.

This feeling couldn't be achieved merely by placing expensive objects together.

It was like admiring a great artwork.

Experts might describe it with endless theories.

But ordinary people only need one simple reaction:

"It's beautiful."

Because Henry and the others had traveled all the way from the United States, they were invited to stay for dinner.

The meal was casual French home cooking:

Boeuf bourguignon (red wine braised beef)

Garlic pumpkin

Ratatouille

Savory French quiche

And of course, classic baguette

Normally baguettes weren't served at dinner.

But apparently Henry's appetite had already reached Givenchy's ears.

The bread was clearly prepared in case he needed extra food.

Still, as a guest in someone else's home, Henry behaved politely.

He ate at a relaxed pace and chatted naturally about what they had seen during the day.

Among the sculptures in the castle were works by masters such as:

Bernini

Puget

Girardon

Coysevox

Falconet

Pajou

Houdon

But even more numerous were anonymous pieces.

They weren't made by famous masters.

Sometimes the sculptures even had slightly awkward or strange details.

Yet they all shared one quality:

They were interesting.

At one point Henry stopped in front of a sculpture of Cupid.

He suddenly burst out laughing.

The sound amused Givenchy so much that he stopped beside him to discuss the piece.

Chapter 441 441 — Making the Request

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Even at the dinner table, Givenchy continued discussing the sculptures Henry had noticed earlier.

Many of them hadn't been perfectly preserved, meaning their current appearance was likely different from how they looked centuries ago when first completed.

According to Givenchy, these sculptures felt almost alive, continuing to "grow" as time passed.

Because of this, some pieces had gradually developed qualities that no longer matched their original themes.

Since Charlize Theron and J.J. Harris were present, the entire conversation was conducted in English.

Only occasionally—when a word was difficult to translate or when the English felt imprecise—would Givenchy and Philippe Venet switch briefly to French to clarify.

Charlize, however, was not left out of the discussion.

She had previously spent plenty of time listening to Henry analyze films—breaking down how directors, cinematographers, and actors collaborated to produce perfect cinematic language.

That exposure had trained her sensitivity to artistic expression.

She couldn't quote historical references or compare different masters the way a fashion legend—or Henry—could.

But she could describe her own impressions and feelings at just the right moment.

And that mattered.

It showed she had her own aesthetic sense, whether natural or cultivated.

Givenchy appreciated that.

What he disliked most was asking models for their thoughts and receiving nothing but empty flattery.

For dessert, they were served soufflé along with Irish coffee.

One might wonder why French people liked Irish coffee so much.

Its preparation is simple:

Hot coffee

Sugar

Irish whiskey

These are mixed together and topped with whipped cream, which is not stirred in.

As a result, each sip delivers three layers of flavor:

Cold cream

Hot coffee

Whiskey

But judging from the proportions served by Givenchy's staff, the drink tasted more like a cocktail with coffee added, rather than a normal cup of coffee.

During dessert, Givenchy finally turned the conversation to Henry.

"So, Henry," he said,

After all, it was a statue of the god of love.

But the little angel's face looked grim and resentful, as if burdened with deep grudges.

The heart shape on the arrow—whether carved intentionally or altered by time—was covered in cracks.

Cupid was supposed to bring lovers together.

But this one looked more like he had come to break couples apart.

Or perhaps to ensure that the most incompatible people ended up together.

How could anyone not laugh at that?

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"you mentioned on the phone that you were having trouble and hoped I could recommend a designer."

"What exactly is going on?"

Henry answered plainly.

"It concerns my girlfriend, Charlize Theron."

He explained her situation without hiding much.

Then he concluded:

"Because of my situation, she's being targeted as well."

"She needs to attend an important film premiere early next month."

"And right now she doesn't even have a suitable gown."

"So I was hoping you might be able to introduce us to a designer with a bit of courage."

Givenchy raised an eyebrow.

"Courage?"

"What sort of trouble have you gotten into?"

Henry replied:

"I'm not sure how well known he is outside Los Angeles on the U.S. West Coast."

"Have you heard the name Gitano Dragoneiti?"

"Dragoneiti..." Givenchy frowned.

He exchanged a glance with Philippe Venet.

"I feel like I've heard that name... in places where unpleasant things are discussed."

Henry said calmly:

"They're vampires."

"Well," Givenchy replied,

"That's not surprising."

Neither Givenchy nor Venet seemed shocked.

It was clear they already knew about that shadow world.

Givenchy asked:

"I remember you saying you recently started working for a film company in Hollywood."

"As far as I know, if you stay away from that world, they usually won't force themselves into your life—"

"Unless you possess some kind of valuable interest."

Henry nodded.

"Their real target is Tony Stark and Stark Industries."

"I'm just collateral damage."

"I've already informed Stark about the situation."

"He can issue warnings that prevent them from doing anything too outrageous."

"But it's impossible for him to protect every small detail."

With Stark's wealth and power, solving Charlize's problem would actually be easy.

The real question was:

Why would he bother?

She wasn't his girlfriend.

And even if Henry didn't mind potential rumors, asking Stark for help would give gossip journalists endless material.

Charlize was still too young in her career to endure that kind of scandal calmly.

Henry preferred avoiding problems that might later require him to act as her therapist.

That was why Givenchy was the perfect solution.

After all, Henry had already briefly explained the situation during their phone call.

Now he laid everything out clearly.

"Givenchy," he said sincerely,

"I know the fashion world is... special."

"At your level, even creatures from the darker corners of society hesitate to interfere."

"But I also understand that brands like Louis Vuitton, Chanel, or Gucci won't work with someone who lacks sufficient commercial value."

"So I'm not asking for that."

"I just want to know if you could introduce a designer brave enough to work with us despite the pressure."

"Of course, if they have conditions, we can negotiate."

"Mutual benefit is always the foundation."

The fashion industry had an enormous range.

At the top were people like Givenchy, welcomed by old-money families and European aristocrats.

At the bottom were people who simply owned a sewing machine and called themselves designers.

Even setting aside his noble lineage, fashion icons like Givenchy were highly valued by the wealthy and powerful.

Why?

Because those elites needed something to display their status.

And nothing distinguished them from ordinary people better than luxury fashion that ordinary people couldn't afford.

Chapter 442 442 — The Recommended Candidate

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Givenchy continued:

"However, this lady is... rather special."

"She isn't merely unafraid of vampires."

"She's bold to the point of recklessness. Practically no one is worthy of her respect."

"I can guarantee her talent."

"But I cannot guarantee that you will want to work with her."

"Her personality can be... quite a headache."

Henry laughed.

"That's certainly a unique evaluation."

At this moment, Philippe Venet, who had mostly been listening quietly rather than leading the conversation, seemed to realize who Givenchy intended to introduce.

He asked in French with concern:

"Are you sure? You want to involve that woman?"

Givenchy replied calmly:

"Why not?"

"Sooner or later we will have to accept her into our circle. It's only a matter of how."

"Since she can be useful now, I consider this a very fair exchange."

Venet sighed and made a small sign of the cross over his chest.

"My God. I feel like negotiating directly with vampires might actually be easier."

Hearing their exchange, Henry grew curious.

"Is there anything... we should be aware of about this designer?"

After a moment of thought, Givenchy answered honestly.

"She is the illegitimate daughter of Baroness von Hellman."

"But the Baroness was imprisoned for murder."

For them, protecting great designers was equivalent to protecting their own prestige.

As long as these designers didn't destroy their own reputations, anyone who tried to harm them had to ask themselves whether they were qualified to do so.

For those designers who hadn't yet reached that level but still dared to resist the influence of the dark world, their courage often came from:

Strong backing in other areas

Or a clear stance that attracted like-minded allies

After all, vampires might be troublesome.

But they did not completely control the dark world.

And this was the Marvel universe, a world where superheroes existed everywhere.

Even before the grand stage of heroes fully appeared, the forces held by governments—and the existence of mutants—were enough to prevent vampires from acting without restraint.

Givenchy nodded thoughtfully.

"Actually," he said,

"I do have someone in mind."

The moment those words came out—

Charlize and J.J.'s eyes lit up.

Even Henry straightened slightly.

"Oh?"

"Who might that be?"

"And could you introduce us?"

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"Some people believe that the entire incident was orchestrated by that daughter herself."

"And that she secretly transferred the Baroness's assets into her own name."

"Recently, the Baroness died in prison."

"Now that the last obstacle to inheriting the title is gone, she hopes to gain support from members of the nobility."

"And she doesn't want just any insignificant nobles."

"She wants support from someone who is..."

Henry finished the sentence for him:

"Someone like you—a noble with a legitimate title and status in the fashion world."

Givenchy nodded.

"Exactly."

"Although their family developed mainly across the Channel, Baron von Hellman's title is actually French nobility."

"That pirate country across the sea"—he meant Britain—"still uses male primogeniture, where women cannot inherit titles."

"So in the circles she has cultivated over the years, I am the most suitable candidate."

"And if she wants to climb even higher, she needs supporters with real influence."

"And a bigger stage."

"Hollywood might serve that purpose."

London was one of the four major fashion week cities, so it certainly belonged to the core of the fashion industry.

But Paris, the only city hosting Haute Couture Week, stood firmly at the top of the fashion pyramid.

Givenchy therefore had every reason to speak with such confidence.

The woman he referred to clearly came from England.

Henry sighed slightly.

"So this would mean you'd owe her a favor."

Givenchy shook his head.

"No."

"Because of her talent, I would eventually support her anyway."

"The problem is that I don't know what I would receive in return."

"You should understand something."

"Making that woman owe you a favor is meaningless."

"You must obtain something immediately."

"Otherwise she'll turn around and pretend it never happened."

Henry rubbed his chin thoughtfully.

"So that's the kind of personality she has."

"What's her name?"

Givenchy replied:

"Cruella. Cruella de Vil."

"When you see her, you'll understand."

"She's already in her forties, yet she carries herself with the energy of a young girl."

"Her ambition and aggressiveness are unlike ordinary people."

"I suspect that even if a vampire stood in front of her and bared its fangs..."

"She would bite back and drink the monster dry."

Henry paused internally.

Wait...

Wasn't that Cruella from Cruella and 101 Dalmatians?

Thinking about it carefully, in this world's Disney film catalog, 101 Dalmatians didn't exist.

Some films that existed in Henry's previous memories were missing here.

Others had appeared instead.

Perhaps some stories had been stitched into this Marvel universe differently.

He'd have to pay attention to that later.

Henry returned to the discussion.

"So how can we meet this Ms. de Vil?"

Givenchy thought for a moment.

"As it happens, in two days we'll host a semi-public gathering."

"It's a preparation event for the Paris Men's Ready-to-Wear Fashion Week at the end of June."

"I can take you with me."

"And I'll invite Cruella."

"If everything goes well, you'll meet her there."

"Do you have other plans?"

Henry glanced at the two women he had brought.

Both Charlize and J.J. Harris immediately shook their heads.

Right now, nothing in the world seemed more important than this opportunity in Paris.

Givenchy continued:

"In that case, I can arrange accommodations for you at the Paris Hotel."

"Or if you prefer, you may stay here at the castle for the next two days."

"I can show you more of the collection."

"And we could take a walk through the nearby forest."

Henry turned toward Charlize.

"What do you think, darling?"

Their relationship hadn't been hidden from Givenchy.

After all, Henry wouldn't have used this connection otherwise.

A worldly man like Givenchy understood that immediately.

Charlize smiled.

"I'd love to stay."

"When you have money, Paris can be visited anytime."

"If I wanted, I could even buy half the stores in a shopping street."

"But opportunities to interact with a fashion legend like you..."

"Those don't come just because you have money."

Chapter 443 443 — A Private Morning Concert

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However, she suddenly remembered something.

A slightly worried look appeared on her face.

"But Henry..."

"What about Kitty back home?"

Henry waved casually.

"Don't worry."

"I asked Old Gary to feed her."

"There won't be any problem."

Charlize broke into a cold sweat.

Feed her?

Was Gary supposed to feed Kitty... with himself as the food?

Of course, Henry had his reasons for traveling so far.

BB, his robot, had already been rebuilt.

Gary would simply collect the meat deliveries and leave them inside.

BB would take care of everything else.

Unless...

Kitty destroyed BB again.

Hmm.

That possibility suddenly felt a bit worrying.

Hopefully that big cat would behave itself.

Worst case, Henry could always sneak back home at night to check.

That was his quiet plan.

---

Givenchy asked curiously:

"Kitty?"

Henry grinned proudly.

"My pet."

"A very cute cat."

The two Frenchmen imagined something like:

A Ragdoll

Or a Russian Blue

The kind of cat that truly matched the word cute.

They also knew traveling with pets could be inconvenient, so leaving it at home with someone feeding it seemed perfectly reasonable.

But the two women present—who knew the truth—felt differently.

A four- to five-hundred-pound monster...

Cute?

That was probably the biggest difference in judgment between Henry and Charlize.

---

In any case, the three guests decided to stay.

They were treated to the hospitality of old French aristocracy, living temporarily in a castle that had been declared a historic monument by France in 1984.

Fortunately, the interior had been modernized.

Living conditions were very comfortable.

Unlike the Palace of Versailles during Louis XIV's era.

That palace had rooms for every imaginable purpose—

Except one.

Bathrooms.

And somehow, only the French could have built something that absurd.

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Early in the morning, Charlize Theron woke up and realized she couldn't find the man who had been beside her pillow.

That didn't make her panic.

She knew that within seven steps—

Well... seven steps was probably too short.

In any case, he would definitely be somewhere nearby.

The only question was where he might suddenly appear from to scare her again.

After being startled a few times already, she had more or less developed immunity.

After finishing her morning routine in the guest room's bathroom and getting dressed, Charlize stepped out into the hallway to look for her boyfriend.

A gentle piano melody drifted through the corridor.

Without thinking much about it, she followed the sound instinctively.

Inside the music room, the person playing the piano was indeed Henry.

Givenchy and Philippe Venet sat quietly on a vintage sofa nearby, listening attentively.

From the logo on the front of the grand piano, Charlize recognized the instrument.

It was a Steinway.

Among handmade pianos, Steinway instruments were world-renowned for reaching the pinnacle in tone, touch, and aesthetic craftsmanship.

But as for the piece Henry was playing—

Charlize couldn't identify it.

It only sounded familiar.

Trying not to disturb anyone, she quietly found a seat and sat down.

She knew Henry could play musical instruments.

When they talked about film scores, he could analyze them quite well.

But she had never heard him play guitar, and the only music she had heard from him before was electronic music he produced on computers.

So this moment was rare.

She simply listened quietly to her boyfriend's performance.

The music sounded beautiful.

Yet it didn't feel immersive.

Henry looked handsome while concentrating, but he lacked the confident aura typical of performers.

If this man weren't Henry Brown, Charlize might have felt uncomfortable sitting there.

Something about the scene felt out of place.

It reminded her of how he handled machines—

precisely manipulating them so that they performed exact movements.

Accurate.

Consistent.

But somewhat mechanical.

When the piece ended, the two men applauded politely.

They had long noticed Charlize had joined their little morning concert.

Out of respect, however, they had not interrupted the performer.

Now that the performance was over, Givenchy turned and asked:

"Miss Theron, what do you think of Henry's performance?"

Charlize replied politely,

"Mr. Givenchy, please don't call me Miss Theron. Just call me Charlize."

"Then please drop the 'Mr.' as well," Givenchy said with a smile.

"Just Givenchy."

"Philippe," his husband added.

Givenchy returned to his question.

"So, Charlize—how did Henry's music feel to you?"

Charlize hesitated.

"Um... very clean? Very precise?"

Givenchy nodded.

"I believe your impression is similar to mine."

"But if I were to describe it more precisely—"

He turned back toward Henry, who still sat on the piano bench.

"It is extremely skillful, but lacking in passion."

Philippe nodded in agreement.

"Liszt's Liebesträume No. 3 is supposed to be a piece about dreams of love."

"It should flow with a sense of magic and romance, something that captures the listener's heart."

"But Henry, your interpretation followed the sheet music perfectly, almost mechanically."

"No passion."

"Do you know that this piano piece originates from a poem?"

Henry responded immediately.

In German, he recited a line from a poem by Ferdinand Freiligrath:

> "O lieb, so lang du lieben kannst,
O lieb, so lang du lieben magst..."

Then he repeated the verse again in English, so Charlize could understand.

Philippe laughed and said to Givenchy:

"You see? Such a clever young man."

"Of course he knows the poem."

Then he turned back to Henry and spoke frankly.

"But you performed it coldly."

Henry shrugged and joked:

"Which proves that choosing not to become a pianist was probably a wise decision."

Henry was well aware that something about his psychology was... unusual.

But as the saying goes:

Doctors rarely heal themselves.

And he certainly had no intention of visiting a psychologist.

What if he accidentally met someone like Hannibal Lecter?

If that man became curious about the taste of Kryptonian flesh, what would Henry do?

In Henry's view, it wasn't really a mental disorder.

It was more like a side effect of his superbrain.

When a person analyzed everything too clearly, it became easy to fall into a form of mechanical rationality.

Since that explanation sounded reasonable enough, Henry stopped worrying about it.

But Charlize wasn't going to stand by while her boyfriend was criticized.

She walked over to the piano bench and sat down beside him, sharing half the seat.

Her fingers lightly touched the keys of the expensive instrument.

"Don't you have something more lively to play?"

She looked at him with bright, watery eyes.

Those deep eyes felt almost hypnotic.

Before Henry found himself getting lost in them, he turned his head away and placed his hands on the keys again.

"Something lively, huh?"

"How about the Finnish polka 'Ievan Polkka'?"

In the future, this song would become world-famous as the Leek Spin Song.

As Henry played, he began singing in Finnish.

When the music reached the latter half of the fifth section and the entire sixth section, the rapid, playful improvisational chanting made everyone smile.

Even Henry, singing and playing at the same time, couldn't help glancing at Charlize beside him.

Charlize initially tried to follow the beat, lightly swaying her head left and right.

But the tempo became too fast.

She quickly lost track of the rhythm and burst out laughing.

When the song ended, the two men behind them applauded enthusiastically.

"Bravo!"

Givenchy even walked over excitedly.

"I originally thought your music sounded like a machine performing."

"But apparently you need your muse beside you."

"With her here, it's like someone flipped a switch."

"Only then does your passion appear."

Henry looked surprised.

"Is the difference really that big?"

He glanced at Charlize beside him.

He had never noticed this side of himself.

Charlize herself was stunned by the effect she seemed to have—and her face flushed red.

The two older men laughed heartily.

At that moment, J.J. Harris finally arrived.

She had only heard the laughter.

"What's everyone so happy about?"

The two men excitedly summarized what had just happened.

J.J. looked at Henry with surprise.

"Henry, I didn't know you could play piano too."

Chapter 444 444 — The Black-and-White Witch

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Contrary to popular imagination, a fashion industry gathering wasn't filled with bizarre or outlandish outfits.

Perhaps it was because Paris—capital of fashion—didn't chase avant-garde eccentricity the way London did. After all, the line between innovation and absurdity often came down to a designer's whim.

Here, men focused on subtle flair layered onto formalwear—small, thoughtful details. Women leaned toward elegance and composure, with minimal exposure and restrained ornamentation.

Though it wasn't yet Fashion Week, competition among designers had already begun beneath the surface. Attendees weren't wearing outdated pieces; rather, many outfits were designs that hadn't made it onto the runway due to theme mismatches.

The guest list extended beyond designers. Brand-affiliated models attended, as did actors and singers connected to the fashion world.

Some were invited by brands.

Some came seeking endorsements.

Others simply wanted to be seen.

Givenchy and Philippe Venet arrived early.

He made no effort to hide his association with Henry and Charlize, introducing the couple openly to his circle.

Though retired, Givenchy remained a towering figure. For someone whose currency was creativity, returning to the industry would only take a decision—whether the market accepted it was another matter.

Thus, people treated him with a peculiar mix of reverence and caution:

They feared his return.

Yet hoped to benefit from his prestige.

Still, respect prevailed.

Even celebrities and models sought his approval—none dared show hostility.

Henry and Charlize, however, did not receive the same courtesy.

To Henry, the otherwise ordinary cocktail party felt like a bumper car arena.

Every few minutes—

An elbow.

A trip.

A "careless" waiter nearly spilling drinks.

Each offender would apologize profusely, feigning innocence, asking if anyone was hurt.

Occasional bumps were normal in such gatherings.

But when it happened every few minutes?

"What can't you do?"

Henry thought for a moment.

"Well..."

"If I don't know something, then I can't do it."

"That's pretty normal, right?"

Such an absurdly arrogant humblebrag earned him a round of eye-rolls from everyone present.

Just then, Givenchy's butler stepped forward politely.

"Master, honored guests."

"Breakfast is ready."

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That wasn't coincidence.

Fortunately, Henry's Kryptonian senses turned him into a perfect bodyguard. Charlize avoided embarrassment entirely.

He chose not to retaliate.

Because in such situations, both parties lose face—only one looks worse.

If others were willing to drag Charlize down, Henry refused to stoop to the same level.

He was here with a purpose—and with Givenchy.

Reputation mattered.

Charlize, on the other hand, nearly snapped more than once. She wasn't someone who tolerated bullying easily.

Each time, Henry quietly stopped her.

By now, Henry had a new understanding:

The fashion world was a battlefield.

No gunfire.

No blood.

But no less dangerous.

Just as he intercepted yet another "accidental" collision—this time stabilizing a waiter's tray mid-spill—

A commotion erupted outside.

Some guests rushed toward the entrance, as if expecting a spectacle.

Givenchy remained still, sipping his drink.

"She's here," he said calmly.

Then came laughter—bold, unapologetic.

Gasps followed.

A woman entered.

Voluminous hair split black and white.

A fur coat—despite the summer season.

A black dress.

Red lips.

Red heels.

Long crimson gloves.

The fur itself was white with black spots.

Her presence clashed violently with Parisian subtlety—loud, theatrical, impossible to ignore.

Even those who frowned couldn't help scrutinizing her outfit, searching for flaws.

She moved like a supermodel on a runway—exaggerated, deliberate, commanding attention.

Few noticed the two figures behind her:

One tall and thin.

One short and stout.

Both impeccably dressed in tailored suits and tilted bowler hats.

Individually stylish.

Collectively overshadowed.

She walked straight to Givenchy.

Without greeting, she extended her hand—adorned with a blue diamond ring.

Givenchy took it and performed a gentleman's hand-kiss.

"Cruella," he said, "your style is as striking as ever. Like an assault on the eyes. Spare an old man like me."

She pivoted smoothly, half leaning into his chest, gazing up with provocative ease.

"Old?" she purred. "Then marry me. I guarantee the rest of your life will be... spectacular."

"I already have a husband," Givenchy replied, gently pushing her away.

There were women who built fortunes through marriages and divorces.

Givenchy, with his particular preferences, had no intention of becoming such a target.

Cruella spun away effortlessly.

Her attendants moved in perfect synchronization:

One handed her an extended cigarette holder—with a cigarette already placed.

The other flicked open a Zippo—click—and lit it.

Chapter 445 445 — Terms of Alliance

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Cruella showed no concern whatsoever about monopolizing Givenchy's attention. She spoke as she pleased:

"So, you dragged me all the way from London... have you finally decided to support my claim to the title?"

"Actually," Givenchy replied calmly, "I have something I'd like your help with. An exchange of conditions—fair, wouldn't you say?"

"Acceptable." She took a drag from her cigarette and exhaled to the side. "What do you need?"

Givenchy didn't answer directly. Instead, he gave a subtle look.

"Let's find somewhere quieter."

"Fine."

The group moved to a small meeting room beside the banquet hall. After instructing security to keep others away, Givenchy closed the door.

Cruella recognized Givenchy and Philippe Venet immediately.

But the other three?

Two young people and an older woman—unknown.

So she did what she did best.

She evaluated them.

Her eyes landed on Henry first.

"Pass."

Henry blinked. "What did I do? I got dismissed in one glance?"

Cruella stepped closer, cigarette holder in hand, and spoke bluntly:

"That suit—Givenchy, seven years old. Designed for successful men over fifty.

"The cut allows for... less disciplined physiques. On you, it fits—barely acceptable.

"But the shoulders, the waistline—this was altered off-the-rack. Poor tailoring. Small flaws everywhere."

She adjusted his collar, fingers sliding down to his tie.

"For someone wearing outdated clothing, with mediocre tailoring... do you have any reason for me to take you seriously?"

She didn't wait for an answer.

"No. You don't."

Their coordination was flawless. Practiced.

This was the 1990s.

Secondhand smoke was simply endured.

No smoking bans. No objections.

In France, if you disliked the smell—you masked it with stronger perfume.

Cruella's cigarette drew no protest.

In fact, a few smokers joined in. Even cigar enthusiasts took the opportunity.

True to form, Cruella didn't circulate or greet others.

She anchored herself in front of Givenchy.

Her presence alone created a vacuum.

Others who wished to approach him hesitated—held back by the sheer force of her personality.

The room, for a moment, belonged entirely to her.

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Then—

A pause.

"But," she added, "I'll give you this—the tie. Excellent taste. Though I doubt you chose it yourself."

She glanced sideways.

"Sapphire blue with white diagonal zebra stripes. Silk. Philippe—this is yours, isn't it?"

Givenchy chuckled, nudging his old friend.

"See? She says your craftsmanship has declined."

Philippe bristled. "I've had presbyopia for years! Did you notice any flaws? If so, why didn't you tell me?"

"My eyesight isn't what it used to be either," Givenchy said, raising his hands in surrender.

Cruella smirked.

"Philippe, if your eyes are failing, stop working. No one stitches forever."

Henry nearly whistled.

What a personality.

Next came Charlize and J.J. Harris.

Cruella looked them over.

"...Acceptable."

And that was it.

Both wore older Givenchy gowns—conservative, properly fitted. Women's eveningwear was easier to adjust, leaving no obvious flaws to critique.

Cruella wasn't foolish.

She knew Givenchy hadn't brought these people here by accident.

So she stopped wasting effort on superficial judgment.

Turning back, she asked:

"This involves them, doesn't it?"

"Yes," Givenchy said. "Simply put—Ms. Charlize Theron has a film premiere next month.

"They've been targeted. No designer is willing to work with them. So they're looking for someone... bold enough to step in. Perhaps even make a move into Hollywood."

Cruella narrowed her eyes.

"Targeted? By what?"

Givenchy glanced at Henry, uncertain how much to reveal.

Henry didn't hesitate.

"Vampires."

A beat.

"Not metaphorical. Not symbolic. The kind from bedtime stories."

Cruella raised both index fingers beside her mouth, mimicking fangs.

"You mean the badly dressed, medieval-looking creatures with terrible taste?"

Henry nodded. "Those. Though they've modernized their wardrobe."

"So why aren't you consulting priests instead of me?" she asked flatly.

Henry replied:

"Because in Hollywood, they control a significant portion of the lower and mid-level infrastructure. Their influence rivals major studios.

"They're using commercial pressure against us. So we respond commercially.

"We avoid escalation—if possible. Once it escalates, the damage spreads.

"But I won't drag uninformed people into something that could turn violent. This is my first direct encounter with them. I don't know how far they'll go.

"Next step could be bloodshed."

Givenchy interjected gently:

"It's not quite that dire. They avoid exposure, which limits them. From what I've seen, firm refusal is usually enough to make them back off."

Henry didn't correct him.

For someone like Givenchy, that was true.

For others?

Not necessarily.

Cruella ignored the reassurance.

She looked straight at Henry.

"What do I get?"

Chapter 446 446 — A Dangerous Alliance

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"So you're Charlize Theron?" Cruella asked, already reaching out to pinch and prod her face. "Any cosmetic work done?"

Charlize didn't slap her hand away, but her expression turned cold.

"No money. No surgery."

"Hollywood, hm." Cruella even removed her gloves and began feeling along Charlize's figure without hesitation. "I do need a proper clothes hanger—someone who can carry a theme—for ads and editorial shoots.

"If you cooperate, providing you with gowns won't be a problem. As for how long... that depends on your performance."

J.J. Harris quickly stopped Charlize from responding and stepped forward instead.

"If my client is to shoot advertisements and editorials, how are you planning to structure compensation?"

Cruella glanced at her with clear disdain.

"And you are?"

"J.J. Harris. Charlize Theron's agent. And don't even think about suggesting unpaid work. If you damage her commercial value, it won't reflect well on your brand either."

Fashion wasn't like film.

In film, producers and directors prided themselves on doing more with less—small budgets, big results. What happened inside large productions was another matter entirely.

But fashion?

Fashion never asked how to save money.

It asked how to spend it—and spend it lavishly.

Luxury was built on excess: materials, labor, marketing. If those were cheap, the product itself couldn't claim to be high-end.

So if Cruella had Charlize work for free, she'd devalue her own brand—and drag Charlize's market value down with it.

Direct. Unfiltered.

Henry didn't expect Givenchy to carry the entire cost.

But he also had no idea what Cruella valued.

So he answered plainly:

"What do you want?"

"I'm the CEO of Stark Pictures. I have resources—at least compared to most people. I doubt you're interested in AR wearable systems.

"And that technology isn't ready for market anyway.

"So tell me what you want. It's faster than guessing."

He laid his cards on the table.

Even technical cooperation wasn't off-limits—though AR was still premature.

Cruella didn't even ask what AR was.

Instead—

She stepped directly in front of Charlize.

The future "Ice Queen," not yet at her peak presence—but already tall, poised, and unflinching.

Half a head taller than Cruella.

The two women locked eyes.

Neither yielded.

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A lose-lose scenario.

Cruella understood that perfectly.

Which meant she couldn't argue.

"Tch. Sharp agent," she muttered.

At this point, it was no longer Givenchy's place to intervene.

His role was done.

As for supporting Cruella's inheritance claim, a verbal stance was enough—no contracts required.

So he let the three women continue their verbal duel and led the men toward a small bar table in the meeting room.

These rooms were often used for private negotiations during events, so they were stocked with upside-down clean glasses and bottles of whisky and brandy.

Givenchy poured drinks for everyone.

Introductions followed.

Henry spoke first:

"I'm Henry Brown, CEO of Stark Pictures. A pleasure to meet you both."

The tall, thin man tipped his hat.

"Jasper Badun."

The shorter, heavier one removed his hat and attempted a polite bow.

"Horace Badun."

Henry raised a brow. "Brothers?"

They exchanged a glance and shook their heads.

"No. Orphans. The nun who took us in gave us the same surname. Whether we're actually related... we don't know."

Henry nodded.

"Fair enough. No offense—but my background isn't much different. Unknown parents. Same story.

"So we rely on ourselves, right?"

They clinked glasses.

Henry took a sip, then asked:

"So what exactly do you do for Ms. de Vil?"

Jasper answered, glancing at Horace:

"Officially, assistants. In reality? Everything that isn't design.

"Cruella's brilliant—but her mouth gets her into trouble. Without us as muscle, she'd have been beaten to death by now."

Henry blinked.

"...You're more honest than I expected."

Horace shrugged.

"You could say that in front of her too. She wouldn't care. At most, she'd treat it like background noise."

Jasper nodded in agreement.

Givenchy raised his glass.

"A designer having conviction is not a bad thing. If you let critics sway you too easily, you lose your vision—and eventually yourself."

They drank.

Henry glanced toward the women.

The argument had escalated—fast.

Even as Charlize's agent, J.J. should have handled things alone.

But Cruella's presence was overwhelming. Her tone relentless.

It took both women just to hold their ground.

And Cruella's words?

Infuriating.

Charlize had already snapped back several times, unable to stay silent.

"They'll be okay... right?" Henry muttered.

Jasper waved it off.

"Relax. Cruella doesn't hit first. Unless someone else does."

Henry frowned.

"She's always like this... in collaborations?"

Horace answered bluntly:

"No. No one can tolerate her.

"Outside of runway shows—where models are contractually obligated—she wears her own designs and shoots her own editorials."

Chapter 447 - 447 — Givenchy’s Legacy

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Night fell over Château Jonchet.

In a small pavilion in the garden, Hubert de Givenchy and Philippe Venet sat together, enjoying the cool air, the moonlight—and waiting for someone.

Henry arrived late, carrying a bottle of champagne and three flutes. The champagne had been provided by Givenchy's butler; Henry simply played courier, pouring for the two elders first.

Givenchy eyed him with a peculiar expression.

"Judging by the look of you, your girl had quite a few complaints today. Finished venting?"

Henry let out an awkward laugh.

As a "fragile Kryptonian" who had been dragged into a guest room and thoroughly attacked the moment he returned, he could only say—Charlize Theron had been... unusually intense today.

One downside of an old castle: poor sound insulation.

If someone got loud, the echoes might carry through half the building.

Henry tried to smooth things over.

"Seems like Charlize was really provoked by Cruella today. I can kind of understand now why someone so talented isn't exactly well-liked."

"So? Did their collaboration fall apart?"

That... made perfect sense.

Henry turned to Givenchy.

The older man raised both hands quickly.

"I had no idea it was this bad. I only heard she was looking for a brand ambassador recently—that's why I recommended her."

Horace added, unfiltered as ever:

"She's in her forties now. Even with good maintenance, she can't compete with younger faces.

"I've been telling her to get a proper representative instead of doing everything herself."

"—They're fighting! They're fighting!" Philippe suddenly shouted, slapping Henry's arm.

Henry turned—

Just in time to see it.

Cruella had already thrown a punch.

Charlize's hands were raised like claws, teeth clenched, ready to go for the face.

Only J.J. Harris, risking her life in between them, was barely holding the line.

Henry moved instantly.

He hoisted Charlize over his shoulder and pulled her back.

The Badun brothers grabbed Cruella and dragged her away as well.

Distance—finally.

No physical fight.

But distance didn't cool anything down.

If anything—

Without fists, their words got sharper.

Much sharper.

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"No. They actually reached an agreement. Signing tomorrow. They clearly dislike each other, but somehow they've become each other's last lifeline... Still, I'm not optimistic about how it'll go."

Givenchy suddenly asked, seemingly out of nowhere:

"Do you know the difference between being skilled and being professional, Henry?"

Henry shook his head.

Givenchy continued:

"Skill means you're good at something.

Professionalism means you can set aside personal feelings and work with anyone.

"Take Gone with the Wind. Vivien Leigh and Clark Gable reportedly disliked each other so much they ate garlic before kissing scenes—yet on screen, they conveyed perfect romance.

"Cruella has many flaws, but her professionalism is unquestionable. If Charlize can reach that level—and with your help—I believe she'll achieve great things."

She would've made it even without me...

Henry thought so, but still raised his glass with a smile.

Givenchy and Venet drank with him.

After a sip, Givenchy gently touched Venet's hand. His partner understood immediately and stepped away, leaving them some distance.

Only then did Givenchy speak again.

"Henry, I asked you here tonight because I have an inheritance I wish to entrust to you."

Henry immediately recoiled half a step, hands up.

"Whoa—Givenchy, you're still very much alive. What kind of 'inheritance' are we talking about?

"If you want to keep working, you don't need to retire at all. Even after selling your brand and leaving LVMH, there are ways to continue designing.

"Look at Karl Lagerfeld—he's running Chanel, his own brand, Fendi, Chloé... and he's only five years younger than you. Honestly, your retirement last year felt a bit rushed."

Givenchy gave a bitter smile.

"I thought you would understand. After 1993... before spring even came, my inspiration felt buried in a grave.

"I held on for two more years. But there was nothing left to draw from. So I stepped away."

...Audrey Hepburn.

Henry's expression softened—tinged with both sadness and nostalgia.

Placing a fist lightly against his chest, he said quietly:

"Yes... that kind of emptiness doesn't just disappear. But the living still have to move forward."

"Indeed," Givenchy nodded. "But I hope some memories can continue on."

He took out a handwritten sheet... and a small, partially filled perfume bottle, placing both on the table.

The bottle looked aged but well-preserved, its seal intact. Smooth, rounded—almost as if polished by years of handling.

The paper, written in French, contained a perfume formula.

Givenchy pushed them toward Henry.

"This is what I want you to have."

Since it was explicitly meant for him, Henry didn't hesitate.

He picked up the bottle, gave it a gentle shake, then brought it closer and inhaled.

The moment he did—

His expression changed.

"This is...?"

Givenchy's voice turned firm.

"As long as I don't acknowledge it, it isn't."

But Henry's enhanced senses left no room for doubt.

This was Audrey Hepburn's perfume.

Her true perfume.

Back in 1954, during a visit to Givenchy's lab, she had fallen in love with a scent. Givenchy gifted it to her—never releasing it publicly.

Years later, with her permission, a version was commercialized under the name L'Interdit.

But—

Henry knew the truth.

The commercial version and Audrey's personal one were not the same.

The difference was subtle—so subtle most people would never notice.

But it existed.

Chapter 448 - 448 — Three Busy WomenNo

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sooner had Henry and the others returned to Los Angeles than Cruella arrived with her team right on their heels.

The premiere of The Rock was scheduled to take place on Alcatraz Island, the former prison off the coast of San Francisco. There were just over two weeks left.

For Charlize Theron and Cruella de Vil, that might sound like plenty of time—but in reality, it was extremely tight.

Including J.J. Harris, the three women were working at full throttle. Even their usual bickering had toned down. Though every time they met, they still looked like two fighting roosters thrown into the same cage—pecking at each other a bit before getting down to work.

Honestly, even with a Kryptonian super-brain, Henry couldn't quite understand why they were so tense.

To him, attending a formal event was simple: as long as you weren't naked, you were appropriately dressed.

And the bottle before him... was the original.

The real "forbidden" fragrance.

A secret shared between two masters, quietly hidden from the world.

Givenchy gently caressed the formula sheet, his gaze soft.

"Audrey is gone. I haven't made this perfume in years.

"The bottle you hold is all I have left. And this formula... the only copy. I destroyed the rest.

"I once thought of taking it with me to the grave.

"But Audrey once told me—you could tell the difference between this and the commercial version.

"If someone still remembers this scent... then perhaps it shouldn't disappear with me.

"I want someone to remember her as she was—bathed in this fragrance.

"Not just anyone. It must be someone we both knew. Someone who understands what she meant.

"That person... is you.

"If you refuse, then this will go with me into the ground."

Henry carefully placed the formula back on the table.

Givenchy added quietly:

"It's yours now. Do with it as you wish.

"Only one request—if you ever make it public, do so after I'm gone.

"Until then... let it remain Audrey's alone."

Henry picked up both the bottle and the formula.

"I understand. I'll accept this as your legacy.

"But I won't use it for profit. I'll preserve it—nothing more—until the day I'm gone as well."

Givenchy smiled faintly.

"Thank you."

Henry then asked, "Does Mr. Venet know?"

Relieved, Givenchy leaned back, lighter now.

"He does. I told him. But I've already left him plenty. He won't lack for anything."

The night grew quieter.

Only the scent—faint, precious, and irreplaceable—remained between them.

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He understood fashion—but that was his core value system. Unfixable.

Still, their busyness had its benefits. At least their daily clashes were limited to verbal sparring. No time for actual fights, no time for passive-aggressive delays. Work came first.

Though... Henry's evenings were getting a bit rough on his back.

He had to "convince" people—definitely convince, not anything else—to stop dwelling on unpleasant matters... and maybe distract them a little.

What they were busy with wasn't just premiere outfits.

Cruella also wanted to complete TV commercials and print shoots at the same time.

Those two weren't urgent for Charlize—but Cruella herself had to attend Paris Men's Fashion Week at the end of June. Her time in Los Angeles was limited.

All three projects combined—that was the real reason the three women were running themselves ragged.

As for the vampire situation—it hadn't escalated.

Just standard business sabotage.

If you ignored their true identities, it looked like nothing more than a powerful competitor setting up obstacles.

Henry, meanwhile, stayed within Stark Pictures.

The "Stark" name still carried a certain protective aura—like a charm warding off trouble. Most problems didn't reach him.

But when they did... they weren't small ones.

After spending some time catching up on lagging Git projects, Henry returned to his own work.

Recently, certain... questionable images had begun circulating online.

Naturally, upon discovering such materials, Henry conducted a very thorough and serious "critique."

He was even considering whether to quietly become an unsung hero—launching a hacker-level cleanup of the internet.

Just as he was weighing the idea, his phone rang.

"Hello, Henry Brown speaking. Who's this?"

"Hey, it's me. Charlize."

"Ah, sweetheart. Missing me already? I was just thinking about you—see, perfect timing. But shouldn't you be filming the commercial right now?"

He kept track of her schedule—not obsessively, just normal concern.

Today was special. They were using Stark Pictures' green screen stage to shoot, planning to composite the footage later with existing material to match Cruella's concept.

Henry had been planning to slack off a bit longer before dropping by.

Apparently, Charlize had other plans.

"Can you do me a favor? Bring Katie over. I want her in the ad."

"...You're serious?"

"Completely. How fast can you get here? The sooner you arrive, the sooner we can wrap. I miss you."

Ah.

So the collaboration had gone poorly again.

That explained it.

Otherwise, this South African firecracker wouldn't casually say something like "I miss you."

"Alright. Traffic's light—I can do a round trip in twenty, thirty minutes. In the meantime, coordinate with the crew and get everything ready."

He stood up as he spoke, heading out of the office.

Passing the secretary's desk, he covered the receiver and told Yulian, who was busy eating cookies:

"I've got to step out. If anyone asks for me, leave a message or contact me directly."

Caught off guard, crumbs scattering everywhere, Yulian jumped up.

"Yes, boss!"

"Relax," Henry said, waving her down. "And clean up your desk—unless you want an ant invasion."

Then, back into the phone:

"Sweetheart, I was just talking to Yulian. You know how she is—snacks all day."

He hung up and headed for the parking lot.

Stark Pictures' soundstages might not match the Big Eight studios in scale, and some props were a bit dated—but the equipment was all in-house and cutting-edge.

Chapter 449 - 449 — Katie Earns Her Keep

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Charlize dared to make such a request because she and Katie were already familiar with each other. She could touch, pet, and interact freely without worry.

But the rest of the crew didn't share that confidence.

If not for the distance, some of them might've already bolted—or climbed onto something high to escape the tiger.

There was, however, one exception.

Cruella.

Dressed in her signature black-and-white suit, the British designer stood on set—whether to supervise or to interfere was anyone's guess.

For his girl? Of course he reserved the best stage.

Unused anyway.

Due to the vampire situation, Henry had also increased on-site security. No firearms—but batons and pepper spray were standard.

Against real vampires, that wouldn't help much.

But their daytime operatives were still human. A stronger visible presence was enough to deter petty troublemakers.

Henry's old Cadillac was already registered—no cliché scene of a security guard blocking the CEO.

He parked outside the stage, opened the rear door—

And let Katie out.

No leash.

No chain.

Just a 550-pound apex predator stepping onto set.

Instantly—

Gasps.

Sharp inhales.

Whispers of alarm.

This wasn't a pit bull or a Tosa.

This was a tiger.

Animals would flee at its scent.

People just froze.

Only one person approached without hesitation.

Charlize Theron, wearing a gold gown, walked up, crouched down—

And firmly rubbed Katie's head.

"Hey there, Katie."

Henry raised a brow.

"What exactly are you planning to shoot? Why do you need her?"

Charlize stood up with his help and gestured behind her—toward a group of staff too scared to come closer.

"Cruella wants a 'wild' theme. We're planning to composite African savanna footage and lions later.

"But the director has no idea how the lion will move or how I should interact with it. And Cruella's losing her mind.

"So I suggested—why not use a real tiger? We can actually interact. Later we just swap in whatever background we want—savanna, jungle, whatever."

She shrugged.

"Problem solved."

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Her eyes lit up.

Arms slightly extended, she advanced step by step like a zombie, her gaze fixed greedily on Katie's striped fur.

The aura alone was enough—

Even Katie instinctively took half a step back.

Henry immediately stepped in.

"Pet's not for sale. Fur's not for sale. And you're definitely not turning her into a coat today."

"I haven't said anything yet!" Cruella snapped, hands on her hips.

Her two henchmen quickly flanked her, trying to "protect" their boss—though realistically, they wouldn't last a second against a tiger.

Meanwhile, Katie curiously looked around, taking in the unfamiliar crowd.

No leash. No restraints.

Only Henry’s hand scratching behind her ears kept her from wandering.

Henry continued calmly:

"I've looked into your past work, Ms. de Vil. Your love of fur has made you quite... unpopular with animal rights groups.

"I'm not here to judge. But when it comes to my pet—this lovely little 'tabby'—I have to advocate for her life. I've raised her since she was tiny. I'm attached."

"Such a shame," Cruella sighed. "Can you imagine the magnificent garments her fur could become?"

"An African chieftain outfit?"

...

Henry had a rare talent—not just for warming up a room, but for freezing it solid.

Cruella's mind instantly filled with the image of a tribal leader draped in tiger hide.

Her fingers curled into claws. She looked ready to strangle him on the spot.

Charlize burst out laughing, breaking the tension.

Clapping her hands, she addressed the crew:

"Alright—our animal star is here. Let's proceed as planned.

"Anyone uncomfortable can step out after finishing your tasks.

"And Cruella—you'll need to discuss compensation with the animal's owner. This isn't free.

"But I guarantee this will save money compared to blindly shooting with no direction.

"You handle the clothes—you're the expert. I handle the camera—I'm the expert."

Cruella turned back to Henry, tapping her foot impatiently.

"Payment. How much?"

Henry froze.

His first thought:

Wait... Katie can earn her own food now?

But as for pricing?

No idea.

He hadn't even made it as more than a background actor—and now his "tabby cat" was co-starring with Charlize Theron.

He shot a sharp look at Katie, who was being led away by Charlize.

Maybe tonight we eat tiger steak... she's getting a bit too well-fed anyway.

"Hello? Still alive?"

Cruella snapped her fingers loudly.

Henry blinked, snapping back.

"I... actually don't know what to charge. Uh—Jen? Can you help me here?"

He waved over J.J. Harris, who had been keeping a very safe distance.

"Jen, do you know how animal actor contracts work? Can you handle Katie's deal?"

J.J. hesitated.

"It's similar to human actors. The owner signs on their behalf, and everything must comply with animal welfare regulations. But I'm not deeply familiar... I might not be the best choice."

She had seen Katie before.

That didn't mean she was comfortable.

Not even close.

Henry sighed.

Chapter 450 - 450 — Fitting

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On the eve of The Rock premiere, Charlize Theron, accompanied by Henry, was trying on the gown Cruella had prepared.

The dress was a form-fitting, backless green silk gown.

"Then just help this once. A temporary contract is fine. I'm not planning to take Katie around for gigs anyway.

"Unless you're willing to bring her to auditions yourself?"

J.J. shook her head so hard it looked like it might come off.

Henry chuckled.

"Exactly."

He had no intention of letting Katie out of his sight.

And not everyone had Charlize's nerves.

She could casually grab a tiger's head and boss it around.

Try that with a stranger—and see what happens.

"About payment," Henry added, "if you know the market rate, go with that. If not, lower is fine. I'm only here because Charlize asked.

"If Katie had to feed herself, she'd be skin and bones by now."

J.J. sighed.

"Alright. I'll handle it."

"Perfect. And set your commission higher—I don't mind."

Henry happily delegated the problem away.

Negotiations were left to the professional agent and Cruella's sharp-minded assistant, Jasper.

Cruella herself?

Already consumed by inspiration.

A real tiger on set—

Ideas flooded her mind like a broken dam.

She rushed to the director, firing off shot concepts one after another. If she didn't supervise personally, she was convinced the result would be garbage.

Charlize, meanwhile, had multiple outfits.

Which to use? What styling?

All under Cruella's command.

Because for her—

This wasn't about commercial value.

It was about perfection.

Soon, Cruella took over the set entirely.

Her presence overwhelmed even the director.

She barked orders at everyone—including Charlize.

The only reason she didn't grab Katie by the ears and direct her personally...

Was because she assumed the tiger couldn't understand.

Henry, however, was sweating slightly.

If my girlfriend accidentally lets the tiger bite someone...

The entire shoot unfolded in a storm of shouting, chaos, and frantic energy.

And somehow—

It worked.

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Its design was relatively restrained—not nearly as wild as Cruella's usual work. The most unconventional aspect was the color itself: green.

Back in the Victorian era, green dresses had once been fashionable among aristocratic ladies. But the dye used at the time contained highly toxic arsenic—better known as arsenic poison.

As a result, the wealthiest women chasing fashion often died the fastest. The more obsessed they were, the worse their fate.

For a long time afterward, green clothing became taboo—inevitably associated with women who died in pursuit of beauty.

Fortunately, the silk gown Charlize wore used no such dangerous dyes. If it did, Henry's Kryptonian nose would have detected it instantly.

Aside from its rebellious color—a signature Cruella touch—the design itself was fairly conventional.

Henry, however, looked surprised.

"Ms. de Vil, are you running out of inspiration? Couldn't come up with something more outrageous?"

Cruella immediately grabbed a feather duster and waved it around furiously.

"Running out of inspiration? Do you even hear yourself?!

"Charlize is attending a formal event! There are expectations to consider! Should she show up dressed like a peacock?!

"And if someone like Sean Connery thinks it's inappropriate, won't you two start complaining that my designs aren't good enough?!

"Designing according to the client's needs and the occasion—that's what professionalism looks like!

"I'm already enduring this boring work—what more do you want?!

"If you want attention so badly, go wear a swimsuit covered in rotting beef to the red carpet. I guarantee you'll make every headline tomorrow!"

Henry had said exactly one sentence.

And got buried under a full lecture.

He instinctively looked to Charlize for comfort—only to receive a deadly glare and a flick to the forehead.

Clutching his "injured" head, the Kryptonian retreated to the wall, sulking.

Still, watching the room bustle with activity... felt strangely satisfying.

It wasn't about slacking off while others worked.

It was like watching art being created.

A group of people carefully refining a girl's appearance—taking something already beautiful and elevating it to something stunning.

Like watching a sculpture emerge from stone.

From ordinary... to extraordinary.

Seeing the whole process unfold—who wouldn't find that interesting?

And transforming someone already beautiful into something breathtaking—

That was far more enjoyable than the so-called "Eastern Asian transformation magic," where makeup turns someone completely unrecognizable.

That kind of thing was basically fraud.

Honestly, it should be illegal.

The people who invented beauty filters? Public punishment.

Henry's suspicious grin clearly didn't help his case.

Cruella snapped:

"You—next door. Go try your suit. Stop being an eyesore."

Charlize nodded in agreement.

This was a fitting session—adjustments often required removing the dress entirely.

And while Henry had already seen everything there was to see...

In a room full of female staff and tailors, having him stare like that was still too much.

With Cruella leading the charge, everyone silently agreed.

If they could, they'd have kicked him out.

Rubbing his nose, Henry retreated to the next room.

There, a mannequin displayed a dark gray suit.

Jasper Badun, Horace Badun, and several tailors were waiting.

"You finally got kicked out," Horace said, stuffing his face with a donut. "Took longer than I expected. Guess you're more impressive than I thought."

Chapter 451 - 451 — The Premiere at Alcatraz

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Although Charlize Theron and J.J. Harris placed great importance on participating in The Rock, Charlize's role was ultimately just a minor supporting one with only a
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Since arriving in America, Horace had practically lived on donuts—at least one a day, often more.

His belt had loosened a notch or two, though his shirt buttons were still holding on for dear life.

Which just showed how much attention Cruella paid—even his clothes were constantly being adjusted.

Henry chuckled.

"She's my girlfriend. What's wrong with looking?"

Jasper raised a bottle toward him. Henry waved it off.

"He doesn't mean that," Jasper said, pouring himself a drink. "He means Cruella actually tolerated you in there that long. That's the surprising part."

"Oh? She's that intense?"

"'Intense' is putting it lightly. When she's working, she's... obsessive. Even we get intimidated sometimes—and we've known her since childhood."

Jasper gestured toward the suit.

"Try it on. If anything doesn't fit, we fix it immediately. If Cruella sees you in an ill-fitting suit, she'll lose her mind."

Henry glanced at the suit, then at their outfits.

"Same style as yours?"

From the next room, Cruella's voice rang out:

"You're the one who says 'as long as I'm not naked, I'm fine'—and now you care about style?!

"I should just give you two leaves—front and back—tied with rope! Meets your standards and gets you attention!"

Henry quickly called back:

"Come on, I have some dignity! If I wore that, I'd have to flee to a deserted island the next day!"

"Shut up! Try the suit!"

Moments later, Henry stepped out in the dark gray suit.

"...Wait. Why does this fit perfectly? When did you measure me?"

Horace grinned through a mouthful of donut.

"Cruella's eyes are better than any measuring tape. Impressive, right?"

"...That is impressive."

Henry tested the fit—waist, sleeves, movement.

Perfect.

A well-tailored suit wasn't supposed to restrict movement.

Originally derived from military uniforms during the reign of Louis XIV, suits later evolved into casual wear before becoming formal attire.

Even today, plenty of dangerous men conducted serious business in suits.

Mobility mattered.

Balancing freedom of movement with a sharp silhouette—that was the true skill of a tailor.

And this custom-made suit?

Far superior to anything Henry had ever worn from Armani.

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few scenes. Logically, she shouldn't have attracted much attention.

So J.J. Harris's strategy wasn't to fight for media exposure, but to build relationships within the industry. Their primary goal was to connect with Sean Connery, the veteran actor who had helped them.

Henry's attendance, on the other hand, came courtesy of his position as CEO of Stark Pictures—not his personal reputation. And since Charlize wasn't walking the red carpet as his date, Henry entered the venue quietly through a separate entrance.

Charlize walked the red carpet alongside her on-screen father—Sean Connery.

The veteran actor spared no effort in supporting her. Whether answering reporters or speaking with hosts, he consistently highlighted Charlize.

Naturally, Charlize returned the favor, praising Connery's guidance and care during filming. She also thanked the producers, director, and fellow cast members—she was practically turning the red carpet into an awards acceptance speech.

Normally, someone without buzz would be largely ignored by reporters.

But from a distance, Henry noticed something different.

The media's enthusiasm toward Charlize clearly exceeded her current market value. Camera flashes went off nonstop.

And it wasn't just because she was on Connery's arm.

Many reporters were calling her name directly, asking her to look toward their cameras.

Some even repeatedly used a nickname—

"The Tiger Beauty."

Others called her "Belle."

Confused, Charlize asked, "Why are you calling me that?"

Sean Connery, slightly surprised, asked, "You don't know?"

Charlize thought for a moment. "Is it because of Cruella's advertisement?"

A reporter eagerly answered:

"Yes, Ms. Theron. Cruella de Vil's brand advertisement has already aired in England and caused quite a sensation.

"According to Ms. de Vil, the tiger in the ad is real—no editing tricks. You personally performed all the interactions. Is that true?"

Connery added, curious himself, "That's what I'd like to know too. Was it really a tiger? Did you actually go to the savannah to film?"

Charlize answered honestly:

"We filmed in front of a green screen. The savannah was added later using Stark Pictures' CGI technology.

"But the tiger is real. It belongs to my boyfriend—Henry Brown."

In Hollywood, relationships often boosted publicity.

As long as nothing illegal was involved—even affairs—most people didn't hide them.

So Charlize spoke openly.

Connery smoothly backed her up, saying:

"Ah, that talented young man. Someone I admire."

He didn't elaborate, but that was enough. Any competent reporter would dig into "Henry Brown" afterward.

Still, Charlize didn't let the red carpet turn into a personal publicity event.

Henry and J.J. Harris had both warned her:

If she wanted to benefit from Connery's reputation, she had to show proper respect.

This was his film.

Anything unrelated should be kept in check.

So Charlize only gave detailed answers when Connery asked. To reporters, she simply redirected attention back to the movie.

Connery, seasoned and perceptive, was very pleased with her attitude.

He even helped her out—asking a few off-topic questions himself to give her controlled exposure.

Once he felt the timing was right, the two moved on together.

After entering the pre-screening reception area—free from flashing cameras and filled only with industry insiders—Connery brought Charlize over to Henry, who had been watching from afar.

Henry stepped forward first.

"Good evening, Mr. Connery."

"Henry," Connery replied warmly, shaking his hand before handing Charlize back to him with perfect gentlemanly grace.

Chapter 452 - 452 — The Work That Follows

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Then, leaning closer, he asked in a low voice:

"You really keep a tiger?"

Henry gave an awkward smile.

"Well... it's actually a tabby cat. Just a bit large—about five or six hundred pounds."

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What kind of cat weighs five or six hundred pounds?

Even a pig couldn't be raised like that.

But seeing Henry's cheeky grin, Connery immediately got the joke.

"Oh, a tabby cat, I see."

---

At that moment, another major star approached—

Nicolas Cage, nephew of legendary director Francis Ford Coppola, and a key figure among Hollywood's Italian faction.

In high spirits, he walked up and gave Henry a friendly pat on the shoulder.

"You really keep a tiger? I've gotta come see it sometime."

For strangers, that might've seemed rude—but among peers, it was a sign of familiarity.

Henry didn't mind. He actually liked Cage quite a bit—even before his transmigration.

Raising a hand in greeting, Henry replied:

"It's a tabby cat! But you're welcome anytime. Just remember—it's a top-tier predator. Don't show up looking too... appetizing."

---

Cage, who had been about to leave, turned back immediately.

"Wait—does it bite?"

Henry grinned.

"It's a sweet big kitty. Why would it bite? It just has slightly sharp teeth... and a slightly big mouth."

---

Cage burst out laughing.

"Alright, you got me."

"Let's catch up another time. Oh—and Charlize, great performance. You look fantastic on camera. Keep it up."

With that, he strode off energetically.

---

Watching him go, Henry couldn't help but think:

For someone like him... ending up bankrupt over taxes later on...

Was that really just bad luck?

Or did someone set him up—trying to take down a rising figure from the Italian camp?

After all, Coppola's daughter hadn't been able to carry on his legacy.

Among the next generation, Nicolas Cage was the most capable—even if he wasn't a director.

---

Yet even after bankruptcy, the man kept going.

Five films a year. Ten, even.

No matter how many flops he starred in, he clawed his way back.

Just that resilience alone—

That was the mark of a real man.

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The film was still excellent—despite some characters differing from the version Henry remembered.

In *The Rock*, the director had even added a shot for Charlize Theron that didn't exist in the original: a simple glance back.

Her makeup wasn't runway-level perfection—closer to a natural, almost bare-faced look—but within the film's setting, that fleeting turn of her head sent a shiver down Henry's spine.

By contrast, Charlize herself remained calm.

This wasn't the first time she'd seen her performance on screen. Even on the big screen, her instinct was to review her acting—analyzing where she could improve.

Even when watching others, she wasn't really "watching" the movie. Instead, she kept thinking about how she would perform those scenes, and what she could learn from the actors on screen.

In a way, Henry had already "ruined" her ability to enjoy movies.

But Charlize had no intention of breaking out of that mindset.

She understood clearly—without a director father or a celebrity mother, reaching the top would depend largely on her own effort.

After the premiere concluded successfully, Henry drove Charlize home in his old Cadillac.

It was her first time attending such a large-scale premiere. The flashes of cameras had left a deep impression.

Even if most weren't aimed at her, it still served as motivation—a reminder that she needed to become someone worthy of that spotlight.

Lost somewhere between ambition and imagination, she suddenly noticed Henry sneaking glances at her.

Out of nowhere, she said:

"The dress has to be returned to Cruella. Don't tear it."

"Tear it? Why would I do that?" Henry looked confused.

Charlize replied cautiously:

"I've heard some powerful people like tearing dresses... I was worried you might have that bad habit too. Even if you can afford to buy plenty from Cruella, I don't want you picking that up."

Henry waved it off.

"Relax, I don't. Frugality is a virtue. Sure, spend when it's necessary—but that's not an excuse to waste things. Buying clothes just to tear them? That's ridiculous."

There are plenty of other... ways to have fun anyway, Henry thought.

The Kama Sutra, the Japanese forty-eight techniques...

Too bad I can't find any Taoist dual cultivation manuals...

It was strange—ever since arriving in this Marvel world, anything related to classic Eastern texts seemed... blocked. No originals in bookstores or libraries, only butchered, nonsensical translations.

Not that Henry had any desire to set foot in that region anyway.

Who knew what kind of trouble that might trigger.

Just as Henry's thoughts drifted toward nighttime "activities," Charlize suddenly asked:

"Did Cruella mention it to you?"

"Mention what? Oh—the runway show?" Henry nodded. "I was going to ask you. What do you think?"

Cruella's invitation wasn't really about him—it was about Katie.

Her theme this season was "Wildness."

From advertisements to photoshoots to the runway, the aesthetic needed consistency.

And that meant—

Katie was unavoidable.

Originally, the lion in the ad was just CGI. But now that a real tiger had been used, how could Cruella pass up the chance?

Of course, the real focus was still the models.

Charlize hesitated.

"Do you think... I'm suitable for the runway?"

Henry answered plainly:

"Why wouldn't you be? You're not worse than those models.

"And celebrities walking runways isn't unusual. At your stage, what matters most is building recognition—getting the audience familiar with you.

"If it's positive exposure, it's worth trying."

He paused, then added:

"But if you don't go, I'm not bringing Katie either. I'm not handing that big cat over to strangers. If something goes wrong, no one wins."

In truth, with his tiger-language translator, Henry could easily get Katie to behave on a runway.

That wasn't the issue.

The real problem was logistics.

Transporting a tiger across borders.

Legal restrictions.

Endless paperwork.

And babysitting her the entire time—for what? A bit of money?

Not worth it.

Unless he smuggled her in using flight.

But then it couldn't be public.

Which defeated the whole purpose.

If it helped Charlize, Henry wouldn't hesitate.

But if not?

Letting Katie run wild somewhere would probably make her happier.

And save him a lot of trouble.

Charlize nodded.

"Got it. I'll talk it over with J.J."

After a brief silence, Henry asked:

"This isn't your first film on the big screen—but it's your first premiere. How does it feel?"

Charlize slipped off her shoes, curled up in her seat, hugging her knees.

Her tone carried a hint of frustration.

"...Honestly? Nothing special. It's not like I'm the lead."

Henry laughed softly.

"Don't worry. You'll get there. Lead roles—even films centered entirely around you—they'll come."

Resting her chin on her knees, Charlize suddenly said:

"Am I... useless?"

"If it weren't for you, I wouldn't be where I am today."

Henry shook his head.

"How could that be?"

"Think about everything you've done. Would it all be meaningless without me? No.

"Even without my help, you'd still build your own brilliant life."

After all—

In his previous life, Charlize Theron was already untouchable.

A star far beyond reach.

His presence hadn't created her success.

At most, it had changed the path.

He continued:

"Maybe without certain help, the road gets rougher.

"But I believe you'd still keep going.

"You've already made it through the hardest part. Why would what comes next stop you?"

The words were meant as encouragement.

But Charlize heard something else.

Her eyes narrowed.

If Henry hadn't been driving, she might've already grabbed him.

Instead, she stared sharply and said:

"Explain."

"What do you mean 'even without you'? Where are you planning to go?"

"You're not allowed anywhere. You stay with me. Got it?"

Henry raised a hand in surrender, smiling.

Chapter 453 453 — The Arrival of the Big Ship

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With the successful debut of The Rock (Brave Through Alcatraz), and the buzz generated by the joint momentum of Charlize Theron and Cruella De Vil, the women were doing everything they could to increase their exposure in their respective fields.

By comparison, Henry—who mostly played a supporting role—was far less busy. In fact, aside from cheering from the sidelines, if he tried to get too involved, he'd just earn annoyed looks from both of them...

Cruella's strong personality went without saying.

And Charlize, as if competing with her, had become equally proactive in every aspect.

She clearly had no intention of being labeled by that irritating designer as a woman who relied on men.

As for President Brown—what could he even say? He simply settled into the role of cheerleader and logistics support, staying out of the line of fire and idling away in his office most of the time.

It was during such a moment that an expected yet surprising heavyweight figure came knocking—

James Cameron arrived at Stark Pictures.

"Mr. Brown."

"Director Cameron."

Henry personally went down to the lobby to receive him, greeting the director with a handshake.

Such courtesy left Cameron—once a truck driver turned filmmaker—somewhat flattered.

Because lately, his reputation could best be described as... widely disliked.

The reason was obvious.

That massive ship project.

Industry insiders were already predicting another Cleopatra-level disaster. And the failure of Kevin Costner's Waterworld the previous year was still fresh in everyone's mind.

A \$175 million production budget, plus unmentionable distribution costs—

and a global box office of only \$264 million.

It didn't even cross the basic break-even threshold.

Universal Pictures' executives had practically cried themselves unconscious.

Hollywood had seen countless studios collapse because of a single disastrous film. United Artists—once one of the Big Eight and founded by Charlie Chaplin—was one such casualty, eventually acquired by MGM.

And now—

Before filming had even officially begun, the early investment in Titanic had already pushed 20th Century Fox to its limits.

Yet James Cameron was still chasing Fox executives for more money.

Fortunately—or unfortunately—the project had been initiated by Cameron himself. No one else truly understood what he intended to do.

In other words, you couldn't just fire him and replace the director. The project would collapse.

To avoid turning that full-scale ship replica in the Gulf of Mexico into a useless wreck, Fox had no choice but to grit their teeth and let Cameron continue... while praying for another miracle like The Terminator.

They wouldn't replace him.

But additional funding?

Absolutely not.

"Yes, my queen."

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The board had unanimously agreed:

not another cent.

So from Fox, to producer Jon Landau, to Cameron himself—everyone was scrambling to secure new financing.

And Henry, during Stark Pictures' celebration banquet earlier that year, had given Cameron a hint.

So now—

He was here.

Just as Henry was about to invite him to the office, Cameron spoke first:

"Mr. Brown, would it be possible to take a look at Stark Pictures' supercomputer... and the departments using it?"

Henry didn't hesitate.

"Of course. Come—I'll show you around personally. Let you see the pride of Stark Pictures."

The supercomputer—"Hollywood Kid"—wasn't something that could be reverse-engineered just by looking at it.

Its true value lay in brute-force hardware investment.

A money-burning monster.

The server facility wasn't inside the main building, but it wasn't far either.

On the way there, the two discussed performance metrics. Cameron, being deeply invested in film technology, could keep up with the conversation.

Once inside, Henry walked him through everything—from the core systems and maintenance staff to the various departments using terminal access.

Currently, "Hollywood Kid" supported several major divisions:

- Digital Restoration Department

Restoring archived films

Commercial services for wealthy clients: restoring old photos and home videos

- Digital Editing Studios (Rental)

External studios rented computing power

Many small-budget B-movie companies preferred renting over building their own systems

Including... quite a few adult film studios from the Valley

- Core R&D Team (Henry's project)

Film-grade digital imaging technology

Encoding systems

Development of digital cameras and projectors

Bridging digital and traditional film workflows

Digital restoration itself had been born from this philosophy.

- White-hat Hacker Team

Managing virtual machines

Internal cybersecurity (including distributed version control systems like Git)

Actively battling hackers worldwide attempting to breach the system

As for Tony Stark's private virtual machines—and Henry's own—

Those were strictly off-limits.

Even system administrators might not know about them. And Henry certainly wasn't about to tell Cameron.

After the tour, the two returned to Henry's office.

Cameron suddenly asked:

"Mr. Brown, have you considered establishing a dedicated software division?"

Henry didn't answer directly.

"Oh? What do you have in mind, Director Cameron?"

Cameron leaned forward slightly.

"I need computing power to simulate—

wind, ocean waves, sunlight, refraction, vortices, physical collisions."

Henry raised a brow.

"That sounds similar to what Steve Jobs' Pixar is doing."

Cameron immediately shook his head.

"No. Not cartoons."

"I want true realism. The kind of visuals that make people believe they're watching reality itself."

"Pixar can't do that."

Steve Jobs had originally acquired Pixar to promote the Pixar Image Computer.

Toy Story—in this world as well—had effectively been a five-year, high-budget advertisement in collaboration with Disney.

But its unexpected success, combined with the emergence of the "Hollywood Kid," had shattered Jobs' hardware ambitions.

Chapter 454 454 — The Investment Invitation

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Trying to put his vision into words, James Cameron said:

"We all know how the Titanic ends. But how do I show that on screen?

"I've tried scale models. I've tried simulating it in swimming pools. None of it feels real. At this point, I'm one step away from actually sinking the full-scale ship model in the Gulf of Mexico just to film it.

"But I don't want just one shot.

"I want to capture the sinking from every angle, every perspective—every single person in that moment."

He paused, then continued:

"Pixar's animated films opened up a new line of thinking for me. I've also teamed up with Scott Ross—formerly of Lucasfilm—and an old friend, Stan Winston, to establish Digital Domain. We're planning to develop this kind of technology ourselves.

"But in Hollywood, there isn't a second studio like yours—one that already has a supercomputer dedicated to image processing, and actual results to show for it.

"So besides asking for your professional opinion, I also hope Stark Pictures can collaborate with Digital Domain to develop this technology together... and see if we can achieve what I'm aiming for."

Henry pretended to think for a moment before replying:

"Well, since you already have a visual effects company, you should understand the basics.

"We need a physics engine—something that can simulate how objects behave in reality.

"The difference is, animated films simplify things. If you look at the polygon count in Toy Story, you'll see they've made trade-offs to achieve smoother visuals.

"But if you want realistic water splashes, vortices, light interacting with the human body—

"That's an entirely different level of rendering complexity."

He shrugged lightly.

"Can it be done? Sure.

"If there's demand—and the money's there—then even things that don't exist yet can be created.

"That's how the business world works."

Cameron's eyes lit up.

"That's great, Mr. Brown! Then we definitely have room to collaborate.

"But... there's just one small problem between us."

Henry played dumb.

"What problem?"

Pixar pivoted earlier than expected.

And once it did—

There was no turning back.

But what Pixar had achieved...

Was not what Cameron wanted.

So he came here.

To Henry Brown—

The man pushing Hollywood toward true digital cinema.

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Cameron gave a dry smile.

"I'm broke."

Henry let out a helpless chuckle.

"Director Cameron, business is business.

"What you're asking for isn't something we can just improvise overnight. It takes manpower, resources.

"For the sake of cinema, I can accept not making money—but I can't take a loss and work for free.

"If I say yes to you today, what happens when someone else comes tomorrow with the same request?

"In the end, relying purely on passion to support filmmaking will destroy Hollywood.

"Because passion varies from person to person—but everyone still needs to eat."

Cameron forced a smile—far from the domineering "set tyrant" he was known to be. It was awkward, almost painful to watch.

"You're right. I understand that.

"But this is a commercial project. If I invite you to invest... would you be interested?

"You told me before—if I needed funding, I could come to you."

Henry widened his eyes in surprise.

"20th Century Fox agreed to that?"

Normally, co-financing a film helps spread risk. After all, no one knows whether a movie will succeed before release.

But in practice—

Good projects don't get shared.

Sequels, big directors, star-led productions—these are considered safe bets. Studios hold onto them tightly.

That's why Henry had previously said:

only projects rejected by major studios trickle down to smaller companies.

But Waterworld's catastrophic failure had shaken Fox's confidence in Titanic.

Cameron explained:

"Fox refuses to increase the budget. But without more money, we can't continue filming.

"So they compromised—allowed us to seek external funding.

"I won't hide it from you. Fox approached Universal first. We worked well together on True Lies in '94. But after Waterworld, they're too scared to join.

"Last month, Fox approached Paramount. They had success with Braveheart last year. Paramount is interested—but details haven't been finalized.

"I figured I'd need Stark Pictures' computing technology anyway, so I came to ask you directly.

"If you're willing to join, then naturally, all the CGI work would go to Stark Pictures."

He hesitated, then added reluctantly:

"And... if you want to push that actress you're supporting into the film, I can reconsider."

"But it won't be a major role. Most characters are already designed around specific actors, and the script is set."

Watching the director struggle to say that, Henry nearly laughed inside.

This was a man famous for his iron will—yet here he was, making concessions.

It showed just how much he believed in this project.

After all—

When Cameron would one day stand on the Oscars stage and declare, "I'm the king of the world!"—

Who would remember this moment of compromise?

Henry spared him further discomfort.

"As for casting, Director Cameron, just stick to your original plan."

"At most, Charlize could do a cameo—but her current level of recognition isn't enough for a significant role."

In other words:

Important supporting role? Not happening.

Background extra? Not worth it.

→ Better to skip it entirely.

Then Henry got to the point:

"Let me ask—how much has the project spent so far?"

Relieved, Cameron answered without hesitation—showing zero concern for Fox executives:

"Fox has already spent about \$135 million."

"Mostly on sets, props, locations, and early staff salaries."

Chapter 455 455 — A Sharp-Tongued Financier

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According to Henry's memories from before his transmigration, by this point 20th Century Fox should already have reached an agreement with Paramount to co-finance this "big ship."

But this project had one undeniable core—

James Cameron himself.

Without his approval, nothing could move forward.

The reason this director had come personally to Stark Pictures wasn't just because of Henry's earlier hint—it was also because of Stark Pictures' technical capabilities.

If he worked with Paramount, he'd still need to find another partner for the CGI work.

So why not go straight to the source?

A studio that already had the technology.

Although Stark Pictures hadn't made any large-scale investments for quite some time, its parent company was still Stark Industries, a military-industrial giant.

And the studio now had a new CEO.

Maybe—

A newcomer would bring new possibilities.

After all, everyone knew:

Young people—and especially inexperienced newcomers—were far more likely to take risks on impulse.

That was exactly what Cameron was betting on.

But what no one knew was—

At this moment, Henry might very well be the person in the world most confident in Titanic's success.

"If we diverted actor salaries, we could keep things running for a bit—but those funds are locked in separate accounts."

"In reality, the project is out of money."

"In a few days, principal photography begins. I don't even have the daily operating costs covered."

"You could say... we're at the deadline."

Henry frowned slightly.

"How much more do you need to finish the film?"

Cameron replied:

"Fifty... no—sixty million dollars."

"That includes crew costs, logistics, food, accommodation."

"We'll start filming modern-day scenes in Canada, then move to the Gulf of Mexico for the main shoot, where the full-scale Titanic set is ready."

"I guarantee—give me this funding, and I'll finish the film."

A director's "guarantee," huh.

Henry couldn't help but feel it sounded like a flag being planted.

After all—

Wasn't that exactly how 20th Century Fox ended up on this sinking ship in the first place?

And now...

It was heading straight for the iceberg.

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And now that Cameron had delivered himself to his doorstep—

How could Henry possibly turn him away?

Putting on a conflicted expression, Henry said:

"Director Cameron, from a personal standpoint, I'd absolutely be willing to support you."

"But Mr. Tony Stark has set an annual film production budget for us—only \$10 million."

"Anything beyond that requires his approval."

"Of course, even if he refuses, I personally have the funds. But if we're investing through Stark Pictures, we still need to inform him."

"You understand, right?"

Cameron nodded, somewhat uneasy.

"Of course. I understand."

"But... when would you be able to ask Mr. Stark?"

Henry didn't keep him waiting.

"How about this—you sit tight for a moment. I'll call him right now."

"Your coffee's gone cold. Want me to get you a fresh one?"

"No need," Cameron said quickly. "This is fine. The call is more important."

Henry smiled, stood up, and returned to his desk.

"Just a moment."

He dialed the number, switched to speaker mode, and set the receiver down.

Cameron listened as the ringing echoed through the office, his emotions rising and falling with each tone.

Finally—

The call connected.

A crisp female voice came through:

"This is Mr. Tony Stark's private line. I'm his secretary. May I ask who's calling?"

Henry replied:

"Hello, this is Henry Brown. Stark Pictures has a major investment proposal for Mr. Stark.

"Please tell him—it's quite a challenge."

"Understood, Mr. Brown. Please hold."

A moment later, the line picked up again.

A familiar, arrogant voice rang out:

"Walt! Loser! Finally calling to surrender?"

"I'll allow you to kneel and worship me over the phone. No need to come in person."

Henry resisted the urge to fly to the East Coast and smash that smug face.

"What exactly am I surrendering for?"

"It's Director James Cameron—he's here seeking investment for his film.

"He also wants to use computer rendering for certain scenes, which requires a solid physics engine and proper hardware.

"We've got the hardware.

"What we lack is a dedicated department to design and operate the physics engine—and funding.

"So I'm asking whether you're interested in investing, and whether you approve expanding the company."

Tony didn't miss a beat:

"James Cameron? Oh—you mean that ship that's destined to sink?"

"I don't follow Hollywood much, but even I've heard it's a mess.

"If you want a physics engine, then hire people and build one. Why invest in the movie?"

Henry chuckled.

"We need a platform to prove that we can do it.

"If you think the risk is too high, I can always use the compensation money I got from Sony.

"I just wanted your approval to invest through Stark Pictures.

"Though Sony hasn't paid everything yet—so I might need a short-term loan from you."

Tony didn't answer directly.

"How much do you need?"

"Fox has already invested \$135 million.

"Director Cameron says another \$60 million will complete the film."

Tony scoffed.

"If you're so confident and willing to gamble your own money, why go through the studio?"

Henry replied frankly:

"This investment is nearly a third of the total budget.

"I'm not interested in being some idiot investor who just hands over cash like those fools on Wall Street.

"I want Stark Pictures to negotiate with Fox—for distribution rights, or home video rights like VHS and VCD.

"That way, even if the box office fails, we still have revenue streams to recover costs.

"Otherwise, we risk losing everything.

"And trust me—you want a lesson on Hollywood accounting tricks?"

Tony responded immediately:

"Alright. Here's the deal.

"Give him \$65 million. Round the total budget up to \$200 million.

"You go tell Fox—I want North American distribution rights.

"Let's be realistic—your studio doesn't have international distribution capacity yet.

"And home video takes too long. I'm not waiting.

"If Fox agrees, great. If not, forget it.

"Of the \$65 million, \$10 million comes from Sony's compensation—that counts as your personal investment.

"The rest is mine.

"If it profits, you get your share proportionally.

"If it loses money, my portion covers the losses first.

"Deal?"

"Oh—and any additional funding later? That's on you."

Henry grinned.

"That was fast. I thought you'd dump the whole thing on me."

Tony replied coldly:

"I'm just curious.

"You've never cared about investing in films. So why jump straight into something this risky?"

"There must be something you see that others don't.

"I don't understand movies.

"But I know you're not that stupid."

Henry feigned surprise.

"Wow. Trusting my judgment that much? I'm flattered, young master."

Tony's voice turned vicious:

"No. I actually hope you screw this up.

"So I finally have a reason to strangle you."

Henry shot back instantly:

"Then you'd better invent a press strong enough first.

"Otherwise, those weak arms of yours trying to strangle me will feel more like a gentle caress.

"And that would be disgusting."

"F*CK!"

Tony slammed the phone down so hard it nearly snapped the antique receiver stand.

If anyone could see where Tony Stark was at that moment—

They'd notice he was standing in a study decorated in 18th–19th century style.

Except—

Up, down, left, right...

All surfaces functioned as the floor.

Tony was standing on the ceiling, completely ignoring gravity.

Back at Stark Pictures—

Henry listened to the "beep-beep" of the disconnected call, then awkwardly smiled at Cameron, who had been watching anxiously the whole time.

He walked back over and said:

"Looks like we've dealt with the toughest guy involved.

"So—who should I talk to at 20th Century Fox?"

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Chapter 456 456 — The Man Who Went Missing

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On a summer night, even with the air conditioning running, Katie still sprawled lazily across her steel cat tree. Once a spot warmed up, she'd simply shift to another platform and continue lounging.

Henry's Kryptonian physique made him resistant to heat and cold—but that didn't mean he couldn't feel them. It simply meant he wouldn't suffer heatstroke or freeze to death.

Still, hot and humid weather could sour his mood. As for cold... even before transmigrating, he had always tolerated cold better than heat. As long as he wasn't shivering or catching a cold, he considered it manageable.

On a night like this, Henry had been considering flying up to ten thousand meters for some cool air—beer in one hand, moon overhead.

It was a full moon.

Charlize had worked late. After chatting briefly, she'd gone back to her room to rest. So Henry planned to enjoy the night sky first, then continue work on his underwater laboratory.

The lab was being carved into the seabed—an excavated cavern reinforced with corrosion-resistant steel, forming an egg-shaped sealed structure. Only a small portion would protrude above the ocean floor; the rest remained buried beneath.

Since he didn't plan to bring people down there—or grow plants or raise animals—the interior would be filled with pure helium instead of air.

The advantage?

No microbes. No mold. No cockroaches or ants.

Without oxygen or carbon dioxide, carbon-based life either dies—or goes dormant.

The downside?

Helium was expensive.

Filling the entire chamber to one atmosphere would cost a fortune. After all, helium couldn't be synthesized—it had to be extracted from natural gas.

To solve that, Henry had built a subsea natural gas extraction site.

Methane hydrates—"flammable ice"—were abundant beneath the seabed. Even decades later in his previous world, efficient extraction remained a challenge.

The biggest issue was transporting gas from seabed to surface without leaks, corrosion, or biological damage.

Oil pipelines already struggled with leaks—methane pipelines would be even worse.

Henry's solution?

Process everything on-site at the seabed.

Maintain the structure, extract what he needed, and eliminate pipeline risks entirely.

His primary goal was helium extraction—but methane could also be used for power generation.

Two birds. One stone.

The oxygen needed for combustion? Supplied via electrolysis of seawater.

Initial power came from underwater current-driven turbines.

His design delivered a rated output of 50 megawatts.

For comparison:

A typical generator: 3–8 kilowatts

His system: 50 megawatts

Sure, it looked modest compared to Tony Stark's future arc reactor—but 50MW could power an entire town of ten thousand people.

Europe's total daily consumption? Around 350 gigawatts.

For a single lab, 50MW was more than enough.

Of course, everything was still under construction.

The outer shell of both the lab and methane facility was complete. Lately, Henry had been testing structural integrity and gradually relocating equipment—along with the

Chapter 457 457 — Blade

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After leaving the house, Henry drove a short distance before stopping on another street. Slipping into a dark alley, he took off into the air and headed straight for the

turbine generators.

Once operational, the lab would house his research into Kree and Skrull technology.

Goat Valley Lab might be remote—but not unfindable.

The ocean floor, on the other hand?

A blind spot.

Unless Namor and his Atlanteans decided to interfere, security would be far superior.

As for the Moon?

Out of the question.

Too many unknowns. Too many eyes. The Inhumans' city, Attilan, sat in the Blue Area. Henry had already ruled it out.

Compared to that, the deep sea was practically ignored.

He hadn't encountered Atlanteans yet—but then again, he hadn't explored the entire ocean either.

Just as he was deciding what to move next—

Knock knock.

Katie didn't budge.

Henry frowned. Who would visit this late?

A glance with X-ray vision—

Charlize.

He opened the door, surprised. "I thought you were going to sleep. Can't rest?" He reached to pull her in.

She slapped his hand away and held up a portable phone.

"Cruella wants to know—have you seen Jasper today?"

"Her tall, skinny sidekick? No. Why?"

"She's in Paris for Fashion Week. She sent Jasper to Los Angeles with invitations—including yours.

"But tonight she tried calling him for an update. No response. So she contacted me to ask you.

"You're first on the list. He should've come to you first. If you haven't seen him... something might've happened."

"Did Cruella say that?" Henry asked, alert now.

Charlize curled her lips. "That woman is a control freak. Do you think Jasper would just wander off? The Badun brothers are completely under her thumb—they wouldn't dare."

Henry's expression turned serious.

Given his own recent troubles... if Jasper had been targeted because of him—perhaps by vampires—it wasn't impossible.

"I understand," Henry said. "I have contacts on the street. I'll go check. Let Cruella know—and get some rest. Leave this to me."

Charlize hesitated. "Can I stay here? If something happens, you can tell me immediately. I'm worried about Jasper too. He looks like a thug, but he's actually a decent guy."

Henry didn't object.

He stepped aside.

Charlize entered.

He turned to change clothes and grab his car keys.

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Goat Valley Lab.

There, he changed into his all-black Kevlar suit—complete with mask.

Going through the Continental would be too slow. If vampires were part of the High Table, the hotel wouldn't provide false information—but delays were very possible.

And if Jasper Baden was truly in danger, that delay could mean the difference between life and death.

Henry had already narrowed down the likely culprit: vampires.

If business tactics failed, escalation was only natural. And what better warning target than a peripheral figure?

So he would handle this himself.

Nighttime might be the domain of creatures of darkness—but it was also perfect for operating unseen.

Black Superman—online.

In an instant, he returned to downtown Los Angeles.

Standing at the edge of a rooftop, he unleashed his full suite of super-senses, scanning a ten-kilometer radius.

He didn't know Jasper's habits—where he might go, what places he frequented—so he had to search everything. Any sign of conflict drew extra attention.

His focus, however, was on vampires.

Their body temperatures were significantly lower than humans—almost indistinguishable from ambient surroundings. Any cluster of such "cold signatures" stood out.

And then—

He saw something unusual.

Those cold, humanoid figures would suddenly spike in temperature... and then lose their human form.

Someone was hunting vampires.

The scene was in South Los Angeles—the roughest area, dominated by Black and Hispanic communities.

What drew his attention wasn't just the activity—

It was two familiar faces.

One was Jasper Baden.

The other...

Unfamiliar—yet recognizable.

A Black man with a buzz cut, long black coat, sunglasses at night, and a sword strapped to his back. Slaughtering vampires.

That image could only mean one thing.

Blade.

One of the most famous vampire hunters in America.

Unlike most hunters—who were fully human—Blade had another title among vampires:

Daywalker.

He was half-vampire.

Not exactly a secret—at least not within hunter circles.

Which was why he usually worked alone. Many hunters considered him just as dangerous as his prey.

Henry had learned all this after realizing he'd crossed paths with vampires—but until now, he hadn't engaged directly.

Now, he was witnessing Blade in action.

As for Jasper—

He lay collapsed on the ground.

Judging by the blood loss at his neck—

He'd been bitten.

There were no other victims, and the location was an alley. That strongly suggested Jasper had been specifically targeted—not a случай victim stumbling into a vampire nightclub.

At this point in time, vampires still operated cautiously. Their clubs had strict access control. Random civilians didn't just wander in.

Their "blood bags" were carefully selected—lured in by attractive vampires, chosen specifically because no one would look too hard if they disappeared.

Which meant—

Feeding in an open alley like this?

Not their style.

By the time Blade finished off the last vampire, Black Superman stepped into the alley.

His arrival was greeted with a silver spike hurled straight at his chest.

It bounced off.

Chapter 458 458 — Treating the Embrace

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No surprise—Kevlar armor, plus Kryptonian skin.

If a thrown spike from a half-vampire could pierce that, the patent belonged in the trash.

Black Superman didn't move. No aggression. No sudden motion.

Blade paused.

"Who are you?"

"I was sent for him," Black Superman said, pointing at Jasper.

"The spike at your feet is yours now," Blade replied flatly. "When he turns, use it. Clean kill. Nothing left behind."

He then crouched, rummaging through the ashes of the vampires—collecting wallets, watches, anything valuable.

Those items survived—unlike clothing, which burned away with the body.

"Vampire hunter?" Black Superman asked.

Blade glanced back, annoyed. "If you're not blind, maybe cut eyeholes in whatever you're wearing."

"...Blade. The Daywalker."

Blade froze.

Behind his sunglasses, his gaze sharpened.

"Who are you?"

Black Superman ignored the question.

"Can you save him? Payment—one hundred thousand dollars."

Blade paused.

The mention of money clearly registered.

"Who is he?"

"Someone my client wants alive. Not dead. Not turned."

Blade studied Jasper. "Fresh bite. There's a chance. Just a chance. But you don't look like someone carrying a hundred grand."

Black Superman pulled out a Continental gold coin from his utility belt.

He showed it—then flicked it over.

Blade caught it.

"Save him first," Black Superman said. "Whether he lives depends on him. No one carries a hundred grand in cash. I'll get it."

Blade turned the coin over in his hand.

"One coin. One promise."

He pocketed it and moved to Jasper's side.

"I can help him. But how do I get paid?"

He clearly intended to take both the coin and the money.

Black Superman didn't argue.

"Save him. I'll find you."

Blade grabbed Jasper by the front of his shirt and lifted him like luggage.

He was about to say more—

But the man in black was already gone.

Blade looked around.

Nothing.

No trace.

After a moment, he shrugged, carried Jasper back to his Dodge Charger, and shoved him into the trunk.

Then he drove off—

Back to his hidden base.

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In a hidden base set up within a warehouse district, Blade's mentor and weapons supplier—Abraham Whistler, a veteran vampire hunter with a crippled leg—watched as his apprentice, whom he treated like a son, carried in an unfamiliar man and dumped him onto the workbench.

"What the hell is this?" the old hunter asked.

"He's worth a hundred grand," Blade replied. "Give him a shot of garlic extract, Whistler."

Whistler stared in disbelief. "This guy is worth a hundred thousand dollars? I don't buy it."

"That amount includes saving him—plus the location of your base and your treatment method," Black Superman's voice suddenly echoed.

Instantly, a gun and a crossbow were aimed at him.

Blade lowered his gun first. "How did you find this place? Is there a tracker on him?"

"I have my own methods." Black Superman didn't elaborate. He simply took off the backpack slung over his shoulder, unzipped it to reveal stacks of cash, and tossed it over.

Blade caught it, checked inside carefully—no explosives, nothing suspicious.

"Hundred thousand?" he asked.

"I don't mind if you count it," Black Superman said calmly. "But will he still be alive by the time you're done?"

Beside them, Whistler kept his crossbow raised, shouting, "What the hell is going on? Who is this darker-than-dark bastard? And what's with that voice?"

Black Superman's voice, transmitted through a bone-conduction mic and modulated speaker, sounded flat and mechanical—emotionless, unnatural.

Blade didn't answer. He didn't know either.

Black Superman sighed. "Clearly, I don't want my identity exposed. That's all you need to know. I'm not a vampire—and I've got my own issues with them."

"How do you prove that?" Whistler demanded.

With mild annoyance, Black Superman removed his left glove, revealing a pale hand. With his right hand—still gloved—he picked up the silver spike Blade had thrown earlier and drove it hard into his own palm.

The result—

The spike bent.

His skin remained untouched.

Like a bullet flattening against steel.

He casually tossed the warped spike back. "Can vampires do that?"

Whistler, still cautious, retrieved the spike and examined it. Confirming it was genuine—not some fake prop—he finally lowered his crossbow.

"You a mutant?"

"I could be. Does it matter?"

Whistler snorted and set the crossbow aside. "Not really."

In Marvel lore, vampires could shrug off most conventional damage—bullets could pierce them, but wounds healed quickly. However, they couldn't deform silver weapons without injury.

That alone proved this man wasn't one of them.

Meanwhile, Blade dumped the contents of the bag onto the table—bundled stacks, loose rolls. A substantial sum.

Whistler stopped arguing. He turned to a nearby medical kit, pulling out a syringe and a test tube filled with thick, cloudy liquid.

The pungent smell of garlic filled the air.

At least it definitely wasn't... anything else.

Drawing the extract into the syringe, Whistler spoke before injecting:

"Normally, once bitten, full transformation takes about twenty-four hours.

Chapter 459 - 459 — Creating the Serum

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The unnatural stability of the vampire virus likely explained how, in Blade, that hematologist managed to develop a retroviral serum in just a few days.

However, the serum in the movie only worked on those newly infected—before full transformation. Once someone had completely turned, the serum would simply kill them.

So... should he make one?

Cruella, as a designer, still had value—she came recommended by Givenchy, after all. And despite her loud personality, she somehow clicked with Charlize.

"Garlic extract might kill the vampire virus—or just delay it. If he turns, I'll still put him down. Clear?"

"Wait."

Black Superman stopped him.

He grabbed an empty syringe, sterilized the needle with a lighter, and drew a vial of blood from Jasper's unconscious body.

The motion was so smooth that by the time Whistler reacted, it was already done.

"Where do I inject?" Black Superman asked.

"Neck. Opposite side of the bite—best effect."

After sterilizing the needle again, Black Superman injected the garlic extract without hesitation.

The reaction was immediate—

Violent.

Jasper's body convulsed under the intense pain, even in unconsciousness.

Black Superman held him firmly, preventing the needle from snapping mid-injection, while simultaneously activating his full super-sensory perception to monitor internal changes.

The garlic extract worked more aggressively than expected.

It didn't just attack the vampire virus in the bloodstream—it also destroyed already-altered cells: bi-concave red blood cells, binucleated infected cells.

That destruction—

Was the source of the pain.

Fortunately, Jasper hadn't been fully converted yet. Enough of his cells remained normal to allow recovery.

That explained why garlic extract outright killed fully turned vampires.

As for why it didn't always cure—

The extract circulated with the blood, but might not eliminate every infected cell or virus particle before being depleted—or filtered out by the kidneys.

Any remnants would replicate again.

And eventually—

Full transformation.

So garlic extract wasn't a perfect solution.

But during observation, Black Superman noticed something remarkable:

The vampire virus was extraordinarily stable.

Take influenza, for example—

It mutates constantly. New strains emerge rapidly, changing symptoms and transmission rates. That's why there's no universal cure.

But the vampire virus?

No variation.

Every replicated strain was virtually identical to the original.

No mutation. No drift.

Perfect consistency.

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Maintaining that alliance mattered.

Moreover, a vampire serum could also be used to win over Blade and Abraham Whistler.

After all, the attack on Jasper Badden was already a declaration of war. If Black Superman didn't want to waste time personally hunting vampires, supporting professional vampire hunters was the most efficient approach.

Even outside the Marvel context, among all vampire hunters he knew of, Blade ranked the highest. The only issue was his identity as a half-vampire, which made many reluctant to cooperate with him.

Thirdly, from his time as a Tinkerer, Black Superman had synthesized plenty of conventional pharmaceuticals through chemical methods. He wasn't a complete novice in medicine.

Granted, retroviruses belonged to genetic engineering—a completely different field from traditional chemistry. But the foundational knowledge? He already had it. What he lacked was hands-on experience.

Perhaps this was the perfect opportunity.

And for Jasper Badden—

If he didn't act, Jasper was as good as dead.

There was no way Black Superman would allow a newly turned vampire to remain at Cruella's side.

If Jasper couldn't be restored to humanity, then even if Whistler didn't kill him, Black Superman would drag him into the sunlight himself.

Even if that meant completely offending Cruella.

She had far too many opportunities to get close to Charlize. That kind of risk couldn't be tolerated.

With so many reasons to act, Black Superman didn't hesitate.

He glanced at Jasper, whose condition had stabilized somewhat but who had begun running a fever.

"Take care of him," he said. "I'm going to make a serum."

"A serum? How are you going to make a serum?" Whistler asked in shock.

Black Superman raised the blood sample he had drawn earlier.

"This contains vampire virus in the transformation stage. Since it's a virus, we treat it like one. That makes sense, right?"

"You sure it'll work?"

"If it doesn't," Black Superman replied coldly, "he's dead anyway. Isn't he?"

His voice, distorted and emotionless, continued:

"That's why I didn't take him with me. I need you to verify whether what I make works.

"If it doesn't... then he died from the vampire attack earlier."

Whistler and Blade exchanged a look.

The old hunter said, "You should know—he doesn't have much time to wait for you to slowly figure this out."

"I know. Which is why I should be doing exactly that right now."

With that, Black Superman turned and left.

The moment he stepped out of sight, he activated his super speed and flight, returning instantly to the Yangdong Valley Laboratory.

Left behind, the two hunters weren't particularly interested in the mysterious man—at least not beyond casual discussion.

"Where'd he come from?" Whistler asked.

"I was tracking a group of vampire killers. He showed up out of nowhere," Blade replied. "Came for the guy on the table."

"Know who he is?"

"Not a vampire. Not a cop. That's enough."

"Doesn't look like X-Men or Brotherhood either," Whistler muttered, still guessing based on the silver-proof skin.

"Who cares."

Blade swept the cash back into the bag and tossed it to Whistler.

Chapter 460 - 460 — Cooperation

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At dawn, Black Superman appeared once again at Blade's warehouse hideout.

Old men sleep lightly and wake early—that was expected. Even Blade, who treated meditation as rest, snapped awake the moment he sensed someone approaching.

Of course, Black Superman had allowed himself to be detected. Otherwise, slipping in unnoticed would have been effortless.

The moment he entered, his gaze went straight to Jasper Badden, who was still strapped to the workbench.

"He's not dead yet, right?"

At the same time, he noticed something—Blade hadn't placed Jasper there randomly. The morning sunlight streamed through the window, perfectly covering the workbench.

The man lying there, bathed in sunlight, wore a pained expression, clearly suffering.

Abraham Whistler stepped forward to examine him, focusing on the bite wound. After a moment, he said:

Catching it, the old man asked, "There really a hundred grand in here?"

"Close enough. Didn't count."

Blade looked at Jasper. "What do we do with him?"

"Tie him up. I'm not babysitting, and I don't want him wandering off," Whistler said, grabbing a box and starting to clear the table.

As Blade found some rope, he frowned. "Is that really necessary?"

"Yes. Once we're done here, we move."

Whistler's tone turned sharp.

"This place is compromised. Doesn't matter if that guy means harm—too many people know about it now. You want to wake up one day with someone tearing this place apart? Fuck!"

He suddenly exploded in anger, startling even Blade.

Blade's expression twitched slightly. "What are you yelling about?"

"That shady bastard—didn't he call himself 'Black Superman'?"

"He's not even Black. You saw his skin. Colorblind doesn't mean blind," Blade shot back. "And I don't know what he calls himself."

Whistler stepped aside, revealing their computer system.

On the bulky CRT monitor—originally displaying a Windows 95 interface—part of the screen was now overridden by a message:

I can see you. — Black Superman

Blade's eyes narrowed. "He hacked our system? How?"

"Hell if I know."

For an old hunter like Whistler, learning to use a computer was already an achievement. Setting up surveillance, wiring systems, linking everything together—that was beyond most users of his generation.

But hacking?

Writing code?

Infiltrating systems?

That was beyond him.

Even when he rebooted into safe mode and ran antivirus scans like in the DOS days, nothing showed up.

Because there was no virus.

Black Superman had used a worm—

And at this point in time, antivirus software didn't even know to look for that.

Blade stared at the message, thinking.

"What's his angle?" he muttered. "Looking for trouble?"

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"The wound's still deteriorating. Looks like that garlic extract didn't do much. Got any progress on your serum?"

Black Superman reached out, dabbed a bit of fluid from the wound, and asked:

"You judge by the bite? What counts as improvement?"

Whistler, despite still being irritated about last night's hack, answered seriously:

"If the wound heals, that means something's changed—either he's fully turned, or he's beaten the virus.

"But this? Pus like this? That's bad. If you don't have a serum, you'd better prepare a silver bullet for him."

"Silver bullets kill vampires?" Black Superman asked flatly. "I thought that was for werewolves."

Whistler explained:

"Silver works on most dark creatures. It stops regeneration. Once they can't heal, you can kill them."

"Other weaknesses?"

Perhaps because the topic interested him, Whistler didn't hold back:

"Garlic extract—you've seen it. A full dose doesn't just hurt vampires, it kills them.

"I've heard in Europe they use silver nitrate rounds, or UV-radiation rounds—one for werewolves, one for vampires. Never seen them myself, though."

"Want those kinds of weapons? I can develop them."

As he spoke, Black Superman pulled out a vial of serum from his utility pouch.

Neither Whistler nor Blade responded immediately. Their attention was locked onto that vial.

Black Superman didn't care. He calmly prepared the injection—then administered a large dose directly into Jasper's body.

The reaction was instant.

Jasper's body curled like a cooked squid, limbs contorting violently. He convulsed, foamed at the mouth, and let out a low, guttural growl.

Black Superman remained completely unfazed. One hand pressed firmly against Jasper's chest, keeping him from thrashing off the table.

The other two simply watched.

When the convulsions stopped, Jasper lay there drenched in sweat, like someone who had just run a marathon.

"He alive?" Whistler stepped forward.

"Not dead," Black Superman replied after a brief check. He then stepped aside, letting Whistler examine him.

The old hunter eagerly got to work, poking and prodding.

Even Blade came closer, watching.

"It works?" he asked.

"Looks like it," Whistler said, clearly excited. "The wound's no longer oozing white pus—just normal blood and discharge. The redness in his eyes has faded. Teeth haven't changed.

"If he can still stand sunlight tomorrow morning... he'll make it."

Whistler turned to Black Superman.

"How'd you make this serum?"

Black Superman didn't hide anything. He placed several remaining vials on the table, along with a 3.5-inch floppy disk.

"This is what's left from a single batch. The disk contains the process and material ratios. Though... your equipment isn't quite enough to reproduce it."

"Hmm. 'Black Superman,' was it?"

Whistler picked up a vial, examining the pale blue liquid.

"Why do all this? Even offering to help us develop weapons?"

"I have a grudge against vampires. Is that reason enough?"

Blade spoke up:

"Not enough. If you want to work with us, we need to know who you are. How do I know you won't sell us out?"

Fair point.

Even Black Superman wouldn't trust someone completely hidden.

So—

He reached up and pulled off his mask.

"—You!"

"—Who are you?"

Ignoring Blade's confusion, Whistler sighed and explained:

Chapter 461 - 461 — Shadow War

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It wasn't exactly that the Men in Black had formally absorbed Blade's group. But in the war against vampires, they had gained a powerful enforcer.

There were no restrictions—no rules about which vampires could or couldn't be killed. After all, every last one of those fanged creatures deserved a beating. None of them were innocent.

Jasper Barden stayed one more day at Blade's hideout.

Though he woke up uneasy, dealing with people like Blade and Abraham Whistler wasn't unfamiliar territory for someone who'd lived on the streets.

It didn't take long before he was calling Whistler "brother" and treating Blade like a junior—much to the irritation of the half-vampire.

Because Cruella's side was pressing for urgency, the Men in Black made the call to stall things for a day. Only after confirming Jasper showed no signs of vampire infection was he reluctantly escorted out and sent back to England.

~~~~~

As for his mission to personally deliver invitations—it fizzled out. The invitations were instead sent through Stark Pictures' mailroom.

But with vampires involved, far fewer Hollywood stars were willing to attend.

Blade and Whistler didn't relocate their base. Instead, the Men in Black upgraded their surveillance system, expanding its coverage.

Anyone approaching the warehouse district would trigger tiered alerts.

The system even quietly linked into police databases. Anyone with a criminal record could be flagged through facial recognition in advance.

Of course, given the era, the accuracy wasn't great—but it was better than nothing.

The Men in Black provided both the software and the police database access mainly to gather more data for future improvements.

And if anything went wrong?

Well—the users weren't them. Having someone else take the fall wasn't a bad backup plan.

As for UV bullets and silver nitrate rounds—those were easy.

The Men in Black practically handed over the tech and manufacturing equipment, just short of guiding Whistler step-by-step on how to produce them.

Money or knowledge being "freeloaded" wasn't a concern.

As long as someone was out there killing vampires—and doing it enthusiastically—it was worth it.

Blade and Whistler certainly didn't mind either.

With or without support, they would hunt vampires. Now that someone was funding them and supplying ammo, they simply hunted harder.

And just as predicted—

Hollywood changed.

As Blade stirred wave after wave of bloodshed, the underworld fell into chaos... while the surface world grew quieter.

Previously, Blade hadn't been as active due to limited ammunition.

Looting vampires barely covered costs. Sometimes the money taken off a corpse wouldn't even pay for the silver stake used to kill it.

And when it came to firearms, Blade followed classic U.S. military doctrine—

Ammo was meant to be spent.

During the Vietnam War, it took an average of 70,000 rounds to kill one enemy. Blade wasn't that inefficient—but he still burned through ammo fast. Most fights ended with him running dry and switching to melee.

After each battle, he'd enter a cooldown period—gathering intel, stockpiling ammo, and occasionally taking side jobs at the Continental Hotel to make ends meet.

No wonder he valued gold coins.

But with Men in Black support, those downtime periods shrank.

And that meant one thing—

Vampires were in trouble.

Ironically, despite Blade's increasingly aggressive hunts, the vampires—still lacking a unified radical leadership—became more cautious instead of retaliating.

If Blade and Whistler were easy to eliminate, they'd have been dead long ago.

The fact that they were still alive proved otherwise.

The calm on the surface was noticeable in Hollywood.

Strange parties disappeared. Odd invitations stopped coming.

But that didn't mean vampire activity had ceased.

With backing from dying old-money elites, their operations had simply become more secretive—and far more brutal.

Public-facing activity stopped only to avoid leaving trails.

After all, the vampires Blade hunted were the careless ones.

However, Blade now faced a new limitation—

Intel.

Every time he wiped out a nest, the rest went deeper underground.

Finding them became harder and harder.

The Men in Black could help—but they had no intention of turning themselves into a full-time vampire radar.

Even with Kryptonian super senses, information gathering was passive—and time-consuming.

Criminals didn't sit around 24/7 repeating their plans for easy interception.

Supporting Blade was always meant to be a low-effort strategy—

Chapter 462 - 462 — The Girl Who Got Played

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Henry asked curiously, "You two haven't just been standing here the whole time, have you?"

"From experience, this is the best spot," Horace Barden replied.

Jasper nodded in agreement. "At times like this, Cruella's extremely busy. If she suddenly needs something and can't find us, she'll be furious.

"But if we stick too close and get in her way, she'll also be furious. So standing here is safest—easy to call, but not in the way."

Henry chuckled. "Sounds like Her Majesty is quite the tyrant."

The two Bardens exchanged knowing smiles.

After giving Jasper a quick once-over, Henry asked, "Any aftereffects from that day? Feeling alright?"

Since vampire matters couldn't be discussed openly, Henry kept it vague. Jasper understood immediately and smiled.

Spend money. Avoid work.

As long as vampires were kept busy and unable to target them, that was enough.

Clearing America of vampires?

That wasn't their job.

If even the U.S. government wasn't doing it, why should they?

---

At the end of June, Henry traveled to Paris as a guest to attend one of Cruella's menswear fashion shows.

Charlize Theron accompanied him.

The moment they arrived backstage—

Charlize made a beeline straight for Cruella.

Almost deliberately.

Without caring whether the designer was overwhelmed, she immediately started picking a fight.

"Capri pants with black-and-white striped stockings? What is this—Victorian British hunting fashion? Is that what you're going for, Cruella?"

"Fashion is cyclical," Cruella shot back without missing a beat. "Each era has its own themes. It's fine if you don't understand—but shallow criticism only makes you look foolish."

The two women clashed like fighting roosters—sarcasm flying, neither yielding an inch.

Yet—

Cruella's hands never stopped working.

She directed assistants, adjusted accessories, and personally refined model styling on the fly.

Charlize, for all her sharp tongue, didn't interfere physically. She kept her distance, careful not to disrupt the workflow or damage anything.

After greeting them, Henry moved to a corner—out of everyone's way.

Partly to avoid the battlefield.

Partly because the Barden brothers were there.

"Henry," Jasper Barden greeted warmly.

After all, this man had saved his life back in Los Angeles.

Without Henry, Jasper might not have made it out alive.

Naturally, his attitude carried genuine gratitude.

Horace Barden, though more reserved, knew the story as well. Even he showed more friendliness than usual.

"Jasper, Horace. Good to see you," Henry replied with equal ease.

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"No problem. I can still walk under sunlight, at least."

"Sorry. You got dragged into that because of me."

"But you also helped me," Jasper replied.

Being dragged into danger naturally left some resentment—but he understood the situation. Henry had warned him of the risks from the start, and when things went bad, he didn't abandon him.

Even if Henry hadn't shown up personally at the most critical moment—getting the right people for the job was better than showing up uselessly.

Having grown up on the streets, Jasper understood that well.

Still, curiosity got the better of him. Leaning closer, he asked in a low voice:

"Those people... you knew them?"

Henry was a bit surprised.

Most people, after encountering something dangerous, would want to stay as far away as possible. Especially when it came to vampires—legendary creatures of the dark.

Yet Jasper was asking about them.

Another vampire romantic? Dreaming of that fake immortality?



Still, Henry answered.

He pulled out a Continental gold coin from his pocket, briefly showing it to the Bardens before slipping it away again.

"I contacted them through this. You recognize it?"

"Ah... I see." Jasper nodded.

Horace, however, looked confused. "What is that coin?"

Jasper hinted instead of saying it outright. "Back when we were still on the streets... remember the group that used gold coins for transactions?"

"Oh—you mean the—"

Jasper clamped a hand over his mouth. "You know, so don't say it."

The shorter man's eyes widened. He nodded quickly, and only then did Jasper let go.

Henry leaned in slightly. "Why ask about them?"

Jasper replied quietly, "You know—those creatures are way more common in Europe than in the States. I just want to know who to turn to if something happens here.

"But without coins... that route's probably closed to me."

Without hesitation, Henry took out his coin and pressed it into Jasper's hand.

"Take it. If you ever need to, use it to stay a night at the Continental. It's neutral ground—no business allowed. That should buy you enough time to ask for help."

"Are you sure?" Jasper asked—but his grip tightened immediately, clearly not intending to give it back.

"I only have one on me, so take it. But remember—one coin, one night. Use it carefully. I'll get you more when I can. These things can't be mailed."

"Thanks." Jasper didn't stand on ceremony. He pocketed it right away.

Henry added, "But you should also know—those creatures are part of the hotel's upper ranks. They won't break the rules, but confidentiality isn't one of them. Information always has a price."

"I understand."

"Still, you don't need to worry too much. Same species, different territories. I don't have conflicts with the ones here."

Jasper nodded.

At first, he'd seen Henry as nothing more than a lucky guy—someone who suddenly rose to power while surrounded by beautiful women.

But now?

Henry had saved him—and had access to Continental gold coins. That meant his past wasn't as clean-cut as it looked.

For someone like Jasper, who grew up as a street thief, that made Henry feel a lot more... relatable.

---

"JASPER! HORACE! WHERE THE HELL ARE YOU?!"

The sudden shout made both men stiffen. They immediately dashed over.

"What is it?"

"Jewelry case. Tie rack," Cruella said curtly.

They instantly understood and moved to fetch the items.

Meanwhile, Henry followed their line of sight—

### Chapter 463 - 463 — The Menswear Runway

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At the finale of Cruella's menswear show, a model with clearly feminine features stepped onto the men's runway—instantly causing an uproar in the fashion world.

It wasn't that no one had ever done this before. But to do it here, on Paris's most important stage—and to create this level of impact—was unprecedented.

In terms of avant-garde experimentation, London Fashion Week was usually the boldest among the Big Four. But pulling this off at Paris Menswear Ready-to-Wear was practically pushing the limits of market acceptance.

And yet—

The one walking the runway was the Tiger Beauty who had recently gone viral in TV commercials.

From the wild, feline-accompanied womenswear in advertisements to the sharp, commanding presence in menswear on the runway, what she projected wasn't the regal, queen-like aura of the five supermodels—like Cindy Crawford.

Instead, it was something more dominant.

—and froze.

His girl had been completely stripped by Cruella's assistants and dressed in a full menswear outfit.

Stunned, Henry walked over to Charlize—who looked equally stunned.

Makeup artists and stylists were working on her face and hair.

"What's going on?"

Charlize clenched her teeth. "I got played."

"You're walking the runway? In a menswear show?" Henry asked, incredulous.

"...If I'd brought Katie—"

Henry blinked. Was she serious?

"—I'd have let her loose to bite that woman to death!"

...Alright. She really had picked up his style.

If you don't have to dirty your own hands—don't.

As for who she meant? That didn't even need asking.

In later years, gender-fluid runway casting would be normal—models crossing between menswear and womenswear shows without issue.

But this was the 90s.

Even mentioning homosexuality openly was still taboo.

Runways were strictly divided. Crossing over wasn't just unusual—it risked stepping on someone else's livelihood.

Looking at Charlize's perfectly tailored outfit, Henry sighed.

"This was planned. No way they just happened to have clothes in your exact size."

Charlize, currently being patted with powder, couldn't even open her mouth to curse.

From behind came Cruella's voice:

"Move. Don't get in my way! I gave her the finale—she should be thanking me. Do you even know how to spell it? T-H-A-N-K-S. Or do you only know 'Bedankt'?"

"Bedankt" was Dutch for "thank you."

For someone whose native language was English and second language French, Cruella deliberately using Dutch made her target obvious.

Charlize finally gave up worrying about powder getting in her mouth.

A stream of Afrikaans curses burst out.

To make matters worse—

The \$100 hairstyle she'd just gotten in Los Angeles had been completely ruined by the stylists here.

If not for the setting, she might have screamed.

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Something undefined.

A presence that refused categorization—stepping onto a stage that "belonged" to men.

Even as the flashes from countless cameras flooded the runway like a sea of light—"film murder," as photographers called it—Charlize Theron completed her single walk flawlessly.

Probably only Henry could tell—

She was channeling the essence of Marlon Brando and Al Pacino from The Godfather.

Her gait wasn't the typical model walk.

It wasn't the feminine, straight-line step designed to accentuate hip sway.

Her steps were wider, more grounded—placed deliberately left and right, carrying weight and authority.

The only thing constraining her was time.

She couldn't walk too fast or too slow—she had to hit the mark perfectly.

And she did.

A performance so complete that even she might never replicate it again.

---

The result?

The black trench coat, paired with an off-white plaid vest, a crisp white shirt, black trousers, and that tilted plaid bowler hat—

All of it triggered a wave of inquiries and orders.

Customers came from both genders.

It shattered the notion that menswear was only for men—or that "female-friendly menswear" somehow didn't suit actual men.

Who said slimmer, smaller-built men couldn't look sharp and commanding?

This wave alone had Cruella grinning from ear to ear.

---

An unexpected bonus followed.

When the news made its way back to the U.S., The Rock—already in its fourth week—experienced a renewed surge at the box office.

Even though Charlize had only a few scenes, audiences were curious to see how this "headline beauty" performed on screen.

The buzz was so strong that J.J. Harris called across the ocean to discuss Charlize's next steps.

If Henry hadn't been preparing to return to Los Angeles, she might have flown to Paris herself.

Previously, due to vampire interference, Charlize had lost several opportunities.

Now, not only were some of those offers returning—her salary had room for negotiation.

Some projects even voluntarily raised their pay.

Both J.J. Harris and Charlize felt a long-overdue sense of vindication.

Auditions followed the same trend.

Major productions that had once shown little interest were now extending invitations.

Of course, most offers were still runway-related—modeling agencies eager to sign her.

But Charlize had no intention of pursuing that path.

She knew exactly where her future lay: Hollywood.

Acting across all roles—not surviving on youth and starving herself into a skeleton.

---

After a call with her agent in Paris, Charlize looked at Henry with a strange expression.

It made his scalp prickle.

"What?"

"Jen told me—you invested in Titanic. Sixty-five million dollars."

"And you're asking why I didn't get you a role?"

"She told me to ask you to arrange one."

Henry explained, "I've read the script. Aside from the female lead, there's no standout supporting role that suits you.

"Cameron did say he could give you a small part—but he wasn't exactly enthusiastic.

"You really think joining a 'set tyrant' like him under those conditions would be pleasant?"

"And the schedule conflicts with your current work. Dropping everything for an insignificant role—it's not worth it."

"...What about the female lead?" Charlize asked, aiming high.

Henry gave her a simple, irrefutable answer.

"You don't fit James Cameron's aesthetic. He prefers fuller, more rounded women."

"...Alright."

She knew when to let go.

What Henry didn't say—

Was that the film would truly elevate only one person: the director.

The leads would gain fame—but their acting careers would actually suffer from it.

Being part of it wasn't necessarily a blessing.

---

Back in Los Angeles, both of them dove straight into work.

J.J. Harris continued pushing her clients—including Charlize.

Charlize kept auditioning, taking roles big or small, and giving her all on set.

Henry?

He pushed forward the construction of his underwater laboratory, researched alien tech, and continued funding Blade and Abraham Whistler in their vampire-hunting campaign.

Whenever Charlize had time, he dropped everything to be with her.

Whatever remained—

Went to Hollywood social obligations.

Interestingly, as vampires became busier dealing with Blade, invitations to Henry increased again—and became far less... bizarre.

Occasionally, he would remember to guide Stark Pictures' digital imaging development—technically his actual job.

But he remained committed to his personal goal:

Being a paid slacker.

Life was, all things considered, extremely comfortable.

---

That evening, he was debating whether to head underwater again—installing methane collectors, natural gas generators, and helium purification systems—

When a notification popped up on his computer.

A message from Abraham Whistler.

Marked urgent.

No hesitation.

Henry slipped out.

---

Passing by his small office, he saw his secretary—his "black chubby girl"—watering a cactus while eating a donut.

"Yulian."

"Yes, boss." She quickly set things aside and looked up.

Henry almost told her:

Succulents don't need that much water. That cactus is about to die again.

But in the end, he just said:

"I've got something to handle. If anyone asks for me, take a message."

"Got it, boss."

---

In the underground parking lot, Henry grabbed his refurbished off-road bicycle and prepared to leave.

Why a bike?

Not for environmental reasons.

Not for exercise.

Simply because he was being followed more often.

Driving a car had nearly gotten him boxed in multiple times.

Only by slipping through alleyways had he avoided high-speed chases through L.A.

Charlize, needing a car for work, had planned to buy a used one.

Henry just tossed her the keys to his old Cadillac.

Gas money? Her problem.

He, meanwhile, salvaged a bike from a scrapyard, fixed it up, and rode that instead.

This way, when using super speed or flight, he didn't have to abandon a vehicle—he could just carry it.

Mobility improved dramatically.

And since it was a junk bike—

Losing it didn't matter.

For a Kryptonian, vehicles were just props.

---

So now—

He simply hoisted the bike onto his shoulder...

...and walked straight past the surveillance teams.

Right in front of them.

Leaving them with nothing but his back—

And, well—

Not even exhaust fumes.

Bikes don't have those.

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Chapter 464 - 464 — A Serum for Bloodlust

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Although a dark figure flying through the sky in broad daylight would be rather conspicuous, moving at super speed through the city streets was far less noticeable.

As long as he avoided densely populated areas—so the shockwaves from his movement wouldn't sweep up innocent bystanders and draw attention.

Black Superman once again arrived at the warehouse district, at the location of Blade's hidden base.

Using his enhanced senses first, he confirmed that aside from Blade and Abraham Whistler, the two vampire hunters, there was no third party present. There were no signs of an intrusion either—so this wasn't a call for emergency backup.

Then what exactly was so "urgent"?

As he approached within a certain distance, the soles of his tactical boots struck the ground, producing audible footsteps—within the range covered by the surveillance system he had helped install.

The purpose was simple: to let them know he had arrived.

Moreover, while the system couldn't detect his own movements—essentially giving himself a backdoor—he deliberately made his presence known. It was a way to appear less "inhuman" and earn the trust of these deeply suspicious vampire hunters.

Whether they believed it or not didn't matter.

As long as that final layer of truth wasn't exposed, both sides could continue cooperating.

That was the current nature of Black Superman and Blade's partnership.

"You're here," the limping old hunter greeted first.

Blade, unusually, was also inside the base during the daytime.

While vampire hunting mainly happened at night, Blade typically spent the day gathering intelligence or procuring materials for Whistler, whose mobility was limited.

Still speaking through his electronic voice filter, Black Superman asked,

"What do you need? You don't look urgent at all. If it's just about weapon development, that could wait until tonight."

"No, not that," Whistler shook his head. "With the equipment you provided, making silver nitrate rounds, UV rounds, or even standard silver bullets isn't a problem anymore. Material waste has also dropped significantly."

In the past, Whistler had crafted silver bullets using traditional crucibles and molds. The downside was that each bullet required polishing afterward—otherwise there was a risk of barrel explosions or erratic trajectories.

And since the old man wasn't a professional silversmith, he had no efficient way to collect the silver filings during polishing—resulting in significant waste over time.

Black Superman only handled R&D and provided compact manufacturing equipment. He wasn't about to sit there mass-producing bullets all day for Blade's slaughter runs.

Once the equipment and processes were handed over, he left the rest to them.

As long as vampires suffered more trouble, that was enough.

However, as he got closer, he noticed additional medical equipment in Whistler's workspace.

"You're planning to produce serum yourselves?" he asked. "Ran into something you don't understand?"

He had previously provided the formula and process for an antiretroviral serum—used to reverse early-stage vampiric infection.

According to Blade, injecting it into a fully turned vampire resulted in a spectacular head explosion—just as effective as conventional weapons.

So... were they trying to weaponize it?

Whistler shook his head.

"Do you remember what you said before? About helping develop a serum to treat Blade's bloodlust?"

Chapter 465 465 — A Method of Treatment

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"I remember. I also remember you refused."

"That was before we trusted you," Whistler replied. "And Blade didn't want his blood samples leaving this place."

"You know how the military is—still obsessed with super soldier programs. We're not interested in creating more vampires... or something even worse."

"So?" Black Superman prompted.

"We want you to do the research here. The blood samples don't leave this base."

Blade nodded in agreement.

Whistler added, "I've gathered equipment based on the requirements you listed for serum development. If anything's missing, tell me—I can get it."

Without hesitation, Black Superman stepped forward and began adjusting the equipment.

"Draw your own blood," he said casually. "No friendly nurse here. Either the old man helps, or I do—pick your poison."

Though he gave Blade a choice, he made no move to approach.

Blade glanced between the two options and finally said,

"Whistler, give me a hand."

Self-injection was one thing—drawing his own blood was another.

The old hunter tied off his arm and filled a syringe with a full tube of blood.

Once the sample was ready, Black Superman stepped forward, took the syringe, and—without removing the needle—placed a few drops onto a glass slide. The rest he transferred into a test tube and set aside.

Under the microscope, Blade's blood looked very different from Jasper Barden's—who had been mid-transformation after infection.

In infected individuals, cells displayed dual nuclei, and red blood cells shifted from their normal biconcave shape to a biconvex one.

Blade's blood, however, was peculiar.

Normal human cells and vampire-altered cells coexisted—but the virus showed no sign of further infection or conversion.

They existed in balance.

"Interesting," Black Superman murmured. "Your blood is... unique."

He glanced up.

"How do you suppress the bloodlust? Drinking hospital blood bags like juice?"

Blade shook his head.

"I inject garlic extract. It's painful as hell, but it suppresses the urge."

"Any side effects? And your ability to walk in sunlight—does that depend on the suppression, or is it constant?"

"I don't know about side effects," Blade answered honestly. "I feel normal. And sunlight doesn't affect me, whether the urge is suppressed or not."

"I see."

Black Superman retrieved a vial of garlic extract from Whistler's medical kit.

He added a few drops to the edge of the slide. Through capillary action, the liquid spread and mixed with Blade's blood sample.

In truth, his enhanced vision could already see the result.

But he still went through the motions, adjusting the microscope like a proper scientist.

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At this point, Blade added, "There is one issue. The duration that garlic extract suppresses my bloodlust is getting shorter and shorter. I'm worried that one day, it won't be able to suppress my instincts at all."

"And what happens then?" Black Superman asked casually. "Do you become a full vampire and lose the ability to walk in sunlight? Or do you turn into a mindless

beast that bites anyone it sees?"

Blade answered seriously, "I don't know. And I don't want to find out."

Under the microscope, Blade's cells reacted to garlic extract differently from typical vampire-infected cells.

Some cells, like those infected by the vampire virus, ruptured and died upon contact with the extract. But others reverted back to their normal human state.

The most critical component—the red blood cells—showed an even clearer pattern.

Once infected, red blood cells gradually shifted from their normal biconcave shape into a biconvex form.

Since vampires lose the ability to produce new blood through stem cells, once all red blood cells become biconvex, their oxygen-carrying capacity drops sharply. At that point, they must consume external blood to prevent systemic cellular suffocation.

Garlic extract, however, partially reversed this process in Blade—turning some of the biconvex cells back into functional biconcave ones.

But the extract didn't act exclusively on red blood cells—it also affected other body cells.

That explained why Blade experienced intense pain when injecting it.

And because more and more red blood cells were becoming nonfunctional over time, while only a limited portion could be restored, the suppression window kept shrinking.

After completing the initial examination, Black Superman lifted his head from the microscope.

Though Blade and Whistler appeared occupied, their attention snapped back to him instantly.

"Got something?" Whistler asked.

"I have a rough idea," Black Superman said, explaining his findings before continuing:

"With a blood sample and enough time, I'm confident I can develop a cure that removes the vampire virus from Blade entirely.

"But doing that would turn him into a fully normal human. No vampire weaknesses—but also no vampire enhancements."

"That's not acceptable!" Whistler cut in before Blade could speak. "Our feud with vampires runs deeper than you can imagine. If they find out Blade's become human, they'll throw everything they've got at him—turn it into a damn feast."

Blade, hidden behind his sunglasses, looked helplessly at the old man—clearly not thrilled about decisions being made for him.

Whistler didn't care.

"What're you looking at me like that for?" he snapped. "If I were a vampire, I'd sure as hell do it. You think they like you or something?"

Then he turned to Black Superman.

"So yeah, that option's off the table—unless we wipe out every vampire on Earth first."

Black Superman nodded. "Fine. Then there's another approach."

"I can create a restoration agent that temporarily converts your red blood cells back to their normal state.

"But it won't be permanent. As your blood circulates, the virus will gradually affect them again—so you'll need repeated doses."

"The downside is obvious: you'll be dependent on this drug for life. And I can't guarantee whether resistance will develop, forcing higher and higher doses."

"The upside is also clear—you retain your vampire physiology: enhanced strength, speed, reflexes."

"As for the bloodlust, it might be a physiological trigger causing psychological effects—or something else entirely. Until we encounter it directly, I can't say for sure. You'll have to rely on your own willpower."

Chapter 466 466 — The Unlucky Test Subject

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When Black Superman returned to the warehouse district the next day, he immediately noticed that Blade had actually brought back a vampire.

The guy was strapped to the same workbench where Jasper Barden had once lain unconscious, thrashing nonstop.

Covered in tattoos and unusually lively, the vampire clearly had a foul mouth—so someone had stuffed a filthy sock into it. No idea whose.

"Is he a vampire?" Black Superman asked, just to confirm.

Whistler didn't answer. Instead, he tossed over a metal tray.

"I'll take the restoration agent," Blade said immediately, cutting off any further input from Whistler.

Black Superman nodded. "If you won't let me take your blood samples out of here, I can work on-site. But I'll need various chemical and biological materials to synthesize it. I'll give you a list."

These two vampire hunters had already accomplished plenty before his involvement—they had their own channels to acquire restricted materials.

Black Superman didn't differentiate between controlled substances or not—he dumped the entire list on Whistler.

Better that way.

If he made things too easy, they might start thinking his help was a given.

After a moment's thought, he added:

"If you want to improve the chances of success, I'd like a blood sample from a pure vampire—for comparison with Blade's."

"Turned or born?" Whistler asked.

"Either. If there's a difference, then preferably one of each," Black Superman replied, then added curiously, "There are vampires born that way?"

Whistler nodded. "It's rare, but vampire reproduction does happen. If the mother is human, it increases the chances. Those born with vampire traits are considered 'purebloods.'"

Black Superman considered this.

"So the classification isn't really about lineage, but just a label to elevate certain individuals. Even turned vampires could produce 'pureblood' offspring under this definition."

Whistler shrugged. "There's another problem. To get a blood sample, we'd have to capture a vampire alive. That's risky—and complicated."

"Why? I only need a vial of blood," Black Superman said.

Blade explained, "Vampires have some kind of unknown linkage. Even if you take blood out of their body, once the vampire dies, the sample turns to ash along with them."

"That's... unusual," Black Superman muttered. "Can the ash be analyzed?"

"No," Whistler replied. "It's just dust. No trace of human biology. Like they never existed."

"I see..." Black Superman said. "It behaves like a virus, but doesn't mutate like one. So a few extra strange properties aren't that surprising."

Blade asked, "So do you still need the sample?"

Black Superman continued writing his materials list as he thought.

"If you can get one, it would help for comparison. But if not, I can work with your blood alone."

That was enough.

Blade and Whistler had already decided—they'd capture a vampire alive.

Otherwise, what kind of hunters would they be?

And it wasn't like they needed a high-ranking target.

Just grabbing some low-level grunt wouldn't be a problem.

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On it lay two grotesquely long, sharp fangs—far beyond anything a human could have.

Black Superman pried open the vampire's mouth to check. Sure enough, those teeth had come from this unlucky bastard. The sock inside was soaked with dark, foul-smelling blood, acting like makeshift gauze.

His interference only agitated the vampire further. Fortunately, iron chains and a tensioner held him firmly in place—otherwise he might've already broken free.

Given the strength he displayed despite his not particularly muscular frame, there was no doubt something abnormal about him.

Satisfied, Black Superman kicked the chain tensioner loose.

Both vampire hunters tensed instinctively, ready to react—but held back, curious to see what he would do.

The vampire surged up, thinking he was finally free—



Only to be flipped over effortlessly by the man in black before he could attack anyone.

Black Superman pinned him down with one hand, clenched the other into a fist, and drove a knuckle strike into the back of his neck—right at the cervical spine.

The result was immediate.

The vampire's limbs went limp—completely paralyzed.

Only then did Black Superman calmly re-secure him with chains, tightening them even more than before.

Whistler watched the whole thing, stunned.

"What did you do? Why'd he suddenly behave?"

"Fractured the fourth cervical vertebra. High-level paralysis," Black Superman replied. "Seems vampire anatomy isn't that different from humans. I'm just not sure how fast he can heal—so better keep him restrained."

"You just tapped him once and paralyzed him?!" Whistler exclaimed.

"If Blade hits the right spot, he could do the same," Black Superman said modestly. "I'm just a bit more precise."

"What if he can't recover?" Whistler pressed, almost picking a fight.

"Then I revise my understanding of vampire regeneration downward," Black Superman said casually. "I was actually thinking of testing whether turning him into minced meat would still allow recovery. I've heard some mutants can regenerate from a single cell."

He forgot one thing—

The vampire wasn't unconscious.

He could hear everything.

Unable to move or speak, the poor guy wet himself on the spot.

Black Superman raised an eyebrow.

Interesting.

That suggested some autonomic function was already recovering—meaning partial spinal repair had begun.

"Fascinating," he remarked.

Then he grabbed a syringe and performed a bone marrow extraction from the iliac crest, drawing out thick, dark red marrow.

Another syringe filled with blood followed.

With samples in hand, he moved to the microscope for deeper observation.

"Keep an eye on him," he said. "If he starts regaining movement, let me know. Don't let him escape."

For some reason, both Blade and Whistler felt a flicker of guilt.

Like maybe... dragging this guy here was a bit much.

But the feeling passed quickly.

Vampires weren't human anymore—and in Los Angeles, none of them were clean. Every one of them had blood on their hands.

The reason for extracting bone marrow was to study vampire hematopoiesis.

The result was unexpected.

Chapter 467 467 — Research Results

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With a genuine vampire available for experimentation—and an effectively unlimited supply of vampire-derived materials—Black Super's experiments became increasingly bold.

However, he didn't experiment directly on the subject. Instead, he worked with blood samples and tissue samples.

Rather than worrying about ethics, Black Super was more concerned about accidentally introducing a substance that might instantly wipe out the vampire test subject.

If it turned to ash on the spot, would he have to ask Blade to go capture another one?

Wasting vampire lives was trivial—wasting time was not. What could be solved in one night might take several more just to secure another test subject. Why bother?

His super brain lived up to its name. Before long, Black Super identified the effective components within garlic extract. It wasn't a single compound, but rather a specific ratio of mixed substances.

Soon, he formulated the first batch of the mixture, followed by several variants with slightly adjusted ratios. Which formula worked best would have to be determined experimentally.

Vampires hadn't completely lost their ability to produce blood. Their red marrow still functioned—but at an extremely slow rate.

Too slow to replace the dysfunctional red blood cells.

Which explained why they needed to consume blood externally.

This also aligned with what Whistler had said—vampires could reproduce.

Unlike traditional lore where vampires are undead and biologically stagnant, Marvel's vampires still qualified—barely—as living organisms.

Hence, they retained reproductive capability.

They could also see their reflections in mirrors—another deviation from classic myths.

Which implied they still possessed "souls," in a sense.

After basic testing, Black Superman focused on comparing a normal vampire to Blade—the Daywalker.

If vampire bone marrow still produced red blood cells, then Blade's treatment could go beyond restoring existing cells—

It could stimulate the production of new ones.

One possible approach: erythropoietin.

A glycoprotein hormone that stimulates red blood cell production.

If it worked, things would become much simpler.

After all, in the real world, erythropoiesis-stimulating agents (ESA) were already used—albeit banned in sports for performance enhancement.

Companies like Amgen had been developing this technology since the 1980s.

And for someone who had "visited" their facilities—

The process was already crystal clear.

Since this wasn't for commercial use, Black Superman proceeded without hesitation.

As for the restoration agent, he began refining garlic extract—

Trying to isolate the specific component responsible for reverting Blade's cells.

At first, he even bothered explaining his methods to the two observers.

But as he got into the flow, his movements became faster, more efficient.

He stopped pretending with the microscope entirely.

Whether something worked or not—

He could tell instantly with his own senses.

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Since the compound functioned as a reducing agent targeting red blood cells, human trials weren't necessary—blood samples alone were sufficient.

Black Super tested both the captured vampire's blood and Blade's blood, wanting to compare a full vampire with Blade, who called himself a half-vampire.

The results showed that the reducing agent worked identically on both samples. Different ratios affected speed, duration, and strength of the effect, but the overall response was the same.

In other words, the reducing agent Black Super created could not only suppress Blade's bloodthirst, but could also be used by true vampires.

He recorded the characteristics of each ratio, highlighting several with particularly useful properties.

For example, one formulation acted slowly but lasted longer—suitable as a long-acting suppressor.

Another worked rapidly but wore off quickly—ideal as a temporary combat stimulant.

He added these as notes, leaving the choice of which version to use up to Blade. Black Super had no intention of interfering.

He also tested the reducing agent on tissue cells, using only vampire samples this time—he had no intention of experimenting on Blade.

The results, however, were less promising.

The selected mixture worked well on red blood cells, which lack nuclei. But the infected, dual-nucleus cells caused by the vampire virus showed resistance. The agent couldn't even kill those infected cells.



Despite that, the result actually suited Black Super just fine. He only intended to delay bloodthirst—not cure vampirism or revert vampires back into humans.

With the reducing agent essentially complete, his work on synthesizing erythropoietin (EPO) was also nearing completion.

Removing the EPO from the lab shaker, Black Super injected it into a slide containing red bone marrow samples and observed the changes under a microscope.

Perhaps due to being outside the human body, red blood cell production did occur—but at a much slower rate than in a normal, stable human system.

Further examination of vampire samples revealed that their hypoxia-inducible factors differed from those of humans.

This had already entered the realm of molecular biology. Without cutting-edge medical research and willing vampire subjects, such differences would be nearly impossible to detect.

Still, progress had been made in red blood cell production. Continuing down the path of studying hypoxia-inducible factors would drift into longevity and immortality research—far beyond his current goals. So he set that aside.

Standing before the test tube of erythropoietin, Black Super tapped his fingers lightly against the table.

His options were clear:

Extract bone marrow from the only full human present—Abraham Whistler—for in vitro testing.

Or extract it from Blade.

Or skip straight to human trials... and test it on a vampire.

While Black Super weighed the pros and cons, Abraham Whistler had already finished reading the notes Black Super left on the reducing agent formulas.

Though he hadn't assisted in the research, he had observed the entire process. When he understood something, he watched; when he didn't, he asked.

Eventually, the research became too advanced—even with explanations, he couldn't follow. So he stopped asking, and Black Super focused entirely on his work.

Still, Whistler could understand the results.

The notes on the reducing agent gave him some ideas. He tried not to interrupt Black Super's thinking... though that restraint lasted about three minutes.

Since Black Super's face was hidden behind a mask, Whistler couldn't tell if he was thinking or dozing off. Finally, he spoke:

"So, this stuff you made—is it a success or a failure? Why are you standing there thinking so long?"

Blade, who had been reading the notes behind Whistler, also looked up.

Black Super answered frankly:

"This is a hormone that stimulates bone marrow to produce red blood cells. The results I just got weren't very significant. I'm not sure if it's because the experiment was conducted outside the body, or because I used vampire bone marrow."

"So what are you deciding now?"

"Whether to extract your human bone marrow for testing, or go straight to in vivo testing on that guy. As for Blade's bone marrow... I don't think it'll produce much difference."

Whistler didn't refuse outright. Instead, he asked:

Chapter 468 468 — Vampire Experiment

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The syringe was fully depressed, then withdrawn. Black Super stepped back a few paces to observe the vampire's overall condition.

The unfortunate subject, injected with erythropoietin, began convulsing uncontrollably. Through Black Super's X-ray vision, he could see the shattered cervical vertebrae rapidly reconstructing themselves—but the muscles in the lower body were shriveling, as if losing moisture.

The iron chains binding the vampire rattled violently, as if he were trying to break free. Blade and Abraham Whistler, standing on either side, tensed up and focused.

Suddenly—snap!—a crisp sound rang out as the chains binding the upper body broke!

With both hands pressing against the workbench, the vampire tried to rise, glaring viciously at the living.

His mouth was stuffed with a filthy sock, so the intense heat building inside his body could only escape through his nostrils—two streams of white vapor hissing out.

It looked like something straight out of a horror film—but the ones standing by weren't reckless college kids. They were seasoned vampire hunters.

"Does that guy still have any use?" He pointed at the unlucky vampire strapped to the workbench, paralyzed from a cervical spine injury.

Black Super thought for a moment and replied seriously:

"I've already collected all the data I need. All required experiments and samples are complete. He has no further use to me—you can decide what to do with him."

Whistler didn't hesitate. Pointing at the vampire, he said:

"Then stop wasting time. Test it on him. Whether it works or not, we'll know in one go.

"At worst, he burns to ash and the drug fails. But you came up with two drugs in less than a night—are you sure this thing actually works?"

Black Super replied:

"Because the solution itself isn't something that needs to be invented from scratch. Others just never thought to apply it to vampires. I only needed to synthesize it and determine the dosage."

That was true for erythropoietin—but not for the reducing agent. That part was more of a conceptual shortcut disguised as something else.

Still, Whistler's reluctance to undergo bone marrow extraction was understandable. The procedure carried risks.

Even with local anesthesia, it was painful. And if performed poorly, it could cause serious damage.

Since Whistler had made the call, Black Super didn't dwell on it further. He prepared to inject the vampire test subject.

Drawing a large dose of erythropoietin into a syringe, Black Super paused just before administering it.

Blade and Whistler, both anticipating the result, looked puzzled.

"What's wrong?" Blade asked.

"You'd better get your weapons ready," Black Super said. "If the effect is too strong and he breaks free, you'll need to put him down immediately. We can't have him escaping and spreading word of what happened here."

"That likely?" Whistler asked, surprised.

"Just in case."

It was sound advice. Neither of them objected.

Whistler grabbed a shotgun loaded with silver rounds, while Blade returned to his room and retrieved his titanium alloy sword plated with silver.

The two vampire hunters took positions on either side of the workbench.

Standing at the vampire's waist, Black Super injected the large dose of erythropoietin directly into the lumbar spine.

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Whistler racked his shotgun and fired repeatedly. At the same time, Blade drove his sword straight through the vampire's body. Before the creature could fully break free, they finished it off completely.

Silver bullets blasted through him. A silver blade pierced his core. Even a vampire that fierce couldn't survive such lethal damage.

High heat ignited from within, incinerating every inch of flesh and hair.

Black Super also noticed that the tissue samples he had previously taken from the vampire were burned away as well.

It was absolute death—nothing of the vampire remained in this world.

At that moment, Black Super asked a question he'd long been curious about:

"If you kill one like this, what happens to the bloodline he's turned? Do they die too?"

Whistler used his gun barrel to stir the ashes on the workbench and replied:

"I wish. Kill one vampire and wipe out an entire lineage in one go. Unfortunately... that's not how it works."

"What a pity," Black Super said.

"Now my turn," Whistler continued. "What the hell just happened to him?"

Shaking the test tube containing the remaining erythropoietin, Black Super explained:

"Erythropoietin increases red blood cell production, which boosts oxygen transport and indirectly enhances muscle endurance.

"That makes it a banned substance in sports competitions. And what I injected was a high-dose version—into something that isn't exactly human. So the result was... unexpected."

Whistler raised a brow. "So you're saying it's basically a performance enhancer?"

"You could put it that way."

"And it'd have the same effect on Blade?"

"Most likely."

Seeing the excitement light up their eyes, Black Super immediately poured cold water on them:

"Don't get any ideas about using it as some kind of enhancement drug. In my opinion, it has serious drawbacks."

"What drawbacks?" Whistler asked.

Black Super replied:

"Did you notice that he could move again only after his neck healed? That rapid regeneration required energy—and that energy came from his own body.

"If you paid attention, his pant legs had collapsed inward before he died. I suspect his legs had undergone severe atrophy.

"I don't know whether the rumors are true—that vampires can rapidly recover from injuries by drinking human blood.

"But clearly, this drug enabled rapid healing without supplying energy. So he consumed himself. That's the only explanation for how he went from paralysis to mobility so quickly."

The two hunters exchanged a glance. Blade spoke:

"That rumor is true. As long as they aren't burned to death, drinking blood can heal almost any injury."

Holding the remaining erythropoietin, Whistler sighed:

"Still, even if it's not a proper healing drug, a temporary life-saving stimulant like this is pretty damn useful."

Black Super could tell—they were already thinking about extra uses, not just treating Blade's bloodthirst.

But once he handed over the formula, how they used it wasn't his concern.

Even ordinary people rarely follow advice given "for their own good." Whether they misuse it and get themselves killed—that's on them.

Still, when it came to his field, Black Super maintained professional standards.

He rummaged through Whistler's pile of junk, finding usable parts to assemble makeshift delivery devices.

As he worked, he said:

"Anyway, I've developed what Blade needs—a suppressant for bloodthirst. As for how to use it—spray, injection, tablets, or powder—it probably doesn't matter much

Chapter 469 469: Shadow War in the Northern Lands

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Blade's activities had heavily suppressed the vampires' influence, bringing a brief period of calm to Los Angeles's underworld.

But after several months, this pressure seemed to have had the opposite effect. The hawkish faction among the vampires rose to prominence, and their counterattacks intensified significantly. As the saying goes, the greater the external pressure, the stronger the rebound.

Although their interference with the surface world had not returned to previous levels, clashes between vampires and vampire hunters sometimes became too conspicuous to conceal, even making their way into media reports.

However, when the news covered such incidents, they were either attributed to vicious criminals of no particular group, or the blame was shifted onto mutants.

As for the word "vampire," it remained strictly taboo.

Even Blade and Abraham Whistler's base had been raided once by vampires.

Fortunately, before the attack, Abraham Whistler had received a warning from other vampire hunters. With Black Super's help driving, they relocated their secret base from the warehouse district to an abandoned steel factory in the industrial zone.

Whistler was able to call in such favors largely because he had secretly spread the Embrace Serum developed by Black Super.

Those who became vampire hunters all shared a deep hatred for these dark creatures. For them, the most painful thing was either being turned themselves or seeing their loved ones transformed.

In the past, they could only rely on injecting garlic extract and gambling on luck. Now that there was a serum capable of curing vampirism, who wouldn't welcome it?

to you.

"So I made the reducing agent into an inhaler, like an asthma spray. The erythropoietin will use a needle-free injector. Both can be used quickly in emergencies.

"If you want improvements later, let me know. Standard liquid injections will also be available. As for dosage—that's for Blade to figure out himself.

"But don't assume more is better. The reducing agent works by restoring your blood to a normal state. Once that's done, taking more won't do anything.

"The same goes for erythropoietin. Bone marrow has a limit. Anything beyond that just gets flushed out in urine.

"I've calculated recommended dosages based on Blade's body size and weight. How you use it—that's up to you. I won't interfere."

By the time he finished speaking, he had assembled a simple spray system and a needle-free injector similar to those used by diabetic patients.

With everything done, he clapped his hands and stood up.

"That's it. The rest is up to you. I've left all samples and research data here. The production process is fully documented."

As for researching vampire immortality—Black Super dropped it entirely.

Under a yellow sun, Kryptonians didn't need it. And even if he couldn't live forever, he had no interest in dragging out existence for eternity.

"Thanks, man," Blade said—a rare expression of gratitude.

Black Super shrugged. "Kill more vampires. That's thanks enough."

He meant it.

Since the vampires had declared war in secret, disturbances from the dark world had actually decreased.

Clearly, "letting the hound loose" was an effective strategy.

And Blade—the hound he'd funded and supported—was doing exactly what he was meant to do.

"That, I'm good at," Blade grinned, flashing white teeth.

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Not to mention, the serum could also be used as a weapon against vampires. Its only drawback was low production—otherwise, just in terms of material cost, it was far cheaper than silver bullets or silver stakes...

These hunters simply didn't trust half-vampires like Blade, so they were unwilling to work alongside him.

But Abraham Whistler, as a veteran hunter, was widely respected. Many of his connections were built with the support of his peers.

So when the vampires made a move, Whistler received a warning immediately and evacuated in time.

This chaotic experience of constantly relocating made Henry even more certain that building his secret base somewhere inaccessible to ordinary people was a wise decision. Moving every few days was truly exhausting.

While the battle between vampires and hunters raged in Los Angeles's shadows, another covert war was unfolding in the frozen lands of the north.

Alexei Shostakov, the super soldier codenamed "Red Guardian," had been arrested.

To prevent resistance or escape, the police came heavily armed. Every officer carried firearms, escorting the super soldier with rifles at the ready.

Though Alexei was a brute, his patriotism was genuine. He did not resist or refuse arrest—he only loudly demanded answers from those detaining him.

"Why? Why are you arresting me? All I did was suggest to that Tatar that we should adopt a more lively, more cheerful attitude instead of being so lifeless and serious like before.

"And I only said that to General Dreykov. Did he betray me? Dreykov, come out! I know you're watching nearby. Come out and face me—tell me why. Aren't we comrades?!"

Though he did not resist, Alexei could hardly be called cooperative. He kept turning his head, searching desperately for the treacherous ally who had betrayed him.

The squad leader of the arresting police, while directing his men, said, "Alexei, we're not arresting you for that bullshit reason.

"Don't you know the intelligence you brought back was wrong, yet you still bragged about your achievements? You damn fool. We're here under orders to investigate this matter, so cooperate."

Getting this bear-like man—several times stronger than an ordinary person—into the vehicle took everything the officers had. Their actions inevitably became rough.

That kind of force wouldn't injure a super soldier, but it did hurt his pride. Alexei protested loudly, "Hey! Show some respect, kid! When I was serving the country, you were still suckling milk. I am the Red Guardian!"

Behind him, a young officer pushing with all his strength to shove this bear of a man into the vehicle struggled to say, "Now... there's... no more... Red... that needs... guarding!"

Hearing this, Alexei seemed to lose all his strength. He stumbled and was shoved headfirst into the vehicle.

Perhaps because burying his face in the seat cushion was uncomfortable, Alexei adjusted himself and sat upright inside, allowing the officers to finally breathe a sigh of relief as they prepared to escort him to the State Security Bureau.

But just as they were leaving, Alexei—staring lifelessly out the window—suddenly shouted, "Suka... blyat! Stop the car, stop! I see a damned American—Nick Fury!

"Stop the car! Let's grab him! Do you know how valuable he is? Fury! Podlyuga! Was it you who set me up?! Aaaah!"

By the roadside, two figures—already wearing heavy coats despite it being early September—watched the convoy depart from the corners of their eyes.

It was early morning, the coldest time of day, so their attire wasn't particularly suspicious. The coats and fur hats also helped conceal their faces.

For the older one-eyed white man standing in front, the warm clothing was especially necessary. This mission had made him fully realize that his physical condition was no longer suited for fieldwork.

The young woman behind him was a capable newcomer assigned as support.

However, her composure still needed work. In situations like this, they should have walked past as if nothing had happened to avoid drawing suspicion.

But the target's booming voice seemed to carry even from inside the moving vehicle. The girl couldn't help asking, "Sir, did the Red Guardian notice us?"

Fortunately, she didn't turn her head toward the convoy, so her evaluation in the one-eyed old man's mind didn't drop.

The old man said, "Don't underestimate Alexei just because he's a brute. His battlefield instincts are terrifying. People like him are easy to take lightly—and that's how you end up dead.

Chapter 470 470: S.H.I.E.L.D.’s Think Tanks

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When certain components not belonging to Earth appeared in S.H.I.E.L.D.'s research center, the think tank was forced to consider a wider range of possibilities.

One thing, in particular, was impossible to ignore...

Since the publication of Action Comics in 1938, DC Comics' flagship superhero—Superman—has been a Kryptonian.

Was this a coincidence, or was there some kind of causal connection?

In a country where the entertainment industry thrived, mutants even had their own comics. The X-Men series had once become so popular that the military considered banning it outright. After all, it was best if no one paid attention to mutants—only then could certain unspeakable activities be carried out.

However, as relations between the government and mutants gradually eased, this comic series—modeled on reality—became both a source of emotional support for many mutants and a way for ordinary people to understand them.

Though not entirely reflective of reality, the mutants in comics were much like normal people. They experienced love and hate, worried about daily meals, and lived ordinary lives—except they possessed all kinds of extraordinary abilities like flying and teleportation.

Captain Steve Rogers, better known as Captain America, had truly been active during World War II and was a renowned war hero. That didn't stop Hollywood from repeatedly adapting his story into films, even adding fictional elements to satisfy public imagination.

Many other heroes, real or fictional, were brought vividly to life through the pens of artists.

Of course, in most cases, these masked heroes didn't dare take comic or film companies to court. Even if their likenesses were used, the profits still went entirely to those companies...

Captain America was an exception. Though he had already fallen, he had always been a figure promoted by the U.S. military. Any commercial adaptation involving him had to take the military's stance into account, and profits were naturally shared.

Returning to Superman—

"Luckily, we don't have to face him head-on. What about the second target? Did the contacts I gave you prove useful?"

Barbara Morse, who had come to the northern country, replied, "Sir, the Iron Maiden, Melina Vostokoff, has returned to General Dreykov's protection. No one can locate them."

"So in the end, she went back to the Red Room," Nick Fury said with a sigh. "What about the third target?"

Barbara Morse answered with some difficulty, "The collected fragments and components have been handed over to a courier and shipped back home. We only recovered part of the documents and personnel records from the former extraterrestrial research institute.

"As for personnel, quite a number are missing. We've only identified the whereabouts of a few. We're uncertain whether to make contact, so no contact plan has been initiated for now. If we want to find more, we'll need to stay longer."

Old Nick Fury asked, "Did finding evidence that the man is an alien make it hard for you to accept?"

"No, sir. I'm just concerned whether, as the Skrulls claimed, he might have psychological issues," Barbara replied, offering an excuse.

"Don't treat secondhand accounts from another species about events nine thousand years ago—especially from those who weren't even firsthand witnesses—as reliable intelligence. That man's behavior and performance are what we should base our judgment on."

"Yes, sir."

"Let's go. Withdraw along Route C. We've stayed long enough." With that, Nick Fury brought his journey in Russia to a close.

Perhaps this would also be his final field mission. Trading one Red Guardian was more than worth it, Fury thought to himself.

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Was Henry Brown Clark Kent? Did "Kryptonite" exist on Earth?

Within S.H.I.E.L.D.'s think tank, opinions were sharply divided.

One faction believed it was purely coincidence. After all, prior to today, no planet called "Krypton" existed in Earth's star charts. The name itself was merely a transliteration derived from Skrull intelligence.

That such an extraterrestrial term happened to resemble a fictional character from comics—how could the two be equated?

A strong supporting argument was that Henry Brown had, so far, only demonstrated a body of steel—once even thought to be a mutant trait. This was far from the omnipotent Superman depicted in comics.

Because if an ordinary person truly had Superman's powers, he would have already done whatever he pleased.

According to intelligence records, Henry Brown did not have a happy childhood on a farm. Instead, he had been imprisoned in a research institute of the Red Empire, living a life devoid of sunlight.

The recovered records from that institute only extended into the 1980s. There was no data on what happened afterward, nor the exact date of the facility's closure.

However, since Henry Brown did not leave any public record until 1990 in Alaska, it was reasonable to infer that he had remained in that Siberian facility until then.

Psychologists unanimously believed that a person with such an upbringing would either already be insane or possess antisocial tendencies. In such a case, if he had superpowers, it would be impossible for him not to cause harm to society.

The only reason he hadn't turned to crime was likely because the "body of steel" had limited applications.

On the other hand, Henry Brown was exceptionally intelligent—arguably a genius. From every observable aspect, he clearly understood what role would benefit him most in society.

And he had used his advantages well—becoming Audrey Hepburn's assistant, and eventually rising to the position of CEO of Stark Pictures.

In short, how foolish would one have to be to compare a long-running comic series with a real young man and think it reasonable? Were Hollywood sci-fi films all turning into prophecies of the future? Did that make any sense?

The opposing faction, however, firmly insisted—

Henry Brown was Superman.

They even pulled in non-canon storylines and multiverse versions of evil Supermen, attempting to map certain comic settings onto Henry Brown.

Unsurprisingly, this view had very few supporters. Especially when they requested funding to purchase the complete Superman comic collection as research material, their proposal was immediately rejected...

Still, while small in number, this faction wasn't entirely suppressed.

Their proposals—to develop "green sun lamps," "red sun lamps," and to search for "Kryptonite"—were approved, albeit with very limited resources.

If an evil Superman from the comics were to suddenly appear in reality, waiting until then to study his weaknesses might be too late.

Moreover, these research projects could also serve to test whether "Henry Brown is Superman."

The difficulty, however, was that Henry's current social status made it impossible to simply detain him for experiments. Any testing would have to be conducted covertly—and cautiously—to avoid alerting him.

The real problem was this...

All field agents attempting to "coincidentally" encounter him couldn't even manage to meet him. And it was equally impossible to deploy enough personnel to surround Stark Pictures' building just to wait for its CEO to leave work.

This led supporters of the Superman theory to argue that this was proof Henry possessed super senses—allowing him to evade S.H.I.E.L.D.'s surveillance net time and time again.

Unfortunately, few agreed. Most believed Henry was simply lucky—and that S.H.I.E.L.D. had no reason to allocate additional manpower toward someone who posed no threat.

If possessing abilities beyond normal humans was enough to be deemed a threat requiring elimination, then what should be done about the millions of mutants living in the United States?

After witnessing the genocide against Jews during World War II, Western societies had become extremely sensitive to such actions. As the so-called beacon of the world, would the United States dare take action against millions of mutants within its borders?

**Chapter 471 471: Phil Coulson**

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The receptionist greeted the approaching man with a sweet smile. "Good afternoon, sir. How may I assist you?"

A pity—his forehead was a bit too shiny and his hair a bit too thin. Otherwise, he'd be exactly her type. Should I give him my number? she wondered, hesitating internally.

"Hello. I'd like to meet Mr. Henry Brown, the CEO of the studio."

"Do you have an appointment?"

"No. Please inform him that my name is Phil Coulson. We have a mutual acquaintance—Nick Fury."

Catching sight of the comic book in his hand, the receptionist maintained her smile and leaned in slightly, lowering her voice. "Are you here to discuss adapting a comic into a movie?"

"I don't want to dampen your spirits, but I should tell you in advance—our company mainly produces low-budget films. The chances of approving a comic adaptation aren't very high."

Phil Coulson went along smoothly. "Oh, thank you for the reminder. But since Mr. Brown and I share a mutual acquaintance, perhaps I can find a way through him."

"Ah, that's one way to do it. Please wait a moment while I contact him." She picked up the phone and dialed an internal line.

After a brief, hushed conversation, she hung up and gave Coulson a bright smile. "Please take the elevator to the seventh floor. Turn left when you exit, and you'll find the CEO's office. Mr. Brown is available right now."

"Thank you, miss." Though it was just a polite response, Coulson couldn't help but flash a charming, easygoing smile as he left.

The receptionist immediately regretted it—why hadn't she given him her number? Wasn't the whole point of applying for a front desk job at a film company to meet charming men like that?

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While the receptionist indulged in her daydreams, Henry, seated in his office, was already considering how to deal with this unexpected visitor after being notified by Yulian.

Phil Coulson might be called old-fashioned, but there was no denying he was the kind of man you could trust with your back—so long as Nick Fury wasn't standing behind him...

Law enforcement was already stretched thin just dealing with mutant criminals. Expanding surveillance to include all non-criminal individuals with special abilities—how much budget would that require?

Even a country capable of printing money couldn't sustain that.

Even if one argued Henry was an alien rather than a mutant—and thus could be captured for dissection—what kind of equipment could even cut open a body that bullets couldn't harm?

Larger explosives might work. But if he were blown to pieces, what would there be left to study?

Thus, the "Henry Brown" project was placed at the lowest priority level. Only a small team was assigned to observe and record him in their spare time between other missions.

The development of red and green sun lamps was handed off to the weapons research division, placed low in the queue. The search for Kryptonite was delegated to field agents as a side task.

But such a passive approach was torture for those driven by intense curiosity. It was like ants crawling under their skin—an unbearable itch.

The simplest solution?

Ask him directly.

With approval from his superiors, Phil Coulson—carrying a copy of Superman comics—walked straight into the doors of Stark Pictures.

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In an era full of antiheroes where morality was often blurred, someone like Coulson—an old-school do-gooder with classic superhero values—was, in Henry's view, the hardest type to deal with.

Someone openly looking for trouble was actually easier. If the timing and conditions were right, Henry wouldn't mind giving them a one-way, equipment-free tour of outer space.

But this man—future Director of S.H.I.E.L.D.... should he alter the course of history?

Just as a certain dark thought began to take shape, Phil Coulson knocked lightly on the already open office door and greeted, "Good afternoon. It's an honor to meet you, Mr. Henry Brown."

"Hello. Please, have a seat, Mr. Coulson." Henry stood to greet him briefly, then gestured toward the chair across the desk without offering a handshake.

After sitting down first, Henry used the office intercom. "Yulian, please bring my guest a cup of coffee."

Once Coulson was seated, Henry spoke first. "Mr. Coulson, you mentioned we have a mutual acquaintance in Nick Fury. Don't tell me—you're from that organization as well?"

"Yes. I'm a Level One agent of the Strategic Homeland Intervention, Enforcement and Logistics Division. Director Fury is my superior."

Pulling out the full name, huh? No wonder people got confused—it was long enough to make verification a hassle.

At that moment, the secretary—who was essentially doing odd jobs—entered with a cup of coffee. "Here you go, sir."

"Thank you."

Watching the young secretary leave, Coulson couldn't help but remark, "Mr. Brown, shouldn't you close the office door?"

"No need. The soundproofing here is terrible anyway. Even if I close it, anything loud inside can still be heard outside. I can't be bothered with useless renovations."

It's not like I'm planning to call anyone in here for anything... inappropriate, Henry thought to himself.

"Fair enough." Placing the Superman comic he had been holding onto the desk, Coulson said, "I'm here because of this."

"Looking to adapt it into a film? That doesn't really seem... within your organization's scope," Henry said curiously, picking up the issue.

It wasn't a first edition, nor a special issue marking a character debut. Nothing particularly valuable—maybe in ten years, with a full set, it might catch a collector's interest.

Coulson smiled. "Our scope is quite broad—it's not strictly limited." Then, lowering his voice, he added, "What we really want to know is... are you him?"



Henry burst into laughter, openly mocking. "Are you serious? A fictional character that existed before I was even born—and you're asking if I'm him? Hahaha, sorry, that's just too funny. Me? Superman? Ha!"

Henry had specifically checked this world's timeline. The X-Men comics only appeared after Charles Xavier—Professor X—had already formed the X-Men.

In fact, if you traced the ownership, the publishing company behind the X-Men comics held shares from Professor X himself, along with licensing rights for mutant likenesses.

At the time, Magneto hadn't yet split from Xavier, so the likeness rights for members of the Brotherhood of Mutants were also included.

This was a crucial source of funding for Xavier's school. Even after Magneto went his own way, he still allowed the licensing fees to go to Xavier's institution rather than claiming them for himself as a wanted criminal.

Of course, Xavier had agreed not to interfere with creative freedom—one of the conditions required by the government to permit publication, ensuring the comics wouldn't become mutant propaganda.

Because of that freedom, the comics often featured bizarre mutant settings and unexpected romantic pairings.

Most mutants, however, scoffed at these portrayals and even refused to acknowledge certain characters as being based on them.

Chapter 472 472: If You’re Making a Wish, Go Find a Genie

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Phil Coulson refused to give up on defining Henry Brown. "You should know—nothing in this world is coincidence. You're a Kryptonian, and we need a Superman. A kind Clark Kent."

Henry smiled. "I'd love that too. If I were really that powerful, the whole world would be kneeling at my feet."

"No. Superman wouldn't do that."

"Of course Clark Kent wouldn't. But why are you so sure Henry Brown wouldn't? Let me ask you—if I were Superman, what would you use to stop me? Found any Kryptonite yet?"

"...No. That doesn't exist in reality," Coulson admitted, disappointed.

"So there's no Kryptonite in reality, but I have to be the comic version of Clark Kent, not the real Henry Brown? You guys even handle renaming people now? I'm not in witness protection."

"That's not what I meant. It's just... we hope—no, I hope—you can become Superman and help us."

"...You do realize my abilities are nowhere near Superman's, right? Do you know how many people want to test just how far my bulletproof body can go? Rifle rounds, armor-piercing rounds, depleted uranium rounds... maybe even an ICBM someday."

"Maybe you just haven't fully developed your Kryptonian abilities. Like Superman as a child. We can help you—S.H.I.E.L.D. can unlock your potential and make you a better person."

"And then?"

"Then you can fight crime, uphold justice, and bring peace to the world."

"Oh, that sounds great. So let me ask—how much does that pay? Or what's the salary? People need to eat, have a place to sleep, maybe enjoy some entertainment now and then. All of that costs money."

"A Level One agent like me, depending on role and location, earns about forty to sixty thousand dollars a year. If you reach supervisory level, it can exceed a hundred thousand."

"Wow, that does sound like a lot. Do you know how much I make sitting here, slacking off and living off Stark's fortune?"

"...Two hundred—no, five hundred thousand?"

Henry gave a polite, not-too-awkward smile and held up all ten fingers. "Actually, it's ten... million."

"What?! A ten-million-dollar annual salary? You're serious?!" Coulson's face filled with disbelief.

"Filthy rich guy like him—if I don't fleece him, I'd be doing myself a disservice, right? So tell me, is saving the world more important than that?"

Coulson was speechless. Ten million a year versus secretly saving the world—he simply couldn't bring himself to say the money didn't matter.

After a long pause, he forced out, "But human lives are priceless. Saving lives—doesn't that mean anything to you?"

Henry chuckled. "Law enforcement has the police. Fires and disasters—firefighters. Wars—soldiers. Conspiracies—intelligence agencies. Does Earth collapse tomorrow just because there's no Superman?"

In other words, in this world, comics were comics, and real mutants were real mutants.

Which made it all the more absurd for someone to take a character that existed before his birth, point at him, and claim he was Clark Kent.

"And yet, aren't you?" Coulson pressed. "You're both Kryptonians."

Henry sneered. "That's something I only learned from the Skrulls. And now you're telling me that nearly sixty years ago, someone already wrote out my life's trajectory—and I'm supposed to follow it? Is that what you mean?"

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"And besides, he's a fictional character. If wishing worked like that, shouldn't I go find Arnold Schwarzenegger and mass-produce a T-800 army? We could unify Earth under Skynet by tomorrow.

"Come on. You people got played by the Skrulls, and now you show up with a comic book claiming I'm Superman? I'm starting to wonder if your agency uses the same IQ standards as the military.

"And let's not pretend I don't know what your organization really does. If I became the kind of 'Superman' you want, what happens to my girlfriend? Not every woman is as bold as Lois Lane."

After his long speech, Henry took a sip of water, then looked at Coulson's stunned expression—and suddenly felt a playful urge.

He turned serious and said, "Alright, since you're so insistent, I'll admit it. I'm actually Jesus—sent back by God to save the world.

"If you don't believe me, I'll go put on a crown of thorns, carry a cross through the streets, and see if people fall to their knees begging for forgiveness."

Coulson instinctively replied, "That's impossible. There are plenty of frauds pretending to be the Lord, and even they use more convincing tricks and rhetoric."

"Exactly. I can't be Jesus—but I can be Superman?" Henry shrugged, spread his hands, and pursed his lips in a three-part gesture.

That completely shut Coulson down. Scrambling for another angle, he blurted, "Don't you love this country?"

Henry widened his eyes and pointed at himself. "Me? An alien? Love the United States? Are you serious? I pay taxes, follow the law, and don't commit crimes. Isn't that enough?"

"You can't ignore your identity—"

Cutting him off, Henry said, "This is an immigrant nation. I don't recall the Constitution excluding aliens.

"I know your organization could easily find flaws in how I obtained my identity. But let me remind you—the Earth isn't just the United States."

In truth, if it ever came down to it, leaving the U.S. wouldn't be that difficult a decision for Henry.

Back when he stayed, it was only because, during his most lost days in Alaska, he had somehow obtained legal status and simply gone with the flow.

Now, with his current capabilities, there was nothing to fear from deportation.

Coulson flushed red, still trying to speak, but Henry sighed inwardly. The future director is still too green...

"Mr. Coulson," Henry said, cutting him off again.

Coulson fell silent, waiting.

Henry's tone turned calm and cold. "I think this conversation ends here. Continuing won't lead to anything pleasant. I'm very satisfied with my current work and life. I trust you understand."

Coulson stood, fastening his suit jacket, making one last attempt. "Mr. Brown, if I've offended you in any way, I apologize. But I still hope—"

"If you want to make a wish, go find Aladdin's lamp—not Superman," Henry interrupted once more.

The honest agent, too drained to argue, turned quietly to leave.

"Mr. Coulson," Henry called out again before he exited.

A flicker of hope lit up Coulson's eyes as he turned back—only to see Henry holding up the Superman comic and giving it a small shake.

"I believe this is yours. Don't forget to take it with you."



"...Alright." The disappointment in his voice was impossible to hide.

Coulson didn't even remember how he left Stark Pictures. By the time he stepped outside, Nick Fury had just pulled up to the entrance.

"Coulson, get in," Nick Fury called from the car window.

"Sir." Coulson didn't resist. He greeted him and took the passenger seat.

As the car pulled away, a heavy silence filled the interior. Uncomfortable with it, Nick Fury spoke first.

"I take it the conversation didn't go the way you wanted. I can't say I'm surprised."

Chapter 473 473: S.H.I.E.L.D.’s Assessment

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Phil Coulson, still smarting from the earlier ridicule, gave a wry smile. "Sir, you knew this would happen, yet you didn't stop me."

Nick Fury replied, "Having someone give it a try doesn't cost us anything. And you just got shown the door—not shot and carried out by medics. That's already a good outcome.

"Besides, I told you all from the beginning—before trying to pin the label 'Superman' on that man, you should've investigated the creators of the Superman comics. Find out what they actually knew."

Still smiling bitterly, Coulson said, "The original creators of Superman, Jerry Siegel and Joe Shuster, passed away in '96 and '92.

"And the series has continued ever since, with new stories, new enemies, and new settings. Many different creators have been involved. Investigating the original authors doesn't really mean much."

With a look of gotcha, Fury said, "Exactly. That means Superman isn't based on a single clear real-world reference that was artistically adapted. So what's the point of taking a comic book and questioning a living person with it?

"You're no different from those fortune-tellers who scam people—spouting vague nonsense with no time or place attached, then claiming accuracy after something happens."

Coulson fell silent. After a moment, he asked, "Sir, may I ask your personal opinion of Henry Brown? Not the agency's—your own."

Fury might have brushed off someone else, but Coulson was a promising recruit he intended to cultivate. So he answered:

"His file isn't highly classified. With proper clearance, even you can access it. So what I tell you doesn't violate policy.

"As for the extra details not yet in the records—hear them and forget them. There's no official source, and I won't admit I said any of it.

"Before 1990, his missing years were spent in an extraterrestrial research facility in Siberia. But as you know, after the collapse of the Red Empire, many things changed.

"So in 1990, Henry Brown appeared in Alaska. By 1991, he became Audrey Hepburn's assistant and bodyguard under the classification of a mutant.

"That same year, the desert emergency landing incident involving a small passenger plane—that was the first anomalous crisis he was involved in."

Coulson said, "If he really had Superman's abilities, he should've been the one who resolved that incident."

"Correct. Unfortunately, although Professor X cooperated with the government afterward and helped assess the participants' behavior and positions, he only stated that no one had betrayed anyone—and refused to provide further details."

"Even S.H.I.E.L.D. couldn't get the X-Men to cooperate more?" Coulson asked.

"Mutant affairs are complicated. Our policy is to avoid deep entanglement. We only request X-Men assistance when facing anomalies we can't handle—and even then, it's a last resort. They're also a group we have to guard against."

"Understood."

Fury continued, "Back to Henry Brown. In '93, after Audrey Hepburn passed away, he returned to Los Angeles and got caught up in the massacre of State Senator Mike Liddell Horton's family.

"According to internal intelligence, he wasn't the killer and had no direct involvement in the deaths. He was simply dragged into it. But the incident revealed something important."

"What was that?"

"If he doesn't want to cooperate, forcing him is pointless. Senator Horton wanted Henry Brown to use his abilities to protect him—but the senator still died. So did his family, secretary, and bodyguards. Not one survived."

Coulson thought for a moment. "Failure to render aid? I don't think California has such a law."

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Fury explained, "If someone has a duty of care—like hired security—they could be charged with negligent homicide. In cases involving minors, abandonment charges might apply.

"But Henry Brown wasn't employed in such a capacity. And legally, the senator is still listed as missing—no body, no confirmed death. The perpetrators were from the Continental Hotel, not Henry Brown."

Coulson started, "The Continental—"

"That's not today's topic," Fury cut him off. "Also from internal intel—afterward, Henry Brown operated under the alias 'Fixer,' acting as an underground doctor in South Los Angeles.

"When crime boss Andrew Saxon was taken down, the Fixer played a significant role. But he also walked away with around six hundred thousand dollars in dirty money, which put him on the radar of both the police and the FBI.

"Same problem, though—no direct evidence linking him to the Fixer identity. The FBI even searched his home during the chaos caused by the Skrulls. They didn't find the money."

Coulson tried again, "The Continental—"

"Drop it. That's an order of its own on the other side of the world. The U.S. can declare war on the world, but it can't survive another civil war."

"...Understood. Does he still operate as the 'Fixer'?"

"Now? Of course not. As CEO of Stark Pictures, his position carries weight. His umbrella has shifted from the Continental to Stark Industries—a far more powerful backer. At least, that's what most people think."

"Most people?" Coulson asked.

Fury smirked. "At first, everyone assumed that film-grade digital imaging technology was Tony Stark's work. But does anyone still believe that now?

"Even with Stark Industries behind him, how solid is that backing? Anyone capable would want to test it. Maybe their partnership is just surface-level. So when Sony had an urgent need, they made a move."

Coulson followed, "Which led to the Los Angeles Sony building explosion."

"Exactly," Fury said dismissively. "They signed off on a lost property inventory—then boom, the building exploded right after.

"Who's the prime suspect if not him? But again—no direct evidence. The FBI, for its own sake, didn't push too hard.

"And the incident sent a clear warning: his property isn't easy to take. At least until someone figures out how he detonated those explosives, no one will dare covet his things.

"Honestly, if it weren't for the Skrulls exposing a few cracks, has this man ever truly suffered a loss?

"He doesn't need Superman-level abilities to live well. Maybe he has used such abilities—but there's not even indirect evidence, let alone direct proof.

"If you want to suspect him, you can't base it on a comic that existed before he even arrived on Earth."

Coulson frowned. "So there's really no evidence at all?"

Fury paused. "If we're talking about Superman-like individuals, it's not that there's nothing."

Coulson's eyes lit up. "There is?"

"In '92, during the X-Men's defense against extraterrestrial forces, there was a 'Clown' figure reported by U.S. soldiers. His abilities closely resembled Superman's.

"But he only appeared once. We reconstructed his face—possibly actor River Phoenix. But he's already dead.

"Then there was the end of the Skrull–Kree conflict. When Maria Rambeau, myself, and Skrull refugees were returning from space, we were pursued by Kree fighters.

"At that time, a mysterious figure dressed in black—able to fly freely in near vacuum—shot down multiple enemy craft. That's the second Superman-like individual. Unfortunately, I couldn't catch up, and there were no ground sightings."

Coulson asked, "Was it him?"

Fury shrugged. "Same answer—no direct evidence. At that time, Henry Brown should have been in Louisiana, while we were in California.

"Unless we can confirm he can fly and has super speed, there's no way to connect him to that black-clad figure across such a distance.

"And this kind of logic doesn't work in reverse. We can't use it as proof that he is Superman—it's not reasonable.

"Besides, he's not the kind of super-criminal we're tasked to handle. The most we can do is classify him as a potential threat and conduct non-contact investigation with minimal surveillance."

Coulson added, "But I've heard many within the agency support taking action—even without sufficient evidence. That's why I wanted to confirm whether he's Superman... not Ultraman."

Fury let out a short laugh. "With only circumstantial evidence, we can suspect and investigate. But without direct proof, no decision that violates civil rights will ever be approved.

"If we approve action against Henry Brown today, tomorrow we can use the same logic to accuse the White House, the Pentagon, or Congress of treason—and purge them.

"J. Edgar Hoover already burned that path for everyone who came after. No agency will ever be granted that kind of power again. After twelve years of McCarthyism, no one wants a repeat.

Chapter 474 474: A Mad Fashion Show

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In the final week of September, at Paris Fashion Week for women's ready-to-wear, Cruella de Vil once again became the center of attention—because she put something on the runway that no one had ever used before.

A living, breathing tiger.

With a spiked leather collar—tasteless to the extreme—but when the "tiger beauty," Charlize Theron, appeared holding the beast on a chain, the entire venue collectively gasped.

A tiger-striped crop top paired with a matching narrow skirt and long boots—combined with Henry's suggestions for facial contouring, weight loss, and makeup—gave Charlize a hint of the regal aura she would one day fully embody.

Walking the runway with the tiger in tow, she looked like a youthful yet domineering queen of fashion, surveying her domain and her subjects.

When she stepped onto the runway for the second time, her outfit featured an exaggerated aristocratic high collar reminiscent of a bygone era. One half of her gown trailed along the floor in black with structured shoulder pads, while the other half was a golden, feather-like coat.

Even more insane—

This time, the tiger walked ahead without a leash.

What did it feel like to watch a fashion show where audience members suddenly bolted for the exits halfway through?

Whether those who remained were brave or simply too frightened to move, they all witnessed a show destined to go down in history.

As the tiger reached the end of the runway and prepared to turn, it let out a roar. Charlize gave a sharp whistle, and only then did the beast obediently withdraw.

It was at that moment many photographers realized—they had been so terrified they forgot to take pictures. Those who had managed to press the shutter became the most sought-after, their photos splashed across the front pages of major newspapers the next day.

Many headlines read: a fashion show so insane that the designer disregarded the audience's lives—and the audience, equally insane, stayed to watch despite the danger.

Henry had originally thought he would need to pull some strings to manage Katy's workload—otherwise, he might have to fly around the world with this tiger that barely made any money, just to satisfy a flood of invitations from equally mad designers.

Fortunately, after Cruella's show, most designers jointly issued a statement of restraint, emphasizing that they would not allow wild animals on the runway—let alone unleashed ones.

Because even these fashion-obsessed individuals learned from animal trainers and experts that Katy's performance was impossible to replicate.

Timing her walk like a professional model, following a single path without deviation—this was simply not normal animal behavior.

Especially during the second appearance, where she responded perfectly to a single whistle. Even a trainer who had raised the animal from birth might not achieve that level of control.

There was a reason circus performances with wild beasts were conducted inside cages—one mistake, and the fashion show would have turned into a living hell.

For those directly involved, however, the industry's self-restraint wasn't much of an issue.

Henry had no desire to keep flying around with Katy—that went without saying.

"And if someone does try to give such an order, they'd better be ready for the consequences. This is a man confirmed to have a body of steel—not a mutant, but an alien.

"That means our usual solutions—like mutant suppression collars—won't work. He's not easy to deal with.

"And don't forget—he's the CEO of Stark Pictures. Not some nobody who can disappear without anyone noticing."

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Charlize Theron preferred performing in front of a camera rather than walking runways.

Even Cruella herself understood that featuring a tiger was a bold innovation—but repeating it would quickly turn it into a cliché.

Charlize's collaboration with Katy was simply the final chapter of a long-term plan that began with the tiger commercial. Now that it had been perfectly executed, it was time to let it end on a high note.

The fashion world wasn't like Hollywood, where successful films spawned endless sequels until audiences grew tired and box office returns collapsed.

In fashion, if you played that game, accusations of creative exhaustion and outdated aesthetics would cling to you—and for a designer, that was far worse than any scandal.

After the show, Charlize immediately returned to Los Angeles with Henry. Finding a place in Paris to house a tiger, even temporarily, was both expensive and troublesome.

Most hotels didn't even allow pets, let alone a large predator. Traveling with Katy was far more complicated than traveling with a baby.

Meanwhile, October 4 marked the release of Charlize Theron's second major film—a musical comedy directed by and starring two-time Oscar winner Tom Hanks, That Thing You Do!.

Although the film didn't have a grand premiere, significant resources had been invested in promotion. Charlize needed to return to Hollywood to participate in publicity and media interviews.

Even though she only played a supporting role, her recent surge in popularity made 20th Century Fox eager to leverage her buzz.

After all, she had taken the role specifically to work with Tom Hanks. There was no reason not to show enthusiasm and professionalism—so returning to Los Angeles was a must.

But trouble always appears at the worst possible moment.

While waiting in line ahead of Henry at immigration, Charlize was suddenly stopped by an officer.

"What? My artist visa has been canceled?!" she exclaimed in shock.

Charlize hadn't yet obtained a U.S. green card. Her work in Hollywood was under a P-3 artist visa, renewed annually. Her latest visa had been sponsored by Stark Pictures.

Once canceled, it meant she no longer had the right to enter the United States.

Due to regulations, Henry couldn't step forward and interfere with immigration procedures. Airport police were already approaching.

There was a shameful gray area in U.S. law—those not yet admitted into the country were not protected by its legal system. They couldn't even hire a lawyer.

Anyone denied entry could only take another flight out. If they caused trouble, airport police had the authority to detain them and deport them within six months.

Perhaps aware of her vulnerable position as a foreigner—or perhaps influenced by Henry's usual calm demeanor—Charlize didn't break down or scream. Instead, she cooperated fully.

That alone reduced the likelihood of the police resorting to force.

Henry immediately followed.

But the route used to escort detainees wasn't accessible to just anyone. He was quickly stopped by another officer.

Producing his U.S. passport, Henry said, "She's my girlfriend. Let us speak for a moment—it won't interfere with your work."

The lead officer nodded and stepped aside slightly. Only then did Henry see Charlize—holding back tears, trying not to cry.

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Chapter 475 475: Trouble Strikes Again

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After rummaging through his belongings, Henry pulled out all the cash he had on him and handed it to Charlize Theron. "Go to the UK and find Cruella. If that doesn't work, contact me first, then head to France and find Givenchy.

"Settle down with them for now. I'll resolve the visa issue as quickly as possible. For work matters, contact J.J. Harris—she'll handle it for you. Take care of yourself. Don't let anything happen."

There was still a tiger waiting to pass quarantine, and the root of this issue was clearly within the United States, not abroad. So Henry didn't choose to leave with Charlize.

Some things didn't need to be said aloud. Among the options Henry gave, there was no suggestion for Charlize to return to South Africa to find her mother—precisely to avoid bringing trouble to her family.

Whether it was Cruella de Vil or Hubert de Givenchy, their reputations acted like a protective barrier, enough to make ill-intentioned people think twice before crossing the line.

Though this might be seen as shifting trouble onto others, neither Henry nor Charlize had a better solution—unless they escalated things into full-scale war.

For now, they could only hope the other side intended to obstruct them through administrative means, not escalate further.

Judging by the airport police's behavior, they were simply following procedures and had no "extra assignments." Otherwise, they would have forcefully prevented Henry from speaking with Charlize before she was taken away.

It seemed that Henry's decision to support Blade and other vampire hunters from the shadows—rather than personally escalating the conflict—had been a wise one. His small moves hadn't been detected, which prevented the enemy from going straight for lethal measures.

Their conversation was brief, focused only on key points. Finally, Henry said, "Call me when you arrive. Let me know where you are."

"Okay."

Watching the girl being escorted away, Henry turned back and rejoined the line, waiting to enter the country—without any special privileges, nor forcing his way through with his abilities.

At the same time, he thought this didn't feel like the vampires' style. Could it be those humans who attached themselves to vampires, believing they were superior to the kine?

This kind of tug-of-war was the most troublesome. It wasn't something he could solve by simply going out and killing more vampires.

For now, Henry could only settle Katy first, then find channels to gather information.

But when it came time for Katy to pass quarantine, Henry couldn't help but laugh in anger.

Missing paperwork, deliberate obstruction—it all pointed toward an attempt to have Katy deported on the spot.

If Katy had been a pet imported from abroad, such nonsense might have been somewhat understandable. But this tiger had originally departed from the U.S., gone to France for work, and was now returning home.

Even if a tiger didn't have nationality, if it truly didn't meet entry requirements, it wouldn't have been allowed to leave in the first place.

After a long round of back-and-forth with U.S. Customs and Border Protection (CBP), the situation dragged on—until Katy herself found a solution.

And her method was surprisingly simple:

Cause chaos.

She shook the cage violently, biting at the iron bars. When that wasn't enough, she rammed it, widening the gaps just enough to extend her paw outward, as if ready to strike.

CBP officers were used to dealing with animals like large dogs at most—and their equipment reflected that.

Faced with a tiger, they had no choice but to call in zoo professionals. But those experts would take time to arrive—and the increasingly deformed cage offered little reassurance.

Chapter 476 476: An Eager Invitation

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Several tranquilizer darts meant for large dogs were fired, but Katy dodged them with ease. The few that hit didn't even seem to penetrate her hide—they just hung loosely from her fur.

And it wasn't just one tiger causing trouble—

Her agitation set off the entire quarantine warehouse.

The presence of a top predator was enough. With just a display of aggression, Katy sent smaller animals into a frenzy—barking, screeching, and slamming against their cages.

Birds, too, began crashing wildly inside their enclosures, trying to escape. A few even knocked their cages over and flew loose inside the warehouse.

In short, the place descended into total chaos.

A staff member, unable to endure it any longer, ran out and whispered the situation to the supervisor at the counter.

The supervisor, who had been playing bureaucratic ping-pong with Henry, put on a stern expression. "Mr. Brown, your wild animal appears insufficiently trained and is causing a disturbance. I can allow you into the warehouse—please assist in calming it down."

Henry didn't take the bait. He replied coldly, "All my documentation complies with California law. If you'd just release my animal star, none of this would be happening. On what grounds should I calm it?"

"Do you know the worst-case scenario?" the supervisor said. "If we determine the animal poses a threat to human safety, I have the authority to order it put down."

Henry's tone sharpened. "Go ahead and try. I've already declared that this animal star was working in Paris and earning income. It's simply returning after completing its job.

"If your errors lead to it being killed, you'll be liable for my financial losses. Feel free to gamble on whether Stark Pictures' legal team can win that lawsuit."

There was a reason Henry kept emphasizing "animal star" instead of "pet."

One had economic value. The other only incurred maintenance costs.

With Katy's earnings records—and the job offers Henry had turned down—any competent lawyer could ruin the careers of whoever signed off on or carried out such an order.

At that moment, a perfectly timed tiger roar echoed from inside the warehouse, shattering whatever composure remained among the officers. More personnel fled the scene.

Whether it was Henry's threat or Katy's roar that did it, the once-arrogant supervisor finally gave in. Irritated, he stamped the clearance documents and handed them over.

"Let him take the tiger. But I warn you—if your animal causes any damage, you'll be held fully responsible!"

"Send it in writing. My lawyers will respond," Henry replied evenly.

Following the quarantine officers inside, Henry was greeted by a cacophony—dogs barking, cats yowling, and various smaller animals making a chaotic din.

Katy's cage was visibly warped. The largest gap between the bars was wide enough for half her head—and a claw—to reach through.

Given a feline's flexibility, once the opening reached the width of her whiskers, she could slip out entirely. And she was very close.

Henry stepped forward, pressing a hand against her head to calm her. "Good girl. Well done. I'll give you something extra when we get home. Or... see anything you like here? I can knock it out and stuff it into your cage."

The supervising officer, who had followed in intending to regain some dignity with a few harsh words, suddenly felt a chill run down his spine—and decided to say nothing at all.

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After another exhausting ordeal, Henry finally managed to bring Katy back home—legally, properly, and safely—to Old Gary’s apartment building. Taking this beast abroad once had been more tiring than anything else he’d done. And on top of that, Charlize Theron’s situation still weighed heavily on his mind.

Just as Henry was considering where to start gathering information, the flamboyant landlord came knocking.

Standing outside the door, Old Gary cautiously peeked inside. Katy had her head lowered, busy devouring raw meat in her food bowl—freshly delivered by the butcher.

Even though no one was home most of the time, Henry had asked Gary to help receive the deliveries and store the meat in the freezer.

By now, Henry had switched to monthly billing with the butcher, no longer paying the delivery boy daily.

As for frozen meat... well, for Katy, it was like eating popsicles. Once in a while, she enjoyed crunching on it with loud, satisfying cracks.

But doing that every day? Not a good idea. She’d start giving attitude—ignoring the frozen meat and staring straight at people instead. A rather intimidating sight.

At the moment, though, Katy was focused on eating. Hearing the door open, she merely lifted her head and glanced at the newcomer.

Gary didn’t forget his manners. "Hello, Katy."

Katy licked the icy residue from her mouth and went straight back to her meal.

Only after confirming he wasn’t being targeted did Gary let out a sigh of relief. He then took out a scented envelope and handed it over. "Henry, someone asked me to give this to you today. I think it’s an important invitation."

The envelope bore only the name "Henry Brown." There was no wax seal like European nobility used. Henry simply peeled it open.

Inside was an invitation card made of high-quality patterned paper. It contained only an address and a signature—James Arden. Nothing else.

The border of the card wasn’t decorated with common symmetrical patterns like laurel leaves. Instead, it featured intricate lily-of-the-valley flowers, stems, and leaves.

And in America, lily of the valley was also known as the Mayflower...

That group?

The address, unsurprisingly, was in Montecito, north of Los Angeles—not part of L.A. County, but a true enclave of the ultra-wealthy.

The last time Henry had gone there, he’d been tricked by two FBI agents into witnessing a Black state senator effectively orchestrate his own demise.

What kind of trouble awaited him this time?

There was no time specified on the invitation. Did that mean he could go whenever he wanted?

"Who delivered this?" Henry asked, flipping the card over so Gary could see it as well.

"I don’t know him," Gary replied, shaking his head. "Well-dressed young man. Said it was for you. I even told him I didn’t know when you’d be back. He insisted you’d return today. And... well, here you are."

Only after answering did Gary put on his reading glasses to examine the card.

"Do you know this James Arden?"

"No idea," Henry said honestly. "First time I’ve heard the name."

Gary nodded. "Whoever uses invitations like this... definitely not ordinary."

Then he suddenly remembered something. "By the way, where’s Charlize? Didn’t you two go on the trip together? She didn’t come back with you?"

"She ran into some trouble. I had her fly to London or Paris for now while I sort things out here."

Gary frowned with concern. "Nothing serious, right? She’s a sweet girl."

"It’s fine. Her visa got canceled, that’s all. She still has work lined up—I’ll reapply for her. Just takes some time."

"Alright then. You just got back—I won’t disturb you." Gary turned to leave.

"Sure. When Charlize gets back in a few days, I’ll cook something nice. Come join us."

Henry was once again using food as bait to win over his flamboyant landlord.

Chapter 477 477: Ill Intentions

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Gary immediately perked up. "I want that—what’s it called—the soy-braised pork tied with string."

"Dongpo pork, right?"

"Yes, yes, that one!"

Henry patted his own stomach mischievously and glanced at Gary’s. "With your figure, aren’t you worried about fat?"

"A life without fat is incomplete. Those people obsessed with turning themselves into Arnold Schwarzenegger will never understand the joy."

"Haha, I’ll prepare it."

"Don’t keep me waiting too long."

"Deal."

Before Gary could leave, hurried footsteps approached. J.J. Harris, ever the dedicated agent, stormed in and demanded, "What happened to Charlize?!"

"She already contacted you, huh." Henry stepped aside to let her in, while smoothly ushering the curious Gary away.

J.J. Harris, clearly furious, had forgotten there was a tiger in the house. She jumped slightly upon entering, then quickly chose a seat far from Katy.

"Explain. What happened? She didn’t make it clear over the phone."

Henry handed her the invitation first. "Her P-3 visa was revoked. We’ll need to reapply. As for who did it... I think you can guess. Most likely this person."

"James Arden? Who’s that?" J.J. Harris read the card.

"No idea. First time I’ve heard of him."

She brought the card closer, sniffing the faint fragrance—but it gave her no additional clues. However, when she noticed the lily-of-the-valley pattern, a troubling thought surfaced.

"...It can’t be them, can it?"

"Who do you think?"

"The people who signed the Mayflower Compact—the true blue-blood aristocrats of America."

"They actually still exist? I thought they’d all died out," Henry said with mock surprise.

J.J. Harris replied, "In reality, they’re like European nobility—maternal and paternal bloodlines all mixed together. Only they themselves keep track of it. Outsiders can’t make sense of it.

"But why would they get involved here? They don’t meddle in Hollywood. This place is too low-level for them. Has Charlize ever met this Arden? Is he after her?"

Henry shook his head. "If he wanted her, he wouldn’t cancel her visa and keep her out of the country. This is probably about me—and she got dragged into it."

J.J. Harris didn’t like that answer, but she couldn’t deny it. No one else would take on the trouble surrounding Charlize except Henry Brown. So she had no choice but to rely on him.

Henry didn’t dodge responsibility. "I’ll go meet this Arden tonight and see what he wants. In the meantime, help Charlize coordinate her work."

"I know." J.J. Harris stood to leave, but paused and turned back. "Can you actually fix this?"

"What do you mean?"

"There’s a difference between quietly resolving things before deadlines—and being upfront with partners that schedules might change. I need to know which approach to take."

"Be upfront. Put the blame on me—come up with whatever excuse you like. Visa issues have to go through official channels. I can’t guarantee she’ll be back in Los Angeles tomorrow."

"...Alright. Got it."

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Henry drove his old Cadillac once again to the mansion district of Montecito in Santa Barbara County, California.

Even though he was driving himself this time, his mood was no different from last time—equally unpleasant.

The mansion listed on the invitation was even more extravagant than that of the overweight Black state senator he had visited before. The garden alone was likely

more than twice the size.

The difference was that last time, the senator knew he had stirred up trouble, so he had stationed numerous heavily armed guards. In the end, it hadn't mattered—they were all wiped out by the Continental.

This time, James Arden's estate didn't have that many visible guards. The pathways were simply well-lit, ensuring no one lost their way.

That didn't mean security was lax. In just a few minutes after passing through the front gate, Henry had already spotted numerous surveillance cameras—covering nearly every angle without blind spots.

The Mellon family's Oak Spring Farm operated similarly—loose on the outside, tight on the inside. Not like the cartel compounds in movies, with armed men patrolling everywhere, but certainly not defenseless either.

As Henry approached the gate, the iron bars opened automatically—no need to get out, press a bell, or verify identity. It was a subtle but effective show of control, far more refined than simply blocking entry.

He drove all the way up to the mansion and parked near the side. As soon as he stepped out and removed the key, a butler in a tailcoat emerged from the entrance—as if his arrival had been precisely timed.

"Mr. Henry Brown. My master has been expecting you. Please follow me."

"Of course." Since the invitation was polite, Henry responded in kind.

At the same time, however, he activated his full suite of super senses, scanning the mansion.

Thirty-seven men. Nineteen women. And... two vampires.

The distinction came not just from body shape, but primarily from body temperature. Women generally radiated slightly less heat due to higher fat content. As for vampires—their temperature was close to that of a corpse.

So, they're not here with good intentions.

As for what he glimpsed in part of the basement—something straight out of hell—Henry chose not to dwell on it. Even a glance was enough to make him uncomfortable.

Prepared, Henry followed into what appeared to be a dining hall. The massive table at the center could easily seat twenty or thirty people.

At the head sat a young-looking man and woman, both with refined features and impeccable posture—too young-looking, in fact. Along the walls stood over a dozen large men in black suits.

They seemed to be trying to recreate a Godfather-like atmosphere—but it came off slightly awkward.

Still, the pair at the head lacked the restlessness of youth. Instead, they exuded a calm far beyond their apparent age... along with a hint of excitement.

If they weren't vampires, Henry might have praised the old-money families for raising such successors. Unfortunately—human nature.

He wasn't seated at the far end of the table. With several large floral arrangements in the way, he wouldn't even be able to see the hosts from there.

Instead, the butler guided him to a seat near the head—clearly a place of honor.

"Mr. Brown," the butler announced, "this is my master, Mr. James Arden, and his wife, Mrs. Lilith Arden."

Turning back, he added, "My lord, Mr. Henry Brown has arrived." Then he stepped aside.

"Mr. Brown, it's a pleasure to finally meet you in person," James Arden said, extending his hand warmly.

"The pleasure is mine, Mr. Arden." Henry accepted the handshake.

Chapter 478 478: A Soft Yet Forceful Threat

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Watching the couple playfully exaggerate surrender at the sight of the cross in Henry's hand—only to follow it with mocking laughter—Henry lowered it like a defeated rooster, letting it hang from his chest.

In truth, Henry was acting as well. What occupied his mind was something else entirely:

Do vampires in the Marvel universe experience rejuvenation?

Setting aside animated versions, most portrayals of vampires in film and television followed a common rule—their appearance froze at the moment of transformation. Turned as a child, they remained a child forever. Turned old, they stayed an immortal elder.

Perhaps only the Twilight series portrayed vampires differently—aside from children, all appeared somewhere between young adulthood and middle age, never truly elderly.

The moment their hands met, a crushing force gripped Henry's right hand. If not for his steel-like body, his bones would have been shattered.

Henry didn't retaliate. Arden quickly released him, smiling with no trace of apology—only a hint of mischief.

"My apologies. I simply couldn't resist testing just how durable you are. Truly beyond my expectations."

Henry frowned slightly, as if in discomfort, examining his hand. That only made Arden more pleased.

"So," Henry said, shaking his hand lightly, "can we consider that even?"

"Please, sit, Mr. Brown. We have much to discuss. It won't be settled so easily."

The vampire couple sat first, their tone dripping with authority.

Henry took his seat a moment later. Since they clearly had hostile intentions, he needed to understand their leverage and methods.

Arden wasted no time. "Mr. Brown, I believe Mr. Giancarlo Dragone—"

"Giovanni Giordano Dragone," Henry corrected internally, recognizing the name as Giancarlo Delagonetti (吉塔诺·德拉戈内蒂).

"—has already offered you very favorable terms. Yet to this day, you've given no satisfactory response. This has displeased many."

"His proposal?" Henry shrugged. "I'm afraid I've forgotten the details. But if I forgot, that just proves it wasn't worth remembering."

"That is a very rude statement, Mr. Brown. Some people's words must be remembered—even if they offend you."

"People like Mr. Delagonetti?"

"Exactly." Arden's face showed unmistakable reverence.

Henry tilted his head. "Let me ask you something—what gives you the right to lecture me? Young man, have you even graduated high school?"

"I don't care if these people—" he gestured at the men in black suits around the room, "—listen to you, or if you've hired yourself a proper British butler. All that tells me is your family has more money than mine."

"Don't take that condescending tone with someone older than you. Graduate first."

The deliberate provocation worked perfectly.

The young-looking couple burst into laughter. The woman even wiped tears from her eyes. "Do we really look that young to you?"

James Arden said, "Young man, we are the ones qualified to call you young. I am ninety-three. My wife is ninety-one. Why do you think we look like this? It's a gift from Elder Delagonetti."

"You..." Henry feigned alarm, pulling out a silver cross pendant from under his collar and holding it up with both hands.

That only amused them further.

Arden waved dismissively. "Have you been watching too many horror movies? Crosses don't work on us."

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But in the Blade trilogy and Underworld, there were clearly vampires who showed signs of aging.

Ignoring casting choices, the existence of elderly vampires—and the concept of "pureblood" vampires in Marvel—suggested that vampires in this world didn't have fixed appearances. They aged... or at least changed.

So how did they achieve rejuvenation? Why didn't vampire elders maintain youthful forms instead of appearing old?

The ecosystem of vampires in this universe was becoming increasingly intriguing.

Maybe I should capture one and study it...

Dangerous Kryptonian thoughts were quietly taking root—while the vampire couple in front of him remained completely unaware.

James Arden spoke confidently, "Mr. Brown, I didn't invite you here today to scold anyone, nor to revisit old matters.

"I simply want to remind you—this world is far more complicated than you think. Do you believe Stark can protect you? Whether it's the elder Stark or the younger one, they can barely protect themselves.

"Or perhaps you think your enviable talents—your bulletproof body of steel—are truly flawless? Can it protect everyone you care about, even when you're not by their

side?

"There are countless ways to make people yield. I don't need to threaten your life—or anyone close to you. I only need to nudge them off their normal path, create a little inconvenience.

"Just like what happened to you today. Did Stark help you? Or were you planning to use that bulletproof body of yours to force your way through customs with your little girlfriend?

"Do you understand now? Power—that is true strength. And in front of real power, everything you have is insignificant. I only hope our relationship can be... simpler. More harmonious."

Faced with a threat this blunt, Henry fell silent.

On the surface, he appeared intimidated. But his mind was racing, calculating the best way out.

Charlize's visa cancellation. Katy nearly being detained in quarantine. It was now clear—this couple was behind it.

In a contest of power like this, even a Kryptonian was like fish on a chopping block. The only one who might stand against them was Tony Stark—despite their open disdain for the name.

But why would that arrogant genius help him? Did Henry offer enough value?

Perhaps Henry's performance was too convincing—the couple looked thoroughly satisfied. Or perhaps the long speech had made the vampire thirsty.

With a snap of James Arden's fingers, drinks were brought in.

Three wine glasses.

And a decanter filled with a thick, dark crimson liquid.

Unless his Kryptonian nose had failed him, Henry could swear—it wasn't wine.

It was blood.

The sommelier's hands trembled ever so slightly, his eyes darting nervously. He didn't want to look at what he was pouring—but he had to.

Yet outwardly, he remained professional. Flawless.

The blood wasn't poured into Henry's glass.

The couple drank instead—elegant, refined, as if savoring a vintage wine.

The only break in etiquette was that blood, unlike wine, tended to cling to the lips. Instead of wiping it away, they licked it clean.

Lilith Arden's hazy gaze resembled someone intoxicated—almost high. Henry couldn't help wondering if their "source" had been a drug user.

It was in this state of indulgence that she spoke:

Chapter 479 479: Superior to Humans?

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Lilith Arden smiled. "The right to refuse is a precious privilege—not something everyone possesses. Why do you think you deserve it?"

"Well... perhaps because this is a society governed by law?" Henry replied cautiously.

James Arden said, "The rule of law exists to protect humans. And in our eyes, humans are no more than livestock—nothing but food."

Henry noticed the expressions of those present. What he saw wasn't fear at being likened to cattle—but fervor.

So that was it. They were counting on rising with the tide—one man ascends, and even his chickens and dogs follow.

"—As far as I know, Elder Delagonetti intends to accept you into our ranks. So why would you choose to associate with ordinary humans and lower yourself?"

"Well... maybe because your so-called 'we' isn't quite as..." Henry twirled his hand in the air, searching for the word. After a long pause, he finally said, "...impressive?"

"We are the future of human evolution! A superior species! Tell me—what do you consider impressive?"

James Arden bared his fangs, opening his mouth so wide it looked like he could swallow a man whole. His once refined youthful face twisted into something monstrous.

Lilith followed suit, her expression equally grotesque. At the same time, both casually crushed their wine glasses into fine powder—not merely breaking them, but pulverizing them completely.

The horror of their faces was beyond anything a film director could conceive. If an ordinary person had been sitting here, they would have fainted—or worse.

Henry had already noticed that the mansion's interior had far fewer surveillance cameras. The dining room had none at all.

Convenient—for doing unspeakable things without leaving evidence.

"Child, you are still young. You don't understand—but I won't blame you. When you reach a certain age, you'll realize that the body is the greatest wealth.

"What use are power and money if you're confined to a wheelchair, dependent on others? Watching the young—so full of vitality, with skin as smooth and radiant as an infant's... it's tragic.

"But look at us now. Eternal life. Isn't this the most beautiful arrangement?

"I won't hide it from you—everything has a cost.

"Just like wealth is finite. The more you take, the less others have. Youth is the same. Parents sacrifice their present for their children's future.

"And when you want it back... you can only take it from the young.

"Do you know, child? I was once deeply envious of the girl beside you.

"She was radiant. Glowing. Wrapped in love, she seemed to emit happiness itself. If I could become like her... would you fall in love with me? Would more people love me?

"Heh... have you heard of Countess Elizabeth Báthory? I've always wanted to try bathing in the blood of beautiful women—see if it grants more youth and vitality. Like your girl."

The infamous "Blood Countess"—recognized as one of history's most prolific female serial killers—was not a name to be mentioned lightly.

And yet here she was, speaking of it as casually as idle gossip.

The couple hadn't raised their voices or issued explicit death threats—but every word carried unmistakable menace. Personal. Direct.

Today, it was just administrative interference.

But Henry had no doubt—they could escalate at any time. And they were confident no one could stop them.

Henry forced a strained smile. "Mr. Arden... Mrs. Arden... is this really necessary? Not even giving me the option to refuse?"

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Unhurried, Henry picked up the cross pendant from his chest. In one swift motion, he yanked it off his neck and flicked it forward.

The silver cross shot through the air and embedded itself cleanly into James Arden's chest—straight into his heart.

Silver piercing the heart—there was nothing grand about his death. Like any vampire, his entire body ignited in intense heat, burning instantly to ash—bones and all, leaving nothing behind.

Lilith remained frozen mid-snarl, but the ferocity in her eyes turned into stunned disbelief.

What just happened?

Where did that man go?

People often say thoughts flash like lightning in moments of shock—but those countless thoughts rarely help. Most freeze in place, their minds spiraling uselessly.

Lilith, a pampered aristocrat for most of her life, was no trained warrior. Becoming a vampire hadn't changed that.

As for their security team—James and Lilith's overconfidence in their own vampire strength had kept them positioned at a distance, reduced to mere decoration.

At that range, Henry didn't even need super speed.

With a flick of his wrist, he retrieved the cross midair, catching it between his fingers.

At the same time, his thumb scraped off a thin layer at its base as he muttered, "Honestly... who told you crosses can't kill vampires?"

Did they really think he brought it for divine protection?

Using his other hand to push off the table, Henry vaulted over it in a fluid motion, landing in front of Lilith.

With a casual backhand, he drove the cross into her temple.

Hidden inside was a small amount of silver nitrate solution, which instantly spread through her brain and into the rest of her body.

She followed her husband's fate—burning to ash before even managing a scream.

Only then did the bodyguards react.

They drew their weapons and opened fire.

Without using super speed, Henry didn't evade. Their response was fast and professional—but too slow to save their employers.

The assassin's movements had been seamless. By the time they reacted, both targets were already gone.

All they could do—true to American tradition—was empty their magazines.

Henry simply hunched forward, covering his head, letting the bullets strike him.

Their aim was good. They didn't hit each other.

But ricochets from Henry's body weren't something they could control.

Several were struck by stray rounds, dropping to the ground.

When the gunfire ceased and the magazines were empty, they stared at Henry—his clothes shredded, yet completely unharmed.

Only then did they fully remember what kind of man they were dealing with.

Letting him walk away? Impossible.

Several burly men rushed forward, pinning his arms behind his back and slamming him onto the table.

With the killer subdued, the remaining guards exchanged uncertain glances.

They had contingency plans—but none clearly applied when both primary clients were dead.

This Montecito mansion wasn't the Arden family's main residence. No other family members were present.

There was no one to give orders.

So, without any prompting from Henry, they made the most natural—yet worst possible—decision for the Arden family:

They called the police.

Because to them, if their clients were the perpetrators, there were ways to clean things up. But now that their clients were victims, their priority was self-preservation.

Handing the killer over to law enforcement was the safest option.

Chapter 480 480: The Interrogation Room

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Because the mansion where the incident occurred was located in Montecito, Santa Barbara County—not Los Angeles—the case did not fall under the LAPD, but under the jurisdiction of the local police department.

Henry, arrested in flagrante, now sat silently in the interrogation room. Outside, however, the station was in chaos—like a bustling marketplace. Over a dozen witnesses waited to give statements, overwhelming the small-town police.

The local district attorney, upon hearing the news, showed an unusual level of enthusiasm and personally came to the station to interrogate the suspect.

Unlike the officers—who only knew the victims were wealthy—the district attorney fully understood the identities of the Arden couple.

Members of the Arden family were not people one could easily meet. Now that an opportunity to earn their favor had appeared, how could he not seize it?

If handled well, it could lead to future advancement—or at the very least, significant benefits.

Since this was a case of an on-the-spot arrest, his tone was especially aggressive. He slammed the interrogation table repeatedly, as if trying to intimidate Henry through sheer force.

"Talk! Why did you murder Mr. and Mrs. Arden?!"

"Speak! Were you acting under someone's orders? Was this connected to a mutant extremist group?!"

"I'm telling you—there are plenty of eyewitnesses who saw the whole thing! Don't think staying silent will save you. I'm giving you a chance to explain. If you don't take it, don't blame anyone when the verdict doesn't go your way!"

"Are you even listening to me?! You're in my hands now—there's no way you're walking out of here innocent!"

The interrogation room door opened.

A calm, confident voice cut in. "District Attorney Will, perhaps you should lower your voice. There's no need to frighten my client."

"Damn it, why is it you?!" The prosecutor clearly recognized the lawyer—and not fondly. "Get your client to plead guilty. I can offer a better deal."

The lawyer turned to Henry. "Mr. Henry Brown, my name is Scott Jefferson. I've been retained by Stark Industries as your legal counsel. Regarding the case—"

Henry finally spoke. "I'm not guilty. I will not accept any plea deal."

The prosecutor slammed the table again. "With that many witnesses, you think they're all blind?!"

Had there been actual family members or senior insiders present, they would never have called the police immediately. They would have handled things internally—deciding what to reveal, or burying the entire incident altogether.

But the guards had already fired everything they had.

And their target couldn't be killed.

What else could they do?

At the end of the day, they were just employees.

Henry cooperated fully. He didn't harm anyone. He didn't resist.

Even when someone punched him, he endured it silently.

As for whether that person's fist broke—that wasn't his concern.

After all, no one would believe someone smashed their own fist by hitting another man's face.

The only thing Henry was careful about was keeping his hands clenched—leaving no fingerprints, no opportunities for someone to frame him.

Even the handprint he'd left while vaulting the table had been wiped away during the chaos.

From the moment he entered, he hadn't touched anything unnecessarily.

Because if someone slipped a gun into his hand now—one used for something else—there'd be no explaining it.

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Henry's second sentence was a question. "Who exactly are you accusing me of killing?"

"James Arden and Lilith Arden," the prosecutor replied immediately. "Two wise individuals who made outstanding contributions to society."

"Then... where are the bodies?"

"...The—" The prosecutor's momentum faltered. His excitement turned into unease as he realized the most crucial element of any murder case—the bodies—was missing.

He flipped frantically through the reports. The more he read, the paler he became. Sweat formed on his forehead. "Perhaps you disposed of them... or destroyed the remains."

It was a murder accusation—yet there were no bodies, no forensic reports. The arrest had been made purely based on the testimony of the Arden family's bodyguards.

Henry said coldly, "So let me get this straight. In Mr. Arden's own house, in front of over a dozen bodyguards, I killed both victims, disposed of the bodies somewhere unknown—or completely destroyed them—"

"—and then allowed myself to be restrained at the crime scene and arrested as a 'caught-in-the-act' suspect. Is that correct?

"Mr. Will, does law school teach logic?"

The prosecutor snapped, "Then how do you explain so many people accusing you at once?!"

Henry looked at him like he was an idiot. "If you think mass hallucination is unlikely, then the only alternative is that they were instructed to make false accusations.

"You don't actually believe that a claim becomes true just because enough people repeat it—especially without a body. I hope you can convince a judge with that argument."

The prosecutor made one last attempt. "Then what about the murder weapon? Your cross necklace? So many witnesses saw you kill them with it!"

Even with his hands cuffed, Henry made a clumsy sign of the cross. "Lord, forgive this man for he is blind.

"Determining a murder weapon requires forensic analysis. So go ahead—test it. Check for blood traces. It's in your custody. I can't tamper with it even if I wanted to.

"If they said I used a knife, fine. But a cross? Are you serious? How exactly do I kill an adult with something the size of a finger?

"And do you know how small it is? It's not the kind of cross you nail Jesus onto. You can't even crush someone with it, let alone kill them."

Frustrated, the prosecutor stormed out to question the police further.

The lawyer, meanwhile, stood there, completely baffled.

Before arriving, he had only known his client was arrested for murder—victims being the Arden family heads. He hadn't known any details.

Originally, he believed negotiating the best plea deal was the only viable strategy. The victims weren't insignificant, and the arrest was made on the spot—overturning the case seemed impossible.

Another unspoken objective was to distance Stark Industries from the incident as much as possible.

But now, things clearly weren't so simple.

He spoke carefully. "Mr. Brown, you understand that I am bound by attorney-client privilege.

"I need you to tell me everything—clearly and completely—so I can represent you effectively and achieve the best possible outcome."

Henry glanced at him. The lawyer thought he was hiding his disdain well—but nothing escaped Kryptonian perception.

Still, Henry decided to speak.

"Do you know what vampires are?"

Chapter 481 481: The Missing

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Henry didn't continue down the path of mystical speculation. Instead, he said, "There's no need for you to know things that can't be verified. All you need to know is this—James Arden and Lilith Arden are missing. No bodies. No blood. That's all."

The lawyer repeated blankly, "The Ardens are missing. No bodies. No blood."

Henry spoke with sharp emphasis, "No, no—you didn't understand me. The Ardens are missing. No bodies. No blood.

"If you can't get me out today, you need to relay this information to Mr. Tony Stark as quickly as possible.

"And even if you don't directly manage the Arden family's foundations, if you know anyone who does, you should understand how valuable this information is."

The lawyer murmured again, "The Ardens are missing... no bodies... no blood..." His eyes began to light up.

Henry smiled. "Good. Now you understand."

The lawyer sprang to his feet. "I'll report to Mr. Tony Stark immediately. Mr. Brown, if Prosecutor Will or the police return, just remain silent. I'll have you back home resting today."

Henry nodded. He knew the battlefield had shifted—it was no longer about him. What followed would be a spectacle of human nature at its finest... or worst.

On that battlefield, even a Kryptonian like him had no say. Not even Tony Stark could fully control it. Everything would be decided by greed.

It didn't take long before Henry walked out of the interrogation room like a victor.

Meanwhile, the bodyguards who had served as "witnesses" hung their heads in defeat. Not only were they now defendants for making false accusations, but they also had to answer for opening fire on Henry.

Just because he hadn't been killed didn't mean shooting at a bulletproof man was legal. Attempted murder charges—every shooter would be held accountable.

But no one really cared about these small players anymore.

Because those with the power to care had their attention drawn to a far greater storm.

In Europe and America, the truly wealthy often follow a practice similar to Jewish financial traditions—not holding assets in their own names, but distributing them across foundations, trusts, and various legal entities. This both avoids taxes and disperses risk.

So those so-called "richest people in the world"—were they truly the richest?

Anyone familiar with that circle would confidently say: absolutely not.

If Forbes could estimate your wealth, you weren't truly rich—you were just a fat target for government scrutiny... and a fool.

With assets spread out like this, the wealthy rely heavily on lawyers and accountants to manage their fortunes.

But who could guarantee these professionals wouldn't dip into their clients' wealth?

Stories of Hollywood stars and athletes being swindled by their own lawyers or accountants were common.

They were easy targets because they lacked financial expertise and didn't pay close attention—their money came too easily.

The lawyer scoffed. "My life isn't limited to law books and case files. Of course I know what vampires are. What does that have to do with anything?"

"The Arden couple were no longer human. They turned themselves into vampires. Holy silver removes their cursed existence—leaving nothing behind."

"You've got to be kidding me." The lawyer was initially annoyed—but seeing Henry's serious expression, he hesitated.

He recalled certain rumors.

"...You're not joking, are you?"

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The truly wealthy, however, were far more cautious. Even in death, their estates were structured to pass smoothly to designated heirs.

Usually, the lawyer handling the will was different from the one managing assets—so they could check each other.

But what if a wealthy individual simply disappeared—neither declared dead nor willing to show up?

Then things became... interesting.

In corporate boards and foundation management meetings, those present—following legal procedures—could bypass absent members and make decisions on their own.

This rule was originally meant to prevent shareholders from paralyzing operations by refusing to attend or delegate votes.

But in practice, it was often weaponized.

For example, if a board meeting convened to remove someone—and that person was delayed elsewhere—then even if they held 51% of shares, their absence meant they were counted as having no objection.

And just like that, they could be voted out.

Of course, real operations were more complex—but the principle stood: majority ownership did not guarantee immunity from schemes.

Back to the Arden family.

Assets directly under James and Lilith Arden couldn't be touched without their consent—or their official declaration of death.

But in reality, that portion was nearly nonexistent.

The wealthy avoided estate taxes by transferring personal assets long before death.

What remained were foundations and boards.

And as long as there were other decision-makers, the absent Ardens would be treated as having forfeited their rights.

Would their interests still be protected?

Unlikely.

Had they appointed secondary administrators, there might have been safeguards.

But after becoming vampires, believing themselves immortal, they had eliminated all such redundancies—ensuring total control.

And now, that decision doomed them.

The first to strike was Stark Industries.

Any foundation or board—directly or indirectly tied to James or Lilith Arden—became a target for acquisition.

Even if they couldn't seize everything, they would carve it up with other stakeholders.

The goal: leave nothing behind.

The second wave came from the Ardens' own lawyers and accountants.

Leveraging their familiarity with the system, they quietly siphoned off assets under their management—unchecked in the absence of their clients.

Most people, however, were too focused on Stark Industries' aggressive moves to notice these quieter thefts.

By the time anyone realized, many foundations were already hollow shells.

What remained fell into two categories:

Assets beyond Stark's reach, or those co-managed by other families—harder to plunder through legal maneuvering alone.

The so-called "old money" families had always been tightly knit through cross-shareholding.

You hold part of me, I hold part of you—shared prosperity, shared loss.

That was why they stayed united.

It was also why a financial tycoon once told Tony Stark that the Stark family wasn't truly part of their circle—because Stark stood alone, without entangled interests.

Such networks were usually built through marriage—shares flowing through generations of alliances, creating webs too complex for outsiders to decipher.

But now?

With much of the Arden fortune already devoured—some by Stark, some by insiders—what about the rest?

Would the old-money families honor their supposed unity and safeguard it?

The answer was simple:

They joined the feast.

Because everyone believed—if they didn't take it, someone else would.

So why not take it themselves?

A textbook prisoner's dilemma.

Chapter 482 482: How Do You File a Case for Killing Vampires?

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Once a lofty phoenix that would only perch upon the finest parasol trees, he now sat disheveled—hair in disarray, dark circles under his eyes—before the Santa Barbara County District Attorney, Andrew Will.

Jack Arden, who should have been the next helmsman of the Arden family, once a privileged heir supported by the family's foundations, had instead scraped together money from various sources—even relying on old family connections—just to afford the trip to the West Coast.

They say a tiger's might lingers even after death. Though the Arden family had recently been besieged from all sides—especially by that ruthless bastard Tony Stark —

Even if those at the core of that elite circle knew that once the attack began, no one would leave the Ardens any chance of recovery,

There were still many outsiders who believed this old-money family, tracing its lineage back to the Mayflower Compact, might one day rise again.

That was why Jack Arden had been able to meet Andrew Will so easily.

The moment he sat down, he demanded, "What progress has been made in the investigation of Henry Brown's murder case?"

Andrew Will sighed helplessly. "No progress. The case simply can't proceed."

"That bastard killed my grandparents! There were so many witnesses!" Exhausted and disheveled, Jack slammed his fist onto the table. Though fallen, the airs of a former young master hadn't diminished in the slightest.

A flicker of displeasure crossed Andrew Will's mind. Still, he stood, closed the office door, and shut the blinds.

Only then did he say, "Mr. Arden, without a body, without a murder weapon stained with blood, witness testimony alone is not enough to build a case.

"If there were surveillance footage capturing everything—from your grandparents being alive, to their murder, to their complete disappearance—we could invoke statutes regarding crimes committed using mutant abilities as supporting evidence.

"Then we could attempt to replicate such abilities to verify the authenticity of the footage, rather than dismiss it as special effects from film or television."

He paused.

"Without footage, no number of witnesses will help. In fact, their testimonies alone are enough to get them committed to a psychiatric institution for life."

Jack growled, "So that's it? We just let this go? Use another body as a substitute, fabricate evidence—I don't care! I just want death certificates for my grandparents!"

So that's what it comes down to—a death certificate, Andrew Will thought.

The Arden family's current predicament stemmed entirely from the "disappearance" of its ruling couple.

The remaining Arden family members could only watch helplessly as their fortune was torn apart by countless scavengers.

Their patriarchs couldn't be declared dead. Even declaring them missing or incapacitated required time.

And in that gap, those without authority were powerless to act.

If those two vampire patriarchs hadn't clung so tightly to power, things might have turned out differently.

But now, the living could do nothing.

At this point, who still cared about Henry Brown?

Even those benefiting from the chaos would do everything they could to prevent a murder case from being filed.

As long as the Ardens remained missing, it served everyone's interests.

And only now did many realize a crucial blind spot:

The laws of capitalism might serve the wealthy—

But they were never designed to serve vampires.

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Even if family members attempted to forge authorization documents, others would scrutinize them relentlessly. The slightest flaw would result in charges of document fraud.

Under normal circumstances, no one would go to such lengths to verify authenticity. But now, no one would show mercy—not when so much was at stake.

In short: as long as James and Lilith Arden did not appear, no one else's moves would stop.

And that was precisely what the Arden family could not achieve.

With a regretful expression, Andrew Will shook his head. "Mr. Arden, that's impossible. Fabricating evidence carries enormous risk. The moment a third-party forensic agency gets involved, it will be exposed.

"Furthermore, according to Stark Industries' legal investigation, from the moment Henry Brown entered the Montecito estate to the moment he was arrested, there is a complete timeline supported by video evidence.

"If this had happened at a third-party location with unclear circumstances, we might explore the possibility of accomplices. But he was apprehended inside your family estate—there's no possibility of accomplices.

"And without accomplices, he didn't have the time to destroy bodies and eliminate all traces under the watch of multiple bodyguards—not to the extent of leaving no blood evidence whatsoever.

"From every angle, the evidence does not support the claim that your grandparents were murdered. The only reasonable explanation is that they left voluntarily and disappeared from public view."

Jack took several deep breaths, then seemed to steel himself. "I can tell you a family secret. My grandparents were turned by a vampire elder—they became vampires.

"I believe Henry Brown used this opportunity, employing specialized anti-vampire weapons, to kill them. Would that constitute murder?"

Andrew Will shook his head firmly.

Did he not know this possibility? Of course he did. Among all the absurd testimonies, this was the only explanation that made sense.

But it was not one that could be used in court.

"For a murder charge to stand," Andrew Will said, "there must be motive, a weapon, and a victim.

"Without motive, it may be reduced to manslaughter. Without a weapon, we may still infer its existence through supporting evidence.

"But without a victim, there is no case—no matter what.

"No matter where a body is hidden—even if reduced to bones—it must be found. Even if dissolved with chemicals and washed into the sewers, there will still be trace evidence.

"A scientifically verifiable explanation is essential. Claims like 'they became vampires and left no trace upon death' have no place in court. No judge would accept that."

Jack slammed the table again. "But it's the truth!"

Compared to Jack's fury, Andrew Will grew calmer. "Vampires, magic, curses—these are things that belong in bedtime stories.

"If they were to enter the real world—if courts accepted them—do you understand how dangerous that would be?

"Anyone could accuse someone of killing a vampire with silver. No body required. How many people would be imprisoned simply because someone disliked them?

"We wouldn't even be able to verify whether the accused was innocent. No body. No weapon. Just witness testimony—and a guilty verdict.

"In such a system, how could an innocent person defend themselves? And this wouldn't only affect ordinary citizens—what about those of status and influence?"

Jack's anger gave way to helplessness. "So my grandparents just... die for nothing?"

Andrew Will replied, "Unfortunately, this is no longer just about your grandparents.

"There's already internal debate within our system. But no one supports opening this door—granting vampires the same rights and protections as humans.

"And as far as I know, even the vampires themselves oppose it."

Jack looked confused. "Why?"

Andrew Will answered, "Beings who consider themselves more evolved than humans would find it beneath them to be governed by human laws—let alone

Chapter 483 483: Victims Not Worth Sympathy

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Jack Arden scoffed at such reasoning.

People like him had never believed ordinary individuals were comparable to themselves. In a United States built on financial power, old-money families like theirs should stand above the law.

So who should interpret the law—if not them?

Seeing the young master's dismissive expression, Andrew Will brought out his final trump card. He placed a report on the table and pushed it toward Jack.

"What's this?"

Andrew Will said, "Since your grandparents are the alleged victims, I requested support from the FBI's forensic team to find scientific evidence of murder.

"This is the crime scene investigation report for your family's Montecito estate. Oh—and while the property is still technically owned by a foundation, the management has changed, hasn't it? So it's no longer your house."

Jack couldn't help but curse, "Damn it!"—but he still picked up the report.

At first glance, nothing seemed unusual.

The more he read, the more his heart pounded.

The alleged crime scene—the dining room—did indeed contain significant blood traces. However, analysis showed the blood came from multiple sources, none matching the DNA records of the Arden couple from hospitals.

Further investigation revealed something far worse.

The basement of the estate resembled a slaughterhouse.

At least twenty-three flayed human skins—young women.

Thirty-three sets of severed limbs.

Five fifty-gallon barrels filled with blood, and another half-full.

Five identifiable IDs. Countless personal belongings.

And an incinerator still burning when discovered—filled with clothing remnants. Even shutting it down couldn't recover usable evidence; only photographs remained.

No one knew how many victims there truly were.

From the testimonies of detained estate staff, it was confirmed that the basement—once a waste processing area—had been repurposed about three months prior under the direct orders of James and Lilith Arden.

Sweat beaded on Jack's forehead as he stared at the horrifying photos.

Andrew Will's tone turned icy. "I heard the FBI forensic team all sought psychological counseling afterward. Even I can't imagine a place like that existing—it's no different from hell.

"For the sake of your family's reputation, I chose to suppress this information. It hasn't been made public. The FBI is quietly identifying victims.

"Considering your grandparents are only 'missing,' perhaps I should issue a warrant?

"Or perhaps we leave things as they are. After all, we both know—the primary perpetrators, the Arden couple, are unlikely to ever reappear. There's no one left to hold accountable.

protected by them. To them, that would be an insult to their dignity.

"Moreover, if they want special legal protection, they must first be legally defined—like the disabled or the mentally ill. They must be registered. Who is and isn't must be clearly identifiable under the law.

"Even mutants haven't achieved that. Do you think creatures that must hide from the sun and operate in the shadows would accept such conditions?

"As for your grandparents—frankly speaking, if they no longer wished to be human, why should they receive the protections meant for humans? Sometimes, you can't have both."

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"Mr. Arden, what do you think?"

As for accomplices, investigations continued.

But the missing Ardens had become the perfect scapegoats. Estate staff either claimed ignorance or said they acted under orders.

After all, the couple could no longer defend themselves.

Jack's trembling hands placed the report back on the table. He didn't even know how he had made it through reading it.

He muttered, "This is fine... this is fine..."

He understood all too clearly—

If the family still held power, this could have been buried with a few words.

But now?

If this were exposed, countless opportunists would descend like vultures—and the consequences would extend to the entire family.

In the end, he boarded a Greyhound bus and returned in disgrace to a "home" he wasn't even sure he could keep.

The consequences of the Arden family's downfall extended far beyond what Jack or Andrew Will had imagined.

Old-money elites who had once coveted vampirism as a means of prolonging life suddenly realized—

In modern society, vampires were more vulnerable than humans.

And legally? Even worse.

Because the law had never been designed with vampires in mind.

The dark world maintained its structure only because vampires were numerous and dominant. Humans acted merely as intermediaries—white gloves—allowing them to form a closed system with their own rules.

But those who tried to straddle both worlds?

They were far more fragile than expected.

As a result, many wealthy elites who had gathered around vampires, hoping for the Embrace and "evolution," began to withdraw.

Because they saw clearly—

Under current laws, a missing person required seven years before being declared dead.

Even for those over eighty, it still took three.

That gap was fatal.

During that time, family assets lacked legitimate protection—and were easy prey.

Unless they relinquished power before becoming vampires...

But then—

Without power, could they still access family resources to sustain themselves?

Without power, would vampire elders even consider granting them the Embrace?

A perfect dilemma: you couldn't have both.

There were even rumors that in another old-money family, whose leaders had become vampires, the couple had been imprisoned by their own descendants using artificial sunlight—forced to surrender control.

Whether true or not, most people abandoned the idea of becoming vampires.

Only a small few still tried to design systems that preserved both power and transformation.

But such solutions remained distant—and faced immense resistance.

All of this turmoil rippled quietly within elite circles, unnoticed by the public.

But Henry—the one who had torn away the vampires' facade—had no such peace.

Tony Stark stormed into Stark Pictures personally.

The two men sat across from each other in the conference room, silent—like they were competing to see who could hold out longer.

Eventually, Stark broke first. He tossed a pen-like jammer onto the table, activated it, and said:

"I was just trying to hook a blue-blood shark.

"You? You called in a swarm of piranhas and stripped it clean—nothing left but bones.

"Do you have any idea those old men are blaming me for this?"

Henry spread his hands. "You didn't have to reel the fish in. I didn't kick anyone into doing it—I don't have that kind of power.

"If people dove in and gorged themselves, is it really so terrible that some old men are holding a grudge?"

"The problem is—they ate too, and still pinned it all on me." Stark clicked his tongue. "So what actually happened?"

Henry didn't explain. He simply accessed a Stark Industries laptop and played a recording.

It was the conversation he'd had with the Ardens at their Montecito estate.

Stark's focus immediately locked onto one detail—James Arden's claim that Howard Stark had been unable to protect himself.

Chapter 484 484: Another Path

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"You haven't even tried—how do you know?" Tony Stark shot back stubbornly.

Henry raised a brow. "You need to try something like that? Calm down and think it through. Do you really believe you could've extracted anything useful from that couple?"

"Even if they weren't directly involved, they had to know something. Even scraps—casual talk among those old bastards in their little circle. Anything! But I know nothing. Do you understand? Nothing!"

The more he was told to calm down, the more agitated Tony became. Fortunately, the conference table between them kept him from grabbing Henry by the collar and spitting in his face.

Still, Henry was momentarily overwhelmed by the intensity.

So it wasn't indifference after all...

This obsession—this fixation on his father—was turning into something deeper.

Maybe it was because his mother had died too?

Henry recalled the funeral: everyone else placed a single flower for each parent. Tony had placed both of his flowers on his mother's coffin. His father hadn't received even one.

Hatred that deep didn't come from apathy. It came from something else entirely.

Raising both hands in surrender, Henry said, "My mistake. I should've left them alive so you could interrogate them."

Without a verbal sparring partner, Tony gradually calmed down instead.

"No," he said. "You did the right thing. Even if they were alive, I wouldn't have gotten what I wanted—unless I used illegal methods."

Henry nodded. "And using illegal methods on people of that status? Only two outcomes. Either they get silenced, or you do. There's no third option. That's basically a declaration of war."

"I know." Tony looked exhausted, head lowered, one hand pressing against his forehead. "The only chance was to bait them into slipping up. What you heard—that might've been the limit."

Henry said, "Sounds like you've gotten pretty familiar with how cunning those old men are."

Tony lifted his head, resting his chin on his hand, thinking. "People who aren't cautious don't live that long—or climb that high.

"If they were directly involved, the only ones they'd talk to... would be the dead. Brag a little before killing them, maybe.

"The fact that he said that while trying to intimidate and recruit you means he probably just heard rumors. He was using it as leverage—not speaking from

His expression turned serious. "So my old man's death... there really was something off. Are they truly dead?"

Henry made a small bursting gesture with his hands. "Boom. Burned to ash—gone for good. If they hadn't turned themselves into vampires, I wouldn't have dared do it."

Did killing a vampire count as murder?

Of course not.

The horrors in that basement—though suppressed by the district attorney and FBI—were no secret to those with the right connections.

Tony Stark was one of them.

At the time, he had only felt satisfaction. He hadn't realized the couple might hold further value.

Now that he did, he could only sigh, "What a waste..."

Henry shot back, "You weren't planning to interrogate them for more secrets, were you? That was never going to happen. People like that aren't the kind you can quietly capture and extract information from."

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firsthand involvement.

"If things blew up, it wouldn't trace back to him. The real question is—how much do they actually know? You were the last one to see them. Any thoughts?"

Henry replied, "Honestly, your reasoning is already solid. My take is—what if your parents' 'accident' was something a group of people allowed to happen?

"They weren't the killers, but they didn't stop it either. So the people who knew wouldn't just be James Arden.

"And that same pattern extends to you. None of them are executors—they just see an opportunity and rush in afterward to grab what they can. Just like what you all did today."

Tony tapped his fingers on the table. "So who do you think the actual executors were?"

Henry pointed upward. "The one percent?"

Tony immediately snapped, "That's a non-answer!"

Henry shrugged. "You're not exactly calm right now. If I throw out a name and you go probing recklessly, do I really need to explain how that ends?"

"I am calm."

"Have you ever seen a crazy person admit they're crazy? Everyone says they're fine."

"I have," Tony shot back. "I've seen someone clearly admit they were insane."

"Exactly," Henry said. "Which means their condition was already severe."

"You—!" Tony suddenly felt the urge to design a new kind of armor-piercing round capable of penetrating bulletproof targets.

Depleted uranium shells. Fragmentation designs. Even a handheld tactical nuclear launcher—with burst-fire capability.

When damage isn't enough, increase the yield. Classic American thinking.

Completely unaware he had just been mentally nuked several times over, Henry continued:

"I think you should focus on investigating your parents' car accident—if you really believe something was wrong with it.

"As for rumors from that circle, don't chase them too hard. They might just be bar talk—half-truths, exaggerations.

"It's like hearing someone mention nuclear weapons and assuming they know how to build one, then launching a full investigation—only to find it was drunken nonsense.

"Plenty of people love discussing geopolitics—throwing around Iraq, Iran, aircraft carriers—but they're just outsiders talking big."

Tony frowned. "So what do you want me to do? Hire a private detective? Those guys are good at catching cheaters—not digging into something like this. They'd probably end up at the bottom of the Hudson the next day."

His words already assumed the accident was suspicious.

Henry followed that line. "You mentioned someone had investigated the crash before. I'm guessing it was an organization your father was involved with."

Tony nodded.

"A covert intelligence group?"

"Exactly." Tony's eyes sharpened. "You think the problem was internal?"

Henry quickly waved his hands. "I'm not saying that. Just that if one person can't find answers, it might be because they're limited by their perspective and channels.

"So why not bring in someone else—someone looking from a completely different angle? No preconceived notions."

"FBI? CIA?" Tony grimaced. "That sounds like a terrible idea."

Henry thought for a moment—about Cruella, about certain possibilities in this world. Even if that particular person didn't exist, it might still work.

Then he said, "You have a good relationship with the military, right?"

Tony smirked. "Not bad."

The way his ego practically lifted him out of his chair made it clear just how "not bad" that was.

Henry continued, "I've heard the Army's Military Police have specialized investigative units—top-tier investigators. Think you could get a general to loan you

Chapter 485 485: Assassination Package

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Henry couldn't care less about the chain reaction that might result from nudging Tony Stark into using the military against Hydra hidden within S.H.I.E.L.D.

After all, he was just the guy who gave a bad idea. With the signal jammer in place, as long as Tony didn't go around blabbing about Henry's role, no third party would ever know.

If the military and "Snake Shield" ended up beating each other's brains out, that had nothing to do with him.

Besides, the military and intelligence agencies had never gotten along—let alone S.H.I.E.L.D., which evolved from the Strategic Scientific Reserve (SSR). To many, it looked like a splinter faction that had broken away from the military.

People would simply assume that Stark Industries—now transitioning into a military-industrial giant—had come up with another reckless idea, backed by its close ties to the armed forces.

Henry left shortly after Tony.

He had to head to the airport—his girl had finally gotten her visa reissued at the U.S. Embassy in the UK and was flying back to Los Angeles.

But before getting into his car, Henry hesitated for a moment.

Extending his super senses, he scanned the surroundings—no surveillance personnel, and conveniently, a blind spot in the parking lot cameras.

He reached under the seat and pulled out a bomb detonator.

Of course, he hadn't planted it.

Crushing the detonator in his hand, he minimized any potential harm. The harmless components were tossed casually aside.

As for the explosives themselves—those were worth keeping. Henry had been wondering how to get his hands on some. Four quarter-pound sticks of TNT weren't exactly easy to come by.

On the way to the airport, Henry kept up his usual vigilance, monitoring his surroundings.

That's when he overheard:

"Target spotted. Brown vintage Cadillac. Proceeding along planned route."

The voice came from a sanitation worker by the roadside—speaking quietly into a concealed microphone.

Expanding his perception, Henry quickly located the other end of the communication: a garbage truck waiting at the next intersection.

The driver started the engine—clearly preparing for a side-impact collision.

Instead of playing along, Henry turned early, diverting onto another road. Rather than taking the shortest route to the airport, he made a detour and stopped at a flower shop.

He picked out a bouquet—white dahlias and pink dinner-plate dahlias.

While waiting for the arrangement, a sniper had time to reposition.

As Henry stepped out of the shop—

Bang.

a few for some... private work?

"Your father's death was a major loss for the military too. This might not even be as 'private' as you think. They might just be waiting for you to ask."

Tony's tapping finger suddenly struck the table hard—then stopped.

He stood up abruptly, already heading for the door.

Henry had to call after him, picking up the jammer from the table. "Boss—you forgot your 'pen.'"

"Keep it. Charge it for me. I'll grab it next time," Tony's voice came from afar.

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A sniper round struck his forehead.

Well... not quite.

Henry casually tilted his head, letting the bullet ricochet upward into a building wall, avoiding any chance of injuring bystanders.

He scratched the spot where the 12.7mm round had hit, completely unfazed, then got back into his car.

Behind him, the sniper stared at his rifle in disbelief—half tempted to shoot himself just to check if the ammo was defective.

Back on the road, another threat appeared.

A pickup truck sped wildly behind him, honking nonstop, nearly rear-ending him multiple times.

Henry had no interest in a high-speed chase through city streets.

Using narrow lanes to his advantage, he alternated speeds, swerved left and right—like a chaotic but technically "normal" inexperienced driver.

Eventually, the pursuing truck crashed into a fire hydrant.

Steam billowed from its hood.

Henry didn't even bother stopping.

Frankly, he felt generous enough already for not stepping out and giving the guy a "six-month hospital package punch."

Still... he had doubts.

Was that actually an assassin? Or just an aggressive road rager?

The guy hadn't mentioned anything about killing—just a nonstop stream of colorful profanity.

After dodging two potential "accidents," Henry finally reached the airport parking lot.

Bouquet in hand, he stepped out.

Inside LAX's departure hall, a well-dressed woman approached, concealing a syringe in her briefcase.

A quick jab, a press of the thumb—potassium cyanide injected—and even gods couldn't save the target.

Except—

Her hand slipped.

The needle bent on contact.

The solution sprayed uselessly onto the ground.

Realizing her mistake, the assassin didn't hesitate—she stuck to her escape plan and disappeared.

Henry didn't even react.

To him, it was just another minor inconvenience hidden beneath the flowers.

He thought that was it.

It wasn't.

Two burly men, each carrying concealed stun batons, approached from a distance.

Coincidence? Passing by? Or—

Henry casually shifted through the crowd, as if protecting his bouquet, subtly moving toward airport police.

Whether it was their intimidating appearance or existing warrants, the officers immediately approached the two men.

The moment the pair saw police coming—they ran.

The police chased.

They didn't even know what the suspects had done yet—but running was enough.

And just like that, the two "professionals" exposed themselves without Henry lifting a finger.

He watched, speechless.

From Stark Pictures to the airport, that made at least five assassination attempts.

This density of killers?

If it wasn't the Continental's doing, Henry wouldn't believe it.

Freelancers didn't swarm into Los Angeles like this without checking in—otherwise, the harbor floor would welcome them.

So...

Had he kicked a hornet's nest?

Or was there a bounty on his head?

Standing there with the bouquet, Henry thought it through.

The Continental was just a broker. If someone posted a bounty, this was expected.

His past association didn't grant immunity. He hadn't worked in a long time—and hadn't paid any "dues."

Chapter 486 486: A Bounty at the Continental

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After dealing with jet lag and catching up on several days of missed work, the girl turned in early to rest.

Henry, meanwhile, made a trip to the Continental Hotel—and deliberately entered through the front door.

The fact that he could walk in without issue confirmed he hadn't been excommunicated like John Wick would be in the future—cast out of the system, marked for unlimited assassination by all contract killers until death.

At the front desk, the concierge greeted him with a professional smile.

"Good afternoon, Mr. Henry Brown. How may I assist you?"

Henry placed a gold coin on the counter and slid it forward.

"Is Charlie in the café? I need a cup of coffee to wake myself up. Been a long day—things are a bit... fuzzy."

"Mr. Fisher is at his usual table. You'll find him there. I'll have your coffee prepared—double espresso?"

"Perfect. Much appreciated," Henry said with a smile, heading toward the café.

Along the way, quite a few people pointed at him.

Some were familiar—like the woman from the airport who had tried to stab him with a syringe.

But inside the Continental, business and violence were forbidden. No deals, no revenge killings. So everyone kept their distance.

Henry didn't bother provoking anyone either.

As for the two burly men who had been chased by police earlier—they were here too. Which meant they'd managed to escape.

Their expressions were full of resentment, like they wanted to walk over and punch Henry.

They didn't.

Because they didn't dare.

Ignoring the crowd of would-be tough guys, Henry entered the café.

Charlie Fisher sat in a tailored suit, looking every bit like a dignified figure from The Godfather—one of the respectable Corleone family men after the war.

Honestly, if not for Mooney Fisher, Charlie had more than enough presence to be a boss himself.

Henry approached and, with the polished manners of a British gentleman, greeted him:

"Good afternoon, Charlie. May I sit?"

Protection wasn't free.

As for who would want him dead right now—

One name surfaced instantly:

The Arden family.

Just then—

"Darling!"

A familiar voice rang out.

Charlize Theron ran toward him, dragging her luggage.

Henry handed her the bouquet, then pulled her into a warm embrace and kissed her.

Reunited lovers at an airport—nothing unusual.

Though a few bitter onlookers cast envious glances.

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"Please."

As soon as Henry sat down, a waiter arrived with his coffee.

"Mr. Brown, your double espresso."

At the Continental, service always followed payment. No coin, no service—no exceptions, no matter how familiar you were.

Since the coin had already been paid, Charlie got straight to the point.

"I heard you took a sniper round to the head. Direct hit?"

Henry smirked. "You could ask the sniper if he's willing to admit he missed."

"The armory manager got quite the complaint. Tungsten rounds couldn't penetrate—what, are we supposed to bring out anti-materiel rifles and treat you like a tank?"

"Please don't," Henry laughed. "One shot today already gave me a headache. If you bring out something like that, I'm dead for sure."

"If I believed that," Charlie said dryly, "my IQ would be lower than Forrest Gump's."

"Relax. That guy's too kind to mock anyone."

After a bit of banter, Henry asked, "So—what's my bounty?"

Charlie raised an eyebrow. "Thinking of collecting it yourself?"

"If it's high enough, why not?"

"Unfortunately," Charlie said, "it's only one hundred thousand dollars. Any more, and that family you nearly bankrupted couldn't afford it. Or rather—they're not willing to."

"About what I expected," Henry nodded. "Otherwise you wouldn't have sent such... underwhelming attempts. If you're coming after someone like me, shouldn't you at least bring proper equipment?"

Charlie clicked his tongue. "I should record that and play it for them. Might boost morale. Though first, they should probably thank you for sparing their lives."

"I can't exactly fight back," Henry said innocently. "I'm just... durable."

Charlie gave him a look.

"Honestly," he continued, "you should just grab an Uzi with an extended magazine. Next time someone comes for you, charge straight at them. Once you're close enough, unload. With your... 'talent,' that tactic would be unstoppable."

Whether Charlie knew more than he let on—or genuinely thought that was the optimal strategy—neither of them pressed the matter further.

Henry asked, "Am I the only target?"

"Worried about escalation? Collateral damage?" Charlie shrugged. "Accidents can happen, sure. But one target, one contract. Unless specified, extra kills don't mean extra pay. That's the rule."

"No unlimited pursuit, right?"

Charlie widened his eyes dramatically. "What did you do—anger the heavens?"

"From that family's perspective, I probably did worse."

"Relax," Charlie said. "If enough contractors report failure due to... uncontrollable factors, the bounty can be canceled. That means the difficulty exceeded expectations.

"At that point, the client either gives up—or increases the reward. More money attracts better killers—or more expensive methods.

"You don't think people run this business at a loss, do you? Nobody's spending a hundred grand bounty just to buy a nuke to kill you. Risking your life is one thing—paying out of pocket is another."

Henry sighed. "I'm more worried that a low bounty makes idiots think I'm easy prey. I'll get harassed nonstop."

"Again—don't worry," Charlie said. "If a contract remains incomplete past a certain time, we cancel it ourselves.

"Because if it can't be done within the timeframe, that means the difficulty was underestimated. No extra pay, no deal."

Henry asked, "But I've seen bounties stay open for years. What about those?"

"Special cases," Charlie replied. "Usually tied to the High Table—violations that demand death without end.

Chapter 487 487: Countermeasures

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Narrowing his eyes at the older man in front of him, Henry said with a hint of displeasure, "Why do I get the feeling you're using this opportunity to test the limits of my abilities?"

Charlie Fisher took a sip of whiskey. "Isn't that perfectly normal? We accepted a contract on you. If it succeeds, great. If not... we learn something."

Then he leaned forward slightly, lowering his voice as if sharing a secret.

"Actually, there's a simple way to solve your problem. Want to hear it?"

"Go on."

Rubbing his fingers together in a money gesture, Charlie said, "Put up a bounty of your own. Turn it around. Once their side is dealt with, your one-month deadline? That can be... flexible.

"The Continental doesn't forbid this. Most people can't do it because we don't reveal who posted the bounty. But in your case? It's pretty obvious who's behind it.

"And honestly, that hundred-thousand-dollar bounty on you? It's insulting—to you and to the contractors. No one serious is going to treat it as real business."

It sounded tempting.

But Henry could already see the traps hidden underneath.

He looked at Charlie. "Let me ask you something first. That hundred-thousand bounty—there's outside pressure behind it, isn't there?"

Charlie's eyes drifted. "Maybe. Maybe not. You should know—money and coins aren't the real currency here.

"Favors and rules—that's what matters. This world isn't run by a few Wall Street bankers. Their turf ends there. This place? Different game."

Henry smiled knowingly. "Oh, I see."

"See what?"

"I see that the Arden family still being alive is... inconvenient for someone. They want that entire bloodline silenced—but don't want to be seen doing it. So I'm a convenient pawn."

Charlie didn't deny it. "So? It's a valuable favor."

Henry shrugged. "Too bad I've always had a rebellious streak. The more someone wants me to do something, the less I feel like doing it.

"If they want my help, they can ask me directly. Dressing it up as 'helping me'? Please.

"And I'm a law-abiding citizen," he added with mock sincerity. "No way I'd put out a bounty on someone's life. Let's say ten thousand per Arden—round it up, maybe ten million total? Do I look like a sucker to you?"

Charlie chuckled awkwardly.

In truth, he had only meant eliminating key heirs.

Henry, on the other hand, had jumped straight to wiping out the entire inheritance line.

Best not to clarify that misunderstanding.

"Alright," Henry said. "One month. I'll play along, put on a show, keep those broke little brats entertained. Watching angels fall from heaven into hell... can be

"Most contracts have a deadline—no more than thirty days. You won't see a target with a bounty hanging over them for eight or nine years before someone finally completes it. That's not allowed. The hotel would step in.

"Many contracts are time-sensitive. Like a crime boss wanting a defector killed before trial. If the hit happens after the trial's over and the boss is already locked up—what's the point?

"So just last a month," Charlie finished. "Not too hard, right?"

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amusing."

Charlie raised his hands. "Your call. I've got no objections."

"You say that like things might still change."

"My manager decides that, not me," Charlie shrugged. "You don't think I have that authority, do you?"

Henry leaned in, whispering, "Moody day? Mooney on her period?"

Charlie shoved his face away. "I'm her uncle. Why would I track that?"

Then he added, "But you getting a girlfriend? That did upset her."

"Seriously?"

Charlie nodded. "You're useful. Then you ran off with someone else. You think people with control issues just shrug that off?

"She won't obsess over it—but if she gets a chance to mess with you? She won't pass it up."

Henry sighed. "That bad?"

"Go talk to her yourself."

"After hearing that? I'd rather stay far away."

With the information gathered—and a warning received—Henry was ready to leave.

"One last thing," he said. "Everything you said... still stands, right?"

Charlie smiled faintly. "If you're asking, you already know the answer."

"Rules don't change. Everything else is... flexible. Right?"

Charlie didn't respond.

Henry downed his coffee in one gulp and slipped out through the side exit.

A few minutes later, Mooney Fisher appeared in the café, scanning the room.

"Where is he?"

"Ran. As usual," Charlie replied.

"Did someone warn him?" she asked sharply.

"In your territory? Who would dare?" Charlie said lightly, before adding, "Besides, ever since he stopped being 'the Fixer,' who's managed to corner him?"

Mooney frowned. "You think he has abilities beyond being bulletproof? Like precognition?"

"Luck, instinct—call it what you want. Unless he says something, it's hard to tell.

"Like veteran killers' intuition. Can you classify that as a mutant ability? Maybe not. But it works."

"Damn it." Mooney turned and left, clearly irritated.

Charlie simply continued sipping his whiskey, as if nothing had happened.

Outside, Henry shook off anyone trying to tail him.

He reversed cleanly into a dark alley, killed the engine and lights, and watched as his would-be followers wandered the surrounding streets, searching in vain.

Sitting in the car, he reviewed everything Charlie had said.

A bounty without results wouldn't last more than a month.

Not a strict rule—but a common practice.

The target was only him—so collateral damage was the main concern.

A hundred thousand dollars wouldn't attract top-tier assassins or specialists—unless they were desperate.

And from Henry's experience, professional killers were rarely poor.

If they lived modestly, it was by choice—or because they maintained multiple safe houses.

Their biggest problem wasn't lack of money.

It was dying before they could spend it.

(There was a reason abandoned storage units were such a thing in America.)

So top-tier assassins wouldn't show up for pocket change like this.

Reputation mattered.

Like luxury goods—better to sit unsold than be discounted.

The only variable was whether the Arden family would raise the bounty.

So both the "one-month limit" and "single target" conditions could change.

Still, Henry needed to survive the first month.

As for the assassins coming after him—

Killing them was optional.

Most Continental contractors only made one attempt. If they failed cleanly, they'd withdraw.

Failure meant the job was beyond them.

Those who couldn't recognize that... didn't live long.

Only those who came close to success—or had personal grudges—would try again.

Professional killers valued survival over killing.

Retreating alive to spend money mattered more than completing a job.

Suicidal types were rare.

But passive defense wasn't enough.

Even if he cleared out Los Angeles, the Continental's network meant endless replacements.

He remembered his first encounter—John Wick, the Baba Yaga, arriving with a whole Russian crew from the East Coast.

And constant counterattacks risked exposing his abilities.

Even without witnesses, too many dead bodies raised questions.

That's why he hadn't killed anyone during the first wave.

Chapter 488 488: The Security Team

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In the conference room of Stark Pictures, several old acquaintances—whom Henry hadn't seen in over five years—had arrived.

Naturally, he greeted them warmly, shaking hands one by one.

"Bryan, Sam, Mark, Bernie—long time no see."

"Mr. Brown," Bryan Mills replied on behalf of the group, still carrying that same cautious professionalism.

"Come on, Bryan. No need to be so formal. We've been through a crisis together—we're practically comrades."

"But you called us here for work, didn't you?" Bryan's stern expression suddenly relaxed into a smile. "Still... we didn't expect you to end up as CEO of Stark Pictures."

Henry gave a helpless grin. "And that's exactly why I've run into trouble that requires your help."

Then he added sincerely, "Honestly, I'm glad you came. When I made the call, I wasn't even sure you'd take this kind of job."

Bryan nodded. "We just don't take long-term protection contracts. And our last job ended a while ago—we were looking for something new anyway."

"As for your request, we agreed to come hear you out. If we're not a good fit, I can recommend a team that is."

"That alone is already a big help," Henry said. "You know me—I've got... trust issues."

Bryan nodded knowingly. "I understand. Which is why we're even more curious—what kind of people could possibly cause you trouble?"

Henry gave a wry smile. "More than you'd think."

If the other side was just probing, going all-out would escalate things unnecessarily.

How many people would he have to kill to scare others off?

Or how brutal would he need to be?

There was a simpler solution.

Raise the difficulty.

Hire a proper security team.

That alone would deter most opportunists.

It was the most common—and effective—method.

Otherwise, the entire security industry wouldn't exist.

Assassins capable of bypassing protection and escaping cleanly were exceedingly rare.

In short—

Another problem money could solve.

No need to risk exposing more of his abilities or waste time playing cat-and-mouse.

But not just any security firm would do.

In this world, security companies were graded—up to AAA level.

The system felt... oddly familiar.

Still, Henry had no intention of hiring strangers.

He preferred people he could trust.

With that thought, Henry pulled out his phone—

And dialed a number he had never called before.

Reaching out to a group he hadn't contacted in a long time.

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He then explained everything: being targeted by the Arden family, the bounty placed on him through the Continental.

At the end, he asked, "You've heard of the Continental, right?"

Bryan and the others exchanged glances before nodding.

"We know about it," Bryan said. "Just didn't expect you to get dragged into something like this. Can't kill, can't be killed... well, the second part probably doesn't concern you."

Henry shrugged. "It's not that I can't kill. If people are already pulling guns and throwing explosives, tying my own hands doesn't help.

"But the main goal is deterrence—drive them off, intimidate them. If someone gets themselves killed, that's on them.

"As for me... you all know my situation. Being bulletproof is hardly a secret anymore. If it comes down to it, I don't need anyone taking bullets for me.

"That said, there's one key point—I don't want unnecessary casualties. No harm to people around me, no innocent bystanders getting caught up in this.

"Of course, that depends on what methods the assassins use. I can only say we try to avoid it—not that I'll compromise if someone uses hostages."

Bryan asked, "You said the contract duration is one month?"

"Right. That's the Continental's usual window before a bounty gets canceled. If they want to keep going after that... I have other ways to escalate. At that point, simple protection won't be the solution."

The words were calm.

But to Bryan and the others, they carried a chilling edge.

Bryan knew very well—someone who could carry a plane in flight and hear conversations from outside its hull... what kind of things that person could do.

Even without knowing the full extent of Henry's abilities, what he had already demonstrated was enough for Bryan to devise multiple operational plans—ones that could eliminate targets cleanly while ensuring safe extraction.

The fact that this man sat behind a desk running a film company?

That was probably the world’s greatest stroke of luck.

The four men exchanged a glance and silently reached an agreement.

Bryan spoke for them.

"Henry, we'll take the job.

"We've spent too long working overseas anyway. A domestic contract like this? Consider it a break.

"And honestly, your situation isn't that serious. Mostly just posturing and probing, right?"

Henry nodded. "Exactly."

"Do you need 24-hour close protection? What about home security?"

"No need," Henry said casually. "I’ve got a tabby cat at home... well, okay, a tiger. If anyone’s bold enough to break in, then we’re way past 'just posturing.'"

"A tiger... you’re serious?" old Bernie asked, stunned.

"Found it abandoned a couple years ago. Took it in. Works great as anti-theft security."

The four men stared at him, speechless.

Finally, Bryan wrapped it up. "Alright. That at least means your home security is... solid. I assume bugs and surveillance won't be an issue for you either."

"Correct."

Then Henry added, "There's something else I want your opinion on."

"Go ahead."

"My girlfriend—should she be included in the protection plan?"

"Your girlfriend?" Bryan recalled. "Charlize Theron, right? A minor actress?"

"Yeah. She's had some recent buzz, but not exactly high-profile yet."

Bryan considered this carefully before answering.

"In that case, I don’t recommend giving her visible protection.

"In executive protection, aside from the principal, there are only two types of additional high-priority individuals: a current spouse—not an ex—and biological

Chapter 489 489: Trouble Fading Away

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"Anyone want coffee or donuts?" Charlize Theron asked as she walked into the CEO's office at Stark Pictures, carrying a large paper bag.

Brian Mills and Mark Casey, who were already inside, politely stood up.

Mark—no longer exactly a young man—quickly stepped forward. "I do! Yes, absolutely. This afternoon slump is killing me. Without some caffeine, I'm going to fall asleep."

Even though he said "coffee," the moment he grabbed the bag, Mark pulled out a donut first and took a blissful bite, looking utterly satisfied.

Only then did Brian greet her. "Ms. Theron."

"Brian, just call me Charlize," she said with a smile, handing him a cup of coffee. "When are you bringing Rena and Kim to the studio again? Maybe I can take them to Disneyland."

She leaned closer and whispered conspiratorially, "Don't tell anyone, but I haven't even been there myself. Tell me—are all men as unromantic as you guys?"

Henry, who had just walked over, immediately realized he'd been caught in the crossfire. "Hey now, sweetheart—you're even more of a workaholic than I am. Is it really me not taking you to an amusement park, or you choosing more auditions instead?"

Brian chuckled. "Kim's only three. Maybe when she's older. And with the current situation around Henry, going somewhere like Disneyland might just invite trouble."

Henry slipped an arm around Charlize's waist, pretending to sulk. "Yeah, unless you're planning a girls' day and ditching us."

Despite the teasing, the two shared a sweet kiss.

Mark, mid-bite on his chocolate donut, froze. Suddenly, it didn't taste as good anymore. He muttered, "Maybe I shouldn't have taken the bag... at least then there'd be something between them."

Brian laughed. "If you hadn't, they'd just toss it aside. Then none of us would get anything." He reached into Mark's bag and grabbed a donut for himself.

Brian and his team had taken over Henry's security, and both the arrangement and its details had been shared with Charlize.

children.

"They must be family, with clear inheritance ties, to justify the resources.

"If you suddenly assign heavy protection to someone who appears unrelated, it raises suspicion. Enemies start asking—who is this person? A hidden heir? A weakness?

"That kind of attention creates danger."

He paused, then continued.

"But that applies to high-profile elites.

"You're single. She's just a girlfriend with no major background. To your enemies, she's not a valuable target—no reason to focus on her.

"I assume you already have some private safeguards in place for her. If not, set up something basic. I can draft emergency response protocols.

"But publicly? Don't draw attention. Our job is simply to ensure no accidental harm when you're together."

Everything Henry had been worried about—Bryan had already addressed.

So he nodded. "Alright. We'll go with your approach. I'll just remind Charlize to stay alert."

"Then let's talk about fees."

Henry smiled. "I'm doing alright these days. No need to go easy on me. If spending more makes things smoother, it's worth it.

"Name your price."

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However, she tactfully didn't ask about the cause of the situation—only what she needed to be aware of and cooperate with. That alone spared Henry a lot of trouble in deciding how much to tell her.

Brian Mills truly lived up to his expertise in protection work.

He rotated between two vehicles to escort Henry to and from work. Under normal circumstances, one or two team members stayed close to Henry. During outings, all four operated together.

Their demeanor as former military personnel—distinct from ordinary people—was enough to deter many Continental contract killers looking for an easy score.

And those who still dared to try couldn't escape the keen eyes of Brian's team. Every trap and ambush was identified and neutralized.

Of course, with his own safety on the line, Henry didn't just stand by. On several occasions, his warnings prompted Brian to adjust plans on the spot, helping them avoid potential dangers.

After a few minor incidents, things around Henry noticeably calmed down.

This confirmed his earlier assessment—the Continental's bounty on him was half-hearted at best.

With a competent security team in place, most contract killers lost interest. The reward simply wasn't worth the effort required to break through such a well-prepared defense.

Still, Brian didn't lower his guard. He suspected the killers' reduced activity might be a smokescreen—waiting for them to grow complacent before striking.

Another reason for their diligence was simple: most of them had families in California. Brian himself lived in Los Angeles.

Henry's job didn't require 24/7 close protection, meaning they could go home after work—something they rarely had during overseas missions.

Because of this, Henry and Charlize had both met Brian's wife and daughter, Rena and Kim, and gotten along well.

From an outsider's perspective, Henry could see that Brian truly loved his wife. Their eventual divorce wouldn't come from lack of love, but likely from long separations due to work.

In short, just as Brian had initially judged—this was a relatively easy assignment.

Helping Charlize settle onto the couch in the office lounge area, Henry asked, "I thought reshoots would keep you busy for a few more days?"

"They went quickly. Nothing complicated—just adding a few more lines for me. The studio's in a rush too—they want it ready before the Christmas season."

They were referring to Jingle All the Way, set to release on November 22, starring Arnold Schwarzenegger.

Filming had actually wrapped earlier in mid-April over five weeks.

But after Charlize gained major attention at Paris Fashion Week as the "tiger beauty," the production company—1492 Pictures, led by Chris Columbus—wanted to capitalize on the buzz and expand her role.

Neither Charlize nor her agent J.J. Harris would refuse such an opportunity. They cleared their schedules and completed the reshoots over the past few days.

With just over a month until release, time was tight.

For Charlize—who refused to play by Hollywood's unspoken rules—the best she could do was show professionalism and cooperation, ensuring no one could blame her if the film underperformed.

Despite the trouble surrounding Henry, she carried on as usual.

Which also showed that the Continental had exercised restraint—things hadn't escalated out of control.

After all, a failed bounty might damage their reputation, but offering an absurdly low reward to kill a clearly difficult target—and forcing compliance through internal pressure—would be worse. Assassins weren't disposable tools.

Back when Sony America's president, Mickey Schulhof, had considered placing a bounty on Henry, the Continental quoted a price of one million dollars—enough to

Chapter 490 490: An Unexpected Visitor

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The cheerful little gathering didn't last long before the secretary, Yulian Williams—the plump Black woman—peeked in from the doorway, covering the receiver of her phone. "Boss, there's someone at the front desk asking for you. He didn't say what it's about. He calls himself Jack Reacher."

Brian Mills immediately dropped his smile, his expression sharpening with alertness. Mark Casey followed just a beat slower, his hand drifting to a position where he could draw his gun quickly.

Charlize Theron, though not inexperienced, had never witnessed special operations veterans snap into seriousness at such close range.

For someone currently honing her acting skills, the atmosphere hit her like a physical force. It felt as though her throat was being constricted, her heart pounding painfully against her chest.

Henry placed a hand over hers, steadying her. The flush on her face gradually faded. Then he said to his two reliable old friends, "No need to worry. This shouldn't be from that side. It's something else."

He turned toward the door. "Yulian, have Mr. Jack Reacher come up directly. No need for registration. I'll meet him."

"Got it, boss." The secretary withdrew, muttering something to the receptionist outside.

Though no weapons were drawn, Brian and the others began tidying up the table, making the office look presentable.

Brian asked, "Henry, do you know this Jack Reacher?"

"No," Henry replied. "But people from the Continental don't walk in through the front door like this. So I'm guessing he's from Stark's side."

At that name, Brian knew better than to ask further. Though he couldn't help wondering—did "Stark" mean Stark Industries, or Tony Stark himself?

Their acceptance of this security job had the tacit approval of their organization. Officially, they weren't allowed to operate domestically—but as long as nothing was exposed, no one could fault them.

In fact, Brian and his team had an additional covert task: to investigate Stark Pictures, Stark Industries, and Henry Brown.

It was a vague directive—suggesting even their superiors didn't know exactly what to look for. Likely just intelligence gathering, not worth risking exposure.

But what the CIA didn't know was that Brian and his team had long decided to keep Henry's secrets.

After all, a man who could withstand bullets—and even hold up a plane—was a valuable ally in a life-or-death situation. Compared to that, whatever reward they might get for reporting him wasn't worth much.

As long as Henry showed no signs of treason, they would keep quiet. Their reports would stick to trivial details—things not even worth printing in newspapers.

So the CIA was destined to gain nothing.

Henry, of course, had considered the presence of the CIA behind them. But he chose to trust the character of these four men.

scare him off.

And now?

The Arden family tried to put a mere hundred thousand on the head of a bulletproof "mutant."

Did they think the Continental had no pride?

No wonder most assassins gave up after one failed attempt. Killing wasn't free—bullets might be cheap, but they still cost money.

And so, this small gathering in the office felt relaxed—almost like a casual reunion among friends, filled with laughter and light conversation.

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And even in the worst case—if the CIA already knew—then at most he'd only need to rely on abilities he had already revealed.

As long as Brian Mills remained on his side, most of his current troubles could be handled.

For now, however, Henry's attention was on the man calling himself Jack Reacher.

Though the man was still in the elevator, Henry had already seen him through X-ray vision.

A massive figure, built like a bear, with short, neat hair and an unexpectedly sharp presence. Compared to Brian, he carried a completely different aura.

Brian and his team only displayed their military edge when focused. But Jack Reacher didn't feel like a typical soldier.

If someone said he was a professional wrestler, no one would doubt it.

And yet... there was something else.

A kind of weariness.

Like a lone wolf that had wandered the wilderness too long—ragged, but still deadly. No one would doubt its ability to tear into prey when the opportunity arose.

Is it really the person I'm thinking of?

Ding.

The elevator doors opened. In the sudden quiet, the sound felt unusually loud.

The man who stepped out made the secretary outside gasp softly—his presence hitting some instinctive nerve as she visibly flinched.

"Hello. I'm Jack Reacher. Is this Mr. Henry Brown's office?"

The secretary quickly composed herself. "Yes. Mr. Brown is expecting you inside." Though her voice betrayed a slight tremor.

The man didn't seem to notice. He knocked and entered.

Henry stood by his desk, extending a hand. "Hello, I'm Henry Brown. And you are?"

After a brief hesitation, the man shook his hand. "Jack Reacher. Lieutenant, U.S. Army Military Police Special Investigations Unit.

"Under orders, I'm to assist Mr. Tony Stark in an investigation. But I couldn't find him in New York. Instead, his secretary handed me a ticket to Los Angeles.

"She told me I'd get the information I need—and any necessary assistance—from the CEO of Stark Pictures. I hope this isn't some favor you pulled to drag me into personal business."

The warning was clear—Reacher already had some idea about Henry's current troubles.

At the same time, his gaze flicked toward Brian and Mark. The moment they heard "Military Police," their subtle discomfort was impossible to miss.

Henry stepped in smoothly. "They're my security team. Former Army Special Forces—retired. Not under your jurisdiction anymore.

"As for your assignment, I do know about it. I'll explain everything and provide the assistance you need. But I assure you—this isn't my personal matter."

Having set the tone, Henry didn't immediately continue. Instead, he turned to his own people.

"Sweetheart, what I'm about to discuss concerns Tony's private affairs. Without his permission, I can't share details.

"Why don't you head to the supermarket and pick out what you'd like for dinner? I'll cook when I get back."

"Alright, no problem." Having been trained by Katharine Hepburn herself, Charlize had developed a strong sense of boundaries. She didn't hesitate.

Brian also took the hint. "Charlize, do you have a car? I can give you a ride."

Mark stood up as well.

Of course, they were curious about anything involving Tony Stark—whether or not they'd report it to the CIA. But it was obvious Henry wouldn't discuss it in front of outsiders.

Better to leave on their own terms.

Chapter 491 491: Case Briefing

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After clearing out the office, Henry didn't forget to instruct his secretary. "Yulian, bring my guest a—" he paused and turned. "Coffee? Or tea?"

"Coffee, please."

"Yulian, a coffee for my guest. Knock before you come in." With that, Henry shut the office door.

He closed all the blinds, pulled down a projection screen, and switched on the projector. Returning to his desk, he began operating the computer.

"I didn't expect Tony Stark to send you to me," Henry said, "so I didn't prepare any hard copies. I'll walk you through everything via the projection. If there's anything you want printed afterward, let me know."

He paused, then looked up. "How many people know you came to see me?"

"In New York, only one of Tony Stark's secretaries. Here—your receptionist, your secretary, and the people who just left."

"Good. Then it's fine." Before continuing, Henry added, "Everything you hear today—I won't acknowledge it once you walk out that door. Don't ask, don't confirm. Understood?"

"Understood."

Henry tapped a few keys. The first image appeared on the screen—a newspaper clipping.

Jack Reacher didn't sit. Instead, he chose a position that gave him a clear, direct view of the screen. "This is the news about Howard Stark's car accident."

"Correct," Henry said. "A brilliant scientist and successful businessman with deep ties to the military—and numerous classified projects. On the night of December 16, 1991, Howard Stark and his wife both died in a car accident."

Reacher asked, "Tony Stark doubts the accident? Doesn't he have people who could investigate something like this?"

"He does," Henry replied. "And every report concludes the same thing—it was an accident. Cause: a defective brake system."

In truth, Tony hadn't handed over all the materials. Henry only had what he'd gathered on the West Coast.

But Henry hadn't played by the rules.

He had hacked into Tony Stark's virtual host on the supercomputer Hollywood Kid and found a neatly organized archive—S.H.I.E.L.D. reports, forensic autopsies, and prosecutor-certified death records.

He displayed them one by one.

"And because of that defect," Henry continued, "Tony bought the company that designed and manufactured the braking system. Fixed the flaw himself—then sold it at triple the price. A fine example of capitalist morality."

Reacher ignored the jab. "What made Tony suspicious enough to reopen the case—and request assistance from Military Police?"

"That," Henry said, "starts with why he made me CEO of Stark Pictures. Officially, it's a job. In reality, I've been monitoring things on the West Coast for him."

He proceeded chronologically, laying out everything he had uncovered regarding the Stark family.

Photos and supporting materials appeared on the screen. Audio recordings played where available.

Chapter 492 492: The Spy Watch

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Charlize smiled. "That would be great. I was just thinking I'd have to take a cab."

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Midway through, Yulian entered with coffee. With a single keystroke, Henry blanked the projection—keeping her out of the mess entirely.

What Henry presented was largely his own intelligence. As for the East Coast, most of it came from the pre-organized files Tony had conveniently left on that hackable system.

After some time, Henry finished.

"That's everything we currently know," he said.

"But as you've probably noticed—not all of it is backed by solid evidence. Some are hearsay. Some are personal deductions.

"And the worst part? Even the evidence that looks credible could be fabricated—to mislead or deceive.

"We don't know what's real and what's not. So when you investigate, be careful not to trip any alarms—assuming there is a conspiracy behind this."

After hearing a mountain of information, only to be told it might all be unreliable, Reacher didn't show it—but he was clearly processing.

Henry's reasoning was simple: if this was the Jack Reacher he knew—sharp, perceptive, methodical—then more information, even flawed, would still be useful.

Even false leads carried intent. Patterns. Motives.

Reacher would sort it out himself.

Reacher asked, "If you suspect a conspiracy, do you have any suspects?"

Henry pointed upward. "One percent of the U.S. population."

"That's too vague," Reacher said, frowning for the first time.

Henry answered seriously, "Do you know how many times Tony Stark has faced poisoning attempts and assassinations since taking over Stark Industries? None of that is public.

"And that's just the confirmed attempts. The suspected ones are even more numerous.

"That's why his security detail now consists of people he recruited off the street—people he personally trusts.

"In fact, if not for the collapse of the Red Empire just days after Howard Stark's death—drawing the attention of major players northward—Stark Industries might not have survived at all.

"Whether it was Obadiah Stane or Tony Stark himself pulling the strings, they were surrounded by wolves.

"Just like the Arden family now. Two leaders gone overnight. If you know anything about recent events, you'll know exactly what happened to them."

Reacher looked straight at him. "Was that you? The Arden couple?"

"Yes," Henry replied calmly. "They turned themselves into vampires. Which means their deaths leave no trace.

"Legally speaking, without complete surveillance footage as evidence, they're not dead. They're missing."

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After hearing Henry out, Jack Reacher said with a strange expression, "You just told me you killed the Ardens. What—planning to silence me afterward?"

Henry waved it off. "I already told you—once you walk out that door, I won't admit to anything.

"There's already a group of people claiming they saw me kill the Ardens and turn them to ash. They're on their way to psychiatric evaluation.

"Because if they don't end up in a psych ward, they'll be facing charges for false accusations, perjury, obstruction of justice, and malicious prosecution. One more person doesn't make a difference.

"Besides, in a murder case, the most important thing is a body—or any scientifically verifiable evidence. In this situation, even if I confessed in front of a prosecutor, I'd still walk free.

"Unless you plan to change the law—make killing vampires, who leave no bodies, a capital crime. Think about the consequences of that.

"You might as well just give prosecutors and judges the power to declare anyone a murderer on the spot. Saves you the trouble of defining what a vampire is—and who qualifies."

Reacher frowned. "Vampires are real?"

Henry laughed. "That's what you're focusing on? Fine—pretend they don't exist. I can't prove I killed two vampires anyway.

"All you need to know is this: James and Lilith Arden no longer exist. Legally, they're missing.

"And besides—" Henry looked him up and down, "—even if I wanted to silence you, unless I acted immediately, you'd have enough time to secure yourself.

"So there's no point. I'm just giving you as many leads as possible. You asked, I answered. That's all."

Reacher pressed, "But you also said none of this information is guaranteed to be true."

"At least what I personally experienced isn't false," Henry replied. "I told you exactly what I did."

"Even so," Reacher said, "you've only described your actions—not your motives."

Henry raised his hands in mock surrender. "Whoa there, buddy. I thought you weren't interested in my personal business—just the case your superiors assigned you.

"Howard Stark's death—that's your focus. Everything else is secondary. Besides, if you knew what those two vampires had done, would you still think I was wrong?"

Reacher answered coldly, "I'll make that judgment myself. You don't need to justify your actions like a vigilante."

Henry shrugged and let it go. Not everyone shared his worldview—and that was fine.

In fact, he doubted anyone timid or overly rigid could uncover the truth behind Howard Stark's death anyway.

"You said I could print the files?" Reacher asked, shifting focus.

"Yes. If you think it's necessary. But first—a warning. Some of these documents, if exposed, won't just lead to a hunt for the source of the leak. Anyone who's seen them could become a target. Be prepared."

"I understand."

Even so, Reacher printed everything.

Henry noticed—but chose not to interfere.

Reacher then added, "Stark's secretary mentioned you could provide support for the investigation."

Without hesitation, Henry stood, opened his safe, and took out three rolls of cash along with a vintage mechanical wristwatch. He set them on the table.

"Operating funds. And a survival tool.

"If you need weapons or equipment, tell me—I can arrange it. Or if you'd rather source them yourself, that's fine too.

Chapter 493 493: The End of '96

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Jack Reacher's investigation had no time limit, nor was it meant to attract attention.

So he could only conduct it quietly—digging into seemingly related matters during the gaps between his regular military duties.

On Henry's side, with Brian Mills and his team providing protection, he safely made it through the one-month bounty period imposed by the Continental Hotel.

Of everyone, the one who suffered the most during that month was Katy—the oversized "tabby cat."

Normally, Henry would take her out from time to time—camping, roaming, and letting her hunt a bit.

But with professional assassins watching him, there was no way Henry could safely take Katy outdoors. The big cat was thoroughly pent up.

"If you run out of money, just ask. No need for receipts or reimbursement paperwork. With Tony Stark footing the bill, you're not draining his fortune anytime soon."

Reacher picked up the watch, examining it. "This is the 'survival tool'?"

Henry nodded. "Tourbillon movement. Doesn't look like much, but it keeps time better than a Rolex—no need for daily adjustments. Water-resistant to fifty meters.

"But more importantly—it's a transmitter. It can be tracked, even log movement paths. The signal isn't standard—most people won't detect it.

"The crown—press it lightly once, you'll feel the first click. That activates a continuous distress signal.

"Press it further to the second stage—it triggers self-destruct. Ten-second delay. No warning sound.

"The explosive yield is limited by size, but trust me—you don't want it going off on your wrist.

"To cancel either function, press deeper to reset the crown."

Reacher held the watch thoughtfully. "If you're giving me something like this, it means this investigation could reach a point where I'll need it. Correct?"

Henry didn't answer directly. "If Howard Stark's death wasn't an accident, you don't think some random street punk pulled it off, do you?"

"Think about his world. Who could take someone like him down?"

Reacher didn't hesitate. He strapped the watch onto his left wrist.

"How long for support to reach me if I trigger the signal?"

"Three seconds," Henry said. "Faster than the self-destruct countdown.

"If you have time to press the distress signal, you won't die.

"After the mission, if you keep the watch, you'll still have one emergency response left. Whether there's a second... depends."

Reacher's eyes widened. "If you have someone like that on standby, why not send them to investigate instead?"

Henry smiled. "My friend isn't suited for this kind of work.

"And when it comes to clearing enemies inside buildings, someone skilled in close-quarters combat is better than... say, leveling the place with a tank."

Henry meant it as a metaphor.

Reacher replied flatly, "If there are no hostages, using a tank is the optimal approach.

"If a commander has access to overwhelming firepower but still sends troops into confined spaces full of potential traps—that's incompetence. Do I need to elaborate?"

...Henry had no comeback.

He'd forgotten—this man came from the modern U.S. military.

Overkill wasn't a problem.

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At one point, a foolish petty thief tried to break into Henry's home. He even brought a drugged meat bone, intending to poison Katy.

The result?

Katy bit down on his arm like it was a meat bone and shook it until it dislocated. Then she pinned him to the ground with a paw pressed against his cervical spine—ready to kill at any moment.

It wasn't until Henry returned from work that he rescued the thief—who had been reduced to a human cushion beneath Katy—and sent him off in an ambulance, escorted by police.

Naturally, Henry bore no responsibility for the break-in.

Old Gary, however, was shaken. Incidents like this were rare in his building. And by experience, once it happened, another wouldn't be far behind.

He had to go out and "talk" to certain people—issuing warnings.

Henry didn't point out that the intruder wasn't an ordinary thief. After all, how many street punks carried Continental gold coins in their pockets?

Considering the man's arm would take a long time to recover—if it ever did—and that he'd been so terrified he wet himself and suffered a mental breakdown, Henry decided not to pursue the matter.

After all, you couldn't hold someone accountable when they weren't even mentally present.

When the one-month period ended, Brian and his team completed their assignment.

Henry didn't renew their contract. These seasoned professionals had their own affiliations—long-term commitments wouldn't be allowed.

Besides, the grace period was over. If Continental assassins showed up again, Henry intended to deal with them personally. Having others around would only get in the way.

Fortunately, things unfolded just as Charlie Fisher had hinted.

Once the month ended, the Continental withdrew the bounty.

Partly because the Arden family's follow-up offer... was only ten thousand dollars.

In October, Charlize Theron's film That Thing You Do! was successfully released.

Then, in late November, came the comedy Jingle All the Way, starring Arnold Schwarzenegger, where Charlize played a sharp, capable policewoman.

Compared to Henry's memories from before his transmigration, both films saw slight improvements at the box office.

That Thing You Do! originally had a production budget of \$26 million, barely recouping its costs domestically, with a global total of about \$34.5 million—technically a loss.

But in this world, boosted by Charlize's rising popularity, it performed slightly better: domestic earnings surpassed its budget, and global box office reached around \$45 million.

Still a loss—but a smaller one.

It was hard to say how much of that extra \$10 million could be credited to Charlize.

However, the film's flaws made one thing clear: Tom Hanks, despite being a two-time Oscar-winning actor, might be better suited as a producer than a director.

As for Jingle All the Way, its box office rose from \$129 million in Henry's memory to nearly \$150 million.

Given its estimated budget of \$60–75 million, it was a clear commercial success.

These two films helped Charlize gain more influence in a project that would prove pivotal to her career—

The Devil's Advocate.

Although the film's spotlight was on its two male leads—Al Pacino and Keanu Reeves—this was Charlize's first time starring as a leading actress.

Before securing the role, she had gone through four auditions. Even after filming began, her position wasn't entirely secure.

Director Taylor Hackford worried that her beauty might make it difficult for audiences to sympathize with her character—who was meant to reflect the protagonist's tragedy, not just serve as eye candy.

Filming began on October 28, 1996, in New York.

But early production hit a snag.

Al Pacino—who had already turned down the role five times—clashed with the production, causing a temporary halt.

This conflict even destabilized the rest of the cast (except Keanu Reeves). If Pacino walked away, the director's dream lineup might collapse entirely.

Chapter 494 494: Progress in Analyzing Alien Technology

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While Charlize Theron was busy filming in New York, Henry wasn't idle back in Los Angeles.

The subsea methane power generators and the small-scale natural gas chemical plant had already begun operations. Meanwhile, the underwater laboratory was steadily taking shape, and certain... less presentable—well, alien-related—research projects were gradually being relocated there.

Most importantly, both Kree storage crystals and Skrull storage crystals were now operational, solving the previous limitation where only one crystal could be read at a time.

With the ability to cross-reference data instantly, Henry made significant progress in studying and understanding the technologies of both alien civilizations.

In particular, the encyclopedic knowledge obtained from the Skrulls provided detailed explanations. Even for technologies he couldn't replicate due to material limitations, he now had references for downgraded designs.

To appease the Oscar-winning actor—still riding high after Scent of a Woman—Charlize organized a dinner.

Henry attended as well—and even invited Katharine Hepburn.

The three of them worked together to smooth things over, successfully persuading Pacino to stay.

It wasn't easy.

A method actor of Italian descent, raised in a single-parent household, Pacino had endured years of poverty and frustration before success.

Now, freshly crowned with an Oscar, he was at the peak of his ego.

Without careful handling—almost like dealing with a child—he wouldn't budge.

Fortunately, Katharine Hepburn, a veteran who had seen every kind of actor imaginable, took the lead in calming him down.

Of course, it might also have been that Pacino was willing to give a legendary figure like her some respect.

While filming in New York, Charlize stayed with Katharine Hepburn, who took great care of her—going so far as to use her remaining influence to support her.

Between her positive reception in two films and her role in stabilizing the production, Charlize finally secured her footing in The Devil's Advocate.

In Henry's original timeline, Charlize had once been deported during filming due to visa issues.

But here, that never happened.

Her work visa had been handled by Stark Pictures—something Henry had made a point to ensure, so her career could proceed without disruption.

The only minor inconvenience was distance.

With Charlize filming in New York, they could only meet if Henry flew over.

It wasn't about pride or imbalance—it was simply practical.

Henry had more flexibility, while Charlize was extremely busy.

During filming, she spent an hour every day with a psychiatrist, studying how to portray schizophrenia. On top of that, her finances weren't yet strong enough to support frequent cross-country flights.

Henry visiting her made more sense.

And when he did, he could also spend time with Katharine Hepburn.

The three of them even spent Christmas together.

Charlize also invited her mother—marking Henry's first meeting with his future mother-in-law.

And so, life moved forward steadily...

Into 1997.

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If Earth lacked certain materials and couldn't fully reproduce alien technology, then using available Earth materials to create downgraded versions—so long as they still surpassed current human technology—was enough to make them practical.

That said, Henry placed greater emphasis on advancements in processing and manufacturing.

Not all alien technology relied on materials unavailable on Earth. Much of the gap lay in manufacturing techniques, allowing Kree and Skrull components to outperform their Earth-made counterparts.

For example, in Project Pegasus, the faster-than-light engine developed by Kree scientist Mar-Vell (Dr. Wendy Lawson) used the Tesseract as its energy source—but the engine itself was built entirely from Earth-origin materials.

So why couldn't others achieve the same performance with the same materials?

The answer lay in Kree materials science—not just alloy composition, but the conditions and processes under which materials were handled.

Take something as simple as tightening a screw.

Doing so at 45°C, room temperature, or low temperatures would produce different results due to thermal expansion. The precision of the connection would vary.

Should the temperature be adjusted during assembly?

How many times should an alloy be quenched?

To what temperature should it be cooled?

Under what environmental conditions should a component be assembled to achieve maximum fit?

Earth had only just begun to scratch the surface of precision engineering. Compared to the accumulated knowledge of the Kree and Skrulls, it was still far behind.

Henry's previous mindset had been simple: if the screw fits, it's assembled. If it doesn't, drill a hole or weld it.

But such methods couldn't fully utilize material performance.

In high-stress applications, weak joints would reduce the overall limits of a component.

Think of a car engine: assembled one way, it might fail at 10,000 RPM. But with optimal assembly conditions and techniques, the same engine could reach 12,000 RPM—or higher.

And these optimal processes weren't discovered through brute-force trial and error. Both civilizations had developed formulas.

By inputting material properties—curvature, thermal expansion coefficients, melting points, and more—into these models, they could calculate:

The ideal processing method

The optimal environmental conditions

The exact force required

The precise positioning needed

Some processes even required specific atmospheric compositions. For instance, the surrounding air during welding could affect joint strength.

These differences might seem negligible—but they ultimately determined a component's strength, durability, and performance limits.

What surprised Henry most was the presence of advanced metalworking techniques in Kree technology—including methods for processing exotic materials like vibranium and uru, along with their alloy formulas.

Thinking about it, it made sense.

Ronan the Accuser's hammer—officially called the Universal Weapon—was capable of housing the Power Stone, one of the Infinity Stones.

This weapon could absorb and project energy, manipulate matter, generate force fields, control gravity, and even affect time and teleportation.

A device capable of such feats clearly couldn't be made with ordinary metallurgy.

There was even a comic concept—true or not—that this weapon, sometimes called a Cosmic Rod, wasn't unique to Ronan but standard equipment for members of the Kree Accuser Corps.

In one What If universe, Ronan even used it to kill Thanos.

So encountering these advanced metalworking methods in Kree data wasn't surprising—it was expected of a civilization at that level.

Chapter 495 495: Underlying Currents

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In March 1997, filming for The Devil's Advocate in New York was nearing completion for Charlize Theron. The production would soon move to Florida for a second round of shooting.

This was also Charlize's first experience with a production schedule stretching over several months. And this wasn't even an action blockbuster—just a dialogue-driven film.

One could easily imagine how demanding the director was regarding every detail in front of the camera. It wasn't just about expressions or acting—if blocking didn't align with lighting, the entire shot had to be redone.

Charlize's long-honed acting skills finally had room to shine in this film.

Whether acting opposite Keanu Reeves—who rose to fame with Speed (1994)—or Al Pacino, a seasoned Academy Award-winning actor, Charlize held her ground without falling behind.

She neither tried to overshadow her co-stars nor faltered like a nervous rookie in the face of Pacino's commanding presence.

Her performance earned not only the director's approval but even a rare word of praise from Pacino himself. As for the other actresses hoping to shake her position—they had no chance.

The reason Henry hadn't seen such equipment before was simple: he had only encountered soldiers and commanders—not elite individuals capable of wielding such gear.

Naturally, what he saw were standard-issue tools, not specialized "hero-tier" equipment. That alone suggested these materials weren't abundant enough for mass deployment.

Beyond materials and manufacturing, another major focus for Henry was superconductivity.

However, this area was far more complex and heavily reliant on materials not found on Earth. For now, he couldn't fully understand it—nor could he design downgraded substitutes.

Another critical area was energy.

Mar-Vell's work on Earth had centered on the Tesseract—more precisely, the Space Stone within it.

But that kind of power source was far too dangerous. Henry had no intention of touching it.

What he needed were energy systems that were:

Reproducible

Scalable

Stable

Unlike Iron Man's arc reactor concept—carrying a power source on one's body—advanced civilizations placed greater emphasis on "batteries."

For instance, in Guardians of the Galaxy Vol. 2, the Anulax Batteries of the Sovereign—used by Rocket to destroy Ego—were among the most powerful energy sources in the Marvel universe.

The energy stored in such devices wasn't simple electricity, but a higher-order energy form with greater efficiency and lower transmission loss.

The physics behind it went far beyond quantum mechanics—into deeper, more advanced domains.

Studying these systems broadened Henry's understanding—and even gave him new insights into the cosmic energy associated with the Eternals.

His super brain absorbed all of this like a sponge.

And as he continued unlocking alien knowledge, the blueprint for his underwater laboratory was constantly revised and refined.

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Around the same time, another film wrapped shooting—Titanic. This marked the beginning of post-production.

James Cameron's Digital Domain even dispatched key personnel to station themselves at the "Hollywood Kid" supercomputing center.

Led by Scott Ross from Industrial Light & Magic and long-time Cameron collaborator, special effects expert Stan Winston, they worked alongside Stark Pictures' newly established CGI department to begin visual effects design.

The physics engine developed during filming had already reached a certain level of maturity. Now it was time to test it in real production and continue refining it.

As for Henry, the CEO of Stark Pictures—he remained hidden behind Git, occasionally offering guidance to various departments when they encountered technical challenges. In short, he showed up as little as possible.

On the surface, Henry's life in the Marvel Universe seemed to be falling into place.

His career was thriving. A beautiful partner stood by his side. His research into alien technology was progressing steadily, and his underwater laboratory was officially operational.

Though nothing groundbreaking had yet been produced, the technology he possessed had already broken free from the limits of Earth's science and was advancing into the realm of black tech.

It almost felt like all that was left was buying a big house and having a chubby kid—then life would be complete. Who cared how dangerous the Marvel Universe was? As long as this life was comfortable.

But of course—things were never that simple for a Kryptonian.

First of all, Charlize's career hadn't yielded the expected results.

On April 14, a TV movie Hollywood Confidential aired as a pilot on Paramount's UPN network, testing its potential as a series.

Then came another blow.

On May 30, Trial and Error premiered—a comedy starring veteran actors Michael Richards and Jeff Daniels.

This marked Charlize Theron's first leading role in a major film. Although the project was secured after The Devil's Advocate, it was completed and released earlier.

Unfortunately, the results were disappointing.

Despite decent reviews, the film—made with a \$25 million budget—only grossed around \$14.5 million at the box office. A significant loss.

That said, the failure couldn't entirely be blamed on the cast.

Because just one week earlier, on May 23, The Lost World: Jurassic Park had been released.

With a \$75 million budget, it grossed a staggering \$618.6 million worldwide.

Charlize's film hadn't failed—it had simply been crushed under the feet of dinosaurs.

Even Superman couldn't have saved that situation. He might be able to save the world, but he couldn't control what movies people chose to watch.

Charlize barely had time to dwell on the failure. By July, she was back on set for The Devil's Advocate, with production shifting from New York to Jacksonville, Florida.

Meanwhile, another major Stark Pictures investment wasn't making things easy for Henry either.

Don't assume that just because a tyrant leaves the set, he suddenly becomes lovable.

Once Titanic entered post-production, James Cameron personally took charge. After realizing how useful Henry was, he practically camped out—dragging Henry into work every single day.

He even got familiar with the tiger, Katy—so much so that using the tiger to scare him off was no longer an option.

And whenever Henry tried to slack off, Cameron would bring up Stark Pictures' \$65 million investment.

If they didn't want the film to lose money, then every frame had to be perfected.

It was a perfect demonstration of a universal truth—whoever owes money is the one in charge.

Thus, the elusive CEO who once hid behind Git now showed up diligently every day at the "Hollywood Kid" supercomputing center—becoming a running joke for Tony Stark.

Every time Tony called, he would enthusiastically ask about post-production progress—not because he cared about the film, but because he wanted to enjoy the spectacle.

Even if the movie ended up losing everything, Tony would still find it amusing.

Chapter 496 496: The Returning Aliens

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In 1997, in Bristol, England, a group that had once left Earth returned once more.

To avoid S.H.I.E.L.D.'s surveillance, Nick Fury chose to meet these "old friends" across the Atlantic. The eye that had been scratched blind by the Flerken couldn't help but itch again.

They gathered inside an abandoned building that had once been a blues bar.

The leader of the Skrulls, General Talos, met Fury using the appearance of Agent Keller, the director of S.H.I.E.L.D.'s Los Angeles office.

Two old comrades—both allies and adversaries—shook hands in greeting.

"Talos."

"Fury."

"You finally got my name right," Nick Fury grinned.

"Your friends all call you Fury, don't they?" Talos replied with a knowing smile.

After releasing the handshake, Fury asked, "Are all your people here?"

"Yes. According to our scientists' calculations, all Skrulls exceeding the life-support capacity of the cruiser are here—including my wife and daughter."

Gesturing behind him, Talos said, "Come, say hello to Fury."

Fury greeted them first. "Soren. G'iah."

After all, as a boss who spent his days surrounded by beautiful women and only worked when he felt like it, nothing annoyed him more than subordinates who slacked off while still drawing a salary.

How could anyone live more comfortably than him?

It got to the point where Henry seriously considered sending James Cameron to the moon. Forget shouting "I'm the king of the world" at the Oscars—why not engrave "I gazed upon all of Earth" on his tombstone instead?

Beyond work, the dark world was anything but calm.

The fall of the Aiden family caused old-money elites who had once considered aligning with vampires to withdraw quickly.

This dealt a blow to the vampires—whether large or small.

According to Jewish business principles: money not yet earned is already considered a loss. From that perspective, the vampires had taken a major hit.

How could beings who believed themselves to be the rightful rulers of Earth accept that?

They had never realized that it was the hidden rules of the Camarilla protecting them. Instead, they believed they ruled their own little world—and by extension, should rule the entire planet.

On top of that, the disdain of old money and the increasing aggression of vampire hunters further agitated them.

Where there is oppression, there is resistance.

Radical young vampires began joining forces with the turned vampires—long discriminated against by the purebloods—becoming increasingly reckless.

Some even used temporary sunscreen ointments to walk openly in daylight, launching attacks on vampire hunters who never expected assaults during the day.

These attacks unfolded in full view of the public. Even those responsible for covering up such incidents were growing dissatisfied.

Henry, who had previously stayed out of the spotlight, was finally noticed due to his connection with the Aiden couple.

Though not yet a primary target—since he posed less of a threat than vampire hunters—he was no longer invisible.

The unrest in the dark world was beginning to spill into ordinary life in Los Angeles.

Just as Henry began considering how to escalate his actions against the vampires, another event—far more consequential to the Marvel Universe—was quietly unfolding across the Atlantic.

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As a mother, Soren couldn't simply hide behind others like her daughter. She stepped forward and warmly grasped Fury's hand.

"When our scientists told us that the loss of the genetic seed bank we brought from our homeworld would cause food production to decline, we realized we could only rely on primitive cultivation methods.

"But that meant we could no longer sustain everyone aboard the ship. You can't imagine how desperate we were.

"Fortunately, you were willing to accept Carol Danvers' proposal and take in part of our population. That allowed those on the ship to survive and gave us more time to search for a new home.

"I hope you understand how much this means to us."

Fury smiled. "Out of humanitarian concern and goodwill, it's the right thing to do. But you must also understand—Earth isn't ready to accept aliens. We can't take in too many. This is only a temporary measure."

Talos nodded. "Of course. Until we find a new home. Earth isn't ours, after all."

"Since you agree to that," Fury said casually, "I assume you won't object to another condition."

This time, Talos didn't concede so easily. "I specifically chose individuals who are mentally prepared for this kind of arrangement as temporary migrants.

"But you must understand—leadership isn't based on status. It's based on ability and vision. If you want them to follow you, you'll have to convince them yourself."

Fury raised an eyebrow theatrically. "Wow. I didn't know even your military runs on democracy."

"Are you looking for soldiers?" Talos countered. "Are you planning to lead us into battle?"

"...Fair enough. That's not my goal."

Talos gestured toward the gathered Skrulls, standing in small groups in their natural green forms. "Then you'll have to speak to them."

Fury looked around. "G'iah is here with her parents—that I understand. But there are other children here too? Farah, this is your...?"

Beside a teenage Skrull stood an elderly one—Farah. She answered on his behalf.

"This is Gravik. A very capable boy.

"His parents were killed by the Kree. He escaped alone, piloting a ship by himself. There's anger in him—anger that needs an outlet.

"He's not suited to remain on the cruiser helping search for a new home. So tell me, Fury—do you have what it takes to control that anger? To turn it into strength?"

Learning the boy's story, Fury dropped his earlier casual tone and spoke seriously.

"Kid, I understand your pain. I'm sorry you've had to witness the cruelty of war at such a young age.

"I understand your desire for revenge. But there are no Kree here—no enemies for you to fight. And I won't throw you into a battlefield that isn't yours. That wouldn't be right.

"I'm not here to control you or order you around. But I believe you won't refuse training—to become a skilled hunter, a warrior... someone who can control his anger and understand his purpose.

"You don't need someone to douse that fire inside you. But keeping that flame alive—letting it burn into a blaze at the right time, instead of hurting those around you at the wrong time—that's something worth striving for."

The boy's eyes showed a hint of resolve.

Fury stepped forward and pressed his forehead against Gravik's in a gesture of familiarity common among Skrulls.

Judging by the boy's lack of resistance, Fury knew he had passed the first test.

He didn't seize the moment to address the entire group.

Because what worked for Gravik wouldn't necessarily work for others.

So he waited—for Talos's signal.

Chapter 497 497: The King of Agents Steps In

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Now it was Nick Fury's turn to speak. From Talos's opening remarks, he had already picked up on certain undertones.

The Skrulls were not an easy group to tame—but that was only natural.

For a people who constantly changed their appearance, infiltrated enemy factions, and lived under the threat of powerful pursuers, how could they possibly be submissive, waiting for orders in everything and afraid to make their own decisions?

People like that wouldn't last three days—they'd end up hanging in a cage.

Not to mention, they came from a civilization far more advanced than Earth.

Fury had no intention of changing that nature or turning them into obedient soldiers who followed orders without question. He wasn't a general, and he didn't need blind followers.

What he intended to do was far more difficult.

"Friends," Fury began in a relaxed tone—very different from how he had spoken to Gravik. "The first time Talos and I met...

"Well, the first friendly meeting, at least—I believed that humans and Skrulls could build a strong partnership, based on fairness and mutual benefit.

"Because we both know we're not the kind of people who are bloodthirsty, ruthless, and willing to do anything—no matter the cost to others—to achieve our goals.

"Of course, at the beginning, we probably did think that about each other. We just didn't know each other well enough yet. Thankfully, we both proved we weren't that kind of bastards."

Fury's humor was picked up smoothly by Talos, who chuckled along. The uneasy Skrulls below gradually relaxed and joined in the laughter.

"But friends!" Fury suddenly raised his voice, drawing everyone's attention back.

"What you've been through tells me one thing—the universe is dangerous.

"Earth, still behind in technology, cannot stand on equal footing with you, let alone fight an interstellar war. We don't even have a unified global government. We're divided into hundreds of nations—some allied, some hostile."

As their leader, Talos also needed to formally introduce Fury. Cooperation was inevitable, but how the first step was taken would shape everything that followed.

Talos gathered the Skrulls and spoke:

"My people, we all know why we are here.

"We have scattered across the universe in search of a place to belong. But all we have encountered is the violence of the Kree.

"We have lost much—not just a home, but our families... even everything, until all that remains is ourselves.

"But in our despair, we found a glimmer of hope. Our friend Carol Danvers made us a promise. And because of survival... because of her request... we have returned to this world.

"But we all understand—everything has a cost. The question is who pays it, and whether they do so willingly.

"My first friend on Earth, Nick Fury, has offered us shelter.

"You must understand—for the sake of my family, and for all of you, I do not trust outsiders easily. But he is different. I believe he can be trusted—and I hope you will offer him the same trust.

"At the very least, we can give him the respect of hearing him out.

"Do not think of this as humiliation or coercion. We still have a choice.

"But remember—every choice carries a price. There is no such thing as a free meal in this world.

"And Skrulls are not a people to be forced.

"The Kree could not break us. No one can.

"Our decisions come from our own noble will—guided by justice and dignity."

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"Both Carol Danvers and I have promised to help you find a new, safe home. But that's not something that can be achieved overnight. Whether it's us or you, it will take time and effort.

"That's why you're here today. Why you've come to Earth. These are necessary compromises—for a better future."

"So here, I ask for your help.

"Help me reduce the conflicts on this planet. Help resolve meaningless disputes. By helping us, you're also helping yourselves.

"Maybe you won't be able to walk under the sun in your true forms. Maybe you'll have to wear disguises to blend into this world.

"But I still ask you to stand with me—to work together for tomorrow, for a future we can all believe in."

As the leader of the Skrulls, Talos couldn't speak at this moment—it would look like he was making the decision for everyone.

But his wife, Soren, had no such restriction.

She stepped forward simply and said, "I'm willing to help you, Fury."

As she spoke, her green Skrull form shifted into that of a brown-haired human woman.

"Thank you," Fury said sincerely.

With one person stepping forward, others followed—then more, until all the Skrulls Talos had brought transformed into human appearances, signaling their willingness to support Fury's cause.

The King of Agents on Earth had officially stepped onto the stage.

No one would have imagined that such a title would be built on the foundation of a group of shapeshifters.

On the first day of their alliance, Fury had no intention of treating them like expendable labor and scattering them across the world immediately.

There were too many things to organize—assignments, communication channels, roles. Though he had prepared several contingency plans, only real execution would determine what worked.

So the first day—perhaps the last day these Skrulls would truly relax—was spent settling them in.

Good food, good rest.

Calling it a "last meal" before execution would be excessive—but if you wanted a horse to run well, you fed it first.

Expecting results before providing support? That was how you got failure.

Barbara Morse assisted Fury in handling the Skrulls' affairs. She was familiar with them, having dealt with them before—regardless of whether those encounters had been friendly.

But she was no longer the naive college student she once was, tricked into doing black ops work while thinking she was officially employed.

She knew very well—Fury's dealings with the Skrulls were completely off the books.

After spending time entertaining and reassuring the group—forcing smiles until her face nearly stiffened—Barbara finally approached Fury and complained:

"If it weren't for your old man's dying wish telling me to look after you, I wouldn't be dealing with this mess."

Mention of that old man made Fury frown slightly. "Don't use him to pressure me. Building my own network was his idea too.

"And these people were sent over by Carol. What was I supposed to do—ignore them?

"Better they operate under my watch than infiltrate Earth without us knowing. I've made it clear with the Skrulls—how many come, who they are—I keep track of all of it.

"If they break that agreement... well, an angry Captain Marvel isn't something anyone wants to deal with."

Barbara asked bluntly, "When you find them a habitable planet, will they really leave? And can you even find one?"

Her distrust of the Skrulls was still evident.

Fury replied, "Anything the Skrull Empire can find, the Kree Empire can find too. That's why they've been running—and the Kree keep hunting them.

Chapter 498 498: Each with Their Own Calculations

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Barbara Morse asked, "Is that why you chose to support her? Even with such... unreasonable demands?"

Nick Fury spread his hands. "Powerful people have the privilege of being willful. She believes she can handle the worst-case scenario, so no one can stop her from choosing her path—even if it comes with greater risk.

"But our opinions, and the risks we bear, don't need to factor into her decision-making, do they? As long as nothing goes wrong and no accidents happen, we get the ideal outcome."

Hearing more complaint than explanation, Barbara looked slightly awkward. "So you don't agree with Lieutenant Danvers' approach?"

"That's not the point. The person making the decision doesn't consider our opinions. Whether I agree or not—does it matter?"

...Alright, that was definitely a complaint.

Barbara continued, "Didn't you discuss it with her?"

Fury sighed. "Because of the Kree, her current stance is to help the Skrulls. She's gone from one extreme to another.

"You can't persuade someone like that to let go. The only thing we can do is go along with her and keep the risks contained—otherwise she might fully side with the Skrulls and cut ties with Earth."

Barbara said in surprise, "But she still has friends here... memories..."

"If she decided to meet them behind our backs, we couldn't stop her anyway."

"So you knowingly accepted the Skrulls despite their hidden agenda—and didn't tell Danvers?" Barbara pressed.

Fury replied casually, "In international politics, countries often grant asylum. Is it because those people are good? Worthy? No—many are criminals, even murderers.

"But if they have political value, they're worth protecting. Whether the Skrulls have ulterior motives—I believe they do. But do they have value? I believe they do as well."

Barbara stared at him. "You're just working with them like that? Aren't you afraid they'll find out what you're thinking?"

Fury chuckled. "Earlier I said Talos and I agreed the other wasn't a bastard. Truth is—we both know the other is a bastard.

"And that's exactly why we can cooperate. Compared to that, Carol Danvers is too upright—which makes things more complicated."

Barbara was stunned into silence. After a moment, she muttered, "The adult world is... really dirty."

"Compared to those two empires, do you really think Earth can discover a habitable planet neither of them has found?"

Barbara caught the implication immediately. "You think they've set their sights on Earth?"

"Even if not for immediate colonization, it's probably on their list of options."

"Then why haven't they acted?"

"Because of Captain Marvel," Fury said flatly. "What other reason could there be?

"Without her protection, they can't stand against Kree pursuers. So they have to comply with her demands.

"As long as she remains important, they won't risk angering her by targeting Earth."

Barbara narrowed her eyes. "So if her importance changes... their stance might change too?"

"Exactly."

Fury resisted the itch beneath his eyepatch and continued, "But that possibility is small. You saw what Carol can do—destroying alien missiles with her bare body, taking down an entire warship alone.

"Power like that is rare even in the universe. Talos and his people know it too.

"That's why they're holding onto her so tightly."

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Fury said seriously, "And that's what determines whether you're just another pawn—or someone who plays the game.

"The old man saw something in you. Don't waste it. If you want to do the right thing but don't have someone like Carol's power to make others willingly follow you—then you need the intelligence to influence everything."

After a moment of struggle, Barbara asked her final question:

"Will the Skrulls continue targeting Henry?"

Fury let out a short laugh. "Still worried about him, huh? Don't worry—General Talos promised me they won't target Henry Brown again. That was one of the conditions for letting them come to Earth."

Seeing her calm down, Fury said no more and turned back to speak with the Skrulls.

Many of them he already knew how to handle. Others were new—he needed time to understand their abilities and how best to use them.

As for Skrull technology... he was quite interested. No need to waste potential scientists by turning them all into spies—if there were any among them.

Meanwhile, on the other side, the Skrulls—centered around General Talos—were having a private discussion.

"Priscilla, you'll be responsible for liaising with Nick Fury from now on."

The named Skrull woman understood the implication immediately. She was one of the few among them without a partner.

"You want me to form a relationship with him?" she asked.

"Yes."

"But from my observations, that human isn't easily influenced. Perhaps impersonating him directly would be more effective."

"Our history shows that certain individuals can't be replaced so easily," Talos replied. "Some figures become what they are not because of status or power—but because of their ability and intellect."

"You think Nick Fury is one of those people?"

"Yes," Talos said firmly. "And he is also the only link between us, Earth, and Carol Danvers.

"If something happens to him, do you think Carol wouldn't notice? Maybe we could deceive her for a time—but once exposed, how would she react?

"The biggest reason she helps us isn't sympathy—it's what the Kree did to her that shaped her stance.

"So Fury must not be harmed—at least not by us. Otherwise, we risk losing our greatest ally. Someone who can drive back Ronan the Accuser's fleet alone is not someone to take lightly."

After hearing this, Priscilla said, "But you should also understand—he's not someone easily swayed. If he truly possesses the qualities you described, then if he

does fall for me... wouldn't that prove he doesn't?"

"I know," Talos replied. "But that's not my goal. You only need to get close to him.

"I'll have others investigate his past and preferences. As long as you don't make him dislike you, you've succeeded.

"With your personality, given enough time, no one remains unaffected."

Priscilla gave a bitter smile. "I'm not a trained spy. Have you considered that I might actually fall for him? I might not be able to follow your orders then."

"That's precisely why I chose you," Talos said frankly. "If you were professionally trained, he'd see through the manipulation.

"Sometimes, too much training becomes a flaw. If he accepts you, then when decisions arise, he'll naturally consider the Skrulls more. That's enough.

"What I fear most is him driving a wedge between us and Carol Danvers. In the end, she's human—not one of us.

"That is your true mission."

Understanding at last, Priscilla nodded. "I know what to do."

Chapter 499 499: The Film Premiere

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On October 17, Charlize Theron's film The Devil's Advocate premiered in North America. However, its premiere event had already been held on the 13th at a theater in Westwood, California.

The reason was simple—budget constraints.

To secure Al Pacino, an Academy Award-winning actor, even Keanu Reeves, who co-starred as the male lead, voluntarily took a pay cut so the production budget wouldn't have to be slashed. Only then could they afford an actor of Pacino's caliber.

As for Charlize Theron's salary... compared to the two male leads, it was practically pocket change. Even if she volunteered a pay cut, it wouldn't have made much difference.

The pay disparity faced by actresses in Hollywood was evident.

That said, a premiere wasn't the place for complaints.

Charlize Theron appeared on the red carpet alongside the two male leads, wearing a red, form-fitting evening gown that accentuated her figure, paired with her sharp short blonde hair.

Since this wasn't an especially grand or formal premiere, the two male leads dressed more casually.

Al Pacino, the center of attention, wore an all-black suit with a black shirt and black leather shoes, paired with a loosely tied red-and-green striped tie—far from the stiff, suffocating formal look.

Keanu Reeves' outfit was even simpler: casual clothes, scruffy stubble, and a knit cap. His signature air of melancholy was already beginning to show—completely different from his polished on-screen image.

As for Charlize...

From the neck down, her look was stunning—the red gown, her toned figure, bronze skin, and short golden hair, all results of recent filming work.

But above the neck... was another story.

Her face was caked in heavy white foundation, creating a stark contrast with her skin tone. Add to that bright red lipstick matching her dress—striking, certainly, though perhaps not in the best way.

Henry had already taken his seat inside the theater.

Though The Devil's Advocate was produced by Regency Enterprises and distributed by Warner Bros., and Stark Pictures had no investment in it, getting a premiere ticket as the studio's CEO was effortless.

After finishing the red carpet and interviews, Charlize Theron came over and sat beside Henry. The two exchanged a light, fleeting kiss.

Looking at her boyish short blonde hair, Henry smiled. "Looks like filming for Mighty Joe Young is done. Doesn't seem like you've gotten any rest, though."

"And whose fault is that?" she shot back. "I barely had a few days off before diving into prep for the next film."

"Even so, couldn't you have put a bit more effort into your look?"

Concerned about her public image, Charlize immediately checked herself. "Is something wrong? I took a whole day off just to do makeup and try on outfits."

Henry, clearly courting death, reached out and lightly scraped her cheek with his finger—coming away with a thick layer of white foundation.

"Wow... did you apply this with a cement trowel? When you take it off later, will you need a hammer? Look at me—didn't I just get a mouthful of powder from that kiss?"

As he spoke, he puckered his lips and leaned in again.

At that moment, another Skrull asked, "What about the Kryptonian?"

Talos waved it off. "Ignore him. That was an unnecessary complication on your part.

"I've reviewed his profile on Earth—he's harmless.

"Now that we're cooperating with humans, avoid unnecessary actions that could jeopardize the relationship. Besides, he's only one person—what impact could he possibly have?"

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"You bastard!" Charlize laughed, clawing at his face with one hand and pushing him away.

While the couple joked around, the two male leads approached.

"Henry."

"Mr. Brown."

They quickly stood, and Henry shook hands with each of them. "Mr. Pacino, Mr. Reeves."

The Italian-American Pacino spoke first, warmly. "That chef you had last time—absolutely incredible. When do I get to enjoy that again?"

"Your praise would make Chef Washington very happy," Henry replied with a smile. "I'll have someone coordinate with your assistant to arrange another proper dinner. Good food deserves time to be savored—not rushed between appointments."

"Wow, that sounds fantastic. Don't forget to call me. And—mind if I bring a friend?" Pacino said, slinging an arm around Keanu Reeves' shoulder.

"Of course not," Henry said. "Mr. Reeves, you're more than welcome."

Details like guest numbers, dietary restrictions, and allergies could be handled by assistants later. Pacino clearly wasn't the type to fuss over such things.

No wonder he'd later go bankrupt and end up taking on terrible roles to recover financially. Dealing with lawyers and accountants required a sharper mind—something he didn't quite prioritize.

Still, someone like him was worth befriending. He was generous and unlikely to undermine others without cause.

Keanu Reeves, standing beside him, gave off a similar impression—someone worth knowing.

After chatting briefly, Pacino wandered off to mingle with others.

Reeves, though less outgoing, was still quite talkative. Smiling, he said, "Actually, there's something I'd like to ask you about, Mr. Brown."

"Just call me Henry. And if you don't mind, I'll call you K.C.—I hear that's what people call you."

"Of course. I'm honored... Henry."

"Great. So, what can I help you with?"

Reeves said, "It's about Jean Baudrillard's Simulacra and Simulation. Charlize shared some really fascinating interpretations—I asked her, and she said most of them came from you.

"I've also been studying Kevin Kelly's machine philosophy and Dylan Evans' work on evolutionary psychology. I've been struggling to find someone to discuss these with."

Charlize added, "Yeah, I've got the same assignments. But I don't get why we need to study philosophy just to make a movie."

Henry replied, "It's probably the director's intent. If you understand the underlying ideas, your performance won't drift away from that vision."

After wrapping up Mighty Joe Young, Charlize would begin preparation for another film alongside Keanu Reeves.

That film was The Matrix, the late-20th-century classic directed and produced by the Wachowski brothers—who would later become the Wachowski sisters.

J.J. Harris had already arranged for Charlize to audition.

Originally, the female lead was Carrie-Anne Moss, a Canadian actress with nearly a decade of experience in television and film.

Henry didn't dislike the original casting. But when the Wachowskis came to discuss computer-generated effects, he couldn't resist inserting himself into the casting conversation.

At the time, Industrial Light & Magic—founded by George Lucas for Star Wars—was still the undisputed leader in visual effects.

But by the 1990s, ILM had somewhat lost focus. Its manager, Scott Ross, left to co-found Digital Domain with James Cameron.

For Titanic, directed by Cameron, Digital Domain had chosen to collaborate with Stark Pictures—a fact well known in Hollywood.

After all, few could match Stark Pictures' extravagance—having access to supercomputers thanks to Stark Industries. Even ILM envied that.

Though Titanic's visuals hadn't yet been publicly revealed, they were enough to attract the Wachowskis for a visit.

Without violating any agreements, Henry gave them a "demonstration of firepower," secured a collaboration—and successfully landed the female lead role for Charlize.

After all, with her physical training, willingness to perform action scenes, and determination, she was already high on the Wachowskis' shortlist.

Despite the long production schedule and demanding pre-training, Henry worked to coordinate between J.J. Harris and Charlize.

Chapter 500 500: All for the Sake of the Film

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Bringing up the movie, Henry asked, "If I remember correctly, your training period is four months, under Master Yuen—brought in from Hong Kong as both martial arts director and film director. Getting used to it?"

"It's alright. Just... a bit tough," Charlize Theron replied naturally. Keanu Reeves nodded in agreement beside her.

Henry looked them both up and down, then reached out to feel along Charlize's back and arms. "I think I should arrange a physical therapist for you—someone to assist with your training."

"Is that really necessary? Wouldn't that just add to the cost?" Charlize asked.

Henry explained, "Hong Kong martial arts directors are top-tier when it comes to choreography and professionalism. You can see that from their films."

"But their training methods? They're intense—borderline life-risking. Without the proper foundation, forcing yourself to adapt through sheer effort and professionalism can easily lead to injury."

"And once you're injured—whether it affects your performance or stops you from acting altogether—that's far less professional, isn't it? Same goes for you, K.C."

He glanced at Keanu. "Your neck and shoulders look abnormally stiff—too tense, not relaxed like a normal person. Have you been having headaches or numbness in your arms?"

Keanu was startled. "Actually... yeah, recently. Is it serious?"

"Get it checked by a neurosurgeon," Henry advised. "If it's still early, a good physical therapist can help correct it without interfering too much with training."

"But if it gets worse, it could delay filming. In severe cases, the pain can leave you unable to move. This is all for the sake of the film."

For most adults, advice from someone they barely knew might not carry much weight.

But from a professional standpoint, Keanu didn't want to risk delaying production because of his own condition. In the worst-case scenario, he could even be replaced.

So he nodded. "Looks like I should book a doctor's appointment in the next couple of days. Thanks, Henry."

"I'm just playing Dr. Zhivago here," Henry said lightly. "Go see a real doctor—their opinion will be far more reliable."

"Dr. Zhivago" was a self-deprecating reference—like calling oneself a quack doctor.

"Got it." With that, Keanu returned to his seat as the film was about to begin.

Henry turned to Charlize. "Same goes for you. You might not need a doctor yet, but having a qualified physical therapist is essential."

"Remember what I told you? The most important thing in action films?"

Charlize thought for a moment. "...Don't get injured?"

"Exactly. You can't overemphasize safety and health."

After a brief pause, Henry added, "And I think it's time you got an assistant—or even built a small team."

"You can't rely on Jen to be everywhere with you, or handle every little thing yourself. And hiring a random makeup artist last minute? That didn't really work out."

Charlize looked surprised. "Was it that bad? My makeup today?"

"Well... your face alone passes. But the overall look is a bit..."

"A bit what?"

Regardless of how later sequels would be received, the first Matrix film was undeniably a classic. There was no reason to pass up such an opportunity.

Many actresses who declined the role—like Madonna and Janet Jackson—later regretted it.

And among those who passed on the project... was even a major star of the era: Will Smith, who turned down the role of Neo.

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"Let's just say—you'd better hope Cruella didn't see you. Otherwise, you can imagine what she'd say."

Charlize winced. Even if she didn't assemble a full team, she definitely needed someone who could give her proper advice.

The film began.

At 144 minutes, The Devil's Advocate proved itself a truly outstanding work.

The most eye-catching performance, without a doubt, was Al Pacino as Satan.

His commanding presence and masterful delivery drew the audience in completely. His lines perfectly conveyed a devil's contempt for the world, provoking reflection.

Keanu Reeves, acting opposite him, couldn't quite match Pacino's aura—but he convincingly portrayed an ordinary man struggling under the Devil's manipulation.

Charlize Theron, meanwhile, delivered a powerful performance as someone dragged into darkness—capturing the journey from confusion and despair to ultimate collapse and self-destruction.

Though she had acted in it, this was her first time watching the full film.

After the premiere, back at Henry's home, she asked nervously, "So... how was it?"

"It's an excellent film. Your performance was flawless. It should do well—both commercially and critically."

From Henry's memory before transmigration, the film held a 7.5 rating on IMDb and grossed \$150 million on a \$57 million budget—already a strong success.

Even if this world differed slightly, it likely wouldn't be far off.

And Charlize knew—Henry wouldn't offer empty praise. He wasn't just her boyfriend; he was also her acting mentor. Honest feedback was the only way she could improve.

So his approval made her beam with pride.

After a bit of wine, she grinned. "So? It's not worse than your other big-budget movie, right?"

...Comparing it to Titanic?

Aside from losing to an iceberg, that film crushed everything in its path—and held records for over a decade before James Cameron broke them himself.

In Henry's memory, the top four box office films were: Cameron, Marvel, Cameron, Cameron. That said enough.

Marvel only got there after building up twenty-one films over eleven years for Endgame. Who else could compete with the "King of the World"?

Of course, Henry wasn't about to crush his girlfriend's enthusiasm.

After all, Titanic was still in post-production—its visual effects being painstakingly rendered on the "Hollywood Kid" supercomputing systems.

Thinking about how he'd been dragged into helping with VFX work lately—stuck at a workstation alongside a group of young recruits—Henry felt like crying.

Then he made a decision.

Tomorrow, he'd deliberately pick out a few continuity errors and point them out to James Cameron.

Let that obsessive perfectionist lose sleep over fixing them—pacing around, pulling his hair out trying to patch every flaw.

Hey—don't call it petty.

It's all for the sake of the film.

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### Chapter 501 501: The Ship That Swept Everything Aside

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At the end of 1997, the departure date of the great ship was delayed again and again. It had originally been scheduled for the summer season, but production simply couldn't be completed in time.

However, with a production cost of \$200 million, no one dared release it during an off-season slot. After all, so-called "hot" and "cold" release windows were directly tied to market size.

If they chose a time when the core moviegoing audience was busy working or in school, with little free time to watch films, the box office would predictably suffer even more.

So the next best opportunity was the year-end Christmas season.

They certainly couldn't release it during Halloween and compete with horror movies. Even if those horror films killed plenty of people onscreen, compared to the ship sinking beneath the sea, they wouldn't even count as a fraction.

Although the Christmas season meant competing against the James Bond film Tomorrow Never Dies and DreamWorks' Mouse Hunt, there was no more suitable timing.

As one of the production companies, 20th Century Fox only held overseas distribution rights. North American distribution rights had been taken by fellow investor Stark Pictures. Naturally, Fox focused its efforts on the international market.

That was why they wanted the premiere held in London, the heart of the English-speaking world. To that end, they even arranged it as a Royal Film Performance and invited Prince Charles, the eternal heir to the throne, to attend.

But from Stark Pictures' perspective, North America was the main source of profit—and the home base of Hollywood itself. How could they allow the premiere to be held overseas?

Not wanting a North American premiere was also director James Cameron's own preference. Ever since the ship's enormous production cost became public, the media had mocked and criticized the film nonstop. Even a director whose reputation had been elevated by the Terminator series had begun to lose confidence.

He preferred to open first outside North America, win acclaim overseas, and then return triumphantly to America—the same America that hadn't spoken a kind word about him. It was a rather tsundere sort of attitude: You look down on me today, but tomorrow you won't be worthy of me.

Considering the impact piracy could have on ticket sales, Henry naturally couldn't agree to an overseas-first release.

In the end, all sides compromised: the film would hold its premiere at the Tokyo International Film Festival on November 1st, neatly avoiding the argument over domestic versus international priority.

Premiering at a film festival as a marketing tactic was nothing new in Hollywood. Studios generally didn't care which festival they used—only whether the timing suited them.

The overseas previews also received positive reviews.

This gradually improved the public perception of the ship. The earlier malicious criticism actually had the opposite effect—it made audiences curious to see what all the fuss was about.

In truth, part of the reason the release was pushed back so late was Henry himself.

During an internal screening, he pointed out more than one continuity mistake and visible goof. How could detail-obsessed Cameron possibly tolerate that?

Reshoots were impossible, so they could only fix them through computer effects.

And then the boomerang flew right back to Stark Pictures.

Which meant a certain CEO had to work overtime again...

Ahhh!

In any case, Titanic's official Hollywood premiere was held on December 14th, hosted by Stark Pictures.

At the same time, 20th Century Fox held an equally lavish London premiere, launching the great ship in style.

Finally, on Friday, December 19th, it opened nationwide—

And created one of Hollywood's greatest legends.

Opening day in North America brought in \$8,658,814.

Its first weekend grossed \$28,638,131 across 2,674 theaters, ranking number one at the box office.

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By New Year's Day, it had passed \$120 million.

After 44 days, it crossed \$300 million.

After 66 days, it reached \$400 million.

Its highest single-day gross came on Saturday, February 14th, 1998—Valentine's Day, earning \$13,048,711 in one day.

On March 14th, it surpassed Star Wars to become the highest-grossing film in history.

It also held the number one box office position in North America for 15 consecutive weeks, and remained in theaters for nearly ten months.

Its final totals:

\$600 million in North America

\$1.2 billion overseas

\$1.8 billion worldwide

A record that would dominate Hollywood for nearly a decade.

That was why, even before leaving theaters, it still swept the 70th Academy Awards in 1998.

Fourteen nominations.

Eleven wins.

Including the undisputed major prizes:

Best Picture

Best Director

Meanwhile, the cast of The Devil's Advocate, which didn't even receive a nomination, had no time to brood.

On the day of the ceremony, Charlize Theron was filming The Matrix in Sydney, Australia.

Since the Oscars aired at 11 a.m. Sydney time, everyone on set was too busy shooting to pay attention to what was happening in Los Angeles.

As an unofficial member of the crew, the CEO of Stark Pictures had brought members of the digital effects department to offer advice from the perspective of CGI production.

Henry naturally didn't need to monitor filming or wait around to perform. Nor did he need to help with miscellaneous work.

So he stayed at the hotel and watched the Oscar broadcast, personally witnessing James Cameron stand onstage and shout the line that cemented his godlike status.

Ever since Henry invested in this doomed ship, a fair portion of the criticism aimed at Cameron had shifted onto Henry instead—the Hollywood outsider.

Comments like:

"This guy should stick to scientific research."

"He should focus on digital imaging and stay out of filmmaking."

"What does he know about movies?"

They appeared endlessly in newspapers, magazines, and industry gossip.

Because the financing involved Stark Industries, even Tony Stark got dragged into the ridicule.

The nastier media sarcastically called him:

"Another angel investor from Wall Street about to lose everything in Hollywood."

In the end, the ones who capsized weren't Henry and Tony—

It was the media who had spoken so confidently before.

So these uncrowned kings of public opinion now chased Henry everywhere, desperate to reclaim face—even though they had no idea what story could possibly overshadow the previous one.

To avoid the pests, especially at a moment when Cameron was ascending to legend status, Henry came to Australia to visit the set and lay low.

He wasn't an actor, and his work didn't depend on fame. There was no reason to flatter journalists.

Better to hide first.

But while he could escape reporters, he couldn't escape his girlfriend.

After finishing a day of filming, Charlize returned to the hotel and immediately asked about the Oscars.

There wasn't an actor in Hollywood who didn't care about the industry's highest honor.

So after hearing Titanic's results, she couldn't help privately complaining to Henry.

"Ahhh, such a great movie—and you invested in it. I should've fought for a role no matter what!"

Rolling around on the bed, Charlize grumbled dramatically.

Henry pulled the girl back down onto the bed face-first and began massaging her tired muscles.

"As far as number of awards goes, Titanic was definitely the big winner," he said. "But did you notice it didn't win a single acting award?"

Charlize tried to turn over and talk, but Henry pressed her back down and continued working on her tense shoulders.

She could only ask while lying there, "That's true. Why is that?"

Henry explained:

"This film was the success of one man—James Cameron.

"The lack of acting awards can be blamed on the jealousy of those old white men.

"Or perhaps they believe that no matter who the actors were, with Cameron directing, the film would've succeeded the same way.

"Actors elevated by the movie itself weren't considered worthy of awards.

"And that reputation may drag them down for quite a while.

"If they want to change it, they'll have to start with low-budget independent films—which means low pay.

"Or they can keep accepting repetitive studio scripts built on the same image until they no longer have box office pull.

"And when that day comes, forget transitioning—they might just be thrown out by Hollywood entirely.

"That's not what you want, is it?"

Charlize lay obediently still, enjoying the massage as she sighed.

Chapter 502 502: A Long-Overdue Contact

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As a salaried employee, Henry would have loved nothing more than to hide in Sydney, Australia for the rest of his life—collecting paychecks without working.

He had even acted on a whim and secretly taken some time to visit the hidden residence of those two Eternals, intending to provide some after-sales service. Perhaps the Eternals still had some mysterious pickling stones or a favored kitchen cleaver lying around.

But after arriving, he discovered that Gilgamesh and Thena had already left.

And they had been gone for quite some time—it clearly wasn't because they were deliberately avoiding him.

Perhaps Kingo knew where they had gone.

But Henry wasn't about to make an international call just to ask something like that.

In April, Henry prepared to fly back to Los Angeles because someone he hadn't heard from in a long time had contacted him, saying they wanted to meet at Stark Pictures.

Jack Reacher, Captain of the U.S. Army Military Police Special Investigations Unit.

The last time Henry had seen him was about a year and a half ago. Back then, he had only been a lieutenant.

During the time since, Reacher had contacted Henry only once through the covert communication channel Henry had given him—to request operational funds.

Judging by the amount and delivery method, it was probably money used to buy someone off.

Henry hadn't asked too many questions.

He simply followed Reacher's instructions and placed \$100,000 in a suitcase at the designated drop point.

That had been around the middle of last year.

Only now was there finally some result.

The reason there had been no updates until now was because Henry himself had requested it:

No unnecessary progress reports.

Fewer contacts.

Less exposure.

After all, both of them knew full well they were investigating something dangerous enough to get people killed.

Leaving as few traces as possible was the best protection for everyone involved.

Besides, Henry honestly wasn't that invested in the matter.

"When you put it that way, Leonardo DiCaprio and Kate Winslet are in trouble."

Henry replied:

"No denying the film gave them tremendous publicity too.

"If they can endure the discrimination of those old white men and push forward against the wind, it can become a shortcut to success.

"Maybe even easier than climbing step by step."

Then he added:

"But for you, what matters most is what's in front of you now.

"That ship is already in the past for you as an actress.

"And filming on wires isn't exactly easy, is it?"

"And what about you?"

The girl, understanding the importance of choosing priorities, let go of her resentment toward the ship.

Turning onto her side, drawing one knee up in a teasing gesture, she smiled.

"Don't you also have something in front of you that deserves your full attention?"

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This should have been something Tony Stark handled personally—the people who died had been his family.

Yet somehow the whole matter had landed on Henry's shoulders.

Wasn't he only supposed to be the guy who offered bad ideas?

Given Henry's attitude toward responsibilities that actually fell within the scope of his salary, expecting him to be enthusiastic about unpaid extra work was wishful thinking.

As for whether Jack Reacher had taken public funds and spent them enjoying himself, or skimmed something off the top—

Neither Henry nor Tony Stark particularly cared.

Reacher's secret investigation had always been a speculative move.

Even if it produced nothing, that would have been expected.

When disappointment has piled up enough times, getting no result hardly feels disappointing anymore.

But now Reacher had proactively requested a meeting.

Could it be that he had truly uncovered something?

In terms of urgency, Reacher's matter deserved top priority.

So Henry didn't hesitate.

After informing Charlize Theron and the Stark Pictures team, he boarded a flight back to Los Angeles.

Unfortunately, fate had terrible timing.

While Henry sat on the plane, an alarm device he himself had distributed began emitting a signal audible only to him.

The direct flight from Sydney to Los Angeles took nearly fourteen hours.

Only two hours had passed.

They hadn't even crossed the equator yet.

If he waited until landing, whoever triggered the alarm would probably be dead by then.

Should he go into the bathroom, phase through the aircraft hull using his powers, and rush off to the rescue?

Unfortunately, this flight happened to be packed—likely with a tour group.

If he occupied the restroom too long, a flight attendant would probably open the door to check.

Looks like it was finally time for the prototype to see real combat.

Seated in first class, Henry pulled a specially made glasses case from his carry-on bag.

Inside were not only a pair of glasses, but also ten custom-made rings.

He put them on all ten fingers in a precise order.

The glasses projected a retinal display showing a distant location in California:

One of Henry's secret bases—

Sheep Cave Valley Laboratory.

Within his field of vision, his pet wasn't roaming wildly across the wilderness.

Instead, it lay quietly not far from the lab, with the starry sky behind it, radiating utter laziness.

Just as Henry tapped together the rings on his thumbs and index fingers to activate the remote-control system, it seemed to attract Kitty's attention.

The tiger raised its head and looked over.

A ventilation hatch on the outer shell of the container lab automatically opened.

The prototype support unit codenamed Little Duck detached from its charging dock, activated its hovering system, and floated out.

Borrowing from Kree technology, an anti-gravity device powered by one microliter of gravitonium allowed the box-shaped machine—with two multifunction mechanical claws—to levitate.

On its front were three lenses:

one for close focus

one for long range

one for special functions

The claws flexed experimentally.

The lenses each ran a quick test.

Then the speaker emitted Henry's voice, simulated through brainwave control.

"Kitty, time to head out. Come get suited up."

Kitty: It's nighttime. Rest hours.

Damn it, Henry thought. This thing even understands work-life balance?

Left with no choice, he said:

"One tiger meal. Premium."

Kitty: Which suit?

With a low growl, Kitty leapt down from where it had been resting and padded toward the lab.

On the airplane, Henry tapped the ten rings together in another sequence.

The lower section of the container shell opened into the tiger-armoring access tunnel.

Already familiar with the process, Kitty walked right inside.

Within was a special platform.

Mechanical arms attached armor pieces onto Kitty's body one by one.

Chapter 503 503: Atmospheric Hyper-Acceleration Launch System

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"Go, Kitty. Same as usual—I've marked the route for you. Just follow the arrows."

Using the same retinal projection technology, Henry directly projected the movement instructions into the tiger's eyes. After experimenting with many methods, he had unexpectedly discovered that Kitty could understand directional cues meant for humans just fine.

However, if Kitty had to run all the way from the Sheep Cave Valley Laboratory to the distress signal location, then even ignoring stamina issues, by the time she arrived at full speed, the person asking for help would probably be dead long enough for their bones to be used as drums.

So Henry simply removed the limiter and said to his pet:

"Kitty, go wild."

"ROAR!"

That was the happy cry of a tiger.

At the same time, the four thick mechanical limbs activated their gravity-unium core control systems. In sync with Kitty's leg movements, they provided gravitational acceleration and deceleration.

Tests showed that this system could allow Kitty to accelerate in a straight line to speeds exceeding 200 kilometers per hour.

When it emerged, Kitty had grown to more than double its original size—

Nearly the size of a cow.

But...

It no longer resembled a tiger.

Instead, it looked like a leopard.

With yellow plating and black spots, the armor made Kitty resemble a metal panther.

At the shoulder blades was a clear recessed slot—

Perfectly sized for Little Duck to fit into.

The support unit's claws now acted like clasps and connectors, locking tightly into the armor.

Only the upper camera lenses protruded outside.

"Duck-Panther Armor Prototype—equipped!"

"At a moment like this, we really need epic battle BGM. Maybe I should add a few tracks to the music library."

Kitty: If there's something to do, hurry up. If not, I'm taking this off.

Kitty roared and shook its head dramatically, as if trying to fling the armor off.

To be fair, the earliest prototype actually would have flown apart if it did that.

Even if it stayed intact, the machine would've malfunctioned from the violent vibration.

Honestly, people who train dogs and cats to wear clothes were incredible.

It had taken nearly a full year of revisions before the tiger armor reached its current state.

Unfortunately, even if Henry wanted to show off, there was no audience to applaud.

The only living being present was a tiger.

Better not perform music to cattle.

Remembering the person still waiting for rescue, Henry abandoned his self-congratulatory mood.

No point in having the grand entrance ready—

Only to arrive and find the target already dead.

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More impressively, it granted her a form of pseudo-flight, allowing her to run through the air as if sprinting on invisible ground.

Because the gravitational field repeatedly shifted direction, it disturbed surrounding air molecules, causing the heavier water molecules to condense.

Thus, when Kitty wore the Duck-Leopard Armor and ran through the sky, mist formed around her paws, making it look as though she were soaring on clouds.

Even so, that speed still wasn't enough to support whoever had sent the distress signal.

The Sheep Cave Valley Laboratory was roughly 250 kilometers in a straight line from Los Angeles.

If Kitty ran there at 200 km/h, she'd arrive in over an hour—just in time to collect the body.

So now it was time to use another system:

The Hyper-Acceleration Launch System.

This was not an ordinary acceleration-deceleration device used to move something at extreme speed.

Nor was it a space-jump system used in the cosmos to shorten distances between two points.

Especially the latter—in the Marvel universe's established jump network, jump points had to be deployed in advance. Only vessels equipped with jump capability could use them within a certain range, arriving near another jump point.

If there was no jump point nearby, the only way to reach the destination was to fly there the slow way.

The Tesseract was another matter entirely, and not worth discussing here. It lacked universality, and the Space Stone inside it couldn't be mass-produced.

Henry had naturally found complete technical designs for such systems within Kree and Skrull knowledge archives.

But implementing one inside Earth's atmosphere involved too many unpredictable risks.

And from power consumption to shielding costs, using such a system for atmospheric travel was simply an unprofitable waste.

That was when the late Kree scientist Mar-Vell's final project—the Lightspeed Engine—became useful.

Its purpose had been to allow ships to perform long-range jumps through space without pre-existing jump points.

In truth, the design was nearly complete, and even prototype models had been installed—otherwise Captain Marvel would never have been created.

It was only because the Kree Starforce attacked, and because Mar-Vell (Dr. Wendy Lawson) worried about the Skrulls she had sheltered aboard the Kree cruiser, that she didn't activate the engine and flee. Instead, she fought them.

Actually...

If Carol Danvers hadn't insisted on piloting the test aircraft and had let Lawson fly alone, she might have escaped using the lightspeed engine first, then returned later after shaking off the Kree.

But that was only speculation.

The actual result was simple:

Mar-Vell died.

Captain Marvel was born.

Quite in line with the superhero tradition of "sacrifice the parents, gain limitless power."

The reason the engine required the Tesseract's energy was because the Skrulls needed to flee beyond Kree pursuit range—

Meaning beyond the Milky Way, the Large Magellanic Cloud, and even Andromeda.

Those regions were all within the standard range where jump networks had already been established.

As for jump point deployment, all three great empires had methods for doing so, and their systems had some degree of interoperability.

That was why no matter where the Skrulls ran, they couldn't escape the Kree.

But Henry's desired hyper-launch system wasn't for crossing millions—or tens of millions—of light-years between galaxies.

It was only for use inside Earth's atmosphere.

So ordinary energy sources were enough.

No Tesseract required.

Henry had long since completed the lightspeed engine design and even modified several versions of it.

Even if it couldn't fulfill the original purpose without the Tesseract, atmospheric use was more than sufficient.

The problem with precise jumping was this:

Not only did calculations need to be perfect, but the destination also had to be free of interfering objects.

Otherwise, the result of hyper-launching was simply crashing directly into the obstruction.

And under those circumstances, one shouldn't expect to walk away unharmed.

So during this period, Henry had launched a homemade satellite into geosynchronous orbit.

Since his main sphere of activity was still California, broader surveillance elsewhere wasn't urgent. There was no need yet for a global monitoring network.

After confirming conditions at the destination, Henry prepared the final steps for the hyper-launch device.

Besides giving Kitty psychological preparation, the compact hyper-launch modules mounted symmetrically on the upper rear limbs of the Duck-Leopard Armor needed to preheat.

The preheating time wasn't long—

About 35 seconds.

After that, arrival at the destination would take less than a blink.

Kitty had already experienced the process several times, so there was no discomfort.

In fact...

This tiger had become fascinated by the hyper-launch experience.

It even secreted dopamine during the process, clearly showing excitement.

Earlier tests had only been conducted in the Sheep Cave Valley wilderness, within distances under five kilometers.

This time, however, she was being launched over 250 kilometers for the first time.

According to the design, short and long distances made no real difference to the device.

Only at sufficient ranges did Earth's surface curvature need to be considered.

The distance from Sheep Cave Valley to Los Angeles posed no such issue.

Thus, Kitty—wearing the Duck-Leopard Armor—arrived smoothly in the air directly above the distress signal location.

This was South Los Angeles, the city's roughest district.

The time was a little after 10 PM.

Too early for sleep.

Not really the hour for ordinary people to be outside.

It was the time when demons danced.

The person who had sent the distress signal was none other than that burly man—

Captain Jack Reacher of the Military Police Special Investigations Unit.

And the ones attacking him...

Were a pack of vampires.

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Chapter 504 504: The Armor’s First Real Combat Test

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This group of dark creatures possessed physical abilities far beyond ordinary humans. It could be said that without specialized anti-vampire equipment, normal people stood no chance against vampires barehanded.

That was also the main reason these creatures of the night believed themselves superior to humanity.

Jack Reacher either hadn't brought any weapons, or he had already emptied his magazine and discarded his firearm. At present, he could only rely on fists and kicks to fend off the vampires, looking thoroughly beleaguered.

If Kitty had arrived any later, Henry would probably have only been in time to collect the corpse.

Just as one vampire used speed beyond human limits to circle into Jack Reacher's blind spot, preparing to pounce on the tall man—

Kitty, weighing over five hundred pounds herself, combined with the weight of the metal armor, dropped from the sky and landed directly on top of the vampire.

No matter how much stronger than humans he was, the combined weight of the Duck-Leopard Armor and a full-grown tiger was more than an ordinary vampire could withstand.

The sudden appearance of the armored beast stunned everyone present.

That included Jack Reacher—who had been calling for help for quite some time, mentally complaining that someone had promised support in three seconds but nearly ten minutes had passed without even a ghost appearing—

And it included the vampires attacking him as well.

A gigantic metallic animal with obvious mechanical features was the kind of thing people only saw in movies.

In reality, even creatures from the supernatural world like vampires had never expected to encounter such a... monster.

What made it especially terrifying was its sheer size.

Most people could only tell it was some kind of feline. They couldn't identify whether it was a cat, tiger, or leopard just by the yellow coat pattern with black spots.

But with a bulk comparable to a cow, nearly the size of a compact car, and unmistakably predatory traits, the metal beast looked savage beyond words.

No one would mistake it for an adorable kitten.

From the little duck mounted on the Duck-Leopard Armor's back, the camera switched to a specialized tactical mode.

Through infrared thermal imaging, Henry confirmed that aside from the unlucky guy lying flat on the ground, everyone else present was a vampire.

A few looked somewhat disheveled, but wounds caused by ordinary people healed quickly for vampires. There were no visible scrapes or bruises left on them, much less knife or gunshot injuries.

Only torn or damaged clothing proved they had suffered any harm at all.

Scenes like this were no longer unfamiliar on the streets of Los Angeles these days.

These dark creatures were only one step away from openly marching through daylight like militant activists, shouting slogans such as:

"Vampire lives matter!"

Openly proving their existence to the world.

Of course, no matter how radical they were, vampires could never protest under broad daylight.

Even the sunscreen that helped them resist sunlight had usage limits.

After rapidly assessing the battlefield, Henry projected target markers directly onto Kitty's retina.

Kitty's entire demeanor changed instantly.

For a long time, Henry had never taught Kitty concepts like enemy or prey to be hunted.

Even when feeding her fresh meat, Henry always snapped the animal's neck first, then let Kitty chew whichever parts she wanted.

But marked targets were different.

These were defined as dangerous objects that would initiate attacks.

The training method had been simple:

Set up automatic crossbows or catapults to attack Kitty.

All she had to learn was to retaliate against those targets.

Even so, if marked targets didn't attack first, Kitty wouldn't strike them preemptively.

But once they attacked—

It became Kitty's playtime.

And considering what happened to BB during ordinary play sessions with this tiger, one could imagine the fate awaiting these targets.

Being flattened was commonplace.

Being bitten apart or torn to pieces was also routine.

Henry had no intention of raising a useless beast that wouldn't fight back.

Unless the opponent was Henry himself—or some absurd powerhouse like the Eternal Gilgamesh—Kitty was expected to resist.

But faced suddenly with a massive armored monster, the vampires did not rush in recklessly.

Their confidence existed mainly when preying upon humans—the "unevolved inferior species."

Ask them to tear apart a car barehanded, and most would hesitate.

Much less charge a snarling steel beast.

So the battlefield entered an awkward stalemate.

Though all vampires had been marked and had drawn Kitty's attention, as long as they didn't initiate aggression, Kitty wouldn't close in to attack.

Chapter 505 505: A Rescue That Wasn't Quite Perfect

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Ultraviolet radiation spread outward in an instant, expanding until it met obstacles it could not penetrate. The vampires had no means of resistance at all—they were instantly burned to ash by the violet glow. The flames were so fierce that even the clothes on their bodies were completely destroyed.

The vampires truly deserved the title they gave themselves—"a more evolved existence." A few quick-witted ones reacted the moment they saw the glowing violet object pop out and immediately tried to evade it. Their fast reflexes let some of them move in time.

Some attempted to hide behind their companions, but the specially designed ultraviolet grenade released its attack in waves. As the shielding vampires ignited

For Henry, however, this wasn't a problem at all.

He still retained partial control authority over the Duck-Leopard Armor.

High above in the aircraft, his ten fingers rhythmically tapped his rings together, activating the armor's weapon systems.

If he built high-tech combat gear only for melee fighting, he'd be an idiot.

And since the enemies were vampires—things whose deaths wouldn't be mourned anyway—

Combined with the fact that Jack Reacher was someone Henry intended to protect, Henry had no interest in determining who was morally right or wrong here.

The little duck mounted on the armor activated its speakers.

In a flat, emotionless synthetic voice, it announced:

"Flash grenade. If you don't want to go blind, crouch down, cover your head, and shield your eyes."

Jack Reacher truly deserved his reputation as an active-duty military man.

Though military police, he had not lacked combat training.

The moment he heard the warning, regardless of where the voice came from or who said it, he instinctively followed training and protected himself.

The vampires heard it too.

But lacking disciplined training, they reacted much slower.

Besides, they didn't believe something as trivial as a "flash grenade" could hinder them.

Before any of them could sneer or issue taunts—

The Duck-Leopard Armor's weapon bay opened under Henry's remote control.

A glowing orb pulsing with blue-violet light popped out.

The vampires were all too familiar with this little object.

Recently, they had been traumatized by it.

This was their nightmare:

The anti-vampire superweapon—

Ultraviolet Grenade.

One blast could wipe out groups at once.

Only vampires lucky enough to hide in shadow and avoid the ultraviolet radiation survived long enough to spread the warning.

However, unlike standard grenade-style attacks, the UV grenade launched from the Duck-Leopard Armor did not have a long fuse delay.

The moment it ejected—

It rose to its highest point, barely forty-five centimeters above the launcher.

The whole process likely took less than a second.

Then—

It detonated.

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and crumbled to ash, the second and third pulses of violet light passed through the gaps, setting ablaze those who thought themselves safe.

Only a handful of clear-headed vampires, having learned the grenade's properties from lucky survivors, found real solid cover—small dumpsters, or the corners of concrete buildings.

One wave of attack was not enough to cleanse the world. Some of the vampires chasing Jack Reacher did die under the ultraviolet grenades, but the survivors launched a swift counterattack.

Inside the aircraft, Henry merely tapped together the rings on his left thumb and pinky. Silver-plated claws shot out from the Duck-Leopard Armor. The unlucky vampire who had already been pinned down by Kitty had his heart pierced instantly by the silver steel talons and turned to ash on the spot.

Playtime for adorable tiger Kitty!

The four-legged gravity-launch system gave Kitty acceleration beyond imagination, along with the ability to move across surfaces from different angles.

With a leap and a spin, the metallic beast landed on a wall, looking down from above at the vampires who had missed their pounce. Then she sprang again—both front claws sank deep into two vampires' bodies, while her tail lashed like a whip, smashing another behind them.

The vampires in front burned to ash. The one behind had just begun to rise in resistance when he saw the segmented tail split open, revealing internal mechanisms glowing with ominous violet light. The entire tail now looked like an ultraviolet whip.

One lash downward—

The whip sliced through the vampire like a hot knife through butter. The cut ignited immediately, flames spreading over his whole body.

The one farthest away happened to witness the full attack sequence of the panther-form Duck-Leopard Armor. Without hesitation, he turned and ran.

But Henry had long been guarding against any witnesses escaping. From the long-range aircraft, he tapped his rings again. A hidden magnetic railgun emerged from the shoulder mount, and a silver-jacketed iron-core round killed the fleeing vampire with a single shot.

Since vampires were Henry's primary enemy lately, he had naturally plated all of his melee weapons in silver, or made them from silver outright, adding ultraviolet radiation fluid where appropriate.

These dark creatures who believed themselves superior to humanity and more highly evolved were this fragile when faced with specialized weapons.

To protect his eyes and brace for the expected shockwave, Jack Reacher had covered his face and thrown himself flat on the ground.

But this "flashbang" had not produced six million candela of white light. Instead, it emitted a dark, bluish glow. Nor had it created any deafening blast or noise to damage his hearing and nerves.

He first opened one eye, confirming the effect had faded, then opened the other.

As he rose, he happened to see the Duck-Leopard Armor retracting a gun-like device. In the distance, another vampire turned to ash.

Ignoring his injuries, Jack Reacher asked, "They were vampires?"

Through Little Duck, Henry replied, "With your powers of observation, I trust you can arrive at the correct conclusion."

"So this is the three-second rescue you promised? Looked more like three minutes. By my estimate, about six. Barely under seven."

Most of the lost time had gone into Kitty putting on the armor. Thankfully, Henry had used memories of Iron Man's future assisted-wear systems when designing it. Otherwise, dressing her manually would have taken hours.

Still, feeling guilty about failing his promise, Henry explained, "The first rescue plan—the three-second man—happened to be taking a dump. You can't expect him to maintain super speed while shitting.

"The second plan was inconvenient to use. So this was the third option, improvised on the spot. Since you're not dead, I'd say the rescue still counts as a success."

Reacher snorted. "Good thing I didn't rely on your three-second promise, or I'd have waited until the very end. But I'll admit, reinforcements like this were beyond my expectations. This is... a mechanical panther?"

Henry dodged the question. "You can think of it that way." Then he asked, "But how did vampires end up hunting you? Based on their tastes, a man like you isn't on the menu.

"They prefer vulnerable women, or healthy-looking men thinking with the wrong head. Muscular guys tend to fight back. Unless you only look tough on the outside, you're not exactly ideal prey."

Jack Reacher walked over to the woman lying on the ground and checked her condition.

"I saw them attacking a woman, and she cried for help. So I intervened. I just didn't expect opponents like this."

Curious Kitty naturally padded over after him, giving Henry a chance to inspect the woman through external monitors.

"She was bitten by a vampire?"

Chapter 506 506: Withdrawal

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Although he had some doubts about riding a metal beast, Jack Reacher still swung himself onto it. The sound of police sirens was getting closer and closer—there wasn't much time left to think.

Only after mounting did he realize something else:

How had this metal panther appeared in the first place? And how exactly was it supposed to leave?

"Looks that way." Reacher looked at the two clear puncture marks on her neck, where the bleeding had already stopped. "Can she still be saved? Or is she going to become a vampire?"

"You don't know her?"

Reacher shook his head. "No. We don't know each other."

"But you still stepped in." Henry laughed through the electronic voice modulator, feeling a great deal. Truly worthy of a protagonist-level figure.

Then, on the opposite side of the weapon compartment, a medical drawer slid open.

"This is anti-vampire serum. Give her a shot, and you won't have to worry about her being turned."

Looking at the cloudy white liquid inside the injector, Reacher asked skeptically, "This really works?"

Through Little Duck, Henry replied, "Within twenty-four hours of the bite, as long as she didn't die directly from blood loss, she can definitely be saved.

"Within seventy-two hours, there's only a chance. If she's lost too much blood, at least she can die with dignity instead of becoming some half-human monster.

"If she's already fully transformed into a vampire, then one shot of that and she dies immediately. I hear the body explodes. Certified by Los Angeles vampire hunters."

Reacher skipped further academic discussion and asked directly, "Where do I inject it?"

"The neck. Opposite side of the bite."

Without another thought, Reacher took the syringe and injected it into the woman's neck.

"Put the used syringe back where it was. I don't want weird objects left behind as police evidence or clues leading back to me."

As for that bullet, I'll recover it later, Henry thought.

Reacher returned the syringe to the drawer, watching the medical compartment seal shut. Before he could speak again, the belated wail of police sirens approached from the distance—and there was more than one vehicle.

Through Little Duck, Henry asked in an electronic tone, "Did anyone else witness this and call the police? Or are they headed somewhere else?"

"Before I stepped in, I shouted for bystanders to call them. Good chance they're coming here," Reacher admitted.

"Well then, as a good Samaritan, going to the station shouldn't be a problem for you. With how much vampire trouble there's been lately, explaining that the woman on the ground wasn't bitten by you shouldn't be too hard."

Picking up his backpack from the ground, Reacher checked that everything inside was intact.

"Got a safe house or somewhere temporary to lie low? What I'm carrying isn't suitable for a police station."

And you still dared to play hero?

Henry nearly said it aloud.

Instead, he activated the Duck-Leopard Armor's back plating, which transformed to reveal a riding seat.

Since the armor itself bore the load, someone riding on it wouldn't burden Kitty. It wouldn't affect balance or mobility either. At most, it just provided a place to sit and something to hold onto.

"Climb on, hold tight, and grit your teeth."

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When the creature showed up, he hadn't heard a single sound, nor noticed any warning signs. It was as if it had simply appeared out of nowhere.

Then came a form of aerial maneuvering so absurd it nearly made him scream like a little girl.

The mechanical beast took off from the alley in a running posture.

What had begun as a casual straddle instantly turned into a desperate cling. As the creature charged vertically up the side of a building, Reacher flattened himself against its back, feet locked onto footholds, hands gripping handles, securing himself as tightly as possible.

Since Henry had never tested what would happen to an unprotected ordinary human riding outside the armor under the full acceleration of the launch system, he

didn't activate the near-teleportation movement mode. He didn't want to accidentally kill Reacher.

Even so, the Duck-Leopard Armor's gravity-launch movement system—flying through the air at speeds of two hundred kilometers per hour—was more than enough to make Reacher miserable.

Compared with an airplane, it was slower.

But airplanes moved at a steady speed.

Kitty's Duck-Leopard Armor, however, was not nearly so considerate.

Like any four-legged animal in motion, propulsion came only when a foot pushed off the ground—or in this case, simulated push-off force from each limb. The four legs alternated constantly.

That meant each burst of acceleration was fastest at the instant of "push-off," then gradually slowed until another leg accelerated again.

Normal animals only seemed to run smoothly because millions of years of evolution had perfectly matched stride length and step frequency into harmonious motion.

But Kitty, "running" through the air with the Duck-Leopard Armor, still used a tiger's natural stepping rhythm while her stride length had been dramatically increased.

That was what allowed a tiger—normally capable of short bursts around sixty-five kilometers per hour—to sustain two hundred kilometers per hour.

To Kitty, this wasn't even running.

It was just walking.

Scientifically speaking, the reason armored Kitty could move at such speeds despite a modest step frequency was because her stride length had become absurdly large.

So while the average speed was two hundred kilometers per hour based on distance over time, her instantaneous speed fluctuated wildly—speeding up and slowing down like a hopping rabbit.

Even if the rhythm was regular, it was not a pleasant ride.

Especially not for over an hour.

When the Duck-Leopard Armor finally landed, Reacher could barely stand after climbing off.

The fact that he didn't collapse to his knees and vomit like a civilian was already proof of exceptional toughness. It also required excellent physical conditioning to survive that ordeal.

The support drone Little Duck detached from its docking slot on the armor's back and activated its hovering system again.

Kitty immediately entered the fitting corridor, where the armor could be removed.

After taking several deep breaths, Reacher grumbled, "I thought joining the Army meant I'd be rid of all that damn flying. That thing was supposed to be a panther, wasn't it? Since when do panthers fly?"

"Uh... I heard the Army uses helicopters to move troops too," Henry replied through Little Duck.

"That's why I was Military Police—not Rangers, and definitely not Delta."

Fair enough.

Henry suddenly understood why, after leaving the service and beginning his wandering life, this guy only traveled by bus.

Not only did bus tickets not require proper ID registration—

He also hated flying.

"Where is this place?" Reacher asked casually after finishing his complaints.

"I can only say this is my secret base. Please don't deliberately investigate where it is. And if you figure it out, don't say it aloud."

Henry paused.

"That would spare me the dilemma of deciding whether I need to silence you."

The thought crossed Reacher's mind for only a second before he answered smoothly, "Understood."

He had no desire to argue with someone who controlled a flying metal panther.

Chapter 507 507: Identity Exposed

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After stepping into the container house, Jack Reacher instinctively began observing his surroundings.

The fluorescent lights brightly illuminated the interior. At first glance, it didn't seem much different from most shipping containers—plain and straightforward.

There was a long table covered with various chemical glassware. A sink, refrigerator, a cooking counter with a portable gas stove, and a camp bed in the corner all seemed relatively normal.

At that moment, a small hatch beneath the container house opened.

Reacher expected a person.

Instead, a robot no higher than his calves rolled out carrying a tray.

Its body consisted of two stacked spheres, the lower one acting as a rolling base.

So "rolled out" was not sarcasm—it was literally what happened.

On the tray sat an unopened bottle of water, the kind sold in any supermarket.

Little Duck emitted an electronic voice.

"After one hour of high-speed travel while exposed to the air, you are experiencing at least mild dehydration. You may replenish fluids."

"Thanks."

Reacher took the bottle, twisted the cap open, and drained the entire six hundred milliliters in one go.

Though it looked rough and careless, he had already inspected it.

No puncture marks. No odd spray behavior when squeezed. The cap seal was intact.

That was why he trusted it enough to drink.

During this brief rest, he watched the metal mechanical panther emerge from the container passageway—

As an ordinary tiger.

A real tiger.

Apparently someone had a hobby of making a tiger disguise itself as a panther.

Reacher couldn't fully process that level of weirdness, so he simply chose silence.

Kitty paid no attention to the only human present or the floating drone.

She went straight to her usual sleeping spot and lay down.

Reacher hadn't forgotten—it was nighttime now.

Though tigers could move at night, they weren't truly nocturnal animals. Once the hour came, she got sleepy.

Henry naturally had no intention of making Reacher sleep outside in the wild.

Leaving aside the fact that there was a tiger nearby, the poor giant had just been thoroughly brutalized by vampires. He needed real rest, not a night under the open sky.

Near the container house door, the support drone used a multifunction mechanical arm to unlock the crude padlock hanging there.

The shabby door opened.

Lights inside flicked on.

After many renovations, the secret base was no longer just the primitive chemistry lab it had once been.

It now served many more functions.

Little Duck spoke to Reacher standing outside.

"Big guy, come inside and rest. I believe you would rather not sleep in the wilderness beside a tiger."

Though everything around him felt unfamiliar and unsafe, Reacher had to admit—

A roof overhead was far better than sleeping outside.

At the very least, inside looked civilized.

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But the shelves stocked with all kinds of supplies felt distinctly unusual.

Reacher said in surprise, "Is this some drug dealer's hidden base?"

The moment he said it, he sharply noticed something else.

The space inside the container felt wrong.

Compared with a normal shipping container, it seemed narrower.

Like the area where the tiger had entered through another passage earlier. Looking from inside, there was no visible mechanism there—just a sheet-metal cabinet pressed beneath the shelves and connected to the wall.

Controlling Little Duck, Henry replied, "A few stranded people wandering the wilderness have broken in here before. This kind of disguise makes them behave more rationally and only take survival supplies."

"And I don't keep any refined product here that could be used as evidence. The raw materials on the shelves all have other purposes—they can't be turned into that kind of garbage."

Hearing the explanation, Reacher nodded.

"So there's another hidden level of space."

"That's correct. But if all you need is rest, this level is enough. The camp bed is clean. There are fresh blankets in the box at the foot of it, if you need them."

Henry paused, then added out of old family habit:

"Also... do you need food?"

"I do need something to eat. I was planning to find a place after settling in somewhere tonight. But that got interrupted by those vampires."

"There are preserved rations on the shelves. If you want something hot, there's steak in the refrigerator. Need me to cook one for you? Won't take long. Coffee? Or water?"

"You can cook steak here?" Reacher asked in disbelief.

"Why not?"

Even through Little Duck's electronic voice, the teasing tone was obvious.

At the same time, a concealed hatch beneath the stove opened.

BB-2—the core robot responsible for the Goat Valley laboratory—rolled out.

Following Henry's command, the efficient machine quickly used its external mechanical arms to remove a steak from the refrigerator and pick up a frying pan from the counter.

Under Reacher's astonished stare, the small robot moved like a restaurant chef, cooking a proper steak before placing it on the long table beside the chair.

One mechanical arm extended from its spherical body, thoughtfully presenting a knife and fork.

BB-2 then ducked back through the hatch and re-emerged moments later.

This time it had swapped the cooking arm for another attachment and delivered a mug of coffee to Reacher.

Reacher accepted the coffee, then sat down beside the steak.

BB-2 casually collected the trash Reacher had brought in—the empty plastic water bottle from earlier—and rolled back beneath the stove through the hatch.

As if it had never appeared at all.

Reacher stared blankly for several seconds before finally letting out a long breath.

"I really can't believe everything I've seen tonight. This feels like something out of a science fiction movie."

Little Duck floated over to the opposite side of the table but didn't answer any questions about the technology.

Instead, it simply said:

"Please rest after you finish eating. Tomorrow you'll have to experience the same trip back. Let's hope the police aren't still looking for you."

At that, Reacher couldn't help complaining.

"You seriously don't have another safe house in the city? Or some transportation here so I can get back on my own tomorrow?"

Little Duck answered in its electronic tone:

"There is no other transportation here. And I'm not going to give you any chance to identify the surrounding terrain."

"Is that really necessary?"

Reacher frowned, then asked:

"I'd also like to know—am I talking to a person, or some kind of artificial intelligence? Don't tell me the tiger outside is actually the mastermind behind all this."

"Current artificial intelligence technology is not that advanced. I am remotely controlling the support drone and speaking with you. Earlier operations were also under my control."

Chapter 508 508: Private Communication Line

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The reason Henry had brought Jack Reacher to the Goat Valley Laboratory was partly due to poor planning—

And partly because he was gambling on Reacher's character.

He was betting that Reacher was like the protagonist from the film adaptation Henry remembered before transmigrating: not the sort of man obsessed with power, status, or advancement.

Reacher thought for a moment, then answered honestly.

"In that case, I should remind you of something.

"I don't think it would be hard to find someone in California raising a tiger.

"Sure, the armor making it look like a panther was clever misdirection. But I doubt it would fool many people for long.

"So if you plan to silence me, then considering I just pointed all this out, please give me a warning first."

That exposed blind spot left Henry speechless aboard the distant plane.

In the end, he could only complain through Little Duck:

"As expected, people shouldn't get lazy—especially when making backup plans.

"Your situation caught me off guard today. The rescue plan I improvised on the spot was full of holes after all.

"You're not going to tell anyone about this place, are you?"

Reacher took a sip of coffee.

"What would be the point? I don't know the exact location.

"And based on your past history, I'd guess there's some kind of self-destruct system hidden here too.

"If I bring anyone here without your permission, they'd probably go up in flames along with the whole base.

"In that case, saying nothing causes fewer casualties.

"As long as you don't naively tell me where the bombs are, or how to disable the trigger, I have no reason to reveal anything."

Little Duck emitted an electronic laugh.

"Oh? So my fearsome reputation still has some practical value. Should I be pleased?"

"Can I know where you are right now?" Reacher asked.

"On a plane from Sydney back to Los Angeles," Henry answered frankly.

Only a beat later did he realize Reacher's intention.

The man had been estimating the range of his remote-control capability.

As for what conclusions Reacher was drawing from that, Henry had no mind-reading powers.

Still, Henry wasn't worried anyone would try reopening the Sony Building bombing case from over three years ago.

That incident had long since been officially settled, and public opinion agreed with the verdict. No one sympathized with how much the thief Sony had lost in the explosion.

Reacher felt the same way.

He also wasn't the type to see useful technology and immediately hand it to the military in exchange for promotion, medals, and a future as a general.

As long as Henry Brown was not the kind of vicious criminal Reacher believed deserved punishment, Reacher had no intention of exposing this secret base.

The only reason he asked such questions was simple habit.

After all—

Henry had only forbidden him from investigating the location.

He hadn't forbidden everything else.

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Those earlier warnings had only been part of the performance, so Reacher wouldn't think Henry was inexplicably offering unconditional trust.

What Henry hadn't expected was this:

The laboratory's location remained hidden—

But he himself had been exposed.

And all of this was Kitty's fault.

Once he got back to Los Angeles, that striped cat's weight-loss program needed to be intensified.

Still, since his identity was already compromised, Henry simply said through Little Duck:

"How about this—you eat first. Once you're done, if you don't mind not speaking face to face, you can tell me directly why you wanted to meet me."

Reacher asked, "Is your communication line secure?"

Kree and Skrull communication technology—along with their interception and jamming capabilities—came in different grades.

At the highest level was quantum entanglement communication, which could ignore distance entirely and allow synchronized communication across star systems.

According to records from the Kree scientist Mar-Vell, the Supreme Intelligence of the Kree Empire used that very method to communicate with all imperial citizens.

Of course, the receiving party needed a beacon signal on their person so the Supreme Intelligence could locate and identify them.

It was still technology, not magic that locked onto souls or species.

These beacons could also have secondary uses depending on design.

For example, the device once used on Captain Marvel to suppress her power belonged to this category.

When Mar-Vell discarded her beacon, even though she was still a blue-blooded, pink-skinned Kree, it effectively meant abandoning her Kree identity.

She was no longer monitored by the Supreme Intelligence.

And no longer protected.

But despite how tiny a beacon was, the receiving equipment on the Supreme Intelligence's side was building-sized.

Even if Henry coveted that technology, he had no intention of doing anything so conspicuous.

So instead, he used another system—

One that even visiting Kree or Skrull technical officers would have difficulty cracking.

Quantum encryption.

The data was transmitted in fragmented frequency-hopping bursts.

Even reconstructing the message required overcoming decoding barriers similar to the Enigma machine.

Sometimes block encryption was used.

Sometimes stream encryption.

Sometimes both in mixed layers.

That ensured that even if a segment were intercepted, brute-force decryption using current computing power would take thousands of years.

And even then, the result would only be fragmented nonsense with no meaning.

Since he only needed to operate within Earth's range, Henry didn't particularly care about transmission distance.

Rather than miniaturize a quantum entanglement communicator, it was easier to build a monstrously complex encryption system.

For someone like Henry—whose technological reserves weren't yet systematic and who had to focus resources on solving one field at a time—that was the more practical route.

So when facing Reacher's question, Henry could guarantee this much:

Even if the greatest minds on Earth gathered together, they'd still need several generations of upgraded tools before they could intercept and crack his system.

Pure technological domination.

It felt amazing.

A quantum computer had already been completed in the undersea laboratory.

Though only an early-stage model, it was paired with topological chips.

According to Moore's Law, Earth's science would need at least another thirty years before laboratories could begin approaching Henry's current level.

Commercial products would take even longer.

Of course, it was still possible that some outrageous genius somewhere would invent a shortcut.

But as Henry continued mastering Kree and Skrull technology, his growth rate would only outpace Earth's Moore's Law progress further.

He had no obsession with squeezing maximum profit from every stage before advancing to the next.

That was the logic of businessmen trapped in market economics.

Intel's habit of incremental upgrades was a perfect example.

Henry wasn't in a hurry to establish his own original scientific framework.

First, he would fully digest the knowledge of two great alien empires.

Study the proper roads.

Study the shortcuts.

Watch others walk them first.

Then build something of his own.

That was the truly practical path.

Forget nonsense like:

"Only forging a path no one else has walked is the pride of Kryptonians!"

First of all—how do you walk a different road unless you know what roads others already built?

And unlike Earth, there was no patent law issue here.

He didn't need to avoid seeing other people's designs out of fear of accidentally copying them and getting sued.

Still...

Explaining all this to Jack Reacher would probably be like playing music to a cow.

And much of it couldn't be spoken aloud anyway.

He had already revealed enough today.

No need to expose his final cards too.

So after suppressing his urge to brag for a long while, Henry finally answered through Little Duck:

"The line is secure. But you should still choose your information carefully. Eat first—I'm not in a hurry."

Reacher picked up his knife and fork again and resumed cutting into the steak prepared by a robot.

To his own surprise, it was excellent.

Nothing like the chemical-lab food he had imagined.

Reacher also ate quickly.

But unlike many people, he focused entirely on eating while doing so. He didn't talk with food in his mouth.

During that time, Henry temporarily disconnected.

He removed his glasses and rubbed the bridge of his nose.

This rescue operation had been both a success and a failure.

The success:

He had extracted the target unharmed.

Well... mostly unharmed.

A few scrapes and bruises, but Reacher himself didn't care, so Henry saw no need to fuss.

The failure:

He had accidentally leaked personal intelligence.

Part of that was Reacher's terrifying observational ability.

But part of it was Henry himself.

He had grown complacent.

Pride in mastering alien technology far beyond Earth's visible science.

The prestige brought by the Titanic project.

Though the biggest beneficiary of that was James Cameron, the producer-director.

Still, Henry's old reputation of:

"The idiot investor who knows nothing about movies"

had transformed into:

"The lucky bastard who still knows nothing about movies."

Then there was having one of the world's great beauties as his girlfriend.

Honestly, if that didn't send a man's ego sky-high, what would?

But reality had proven something important:

A smooth winning streak did not guarantee freedom from mistakes.

Just a little carelessness.

A plan overtaken by events.

And suddenly several secrets he never intended to reveal had slipped out.

He called over a flight attendant and requested an alcoholic drink.

Alcohol did nothing to a Kryptonian body—

But at least it could sting his tongue.

When Henry judged enough time had passed, he put his glasses back on and reconnected with Little Duck at Goat Valley Laboratory.

He came back online just in time to see Jack Reacher asking for the first-aid kit and cleaning his wounds.

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Chapter 509 509: The Videotape Appears

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Jack Reacher noticed that the support drone Little Duck was moving differently now.

Especially the warning light on the square upper body—it had changed from red back to green.

Reacher greeted it.

"You're back? Earlier I tried talking to this machine, but it only gave simple mechanical replies. That's when I realized you'd stepped away for a while.

"Hope you don't mind me borrowing your first-aid kit. I only mentioned it, and that little spherical robot brought everything out."

Through Little Duck's electronic voice, Henry replied:

"Don't worry. Tools are meant to be used. Your injuries aren't serious, are they?"

"The strength those vampires had was incredible for their size," Reacher said. "But still within what I can handle."

Looking at this man—easily classified among the toughest of humans—Henry knew there was no need to worry much.

Now that the principal had returned, Reacher finished tending his wounds more quickly.

After packing up the first-aid kit, the remaining items—including trash—were collected by BB-2. The small robot then retreated into the hidden second-level space.

Little Duck floated forward and addressed the former Military Police Special Investigations captain.

"Then please explain the progress of your investigation.

"Since we're speaking over communications, any names or sensitive people involved do not need to be spoken directly. Just tell me roughly how far you've gotten.

"Depending on the situation, I may not be the only one listening. To save your time, I need to judge whether the concerned party should also be informed. You understand."

Reacher frowned.

"Wouldn't it make more sense for me to report to you, and then you relay it to that person?"

Little Duck shook left and right in a very human-like gesture.

"No, no, no. You don't think that person is too arrogant to deal with you directly, do you?

"It's not that. I only handle miscellaneous matters. But I can't predict what details he would want to know.

"So when you've gathered enough intelligence and feel ready to report, naturally you should speak to him directly.

"Unless the reason you came to me today was because you ran into difficulties and needed someone to assist you. That falls within my scope of work.

"Of course, only the parts I can solve. If it exceeds my capability, I still have to notify him."

Reacher nodded.

After a moment of consideration, Henry added:

"Besides, because of my relationship with that person—and with the subject of the investigation—I'm not really a suitable middleman.

"It takes a neutral third party like you, someone completely uninvolved, to restrain some of his irrational behavior.

"At the very least, for a stranger's sake, he probably won't say anything too harsh."

Whether that spoiled rich kid would actually restrain himself, Henry had no idea.

What he did know was that if he wanted to avoid being yelled at, the best strategy was naturally to trick someone else into handling it.

Since they were speaking over communications, both men tacitly avoided mentioning certain names directly, instead speaking in vague terms.

After hearing the explanation, Reacher frowned.

"This complicated?"

"If you investigated the relationship between those two people, then you should understand."

"I do."

Reacher stopped dwelling on it and continued.

"Fine. Then I'll begin.

"The investigation really has hit a bottleneck.

"What happened back then was not the accident everyone believes it was.

"It was deliberate. Planned. Human action.

"Whether the target was a person or an object, I still can't say for certain."

Henry's attention sharpened.

"But I found the culprit.

"More accurately—I know who the culprit is.

"The problem is that continuing the investigation creates many obstacles.

"One of them is authority. I don't have clearance to investigate certain records.

"And I suspect this kind of sensitive data usually has tripwire mechanisms attached.

"In other words, whether or not I find anything, simply accessing the records could alert certain people.

"If there's a cleanup protocol behind it, it would definitely trigger."

Reacher's expression remained calm.

"I was careful. I never directly touched anything that could lead investigators back to me.

"But I can't be certain I erased every trace.

"I can't be sure no one can still find me."

He paused.

"When I ran into those vampires, I actually thought it was the other side tracking me down.

"But after reviewing the circumstances—and how the vampires behaved—it was probably just coincidence."

Henry was speechless.

"You knew trouble might already be following you, and you still stopped to save someone?"

"At first I thought the situation would be easy to handle," Reacher said plainly. "Who knew I'd run into opponents like that?"

"And that's why you didn't want to meet the police?"

"Correct."

"You came here secretly too?"

"I created several breaks in my trail during travel. Following me wouldn't be easy.

"But after the vampire incident, I can't be sure whether the victim saw my face."

"Mm."

Having grasped the situation, Henry no longer pursued whether Reacher's trail had been compromised.

Instead, he returned to the real issue.

"You said you found the culprit.

"Do you have evidence?"

Reacher reached into the backpack he never let out of his sight and pulled out a videotape.

At the same time, he said:

"This is the traffic footage from the crash."

Far away on the airplane, Henry stared wide-eyed at the image transmitted through his glasses.

Jack Reacher had actually obtained the tape.

Henry asked immediately:

"The investigating authorities said no video footage from the accident existed.

"How did you get it?

"Did it come from inside that agency?"

Reacher explained:

"The existence of this tape cannot be found in official records.

"Because at the time of the incident, the road surveillance system in that area was undergoing an upgrade and replacement process."

He continued:



"According to my investigation, that stretch of road was upgraded in December—from the original videotape system to a digital imaging system—and the work was officially approved."

"But the new system was highly unstable in its early phase.

"It often failed to transmit footage or properly save recordings.

"That is why no crash footage officially exists.

"Though I can't rule out the possibility that footage was deliberately deleted afterward."

Henry prompted, "But..."

Reacher nodded.

"But the acceptance process for the upgrade was corrupt.

"The contractor had not actually finished replacing all systems on that road segment.

"They only completed part of it."

"And the old system had not been fully removed yet.

"Its recording function was still active."

He set the tape on the table.

"The company had financial problems. To receive payment on schedule, they bribed the inspectors to falsify acceptance records.

Chapter 510 510: Informing the Young Master

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If the videotape in Jack Reacher's hand was the deadly tape Henry believed it to be, then it explained one thing.

No matter whether this world's Helmut Zemo—the mastermind from Captain America: Civil War—was a Hydra member or not, the way he obtained the tape in the future was very likely the same method Reacher had used.

Because according to Henry's understanding, Hydra's internal resources were nowhere near as smoothly shared as outsiders imagined.

Branches under different leaders often sabotaged one another.

Suppose the Hydra-controlled S.H.I.E.L.D. faction had also sought to suppress the truth and obtained footage of the crash.

They most likely focused on the digital system.

Even if it was S.H.I.E.L.D.'s doing, they would have had their own reasons for hiding the truth.

Reacher had mentioned that the newly installed digital surveillance system was malfunctioning, which explained why the crash footage was supposedly never saved.

But that could also have been a cover story used by intelligence agencies.

Once surveillance hard drives passed their retention period, recovery became extremely difficult.

Old data would be overwritten to make room for new recordings.

Even traces left in the drive mechanisms themselves would be buried.

Whoever handled the cover-up had clearly only looked at the visible digital system.

They had overlooked the old videotape system beneath the surface—the one that should have been scrapped but hadn't yet been removed.

That oversight created the opportunity for both Jack Reacher now, and Baron Zemo in the future.

But since Reacher had obtained the tape today, future Zemo was going to have a headache.

At this point, Henry no longer doubted the tape's authenticity.

Still, he asked one more question.

"Does your source still have any other copies?"

Reacher replied calmly:

"I paid him well.

"If he's smart, he knows this kind of thing can't be sold a second or third time.

"If he's stupid enough not to understand that, then whatever consequences follow are his to bear alone."

"Fair enough."

Henry understood.

The person most likely to care about this information—and pay the highest price for it—was the young master behind him.

Beyond that, Howard Stark's death was old news from seven or eight years ago.

Whether the truth surfaced or not would not affect the current balance of power.

"And by regulation, road footage had to be retained for one month.

"Within that month, the contractor finished the upgrade using the newly received funds.

"The old system's recordings had not yet reached the overwrite deadline, so this tape survived by pure luck."

Reacher looked at Henry through the drone.

"Only the workers involved knew this.

"That's why no one else knew the tape existed.

"Even though Howard Stark's fatal crash was major news, they kept quiet to protect themselves."

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So Reacher not trying to suppress the information was understandable.

Because to anyone else, the information had little value.

That assumption, of course, depended on Tony Stark already knowing.

After thinking for a moment, Henry asked:

"You watched the contents?"

Reacher nodded.

"Yes.

"And I conducted a preliminary investigation into the killer.

"But pushing further would trigger exactly the kind of problems I mentioned earlier.

"So I stopped there.

"Then I contacted you."

He added:

"My original orders from my superior were only to assist with the investigation.

"They did not include arresting anyone.

"And in this matter, I have no legal authority anyway.

"This isn't military jurisdiction."

Fully understanding the situation, Henry said directly:

"It sounds like the intelligence you've gathered is already enough to notify that person.

"Based on my judgment, once you brief him, your mission is over.

"Because what comes next will be conflict on another level."

Reacher looked relieved.

"If so, that would be excellent.

"This private assignment has taken too much of my time.

"I still have many real criminals who deserve attention—and they're still walking free."

At that moment, BB-2 rolled out from the hatch beneath the stove again.

This time, balancing on its head was a portable phone unlike any commercial model.

Little Duck floated above it.

Rather than dialing normally, a small connector extended from its utility arm and plugged directly into the phone.

Then it dialed.

Moments later, the call connected.

Since it was the middle of the night, the person on the other end sounded full of murderous irritation.

"Who the hell is calling this number?"

"If this isn't important, I guarantee you won't see tomorrow's sun.

"And by important, I mean World War Three—or some unlucky asteroid heading for Earth.

"So speak.

"And you'd better pray I'm fully awake right now."

Through the connection, Henry said plainly:

"The investigation from over a year ago has results.

"You were right.

"If you want to see it, come over."

The words were simultaneously broadcast through Little Duck's speaker.

"Fu—"

The moment Henry heard the F-word begin, he immediately cut the call.

Then he said cheerfully to Reacher:

"That should make him come as fast as possible.

"If he could open portals, he'd probably appear behind us right now."

He meant it as a joke.

But Reacher suddenly looked like he had seen a ghost.

He rubbed his eyes in disbelief.

Henry asked through Little Duck:

"What's wrong?"

"I thought I just saw sparks appear in midair," Reacher said slowly. "Then they vanished.

"Do you have some kind of strange device here?"

Little Duck immediately spun in place.

One flaw of the drone was that its field of vision only covered the direction of its camera, leaving blind spots.

So Henry asked:

"Where exactly did you see sparks?"

"About five o'clock from where you were floating before.

"Five inches upward."

Little Duck quickly repositioned and examined the indicated location.

"Here?"

"Close enough."

It circled the spot several times.

Unfortunately, the sensors on Little Duck were still too limited.

Or perhaps whatever had happened left no detectable trace.

Henry found nothing unusual.

With no better answer, he shrugged verbally.

"Maybe your eyes were playing tricks on you.

"Forget it. Get some rest.

"You still have to bounce all the way back to the city tomorrow."

The thought of repeating that trip made even a hard man like Jack Reacher feel pain in places best left unnamed.

Henry was about to dock Little Duck on its charging station and put it into standby mode when Reacher spoke again.

"Can I ask you something?"

"If it's something I can answer, I will."

The hidden meaning was obvious:

If he couldn't answer, he wouldn't say a word.

Even so, Little Duck floated back toward him.

Chapter 511 511: Meeting Up

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Traveling in broad daylight was, in the end, far less convenient than moving at night.

Especially since Kitty's Duck-Leopard Armor had no stealth system installed yet, and its size wasn't exactly small.

If it streaked through the daytime sky over the city, it would be highly conspicuous.

There was no guarantee some nosy citizen wouldn't spot it, tell a tabloid reporter, and create yet another urban legend.

So this trip did not go all the way to Stark Pictures.

Instead, Reacher was dropped off near the outskirts of the city.

Reacher didn't ask for favors or make deals.

He simply said:

"I want to know about vampires."

Little Duck lowered itself and hovered in front of him again.

Henry asked:

"Why do you want to know about vampires?"

"If they're living among us, then knowing more can't hurt.

"And I've got a score to settle with them.

"Even if the ones who attacked me already died by your hand."

As dark evil creatures, vampires clearly already had a deep-rooted public image.

No one seemed interested in asking whether any vampires might be decent people.

So Reacher's attitude was perfectly normal.

Henry asked:

"What do you want to know?"

"Anything.

"Habits. Weaknesses. Traits. Distribution.

"How to find them.

"How to avoid them.

"What to watch out for."

Just as Henry generously funded Blade and his vampire hunters to make life miserable for vampires, he certainly wasn't going to suppress Reacher's curiosity.

Under Henry's control, BB-2 brought out a white projection screen and hung it on the wall directly facing Reacher.

The lights inside the container dimmed.

Then BB-2 moved before the screen and began projecting images.

Little Duck became the lecturer.

Henry explained everything he had personally observed about vampire biology and their situation in Los Angeles.

He also described what he knew of other regions—including Europe.

Though only in broad terms.

He couldn't provide detailed descriptions of each faction's structure or political traits.

He even reserved judgment on whether all vampires were truly the same species.

Because Henry knew something else.

If Morbius existed in this universe, then that man was a completely different breed of vampire from the kind Blade hunted.

Which only proved one thing:

This universe was an absolute mess.

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There, Henry had arranged a car overnight using Little Duck—a vehicle Reacher could drive himself into town.

Though it took more time, it spared him another full ride of brutal bouncing on the Duck-Leopard Armor.

Reacher naturally had no objections.

The vehicle Henry prepared was an old battered pickup truck.

When it started, the engine coughed and rattled as if it were about to shake itself apart.

Still, all four wheels remained attached, and pressing the gas pedal made it move.

According to Henry:

"When you're done with it, just dump it by the roadside. No need to park it anywhere specific."

Reacher also didn't leave Goat Valley Laboratory empty-handed.

The previous night's vampire briefing had naturally included methods for killing vampires.

Crosses were useless.

Unless the cross was made of silver—and you were strong enough to hammer it into a vampire's heart.

The real tools were garlic extract and silver weapons.

Ordinary garlic only triggered instinctive disgust in vampires. It had little killing power.

Silver, however, worked wonderfully.

Against werewolves too.

The downside was obvious:

Expensive.

Traditional silver bullets were indispensable tools of modern vampire hunters.

Because of the heat and speed generated when firing, bullets couldn't simply be silver-plated.

The coating would likely burn off during discharge.

So traditional hunters had to cast bullets entirely from silver.

One could imagine the cost.

That expendable ammunition expense was one of the key reasons vampire hunters could not launch large-scale offensives.

Very few people could do what Blade did—fight vampires head-on with melee weapons.

Usually, if a hunter had to rely on close combat, it was already the signal to retreat.

Even with silver weapons, they might kill a few vampires—

But not many.

And they themselves would leave wounded or exhausted.

The silver nitrate rounds and ultraviolet rounds Black Super had developed were vastly more difficult to manufacture than traditional pure silver bullets.

But their cost was dramatically lower.

Unfortunately, the equipment Black Super had provided to Abraham Whistler—Blade's quartermaster and mentor—for producing the special rounds had limited output.

Others who copied the machines produced flawed ammunition to varying degrees.

When they discussed this the night before, Reacher had asked:

"Why doesn't anyone just hand these machines to an arms factory and mass-produce the rounds?"

But even as he asked, Reacher had already thought of the answer.

So he instead asked another question.

"How effective are these special rounds against ordinary humans?"

Henry replied:

"If you shoot a person, they'd probably only be slightly worse than rubber bullets.

"But high-concentration silver nitrate is corrosive to human tissue.

"And ultraviolet rounds carry mild radiation.

"So the wounds would be harder to treat than normal gunshot injuries."

Reacher nodded.

"So factories producing anti-vampire ammunition would simply become targets for vampires.

"The best method is still mobile small workshops—basically the current vampire hunter model."

"Correct."

After finishing the discussion, Henry still had BB-2 deliver Reacher a standard Beretta M9 pistol.

Along with it came:

one magazine loaded with silver nitrate rounds

one magazine loaded with ultraviolet rounds

one magazine of ordinary ammunition

Including the magazine already inside the pistol, that was more ammunition than an average patrol officer usually carried.

Once he had a weapon in hand, Reacher immediately ejected the standard magazine and loaded the ultraviolet rounds instead.

Then he handed the two standard magazines back.

For him, ordinary humans were manageable.

Vampires were not.

Chapter 512 512: The Truth Revealed

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about:blank

So firearms should be optimized for vampires.

Henry naturally said nothing.

That entire night, Reacher's hunger for vampire knowledge had been intense.

Compared with that, Henry didn't actually have endless intelligence to provide—

Unless Reacher wanted to hear old folklore and campfire stories about vampires.

Clearly, he did not.

So the large man who had taken a beating from vampires still managed to get some sleep.

Considering the young master on the East Coast might drive west at some insane speed once notified, Reacher set out at dawn from the Goat Valley wilderness.

Henry, meanwhile, had no choice but to wait for his own plane to land and then return from the airport to Stark Pictures by car.

No matter how urgent things were, speed had limits.

He had not submitted advance business-clearance requests days earlier, so this sudden trip could not use VIP customs lanes.

He had to queue with everyone else—

Just to receive an entry stamp on his passport.

The result:

Henry and Jack Reacher arrived at Stark Pictures at nearly the same time.

But the true owner of the building, Tony Stark, had already been sitting in the CEO's office for who knew how long.

The moment Tony saw Henry, he opened fire verbally.

"How were you contacting me from a plane?"

"When I got here and couldn't find you, I was one step away from driving to your house and dragging you out of bed.

"Then I asked around and found out you were flying back from Sydney. You hadn't even landed this morning.

"And another thing—your computer files consistently show concern about artificial intelligence.

"You don't seriously think Skynet-style nonsense is easy to build, do you?"

"Connected to a network and suddenly omnipotent? Distributed nodes impossible to track?

"That's fantasy written by people who don't understand technology.

"Just solving data-flow aggregation alone—do they think the human nervous system can all function as a brain?

"No... actually maybe they do.

"Given the size of their brains, a few nerve clusters would be enough.

"And blockchain systems—you know how much computing power and electricity that takes?

"If blowing up a power plant can cripple it, why are you afraid of it?"

The moment they met, Tony unleashed a torrent of questions and criticism.

Henry didn't even know where to begin responding.

But Tony's attitude did not mean he didn't care why he had rushed across the country.

It meant the opposite.

The closer he got to the truth, the less he wanted to face it.

So he distracted himself by obsessing over anything else.

Henry answered none of the questions.

Instead, standing in the doorway, he called out:

"Yulian, three coffees please.

"And Mr. Stark and I need to discuss something.

"So no matter how important anything else is—hold it back for now."

"Yes, boss."

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When secretary Yulian Williams brought the coffee into the office, Henry and Tony Stark were in the middle of debating the moral implications of artificial intelligence—where ethical red lines should be drawn, whether they should exist at all, and who had the right to draw them.

It had become their most common topic lately.

To the point that they practically argued about it every time they met.

The reason was simple.

It wasn't that Henry was paranoid.

It was that Tony Stark had recently earned a doctorate in artificial intelligence from MIT, and every time they met, he simply had to show off to the man who technically didn't even have an elementary school diploma.

So Henry naturally made it his mission to undermine him.

Whenever Tony started, Henry would casually pull out The Terminator or the 1982 film Blade Runner as counterarguments.

That cult sci-fi film had, after sixteen years, finally begun to mature in influence.

And if anyone wondered why Tony Stark couldn't simply out-debate Henry—

The answer was obvious.

Henry had fully awakened into a contrarian keyboard warrior.

With the intelligence of both men, it was far too easy for them to quote papers, philosophy, and logical loopholes while mercilessly attacking each other's weak points.

The result:

Neither could win.

Only after the office door closed behind Yulian did Henry loudly declare:

"I'm done listening to you."

Then he switched on the large office television, changed it to CNN, and turned the volume up high.

Tony Stark wordlessly placed a signal jammer onto the desk.

The device was even larger than earlier models.

That wasn't because Tony's miniaturization skills had declined.

It was because it now integrated more sophisticated anti-surveillance and anti-eavesdropping systems to counter newer spying methods.

Hence the increased size.

Meanwhile, Henry prepared a VCR and a smaller television.

He was about to play the videotape Jack Reacher had brought.

Tony said nothing.

He simply watched Henry work.

When the grainy black-and-white surveillance footage appeared on screen, Tony instinctively turned his face away.

Then he forced himself to look back.

And watched seriously.

The footage showed a quiet road with little traffic.

Suddenly, a familiar Chrysler sedan smashed at high speed into a roadside utility pole.

At the top of the frame, something flashed past.

Moments later, that object returned.

It was a rider on a heavy motorcycle, stopping behind the wrecked Chrysler.

It looked less like rescue—

And more like blocking escape.

At that moment, the driver had already crawled out of the vehicle and was dragging himself across the ground.

That white hair.

That suit.

So familiar.

So painful.

The motorcyclist did not rush to help.

Instead, he first opened the trunk of the Chrysler, checked something inside, and only then walked over to the injured driver.

But he did not help him.

He punched that face—the same face Tony probably imagined every time he looked in the mirror—several times with brutal force.

Then he dragged the man, unconscious or dead, back into the driver's seat.

The rider paid no attention to the engine already catching fire.

Instead, he moved to the passenger side and remained there for several moments.

Though the camera angle couldn't show what happened, judging from the driver's fate, the passenger likely met no kinder end.

And though Tony could not see the face clearly—

He knew exactly who had been in that seat.

After finishing everything, the motorcyclist walked directly toward the surveillance camera and raised a gun to destroy it.

No one knew why he hadn't done that immediately after turning back, but only waited until the deed was done.

Yet that very decision allowed the camera to capture his face clearly.

Especially the unmistakable metallic sheen of his left arm.

Not something an ordinary man wore.

Henry had intended to pause the footage the instant the killer aimed at the camera.

Instead, he said nothing.

He let the image dissolve into static.

Silence filled the room for a long time.

Reacher, who had already seen the footage, spent the entire time watching Tony Stark.

A man he normally would never have the chance to approach.

Tony's microexpressions and involuntary gestures never stopped.

His internal turmoil was obvious.

In fact, even through the external noise, Reacher felt as though he could hear Tony's furious heartbeat.

Thump.

Thump.

Unlike their earlier AI argument, Henry said nothing sharp this time.

He kept his eyes on the little television and never looked at Tony's face.

Only when Tony finally spoke in a dry, strained voice did Henry move.

"Who is the killer?"

Henry rewound the tape to the frame where the gunman's face was clearest as he aimed at the camera.

Then paused it.

Reacher opened his backpack and spread the collected files across the desk.

He selected one and placed it in front of Tony.

"Based on facial analysis, the killer is highly likely to be this man.

"U.S. Army Sergeant James Buchanan Barnes.

"Nickname: Bucky Barnes.

"Original member of Captain America's Howling Commandos.

"And Steve Rogers' closest friend before enlistment."

Tony's first reaction was not anger.

It was confusion.

"Wait.

"If that's true, then he and the old man should have been friends.

"And World War Two?

"How old is he now?"

"Born in 1917," Reacher answered calmly.

"He should now be eighty-one years old.

"But officially, in 1945—days before Nazi Germany surrendered—he was listed as MIA during an operation.

"Later declared dead."

Tony stared at him.

"What the hell is that supposed to mean?"

Reacher pulled out another file and placed it down.

"Based on my investigation, the most plausible explanation is as follows:

"From World War Two onward, nations invested heavily in super-soldier research.

"The only publicly known wartime successes were Nazi Germany's Red Skull—

"And Captain America."

He continued:

"After the war, such research never stopped.

"Every nation sought ways to mass-produce super soldiers, not merely create one or two symbolic heroes."



"The Red Empire proposed a concept:

"Use mechanical prosthetics to restore crippled veteran soldiers to combat readiness.

"Then apply mental conditioning to strip away their humanity and create perfect soldiers."

He turned another page.

"To extend operational lifespan, these soldiers would be cryogenically stored when not in use, then thawed only for missions.

"That program was called—

"The Winter Soldier Program."

Tony narrowed his eyes.

"How do you know any of this?"

Reacher produced more papers.

"During the Cold War, both the United States and the Soviet Union constantly floated bizarre military concepts and fake programs to make the other side waste resources chasing shadows.

"Strategic deception.

"Bluffing.

"Psychological warfare.

"There were endless files like that.

"Because many were only concepts, their classification levels were low."

Chapter 513 513: Where the Serum Went

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Tony Stark picked up the files on the desk and flipped through them rapidly, saying nothing the entire time.

Jack Reacher, as if adding footnotes to his own theory, continued:

"If we don't use the concept behind the Winter Soldier Program, then we can't explain why an American MIA soldier never returned home and instead remained in a former World War II Allied nation.

"Nor can we explain why a decorated war hero who once served in the Howling Commandos—someone who should have known Howard Stark personally—would carry out that assassination as if he didn't recognize him at all.

"I personally went to the Smithsonian Museum in Washington and visited the Captain America exhibit. I confirmed Sergeant 'Bucky Barnes' appearance and wartime record.

"I find it extremely difficult to believe a brave and honorable war hero like that would murder an old friend.

"And do it in such a disgraceful way—disguising it as a traffic accident."

Only then did Henry finally get a chance to observe Tony Stark's reaction.

It was very different from the rage Tony showed in Captain America: Civil War, when Baron Zemo exposed the truth.

Back then, Bucky Barnes—already mostly recovered mentally and aware of what he had done—was standing right there.

The feud had been dragged into the open by a third party.

Bucky offered no apology.

Captain America defended him.

Anyone would explode under those circumstances.

Especially someone as emotional as Tony Stark.

But now, there were only files on the table.

No inseparable pair of best friends standing there to irritate him.

That gave Tony room to calmly think through the causes, consequences, and possible hidden factors.

Or perhaps—

He was so furious he literally couldn't speak.

Henry and Reacher simply weren't the targets of that fury, so Tony was restraining himself.

Either way—

Timing mattered.

Baron Zemo had orchestrated everything carefully and revealed the truth at the most destructive possible moment.

"But once a project was proven real—or actual progress began—its security level would be raised."

He tapped the documents.

"Back then, records were still mostly paper.

"Things slipped through."

"I found only one surviving sheet referring to the Winter Soldier Program.

"It merely described the concept.

"That is highly unusual.

"Most fake programs leave larger paper trails."

He looked directly at Tony Stark.

"So I reasonably suspect the program was real.

"It advanced to active execution.

"And that single surviving page was simply overlooked during reclassification."

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If the already fractured group of heroes hadn't completely imploded, it would have been a waste of all his effort.

As for what effect it would have now that Reacher had exposed the truth years earlier—

Henry was genuinely curious.

"Motivation?"

Tony carefully placed the file back onto the table.

The deliberate gentleness made it obvious how hard he was suppressing his anger.

He said:

"First, we can rule out personal revenge.

"That idiot looks like he was brainwashed into being nothing more than a killing machine.

"So there was definitely someone behind this.

"But what was the motive?"

He looked up.

"We all know the Red Empire collapsed only days later.

"Assassinating a capitalist through covert murder wouldn't save anything.

"And the world treated my father's death as an accident—not some glorious red victory."

"Regarding that..." Reacher rummaged through the pile and pulled out the bottom-most file.

"This was obtained by chance.

"It may explain some things."

He continued:

"As I mentioned earlier, every capable nation continued super-soldier research after the war.

"There were broadly two directions.

"One: pursue entirely new approaches.

"Two: replicate the successful Captain America model."

"However, Dr. Abraham Erskine—the principal researcher behind the serum—was dead.

"The original formula and serum were lost or destroyed."

"So the only advantages remaining in American hands were:

"Captain America's blood samples.

"And Howard Stark himself, one of the scientists involved in the original project."

Reacher placed a finger on the file.

"For a long time, recreating the original super-soldier serum used on Captain America was a military task assigned to Howard Stark."

"I heard there were several partial successes over the years.

"I couldn't access those records due to clearance restrictions."

"But the final successful transport involved Howard Stark personally."

"Officially, he and his wife were driving from a research facility back to their home on Long Island, New York."

"In reality, they were transporting five doses of super-soldier serum to be delivered to someone—or some organization."

"They were intercepted en route."

"The Stark couple died."

"The serum vanished."

Tony picked up the final file.

Inside was a classified transport schedule.

Howard and Maria Stark had been only one segment of the delivery chain.

The document was incomplete, but enough remained for a clear conclusion.

Anyone who obtained that plan and wanted the serum would naturally strike the weakest link.

Howard and Maria Stark.

From that angle—

The Starks had not been the target.

They were collateral damage.

The realization made Tony's anger surge instantly.

If he could breathe fire, he would have found some unlucky bastard and roasted him alive.

Which idiot designed a plan this flawed?

If the cargo was truly important, why wasn't it escorted under heavy guard?

Why entrust it to an older married couple?

The result:

They lost the serum—

And lost two lives with it.

Tony did not doubt the file's authenticity for a second.

It also explained why Bucky Barnes, after forcing the crash, first opened the trunk instead of immediately killing anyone.

Because his primary mission was the serum.

Howard and Maria's deaths were less assassination than cleanup.

They had to die to conceal the theft.

Tony's suspicion immediately shifted to another group:

The people who had told him the crash was merely an accident.

If they knew the serum had gone missing—

How could they have concluded it was accidental?

That meant they had lied.

But why?

Did they know the truth?

Or—

Had they helped cover it up?

Chapter 514 514: Sentry

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"I don't like this guy."

Tony Stark gave his verdict immediately.

And the first time Henry had seen this man appear on television, it had made him question all over again exactly what world he had transmigrated into.

Sentry had burst onto the American East Coast scene in late 1996, roughly a year after Captain Marvel left Earth.

He repeatedly appeared to resolve crises large and small, acting exactly like a comic-book superhero.

But the battle that truly established Sentry's reputation happened earlier this year.

His opponent was said to be a marine iguana affected by French Polynesian nuclear testing.

One of the iguanas had been mutated by radiation into a gigantic beast resembling a dinosaur, and it invaded Manhattan, New York.

Maybe even participated?

Tony said none of this aloud.

He knew the difference.

Hiring the U.S. Army Military Police to investigate an old crash was one thing.

Penetrating another organization and investigating internal operations was another entirely.

In the intelligence world, that was nearly equivalent to declaring war.

He could not outsource that.

Nor did he need to.

Jack Reacher had already done enough.

He had uncovered the truth.

And if this were a normal police case, the next step would be arrests and interrogations.

But when Reacher had been loaned out, the military had drawn clear boundaries.

They likely suspected there was more to the Starks' deaths too.

They just lacked details.

So they lent Tony one of their best investigators—

With limits.

Reacher was not allowed to escalate matters recklessly.

Which meant Tony now needed more intelligence and leverage of his own.

So he asked another question.

"Who got the stolen serum?"

Reacher hesitated.

Then chose honesty.

"I suspect..."

"...that one of the doses may be connected to the man currently on television."

Henry and Tony both turned.

CNN was broadcasting the grand opening ceremony of New York City's Watchtower Building.

Descending slowly from the sky at the center of the screen was a man in a golden bodysuit, blue-green cape, and black belt bearing a large S symbol.

The media called him the world's first true superhero.

Known to the public as:

The Golden Guardian

Sentry.

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The reason its origins were so clearly known was because French intelligence cleanup teams had been tracking the creature's movements all along, trying to "handle" it.

Whether by capture or extermination.

But after multiple failed operations, the French never succeeded.

Eventually the monster surfaced in New York, landed in Manhattan, and built a nest in Madison Square Garden to lay eggs.

That was when Sentry appeared.

He swiftly solved the monster crisis that ordinary soldiers could not handle, and completely destroyed the eggs in Madison Square Garden.

Before the beast could cause even greater destruction to New York, he erased the disaster entirely.

Prior to that, then-New York Mayor Rudy Giuliani had seriously considered issuing a citywide evacuation order with military assistance.

The economic losses would have been enormous.

Fortunately, it never came to that.

At the same time, the X-Men were still arguing with the government over whether they should be deployed.

The X-Men under Mystique operated very differently from Professor X's old team.

If a mission did not directly threaten mutants—or involve mutants—Mystique would stall if she could, dodge if she could, and drag things out if she couldn't.

Rumor had it that official dissatisfaction with the new X-Men had nearly reached the breaking point.

The defeated monster was named by the media:

Gozilla.

Everything about it sounded absurd.

Iron Man hadn't even been born yet.

The curtain on the Marvel Universe hadn't risen.

And yet the world had already twisted into something Henry barely recognized.

Marvel Comics colliding with a kaiju universe?

That was also why Henry had secretly begun building battle armor.

He needed something that could conceal his identity as much as possible while still providing real combat capability.

Because if he waited any longer, it would be too late.

Ever since Sentry appeared, that sense of urgency had settled over him.

After Sentry's battle with Gozilla, the superhero's influence only grew.

Major disasters around the world frequently saw his intervention.

The media even praised him extravagantly:

"We finally have our own Superman—our own Clark Kent."

The hottest recent news was that Sentry had personally erected a skyscraper in downtown New York in a very short time.

He had also created the artificial intelligence system C.L.O.C., tasked with monitoring the entire world and informing Sentry wherever disasters occurred.

The media's manic worship elevated this superhero's prestige to unimaginable heights.

Even politicians were exhausting themselves trying to appear in the same frame as him, hoping to receive a single sentence of endorsement.

As if to prove his dislike was not merely jealousy, Tony Stark unexpectedly added:

"I don't trust anything that looks perfect.

"Unless it's mathematics."

Then Tony immediately turned and asked:

"You said the super-soldier serum may be connected to him. Explain."

Jack Reacher answered:

"It still traces back to the super-soldier program.

"Canada's Department K joined forces with the American civilian project known as Operation Rebirth.

"The goal was to develop a serum surpassing the one used on Captain America."

He snorted faintly.

"Unfortunately, they had grand ambitions and miserable competence.

"Over several decades, they created thousands of isolated subprojects.

"Laboratory work was outsourced to private contractors.

"It looked like a shell program designed to siphon funding.

"No management worth mentioning."

"Then in 1992, the project suddenly announced a breakthrough.

"They claimed to have completed the Sentry Serum, boasting effects one hundred thousand times stronger than Captain America's super-soldier serum."

Tony's eyes narrowed.

"From a timeline perspective, they produced nothing for forty or fifty years after World War II.

"Then immediately after Howard Stark's super-soldier serum was stolen, everything changed.

"That makes me suspect the two events are connected."

Reacher lifted a hand.

"But that is only suspicion.

"I have no direct evidence."

He continued:

"For the next few years, the Sentry Serum remained in the validation stage.

"It had not yet officially reached human trial status.

"And just like the chaos of the larger project, too many laboratories interfered and submitted contradictory reports."

"Then in 1996, one of the subproject laboratories was robbed.

"And by year's end, a superhero calling himself Sentry appeared."

Tony asked sharply:

"You know his original identity?"

"Robert Reynolds.

"A drug addict.

"A habitual thief."

Tony frowned.

"No one intends to prosecute him for theft?"

Reacher answered with a trace of helplessness.

"From the government's perspective, fairly speaking—

"No one can prosecute him."

"Public authority ultimately depends on military force."

"But against someone who can kill a creature like Gozilla, can fly, and can appear anywhere in the world within moments..."

He spread his hands.

"Even if you wanted to nuke him, you'd first need to pray he politely remained still long enough to be hit."

Resting his chin on one hand, Tony tapped his cheek thoughtfully.

"Of everything you've said, what parts are actually proven?"

"Only Sentry's real identity has directly traceable evidence.

"As for the super-soldier serum connection, I have no proof linking it to Howard Stark's stolen formula.

"But in terms of timing, it is the most suspicious lead."

Tony's voice lowered.

"Do you think they ordered the theft?"

Reacher answered seriously:

"My view is that the people in Department K—whether core leadership or subproject heads—do not look like individuals with enough influence to order such an operation."

"Given how chaotic the program was, obtaining the serum for research feels more like a casual side move by whoever was truly behind it.

"Or a diversion."

"To pull attention away from the real target."

He leaned back.

"After all, any organization capable of locating the super-soldier serum, learning its transport route, and deploying an assassin with super-soldier-level ability to seize it..."

His tone hardened.

"...would not then allow some junkie to casually infiltrate them and steal the results."

"Probably the only thing outside their expectations..."

He looked toward Tony.

"...was that the project actually succeeded."

"And because of that, anything related to the Sentry Serum received much higher classification afterward.

"What I know ends there."

Tony was silent for a long moment.

He glanced toward the other man in the room—Henry—who had remained quiet the entire time.

He almost asked for his opinion.

Then decided against it.

Instead, Tony turned back to Reacher.

"I understand your findings.

"The next part will be handled by me.

"This goes beyond anything you people can touch."

He paused.

"Do you need anything?"

Anything at all?

Say the word."

Tony knew perfectly well that if the matter went deeper, then without legal authority or hidden power of his own, he would need outside help.

Whether the military would support him was not something a mere captain like Jack Reacher could decide.

So Tony was braking here.

He also had no idea which generals he could approach—or which might stand with him.

Looks like I need to visit an old uncle.

General Phillips.

Former head of the Strategic Scientific Reserve during World War II.

Creator of Captain America.

One of the old man's close friends.

The retired general was probably the most likely person to side with him.

But Reacher rejected Tony's goodwill without hesitation.

"No.

"And I don't need anything."

"I investigated this because it was my commanding officer's order.

"Not because I expected reward."

As he spoke, he casually organized the scattered documents on the table.

Naturally, these materials were for Tony Stark.

A billionaire's friendship meant very little to a drifter like Jack Reacher.

The only people Reacher trusted were comrades-in-arms.

But if the man he had hired refused reward, Tony Stark's pride would never allow him to do nothing.

He tore a blank strip from an unimportant document, wrote a phone number on it, and placed it in front of Reacher.

"My promise stands forever.

"When you need something, call this number."

Chapter 515 515: The Tough Guy Who Insisted on Taking the Bus

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Tony Stark making a trip to Los Angeles naturally didn't mean he had come only to inspect Stark Pictures.

Being diligent about work was never part of his persona.

So unsurprisingly, the guy had once again gone to throw a party at his private Malibu beach house.

With his wealth, this kind of pastime could be repeated every day until the day he croaked, and he still wouldn't run out of money. So as an employee, Henry saw no reason to worry about his boss's finances.

Henry drove his Cadillac, taking Jack Reacher on his way out.

Along the road, the former military police captain was even quieter than expected, making the atmosphere inside the car slightly awkward. Henry had no choice but to start the conversation.

"Do you have plans for getting back? Or I could send you on a private jet. You'd be back on the East Coast within three minutes."

Reacher replied, "No, thanks. I can roughly imagine your method. But I'm on an official assignment this trip, and I need to continue investigating in the Midwest.

"The West Coast matter took one day less than I expected, so I've got plenty of time now. Just drop me off at a bus station."

Henry had actually wanted to use a normal living human to test the Duck-Leopard Armor's hyper-acceleration launch system. Since Reacher refused, it wouldn't be proper to tie him onto Kitty's back by force.

So that idea was dropped.

Then Reacher suddenly asked, "That armor for the tiger... was it made by Stark Industries?"

"No. I designed and built it myself. It has nothing to do with Stark Industries." Henry looked curious and asked back, "Why would you think it did?"

"I just don't want to see something like that on a battlefield. If it wasn't developed by a genius arms dealer, that's a relief. But why make something like that in the first place?"

"You were military police, right? You weren't supposed to be on battlefields anyway..." Henry quipped before answering.

"You saw that guy on the news. And there are mutants everywhere. This world is too dangerous. I need some means of self-defense."

Reacher grumbled, "Military police don't go to the front lines, but how serious do you think military weapon leakage is?

"I don't want to be out in the field investigating something one day and have somebody unleash one of those metal monsters on me. The only opponents I'm confident dealing with are humans.

This time Reacher did not refuse.

But he merely picked up the paper, glanced at it once, and set it back atop the file stack.

"I've memorized it."

Tony blinked.

"That's it? You're just going to remember it?

"What if you forget?"

Reacher replied calmly:

"If it's something I can forget...

"Then it wasn't important to me."

Tony looked at the Military Police captain.

Then looked at the CEO he himself had appointed.

Then fell silent.

One or two men with personalities like this—

Made him want to strangle somebody.

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"But do you really need something like that for protection? According to what I've read, you're one of the mutants too. Your ability is that handgun rounds can't injure you."

Henry said, "My skin is thicker than average, sure. But that doesn't mean I can outrun everyone. There's an old joke, right? Two people are being chased by a lion on the savannah. They don't need to outrun the lion—just the other guy."

Speechless, Reacher finally squeezed out one sentence.

"So in the end, you don't trust the Sentry."

"Only an idiot entrusts their safety to the kindness of a superman. Maybe the comic one is an alien, while our Sentry is from Earth—but do you really think those concerns are unreasonable?"

"You planning to play Lex Luthor?" Reacher saw Henry's expression of disbelief and naturally added, "I had a childhood worshipping Superman too, you know. Is it that surprising I know the character?"

Returning to a normal expression while driving, Henry said flatly:

"I have no interest in becoming the Sentry's arch-enemy. If that guy causes trouble, I'll run as far away as possible.

"The media praising him as a savior and messiah, and the people behind promoting all of it—they're the ones who should clean up the mess if something happens. Though they'll probably also be the first to get warned and the first to run."

Reacher wanted to say something, but his mouth opened and closed several times before nothing came out.

As far as he knew, the reason the military and government were so indulgent toward the Sentry was simple:

They lacked any force capable of opposing him.

So they had settled for the next-best option—trying to control him through flattery.

Meanwhile, rumor had it that unauthorized human experiments with Sentry Serum had already begun.

But Canada's Department K was badly managed, and too many random civilian subcontractor labs were involved. No one even knew which specific serum dose had successfully created the Sentry.

Even the military, after intervening, still hadn't found the formula that had produced the first Sentry—let alone create a second one.

Suddenly, the pink cartoon electronic watch on Henry's wrist began to ring.

Reacher noticed it wasn't the top of the hour, nor was it exactly one hour after he had gotten in the car. So he asked directly:

"Got something else you need to handle?"

"Looks that way. I was actually thinking I could still take you farther, no matter where you were headed."

"No, thanks. I'm firm on this. I'll take the bus."

The tough guy remembered those two earlier trips that had been anything but comfortable, and rejected the offer with determination.



"Alright, alright. Bus station's here."

Henry pulled into the passenger drop-off area.

Carrying the backpack that held his military uniform, Reacher stepped out and raised his wrist, showing the watch Henry had given him—the one equipped with a tracker.

"I'm keeping this. Just like you said, there are too many crises in this world that manpower alone can't resist."

Henry smiled. "Next rescue will definitely be on time. But I still hope you never have to use it."

"Can anyone besides you track the signal?"

"Pull the crown beside the watch face out two clicks, manually set it to six-thirty, then activate it—that disables the active signal. Unless you press the distress button, the watch stays silent.

"To turn it back on, use the same method and set it to twelve o'clock."

Reacher glanced at the watch on his wrist.

"Thanks."

With that simple word, he turned and walked away.

Only after this very traditional American tough guy had gone some distance did Henry drive over to a nearby parking spot.

The cartoon watch alarm was also a distress signal.

The caller was Blade or Abraham Whistler.

The location: their hideout in the abandoned steel mill.

But it wasn't a direct emergency call.

Black Super had helped build their alarm system. Only when certain conditions were met would it automatically transmit a distress signal to Henry.

Otherwise, if those two vampire hunters triggered alarms over every little inconvenience, Henry would never get to live a normal life.

If they needed help with an emergency evacuation, Abraham Whistler would contact him personally.

Chapter 516 516: The Secret Base Under Surprise Attack

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The abandoned steel mill had just gone through a fierce battle.

Most of the place consisted of large industrial steel machinery that wasn't easily damaged, but there were still shattered bottles, scattered personal belongings, and obvious signs of bullet impacts and destruction.

Some corpses remained where they had fallen, all killed by shotgun blasts.

Black Super easily spotted faction markings on the backs of their necks or wrists—signs belonging to vampire clans.

As for the only two living people...

As he approached, Black Super saw an enraged Blade and Abraham Whistler slumped in a chair, having been brutally tortured.

The deliberate sound of approaching footsteps naturally drew attention.

Blade flicked his hand and instantly drew his modified large-caliber pistol, aiming it at Black Super.

Black Super didn't care in the slightest. He walked straight past the furious Daywalker and came to the limping old hunter's side.

"Whistler, you look like shit."

"Fuck you. Do you know I'm dying?"

Blade lowered the gun, his gaze sharp beneath the sunglasses.

"How did you know to come here?"

"I helped install your alarm system, remember? If there's abnormal shutdown activity, I get notified."

Black Super turned Whistler's neck to inspect it.

"You were bitten?"

"Yes. I got bitten. So do me a favor and end it quickly. You know what happens to someone like me—I'd become something worse than a vampire. I don't want to live like that. Put a bullet in me. Blade's a pussy. He won't do it."

Ignoring how the nearby black man somehow managed to visibly darken in mood, Black Super said:

"So even if I can save you, you still want to die? Tired of living?"

Blade immediately reacted.

"You can save him?!"

But this time, the signal had been sent automatically.

Which probably meant their secret base had already fallen.

Seeing the sun high in the sky, Henry wasn't surprised.

Because vampires feared sunlight, vampire hunters usually used daytime hours for investigations or personal business. Very few expected a vampire attack in broad daylight.

But vampires had developed sunblock long ago, allowing them to move briefly under sunlight.

Not to mention the humans serving them—those people were the real daytime operatives.

Traditionally, vampires simply didn't act during the day.

But recently, the loudest troublemakers were the younger radical faction among them.

If such a group of vampires and human collaborators launched a surprise attack—and Blade had been lured away—then that old man with one bad leg had no chance of defeating the invaders.

He might not even have been able to escape.

In truth, that was why Henry was moving so slowly and calmly.

The cartoon watch alarm was less a rescue signal—

And more a notice for him to come clean up the aftermath.

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"If he wants to live, yes. If he's determined to die, even Jesus couldn't save him."

Whistler suddenly looked like someone injected with adrenaline. He grabbed Black Super's arm.

"I can go back to normal? Walk in the sunlight?"

Black Super pressed him back down.

"Don't get excited. If your blood pressure rises and the bleeding worsens, then you really will die."

Then he added:

"Though if all you want is to walk... should I fix that crippled leg while I'm at it?"

"Do it! Whatever you want. I owe you my life!"

The old hunter lay back in the chair, grimacing in pain as he pulled something in his wounds.

Blade asked from the side, "What can I do?"

Black Super looked at the half-vampire, then at a videotape on a nearby shelf labeled PLAY ME.

"You're better at killing vampires than I am. I'm better at saving people than you are. Maybe you should go watch their message."

Whistler grabbed Black Super again.

"No! It's a trap. They pissed Blade off because those bastards need him."

Black Super pried the old man's hand off.

"I told you not to get excited. Keep bleeding like this and you're done."

As he spoke, he tore all of Whistler's clothes off—including the pants—exposing every wound.

The rough treatment made Whistler curse loudly.

"Fuck! What are you doing?!"

Black Super rummaged through the emergency medical kit.

"Treating your wounds. Nobody's interested in your old asshole."

Then he added casually:

"Unless those clothes had sentimental value. Like your dead wife gave them to you or something."

"Fuck! Just give me a bullet!"

Blade, standing nearby, let out a laugh.

Whistler shouted another furious:

"Fuck!"

Black Super removed his combat gloves and replaced them with medical rubber gloves from the first-aid kit.

He poured hydrogen peroxide over the wounds, disinfecting and cleaning them.

The pain was so intense that Whistler nearly lost the strength to curse.

As he worked, Black Super asked:

"Looks like I skipped a lot of plot. What's going on? Blade, explain."

Blade's voice returned to its usual low, dangerous tone.

"Deacon Frost. The vampire I've been tracking. The one who bit my mother.

"He's also the leader of the recent radical vampire faction in Los Angeles.

"From my investigation, he wants to carry out some ancient ritual—to transform himself into something beyond a vampire.

"The relevant information is on the hard drive I brought back. Whistler and the others cracked it recently and accessed the contents.

"And apparently I'm part of the ritual. That's why they're trying to lure me there."

Black Super began by treating the worst bleeding wounds first, then internal bleeding, and finally the torn flesh that merely looked worst.

That included the large mangled bite wound on Whistler's neck left by a vampire with terrible table manners.

The hardest part was the internal bleeding—because it couldn't be seen externally.

But for Black Super, who possessed x-ray vision, that wasn't a problem.

Sometimes he inserted forceps and thread through an existing wound to stitch internal damage.

Sometimes he had to cut a wound open further in order to suture and ligate bleeding inside.

He didn't explain any of it to Blade.

He simply moved quickly and efficiently from one injury to the next, smooth and practiced.

Any real medical professional witnessing it would have been stunned by the speed alone.

Black Super also didn't let Blade stand there uselessly.

"So now that the old man isn't dying, are you still planning to walk into their trap?"

Blade replied, "I'm guessing they also took Dr. Johnson. I still have to rescue her."

Chapter 517 517: Hints of the Blood God Ritual

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When Blade picked up a rag from who-knew-where, dipped it in water, and was about to wipe Abraham Whistler down, Black Super immediately stopped him.

"Get a fresh bucket of clean water," he said. "Then use the gauze from the first-aid kit to clean the blood off Whistler.

"If you really want him dead, just put a bullet through his forehead. No need to watch him suffer through infection and fever for half a day. Of course, if the two of you have some deep personal grudge, then forget I said anything."

Blade looked at the rag in his hand—something that might have wiped down engines or floors for all he knew—then at Whistler glaring daggers at him.

For once, Blade took advice.

But the moment the two men turned their heads and blinked, they saw Black Super walking back from afar with a pile of items in hand.

Blade stared blankly. "How did you..."

"I left some things in the car. Went out, grabbed them, came right back. Quick trip."

"You drove—...forget it. Never mind."

He had originally wanted to ask when exactly the guy had arrived by car. Then he realized trying to investigate these things was stupid and let it go.

Black Super returned to Whistler's side, casually dragged over a rack, and dumped the supplies onto it. Then he brought over something like a clothes stand and hung a bag of blood-red fluid from it, preparing a transfusion for the old vampire hunter.

Blade's sharp senses immediately told him something was off.

Pointing at the red bag, he asked, "What's that? That's not plasma."

Black Super replied, "Artificial plasma. It only acts as a temporary substitute. Recovery still depends mainly on the patient's own blood-forming ability. So for vampires, it's completely useless."

He glanced at Blade again.

"Hey, my connections aren't that good. You think ordinary people can casually get medical plasma whenever they want? If it saves him, that's enough. If you care so

"Dr. Johnson? Who's that? New member of your team?"

Blade answered:

"No. Dr. Karen Johnson. A hematology expert.

"She was bitten by Quinn before, and your Embrace Serum saved her life.

"She stayed because vampires were after her and she had nowhere else to go.

"Besides lying low, she also wanted to use your serum as a foundation to develop a cure for me—one that preserves my enhanced abilities.

"She got dragged into this because of me. So I'm responsible for bringing her back."

Black Super couldn't be bothered asking whether Dr. Johnson had the same romantic subplot with Blade as in the movie.

Instead he said:

"Alright, tough guy. Go get me a bucket of clean water.

"I need to wipe the blood off this old bastard before I bandage him. If dirt and blood stay on the skin, bacteria can cause infection."

At the same time, he removed the medical gloves and tossed them into the trash.

Blade asked:

"All the wounds are handled?"

"I've done everything I can for now.

"But I still need to go get plasma for this old fossil. With the amount of blood he lost, recovery will be terrible otherwise.

"As for his leg, he'll need an artificial joint.

"I'll have to get medical supplies first before I fix it too.

"You can't seriously expect me to carry that kind of thing around on me."

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much, send him to a real hospital."

Blade's mouth twitched.

"Do whatever you want."

Ignoring the permanently annoyed-looking man beside him, Black Super looked at Whistler, who already seemed somewhat better.

"Whistler, next I'm going to inject you with Embrace Serum to solve the transformation issue.

"I'm also giving you anesthetic so I can operate and reduce the pain.

"Afterward I'll move you somewhere safer to recover. This place is compromised now. No telling when vampires might come back."

Whistler's immediate response was:

"Damn it, if you had anesthetic, why didn't you use it first?!"

Black Super shrugged.

"The lie would be that I wanted to see whether your mouth was tough enough, and whether you really wanted to live."

Then he added:

"The truth is... I forgot."

Even though his face was completely hidden beneath a black hood, everyone somehow felt like they could see the smug expression underneath.

It made people want to punch him.

Whistler had only just begun to curse with a word starting in F when Black Super jabbed a syringe into his neck.

The old man instantly blacked out.

Blade's eyes widened so much even his thin-framed sunglasses couldn't hide it.

"What the hell did you inject him with?"

"Oh. I accidentally used the anesthetic first. Should've given him the serum before that."

Then he calmly used another syringe and injected the same spot again.

Blade stared.

"What kind of anesthetic knocks someone out instantly? Aren't those things supposed to take ten to fifteen minutes? That kind of immediate collapse only

happens in movies."

"This is my own custom formula. Strong anesthetic. Specially designed for road rage, hysteria, and unreasonable people.

"Can't use too much, though. Otherwise they get summoned by the Lord."

Blade's teeth ached just listening.

He tossed aside the gauze in his hand.

"Give me a few liters. I could use that stuff. Does it work on vampires?"

"A few liters? What are you planning, drinking it?"

Black Super snorted.

"Using this on vampires would be a waste. Just use vodka. Or industrial alcohol."

Then he added:

"Besides, do you know where you're going to kill them?"

"You said it yourself—that's what I'm good at."

Blade picked up the videotape labeled PLAY ME.

"If this is a trap to lure me in, then the message should include a location.

"I don't think they'd leave riddles and patiently wait for me to solve them. Deacon Frost isn't as composed as the older bloodsuckers."

Black Super took out a plastic bag from among the supplies he brought and handed it over.

"If you're going vampire hunting, here are some little cuties I'm sponsoring."

Blade's eyes lit up.

He opened the bag and pulled out three differently shaped objects glowing with deep blue light.

Grenades?

"What are these?"

Black Super answered proudly:

"Melon Type One, Two, and Three. All prototypes.

"Like the UV bullets, they're filled with ultraviolet-radiation solution.

"But I increased the concentration. In theory, stronger lethality."

He pointed one by one.

"Type One is an airburst model. If it rolls on the ground after being thrown, it automatically bounces to a preset height before exploding.

"Type Two is cluster type. It detonates in nine waves. More than the three-wave version I used when supporting you before. Helps kill vampires hiding in their companions' shadows.

"Type Three is concussion type. It also includes flash and sound."

Then he grinned.

"Use them on this trip and help me test which are useful and which are trash."

He paused.

"Now, about this Deacon guy wanting to hold some ritual and evolve himself. And you're part of the ritual?"

Blade replied:

"That's what Whistler told me. The details should be in the decrypted files.

"The ritual comes from the ancient Book of Erebus—the Vampire Bible."

Black Super thought for a moment.

"I highly doubt an ancient ritual specifically says it requires sacrificing you by name.

Chapter 518 518: The Man in the Medical Tank

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On the third level of the Goat Cave Valley Laboratory, Abraham Whistler opened his eyes inside a hastily assembled medical recovery tank.

Because his nose and mouth were covered by a breathing mask, things weren't too bad. But opening one's eyes underwater required a moment of adjustment, even for people capable of doing it.

Suddenly finding himself in such an environment, the old vampire hunter was understandably alarmed.

Especially since his hands, feet, and body were restrained.

His first instinct was that he had been captured and imprisoned.

"Calm down, Whistler. You're inside my medical tank. It helps speed up recovery."

"So what they actually need must be some trait connected to you.

"What do you think it is?"

Blade answered immediately.

"The Daywalker..."

"Mmm."

Black Super nodded.

"To many vampires, walking under the blazing sun is a dream. An impossible one."

Then he changed tone.

"If that's the case, I suggest you prepare methods beyond ultraviolet weapons. In case something unexpected happens."

Blade frowned.

"Is that necessary?"

Black Super explained:

"I don't know the ritual process.

"If they gain the ability to walk in sunlight before the ritual is complete, and you're only the final step, then UV bullets and grenades won't be reliable anymore."

That statement was actually a deliberate misdirection meant to produce the correct result.

After all, Black Super couldn't exactly say:

The Blood God is definitely coming, and he won't fear sunlight or silver.

Blade nodded.

"I understand."

Black Super asked again:

"Do you have a backup safehouse? I need to move Whistler somewhere secure.

"If not, I'll take him to my place for now."

Blade replied:

"Take him with you first. Once he recovers, we'll figure it out.

"I don't even know whether any of Whistler's backup spots are safe."

"Fair enough."

Black Super pointed toward the nearby computer.

"You know how to contact me with this junk.

"And after you kill the vampires, don't forget."

He grinned.

"I'm waiting to hear your review of the new weapons."

Knowing someone was expecting his return, Blade flashed his signature bright white smile.

"I know."

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Standing outside the glass enclosure, Black Super somehow transmitted his voice into the old man's ears.

...Or at least, Whistler thought he heard something.

Black Super tapped on the tank's glass.

"If you want to speak, talk softly. There's a small microphone inside the breathing mask. We can hear you out here."

Although he had already completed a tiger-language brainwave translator, human thought patterns were far more complicated. For now, the brainwave device could only detect emotions, not accurately interpret language.

Still, Black Super had placed a brainwave sensor on the old hunter anyway, collecting data while he was at it.

Whistler asked from inside the tank:

"Where am I? Why am I tied down?"

"This is my secret base. Completely secure."

One hundred and ten meters underground.

Even nuclear disaster shelters weren't always this deep.

If this place wasn't safe, then nowhere was.

Its power came from the same batteries used in the Duck-Leopard Armor, charged at the undersea power station—a Kree technology product.

"As for restraining you, that's because I don't want you moving around.

"Your wounds have only been stitched, not healed. Movement won't help.

"I also treated the old injury in your left leg. That needs rest too."

Whistler immediately asked about his beloved student.

"Where's Blade?"

"Off causing trouble for vampires."

"Damn it. Don't tell me you don't know it's a trap."

"Blade said as much. But do you think I could stop him?

"And you were half dead. Was I supposed to abandon you?

"Even if I wanted to ditch you and go with Blade, he wouldn't allow it."

"Damn it! How much time has passed?"

Black Super answered casually.

"Since the moment I jabbed you with that anesthetic needle? About seventeen hours.

"It's already the evening of the next day.

"The surgery was a success. Aside from that foul mouth of yours—which is beyond saving—everything else is fine."

He continued:

"I gave you two bags of artificial plasma, plus an erythropoietin shot.

"Right now the IV drip is glucose nutrition.

"And no, don't think I'm letting you out for dinner."

"Black Super... do me a favor."

"It already sounds troublesome. Can you not say it?"

"Go help that boy."

Whistler's tone became serious.

"He went alone into enemy territory. Too reckless.

"Especially knowing they set a trap specifically to capture him."

Black Super sighed.

"You still said it.

"You understand why I don't want direct conflict with vampires, right?

"Changing my appearance isn't enough against creatures with noses like theirs."

Vampire smell was bizarre.

They didn't merely detect body odor.

They could smell blood itself.

That was why Blade had immediately noticed the plasma Black Super brought earlier was wrong.

Because it really was artificial plasma.

Not the real thing.

Whistler continued:

"I know.

"But there's no one else I can ask.

"Other vampire hunters and exorcists—they don't trust Blade. No matter how much that kid's done."

Then he added:

"You're the only one who got close to him without wanting money... and not because you wanted to screw him over his looks or physique."

Black Super nearly rolled his eyes.

"I'm not asking you to fight beside him.

"Just watch his back route.

"If it gets dangerous, help him once.

"I don't dare ask for more."

Black Super walked from one side of the medical tank to the other, using those few steps to think.

During the earlier Kree-Skrull war, one major reason he dared stay uninvolved was Captain Marvel's absurd level of power.

Once that woman went all out, there were very few beings capable of stopping her.

The only thing Henry had done was assist a crashing Quinjet on its way down from space, reducing the number of Kree warships chasing it.

Mostly because Nick Fury had been onboard, and Henry had still hoped the man might clear his name someday.

But the current situation was different.

It was foreseeable what came next:

The Blood God versus Blade.

Did Blade have a guaranteed chance of winning?

Would the Blood God be as pathetic as in the movie?

If Deacon Frost actually succeeded, it would undoubtedly create even more trouble for Henry.

Unlike the Kree and Skrulls, whichever side won would eventually leave Earth.

At worst, they might blow the planet into cheese first.

But if the Blood God defeated Blade—

Then Deacon Frost, or whichever vampire became the Blood God, would become far bolder in attacking the real world.

Could anyone expect them to kill only the poor and powerless, while sparing the rich and influential?

Of course not.

In the end, it would be the same old story:

Submit and prosper.

Resist and perish.

And someone like Henry, unwilling to cooperate, had a high chance of becoming the sacrificial chicken used to scare the monkeys.

Which meant—

If he didn't want a bigger disaster later, he had to stop it now, at this critical moment.

Not stand aside and let events plunge into the abyss.

Having reached that conclusion, Black Super sighed softly.

"Fine. I'll help."

Whistler relaxed.

"Thanks."

"No need."

Black Super reached the control panel.

"I'm giving you another shot. Sleep well.

"Hopefully the next time you wake up, I'll have good news."

He added a measured dose of sedative into the tank.

Under the medication's effects, the badly wounded old hunter drifted back into deep sleep.

---

Black Super returned to the laboratory's second level.

This was the original excavated cavern area.

Unlike the third level, which had been reinforced with synthetic concrete until it resembled a proper building interior.

The makeshift medical tank had required dismantling quite a few components from this floor.

Fortunately, the disabled systems were mostly unimportant ones.

He removed the Black Super Kevlar combat suit.

Against vampires, that outfit was basically transparent.

It couldn't conceal his identity at all.

Blade himself had confirmed it.

Every time Blade recognized him, it wasn't because of the deliberate footsteps Black Super made.

It was because of that unique blood scent.

So now—

It was time to change suits.

Duck-Leopard Armor, Duck Form.

Green paint scheme.

Its most striking feature:

A Punjabi-style hat with a circular inner frame, triangular edges—

And a pheasant feather sticking proudly out of the top.

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Chapter 519 519: Edgewood Tower

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"You have failed this city!"

As the Duck-form armor's startup voice line ended, Henry began running diagnostics on the suit.

The panther-form Duck-Leopard Armor used by Kitty had been designed based on the concepts of Iron Man's later metallic armors.

So it had an extremely heavy metal aesthetic, looking like a ferocious steel beast.

But the Duck Form was completely different.

Its outermost layer was covered in plush fabric camouflage, making it look like one of those costumed mascots often seen in amusement parks.

And because it was a duck, it inevitably reminded people of one of Disney's three flagship mascots—mouse, duck, and dog.

Still, since it wasn't wearing the signature sailor outfit, Disney's legal department probably wouldn't come after him...

Since it had no pants, the fluffy white duck backside was especially obvious.

But unlike that famous blue-and-white duck celebrity, this armor used green and white as its primary colors. Combined with the Punjabi-style cap adorned with pheasant feathers and the green eye mask, the whole thing looked absurdly like a cartoon character.

Yet no one should mistake this mascot-like appearance for low technology.

First of all, it was a highly airtight suit capable of spacewalking in vacuum.

That same vacuum-grade sealing effectively blocked vampire scent detection.

That was one major reason Henry chose this suit.

The second reason was that this armor integrated every weapons system Henry had designed.

Its raw destructive power wasn't particularly high. It couldn't effectively fight top-tier targets—certain superheroes or supervillains, whether technology-based or mutation-based.

But against large numbers of ordinary enemies, it was perfect for battlefield clearing.

After all, it had originally been designed with vampires as the primary hypothetical enemy, while also requiring a combat style that concealed Henry's personal traits.

Naturally, that meant using the grand American tradition:

Maximum firepower.

So besides the obvious machine gun mounted on the back, its main weapons were concealed railguns, while secondary weapons were small multi-directional tracking missiles.

Having chosen his battle suit, Henry began gearing up.

It wasn't troublesome.

Putting it on was more like climbing into a mascot costume than assembling Iron Man armor piece by piece.

Reloading ammunition was the real hassle.

The primary ammo bay was located in the duck butt.

Naturally, Henry loaded large quantities of specialized anti-vampire rounds.

Considering there might also be many vampire thralls—humans serving vampires as enforcers—ordinary ammunition was loaded as well.

Finally, driven by a certain malicious sense of humor, he draped two ammo belts across his body to feed the machine gun on his back.

In short:

This Green Arrow Duck didn't use bows or crossbows.

It used guns.

Once fully prepared, Green Arrow Duck entered the dedicated underground launch tunnel and shot into the night sky.

Each outstretched arm housed three thrusters, six total.

There were also two symmetrical hyper-acceleration systems mounted left and right.

The duck flippers on the feet contained anti-gravity devices built around trace amounts of gravitonium, providing lift.

Inside the helmet, instead of retinal projection, there was a panoramic display allowing the wearer to directly observe the outside world.

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Through it, Green Arrow Duck noticed Kitty on the ground below, looking up and hopping excitedly as if asking to come play too.

Obviously, Green Arrow Duck was not bringing Kitty along.

She had already exposed him once in front of Jack Reacher.

If he wanted to walk the tiger in the future, he'd need another method.

Because artificial intelligence still wasn't fully reliable, the control system had three input methods:

Voice command.

Brainwave control.

And finger-joint buttons similar to those used previously to remote-control Little Duck.

With both arms held level, Henry opened and closed all ten fingers twice.

Then clenched both fists.

The moment the command was received—

All six thrusters fired at full power.

He broke the sound barrier instantly from a standing launch, creating a thunderous sonic boom.

At Mach 3 flight speed, Green Arrow Duck crossed from Goat Cave Valley wilderness to Los Angeles city airspace in just four minutes.

His first stop was Blade and Abraham Whistler's abandoned steel mill hideout.

Rather than wasting time searching for Blade directly, it was faster to examine the videotape message.

The tape would certainly contain clues.

Inside Blade's meditation room, Green Arrow Duck found the tape halfway played.

He didn't bother using a VCR or television.

Instead, he directly read the magnetic tape contents, converted it into digital video through the undersea basic quantum computing network, and played it in a small corner display inside the helmet.

From the footage, he quickly identified the named destination:

Edgewood Tower.

It also let Green Arrow Duck confirm what this world's Deacon Frost looked like.

A man who wasn't ugly.

Most notably, his face carried a hint of wickedness.

His appearance resembled the younger film version rather than the older comic version.

According to Blade earlier, this Frost was a turned vampire.

So he didn't get along with the purebloods born as vampires.

Among Los Angeles vampires, he belonged to the younger radical faction.

But "young" here was only relative to the ancient old vampires.

In truth, he was already three to four hundred years old.

Not some recently turned modern vampire.

Having confirmed the target, Green Arrow Duck naturally began gathering intelligence through networks—including government internal systems.

Edgewood Tower was actually the name of a downtown Los Angeles high-rise.

Ownership was mysterious.

It was almost never rented to outsiders.

Now it was obvious:

This was vampire property.

But entering a downtown skyscraper wasn't as simple as flying straight there.

The sun had only recently set, and downtown was still busy.

Green Arrow Duck's appearance had almost zero camouflage value.

Even flying high overhead, some enthusiastic citizen would probably notice and dial 911.

So direct level flight over downtown was impossible.

Instead, he needed to ascend vertically to high altitude, fly level unseen, then descend vertically onto the destination.

The building rooftop lacked a standard helicopter landing pad.

But the penthouse balcony featured an outdoor swimming pool, and the interior visible through windows was luxuriously decorated.

Clearly the owner was wealthy or powerful.

Not wanting to alarm whoever might be inside, Green Arrow Duck did not land on the balcony.

Instead, he slowed early and perched on a maintenance platform attached to a decorative rooftop spire.

The Duck-form armor had surveillance functions.

But compared with Henry's own kryptonian x-ray vision, it was nowhere close.

So Green Arrow Duck directly used the wearer's natural abilities to search for Blade.

Unfortunately, there was no sign of the half-vampire anywhere in the building.

There were, however, plenty of vampires.

Which confirmed this tower truly belonged to a vampire clan—otherwise such density would be impossible.

Thinking back to the movie, the final battle took place in a temple-like structure.

But nowhere inside this tower, including the basement, contained any such architectural level.

Chapter 520 520: Infiltration

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A bit of common sense when using powered armor:

Don't expect it to be especially agile when it comes to walking.

Mechanical joints have difficulty balancing three things at once—power output, speed of articulation, and durability.

Not to mention the noise problem.

Whether it was armored feet striking the floor or the sound of mechanical joints moving, all of it highlighted just how incredible biological joints really were.

So when not flying—when moving on the ground or through cramped indoor spaces—other systems had to be relied upon.

In the original design, the Duck-form Duck-Leopard Armor had several omni-directional wheels hidden beneath the flippers, intended to move the suit along the ground.

Leg motion would only assist when dealing with complex terrain.

But that mobility system was quickly abandoned.

Motor drive issues, braking, noise, maintenance difficulty, durability—too many problems remained unresolved.

Clearly, it was not a mature design.

By contrast, using gravitonium to create a low-hover state, combined with small posture-adjusting jets, allowed movement similar to gliding on roller skates.

It was fast.

It was agile.

And it could share systems with the flight mode.

When outputting only minimal thrust, the noise level was also extremely low—quiet enough that ordinary human hearing would struggle to notice it.

Thus, this became Green Arrow Duck's preferred ground movement method.

The only inconvenience came during shooting.

Because firearm recoil would push the lightly hovering Green Arrow Duck backward.

At those times, he either had to constantly adjust posture—or simply land and brace both feet for stability.

Green Arrow Duck's various scanning modes included infrared heat detection, sonic disturbance imaging, and other systems capable of seeing through obstacles.

This wasn't because Henry thought Kryptonian abilities alone were enough and therefore skipped technological development.

If ordinary people were to wear the armor—or if it was remotely controlled—then such functions still had to exist.

Otherwise, developing powered armor would be pointless.

Considering that this was not yet an era where every trivial incident got uploaded online for strangers to discuss, Green Arrow Duck abandoned the idea of hacking computer systems to track Blade's movements.

Instead, he decided to catch a tongue and interrogate directly.

Using silent hover movement, Green Arrow Duck slipped behind an unlucky isolated target—

And captured him in one move.

Dragging the man into a blind spot beyond camera view, Green Arrow Duck asked:

So had Blade been moved elsewhere?

Or lured away to another location?

It seemed the only way to know now...

Was to go inside, ask someone directly—

Or find another way to investigate.

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"Quack quack quack."

"What?"

Ah.

Forgot to switch voice mode.

That was the encrypted communication setting used for Panther Form.

Switching to normal speech mode, Green Arrow Duck asked again:

"Where did Deacon Frost and the other vampires go?"

"Okay, Robin Hood, why don't you go back to Disneyland?"

The captive sneered.

"Don't think hiding in a mascot suit scares me. Come back wearing something uglier."

As he spoke, the man threw a full-force punch straight at the mascot duck head.

Then his tough expression instantly collapsed.

He nearly cried.

Apparently he hadn't expected that beneath the plush exterior wasn't foam padding or soft support—

But heavy tank-grade composite armor.

The harder he punched, the more it hurt.

Green Arrow Duck, of course, felt zero sympathy.

With the left hand restraining the man, he raised his right hand in front of the captive's face.

Electrodes extended from the tips of the index and middle fingers like stun prongs.

Blue arcs crackled violently between them.

"You ever been shocked by a cattle prod?"

Know why cows start running after they get zapped?

Honestly, I haven't.

So be sure to tell me your experience."

Then he applied it.

The thug's whole body stiffened instantly.

Violent convulsions followed.

Luckily he hadn't had time to open his mouth.

Otherwise he might have bitten his own tongue off.

Once the first charge was spent, Green Arrow Duck asked again:

"Where did Deacon Frost and his vampires go?"

"I... don't know..." the man managed to force out.

"What? You don't know?"

Green Arrow Duck gave him another full-body nervous system treatment.

The man could only widen his eyes and strain out:

"Ghhhhh—!"

Green Arrow Duck patted his cheek.

"I'll ask one last time.

Where did they go?"

"Fuck! Donald Duck!"

The man screamed.

"I really don't know! I'm just building security! This is a normal job! Why would those freaks report their plans to me?!"

Looks like he was telling the truth.

Slightly disappointed, Green Arrow Duck casually shocked him one more time—

This time hard enough to knock him unconscious.

"You're carrying a gun and working for vampires.

Don't paint yourself as innocent."

Dropping the limp man aside, Green Arrow Duck began searching for the next victim.

Looks like ordinary patrol staff were useless.

Too low-level.

No useful information.

He needed someone with rank.

Or better yet—

A vampire.

Within the armor's detection range, there were no abnormal-temperature entities resembling vampires.

But switching to the wearer's own natural senses, Henry locked onto targets immediately.

The problem was route planning.

No matter how he calculated it, exposure would be difficult to avoid.

And forget those movie-style air ducts big enough for a person to crawl through.

Green Arrow Duck's body size was larger than most adult men.

Even if such absurd vents existed, he wouldn't fit.

So after selecting the shortest route—

Green Arrow Duck began his push inward.

Even so, he didn't recklessly expose himself.

Every security camera along the path was destroyed before it could capture his image.

If one was positioned directly around a blind corner where exposure was unavoidable the moment he turned—

Chapter 521: Corridor Showdown

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The first shot was a ricochet round that destroyed the surveillance camera mounted above the security guards blocking the corridor.

Anyone who noticed it was deeply impressed by the shooter's skill.

Most of them, however, were too confused to realize what had happened.

Green Arrow Duck did not make the sort of slow dramatic entrance where he stepped around the corner and became everyone's target.

Instead, using the mobility advantage of low-hover movement, he burst around the corner in an instant.

The heavy machine gun that had been mounted on his back was already in his hands.

Then came the metallic roar of hell.

Out of more than a dozen pistols, most of their owners never even got the chance to pull the trigger.

Only a few lucky ones fired a single shot.

Anyone who wasn't immediately cut down by the first sweep instantly began scrambling backward—rolling, crawling, fleeing in blind panic.

Without exception.

One obvious rookie managed to escape behind the corner, then pressed himself against a concrete wall while raising his pistol, seemingly intending to ambush the strange-looking intruder.

But another veteran guard who got along with him fairly well grabbed him while retreating and dragged him away.

The younger man was about to protest—

Then from the corner of his eye he saw the spot where he had intended to hide.

The concrete wall he'd trusted was being shredded into fragments by the heavy machine gun.

Terrified, he immediately joined the others in their desperate rolling retreat.

Even after the machine gun fire stopped, nobody dared turn back.

He still refused to let even half an arm be recorded.

Instead, he used ricochet shots to destroy them in advance.

The reason he didn't simply hack the surveillance system was simple:

To hack something, the enemy needed to have computers.

Their entire security network was still old-school tape recorders and cable systems.

Hack what exactly?

These antiques used antique equipment.

Who could he complain to?

Although Green Arrow Duck was certain his image had not been captured, cameras failing one after another was enough for anyone with a functioning brain in the control room to know something was wrong.

Reinforcements were already on the move.

Apparently there were capable people in the control room.

From intercepted walkie-talkie chatter, Henry learned they had deduced his direction simply from the order in which cameras were destroyed.

And from that, predicted his likely route.

So naturally, those reinforcements moved to block the intruder's path.

More than a dozen men stacked into a narrow corridor, filling it wall to wall.

At least they had some brains.

They left clear firing lanes.

More than ten pistols were aimed directly at the corner Green Arrow Duck would have to turn.

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They fled straight for the stairwell and only stopped after descending several floors.

Still shaken, they looked at each other.

After counting heads, only eight of them had made it down.

That meant six or seven men had been left behind in that corridor.

After a long silence, someone finally asked:

"There's no more gunfire... should we go back up and check?"

The most seasoned veteran cursed:

"Fuck that. Go yourself."

"In a narrow hallway, against a heavy machine gun—you know what that means?"

"That setup is basically the entrance to hell."

"I don't care what kind of monster can carry a machine gun while moving and firing at the same time. I've only got a pistol."

"I'm not trading fire with that."

---

Upstairs, Green Arrow Duck had been forced to abandon hover mode in order to resist the recoil of sustained machine-gun fire.

Instead, he planted both feet on the floor and advanced on foot.

That undoubtedly reduced his mobility.

But the results were astonishingly effective.

Most ordinary people misunderstood firearms.

They believed cover could block bullets.

In reality, the main purpose of cover was simply to prevent the enemy from seeing you clearly—forcing them to miss.

Luck played a large role.

Take common street gunfights, for example.

Unless a car door had been reinforced with ballistic steel, the only truly reliable cover was the engine block—that giant chunk of metal.

Hide behind a door or trunk panel, and if your luck was bad, bullets would punch right through and bite into you anyway.

And the weapon in Green Arrow Duck's hands was a Browning M2 heavy machine gun.

The famed .50 cal.

Using 12.7mm rounds.

This particular one had been modified for one-handed support and one-handed firing.

In military range training, this weapon usually fired at dirt berms—not paper targets.

And it often erased the berms.

Ordinary concrete walls in commercial buildings simply weren't enough.

That was why real military fortresses measured wall thickness in meters.

Anything less couldn't even stop a heavy machine gun, much less artillery.

Inside an ordinary office tower, the only things limiting such a weapon were line-of-sight obstruction caused by complex architecture—

And ammunition capacity.

But Green Arrow Duck's sensor systems erased the first disadvantage entirely.

He couldn't quite manage one-shot-one-kill precision through walls—

But if he wanted to, he could absolutely use sheer firepower to kill targets behind floors or several rooms away.

Still, killing people wasn't his main objective.

Even among those cut down in the opening burst, some had merely lost arms or legs.

They lay on the ground in terror, dragging mangled limbs as they tried to crawl away from the ridiculous-looking mascot figure before them.

As for those hit in the torso or head—

They looked as if some savage beast had bitten chunks out of them.

Very dead.

---

Green Arrow Duck resumed low-hover mode and glided through the bloody corridor with the machine gun still in hand.

He didn't finish off the wounded.

These were ordinary humans.

Whether or not they knowingly chose to work for vampires, they were still human.

Besides, those who survived would be crippled for life.

And if he wanted fear to spread, he needed witnesses.

Anyone who experienced all this and still came seeking revenge afterward—

Well, Green Arrow Duck would genuinely respect them.

Without caring whether the liquid soaking their pants was blood or urine, he simply floated past them and continued onward.

Apparently the machine gun assault had terrified the previous group badly enough.

No more human guards appeared ahead.

Instead, the defenders now were the vampires stationed in the building.

These dark creatures still maintained their uniquely awful aesthetic.

Compared to street gang punks, they looked more like pre-90s biker gangs.

They wore rebellion and anti-mainstream identity like fashion.

They fully embodied the word:

Perverse.

For reasons unknown—perhaps overconfidence—they came out carrying only knives, or sometimes empty-handed.

Not one of them seemed to care about Green Arrow Duck's machine gun.

They shouted taunts and jeers with great enthusiasm.

Chapter 522: Temple of Eternal Night

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The Temple of Eternal Night was a shrine built by the first vampires to arrive in the Los Angeles region—back in an era when there wasn't even a town here yet.

They were vampires of ancient lineage.

Unlike most religious architecture, which rose toward the sky, the Temple of Eternal Night had been built underground.

Green Arrow Duck naturally had no intention of wasting machine-gun rounds on enemies he knew ordinary bullets would barely affect.

He relaxed both arms and flicked them backward.

The heavy machine gun was retracted onto the armor's rear mounting rack.

Seeing this, one vampire sneered:

"Haha! Big mascot!"

"I thought you were dangerous."

"What, surrendering already?"

"Take off the mask, tell us your name."

"Maybe we'll let you become a probationary member."

"Maybe we'll even let you earn one of our marks."

The way he spoke made it sound as if the dead and wounded human servants didn't exist.

But to vampires, blood thralls and hired followers were disposable tools.

They felt no regret whatsoever.

What the vampires hadn't expected was this:

Green Arrow Duck had brought limited anti-human ammunition.

That was one reason he hadn't bothered using the machine gun on vampires.

But anti-vampire ammunition?

He had brought plenty.

He'd tolerated these bastards long enough.

Today they had conveniently gathered together.

There was no way he wouldn't make the most of it.

Without responding to their taunts, Green Arrow Duck simply raised his left arm and spread all five fingers.

An electromagnetically accelerated round shot forward.

The projectile was filled with silver nitrate solution.

It struck the vampire square in the chest.

The shell ruptured.

Silver nitrate flooded into the vampire's body.

Holy silver ions rapidly broke down the dark creature's cells, triggering spontaneous combustion.

Compared to the humans earlier who had been blasted apart by machine-gun fire, these vampires died almost silently.

Five shots.

Five vampire lives.

The sole survivor was not spared because the railgun had a slow reload speed.

It wasn't that at all.

Green Arrow Duck needed someone alive for questioning.

He hadn't forgotten why he came here.

He was here to rescue people—

Not merely clear the building.

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That was why this special structure belonging to the vampires had never been exposed to ordinary people.

Above ground, it appeared only as an abandoned construction site in West Los Angeles.

Far from downtown.

And surrounded by nothing lively or prosperous.

This deliberately cultivated desolation was naturally the work of the vampires.

From this alone, it was clear that vampire influence in Los Angeles was formidable.

Otherwise, how could a valuable piece of urban land remain undeveloped for so many years—never built upon, never converted into a public park?



Still, most people who became vampires were hardly devout believers with unwavering faith.

So the creation of this temple was less about establishing a religious center for vampires of North America's West Coast—

And more about displaying political power.

Most vampires in North America belonged to the ancient Thirteen Sects, particularly the Mystical Faction.

And the first vampires who came west and established themselves in Los Angeles had come from twelve ancient clans.

The Temple of Eternal Night bore the marks of all twelve ancient vampire clans.

Once, it had represented supreme authority.

But in reality, rebellious vampires were not creatures who obeyed management easily.

Over time, the Temple of Eternal Night became little more than a record of those twelve clans.

It was forgotten.

No longer symbolic.

Until today.

---

When Green Arrow Duck arrived at the location, he realized that without the abilities of the person inside the suit, relying only on the armor's scanners might have completely missed the underground structure.

The vampire temple was built of granite and extended twenty to thirty meters beneath the earth.

At the east, west, south, and north directions stood giant carved statues symbolizing vampires.

Naturally, since it was designed for vampires, the interior did not rely on natural light.

For creatures with night vision, operating inside was no problem.

But modern vampires possessed many human servants and affiliated followers.

Those people did not have night vision.

So numerous temporary electrical lines had been installed throughout the temple.

These mainly powered lighting equipment, plus limited ventilation and air circulation systems—

To keep the frail humans, as vampires saw them, from suffocating underground.

---

By the time Green Arrow Duck arrived, it was just past midnight.

Below, the ritual of the Blood God's descent was already underway.

The entire ceremony matched Henry's memories from the movie before his transmigration.

The Daywalker vampire was imprisoned inside a stone coffin on the temple's uppermost level.

His blood would serve as the key to activating the ritual.

Thus Blade, bound inside the coffin, had both wrists slit.

Blood continuously flowed downward.

Through channels carved through the temple floor and lower levels, the blood was collected and divided.

A small portion first dripped onto the foreheads of representatives from the twelve ancient vampire clans.

This blood acted like a mark.

It linked the vital presence of those twelve clan members with the temple itself.

At this stage, even if no guards remained to physically restrain them, they could no longer leave.

---

Beneath the spherical central dome stood three vampires who longed to transform into the Blood God.

Two men.

One woman.

Besides Deacon Frost, there was Blade's old enemy—the impossible-to-kill Quinn.

And Frost's lieutenant:

The beautiful vampire Raquel.

That last woman was, in fact, the same seductive vampire who had once guided Henry when he first met Giacomo Dragone.

---

Green Arrow Duck had intended to rush in and rescue Blade.

But he noticed a Black woman had beaten him there, arriving first at the sacrificial chamber where Blade was imprisoned.

She freed the half-vampire just as he was on the verge of death.

Unfortunately, Blade had lost too much blood.

Even though Green Arrow Duck carried various serums, none would help someone hanging on by a thread.

The female doctor made a decisive choice.

She offered her neck.

The sweetness of living blood.

The temptation.

The instinctive hunger for survival.

All of it caused the half-vampire who swore never to drink human blood to finally break his vow.

Sharp fangs emerged.

He bit down.

Watching a scene even more passionate than a kiss, Green Arrow Duck immediately understood there was no need to worry about the old black man anymore.

For Marvel-universe vampires, fresh blood healed better than any miracle medicine.

---

Meanwhile, the vampires on the main altar waited nervously for what would happen next.

After all, the ritual process had been forcefully translated from writings in a language nobody alive understood.

Most vampires had little faith in it.

At best, they treated it as an experiment.

Only Deacon Frost, standing at the center, truly believed it would succeed.

Because he was like a gambler who had pushed all his chips into the pot.

There was no retreat left.

At that moment, Quinn received a phone call.

He listened while cursing under his breath.

Even after hanging up, he continued muttering nonsense.

Compared to Frost—who was fanatically staring at the ceiling waiting for destiny—Raquel, the more practical second-in-command, cared far more about the message Quinn had received.

"What happened?"

"Security from Edgewood Tower called."

"They said some Donald Duck dressed as Robin Hood stormed the place with a machine gun and killed a bunch of people."

"Even some of the vampires guarding the place got killed."

Normally expressionless and icy, even Raquel stared blankly.

"What kind of nonsense is that?"

"Were they high when they called?"

Deacon Frost, however, couldn't be bothered.

Hearing their conversation, he said dismissively:

"Ignore it."

"Once this ritual ends and we become vampire gods, any enemy will kneel before us."

"Haha! Damn right!"

Quinn laughed crazily.

---

What none of them expected was that Blade had already escaped the upper chamber —

And had just finished a battle of patricide.

Blade had always believed his mother died long ago.

In truth, she had become a vampire and stayed by Deacon Frost's side.

Her beliefs were no longer human.

She now stood opposite her son, who hated vampires with every fiber of his being.

In the end, Blade sent his mother on her final journey.

He severed the path leading toward vampire acceptance.

He chose to remain human in spirit.

Then he departed—

To confront the man responsible for all of it.

Deacon Frost.

---

And that very vampire was now watching blood begin to flow from the twelve circular openings in the great spherical dome.

Streams of blood trickled downward.

Converging toward the lowest point of the sphere.

Deacon Frost believed this collected blood would be the true key to the ritual.

Compared with the vampires underground, Green Arrow Duck—still outside the Temple of Eternal Night—could sense the changes in the surrounding climate more clearly.

The sky had been clear moments before.

Now dark clouds drifted in.

Chapter 523: Showing Off Gets You Struck by Lightning

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Based on memories of the movie from before transmigration, Green Arrow Duck compared them one by one with the scene unfolding before him.

It gave him a strange sense of immersion—

No, not immersion.

He was literally here in person, witnessing the whole spectacle firsthand.

If there was any difference from the film he remembered, it was that there were far more people inside the underground structure.

Judging from the body heat they emitted, there were vampires, ordinary humans, and even...

Mutants with clearly abnormal traits.

Still, any mutants mixed in with vampires probably weren't particularly powerful. Most were likely Epsilon-level at best.

Fortunately, he saw no mutant vampires.

And judging by how they were treated, those mutants ranked even below the armed human guards.

So in the underworld hierarchy here, mutants were beneath both vampires and humans?

Green Arrow Duck watched the scene with great interest.

Except...

He had forgotten something.

Something very important.

He only remembered it when a bolt of thunder crashed down from the sky.

The final step of the Blood God ritual required enormous energy to complete the transformation.

That energy came in the form of lightning from above.

Since the ritual could apparently attract thunderbolts, it had already gone beyond anything science alone could explain.

There was something supernatural involved.

In other words—

Magic.

This was the first time since arriving in this world that Green Arrow Duck had a chance to personally witness magic.

But the problem was...

He had chosen to watch the show from the best seat in the house.

Which meant floating in the night sky above Eternal Night Temple using Green Arrow Duck's levitation ability.

And the pheasant-feather antenna on his Punjabi-style hat was made of metal.

The heavy machine gun mounted behind him on articulated supports was also metal.

So even though the Duck-form Duck-Leopard Armor was wrapped in fluffy camouflage fabric, Green Arrow Duck hovering in the sky looked exactly like the nearest lightning rod to the storm clouds.

A moment ago this was supposed to be magic.

Now suddenly physics rules apply?!

The lightning that was meant to strike the ground directly above Eternal Night Temple and channel vast energy into the vampire shrine abruptly bent in midair—

And slammed straight into Green Arrow Duck.

They covered the moon hanging high above.

As though heralding that something terrible was about to happen.

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The numb, electrifying sensation instantly reminded the person inside what he had forgotten.

Thus unfolded a live-action performance of showing off and getting struck by lightning.

The person inside, of course, wasn't afraid of being hit by lightning.

But not long ago, he had used a stun baton on someone else while trying to interrogate them, all while mockingly asking what being electrocuted felt like and requesting a review.

Then he got zapped himself.

Honestly, the sensation from the lightning was little more than a tingling reminder that current had passed through his body.

Not enough to leave him unconscious like a corpse.

This was, in fact, the genuine experience of a Kryptonian empowered by yellow sunlight and possessing heightened senses.

No matter what was done to him, he still felt it.

It was simply that his pain threshold was absurdly high, so long as no real damage occurred.

But while he could ignore lightning, his armor could not.

As a vehicle meant for high-altitude flight, lightning protection was naturally essential.

Otherwise every airplane in a thunderstorm would need to be grounded or rerouted.

Important internal components had surge suppression and anti-shock safeguards.

Otherwise a powered suit disabled by a simple stun baton would have an embarrassingly obvious weakness.

But the externally mounted heavy machine gun had no such protection.

Normally, lightning hitting the gun alone wouldn't matter.

However, before leaving home, Green Arrow Duck had flamboyantly draped two ammunition belts across himself..

Though he had already fired off some rounds earlier, the remaining 12.7mm ammunition detonated spectacularly across the surface of the Duck-form armor.

It felt like having strings of firecrackers exploding all over his body.

The pilot inside was blasted senseless.

Even the outer fuzzy camouflage was shredded apart in several places, exposing the metal armor underneath.

Fortunately, the outer shell was tank-grade composite armor.

The blast itself and the fragments of cartridge casings couldn't penetrate the protection.

As for the heavy machine gun—

No need to discuss it.

Back home for a major overhaul.

Even ignoring mechanical damage, the ammunition was now gone.

Though from a balance standpoint it could still be swung backward like a decent iron club, Green Arrow Duck wasn't Clown Superman, that lunatic.

Why choose melee when ranged combat exists?

By the time the person inside regained his senses, retook control of the armor, and ran three diagnostic checks, the Blood God ritual below had already been completed.

Even if he wanted to stop it now, it was too late.

Still, because he had intercepted the lightning energy from the sky, the ritual's required power could only come from the generators the vampires had hauled into Eternal Night Temple, along with the external power cable connected to the city grid.

The cinematic trope where one location suddenly draws so much electricity that an entire district blacks out was pure exaggeration.

Modern electrical systems had multiple layers of safeguards.

If an appliance in a house malfunctioned and began drawing abnormal power, the breaker would trip to protect the wider grid.

Regional blackouts only occurred when source-side infrastructure—the power company's equipment—failed.

Utility companies would never allow end users to damage the grid from the consumer side.

So even though the ritual demanded huge amounts of power, the cable linking Eternal Night Temple to the city grid burned through almost immediately.

The breaker tripped as well, severing the connection.

Which meant the ritual had not received sufficient energy.

And Blade—the crucial blood sacrifice—had already been rescued by others long before.

Though the offerings of the Twelve Clans had still delivered their ancient lives on schedule, whether the Blood God that descended still possessed the strength it was supposed to have...

That was highly debatable.

But the greatest immediate consequence was this:

All lighting in the underground Eternal Night Temple went out.

Even emergency power failed.

No lights of any kind remained.

Chapter 524: Dr. Johnson

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Or perhaps that wave of madness was the result of the Blood God's incomplete descent.

The hunger born from bodily imperfection, combined with the arrogance of transcending one's former limits, influenced the nearby vampires, driving them to attack the "meat" around them.

A bloody, brutal massacre—more slaughter than battle—erupted without warning.

The dying screams of the first victims acted like a catalyst, dragging the situation inside Eternal Night Temple into an abyss.

The remaining humans, though unable to see their surroundings, opened fire wildly in every direction as long as they still had weapons in hand.

That only further stimulated the vampires, pushing them into even greater savagery.

Collapse came in an instant.

This turn of events had not been expected by Green Arrow Duck.

It left him hesitant, unsure whether he should go down there and get involved.

The humans were not being slaughtered entirely without resistance.

Their weapons had originally been prepared to deal with Blade, the half-vampire.

Which meant they were equally effective against vampires.

Even in complete darkness, some unlucky vampires ran straight into gunfire.

And as the bullets spread wider and wider, more of them did.

Still, overall, the underground darkness favored the vampires.

The humans' hysterical shooting quickly exhausted their ammunition, leaving them with no way to fight back.

As for the man most likely to reverse the tide—

Blade had already picked up his tactical vest and was heading underground.

It looked like he intended to confront Deacon Frost directly.

That guy clearly didn't need worrying about.

Green Arrow Duck simply didn't want to interfere because it was troublesome.

This wasn't an online game where kill-stealing the boss got you loot.

As long as the Blood God died in the end, and Blade—the useful hired thug—survived, then whatever happened between them was none of his business.

However...

There was one person he couldn't ignore.

Karen Johnson, the doctor who had been the key reason Blade walked willingly into the trap.

This should be the Black woman who had earlier rescued Blade from the stone coffin and willingly let herself be bitten.

At the moment, she was curled up beside the base of a stone pillar.

For vampires, who possessed night vision, this wasn't a major problem.

For the many human servants who had also entered the temple—

It was fatal.

Almost none of the humans underground had brought flashlights.

Adults willing to associate with vampires weren't the sort to scream hysterically just because of darkness.

But they had forgotten why dark creatures were called dark creatures.

The inner malice and evil in them had only been restrained.

It had never vanished.

Now, in absolute darkness where one could not see a hand before one's face, human body heat stood out with crystal clarity to the vampires' night vision.

And a wave of madness began to spread.

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That might protect her from blind gunfire by fellow humans.

But to vampires, it meant nothing.

What could be seen, would still be seen.

Several vampires were already moving toward her position.

Green Arrow Duck moved.

Using the micro-hover system, his movement was like skating—silent and fast.

Since the main propulsion system was useless in the current confined environment, both arms and all ten fingers transformed into extensions of magnetic railgun launch rails.

He precisely shot dead or crippled every vampire and human along the way.

The point was simply not to let anyone get back up.

He reached the female doctor's location quietly and spoke:

"Dr. Karen Johnson? I'm reinforcements sent by Abraham Whistler. Are you there?"

Because screams and fighting filled the temple, his voice wasn't particularly clear.

He could already see exactly where the woman was, but speaking first was wiser to avoid misunderstanding—or injuring her by accident.

He repeated himself.

Only then did he hear a very soft voice ask:

"You say Whistler sent you. How do you prove it? What happened to him?"

That second question was the real danger.

If he didn't know the old hunter's condition, things could go badly.

Green Arrow Duck answered:

"Whistler was tortured by vampires. He looked awful, but he was saved.

"If Blade remembered to tell you, then you should know that.

"And our mutual friend is the one who created the Embrace Serum."

After a moment of silence, Karen Johnson asked:

"Do you have a flashlight? How are we leaving? I can't see anything.

"Are you a vampire? Only those monsters can see in the dark here."

Green Arrow Duck extended a hand toward her.

"It's not only monsters. We must believe in the power of science.

"My hand is directly in front of your face. Reach forward and you'll touch it."

Half doubtful, Karen stretched out her hand.

As expected, in the darkness she touched something.

It felt like touching a sculpture wrapped in velvet.

Soft on the outside.

Hard underneath.

Then several new voices sounded in the dark.

One female voice was instantly recognizable to Karen Johnson.

"Hehe... look what we've found. A strange big fellow and a pathetic human trying to flee."

"So you're the Robin Hood Donald Duck that Edgar reported?"

"I never expected you'd actually dare come here."

"Let me see who's hiding inside."

"You said that old man helping Blade didn't die?

"Did you turn him fully into a vampire and feed him a bucket of human blood?"

Vampires naturally had sharper hearing than humans.

So it wasn't surprising they had overheard the conversation and followed the voices here.

Green Arrow Duck couldn't be bothered exchanging nonsense with them.

Once violence had started, there was no need for dialogue.

Even if the leader among them was the high-ranking female vampire—

Raquel.

One hand needed to hold Karen.

The other needed to guard against surprises.

So Green Arrow Duck activated another weapon system directly.

Inside the helmet, infrared panoramic sensors marked every cold-bodied vampire target.

On the white duck backside, rows of missile hatches flipped open.

Ten miniature multi-directional tracking combat missiles launched from each side.

Twenty in total.

Each missile was only slightly thicker than a thumb.

They shot toward the incoming vampires in erratic, twisting trajectories.

From launch to impact took less than three seconds.

Even the more alert vampires who tried to dodge the moment they saw smoke and objects launching from the duck's rear could not evade the close-range tracking missiles.

They were hit one after another.

## Chapter 525 525: Cleaning the Field

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As the only surviving witness on site, Dr. Karen Johnson was able to glimpse parts of what happened by the exhaust flames of the many miniature missiles and the firelight from vampires burning alive.

But most of her attention was focused on the bursts of ultraviolet light and the vampires screaming as they turned to ash.

Without question, hearing those monsters howl in agony was deeply satisfying for someone who had once been their victim.

The flashes were brief, however, and she never got a clear look at the one who had come to save her.

Still, judging by the sheer enthusiasm with which he slaughtered vampires, she already trusted him.

The female doctor sprang up from her crouched position.

That sudden movement made her dizzy for a moment—the blood loss from when she had willingly let Blade bite her earlier was still affecting her.

Fortunately, it remained manageable.

Bracing herself against the wall, Karen Johnson asked:

"How are we getting out?"

"Relax, and leave everything to me, ma'am," Green Arrow Duck said in his synthesized electronic voice.

Then he immediately got to experience what it was like to have a woman suddenly riding a roller coaster scream directly into his ear.

To clarify:

The Duck-Leopard Armor had excellent sound filtering.

When abnormal external noise levels were detected, incoming audio into the helmet was automatically reduced.

The entire process occurred in microseconds.

Unfortunately, that didn't help much when the person inside naturally had super hearing.

Some tried offense as defense—charging Green Arrow Duck with vampire speed in hopes of killing him first.

But the missiles simply altered direction, turned sharply, looped back, and struck them anyway.

These maneuvering missiles had predictive intercept paths for multiple movement patterns.

Even if one somehow outran a missile, another from a different trajectory would still hit the target.

That was why twenty missiles had been launched against far fewer vampires.

Not only to account for vampire evasive speed—

But to guarantee success.

And naturally, the warheads were specialized anti-vampire munitions.

Split left and right, they carried either silver nitrate payloads or ultraviolet payloads.

A direct hit from either type was lethal to a vampire.

If hit by two or more...

Death was guaranteed.

One after another, bursts of explosive light flashed across the darkness like fireworks.

Each flare briefly illuminated the damaged metallic surface of the Duck-form Duck-Leopard Armor.

The scene was eerie.

And strangely beautiful.

Every spark paid for in vampire lives.

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Though the Kryptonian pilot mainly relied on the armor's sensors rather than his own enhanced senses, that didn't mean his eyes and ears were useless.

He still heard and saw everything he normally would.

After leaving the underground Eternal Night Temple, Karen Johnson finally used the weak moonlight to see what had rescued her.

The vampires' description had actually been fairly accurate.

Robin Hood Donald Duck.

Except this version was battle-damaged.

Most of the fuzzy cloth camouflage covering the body had been scorched or torn away, exposing sections of metal armor beneath.

It gave the cute appearance a touch of smoke, menace, and brutality.

Once she was set back on the ground from where she had been tucked under one arm, the doctor asked in disbelief:

"You... what exactly are you?"

"I'm just the reinforcements someone called in. Don't ask too many questions and force me to silence you."

Green Arrow Duck answered bluntly.

Mostly because he didn't want to deal with endless questions he had no intention of answering.

Sure enough, his attitude instantly blocked up all the questions in Karen's heart.

She wanted to ask.

But if asking got her killed...

From the medical compartment on his back, Green Arrow Duck pulled out a dose of Embrace Serum and handed it to her.

"You look like you were bitten. This can prevent transformation into a vampire. You know how to use it, right?"

Karen accepted the serum but didn't inject it immediately.

Too many questions scratched at her curiosity.

Not asking was painful.

But asking might get her murdered.

Seeing her conflicted expression, Green Arrow Duck ignored it and turned toward the entrance of Eternal Night Temple.



Watching the battle alone from outside was one thing.

Having another person around was another.

Better to head back underground and pretend to be busy.

Karen hurriedly asked:

"You're going back in?"

"I'm reinforcements. You didn't think Whistler called someone over here just to rescue you, did you?"

"Find somewhere to hide.

"You'd better hope the next people to come out of that tunnel are me and Blade.

"Otherwise, make sure wherever you hide is safe and well concealed."

After saying that, Green Arrow Duck bent his knees slightly and glided toward the temple entrance as though wheels were mounted under his feet.

Then he jumped inside.

Because the Duck-Leopard Armor had relatively short sensor range in the underground environment, the pilot simply issued a standing kill order on all vampires and relied entirely on tracking combat missiles.

It was also a convenient chance to test the weapons.

Know why the armor had been designed in duck form?

Because a duck's backside had enormous carrying capacity.

Enough to bring ammunition for a small war.

If it were like a fighter jet that needed to return to base after firing six missiles, forget about clearing the battlefield.

Or he'd have to imitate those idiots in advanced armor who charged into melee waving spears and yelling.

Now blowing up vampires was like setting off firecrackers.

Even though it belonged to the same Duck-Leopard Armor series, the Panther form simply couldn't match the Duck form's battlefield-clearing capacity.

As for humans—

Railgun treatment.

The ammunition he carried for normal targets was only practical through the magnetic railgun.

The anti-vampire specialty rounds weren't particularly effective against humans.

Whether humans lived or died depended on luck.

Just don't block the way.

He advanced downward, following Blade's trail.

The large number of vampires and humans previously detected had already been thinned out by Blade earlier.

This second trip down was merely cleanup duty.

Los Angeles had been turned into a smoky mess for more than a year by these radical vampires.

Small nests and isolated dens could be handled by vampire hunters.

A certain film studio executive was too lazy to get involved.

But a gathering this large?

A once-in-a-lifetime opportunity.

There was no reason to let them survive and continue causing chaos in the streets of Los Angeles.

As for the human collaborators—

Green Arrow Duck had less murderous intent toward them.

Once Blade finished and left, this ruined temple would be blown apart anyway.

Hopefully any surviving humans would climb out in time.

Otherwise they'd simply be buried alive inside the sacred ground of vampires.

Look at that.

Chapter 526 526: Wrapping Things Up

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No matter how Blade injured Deacon Frost, the vampire he hated most always healed instantly.

Even if one arm was cut off or a leg severed, the missing limb would regenerate at once from gathered blood.

Nothing like ordinary vampires, who needed to drink blood or soak in blood pools to accelerate their healing.

How merciful he was.

At least he hadn't told them, You failed this city, before executing them.

Most of the time he only aimed for their legs.

Feeling saintly and compassionate, Green Arrow Duck passed a human frantically swinging an empty rifle in all directions.

Intentionally avoiding vital points, he fired one shot at the man's leg.

Unfortunately, the railgun round was too powerful.

Not only did it punch straight through the leg, it ricocheted.

After several bounces, the bullet somehow lodged in the poor bastard's rear neck and cerebellum.

Absolutely unsalvageable.

What a pity.

When your luck runs out, even mercy can't save you.

The guilt lasted approximately 1.5 nanoseconds.

Then Green Arrow Duck forgot about him completely.

Because something more important required attention.

The place where Blade and Deacon Frost were fighting was exactly as in the movie—

The main altar platform of Eternal Night Temple.

The difference was that in the film, the room had been brightly lit.

In reality, the battle between half-vampire and Blood God was taking place in total darkness.

Though Green Arrow Duck had sabotaged the ritual and intercepted much of the natural energy infusion—

And though the Daywalker, who should have been drained to death as the sacrifice, had escaped early thanks to outside help—

Strictly speaking, the Blood God Deacon Frost had become should have been incomplete.

Defective.

Yet judging by the firearms discarded nearby that still contained ammunition, the pre-battle concern had likely been correct:

The Blood God was immune to silver nitrate rounds and ultraviolet rounds.

That was why Blade had abandoned guns entirely.

The only weapon left capable of cutting the Blood God was the acid-etched silver-plated titanium sword in Blade's hand.

But even sword wounds merely slowed the Blood God's regeneration slightly.

They caused no true damage.

For reasons unknown, Deacon Frost had somehow acquired a katana and was dueling Blade blade-to-blade.

No matter how much time advanced or technology improved, brutal close combat remained the most primal and thrilling kind of battle.

Anyone could tell, however—

If this continued much longer,

The final victor would be Deacon Frost, Blood God incarnate.

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The Blood God seemed to possess an endless supply of blood, remaining in peak condition at all times.

Meanwhile, Blade's wounds continued to accumulate, and his stamina steadily declined.

Even if he was currently in the heightened state brought on by his first real feeding, sooner or later he would begin to weaken.

Watching the Blood God perform like this, Green Arrow Duck was no longer so confident that the Embrace Serum—which destroyed vampire cells—would still be effective.

Hidden behind cover, Green Arrow Duck was considering the right moment to intervene.

Then Blade seemed to notice something and suddenly changed tactics.

He used whatever weapons he could pick up from the ground to harass Deacon Frost, the opponent who believed victory was already his.

At the same time, he tried to retrieve the high-concentration Embrace Serum lodged high in a wall.

Finally, using a hidden mechanism in his sword hilt, he widened the crack in the wall and caused the serum to fall into his hands.

Then came one injection.

Two.

Three.

Four.

Every last syringe was plunged into Deacon Frost—the Blood God.

Apparently the Blood God's vampire cells retained the same biological traits as before.

Which meant this "Blood God" was fundamentally the product of a magical ritual.

At the biological level, it was no different from the vampire cells Black Super had studied when developing the serum.

So once massive doses of weaponized high-concentration serum were injected into the body—far beyond the Blood God's healing capacity—

The swollen vampire exploded like an overfilled water balloon.

Blood sprayed in every direction.

No trace of vampire form or existence remained.

Blade had won.

But he barely had time to savor the victory.

Green Arrow Duck emerged from hiding, immediately putting Blade on guard again.

"I'm not here to fight, Blade. I'm reinforcements called in by Whistler through Black Super."

Green Arrow Duck stated his position first.

"Reinforcements, huh."

Clearly the old Black man didn't believe him.

Though whether he doubted the reinforcements part or the Whistler part was unclear.

Still, Green Arrow Duck continued:

"Anything you need to take with you?"

"I'm planning to blow this place up.

"If someone performs that ritual again and creates another monster like that, none of us will have an easy time dealing with it."

"Wouldn't blowing this place up cause too much commotion?"

Blade knew this wasn't some remote mountain wilderness.

This was still within Los Angeles city limits.

Not downtown, perhaps—but certainly not somewhere the government could ignore if it exploded.

Still, Blade did not object to destroying it.

Green Arrow Duck thought for a moment about bureaucracy and regulations.

"That depends how much the local government cares about an unlicensed structure with no building registration.

"If no one can prove people are buried underneath, and since this was vampire territory, they might even help cover it up instead of asking what's down there."

Don't assume the authorities had no temper after everything vampires had caused recently.

For some unknown reason, the U.S. government had not formally gone to war against vampires.

But if the military ever became directly involved, vampires would fare even worse than mutants.

Both sides knew that.

Which was why vampires had usually exercised restraint.

Only the young radical faction truly believed they could rule the Earth.

Blade left first, emerging from the underground Eternal Night Temple.

Outside, he was met by Karen Johnson as the sunlight of Los Angeles greeted them.

Green Arrow Duck remained below, placing sufficient homemade explosives at carefully calculated structural points.

His goal was not merely to bury the place.

He wanted it wrecked.

Crippled.

Reduced to the point that digging it out and repairing it would be harder than constructing an entirely new temple.

He couldn't stop future lunatics from rebuilding another Eternal Night Temple for another Blood God ritual.

But allowing anyone to reuse this one would mean he hadn't done his job today.

By the time Green Arrow Duck returned to the surface, Blade had just declined Karen Johnson's suggestion and was saying righteously:

"My war isn't over yet. There are still hard battles ahead.

"If you want to help me, then make a better serum."

Most of Green Arrow Duck's furry camouflage had been destroyed.

The exposed metal armor gleamed brilliantly in the morning sunlight.

Naturally, it drew attention.

To avoid seeming too conspicuous, Green Arrow Duck casually said:

"Even if vampires aren't wiped out, taking out this group should at least quiet the streets of Los Angeles for a while."

"The young radicals were probably all here.

"But there will always be someone dissatisfied enough to cause trouble.

"You can't expect eternal peace unless we exterminate vampires completely."

Blade answered bluntly.

Green Arrow Duck was about to say more when Blade asked first:

"How's Whistler?"

"He's safe. Somewhere even I don't know.

"According to another person, give him two or three more days of recovery and he should be able to walk around.

"You'll see him then."

"Tell the old man I avenged him.

"But if he wants to come back, he'd better be prepared for the same thing to happen a second time. Or a third.

"If he wants to retire and disappear somewhere no one can find him, I won't blame him."

Green Arrow Duck responded impatiently:

"Tell him yourself when you meet.

"I'm not anyone's messenger."

"Then who are you?"

"I've never heard of anyone like you.

"Don't tell me you're Disneyland's secret weapon."

Blade held no weapon, but the oppressive force of his presence bore down heavily.

"Just a passerby who happens to have a grudge against vampires."

Green Arrow Duck revealed nothing.

At the same time, the anti-gravity systems in his webbed feet activated again, and he slowly rose into the air.

"Don't say I didn't warn you.

"I planted explosives below.

"You've got about twelve minutes to leave.

"The blast shouldn't spread too far—just get outside the underground structure's area.

"But once something happens here, government people will definitely come investigate, whether they care what's buried below or not.

"If you're still here then, it'll be troublesome.

"Never mistake officials for rational people who can be reasoned with."

Once he finished speaking, Green Arrow Duck extended both arms outward.

All six main thrusters ignited simultaneously.

The force of his takeoff created such intense wind pressure that it nearly knocked people off their feet.

"Do you know who he is, Blade?" Karen Johnson asked.

"If he doesn't want people to know, then don't investigate.

"As long as we know he's a friend, that's enough."

Blade's attitude was simple and direct.

Even though other vampire hunters distrusted him, Blade was used to treating such people as allies.

As long as they shared the same enemy.

"Let's go.

"There should be vehicles nearby that the vampires used to bring us here.

"We need to leave before the explosion."

Blade said to the doctor.

The two departed side by side.

Exactly twelve minutes after Green Arrow Duck's warning, the buried explosives detonated simultaneously.

The ground over Eternal Night Temple bulged upward violently, as if something enormous were trying to burst out from below.

Then the entire area collapsed inward.

When it was over, only a massive crater remained—

Chapter 527 527: A Cleaner Los Angeles

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Sure enough, when dealing with a force like the vampires, you couldn't chase them one nest at a time like a dog hunting rats.

You had to gather them together first—

Then wipe them out in one blow.

Deacon Frost's ambition to ascend as the Blood God had been crushed by Blade.

Along with him, the vampire power base built around Deacon suffered a devastating blow.

Of course, some vampires and human followers belonging to that faction had avoided disaster simply because they never went to Eternal Night Temple.

But those survivors would not find it easy to carry the banner of the radical vampire faction.

Because the Twelve Houses—who had been manipulated by Deacon and suppressed by him—would never let such an opportunity pass without taking revenge.

At the very least, Deacon Frost's fortune would be carved up by those old monsters.

Any radical survivors hoping to rise using Deacon's inheritance would first have to ask whether the watching elder vampires approved.

And when vampires dealt with their own kind, they were just as vicious.

There was no sense of brotherhood or shared bloodline among them.

Completely unlike Magneto's Brotherhood of Mutants, which loudly claimed our own do not kill our own and placed mutant collective interests first.

Whether members under Magneto actually killed mutants was another matter.

But Magneto himself truly was quite tolerant toward mutants.

Otherwise, the X-Men roster would have gone through several complete replacements by now.

In any case, in practical terms, Los Angeles streets suddenly became much cleaner.

The police had an easier time.

Street gangs no longer lived in fear that they might somehow offend vampires.

Those dark creatures who boasted themselves as more evolved than humans were not the sort to welcome random thugs seeking refuge.

If they weren't careful, those gangsters asking to join simply became convenient blood bags.

What gang member looked for protection just to die?

They wanted backup in fights, cover when committing crimes, and someone powerful watching their backs.

But vampires not only looked down on street-level criminals—

They regularly ate them.

If gangs welcomed vampires, that would be the real miracle.

So when those sunlight-hating creatures disappeared from the streets of Los Angeles, people might not openly celebrate in public—

But privately, many were quietly delighted.

Some even celebrated in secret.

Hollywood was much the same.

As a long-standing Jewish stronghold, vampires had exerted influence there for many years.

But they had never done so with the arrogant, domineering attitude of Deacon Frost's radicals.

No one wanted mysterious new bosses appearing overhead, demanding a cut of the money.

Worse still, those dark creatures not only ignored existing rules—

They wanted to make new ones of their own.

Burying the evil that had once infested that land.

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That was what people truly could not tolerate.

Henry quickly began to experience the benefits of fewer radical vampires.

Charlize Theron was still filming in Australia.

But her agent, J.J. Harris, remained in Hollywood.

Besides handling the actress's career, Harris also managed other talent.

Over the past year, the resistance and obstacles standing in her way had suddenly vanished, making work far smoother.

From time to time, the agent would visit Stark Pictures personally and chat with Henry about industry matters.

Partly to show how seriously she took Charlize's career.

Partly to use the studio's channels to gather information.

And partly to cultivate ties with the company's executive director.

Henry didn't dislike this kind of goodwill mixed with self-interest.

At least it was mutually beneficial.

Not one-sided exploitation.

Beyond those visible improvements, the combat testing of the Duck-form Duck-Leopard Armor and the Multi-Directional Tracking Combat Missiles had become Henry's main private research focus recently.

Inspired by the Macross anime franchise, the weapon system had presented many technical difficulties when adapted into the Marvel universe—

Though not as many as expected.

First, these missiles were primarily designed for space combat outside an atmosphere.

So they didn't require wings or fins for steering.

They relied entirely on multidirectional thrusters for maneuvering and propulsion.

They could still be used in atmosphere, but range became significantly shorter, and some design/material adjustments were necessary.

Second, the reason their attack paths looked so erratic was because they constantly overcorrected during pursuit.

They'd overshoot the target, then turn back again.

Normally, such wasteful fuel consumption would get both the thrust-program engineers and the missile physicists dragged before a firing squad.

But this overloaded design accidentally gave the missiles unpredictable flight paths —

Making them harder to intercept or evade.

What should have been a flaw became a strength.

A true marvel of engineering history.

So their bizarre movement wasn't an intentional feature.

It was the lucky result of one mistake layered atop another.

Negative times negative equals positive.

The initial launch direction determined from which angle a missile would begin tracking the enemy.

With Henry's current technology, he could control course changes mid-flight instead of letting missiles track independently—

But precise fine-tuning remained impossible.

Or rather, he had never intended precision in the first place.

Unpredictability was one of the weapon's greatest strengths.

Chaos was the point.

Its only real weakness was size.

Once warhead payload and fuel were installed, there wasn't much room left for anything else.

So these missiles lacked true fire-and-forget capability.

They required an external system for locking, tracking, and control.

If every function had to be built into each missile, they wouldn't be merely thumb-thick anymore.

They'd need to be two or three times larger.

As things stood, control signals were transmitted wirelessly through the quantum computing system Henry had built behind the scenes.

Fortunately, his communications systems were based on alien technology.

Modern Earth technology couldn't crack them.

It probably couldn't even detect them.

Meanwhile, the explosive compounds had been upgraded.

At equal weight, their power was several times stronger than TNT.

The propellant formulas were also from the Galactic Empire version of science, far more efficient than Earth fuels.

Still—

Miniature missile size remained the greatest limitation.

Once you required enough explosive force to matter, fuel capacity simply couldn't support long-distance travel.

That was why Henry classified them as combat missiles.

Without heavy maneuvering, they could fly only about one kilometer.

If maneuvering restrictions were removed, their practical combat range dropped to roughly five to six hundred meters.

Unless used outside atmosphere.

In space, fuel dynamics differed enough that range would increase substantially.

As for enlarging the missiles to carry more explosive and more fuel—

That idea barely crossed Henry's mind before he discarded it.

The true strength of the system lay in overwhelming targets through sheer numbers.

Tracking from multiple directions made interception difficult.

And they could lock onto multiple targets simultaneously.

Those qualities made them ideal for close-range chaotic multi-target combat.

At medium and long range, they were actually less suitable.

Besides, these things had originally been meant to shoot down aircraft.

Using them on people was already somewhat excessive.

Armored vehicles, tanks, armed helicopters—

All perfectly manageable.

Chapter 528 528: A Distress Call from New York

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The call came through to Henry's personal mobile phone.

Naturally, the device was no longer connected to any self-destruct mechanism and functioned normally now.

"Mr. Henry Brown, please save us! Something like this has happened—I don't know who else I can turn to. Where are you?"

A woman's panicked, tearful voice came through the line.

Henry confirmed immediately that he had never spoken to her before and didn't recognize the voice.

But since she clearly knew his name, he still replied calmly:

"Please calm down, ma'am. First—who are you?"

"I'm Maria Thomson, Miss Katharine Hepburn's private caregiver. Miss Hepburn often mentioned you whenever she was lucid, and said that if there was ever any trouble, we could call you for help."

In the winter of 1996, Katharine Hepburn had been hospitalized with pneumonia.

After her discharge, her health had remained poor, and the acting career she loved had completely come to a halt.

There were even reports that she had begun showing symptoms of dementia.

Henry didn't know the name of her caregiver, but the circumstances matched.

Since this sounded serious, he skipped any suspicion and asked directly:

"Calm down and tell me what happened. Is Katharine alright?"

"It seems you're not in New York, Mr. Brown. This is all over the news here. If you were in the city, there's no way you wouldn't know."

"Don't tell me another giant monster crawled out of the ocean and onto land again."

Henry immediately thought of the earlier Godzilla incident in New York.

Increase the power further?

Then what exactly was he planning to fight?

This universe didn't have Gundams.

During development, Henry had even removed the warheads entirely, replacing them with inert counterweights, and used Katie as the simulated target.

That tiger had received excellent dodge training as a result.

Since the first real combat test had been against vampires whose speed exceeded both humans and tigers, Henry had gathered a great deal of valuable battlefield data.

All of it could be used to improve the combat missiles further.

Though he had no intention of switching careers to become an arms dealer, the era of superheroes appearing in bulk was drawing ever closer.

And for some reason, Henry felt an increasing sense of urgency pushing him toward certain preparations.

You could also say that if he didn't spend his time researching alien technology and building strange weapons, he had no idea what else to do with a super-brain like his.

Money was trivial.

Not worth pursuing.

If it couldn't be converted into something beneficial to him, then it was merely a boring number.

And anything money could buy—

What was better than what he could personally build?

That sense of confusion had begun affecting his daily life as well.

Until—

A distress call interrupted everything.

Again?

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At that time, he had also checked on his elderly friend on the East Coast.

By coincidence, Katharine Hepburn had then been staying at her family seaside villa in Connecticut and escaped unharmed.

But this time, someone at her side was calling for help.

Clearly, the situation was serious.

As he turned on the office television, Henry said:

"Isn't Sentinel in New York? What kind of disaster could he possibly fail to solve?"

The TV switched on directly to a news channel.

The screen showed scenes of civilians fleeing chaotically through disaster-stricken streets.

The image shook violently, with no anchor narration—meaning the cameraman was literally running for his life while filming.

As if answering Henry's question, Maria Thomson said in despair over the phone:

"Sentinel is the one who went insane."

At that moment, the tumbling camera on the TV spun once more before hitting the ground.

Henry recognized several iconic Manhattan landmarks.

Then the rolling stopped.

The camera pointed upward at a man floating in the air.

Sentinel.

Not only the strongest superhero of the era, but perhaps theoretically the strongest in the Marvel universe as well—existing on a completely different level from Captain Marvel.

Yet his expression looked nothing like the confident, warm, reassuring face people knew from television.

Instead, his face was sunken and grim.

His eyes were dead, like those of a fish.

This was...



The Void?

Sure enough, on-screen, spreading unnatural darkness swallowed anyone it touched.

All that remained of those people were black silhouettes burned into the world.

Then the horrifying footage was abruptly cut by the station and replaced with the anchor desk.

Realizing how severe the situation was, Henry asked urgently:

"Maria, where are you now? Are you at the Turtle Bay residence on East 49th Street?

"Besides you and Katharine, is anyone else there?

"I'm in New York too, just out at the moment, so I hadn't seen the news. I only just caught what's happening on a store TV by the roadside."

As he said this, Henry was already standing in Stark Pictures' underground parking garage beside his brown old Cadillac.

The woman on the line quickly replied:

"Yes, yes! We're at East 49th Street, in Miss Hepburn's home. Just the two of us.

"Her condition isn't good. She absolutely refuses to leave.

"I can't handle this situation alone, so I called you."

Now understanding the circumstances, Henry immediately said:

"Alright, Maria. Listen carefully and stay calm.

"I'm driving there right now. I'll take both of you to Katharine's family seaside villa in Connecticut.

"What you need to do right now is pack the important things.

"Especially Miss Hepburn's medications. Don't forget those.

"When I arrive, I'll knock on the door, and then we'll bring her out together. Understood?"

"Yes, yes, Mr. Brown..."

The woman was still flustered.

"But when will you get here?"

"Just give me a few minutes. I'm hanging up now."

Flying to the East Coast and then renting a car would already take too long.

Though the Void's rampage was still some distance from Katharine Hepburn's home, its destructive potential was impossible to estimate.

Henry had no intention of allowing that woman to come to harm.

So the fastest option—

Was to carry his own car there.

But New York was mutant territory.

Would the X-Men intervene to stop the Void?

Was Jean Grey—the Phoenix—currently there?

If one talked about Earth's current combat power, the person most likely capable of stopping the Void was probably Jean Grey empowered by the Phoenix Force.

Forget the Thunderbolts.

Even a complete movie-version Avengers lineup probably wouldn't be enough.

Call Captain Marvel back?

At her response speed, by the time she arrived, it would all be over.

And that didn't even touch the issue of whether she could win.

More importantly, in this situation, would there be any political benefit in recalling Captain Marvel to fight Sentinel?

That was the real key to whether Nick Fury would act.

After all, in Avengers: Infinity War, the one-eyed old Black spymaster had waited until he himself was turning to dust before activating the pager.

He only used it because if he didn't, he'd lose the chance forever.

Otherwise, when Thanos' fleet openly invaded Earth for the Infinity Stones, would the man controlling the world's greatest intelligence network really not know the planet was in danger?

Or had he simply trusted the Avengers to handle it—until he himself was dying and realized they'd lost control?

No matter how you framed it, Nick Fury was fundamentally a political creature.

If there was no advantage and no way to control the outcome, don't expect him to commit.

The X-Men had their own problems recently as well.

At minimum, the government's attitude toward mutants had been worsening.

Because the X-Men led by Mystique—Raven Darkhölme—were far less diplomatic than the team once led by Professor X.

Reports of defiance and refusal of orders appeared regularly.

So neither side could be relied upon.

The best strategy was simply to run far away.

If all he needed was transportation for evacuation, stealing a car in New York would be easiest.

But then how was he supposed to explain that to Katharine Hepburn?

That would be infinitely harder.

After thinking it over, Henry decided to carry his own car there.

The old lady's dementia was only intermittent.

It wasn't severe enough that she forgot everything or couldn't tell reality from nonsense.

He could plausibly explain having driven to New York on business.

He absolutely could not explain stealing a random car to evacuate her.

So—

Being responsible was the better option.

Henry grabbed the underside of the front bumper with one hand.

Like a hydraulic jack, he lifted the entire car.

Then he slid beneath it, supporting it overhead—

And activated his flight ability, heading straight from Los Angeles to New York.

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